HOPE

Philosophizing From Multi-Horizons

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Edited by
Ivan D'Souza

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Editorial Introduction

The Polyphony of Hope
Philosophical Resonances from Finitude to Future

Human life comprises the vicissitudes of ups and downs, ebbs and flows, twists and turns, crests and troughs. It is a Pandora's Box that opens onto many problems, disappointments, difficulties, and deviations. Life never flows in a straight line. There are various layers and levels to it: physical, psychological, social, cultural, political, religious, spiritual, and so on. In all these spheres of life, hope is that which supports, sustains, and endures. Hope is not singular or one-directional; hope is not merely of the future, but is connected to past and present, moving backwards and journeying forwards—a frontal and dorsal *Weltanschauung*. It not only relates to the human world, but also permeates cosmic and divine horizons. In other words, hope is internal, external and transcendent. Hence, it is multi-horizonal.

Syed Umar Khalid, former JNU student leader and PhD scholar, was arrested under the UAPA in 2020 for alleged conspiracy in the Delhi riots. He has since been held in Tihar Jail without trial, denied bail six times, most recently in September 2025. Despite such prolonged captivity, he has not lost hope, finding solace in Dostoevsky's *The House of the Dead*, whose account of imprisonment nurtures his resilience. "We are not alive though we are living and we are not in our graves though we are dead."[1] Khalid quotes from Dostoevsky's fiction, based on the writer's own experiences of imprisonment in Tsarist Russia in the mid-19th century.

Khalid shares Dostoevsky's ruminations on hope, waiting, despair, longing, and captivity as follows:

1 Umar Khalid, "'Nurturing Hope in Prison a Risky Business': Umar Khalid Writes from Tihar Jail." *The Quint*, 28 July 2025, www.thequint.com/voices/blogs/umar-khalid-writes-from-tihar-jail-delhi-riots-case-imprisonment-5-years, accessed 04 September 2025.

> From the first day of my life in prison, I began to dream of freedom. To calculate in a thousand different ways when my days in prison would be over became my favourite occupation. … The hopes of a prisoner deprived of freedom are utterly different from those of a man living a natural life. A free man hopes, of course (for a change of luck for instance, or the success of an undertaking), but he lives, he acts, he is caught up in the world of life. It is very different with the prisoner. There is life for him too — granted prison life — but whatever the convict may be and whatever may be the term of his sentence, he is instinctively unable to accept his lot as something positive, final, as part of real life. Every convict feels that he is, so to speak, not at home but on a visit. He looks at twenty years as though they were two, and is fully convinced that when he is let out at 55 — he will be as full of life and energy as he is now at 35.[2]

Khalid also notes that hope can be a risky business. "The higher you hope, the higher is the height from which you come crashing down. Simply put, I am afraid of hope, so I try not to remain hopeful."[3] Yet he firmly asserts that nurturing hope in the midst of hopelessness will, in the end, bear fruit. Khalid recalls a prisoner who spent 28 years in jail without parole or furlough until the Supreme Court granted him a 21-day release, which felt like just 21 minutes. Returning voluntarily, he held on to hope of future furloughs, even while facing life imprisonment. As Dostoevsky notes, prisoners who have endured years of captivity often do not flee even if the gates are opened, for they live by hope.[4]

The hope of and for the earth is beautifully presented by Trina Paulus, an American author, environmental activist, in her novel *Hope for the Flowers*. It is an allegorical parable which envisions hope for humans and the earth simultaneously. It is a story of two caterpillars, Stripe and Yellow. They begin their life eating leaves. But later realise that there must be more to life than eating leaves. Hence, they desire and dream of flying high in the sky. Stripe climbs to the top of the caterpillar pillar by literally stepping on and climbing over others. On the top of the pillar, he becomes disillusioned with his own little narrow world and realises that sky is higher than the pillar. Yellow, meanwhile, spins a cocoon, emerges as a butterfly, and flies into the sky. She returns to guide and help Stripe so that he too may transform and fly. Upon waiting till he becomes a butterfly, both of them fly off together.

2 Khalid, "Nurturing Hope in Prison a Risky Business."

3 Khalid, "Nurturing Hope in Prison a Risky Business."

4 Khalid, "Nurturing Hope in Prison a Risky Business."

On the one side, the plot speaks about the realisation of one's true destiny—those who struggle to climb high before understanding that they are meant to fly. On the other side, it is about remaining hopeful while giving hope to others. One cannot truly rise by stepping or stamping on others. Only by changing one's approach can one ascend on to the top and take others along. Nature represents Yellow which has to be our hope to fly in the sky. Like Stripe, humans keep stamping on nature and others. It is Yellow that creates endless hope for us. It is a reminder for us to consider nature as our partner or pilgrim. Thus, Paulus presents hope not merely as personal transformation but as communion with nature and others.

Hope is a divine virtue, oriented toward eternal happiness with God. Thomas Aquinas states hope as the "object of hope is a future good, difficult but possible to obtain" (*Summa Theologiae* I-II, Q. 40, Art. 1). Hope includes four characteristics: a good object, lying in the future, involving difficulty, and yet possible to achieve. Hope differs from despair—which deems the future good impossible—and presumption—which considers attaining the future good as easy.[5] Thus, hope is the patient expectation of a difficult but possible future good.

Hope is among the most resilient and mysterious dimensions of human existence. It is a force that defies despair, a light that endures through darkness, and a dynamic orientation toward what is yet to come. In a crisis ridden world there is an urgent and timely need to re-engage with hope as a philosophical category. The theme of hope gains special resonance in the Jubilee Year 2025—a 'Year of Hope' proclaimed by Late Pope Francis as a time of forgiveness, reconciliation, and spiritual pilgrimage under the banner 'Pilgrims of Hope.'

In this context the Association of Christian Philosophers of India (ACPI), reflected on the theme, ***"HOPE: Philosophizing from Multi-horizons,"*** during its 47th Annual Research Seminar at St Joseph's Interdiocesan Seminary, Jeppu, Mangalore, Karnataka from 19 to 21 October 2024. This volume contains twenty-eight papers which reflect on the nature, challenges, and promise of hope in our time. Together, they offer not just a set of academic essays, but a symphonic dialogue across traditions, disciplines, and lived realities.

5 Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, I–II, q. 40, a. 1, in *The Summa Theologica of St. Thomas Aquinas*, trans. Fathers of the English Dominican Province (New Advent, 1920), https://www.newadvent.org/summa/3040.htm. *See also* Jonathan S. Jodry, "The Thomistic Virtue of Hope in Tolkien's *Leaf by Niggle*." *Christian Scholars Review* (July 2021), https://christianscholars.com/the-thomistic-virtue-of-hope-in-tolkiens-leaf-by-niggle/, accessed 04 September 2025.

The present volume is structured around the acronym of its theme: **H-O-P-E,** dividing the papers into four interconnected parts:

Horizons of Hope: Foundational Analysis;
Offshoring of Hope: Psycho-Somatic Dimensions;
Practices of Hope: Socio-Political Engagements; and
Ethics of Hope: Transformative Vision.

The first part engages with the conceptual and existential foundations of hope. It delves into metaphysical frameworks, phenomenological reflections, and classical thinkers such as Marcel, Kierkegaard, and Camus. The second part turns to the inner dimensions and psychological textures of hope. Drawing from phenomenology, neurobiology, emotion theory, and religious spirituality, these papers investigate how hope arises in the human experience of illness, fear, faith, forgiveness, and inner transformation. Hope, however, is not merely a sentiment or idea—it is also a social and political practice. The third part focuses on how hope animates ethical engagement, public discourse, identity, and resistance. The final part reflects on future-oriented and integrative visions of hope. The papers offer pathways to rethink hope not only as a personal virtue or collective aspiration, but as an ethical imperative for reimagining life on a fragile planet.

In arranging the essays through this four-fold lens, this volume invites the reader to embark on a reflective journey—from foundational questions to personal experiences, from embodied struggles to visionary futures. Each contribution brings its own horizon, yet together they expand our understanding of what it means to hope today.

Part I: Horizons of Hope: Foundational Analysis

Nishant A. Irudayadason, in his paper, "Heterogeneity and Hope: A Contemporary Philosophical Exploration," presents the complex relationship between heterogeneity and hope through the philosophical perspectives of Derrida and several other key figures in 20th century thought. In a world increasingly marked by social, political, and cultural divisions, Derrida's philosophy and that of his contemporaries provide a framework for rethinking hope in ways that move beyond the binaries. Heterogeneity is the source of hope to understand the nature of human existence, language, identity, otherness, future, justice and so on. Hope keeps coming and always in the process of becoming by embracing the difference, diversity, and multiplicity. Hope is continually in the making which emerges from the encounter with the Other. The idea of hope, according to Derrida and others, has broader implications for political theory, ethics, and contemporary identity studies.

Johnson J. Puthenpurackal philosophically reflects on hope in his article, "Thrown to Life, Born to Hope: Philosophical Reflections." Considering two-directional opening in the journey of human existence

'already' (thrown to life) and 'not-yet' (born to hope)—he notes that the act of hoping is the struggle against despair and transcendence from the borders of individual dream and hope. Only when hope accompanies with faith and love, the present gets bridged with future. Having a dream is entering into the world of hope which is ever moving to the never reachable. Hope is seen as existential responding to the cries and listening to the voices of suffering people. It is the responsibility of humans to transform a *curse* of despair into the *grace* of hope which enables one to shape the history of humankind as well as the world.

In the next essay, "Hope, Hauntology, and After Hope," Victor Ferrao points out that hope is not closed reality. Taking a cue from Derrida's hauntology, he highlights that just as the past and the future haunt our present, so also hope allows us to envision and strive for a better present and the future. Hope is not a finished, final or fixed product. Hope is undying and continues to lead humanity even in hopelessness as After Hope. After Hope is an antidote to a society that has entered a state of After Future.

The study of Francis Arackal Thummy titled, "A Metaphysic of Hope: Reading of Gabriel Marcel" highlights the philosophy of Christian existentialist thinker Gabriel Marcel. His theism has shaped his reflections on hope. Marcel emphasises the communitarian and transcendental dimensions of hope. The study suggests that the problems of contemporary world can be faced with courage and confidence through a Metaphysic of Hope—a hope which is anchored in God. The Absolute Thou summons us to His own future when humans journey forward in hope.

Following him, Biju Rockey Pallippadan continues the discussion on hope from another existentialist philosopher Søren Kierkegaard in his paper, "Concept of Faith and Hope in the Writings of Søren Kierkegaard." Biju examines the relationship between faith, love, and hope from the perspective of Kierkegaard and asserts that the Other acquires a pivotal place in these three Christian theological virtues. Even in hope it is hoping for others that creates the authentic hope.

Suresh raises the question in his essay, "Hope and Absurdity: Camus and Sartre" whether hope is possible in this world of brokenness, hatred, and confusion, given the nature of human existence as absurd and meaningless. It calls humans to leap to a hope-filled world and walk to a hopeful future by ascribing purpose to life. Camus is of the view that one cannot escape from the reality of absurdity as it is intrinsic to humans. He calls one to revolt against the absurdity in order to choose life as necessary good. Sartre emphasises on making the right 'choice' of life in 'freedom' to live a hopeful life and build a hope-filled world.

Part II: Offshoring of Hope: Psycho-Somatic Dimensions

Shibu T S, in his paper, "Unveiling Hope in the Experience of Illness and Suffering: A Phenomenological Inquiry," establishes a nexus between suffering and hope. The inevitability of suffering must be experienced with the resilient hope. The philosophical frameworks are considered to construct a phenomenology of hope to envision a better future and stretch hope across and beyond the limits. The study takes into account insights of several philosophers to assert that suffering leads to a meaningful human existence and purpose-driven life.

The question whether hope rational, psychological, or theological is an area of debate. When hope is seen as a human happening all the dimensions must be considered—philosophical, psychological, religious and so on. In this line, Lisbert D'Souza, in his article "Emotions and Hope: A Philosophical Study of Their Interplay," explores the correlation between emotions and hope from the Wittgensteinian perspective. Hope as an emotion impacts human living and is connected to many other emotions. Hope is grounded in human milieu and operations having its implications on self and others. D'Souza upholds that hope is the hallmark of being human.

Does fear help or hinder in hoping? This question is grappled by Jacob Palaparambil in his analysis, "The Interplay of Hopeful Fear and Fearful Hope: A Psychoanalytic Philosophical Examination." When future is open-ended and unknown, there can be either hope or fear. Palaparambil shows that hope and fear are so entwined that in hope there is fear and in fear there is hope. The paradoxical nature of hope and fear is well articulated in the paper not as two opposing poles but as motivators. They assist individuals in maintaining a sense of balance, even in the face of uncertainty. When fear dominates human emotion, while hope remains present, it becomes *hopeful fear*; and when hope is stronger than fear, it leads to *fearful hope*. But one exists within the other, since both involve an element of a 'leap into the dark.'

Augustine Pamplany, in his article, "The Neurobiology of Hope and the Neuroethical Challenges," sheds light on hope as an emotional and cognitive mechanism that is grounded in the brain's complex neural circuitry. Understanding the neurology of hope opens new perspectives on the nature of love and sexuality. The research on the neurology of hope carries profound ethical issues and implications connected to mental well-being, autonomy, and moral agency. The areas of brain which are intricately woven foster hopeful outlook. The paper argues that hope surpasses optimism, providing continuity and purpose even in situations where favourable expectations are absent. Morally and psychologically speaking hope is a necessary virtue both for personal and communal growth.

Keith D'Souza, in his essay, "The Freedom of Forgiveness: A Transcendental Invitation," brings out philosophical nuances of phenomenon of forgiveness. He posits that forgiveness is both a gift and a task given and assigned to individuals as well as communities. The practice of forgiveness has the potential to create hope when it is considered in three ways: forgiveness is an existential invitation; forgiveness is a transcendental invitation—that is intrinsic to human nature; and forgiveness nurtures an enriched experience of existential and affective openness to both the one who are forgives and the one who is forgiven. The gifting of forgiveness creates conditions for personal, inter-personal, and social peace and amity—and more fundamentally, conditions for hope.

Generally, the principle of *karma* is seen as a cycle of rebirths and deaths where soul gets imprisoned within the body multiple times. But Ivan D'Souza, in his study, "Kinesis of *Karma*: Hiking Towards Hope," reveals that the *karma* keeps on creating hope leading to higher births and eventually the infinite hope. *Karma* need not be seen as a hopeless situation but as an opening towards hopeful hope. It is always a meaning in the making and humans in becoming. Hope is ever present in *karma* and *karma* ever creates hope. It is hope which is directed towards something desirable, worthwhile, and meaningful. Hence, one can celebrate *karma* as an opening for eternity or a plurality of hope.

Jose Pennaparambil explains in his article, "Islamic Perspectives on Hope." Hope is a driving force to achieve higher and greater ideals in life. It enables one to face the challenges of life with optimism, resilience, courage, and positivity. Muslims believe that hope is accompanied by fear too. In such situations, turning to Allah and attaining Him is seen as the destiny of hope. Allah reaches out to his believers in inexplicable ways. What makes one hopeful in Islamic religious framework is that Allah is the one and only hope.

Part III: Practices of Hope: Socio-Political Engagements

Henry Jose Kodikuthiyil, in his exploration, "Hope in the Vision of Jürgen Moltmann" examines Jürgen Moltmann's theology of hope. Moltmann finds hope as the germane answer to respond to the challenges of war-torn and violence-driven world. In Christian hope, present suffering goes along with future glory. Suffering opens the door towards the future where one finds meaning, in and through the person of Christ in whom God's redemptive work is fulfilled. The participation in God's redemptive work invites all to work for justice, healing and transformation of the world in which one lives. It is a call to go beyond the boundaries of traditional Christian theology. Hope is dynamic becoming of oneself and an ongoing engagement in the mystery of Christ's cross, death and resurrection.

Varan Vardhan, in his article, "Hope for the Subaltern: Dr Ambedkar–Gandhi Complementarity," makes a probe into the Dalit emancipatory methodologies of Ambedkar and Gandhi. He finds them complementary and mutually contributing towards Dalit liberation rather than conflicting and contradictory. Dealing with the differences of Ambedkar and Gandhi creatively and constructively will help in confronting the challenges of India's caste-ridden society. Ambedkar advocates empowerment, involvement, activism, and self-reliance, whereas Gandhi harps on conversion of the heart of the oppressors, the caste Hindus. It is a two-directional approach: internal and external. Internally, there is a need for Dalit self-empowerment, and externally, moral awakening of the caste Hindus is necessary. In such an attempt hope for the Dalit subalterns—equality, liberty, and fraternity—can be achieved.

Joswine Praveen D'Souza, in his paper, "Hope and Recognition in Charles Taylor: A Philosophical Reflection on Identity Politics," takes into account Charles Taylor's philosophy of recognition tailoring it to India's constitutional democracy. He maintains that the challenges of multiculturalism and religious pluralism can be addressed by upholding the two principles of philosophy of recognition: the politics of universal dignity and the politics of difference. Recognition gives space and value to individuals, collective identities and alienated groups of the society. It germinates the hope of a new inclusive society where everyone's dignity and identity are respected. The ideal of politics of recognition is a source of hope for all those people who languish without due recognition and a potential pathway for promoting hope and solidarity.

Jose D. Maliekal, in his essay, "Hope and Vulnerability: Walking with Transpersons," provides a philosophically grounded, socio-political and praxis-oriented, reflection on the condition of transpersons. He philosophises the issue of transpersons from the prism of Judith Butler, Gilles Deleuze and Felix Guttari. The essay invites people to share the vulnerabilities of transgender people and walk with them in hope. There is a dire need to recognise the identity of transpersons in our society today. Transpersons need the accompaniment and activism of all the people in the society in their resistance against exploitation and assertion of their rights. Their recognition as humans and representation as leaders will widen their horizon of hope.

Raju Felix Crasta, in his study, "Indigenous Worldview as Hope for a New Society," discusses the life and values of indigenous communities. The indigenous values such as harmony, communal living, and mutual respect are relevant to face the contemporary societal challenges. The resilience, communal support, and spiritual interconnectedness of *Adivasi* or tribal people help in creating a humane society and a hopeful community. The aspect of faith and hope in the lives of the tribal people nurtures a sense

of belonging and potential for a better future. The deep bonding of tribals with nature and their traditional ecological knowledge reveals that nature has a hope. The article suggests the need for rediscovery and reliving of indigenous values, culture, and identity with the hope of a new and equitable society.

Basil Xavier, in his paper, "Hope of the Periphery in their Culture: An Ethnophilosophical Exploration," dwells on the people of the periphery, namely, Arunthathiyars, the dalits of the dalits in Tamil Nadu. These subalterns celebrate life through singing, dancing, feasting, sharing, and caring in spite of their distress and difficulties. Their hope is built on their myths, worship, rituals, history, identity, profession and practices. Their culture is their life and hope. This culture is the extension and manifestation of life of Arunthathiyars that is lived in its fulness with hope. Culture is a shelter and weapon of hope for them to resist the casteism, exploitation, and alienation for the arrival of greater hope.

George Panthanmackel, in his article, "*Plunirality* as the Metaphysical Foundation and Hope of Democracy in India," applies the metaphysical notion of *plunirality* to the Indian democratic context. It refers to the original, metaphysical, inseparable unity of both unity and plurality. A democratic society respects the healthy combination of both unity and plurality. Overemphasis on one aspect will lead either to democratic dictatorship or to chaotic anarchy. The hope of democracy lies in respect for *plurinaltiy*. *Plurinality* offers remedy to the evil and destructive forces which fail our system of governance. The violence, marginalisation, conflict, religious unrest, and hatred are the results of the forgetfulness of this original *plunirality* of Being and beings. Considering democracy as a gift, the citizens of India are called to uphold and promote its *plurinal* nature, to find it and make it a hopeful reality.

John Peter Vallabadoss, in his exploration, "Indian Masters of Hope: Vision, Quest, Critique of Abdul Kalam, Amartya Sen and Daya Krishna," elaborates on the vistas of hope which is envisioned by three representatives of Indian Masters of Hope, Abdul Kalam, Amartya Sen and Daya Krishna. They visualised a better and brighter future for Indians, instilling in them a hope with a vision, quest and critique. The author suggests that it is better to chase a dream and a goal that pushes the present context to greater heights of hope, rather than remain imprisoned by the nostalgia of India's past glory as an escape from present-day woes. Taking a cue from representatives of India's master minds, the article offers a a paradigm of hope with a transformative vision for the bright future for individuals and society in contrast to moral decadence and gloomy survival of the present.

Part IV: Ethics of Hope: Transformative Vision

George Rajmohan, in his essay, "Towards a Secular Hope: A Study on Critical Theory with Special Reference to Habermas," revisits the findings of critical theorists as a response to the negative impacts of modernity and its rationality. The reflections of the Frankfurt school thinkers like Habermas, Lukács and others seek to revive the spirit of helpless and hopeless world of today disrupted by capitalism, fascism, consumerism, and the loss of individuality. Habermas maintains that communicative action, public sphere, democracy, dialogue, and consensus will fulfil humanity's hope to live on earth peacefully. He offers hope to humanity by postulating the horizontal role of reason or logos to counter modern problems. The Habermasian theory of pragmatics points out that language is for understanding, communication and social interaction and meaning is context-dependent. The lifeworld gets filled with hope, when reason serves human interests and when logos is employed democratically and dialogically.

Arnald Mahesh Irudhayadhason, in his analysis, "Do Human Enhancements Promote Hope?" examines the moral and philosophical nuances of Human Enhancements (HEs). Prolonging the span of human life by using artificial scientific methods through HE may jeopardise the natural intrinsic human dignity and value of life. The article argues that humans have to find hope in their given vulnerabilities, limitedness and finiteness through a purposeful living and social solidarity. When the pursuit of HE does not take away the inherent and fundamental human dignity or does not compromise humanity, hopeful enhancement can be achieved and looked for.

Kuruvilla Pandikattu, in his paper, "Ethics, Aesthetics, and Hope: Pathways to a Holistic Human Experience," links artistic taste with moral virtue alongside the power of hope. Drawing insights from philosophical traditions from Plato and Aristotle to Kant, Kierkegaard, and Nietzsche, he shows that ethical living, aesthetic appreciation and hope are interconnected resulting in personal development and community transformation. The domains of ethics, aesthetics, and hope collectively influence human behaviour and societal norms. Ethics fosters a just society, aesthetics enriches our sensory and emotional lives and hope inspires resilience and motivation, driving individuals and communities towards a better future. The author is of the view that hope serves as a driving force that inspires individuals to strive for ethical ideals and engage in creative, aesthetic endeavours.

Sunil Jose Mattappallil, in his article, "Ecological Hope in Crisis: Reimagining Integral Ecology Through *Laudato Si'*," evaluates the encyclical of Late Pope Francis which calls for an integral ecology. He stresses the interconnectedness of all creation and urges a holistic approach to ecological issues—one that integrates ethical, social, and spiritual dimensions. The *modus operandi* of integral ecology offers hope, advocating for justice, sustainability, and a love for our common home rather than despair. Prompting the world that this planet is our shared home, *Laudato Si'* nurtures a more compassionate and inclusive outlook, strongly reminding all of us that there is hope both for the earth and humanity.

Stephen S. Jayard, in his study, "Time = Life = Hope: Reflections on Signs of Hope in Sciences," proves that time and life are related to each other per se. He connects hope to the line of time and life as an experiential reality, which escapes our comprehension. Drawing insights from the fields of natural and psycho sciences, and considering the views of Hawking and Paul Kalanithi, the significant scientists, the paper reflects on hope to be looked forward in life which is lived in space and time. The enigmatic nature of time and life makes one to make one's life meaningful through hope. Hope can be revived and restored in the fallen and fractured world of today, as something that which we can create it or find it by ourselves.

Annie Kunnath, in her exploration, "Between Christian Hope and AI's Secular Hope: Thinking with and through *Spe Salvi*," contrasts Christian hope with secular hope. Pope Benedict XVI's encyclical *Spe Salvi* advocates faith and love-driven Christian hope, which results in well-being of individuals, inclusion of all, common good, communitarian bonding and ever-present goodness. Christian hope is transcendent and eternal which is rooted in a future with God. Secular hope maintains that material progress leads to human happiness and fulfilment. It fails to address the spiritual void or the search for ultimate meaning neglecting the spiritual and moral dimensions crucial for integral human development. Guided by scientific and technological advancement, it downgrades values of human life and downplays the role of human free will and emotions without. The given human vulnerabilities, imperfections, flaws, fragility, and finiteness of humans are considered as impediments for secular hope.

The final paper, by Jeff Shawn Jose, titled, "From AI Dystopia to Gandhian Utopia: Envisioning a Path of Hope Toward Ethical AI," argues that Gandhian thought has the potential to infuse hope in AI discourse by placing holistic human flourishing above unchecked technological progress. It critiques the ethical problems of AI through the prism of Gandhian principles, upholding his utopian ideals viz. *Ramarajya* (ideal-state), *swaraj* (self-rule), and *ahimsa* (non-violence). The paper uses three waves of AI ethics: futuristic risks, present concerns, and environmental impacts—and analyses them in the light of Gandhian thought. It offers ethical guidelines of Gandhi's utopias as a hopeful alternative to the dystopian clouds surrounding AI.

The above papers which were presented, discussed, and debated traverse through existential, metaphysical, psychological, socio-political, moral and many other horizons. The reader is invited to find the pointers of hope in them and engage in the mission of hope. Drawing insights and inspiration from the reflections of this volume, all people of goodwill are called to derive or infuse hope in their human, cosmic and divine realms. We extend our heartfelt gratitude to all the contributors, the ACPI leadership, and the organising team of the 47th Annual Seminar for nurturing this collaborative philosophical endeavour. May these pages not only stimulate thought but also kindle new hopes—across hearts, disciplines, and horizons. May hope lead us to holistic, helpful, harmonious and hopeful humanity, for hope never ends.

Ivan D'Souza
St Joseph's Institute of Philosophy, Mangalore
10 September, 2025

Chief Guest's Address

Hope to Find Meaning in Life

Most Rev. Dr Peter Paul Saldanha
(Bishop of Mangalore)

I am indeed delighted to be part of this conference organised by the Association of Christian Philosophers of India (ACPI), in collaboration with the Chair in Christianity, Mangalore University, with a very meaningful theme: "Hope, Philosophizing from Multi-Horizons". It is not a coincidence, I believe, that this theme has been chosen in a society which is pushing many people into despair, where the rate of suicide is increasing, and where Pope Francis has called for the celebration of the Ordinary Jubilee of the birth of Jesus, the hope of the world.

Once I read an article that India has the highest number of suicides in the world. According to a National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) report released in April 2024, 1.71 lakh people died by suicide in 2022 in India. The suicide rate has increased to 12.4 per 1,00,000—the highest rate ever recorded in India. The common stressors in life are related to work, finances, relationship issues, and health. Similarly, student suicides have also surpassed the population growth rate. Tragedies of this sort devastate the whole family and it takes years to recover from the shock.

As an antidote to despair, we have hope in our hearts. Hope is a kind of elixir that gives meaning purpose to life, and it gives the reason to live. Some believe in power and accumulating wealth and put their whole hope in earthly goods. I sometimes wonder: whether these people who daily commute from one place to another foster a sense of purpose? What is it that makes us decide to live today and not decide to commit suicide? In every choice we are somehow grappling with some existential questions: why are

we here? what makes our life worth living? what gives it meaning? In the search of the answer to these existential questions we fall back on our own upbringing and the faith tradition in which we have been nurtured.

Those who lived through great hardships teach us how hope gives meaning in life. Viktor Frankl, who lived through the horrors of Auschwitz and came face to face with death and moral corruption, saw the grim reality of the death camps. Yet, in spite of this realism—or rather because of it—he describes how holding onto hope was literally a life-or-death choice. Those who lost hope, he said, developed a certain look in their eye, a fatalism that inevitably ended in death. They experienced an "existential vacuum," his term for a complete loss of meaning, a loss of hope, a sense that nothing really mattered any more. He helped people to live for someone whom they loved and thereby developed desire to live. His findings he used in the logotherapy he devised to treat patients in despair.

To fight despair, the relationship with a loved one, or perhaps a task which one is called to do matters a lot. Whatever it is, we are invited to live into that meaning, and discern what life demands of you. For in choosing in hold one meaning, one's life will (perhaps surprisingly!) unfold with beauty and purpose, even if the road is difficult. We have the freedom to choose between hope and despair. Between the stimulus and response, we have the freedom to choose. We can choose negativity which is destructive or positively which is constructive. We have the freedom to choose love rather than hate, and thus find our propose for life.

St Paul lived through great suffering and yet he rejoiced. In the letter of St Paul to the Romans, Paul writes lucidly: "we rejoice in our sufferings, knowing that our suffering produces endurance, and endurance produces character, and character produces hope, and hope does not put us to shame, because God's love has been poured into our hearts through the Holy Spirit who has been given to us" (Rom 5:3–5). St Peter also in his first letter invites Christians to give a reason of the hope they have. He writes: "In your hearts honour Christ the Lord as holy, always being prepared to make a defence to anyone who asks you for a reason for the hope that in you; yet do it with gentleness and respect, having a good conscience, so that, when you are slandered, those who revile your good behaviour in Christ may be put to shame" (1 Pet 3:15–18). Hope connects us with the divine, and we pray that the God we believe in may bring forth some good even from the painful situations.

As Christians we hope in the eternal life with God, who is our origin and our destiny. Even Muslims focus on the life with God. Hindus speak of *moksha*. Pope Francis says that we are pilgrims of hope between our birth and death. He writes in his *Bull of Indiction of the Jubilee*: "Everyone

knows what it is to hope. In the heart of each person, hope dwells as the desire and expectation of things to come, despite our not knowing what the future may bring (no. 1). In Christian faith, God's word helps us find reasons for that hope.

It is human experience that everyone suffers. How one handles suffering depends on what we hope for. Viktor Frankl would give a principle to handle suffering drawn from Nietzsche, that is, "He who has a why to live for can bear almost any how." It means that with a strong purpose, people can overcome almost anything that life throws at them. Pope Benedict XVI, in *Spe Salvi*, calls suffering at the setting for learning hope. He writes, "Only the great certitude of hope that my own life and history in general, despite all failures, are held firm by the indestructible power of Love, and that this gives them their meaning and importance, only this kind of hope can then give the courage in act and to persevere (no. 35).

In Christian faith, it is the love of Christ, who has entered into our history that impels us to persevere in the midst of all adversity and trails. This deeper knowledge produces in us endurance, and patience. In this frenetic world, where there is a lot of self-centredness, and unhappiness, hope can direct our gaze to meaningful, if we freely choose to be in relationship with God, with others and with the whole of creation. We have wonderful example of this intense relationship in St Francis of Assisi.

What is hope? It is "the sure and confident expectation of receiving what God has promised us in the future." The believer's hope is not a faint or obscure wish but "an anchor for the soul, firm and secure" (Hebrews 6:19). In Scripture, hope is a virtuous quality because it contains no doubt, always trusting in God's faithfulness and presence no matter the circumstances, whether good or bad (Psalm 71:5). In Christian terms, "Hope to the theological virtue by which we desire the kingdom of heaven and eternal life as our happiness, placing our trust in Christ's promises and relying not on our own strength, but on the help of the grace of the Holy Spirit" (CCC 1817). Without a reference to eternal happiness, I don't know whether one can make meaning out of hope which gives meaning to our life.

Julian of Norwich, a 14th-century English mystic states, "All shall be well, and all shall be well, and all manner of things shall be well." It is a reassuring message of hope and optimism, reminding us that despite life's challenges and uncertainties, things will ultimately would work out for the best. We must remind ourselves that there is much goodness in the world and in the human heart and that is the capital of our hope.

Our deepest desire for happiness or a blessed life, here and hereafter, is fed by hope, which never disappoints us. In the final analysis, there is nothing else that we ask for in prayer. Our journey has no other goal—it is about this alone: happiness or a blessed life. May your reflections help you seek that eternal happiness and that you generate hope in many who otherwise might end up in despair. I wish you all the best for the conference.

Keynote Address

The Location of Hope in Human History

Prof. Parinitha Shetty

First of all, let me thank the organisers of this seminar for inviting me to deliver the keynote address. I thank them for their choice of someone outside the fold to speak on this occasion. I do not belong to the fold in two ways. I am neither a student nor a scholar of philosophy nor am I a Christian with regard to my religion. I do not know if I am befitting of their choice. When I read the titles of the papers that are going to be presented in this seminar, I was rather daunted and my first response to this invitation was a refusal because I felt that I did not have the credentials to be the keynote speaker in a seminar in which the focus is essentially philosophical. But I was persuaded later to accept this invitation because I felt that through my presence a dialogue may become possible. A dialogue on how hope has been understood, and theorised across different cultures and histories and disciplines. A dialogue on how the idea of hope and the belief in hope have been sustained and deployed under difficult conditions. A dialogue on how that belief has been transformed into social and political action that has enabled the survival and defence of individuals and institutions and communities against the onslaught of powerful political and ideological regimes. I felt that such a dialogue, if it were to be interdisciplinary and inter-religious, could provide us with a more nuanced theory and practice of hope.

In recent times I have increasingly taken recourse to hope in order to sustain myself in my personal and professional life without succumbing to despair. I have also heard the word hope being used on multiple occasions

by people, who have stood up for persecuted and marginalised values, when they have spoken of their struggles. Hence, this invitation provided me with the opportunity to sit down and contemplate and unpack the meaning of hope for me personally as well as for the history within which I live. My presentation will not be scholarly in the traditional academic sense and will not follow the protocols of academic research. Rather, I will be speaking from that intersectional location where my personal experience, the history of my reading and teaching and scholarship and my embeddedness in larger social and political and regional communities come together to generate a historically specific and contingent articulation of what it means to hope and the need for hope in our times. But, first of all I will begin with what Pope Francis has said about hope and its importance to the present, on the occasion of declaring 2025 as the Jubilee year in which hope will be celebrated and consciously practised as a central Christian value. I will try to sum up and quote what I consider to be central to Pope Francis' message on hope and the necessity of hope, as articulated in his papal bull. I consider this to be an important preliminary to what I am going to say, because in a sense my own articulations on hope and I think much of what is going to be said in the next two days will be in response to what Pope Francis has said on hope.

In the papal bull titled *Spes Non Confundit* (SNC) meaning "Hope does not disappoint" Pope Francis speaks of what it means to hope. He begins by saying, "Everyone knows what it is to hope. In the heart of each person, hope dwells as the desire and expectation of good things to come, despite our not knowing what the future may bring" (SNC 1).[1]

He says that in the course of the jubilee year of 2025, "every effort should be made to enable the People of God to participate fully in its proclamation of hope in God's grace and in the signs that attest to its efficacy" (SNC 6). In addition to finding hope in God's grace, we are also called to discover hope in the *signs of the times* that the Lord gives us. We need to recognise the immense goodness present in our world, lest we be tempted to think ourselves overwhelmed by evil and violence. The signs of the times, which include the yearning of human hearts in need of God's saving presence, ought to become signs of hope.

Pope Francis then goes on to enumerate these signs of hope. He sees the signs of hope in the following longings, feelings and actions of human beings. The desire for peace in our world, which once more finds itself

1 Pope Francis, "Spes Non Confundit: Bull of Indiction of the Ordinary Jubilee of the Year 2025," SNC no. 1, https://www.vatican.va/content/francesco/en/bulls/documents/20240509_spes-non-confundit_bolla-giubileo2025.html, accessed 12 August 2025.

immersed in the tragedy of war. Having enthusiasm for life and a readiness to share it. Demanding dignified conditions for those in prison, respect for their human rights and above all the abolition of the death penalty, a provision at odds with Christian faith and one that eliminates all hope of forgiveness and rehabilitation.

Inclusive attention to all those in particularly difficult situations, who experience their own weaknesses and limitations, especially those affected by illnesses or disabilities that severely restrict their personal independence and freedom. Care and concern for adolescents, students and young couples, the rising generation who are the embodiment of hope. The concern for migrants who leave their homelands behind in search of a better life for themselves and for their families. The Pope says that their expectations must not be frustrated by prejudice and rejection. A spirit of welcome, which embraces everyone with respect for his or her dignity, should be accompanied by a sense of responsibility, lest anyone be denied the right to a dignified existence. The elderly, who frequently feel lonely and abandoned, also deserve signs of hope.

Pope Francis speaks powerfully and with deep anguish about the need of hope for the poor. He writes,

> I ask with all my heart that hope be granted to the billions of the poor, who often lack the essentials of life. Before the constant tide of new forms of impoverishment, we can easily grow inured and resigned. Yet we must not close our eyes to the dramatic situations that we now encounter all around us, not only in certain parts of the world. … It is scandalous that in a world possessed of immense resources, destined largely to producing weapons, the poor continue to be "the majority of the planet's population, billions of people.
>
> ... hunger is a scandal, an open wound on the body of our humanity, and it summons all of us to a serious examination of conscience. I renew my appeal that "with the money spent on weapons and other military expenditures, let us establish a global fund that can finally put an end to hunger and favour development in the most impoverished countries, so that their citizens will not resort to violent or illusory situations, or have to leave their countries in order to seek a more dignified life. (SNC 15–16).

The pope appeals to affluent countries to forgive the debts of countries that will never be able to repay them. He says,

> More than a question of generosity, this is a matter of justice. It is made all the more serious today by a new form of injustice which we increasingly recognize, namely, that "a true 'ecological debt' exists, particularly between the global North and South, connected to commercial imbalances with effects on the environment and the disproportionate use of natural resources by certain countries over long periods of time." As sacred Scripture teaches, the earth is the Lord's and all of us dwell in it as "aliens and tenants" (Lev 25:23). If we really wish to prepare a path to peace in our world, let us commit ourselves to remedying the remote causes of injustice, settling unjust and unpayable debts, and feeding the hungry (SNC 16).

Pope Francis goes on to say that Christian Hope is founded on the certainty of eternal life promised by the grace of Christ and imparted through Baptism. To quote his words,

> Christian hope consists precisely in this: that in facing death, which appears to be the end of everything, we have the certainty that, thanks to the grace of Christ imparted to us in Baptism, "life is changed, not ended", forever. Buried with Christ in Baptism, we receive in his resurrection the gift of a new life that breaks down the walls of death, making it a passage to eternity (SNC 20).

Today I would like to speak of hope from a 'this worldly' point of view. How can we theorise hope, which is a belief in a better future, as being embedded in and emanating from the processes of embodied existence? What does it mean to hope without belief in a transcendental power which promises grace and an eternal life to come? How can we think of hope as a belief which is founded on the existence of human agency and which enables the exercise of that agency in shaping human history? Would the elimination of the presence of the transcendental, from the origins and rationale for the existence of hope, radically alter our understanding of the necessity of hope, our practices of hope and the ends towards which the practice of hope is aimed? In what ways do we recast hope when we remove it from the realm of religion? How do we unpack the social process that generate the need for hope as well as provide the framework within which hope can be legibilised and organised into social action? These are some of the questions with which I will begin.

From a 'this worldly' point of view hope is the belief that human life is not governed by necessity. Hope assumes that the human condition is changeable. Hope is sustained by our recognition that what, at a certain point in human history, was accepted as the given unchangeable fact of human existence, has been questioned or dismantled or destroyed through human agency. Thus, hope bases itself on faith in the possibility of a future that can be humanly accomplished. Belief in human agency is central to hope. Hope is thus a way of organising the future and the belief that such an organisation of the future is humanly possible. When that future is organised with the intention of enhancing human life and the web of life within and to which human life is linked then hope becomes a tremendously altruistic and deeply humane power and project. Our conception of what constitutes human good may vary historically. But at any particular point in human history, it may be shared by those who are ranged across the spectrum of belief ranging from theism to atheism. Despite the differences in our social, religious, political, geographical locations, our ideal of human good may overlap and intersect with each other.

Today I will speak of hope as being necessitated by the biological and social condition of being human. The reciprocal interdependence of all that exists in our world, shapes the agency through which hope is, and can be put into practice. The practice of hope and the transformative possibilities of this practice are embedded in and shaped by the historical conditions that both necessitate as well as generate hope. Hence, the necessities and possibilities of hope are always framed into legibility through the grids of intelligibility that are historically and culturally given. But the power of hope lies in its ability to rupture the skin of the socially normal and normative and organise a radically new human future with the resources available in the historical present. This belief in the miraculous strength and power of hope is, I think, shared by those who believe in the existence of a transcendental power and those who do not.

The social conditions under which hope is necessitated may be many. The oppressions experienced by individuals and communities, however differently these oppressions may be experienced, are foundational to generating the need for hope. These oppressions can be of many kinds. Hence, there can be many ways in which and many situations in which hope is experienced. Hope can be experienced as a rupture in the normality of the familiar. Hope can emerge as a radical possibility of restructuring the social and political ordering of the world. It can erupt as a breach in the legality of the officially mandated protocols of social living. Hope can emerge at a point in time when the quotidian timetabling of the life of the individual and the community is disrupted and a new temporality for structuring social existence has to be sought. It can also be a quiet pause between the present that has become unlivable and the future that is yet to be lived. It is that which sustains the plodding monotony of an oppressively routinised life which seems to be endless and closed. It is hope that continually reminds

us of the endurance of the human species while we struggle to accept the inevitability of our personal vulnerability to disease and death.

But hope has to materialise in the form of transformative human action if it has to release us from the destructive power of socio-political and biological constraints. Hope is generated at the intersection of dissent and discomfort with our material conditions of existence and the historical possibilities of changing those material conditions. Hope is a part of the transformative process set in motion by this intersection. How does hope emerge at the interstitial spaces of history opening up new possibilities of embodied being for us? Hope can be—generated and shaped by an epistemological shift that results from our confrontation with new cultures, religions and knowledges. Such a confrontation puts into disarray our familiar modes of socio-corporeal existence. Hope emerges through a meeting with the other, with strangeness that makes the familiar unfamiliar. Such a defamiliarisation of the familiar releases us from our "tied downness" to the commonsense of our present. It makes us recognise human reality as a construct and places hope in the instrumental power of human agency to reconstruct human social existence in more enabling ways.

In the context of our own history as a nation, colonialism provided us with such a transformative confrontation. The entry of Protestant Christianity, alongside and through colonialism, brought the hope of radical equality into a society that was structured through the hierarchies of caste. I would like to illustrate this through the example of Pandita Ramabai. An extraordinary woman of her times, Pandita Ramabai, lived in the latter half of the nineteenth century and the early decades of the twentieth century. Her early life was spent travelling across India and later to England and across America. This, in conjunction with the difficult circumstances of her life, forced her to inhabit radically disjunctive socio-cultural, experiential spaces, simultaneously. Existing at the cusp of histories, cultures and religions, not at ease within the institutionalised religions that she traversed, there emerged in her a radically alienated, critical seeing that shaped her hopes for and attempts at creating an egalitarian and humane world for those she considered the most oppressed in her society. The message of Christ, that is of the equality of all men and women in the eyes of God, provided her with the foundational basis for her reforms. The Protestant Christian conception of a personal God who was the God of love appealed to Ramabai. Her hope for a better life for the upper caste Hindu widow and later for women of all castes was structured through this radically new conception of human equality that Christianity introduced to her. It shaped her social and institutional reform to ameliorate the social condition of women and resulted in the unique trajectory of her reform within the larger history of reform movements in nineteenth-century India.

The Protestant belief in the "priesthood of believers," and the conception of the individual conscience as the location of individual choice, judgment and personal and direct access to God, empowered Ramabai to shape a spiritual interiority in consonance with her spiritual longings. Ramabai conceptualised this interiority as the location where Christ directly intervened into her life and where she was brought into his guiding presence. By making this spiritual interiority the location of her vision for humane practices and egalitarian human relationships, Ramabai legitimised her reforms for the most marginalised in her society and affirmed their right to humane concern and care, thus re-defining the category of the human in egalitarian ways.[2]

Hence, introduction to a new religion can provide that space outside the self, a space from where the familiarity of the socially constructed self can be observed, critiqued and dismantled. It is this process that precedes the task of reconstructing the social moorings of the self, such that, re-formed and enabling possibilities of existence can be put into place enabling hoped-for materialisations of the self and its possibilities of being.

Hope can emanate from the discomfort of the body. Hope can emerge as a response to the dis-ease of the body in the form of hunger or sickness or the precarity of marginalised and invisibilised existence. Hope emerges at the moment of disruption in the routines of embodied being brought about by the suffering, disappearance and dis-ease of the body. It can also emerge from the difficulty or impossibility of establishing and nurturing self-sustaining routines for the body that has been pushed to the edges of precarious living. Hope emerges through the struggle to transform the organisation of the material conditions, social regulations and political privileges in order to have equal access to the resources required to make the body socially and corporeally livable. Corporeal dis-ease reveals the vulnerability of bodies that have been exiled from the interdependent networks of support and mutuality between human beings. It is also the experiential location from where the hope of reestablishing these connections emerges with great urgency. The dis-ease of the body opens it to the vulnerability of becoming humane. The vulnerability that confronts the suffering body cracks open the imagined skin of the self which acts as its self-enclosing boundary and makes it porous to the suffering of others and results in a self-dissolving experience of love which is the foundation of hope. When pushed to the edge of survival such a vulnerability might be transformed into anger and dissent. It is from this

2 Parinitha Shetty, "Travelling Through Interstitial Spaces: The Radical Spiritual Journeys of Pandita Mary Ramabai Saraswathi," in *Translocal Lives and Religion: Connections between Asia and Europe in the Late Modern World*, ed. Philippe Bornet (Sheffield: Equinox, 2021), 193–217.

location of dissent that new possibilities of corporeality can be articulated and fought for. The Christian religion gives us an iconic representation of the body that exceeds its own vulnerability through a suffering transformed into a self-dissolving love. I am speaking of the iconic image of the crucified Christ. The crucified Christ becomes emblematic of a mercy and love that exceeds the human. Yet, it also points towards the radical equality of bodies because they share a common vulnerability. That vulnerability can be both remembered and protected through the hope of putting into practice a society based on mutual care, concern and support. That love becomes foundational to the imagining and putting into practice of communities that live through the structures and conventions of neighbourliness and reciprocity. It generates the imagined and lived possibility of un-enclosed shifting communities that are open to each other and overlapping each other. The icon of the crucified Christ and the narrative within which it is embedded becomes emblematic of a radical love that is not withdrawn even in the face of hate and the cruelty and murder authorised by power. It is the belief in and experience of such love that enables the recognition that the embodied practices of human corporeality are complex, unbounded and that everybody has a right to be protected and cherished. It is radical love that can give the hope of acceptance for those whose embodied practices of living are not legitimised or legibilised. It is radical love that gives the hope to defy the normalisation of bodies through restrictive, punitive and cruel measures. From the location of a marginalised body like that of the homosexual, the transgender, the intersex, disruptive questions emerge that undermine our commonsense of the normatively sexed body. From the experience of persecution might emerge critiques of the normative body and more importantly the disaggregation of that body as a biological or social fact. Such a disaggregation generates the hope of a future with the freedom to reorganise the templates through which bodies can be lived in more diverse, liberating and explorative ways. Such a rethinking of the body is itself an act of putting hope into practice. To hope is to believe in and work towards a world that is livable for all that lives in the world. The pope speaks of taking care of the sick as a sign of hope. He is right. Hope is to care for the body despite its mortality and its proneness to decay and disease. It is to believe in the continuity of the human species even as it is to cherish the individual human life which is evanescent and fragile. However, hope also initiates the struggle to change the commonsense of the body through which it is sexed, gendered and sexualised. Hope can emerge from the location of marginalised, immoralised and illegalised bodies and give them the speech that stands up to the power that pushed their bodies to the edge of precarity. Thus, hope is materialised into action by our defiance of every action and regime and power that threatens the survival of the human species and the

interconnected web of life to which it is interconnected and within which it exists. Hope leads us to question all wars of genocide and mass destruction. Hope leads us to question all laws that illegalise non normative sexualities and genders. Hope leads us to take care of those we know are going to die irrespective of all the care we give them. Hope is based on the protection and care of everything that sustains life and a rejection of everything that is inimical to life.

Hope can be experienced as a dogged persistence in the face of a closed future. A stubborn defiance of a political, social or familial regime that is so pervasive and powerful that it is seemingly invincible. Hope can exist as a belief in change that sustains one through periods of intense personal and historical hopelessness. Such a belief could be based on the memory of a past that has survived brutalities and cruelties. Such a belief could be based on retrieving feeble and faint acts of unruliness against power that exist at the interstices of the present. Hope can manifest through the eccentric defiance of authority. Two contemporary examples of such a dogged persistence of hope in the present come to my mind. In the documentary film titled, 'While We Watched' directed by Vinay Shukla and based on the professional life of the journalist Ravish Kumar there is a point where Ravish is shown giving addressing his colleagues at NDTV after having received the Ramon Magsasay award for 2019. He says,

> Every award has a context. All of us at NDTV are going through tough times. When journalistic values in our industry have gone for a toss, it's hard to protect your values and continue believing in them. Everyone tells us that our way of doing things is not relevant anymore. That we are outdated, But I believe good things never get old. They live forever and that's why we should continue. Despite abuses and threats. I mean what more can I say about this. Keep speaking and keep writing. It can get scary. But keep conquering your fears with practice. You keep doing your bit and we'll keep doing ours. Thank you.[3]
>
> In his speech Ravish also says, "Resistance is not a matter of choice."

Prior to this Ravish is shown receiving a bouquet of flowers for having been nominated for the award. A note which is inserted into the bouquet is later read out to the viewers and it says, "Ravish is the voice of the voiceless He

3 *While we Watched,* directed by Vinay Shukla (2022; BRITDOC Films, 1 hr. 34 min.). The quoted lines are spoken at 1:08:16–1:07:26 towards the conclusion of the documentary.

has set an example for brave journalism giving a ray of hope to the entire country.[4]

The documentary shows the dogged stubbornness with which Ravish continues his journalistic war against media disseminated misinformation and hate, as his professional world disintegrates around him and his personal world is threatened with violence and hate. What sustains him is the dwindling professional community that sticks with him, the immediate past of a journalism that could speak truth to power and had the institutional support to do so and the home and family and community of friends and colleagues that stands in love and comradeship with him. Hope materialises through the practice of conquering fear because resistance is mandatory and not a choice. The documentary shows that hope is sustained through communities standing by each other or communities forming around a beacon which sustains their hope. Hope is made possible by establishing such solidarities through which power can be questioned. It is from these collectives that a united language of speaking truth to power is organised and a new grammar of defiance is structured.

Another contemporary instance of hope manifesting itself in defiance is the struggle by women of the Malayalam film industry which led to the Hema Committee Report. The lone act of a woman taking recourse to the law against a powerful patriarchal film industry whose brutal force was instantiated through her organised rape by a powerful male actor, led to a community of women being formed around her to support her. That act of defiance could have resulted from a violation so egregiously violent that it pushed the woman to a point where retaliation and resistance were the only possible responses. But that act of dangerously eccentric defiance led to a community of women forming around her. A community that spoke truth to power. The voice of that community revealed the unnatural grammar of the language through which power had normalised itself through brute strength and violence and threat. In an interview with the journalist Barkha Dutt, Parvathi Thiruvotu, a member of the Women's collective in Cinema, says that it was hope that sustained the Women's Collective in their struggle. The following is an excerpt from that interview:

> Barkha: Let me start by asking you what does this moment feels like? It's been such a long fight for you for others in the collective. I know you've been at it for nearly five years. You have been meeting with the members of the Kerala government. You yourself appeared before this panel. I think you called it somewhere a bittersweet moment. How would you describe what you are thinking and feeling right now?
>
> Parvathi: Thanks Barkha, when the report came out, I was in a state of shock because I had completely given up hope for the last four and a half years and whoever had their vested interest in keeping the report under the carpet had made us beg and grovel for it. I genuinely had given up hope. The collective never does give up hope and that I am so grateful for the fact that I have these women around me and we get to help each other get back on track when we lose hope.[5]

Hope is reaffirmed and materialises into action when a community is formed through the experience and articulation of a common oppression. Such an articulation produces a strange new spectacle of the marginalised, organising themselves into public visibility. They converge to form a powerful group that is speaking what has hitherto remained unspeakable. When we hear that speech, we realise that silence is imposed by fear and not because there is an absence of speech. The spectacle of that speech and its dissemination creates a proximity between all those who have suffered from that silence and have been scattered and made lonely because of their invisibility. When some of those who have been invisibilised become visible then the hope of visibility spreads to all those who have been made to suffer such a silence. To become aware that it is possible to speak and to be listened to and that speech can disassemble and transform an existing world in which silence was normalised, is a great ray of hope. It builds communities and establishes strategies of rebellion. It shows that power was just a surface without depth that could pretend it had depth because we were made to believe so. That when fear is thrown away the structures of power which generated that fear are also thrown away. That there is the possibility of alternative structures of proximity and association among the beleaguered and the powerless which can vest them with immense power. That when they organise themselves into powerful communities they can wrest speech and agency from the stranglehold of power and shape it to their needs.

Hence, hope can be experienced as the linkages of community that persist in the face of attempts to delegitimise and destroy the weak and the vulnerable. Such linkages could be experienced at the level of smallest

4 *While we Watched*, 1:07:09–1:06:55 towards the conclusion of the documentary.

5 Parvathi Thiruvotu, "Parvathy on Kerala Sexual Abuse Storm as Mohanlal Breaks Silence After Mass Resignations," interview by Barkha Dutt, *Bottomline with Barkha*, Mojo Story, YouTube video, published 31 August 2024, 2:13–3:13 from the start of interview, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=1HNYicvO1TY, accessed 10 August 2025.

social unit like the family or through the formation of larger groups and communities. The courage to initiate such communities may be fuelled through the memory or memorialisation of immensely courageous communities in the past that have struggled and triumphed through solidarity. It is in the coming together of such communities that new configurations of theory and praxis can be generated. Such communities are formed at the points of confrontation and through the intersection of social locations. It is the coming together of differently marginalised communities that defamiliarisation takes place.

The German playwright Bertolt Brecht coined the theatrical concept of *verfremdungseffekt* or defamiliarisation. As a theatrical device it was an attempt to alienate the audience from a perceptual normality structured through the historical commonsense within which they lived. It was an attempt to startle the audience out of its routines of living and seeing, normalised and naturalised under their present economic and political conditions of existence. By theatricalising events and actions and putting them within brackets and decoupling them from the familiarity of the perceptual conventions of the historical present they were made strange and initiated the astonishment that was the precursor to critical thinking. Such an astonishment led to what Brecht calls as critical thinking. Critical thinking in turn initiates a process of disassembling the socio-political structures that naturalise the present conditions of living. Such a disassembling opens the possibility of reassembling the social and economic relations in more egalitarian and humane ways. Brecht's epic theatre performs the structuring of social agency and stages the social props that support enable such agency.

Outside the theatre, such a *verfremdungseffekt* is forced upon us at those moments when differently marginalised socio-political locations intersect within our experiential world. When the banality and invisibility of routinised violence is spectacularised through its experiential defamiliarisation and its momentary decontextualisation from the routines within which it was normalised. When our experiential location is trespassed, overlapped and seeped by grids of intelligibility that are simultaneously familiar, as well as radically and critically unfamiliar it leads to an epistemological rupture. From such ruptures both dis-ease and hope are generated. The dis-ease with the normality into which we have been socialised and the hope that comes from recognising the historically contingent nature of this normality and the historical processes through which it has been manufactured and made ordinary. We realise that we can change the conditions of our existence in the world. We also discover that the social props and supports that are required to bring about that change can be built through our alliances with communities that share this dis-ease. We begin to hope in an open-ended history that can be shaped through human agency.

I am fully in concurrence with the pope's message of hope and I read in it a message for the establishment of a humane and radically egalitarian society. A society structured through the reciprocity of care, concern and the mutuality of love and fraternity. I concur with the pope's vision of a humane world and the personal, social and political practices through which such a world can be achieved. The signs of hope in our times are the signs which indicate and reaffirm the human need and capacity to visualise and establish a world of radical equality and deep humanity. It signifies the existence of human agency shaped through a vision of a better human society, an agency that is instrumental in shaping human history in liberating ways. Where I differ with the pope is that I see this history as envisioned and shaped through the material conditions and possibilities of human existence. I concede that human history has, and can, accommodate the hope that is based on the belief in a transcendental power named as and shaped into God. The visualisation of such a transcendental power is a leap that we take into faith and hope. The faith through which we imagine and hold on to a perfection that is historically necessitated and constituted but as yet absent in its imagined perfection, in the present. Our recourse to hope in all its varied forms is necessitated and sanctioned by our attempts to create an equal and humane society. I am deeply touched by the Pope's message of hope because not only does it highlight and critique the inequalities of our present world but it also speaks of the love and care and concern through which the most brutal and unacceptable inequalities of our times have to be confronted and healed. But I believe that we can only dream of, plan for, and strive towards establishing such a society from within the limits of our history and the limitations of our corporeality. We attempt to achieve the humane society through the errors, contingencies and experiments of human history. And that history is open ended and accommodative of many varieties of life, some of which Christianity may consider as sinful.

Part I

Horizons of Hope: Foundational Analysis

Heterogeneity and Hope
A Contemporary Philosophical Exploration

Nishant A. Irudayadason

Abstract

This essay explores the intricate relationship between heterogeneity and hope, through the lens of contemporary philosophical thought, focusing on Jacques Derrida's concepts of différance, avenir, messianic waiting, justice to-come, and democracy to-come. By engaging with the philosophies of Derrida, alongside thinkers such as Martin Heidegger, Hannah Arendt, Emmanuel Levinas, Mikhail Bakhtin, and Judith Butler, the essay examines how embracing difference and indeterminacy opens new pathways for justice, community, and ethical responsibility. Derrida's vision of hope emerges not as a fixed or idealised future but as an ongoing, open-ended process where meaning, justice, and political life are always to-come. This approach resists closure and invites a continuous engagement with the Other, offering a critical framework for rethinking the future in an increasingly heterogeneous world. The essay highlights how Derrida's philosophy opens new avenues for research in political theory, ethics, and contemporary identity studies, where questions of différance and responsibility remain central.

Keywords: *Alterity, Avenir, Democracy to-Come, Différance, Heterogeneity, Hope, Indeterminacy, Justice to-Come, Messianic Waiting, Natality, Polyphony, Performativity, Plurality, Otherness, Relational Ethics*.

Introduction

In 1784, Immanuel Kant famously posed the question: *What is Enlightenment?* His answer, "Sapere aude! Have courage to use your own reason," encapsulated the spirit of an age characterised by a profound confidence in human reason and the prospect of progress. However, as the 20th century unfolded, that optimism was met with increasing scepticism. Two World Wars, the Holocaust, and the nuclear age shattered the Enlightenment dream of a rational, unified world order. In response, philosophers began to reconsider the nature of human existence, language, identity, and the possibility of hope in the face of historical trauma and the fragmentation of meaning. This intellectual shift, especially evident in the works of thinkers like Jacques Derrida, opened new avenues for understanding how heterogeneity—understood as difference, diversity, and multiplicity—might itself be a source of hope.

This essay explores the concept of hope through the lens of philosophical heterogeneity, focusing on the contributions of Derrida and other significant 20th century philosophers such as Ernst Bloch, Judith Butler, Emmanuel Levinas, Martin Heidegger, Hannah Arendt, and Mikhail Bakhtin. These thinkers have all grappled with the nature of language, identity, and otherness, and in doing so, have opened new ways to think about hope not as a fixed ideal or distant utopia, but as something grounded in the fluidity of the present and the potential for transformation that arises from recognising and embracing difference. In particular, the essay will investigate how Derrida's key ideas of *différance*, *avenir* (the 'to-come'), *messianic waiting*, and *justice to-come* offer a vision of hope that is inherently tied to heterogeneity and the constant deferral of meaning.

The guiding research question of this essay is: *How do Derrida's concepts of heterogeneity and hope reshape traditional philosophical notions of the future, identity, and justice?* This question is significant not only for understanding Derrida's own philosophy but also for its broader implications in contemporary thought. In a world increasingly marked by social, political, and cultural divisions, passing through differences without erasing them has become one of the central ethical challenges of our time. Derrida's work and that of his contemporaries provide a framework for rethinking hope in ways that move beyond the binaries of past and future, self and other, and presence and absence. This essay will argue that by

embracing the indeterminacy of meaning and the irreducibility of difference, Derrida opens up a space for a future that is not predetermined but always in the process of becoming—thus allowing for the possibility of justice, community, and hope that are continually *to-come*.

The Searle-Derrida Debate: Language, Meaning, and Heterogeneity

The exchange between John Searle and Jacques Derrida on the nature of language marks a critical moment in contemporary philosophy, particularly concerning concepts of heterogeneity and hope. A fundamental disagreement about the nature of meaning and communication structure is at the heart of this debate. Searle, grounded in the Anglo-American tradition of analytic philosophy, offers a theory of language centred on the idea of speech acts.[1] According to Searle, speech acts operate within a system of shared social conventions, which rely on the speaker's intention to convey meaning. He divides speech acts into locutionary, illocutionary, and perlocutionary categories, each of which plays a role in communicating meaning. Locutionary acts refer to the simple act of producing sounds or words, illocutionary acts are concerned with the communicative force or intent behind the utterance, and perlocutionary acts involve the effect the utterance has on the listener. In Searle's view, this system depends on the inherent stability of meaning, which arises from the cooperative nature of linguistic exchange. This view presupposes a straightforward relationship between language, intention, and meaning. Searle's emphasis on the stability and conventionality of language reflects his broader commitment to a philosophical framework where language serves as a reliable vehicle for conveying fixed meanings across different contexts and users. His theory, therefore, appears to downplay the complexities and ambiguities that may arise in the communication process, prioritising instead the speaker's role in determining the meaning of their utterance. This perspective, however, has profound implications for how we understand not only language but also the conditions of social interaction, as it suggests that communication operates on a foundation of mutual intelligibility and consensus.

Derrida's response to Searle, most notably articulated in his essay *Signature Event Context*, offers a radical challenge to this conventional understanding of language.[2] Derrida introduces the concept of *différance*, which disrupts the premise upon which Searle's speech act theory is

1 John Searle, *Speech Acts: An Essay in the Philosophy of Language* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1969), 16–19.

2 Jacques Derrida, "Signature Event Context," in *Limited Inc*, trans. Samuel Weber and Jeffrey Mehlman (Evanston, IL: Northwestern University Press, 1988), 1–23.

built.[3] For Derrida, meaning is never fully present or fixed at any given moment but is always deferred through an endless process of signification. *Différance* thus captures how meaning is constantly postponed, never fully arriving at a final or definitive interpretation.[4] This deferral means that language is intrinsically open to reinterpretation, misunderstanding, and transformation, as each act of communication carries the possibility of differing interpretations within it. Derrida's critique reveals that language, far from being a stable medium for transmitting meaning, is instead a site of fundamental indeterminacy, where meaning is constantly in flux. This recognition of the instability of meaning introduces the notion of heterogeneity in language itself. For Derrida, every utterance is marked by a heterogeneity of possible meanings, as the conditions for communication are never entirely under the control of the speaker or listener.[5] Rather than being a failure of communication, this indeterminacy is a fundamental characteristic of linguistic exchange, which allows for the continual reworking of meaning across different contexts.

This openness to reinterpretation allows Derrida to connect the concept of heterogeneity with that of hope. The instability of meaning, far from being a weakness of language, is instead the source of its creative potential. Because meaning is never fully determined, language becomes a space where new interpretations, new perspectives, and new possibilities can emerge. This potential for transformation, inherent in language structure, mirrors a broader ethical possibility—the possibility of opening up communication to voices that have been marginalised or excluded. By recognising the indeterminacy of meaning, Derrida suggests, we also open ourselves to the ethical demand of responding to the other in ways not predetermined by existing structures of power and knowledge. The recognition of linguistic heterogeneity thus becomes a form of ethical openness, where the encounter with the other—whether in language or life—is never fully resolved or concluded but remains an ongoing, hopeful process of negotiation and transformation. Derrida's philosophy, in this sense, offers a vision of hope grounded not in the certainty of meaning or the finality of communication but in the indeterminacy that defines our encounters with language and each other. As such, the Searle-Derrida debate transcends a mere technical dispute about the nature of speech acts; it reflects the ethical and political dimensions of language, where heterogeneity is not a problem to be overcome but the very condition of hope itself.

3 Searle, *Speech Acts*, 44.

4 Derrida, "*Signature Event Context*," 17.

5 Jacques Derrida, *Of Grammatology*, trans. Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1997), 73.

Bloch's *The Principle of Hope*: Utopia and the Future

Ernst Bloch's *The Principle of Hope* offers a profound and transformative perspective on hope, adding significant depth to the philosophical conversation about utopia and the future. For Bloch, hope is not a passive or merely speculative notion; rather, it is an active, dynamic force that arises from human consciousness and imagination. Central to Bloch's philosophy is the concept of utopia, which he understands as a projection of the not-yet-realised possibilities that are inherent in the present. Utopia, for Bloch, is not merely a distant ideal but a reflection of the world's incompleteness and the potential for its transformation. Recognising that the present is unfinished creates space for hope to flourish, suggesting that reality is always open to change and renewal. Bloch's view of the future is thus characterised not by continuity with the present but by a radical break from it—an opening towards a better, more just, and more equitable world.[6]

Bloch's idea of utopia is marked by its inherent heterogeneity, as it refuses to reduce the future to a single, predetermined ideal or a static end state. Instead, he conceives of utopia as a multiplicity of potential futures, each shaped by individuals' and communities' diverse and often conflicting aspirations, struggles, and desires. In this sense, utopia is always in flux, evolving with the collective dreams and efforts of people striving for a transformed world. Within this framework, hope is not simply a passive anticipation of a better future; it is the active, creative force that propels individuals and societies towards envisioning and working for a future that departs fundamentally from the present.[7] Bloch's emphasis on hope's dynamic and creative dimensions resonates strongly with Jacques Derrida's ideas concerning the openness and indeterminacy of language and meaning. Both thinkers suggest that hope is born from the recognition of uncertainty and the possibility of transformation, reflecting a philosophical alignment in their understanding of openness as a condition for linguistic and social change.[8]

Moreover, Bloch's vision of utopia is fundamentally relational. It is not an isolated or solitary dream but must be collectively constructed, shared, and realised through dialogue and solidarity. This conception of utopia as a collective project aligns closely with Mikhail Bakhtin's understanding of heterogeneity within language and culture. Bakhtin, like Bloch, emphasises the plurality of voices, perspectives, and meanings that contribute to the

6 Ernst Bloch, *The Principle of Hope*, trans. Neville Plaice, Stephen Plaice, and Paul Knight (Cambridge: MIT Press, 1995), 196.

7 Bloch, *The Principle of Hope*, 73.

8 Derrida, *Of Grammatology*, 92.

richness and complexity of social life.[9] In this sense, Bloch's utopian hope is not an abstract ideal but a practical and ethical demand: it calls for a continuous engagement with others, an openness to difference, and a commitment to the future as a space of shared possibility. This collective dimension of hope also finds echoes in the ethical writings of Emmanuel Levinas and Derrida, particularly in their reflections on otherness and the ethical responsibility to the other.[10] For all these thinkers, hope is not merely a private or individual emotion but a collective force that emerges from recognising differences and openness to new possibilities. Within this space of collective hope, the potential for a more just and humane world can begin to take shape.

Butler and Heterogeneity: Gender, Identity and Hope

Judith Butler's exploration of gender and identity offers a profound philosophical framework for understanding heterogeneity and hope that resonates across social and political contexts. In *Gender Trouble* and subsequent works, Butler critiques the normative frameworks that structure gender identity, arguing that identity is not a fixed or stable essence but a fluid, performative process.[11] For Butler, gender is not a core, internal attribute but something enacted and constituted through repeated social performances. This performative nature of identity reveals the intrinsic heterogeneity within the self, as the self is always in a state of becoming, continually reshaped by external pressures, expectations, and actions. The notion that gender and identity are not pre-given but constructed through social interaction means they are always open to reinterpretation, contestation, and transformation.[12] Butler's insights challenge the traditional binary notions of gender, highlighting instead the multiplicity and fluidity characterising human identity. This perspective foregrounds the heterogeneity within individual and collective identities, as each gender performance carries the potential for disruption, resistance, and redefinition.

Butler's focus on the fluidity and performativity of identity opens the door to a philosophy of hope grounded in the potential for change. She posits that by resisting the rigid categories of gender and identity imposed by normative structures, individuals and communities can work towards a

9 Mikhail Bakhtin, *The Dialogic Imagination: Four Essays*, ed. Michael Holquist, trans. Caryl Emerson and Michael Holquist (Austin: University of Texas Press, 1981), 273.

10 Emmanuel Levinas, *Totality and Infinity: An Essay on Exteriority*, trans. Alphonso Lingis (Pittsburgh: Duquesne University Press, 1969), 43.

11 Judith Butler, *Gender Trouble: Feminism and the Subversion of Identity* (New York: Routledge, 1990), 25-33.

12 Butler, *Gender Trouble*, 136–139.

more inclusive and progressive vision of human diversity. This vision of hope, however, is not utopian in the classical sense; it is not a dream of an ideal future detached from the present. Instead, Butler's conception of hope is rooted in the everyday struggles of individuals to assert their identities and claim their rights amidst the constraints of societal norms. Hope, for Butler, emerges from the capacity to resist and subvert these norms, revealing the possibility of progressive change in the here and now.[13] This hope is embedded in the ongoing process of contestation, where marginalised and oppressed individuals challenge the structures that confine them, creating space for new ways of being and new forms of recognition. In this way, Butler's understanding of hope is intimately tied to action—specifically, the actions that disrupt and displace oppressive systems of gender and identity.

Butler's emphasis on the performative nature of identity also intersects with Jacques Derrida's concept of *différance*, particularly in its insistence on the instability of meaning. Just as Derrida argues that language is never fully present or fixed, Butler suggests that identity is always in the process of becoming, shaped by external forces but never entirely determined by them.[14] This ongoing process of becoming mirrors the heterogeneity of language itself, which, for Derrida, is marked by an endless deferral of meaning. In Butler's framework, identity, like language, is never complete or settled; it is always in flux, subject to redefinition and reinterpretation. The recognition of this fluidity is where hope resides, for it is this very openness—this refusal of finality—that allows for transformation and resistance. Butler's notion that gender, identity, and social roles are not set in stone opens up possibilities for hope within diverse communities, as it implies that individuals and groups can challenge and reshape the oppressive structures that define their lives.[15] In this sense, hope is not an abstract ideal but a concrete, lived reality continually realised through acts of defiance and creativity in the face of constraint.

Through her work, Butler expands the philosophical discussion of heterogeneity beyond the realm of language into the domain of identity and politics. In doing so, she advocates for a vision of hope that is inextricably tied to the recognition and affirmation of diversity. Her philosophy challenges rigid and exclusionary conceptions of identity, urging us to imagine a future in which identities are not confined to narrow categories but are allowed to flourish in their multiplicity and complexity. This vision of hope is deeply connected to the broader struggle for social justice, as it

13 Judith Butler, *Undoing Gender* (New York: Routledge, 2004), 1–16.

14 Jacques Derrida, *Of Grammatology*, trans. Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1997), 68.

15 Butler, *Undoing Gender*, 40.

demands dismantling oppressive norms and creating a more inclusive and equitable society.[16] By engaging with the fluidity of identity, Butler opens up new possibilities for understanding both the self and the social order, positioning hope as a force for collective liberation and transformation.

Bakhtin: Dialogue, Heterogeneity, and Hope

Mikhail Bakhtin's reflections on language, culture, and dialogue provide a profound framework for understanding the relationship between heterogeneity and hope, contributing to contemporary discussions on these themes. Central to Bakhtin's theory is the concept of *dialogism*, which posits that language is inherently polyphonic, a term he uses to describe the multiplicity of voices that coexist within any linguistic or cultural context.[17] For Bakhtin, language is never monolithic or singular but always a site of interaction between different perspectives, histories, and meanings. This polyphony of language mirrors the diversity of human experience, where each voice carries its own distinct worldview yet exists in dialogue with others. Rather than viewing heterogeneity as a problem to be resolved, Bakhtin embraces it as a fundamental aspect of human existence. The richness of language, and by extension culture, stems from this constant interplay of differing voices, shaping the complexities of human experience through dialogue.

Bakhtin's embrace of heterogeneity in language bears a strong affinity with Derrida's critique of the stability of meaning, yet there is a significant distinction between their approaches. Derrida's focus, particularly through his concept of *différance*, highlights the inherent instability and deferral of meaning within language, where meaning is never fully present or final.[18] For Derrida, language is marked by indeterminacy, as each signifier points beyond itself, making meaning always contingent. Bakhtin, while acknowledging the fluid and dynamic nature of language, emphasises the potential for mutual understanding through dialogue.[19] For Bakhtin, the interaction of different voices does not merely expose the instability of meaning but also presents the possibility for dialogue and negotiation between perspectives. In this dialogic process, hope emerges not from a fixed or stable meaning but from the recognition that meaning is always co-constructed through the interactions of diverse voices. Bakhtin's view is

16 Judith Butler, *The Psychic Life of Power: Theories in Subjection* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1997), 103.

17 Bakhtin, *The Dialogic Imagination,* 76.

18 Jacques Derrida, *Of Grammatology*, trans. Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1997), 66–68.

19 Bakhtin, *The Dialogic Imagination*, 259–260.

that no single voice can claim authority or a monopoly on truth; rather, it is through the dynamic process of dialogue that new meanings and possibilities are continually created.

This dialogic vision of language carries significant ethical and political implications, particularly for societies characterised by cultural and ideological heterogeneity. Bakhtin suggests that in such contexts, hope is to be found in the potential for dialogue between diverse groups, each bringing its unique experiences, histories, and perspectives into conversation with the others.[20] Rather than striving for a unified, singular vision of the future, Bakhtin's philosophy of hope encourages the recognition and affirmation of difference. Through the very process of engaging with otherness—through conflict, disagreement, and negotiation—a vibrant, pluralistic society can emerge. Dialogue becomes the medium through which new meanings are produced, and this openness to the interplay of diverse voices offers a hopeful vision of the human community. In such a society, disagreement is not a barrier to progress but an essential element of a thriving democratic ethos.

Bakhtin's ideas on dialogue and heterogeneity resonate with Emmanuel Levinas's ethical philosophy, particularly in their shared emphasis on recognising and engaging with the Other.[21] For both Bakhtin and Levinas, the encounter with difference is not something to be feared or eradicated; rather, it is through this encounter that ethical responsibility and hope arise. In his notion of the face-to-face encounter, Levinas stresses the ethical imperative to respond to the Other, to recognise their difference and vulnerability. Similarly, Bakhtin's dialogic philosophy insists that the recognition and engagement with differing voices create new possibilities for understanding and coexistence.[22] In both frameworks, hope is not found in a homogenised vision of the world. Still, new possibilities for ethical and political futures can emerge in the ongoing dialogue process, where difference is affirmed.

Thus, for Bakhtin, heterogeneity is not a threat to hope but its foundation. Human communities can cultivate hope through the openness to multiple voices and perspectives, as dialogue enables the creation of spaces where new ideas, understandings, and futures can be imagined. In this sense, Bakhtin's work offers a hopeful vision of society, where conflict and difference are not seen as obstacles but opportunities for growth and transformation. His philosophy suggests that the encounter with otherness

20 Mikhail Bakhtin, *Problems of Dostoevsky's Poetics*, trans. R. W. Rotsel (Ann Arbor: Ardis, 1973), 95.

21 Emmanuel Levinas, *Totality and Infinity: An Essay on Exteriority*, trans. Alphonso Lingis (Pittsburgh: Duquesne University Press, 1969), 39–42.

22 Bakhtin, *Problems of Dostoevsky's Poetics*, 252–253.

is unavoidable and necessary for continually reimagining the future, a future grounded in the possibilities that arise from the richness of human diversity.

Levinas: Ethical Encounter with the Other

Emmanuel Levinas's ethical philosophy, particularly his reflections on otherness, provides a profound framework for understanding the moral implications of heterogeneity. In *Totality and Infinity*, Levinas challenges the traditional philosophical focus on knowledge, mastery, and the subject's dominance over the world. Instead, he insists that the self's most fundamental relationship with the world is ethical responsibility towards the Other.[23] This shift from knowing to ethical responsibility radically reconfigures the nature of human relations. Levinas argues that the encounter with the Other is not merely a cognitive event but a moral one, where the self's totalising tendencies—its drive to subsume all difference into its framework—are disrupted. In Levinas's terminology, the face of the Other confronts the self with a demand that transcends understanding and comprehension, calling it into an ethical relationship that exceeds the boundaries of totality.

For Levinas, the Other signifies an irreducible alterity, a difference that cannot be assimilated into the self's worldview.[24] The Other remains beyond the reach of the self's conceptual schemes, representing a radical heterogeneity that refuses any reduction to the same. This encounter with the Other introduces a profound ethical dimension to recognising heterogeneity. It is not merely a matter of acknowledging diversity in abstract terms but of confronting the self with an ethical demand that arises from the presence of the Other. The Other's uniqueness and radical difference place a responsibility upon the self to respond ethically. In this encounter, the self's tendency to dominate, totalise, and render the Other intelligible in familiar terms is disrupted. Instead, the self is called to act in a manner that respects and preserves the Other's uniqueness and irreducibility. Heterogeneity, in this context, is not a challenge to be overcome but a condition for ethical engagement and responsibility.

Levinas's ethical philosophy also offers a distinctive vision of hope intimately tied to the ethical encounter with the Other. For Levinas, hope is not oriented towards achieving some distant, predetermined future but is embedded in the present encounter with the Other.[25] The face of the Other opens up the possibility of new ethical relationships, solidarity and community that emerge not from sameness but from the recognition of difference. In this sense, hope is found in the possibility of ethical renewal,

23 Levinas, *Totality and Infinity*, 33–34.

24 Levinas, *Totality and Infinity*, 43–45.

25 Levinas, *Totality and Infinity*, 204–205.

which arises through the ongoing encounter with otherness. Levinas suggests that the irreducibility of the Other, their heterogeneity, makes hope possible. The openness to the Other, the recognition of their alterity, enables the self to envision new forms of ethical community and solidarity, communities grounded not in homogeneity but in the affirmation of difference.

Thus, in Levinas's philosophy, heterogeneity becomes the foundation of hope. The possibility for moral transformation and renewal emerges through the ethical recognition of the Other's radical difference.[26] Levinas's thought challenges us to reimagine human relationships not as closed systems of knowledge or control but as open, dynamic engagements with otherness. Hope is not about the certainty of a predetermined future but the openness to ethical possibilities that arise in the face-to-face encounter with the Other. This encounter disrupts the self's totalising tendencies. It offers the potential for creating new ethical relations where responsibility and solidarity are grounded in the affirmation of difference rather than the erasure of it. In this way, Levinas's philosophy not only deepens our understanding of the ethical dimensions of heterogeneity but also presents a hopeful vision of human relationships, one that is grounded in the ongoing engagement with the Other's irreducible alterity.

Heidegger and Arendt: The Future, Natality, and New Beginnings

The theme of the future occupies a crucial space in the philosophical investigations of both Martin Heidegger and Hannah Arendt. However, their approaches diverge significantly, offering complementary yet distinct insights into the interplay between heterogeneity and hope. In *Being and Time*, Heidegger's notion of *Sein-zum-Tode* (being-toward-death) establishes the future as a central element of human existence.[27] For Heidegger, the future is not simply a chronological extension of the present; rather, it is a horizon of possibilities that reveals the fundamental openness of *Dasein* (human existence). Heidegger's exploration of the future is inherently tied to his concept of temporality, where the anticipation of one's death confronts the individual with the radical contingency of existence. While often interpreted as a source of existential anxiety, this confrontation with finitude also brings forth the possibility of authentic existence.[28] Through this recognition, the individual gains a sense of freedom, understanding that life is not a pre-determined sequence of events but a series of choices that project one's being into the future. Heidegger's future is thus imbued with

26 Levinas, *Totality and Infinity*, 208–210.

27 Martin Heidegger, *Being and Time*, trans. John Macquarrie and Edward Robinson (Oxford: Blackwell, 1962), 279.

28 Heidegger, *Being and Time*, 310–311.

both existential weight and potential for transformation, as it reflects an openness to possibilities that have not yet been realised. Importantly, while the individual's finite existence shapes the future, Heidegger argues that it carries the potential for hope, allowing *Dasein* to transcend its present limitations and envision new ways of being.

Heidegger's emphasis on temporality and mortality is met with a significant reinterpretation in the work of Hannah Arendt. In *The Human Condition*, Arendt introduces the concept of natality, which she argues is the true marker of human freedom and hope.[29] While Heidegger situates the future within an individual's confrontation with death, Arendt turns toward birth and new beginnings as the foundation of human potentiality. For Arendt, natality represents the capacity for spontaneous action, the ability of human beings to initiate something entirely new, thus breaking free from the determinism of the past. This capacity for new beginnings, she argues, is central to the political sphere, where human action manifests in the creation of new communities, institutions, and possibilities for collective life.[30] Arendt's understanding of the future is deeply tied to the plurality of human existence. In her view, every new beginning responds to the uniqueness of individual perspectives, ensuring that the future remains open, unpredictable, and heterogeneous. This heterogeneity, far from being a source of disorder, is, for Arendt, the very foundation of political hope, as it allows for the continual renewal and reinvention of the human world through collective action. Unlike Heidegger, who focuses on the solitary confrontation with finitude, Arendt's future is shaped by the communal and generative possibilities of human action, where each individual, by acting, introduces new potentialities into the world.

Despite their differing orientations, both Heidegger and Arendt converge in their recognition of the future as a realm of openness and possibility, albeit in different registers. Heidegger's future is fundamentally shaped by the individual's existential awareness of death, which reveals the finite horizon of human existence. Through this awareness, *Dasein* is called to authenticity, choosing its path in light of its ultimate end. This confrontation with mortality is not solely negative. Still, it opens up the possibility for transformation, as the individual is freed from the illusion of permanence and can project themselves into new modes of being.[31] For Arendt, however, the future is not defined by the limits of mortality but by the boundless potential of human action. The concept of natality foregrounds

29 Hannah Arendt, *The Human Condition* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1998), 9–10.

30 Arendt, *The Human Condition*, 178–179.

31 Heidegger, *Being and Time*, 353–354.

the capacity of each individual to act in ways that introduce something unprecedented into the world, a process that is inherently collective and political. Arendt's emphasis on action as the realisation of new beginnings contrasts with Heidegger's more solitary vision of authenticity, suggesting that hope resides not only in the individual's confrontation with finitude but also in the collective capacity for renewal.

Both thinkers conceive the future as open and heterogeneous, replete with possibilities that resist any final determination. Heidegger's existential analysis points toward an individual openness to the future, where the self is continually redefined through its engagement with finitude. On the other hand, Arendt envisions the future as a space for collective action and renewal, where the birth of each individual brings the promise of new beginnings.[32] In both cases, the future represents the refusal of closure, a space where the possibilities of transformation and change sustain hope. Whether through Heidegger's emphasis on the authenticity of *Dasein* in the face of death or Arendt's focus on the generative power of action, both thinkers underscore that the present is never the final word. The horizon of the future remains open, a site where new beginnings and possibilities are always within reach, offering a hopeful vision of human existence.

Derrida: Hope, Heterogeneity, and the Future-To-Come

An exploration of heterogeneity and hope, one cannot overlook the profound contributions of Jacques Derrida, whose philosophy offers a radical rethinking of both concepts. Derrida's engagement with language, temporality, and ethics, particularly through his key ideas of *différance*, *avenir* (the "to-come"), messianic waiting, justice to-come, and democracy to-come, articulates a vision of hope that is intricately tied to the inherent heterogeneity of human existence. Derrida does not simply present a philosophy of hope in a conventional sense but one that is inextricably linked with an ongoing openness to difference, undecidability, and the ungraspable nature of the future. His work invites us to reconsider hope as an expectation that does not rely on the closure of fixed meanings or predetermined outcomes but rather as an ethical and political commitment to what remains unforeseeable, unpredictable, and always exceeding what can be anticipated.

At the core of Derrida's thinking is the concept of *différance*, which signifies both the deferral of meaning and the difference that is always at play within language and existence.[33] Derrida's *différance* problematises

32 Arendt, *The Human Condition*, 247–249.

33 Jacques Derrida, *Margins of Philosophy*, trans. Alan Bass (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1982), 3–27.

the notion of stable, fixed identities or meanings, instead pointing towards the endless play of traces, where meaning is always deferred, never fully present. This inherently unstable nature of language and meaning opens up the space for heterogeneity, as it reveals that there can be no singular, totalising truth or identity. In Derrida's framework, heterogeneity is not merely a feature of social or linguistic life but fundamental to the structure of existence itself. The inability of language to fix meaning once and for all allows for the continual emergence of new possibilities, interpretations, and identities. In this sense, *différance* can be seen as the condition of possibility for both heterogeneity and hope. Hope, for Derrida, does not rely on the eventual closure of meaning or the fulfilment of a predetermined goal but rather on the openness that *différance* perpetually sustains—the openness to difference, to the unexpected, and the "other."

This idea of openness is further developed in Derrida's concept of *avenir*, often translated as the "to-come."[34] *Avenir* reflects Derrida's understanding of the future as something that cannot be anticipated or known in advance. The future, for Derrida, is not a predictable extension of the present; it is what arrives unexpectedly, always beyond the horizon of our knowledge or expectations. This notion of the "to-come" is deeply intertwined with his reflections on messianic waiting. However, Derrida's messianism is what he calls a "messianism without a Messiah."[35] It is not oriented towards the arrival of a specific figure or event that will bring about salvation or closure but rather towards an open-ended waiting for something that is always "to come." A radical openness to the future characterises this messianic waiting, acknowledging that what is to come will be beyond our capacity to foresee or control. In this sense, hope is not tied to a specific expectation but to a stance of openness and receptivity to the unknown. It is a waiting without the guarantee of fulfilment that recognises the irreducible heterogeneity of the future and the impossibility of fully determining what is to come.

In his reflections on ethics, Derrida extends this openness to the future into the realm of justice. Justice, for Derrida, is always "to come"—it is never fully realised or present but remains an aspiration, something we must continually strive towards.[36] This idea of justice to-come is closely linked to Derrida's critique of the law. While laws are necessary for organising society and regulating behaviour, Derrida argues that the law can never fully capture or encompass the demands of justice. Laws are always finite,

34 Jacques Derrida, *Specters of Marx*, trans. Peggy Kamuf (New York: Routledge, 1994), 52–58.

35 Derrida, *Specters of Marx*, 63.

36 Jacques Derrida, *Force of Law: The "Mystical Foundation of Authority,"* trans. Mary Quaintance, Cardozo Law Review 11, (1990), 919.

limited by the contexts in which they are formulated and applied, whereas justice, in its truest sense, exceeds any particular legal framework. For Derrida, justice cannot be reduced to the calculable or the predictable; it demands an openness to the other, the singularity of each ethical encounter, and the possibilities that remain beyond the grasp of any codified system of laws.[37] In this sense, justice is inseparable from heterogeneity, as it requires ongoing responsiveness to the unique and the other rather than imposing a universal or homogeneous set of rules. Hope lies in the possibility of justice, even though it is never fully present or complete—it is always deferred and yet to come.

This notion of justice to-come also extends to Derrida's reflections on democracy. In *The Politics of Friendship* and other writings, Derrida introduces the idea of democracy to-come (*la démocratie à venir*), which, like justice to-come, is never fully realised or present but remains an ongoing project.[38] For Derrida, democracy is always incomplete in a state of becoming, because it must remain open to the inclusion of those who have been excluded, marginalised, or silenced. Democracy, in this sense, is not a stable system or a fixed set of institutions; it is a continual striving towards greater inclusivity and openness, a recognition that the promise of democracy is never fully fulfilled.[7] The very structure of democracy, for Derrida, requires heterogeneity, as it is predicated on the recognition of difference, plurality, and the rights of the other. Hope in the context of democracy to-come is thus not the hope for a perfect or final political order but the hope that the project of democracy can continue to evolve, adapt, and respond to the demands of justice, even as those demands remain elusive and always deferred.

Derrida's insistence on the openness of justice and democracy is crucial for understanding his philosophy of hope. In contrast to utopian visions that promise a final resolution to the problems of injustice or inequality, Derrida's thought embraces the impossibility of closure. Hope, for Derrida, is not about reaching a final destination or achieving a state of perfection; it is about remaining open to the future, to the other, and the possibility of transformation. This hope does not seek to resolve heterogeneity but to live within it, to affirm it as the condition of possibility for justice, democracy, and ethical responsibility.[8] In this way, Derrida's philosophy offers a vision of hope that is deeply intertwined with the recognition of difference and the refusal of any totalising system that would seek to erase or assimilate that difference.

37 Derrida, *Force of Law*, 927–928.

38 Jacques Derrida, *The Politics of Friendship*, trans. George Collins (London: Verso, 1997), 306.

Furthermore, Derrida's engagement with the idea of *différance* and the future also connects with his critique of metaphysics, particularly the metaphysical desire for presence, certainty, and fixed meaning.[9] Derrida's deconstruction of metaphysical thought reveals that the desire for a fully present meaning or truth is a form of closure, denying the inherent heterogeneity of existence. By contrast, Derrida's philosophy affirms difference's irreducibility and finality's impossibility. In this context, hope is not about securing certainty or closure but about embracing the openness that *différance* makes possible. It is a hope that refuses to be confined by the boundaries of metaphysical thinking and instead looks towards a radically open, unpredictable, and heterogeneous future.

In Derrida's thought, then, heterogeneity and hope are inseparable. The recognition of the irreducibility of difference, the openness of the future, and the impossibility of final justice or democracy is not a cause for despair but the very condition of hope.[10] Hope arises from the fact that the future is always to come, that justice and democracy are always to come, and that *différance* ensures that no identity, meaning, or system can ever be fully closed off or complete. This is a fundamentally ethical hope, as it demands an openness to the other and a commitment to justice, even though that justice remains perpetually deferred. It is also a political hope, as it requires a continual engagement with the project of democracy, understood as an ongoing process of inclusion, transformation, and responsiveness to the demands of justice.

Derrida's philosophy offers a radical rethinking of both heterogeneity and hope. In contrast to traditional notions of hope tied to the fulfilment of a predetermined goal or the realisation of a final state of perfection, Derrida's hope embraces the future's openness, undecidability, and unpredictability. It is a hope that recognises that the present is never the final word, that justice is never fully realised, and that democracy is always in a state of becoming.[11] This hope is not passive; it is an active and ethical commitment to the other, the future, and the possibility of transformation. In this way, Derrida's thought invites us to reconsider the relationship between heterogeneity and hope, offering a vision of the future that is open, plural, and always exceeding what can be anticipated or controlled.

Conclusion

Throughout this essay, we have explored the complex interplay between heterogeneity and hope through the philosophical perspectives of Derrida and several other key figures in 20th century thought. What becomes evident in this exploration is that hope, in the philosophical sense, is not a simple or naïve optimism about the future; it is, rather, a deeply ethical orientation that acknowledges the multiplicity and indeterminacy inherent

in human existence. Derrida's philosophy, particularly his concepts of *différance*, *avenir*, *messianic waiting*, and *justice to-come*, offers a nuanced understanding of hope that resists closure and embraces the unknown. For Derrida, the future cannot be predicted or controlled; it is always open, always deferred, and always shaped by the irreducible alterity of the Other.

This vision of hope is closely tied to Derrida's work's ethical and political dimensions. The notion of *justice to-come* signals a form of justice that can never be fully realised or institutionalised. Yet, it remains a guiding ideal that motivates our current actions. Likewise, *democracy to-come* points to a form of political life that is always incomplete, always in the process of becoming, and always open to new voices and new forms of participation. In both cases, Derrida emphasises that true justice and democracy require an ongoing openness to difference and a willingness to engage with what is other, unfamiliar, or marginalised.

The implications of this for contemporary philosophy are significant. Derrida's work challenges us to rethink the foundations of political and ethical life, not as fixed or static but as dynamic processes continually shaped by encounters with otherness. This opens new avenues for research in areas such as postcolonial theory, feminist theory, and environmental ethics, where questions of difference and responsibility to the Other are central. Moreover, Derrida's insistence on the undecidability of meaning invites further exploration into the nature of language, identity, and the self in an increasingly globalised and interconnected world.

In moving beyond traditional metaphysical frameworks that seek to stabilise meaning and identity, Derrida provides a way of thinking about the future that is not about closure or finality but about openness and possibility. His philosophy of heterogeneity and hope calls us to embrace the complexities and uncertainties of human existence, recognising that new possibilities for justice, community, and hope emerge in the very multiplicity of voices, perspectives, and identities. In a time marked by social and political fragmentation, Derrida's thought offers a critical and necessary reminder that hope is not something that lies in a distant, utopian future but is always present in the here and now, in the very act of engaging with the other, of listening to new voices, and of remaining open to what is yet to come.

2

Thrown to Life, Born to Hope
Philosophical Reflections

Johnson J. Puthenpurackal

Abstract

This paper is a reflective journey with the human as existing with its two-directional opening: to the 'already' (thrown to life) and to the 'not-yet' (born to hope). Human being is gifted with the ability to keep on becoming and with the responsibility to respond to. Human existence stands rooted in one's inevitable givenness; I am 'thrown to life.' My thrownness conditions and enables me to be this particular I. Standing rooted in my thrownness, I go forward with hope. As 'thrown to life,' humans are 'born to hope.' 'Hoping' is a forwarding of human existing as becoming. Hope is not a category but an existential. In the act of hoping, one transcends, and not eliminates, the struggle against despair. Hope is thus fragile and finite. It bridges the present with the future; it keeps on enabling us to be moving—ever moving to the never reachable! Hope should link the 'eschatology' of messianic hope and one's 'responsibility' for the other. The grace of hope can be changed into a curse of despair by human defiance. Only persons of courageous hope, founded on faith and built on love for society can shape the history of humankind into the future.

"I have a dream…" cried out Martin Luther King Jr. in his well-known speech on 28 August 1963 at the Lincoln Memorial in Washington,[1] vibrating the collective dream of a group of people—people without any hope![2] Hope that is based on one's existential experience and struggle is both daring and rooted; in one word, an existential hope is born of one's creative and dynamic existing. This paper is not an analytical study on the theme of hope, but rather a philosophically reflective journey with the human as journeying—an ever-moving journeying! Human existence stands open to both the directions: backward and forward, to the already and to the not yet. We begin by elucidating as to what it means to exist as human (I), to be followed by the two-directional opening in the form of existence as 'thrown to life' (II) and as 'born to hope' (III), and the study is ended with some concluding reflections.

Keywords: *Choice, Courage, Despair, Existing, Forwarding, Hope, Optimism, Rootedness, Thrownness.*

I

As per the contemporary Western thought, the human is considered as a movement, a dynamic process, a journeying—all these meanings are summed up in one term, 'existence,' as understood in existentialism.

Many of the 20th century Western thinkers, especially Martin Heidegger, lament that 'being' has been mostly considered in the *nominal* sense (pointing to *a thing* that is), instead of the *verbal* sense (denoting the *activity* of being)—the static *fact*, rather than the dynamic *act* of being. The term 'being,' despite its admittedly nondescript appearance, is the most active of all activity words. In fact, all the so-called activities, such as walking, playing, speaking, etc., are simply an overflow of the *act* of being that an entity has![3] Even an inanimate thing like a stone exhibits the *act of being*;

1 The speech was delivered to a great crowd of demonstrators, demanding justice and equality for all: blacks and whites.

2 "…I have a dream today…that one day every valley shall be exalted, and every hill and mountain shall be made low. The rough places will be plain and the crooked places will be made straight; …" Using Biblical expressions (Luke 3: 4–6) the speaker affirms his firm hope that all hurdles, however strong they may be, will be overcome. The ABBA song too hints at overcoming the hurdles through phrases such as '…I'll cross the stream...,' '...pushing through the darkness,' etc.

3 Cyril Desbruslais, "Existence," in *ACPI Encyclopedia of Philosophy* (Bangalore: Asian Trading Corporation, 2010), 508.

of course, in a very minimal way by just *being* a stone.[4] The *act of being* is more evidently seen in living organisms, and most evidently in humans!

In the humans we find the *act of being* in the most intense manner. The existentialists use the expression, 'act of *existing*,' rather than 'act of being,' while referring to the humans; they take 'existence' in the active and dynamic sense of the *act* of existing, and not the *fact* of existence.[5] As the *act of existing* is best realised in the humans, the notion of 'existence' in the active and dynamic sense is exclusively reserved for the humans; only *they are able to exist*. Only insofar as I *exist* as human, I am human. I exist as human by keeping on choosing to be human.[6] Human being is not just one among the numerous beings; s/he is a uniquely different being gifted with the ability to transcend or to stand-out to be 'more' and 'different.' It is by standing-out or transcending that s/he exists as a human being.

The human being as *existing* keeps on standing-out or excelling; but is there any fixed 'whither' to which it stands out? The answer is both 'yes' and 'no': yes, insofar as the human stands out to itself; no, insofar as its standing-out is not to the identical itself, but to the different itself. If my 'standing-out' were to be to the identical myself, I do not *exist*, rather, I merely *am*—it is like any other object that continues to be just as it has been! Thus, by virtue of my existence, I keep on journeying to myself to be myself.

Almost all the existential thinkers hold to the priority of self-creativity in the meaning of human existence. For Nietzsche (1844–1900), human existence is characterised by a constant *becoming* by 'overcoming oneself'; he conveys this thought with a symbolic expression, referring to the human as a 'tight-rope walker' who is always on the move.[7] Human existence as the never-ending movement consists in one's fundamental 'can be' or ability

4 Spinoza calls the 'act' of every being to remain in being its *conatus*, and Aquinas recognises such dynamism at the heart of all reality and considers it as a being's *synderesis*.

5 As per the traditional understanding, existence (is-ness) has been understood in opposition to essence (whatness), which is applied to everything including humans. In this traditional sense the mere *fact* of being human is one's existence.

6 This dynamic meaning of existence can be better expressed and clarified with the help of its etymological meaning of 'standing-out' (*ex* + *stare*). It is developed with the help of some creative coinages in my book, *Human Existence as Home-Coming: An Approach in Reflective Phenomenology* (Bangalore: Asian Trading Corporation, 2015), 29–39.

7 While walking on a tight-rope, one cannot make a long pause; it is in moving that one gets the balance to remain on a tight-rope. Nietzsche refers to the human being also as a 'rope' that is tied between, or a bridge between, the animal (at times, the ultimate man) and the superman. This too refers to the human who has to be constantly 'becoming.' Although apparently a fixed 'whence' (animal) and 'whither' (superman) is given for the sake of stylistic and linguistic beauty, these are to be taken as non-existent.

to be oneself, to create oneself in freedom—in the words of Kierkegaard (1813–55), an 'existential choice[8] to be oneself,' in the language of Nietzsche 'becoming oneself,' and in the language of Heidegger (1889–1976), an 'ontological transcendence' or self-transcendence. As the human is ordinarily prone not to be itself, there is engrained in the very Being of the human a constant call—a call from itself to itself to be itself.[9] In my 'act of *existing*,' I keep on 'standing out' from myself to be myself. This ontological call is ontically responded to by the human by means of its 'resoluteness' (*Ent-schlossenheit*),[10] which is a personally and individually made choice to be oneself.

Humans become human, not by maintaining themselves in existence, but by growing in their existence; and this 'dynamic becoming' is the philosophical meaning of existence. Humans are able to be; they are gifted with transcendence or 'can be' aspect. The animals merely are; we the humans exist insofar as we can keep on growing in what we are. One's ability to create oneself is not merely a gift to be preserved, but a responsibility to be constantly responded to. What we are, we can be; if we can be what we are, then we ought to be so—the trilogy of *is-can-ought*! A little of explanation seems to be in place. My being human is not something that is statically given to me; it is given to me with a 'can-be'—with my ability to grow in my being human. If I am given that ability, I ought to make use of this ability. Thus, 'ability' goes with 'responsibility.' This fundamental responsibility or ought-character is ingrained in the 'can-be' character of every human being. Thus, human being, as gifted with the ability-to-be itself, has the responsibility to keep on growing in one's existence. As humans in their existence are creative and dynamic, their life and thought

8 It is Kierkegaard, and to a lesser degree Heidegger, who have worked it out in their philosophy. Kierkegaard takes choice as a 'leap.' It is in proportion to the gravity of the question on which I make a choice that there will be the greater or lesser struggle of choice. In every leap, in an eminent way, in the leap of faith, I am in the grip of anxiety or struggle of choice: should I, should I not? This struggle is created by 'objective uncertainty' and 'subjective certainty;' insofar as that which I choose or leap to remains in darkness, I am repelled by it, and insofar as I have a subjective certainty, I am attracted by it. This experience of *attraction* and *repulsion*, sympathy and antipathy, is the existential struggle of choice—the experience of anxiety. Faith as leap links and dissolves the objective uncertainty and subjective certainty. It is the struggle of choice to be oneself. Cf., *ACPI Encyclopedia of Philosophy* (Bangalore: Asian Trading Corporation, 2010), s.v., "Choice, Existential."

9 Cf., Heidegger, *Being and Time*, trans. John Macquarrie and Edward Robinson, 3rd ed. (Oxford: Basil Blackwell, 1973), 317–323.

10 Heidegger, *Being and Time*, 343. The term, *Entschlossenheit*, combines in itself the twofold nuance of the ordinary meaning of 'decision,' and the etymological meaning of 'opening.'

can rightly be characterised as a *way*, as a *journeying*, as a *process*. 'Way' implies 'movement' with emphasis on '*moving'*—the 'whence' and the 'whither' of the movement are not of importance.[11]

The point that we want to underline here is that human existence is a vibrating and dynamic phenomenon, extending itself to either direction: *backwarding* and *forwarding*—rooted in its givenness and open to go ahead.

II

The ever-vibrant and dynamic 'human existence' is well-*rooted* in one's inevitable givenness; life is given to me, or I am '*thrown to life*.' My existence is 'conditioned' in various ways; the fact of my being *conditioned* is referred to as thrownness, givenness or facticity.[12] I realise, not that I just exist, but that *I exist as this particular 'I.'* I cannot exchange my existence for the existence of another. *I am I*! This appears to be a tautology, yet it expresses that I am this particular I; I have this particular body; I am of the particular race and colour; I was born at a particular place and time; I have this particular heredity, this particular IQ, EQ, SQ, AQ, CQ, PQ, MQ, BQ & KQ,[13]—this particular 'everything'! I am also a product of the decisions of some specific socio-cultural group. The decisions of people whom I never knew and who never knew me are shaping my life and the related events,[14]

11 In order to highlight the relation between movement and way, Heidegger has beautifully made use of the archaic form of the German term for 'movement' (*Bewegung*)—its archaic form is *Be-wëg-ung* ('way-making movement'). The 'way' goes on, but there is the constant temptation to 'fix' a goal or a 'whither' for it. Thus, we have different schools of thought, each school giving their own 'fixed label' to the way. The 'way' remains the same, but different people appropriate it differently, as a result of which the 'way' gets stagnated.

12 This too is typically a Heideggerian notion, developed in his *Being and Time*.

13 Besides IQ (Intelligence Quotient), which is popularly known, there are other 'Q' measures: EQ (Emotional Quotient): Measures emotional intelligence, self-awareness and social skills; SQ (Spiritual Quotient): Assesses spiritual intelligence, values, and connection to something greater; AQ (Adversity Quotient): Evaluates resilience, ability to cope with adversity, and stress management; CQ (Creativity Quotient): Measures creative thinking, problem-solving, and innovation; PQ (Physical Quotient): Assesses physical health, wellness, and fitness; MQ (Moral Quotient): Evaluates moral values, ethics, and decision-making; BQ (Body Quotient): Measures physical intelligence, body awareness, and movement skills; KQ (Knowledge Quotient): Assesses knowledge acquisition, retention, and application. These various 'Q' measures provide a more comprehensive understanding of human abilities and potential. Information provided by Meta AI, accessed 25 September 2024.

14 Paul Vadakeoram, "Facticity," in *ACPI Encyclopedia of Philosophy* (Bangalore: Asian Trading Corporation, 2010), 521.

in which I am today caught up, or privileged to be.[15] All these constitute the '*thrown* dimension' of mine, because of which I am what I am today.

The '*thrown* dimension' of human existence is ordinarily considered only as the limiting element that curtails and disables one's existence to a great extent. Without denying it, we also find that human thrownness enables one to be what one is; it is because of my specific thrownness that I am this specific I; my thrownness enabled me to be this specific I. Human possibilities, both individual and social, are always set in a framework of givenness; possibilities crop up from the given situation. Thus, existence never escapes from the tension between possibility and facticity. On the one hand, the human is open to one's possibilities; on the other hand, one is conditioned by one's factical situation into which one is already cast. Thus, human existence is rooted in one's givenness.[16]

To exist as rooted in one's thrownness implies that I exist as someone with a particular identity. My identity of being an Indian refers to the 'Indianness'[17] that I carry with. My identity is not something that is momentarily and casually given; it is deeply rooted in me. What I have been (my givenness) cannot be separated from what I am (my identity). The kind of givenness into which one is thrown shapes one to a great extent. Human Existence is not only what one has already become by virtue of one's givenness, but also what one can still become. Hence the human is faced with the dialectics of necessity and possibility; on the one hand 'it is decided for me,' on the other, 'I can still decide for me.' Thrownness *disables* me by limiting my possibilities; thrownness *enables* me by furnishing me with possibilities!

Humans grow and make progress by creatively choosing from the given possibilities. In comparison to the non-human creatures, the humans keep on growing in many respects as they are able to be creative and innovative in their choosing and living of possibilities. My givenness of being an Indian limits my possibilities to this givenness, and hence it does

15 These two expressions—'caught up' and 'privileged to be'—are used for highlighting that 'thrownness' does not necessarily have only a negative tone in its meaning, but also a positive one.

16 Various are the ways in which the humans find themselves as thrown or in their givenness, some of which are the following. Spatial givenness (the place of one's birth); temporal givenness (the time, the year, the period of one's birth and life); religious givenness (the religious group or set-up into which one is cast); cultural givenness (the cultural milieu—agrarian, urban, tribal, etc—that one is given); intellectual givenness (one's intellectual capacity); physical givenness (the type of physique, one's complexion, height, weight, etc.); sexual givenness (whether one is male or female); economical givenness (financial status of one's family); etc.

17 *ACPI Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, s.v., "Indianness."

not let me have those possibilities that I could have had if I were to be a German. Thus, my innovative ability is limited by my being an Indian. At the same time, the givenness of my being an Indian enables me to have possibilities that I would not have had, were I to be a German. Thus, one's givenness disables and enables—a finite enabling. It is my rootedness in my givenness that enables me creatively to go ahead. What I am *already*, I am *not yet*; the 'I'—the identity of human existence—links and relates the *already* and the *not-yet*, the *rootedness* and the *forwarding*. Standing rooted in my thrownness, I go forward with courage and hope. As 'thrown to life,' humans are 'born to hope.'

III

We are thrown to life! We are given life, not merely to be preserved, but to be *lived* and to keep it moving and growing. It is made possible when we have something to hope for.[18] Martin Luther King cried out "I have a dream…," when he and his people had nothing to dream of,[19] nothing to hope for! Hope, as an existential of the human, flows from human existence. The phenomenon of 'human existence' has brought us to the realisation that we are not mere 'finished products,' but rather 'dynamic *becoming'*; we see ourselves, not as *human beings*, but rather as *human becoming*;[20] 'hoping' is a *forwarding* of human existing as *becoming*. The 'dynamic becoming' becomes a 'joyful and purposeful becoming,' when it is supported and accompanied by hope, and hence we are 'born to hope.'

Hope is founded on and flows from human existence; existence cannot be thought of without the existential act of hope, which is not a *category* in the Aristotelian sense, but an *existential* in the Heideggerian sense.[21] Marcel comes closer to this thought when he says that hope is not a *having* that I possess, but a *being* that I am. Although what I have is at my disposal, it does not constitute my being. But 'being hopeful' is ontologically given to me to

18 Macquarrie puts it negatively, saying that without hope, "it would be impossible to go on living." John Macquarrie, *In Search of Humanity: A Theological & Philosophical Approach* (London: SCM Press, 1982), 243.

19 Humans are the creators and receivers of dreams. As creators of dreams, humans work towards ideals, visions, aspirations, targets, ambitions, goals, objectives, etc.; as receivers, humans keep themselves open any 'vision' that may emerge from out of the given situation.

20 John Macquarrie proposes that 'human becoming' is a more appropriate expression than 'human being.' Cf., Macquarrie, *In Search of Humanity*, 2.

21 In the place of Aristotelian (static) categories, Heidegger refers to (dynamic) 'existentials'—'ways of Dasein's being.'

be ontically responded to.[22] I cannot dispose of my 'being hopeful' without ceasing to be myself; hope belongs to my very being! Thus, as persons of hope, we are enabled to respond and to transcend the darkness of despair and the abyss of uncertainty. 'Transcending' despair and uncertainty is different from 'eliminating' them totally. Does it imply that despair is co-present with hope? Kierkegaard's reflection on the 'leap of faith' may be of help here. In making a choice—every leap is a choice, and vice versa—one experiences the struggle between *repulsion* due to 'objective uncertainty' and *attraction* due to 'subjective certainty.' In making a leap of faith, one 'transcends,' and not eliminates, the attraction-repulsion struggle; faith is *kept alive* through this struggle. Hope too cannot be considered as a situation of unadulterated optimism without any element of despair and uncertainty; human hope is *fragile* and *finite*, insofar as humans, with all their ambiguities of the future,[23] keep on hoping by their struggling against the constant leaning to despair and uncertainty. Can human hope be considered in its purity untouched by any element of despair!

Hope bridges the present with the future, the current situation to the desired future, giving us meaning and purpose. It takes us beyond the great barriers of presence and takes us to the realm of possibilities, giving us possibility to look up to, to be open to the unknown, to the beyond, to the transcendent,…[24] Thus, hope does not point towards a static something; rather it keeps on enabling us to be moving—ever moving to the never reachable! When Nietzsche gives 'superman' as the new meaning of the earth, and explains human dynamism in terms of 'will-to-power,' he does not point to some static and realisable 'something' to which humans are called to keep moving, but rather to the constant *process of becoming*. Just as humans are said to be existing insofar as they 'exist,' so also, they can be said to be *hoping* insofar as they keep themselves in the *act of hoping*. Thus 'hope' is not a *dead category* that humans possess, but a *live existential* that humans are called to be.

Hope is not to be identified with 'desire,' which is oriented to something definite and finite, a reachable something. Whether or not I get what I desire does not ontologically affect me; I continue to be what I am, with or without the desired object. Thus, in Marcel's language, desire belongs

22 What Kierkegaard had mentioned in his thought is given clarity by Heidegger by making a distinction between what is ontologically given and ontically responded to. He does it while dealing with the question of the 'call of conscience' (call is ontological) and the 'resolute response' (response is ontical). Cf., Heidegger, *Being and Time*, 317–348.

23 John Macquarrie, *In Search of Humanity*, 243.

24 Transcendent does not necessarily mean the Divine; it refers to 'the beyond' of the present.

to the metaphysical category of *having*.[25] When one gets what one desires, the subject gets puffed up with the possession. It indirectly asserts that hope belongs to the inner realm. Josef Pieper[26] makes a distinction between hope and optimism: hope is grounded in faith, whereas optimism relies on human efforts. As hope is not synonymous with optimism, the 'hoped for' cannot be narrowed down only to the future and to the positive; it implies that hope is directed to the 'whole beyond'—to the *ahead* and to the *already*—just as memory is not merely extended to the past, but also to the future—memory of the future![27] In this sense, hope links life *in time*, and life *beyond time*—a reference to immortality!

As an existential orientation, hope cannot be confined only to situations of existential struggle or moments of imminent danger, throwing one to the brink of falling into inevitable despair; such a selective hoping is carried out by necessity! Hope has to flow from one's existence—in the language of Heidegger, from the existing, thrown, falling person.[28] This takes us to a related aspect of hope as 'situated'—*rooted* in what one is. An 'act of hoping' that is not solidly rooted in one's being will be an uprooted hope without any existential depth. Existential hope has to be emerging from the whole person as existing, and not as a need when all doors are closed for any light to come in.

What one hopes for is something 'good' (*bonum*) in the ontological sense of the term, a hoping *sub ratione boni*.[29] What is hoped for is something welcome, desirable, beloved, wholesome and realisable. But it need not necessarily be realised; its realisation is beyond the control of one who hopes. Hope as an existential is not given to the humans as a readymade gift; of course, it is a gift—a gift to be received; a gift that calls for a response of personal appropriation. The depth of one's hope—the 'how much' of one's hope—depends, not on the gift given, but on the gift

25 My 'having'—what I possess—is at my disposal; it does not in any way affect my 'being.'

26 Josef Pieper, a German Catholic philosopher, has extensively reflected on hope, especially in his book '*On Hope*' (1954). According to him, fundamental hope, strictly speaking, cannot go with disappointment. 'Disappointment rests on experience—experience of non-fulfilment; in hope one does not anticipate; despair takes place as a result of the 'anticipation of non-fulfilment.'

27 Bergson refers to memory as embracing the whole of one's existence, extending to the past and to the future.

28 According to Heidegger, human existence consists of the three dimensions of one's 'ability to be,' (existing or projecting), one's thrownness (the given or factical dimension), and falling (the tendency not to be oneself).

29 Vincent Aind, "Hope," in *ACPI Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, 622.

received, on one's inner disposition of openness and choice.[30] The human response is indefinitely limitless in its 'how.' At no point one can set a limit for one's hoping as the maximum possible. In simple terms, the 'how' of one's hope is within the power and possibility of the human.

Hope is presented in greater depth and width in the philosophy of Emmanuel Levinas; he relates it to the 'eschatology' of messianic hope, and to one's 'responsibility' for the other. Messianic hope for one's salvation cannot be delinked from others' salvation, or rather one's responsibility for others' wellbeing. From the narrow confines of oneself and one's hope, Levinas, in keeping with his ethical thought, opens it out to the Divine realm and to the human society. It is not without any truth that many of the Marxists point out that religion is diverting our attention from human responsibility with the promise of hope; by repeated reminders about the promise of the *future*, humans are made to forget the struggles of the *present*, and their responsibility for those in struggle.[31] Unless hope is concretised in the form of actions for the wellbeing of others, reflections on hope will remain purely theoretical for intellectual consumption.

Gabriel Marcel, in his concern to develop a concrete ontology based on the indispensability of faith, hope and love, underlines the intersubjective dimension of hope by relating it to faith and love. In one's intersubjective relation with others, one transcends the realm of 'having,' and is in the realm of 'being.' But one's exigency for commitment, fidelity and transcendence is only partially realised in human interrelationships. Hence, one opens out one's commitment to the Absolute through one's intersubjective relation to the finite 'thou-s'; one's opening out to the Absolute Thou is a kind of blind leap into the unknown. Thus, Marcel blends together faith, hope and love, mutually implying one another; hope gets an inner strength with faith, and hope gets a decisive purpose with love.

* * * *

By way of concluding reflections, we reaffirm a few points of practical relevance. Human life is kept moving ahead since humans are able to hope. Then the question poses itself: why do only humans fall into extreme despair

30 Taking inspiration from Kierkegaard, Heidegger has worked it out in terms call and response. The German term used for human response is '*Entschlossenheit*,' which combines the meanings of openness and decision.

31 Albert Camus becomes more poetic when he gives expression to this question of the 'Christian-European' approach and attitude that is more 'future-oriented.' They (European Christians) turn their back to the concreteness of the here and now, and turn to the delusion of power; they reject the misery of the slums in preference to the mirage of an eternal city; they forget the ordinary justice and remind themselves of the Promised Land…

and commit suicide? Only one who can hope can fall into despair; unless one ontically appropriates the ontological gift of hope, there is every chance of one's landing up in the extreme situation of despair. The *grace* of hope can be changed into a *curse* of despair by human defiance.[32] Hope is the act by which one who has the courage to hope, victoriously overcomes the temptation to despair. Hence, every human is challenged to keep oneself transcending in hope; one's *ability* of transcending is one's *responsibility* as well.

Hope helps us to cope with existential anxieties, ambiguities and uncertainties by providing the sense of possibilities! It does not mean that hope takes away all dark elements from our life; rather, hope enables one to take one's life equanimously, that is, without being over-elated at positive experiences or over-depleted at negative experiences. It is significant to note here that Aristotle considers hope, placing it between despair and presumption.[33] Only persons of *courageous hope* and *creative dream* can shape the history of humankind well into the future; they are in the process of *becoming* and *creating* themselves, and along with them, the world as well.

Hope, as transcending, is a standing out into possibilities—into the *absence* of *no-more* and *not-yet*. This ability to extend oneself into the *already* and into the *ahead*—the ability to *see* the presence in its absence—is wisdom, and the one who sees it is the 'seer'![34] For a true 'seer,' hope goes with faith and love. Great persons like Mahatma Gandhi, Mother Theresa, Martin Luther King, Archbishops Helder Camera and Desmond Tutu, got the courage and strength to carry on their liberative works with determination, not from mere hope for a better morrow, but by a hope, coupled with faith in God and love for others.[35] It was a hope, born of the experience of the struggles of the people, whom they sincerely loved; it was a hope, built on their deep faith in God. The suffering related to one's standing with and for the people in struggle does not in any way diminish one's hope, rather it is strengthened by the endurance of the suffering. Such a hope is kept alive by the reverberating cries of the people in struggle, and the repeated divine

32 Kierkegaard makes a distinction between 'despair by weakness' and 'despair by defiance'; in the former case one cannot be found fault with, in the latter case, one is guilty!

33 Such a presentation of hope as the between the extremes is in keeping with Aristotle's understanding of virtue: '*Virtus stat in medio*.'

34 In the Indian tradition, philosopher is referred to as the 'seer' (*Darsanika*).

35 Vincent Aind, "Hope," in *ACPI Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, 624.

promise of support.[36] Marcel sums it up: "hope is a trusting abandonment founded on the ontology of intersubjectivity."[37]

Insofar as hope is founded on faith, and built on the shared human struggles and aspirations, it fosters solidarity and community; hope becomes a collective dream, a communitarian hope, a social transcendence, beyond the limiting borders of individual dream and hope.

36 The promise of divine support is presented in the Bible in such or similar words: "Do not be afraid; I will be with you."

37 As quoted by Vincent Aind, *ACPI Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, 624.

3

Hope, Hauntology, and After Hope

Victor Ferrao

Abstract

Have we reached a time that we might call After Hope? A society that seems to enter an After Future state may have also entered a state After Hope. A closed future also closes our Hope. Hope and Hauntology are intertwined. They express a tension between past, present and the future. Hauntology is a concept introduced by Jacques Derrida assists us to examine how the past and the future haunt our present, disrupting our common sense assumption about the linear flow of time. Hope, on the other hand is a driving force that allows us to envision and strive for a better present and the future. Together they manifest the complexities of our temporal existence and potentials for transformative change. Hope and Hauntology have a tensive relation. With the increase in gradients of Hauntology in our society, it appears that we have entered a state of After Hope and are still Hopeful. But without being pessimistic, here an attempt is made to show that there is still Hope for a society that seems to be drifting away in an absence of clear vision of the future. Hence, we examine how death is itself a living of Hope, every thought and act of thinking is embodying Hope. Hence, Hope is not dead, we still have hope for humanity that is living in a state that is named as After Future Society. Hoping against Hope can also be seen as After Hope.

Keywords: *After Future, After Hope, Endisms, (Dis)Figures of Hope, Hauntology, Hope, Spectral Politics.*

Introduction

Have we reached a time that we might call After Hope? A society that seems to enter an After Future state may have also entered a state of After Hope. A closed future also closes our Hope. Hope and Hauntology are intertwined. They express a tension between past, present and the future. Hauntology is a concept introduced by Jacques Derrida which assists us to examine how the past and the future haunt our present, disrupting our common sense assumption about the linear flow of time. Hope, on the other hand, is a driving force that allows us to envision and strive for a better present and future. Together, they manifest the complexities of our temporal existence and potentials for transformative change. This study strives to explore the complex tensive relationship of Hope and Hauntology. It is divided into five parts. The first part attempts to conduct a hermeneutics of Hope, then we attempt to explore how anxieties of losses and failures haunt us and affect our envisioning of a future, followed by the next section, where we try to figure out the (dis)figures of Hope, particularly from the perspective of death. In the fourth section, we take upon ourselves how every form of thinking is Hope-filled, and finally, we close our effort by seeking a courageous and critical response to a society that has entered a state of After Future.

The Hermeneutics of Hope

We cannot think of humanity without hope. Hope is vital to being human. Humans are indeed pilgrims of hope. This is why it feels right that Pope Francis gave us a theme for the ordinary year of Jubilee 'Pilgrims of Hope'. There are several thinkers of Hope. Musician Ernst Bloch is credited with having have deeply thought about hope.[1] Hope opens us. Humans without hope close themselves to the world and others. Hopelessness makes us passive and locked into nothing. Hope makes us outwardly allied and not inwardly aimed. Hope makes us belong and not withdraw from what is becoming. Existentialists tell us that we are thrown into the world that is not chosen by us. But it is hope that converts this thrownness into givenness/facticity that opens possibilities of being-in-the-world as Martin Heidegger would tell us.[2] Hope, therefore, enables us to dream. Hope makes us look for a better world and leads us towards it. This is why hope is not a simple

1 Ernst Bloch, *The Principle of Hope*, trans. Neville Plaice, Stephen Plaice, and Paul Knight (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 1986).

2 Martin Heidegger, *Being and Time*, trans. John Macquarrie and Edward Robinson (New York: Harper & Row, 1962).

daydream. It is not escapist. It is wakeful. It wakefully anticipates and walks to a better future. Hope does not take things as they are. Hope takes things as they go. Hope takes things into the future.

All thinking is imbued with hope. There is no thinking outside hope. Philosophy, therefore, is mediating hope. Thinking is a way of venturing to the beyond. But this venturing beyond does not go into a vacuum. It takes the present possibilities and actualises them in the horizon of the beyond. Hope remains in front of us not merely as a vision of the future but as an energy that enables every step that we take towards that dream future. Everybody in some way lives in the future. The future contains what is feared or what is hoped for. Hence, it is vital that we choose hope. We cannot fear hope and abandon it. Fear makes us feel that our present and future are lost. This is when, perhaps, fear takes over our hope. Our hope then becomes a hauntology.[3] When we feel that we have no future, we begin to feel anxious. Our fear takes control over us, and we then embrace a haunted hope that strives to give a future to a past that is viewed under the lens of what is called the Hegelian wound. Slavoj Žižek points out that a wound makes us idealise the time before the wound.[4] Hence, the time before the wound becomes sacred, and all energy is then invested to give a future to that idealised past. It is a bad immediacy of the present (the wound) that anticipates a lost future, and, under such a sense of hopelessness, one feels that one's secure past can become a new future.

We humans cannot work hopelessly. This is why even a deception, in order to be effective, has to work with flatteringly and corruptly aroused hope.[5] Hope preached from every platform may not be authentic. We need critical discernment to embrace true hope. Hope that pushes us merely inwards towards an idealised past or towards an empty promise of the other world in the future is certainly somewhat inauthentic.[6] Hope has a constitutive dimension of the present, although it does not lose sight of the past and the future. Hope does not cripple under the weight of the distressed present and the wounded past, but opens an outside that is promising emancipation. This outside stays in the future, but becomes a synergy that pushes us towards the promise of the future.[7] This is why perhaps we have

3 Jacques Derrida, *Specters of Marx: The State of the Debt, the Work of Mourning and the New International*, trans. Peggy Kamuf (New York: Routledge, 1994).

4 Slavoj Žižek, *The Sublime Object of Ideology* (London: Verso, 1989).

5 Bloch, *The Principle of Hope*, 73.

6 Jürgen Moltmann, *Theology of Hope: On the Ground and the Implications of a Christian Eschatology*, trans. James W. Leitch (London: SCM Press, 1967).

7 Bloch, *The Principle of Hope*, 144.

to follow the dictum of Jesus that declares: Let the dead bury their dead.[8] It is hope that enables us to let bygones be bygones. It is hope that will enable us to forgive ourselves and others for our/their failures and losses of the past. The nots/unbecomes of the past and the present are annulled by the not-yetness of the future. The unbecomeness of the unfulfilled past and present does not bog us down, since a new becoming that is coming in the future is visualised by authentic hope.[9]

Hope always stays in the coming. We always grow in hope. Hope is always a shifting destination. Hope, therefore, is always breaking-through the given. It does have a utopic aspect. It always remains a forward dream.[10] This is why we cannot lose sight of the future that remains in the coming. Life never really reaches a finishing line. There is always more to life. It is only hope that can see this more.[11] Even when we may feel there is nothing new under the sun or view life as nothing but a repetition, hope offers a different and novel side of life. Life, therefore, cannot be viewed as a chain of Time-and-Again.[12] Even in this life, the perceived Time-and-Again of the cynic, hope can see the novelty. Hope, therefore, is unending. There are no endings or closures. Hope in the coming is always in the coming, opening to us bigger and wider horizons of the future that we can dream and strive to actualise. It is an unclosed determineness. But the determineness of the unclosed hope is elastic and is always transcending.[13] The hermeneutics of Hope does remain unclosed and is forever open. When we inhabit this condition of hope, we will always walk as pilgrims of hope.[14] But we have to shun away the (dis)figures of hope induced by fear and embrace authentic hope. One of the important (dis)figures of hope is ultimately wedded to death. It is a fear that we always anticipate and await as a limit to our life. We have, therefore, the challenge to embrace this disfigured hope. It is only then that we can remain open to this hope that always stays in the coming, so that we will fully become what we hoped for at the arrival of death.[15] Hope in the coming is linked to death at many levels. Neither hope nor death, therefore, is a dead end. To us, they remain in the coming for now. It

8 Luke 9:60 (New Testament, Revised Standard Version).

9 Moltmann, *Theology of Hope*, 42.

10 Søren Kierkegaard, *The Sickness Unto Death*, trans. Alastair Hannay (London: Penguin Books, 1989), 88.

11 Bloch, *The Principle of Hope*, 219.

12 Moltmann, *Theology of Hope*, 196.

13 Jacques Derrida, *Aporias: Dying—Awaiting (One Another at) the "Limits of Truth,"* trans. Thomas Dutoit (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 1993), 77.

14 Žižek, *The Sublime Object of Ideology*, 213.

15 Kierkegaard, *The Sickness Unto Death*, 108.

is at the point of death, or rather when we live our death, that our horizon of hope will expand; we will be sufficiently open to the hope that death will open to us.[16]

Making Peace with Endisms

We have several prophets of doom. They proclaim the end of several isms and eras. These endisms have proclaimed the end of Christianity, Marxism, and everything that looks solid and lasting.[17] They are haunted by the anxiety of an end.[18] Endism produces a fear of closures. This anxiety produces a fear of losing something. It makes us think that something that we consider precious is in danger. This sense of something precious being in danger generates an anticipatory fear of loss.[19] In Goa, we are haunted by a loss of Goa, Goans, and Goan-ness. It produces various ways that we respond to political, economic, social, and religious issues. We can also see that the majority in our country is also gripped by a sense of Hinduism in danger. This fear produces a kind of politics that haunts our society. What it does is put us into a mode of uninterrupted disintegration driven by the hate of the other. We are, therefore, in the middle of the mode of life that is set into a dynamism that strives to recover that which is considered lost.

It is politics that is produced by the fear of loss of the ground beneath our feet.[20] We are held captive by a horrific fantasy that anticipates the loss before it has occurred. It arrests our thought and makes us act before everything is lost. We are hit by a spectre before the loss has really happened. We are taken over by a politics of self-preservation. Hence, this is called identity politics[21] and is produced by ethnocentrism and xenophobia. It is haunted by politics of memory and loss of inheritance and legacies. It is time that we learn to resist and rise above the syndrome of endism.

We need to make our peace with the fact that time is never in its place. Time is always out of joint.[22] This disjuncture of time cannot be seen as moral or social decay.[23] If we surrender to this thought that thinks of the

16 Derrida, *Aporias*, 89.

17 Derrida, *Specters of Marx*, 102.

18 Zygmunt Bauman, *Liquid Modernity* (Cambridge: Polity Press, 2000).

19 Bauman, *Liquid Modernity*, 45. Also see Ulrich Beck, *Risk Society: Towards a New Modernity* (London: Sage Publications, 1992), 36.

20 Frank Furedi, *Culture of Fear Revisited: Risk-Taking and the Morality of Low Expectation* (London: Continuum, 2006), 112.

21 Benedict Anderson, *Imagined Communities: Reflections on the Origin and Spread of Nationalism* (London: Verso, 1983), 89.

22 Derrida, *Specters of Marx,* 25.

23 Paul Ricoeur, *Time and Narrative*, Vol. 1 (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1984), 67.

disjuncture of time like a perversion of the founding values and principles of our society, we will step into identity politics. This lost past orients us to a recovery of a consummated future. What we need is a consummated present where we make peace with our disjointed time. The politics of today is fixated on a lost past and dreams for a consummated future while we shut our eyes to the present. This is perhaps why our people close their eyes to the grave failures of the ruling benches and remain silent about their excesses of exclusion and discrimination in our society. Therefore, it is urgent that we understand and accept the fact about the disjuncture of time. Time is always in the coming. The fact that time passes and stays in the coming, we are always haunted by the past and the future. This is perhaps why we are seized by endism that grips us with the panic of a loss.

This panic of loss becomes political and economic capital for those that exploit our fears. Fear is an industry, and there are those that create wealth milking our fears and anxieties as raw materials.[24] We can find this clearly at work in the wellness industry, medical establishment, and insurance industry, etc. Fear and anxiety are great sources of political capital. They produce a sense of loss of inheritance and identity and set in a dynamism of recovery that can degenerate into hate and divisions. It produces a spectral politics that already anticipates a loss and missionises people to work to preserve the same at several levels. Spectral politics is the return of the repressed and depends on a narrative that challenges its adherents to take pride in their inheritance and identity, which is deemed to be threatened.

We can clearly see how spectral politics shamelessly brazens out some things that could not be publicly said or done. Spectral politics manifests a decline in the moral standards of society.[25] We can see this in the silence of some sections of people over gross violations of human rights, even to the point of mass lynching. It camouflages our moral depravity and paints mindless murders like mass lynching, riots, and vandalism as noble acts. This means spectral politics decriminalises some of the worst crimes, which are considered to be committed to save that which is deemed as being in danger of extinction.[26] Thus, often that which is plain hate speech then becomes one that expresses loyalty and nobility. This means we are living with ghosts and phantoms that are let loose by our fears and anxieties.

24 Naomi Klein, *The Shock Doctrine: The Rise of Disaster Capitalism* (New York: Metropolitan Books, 2007), 78.

25 Žižek, *The Sublime Object of Ideology*, 56.

26 Hannah Arendt, *Eichmann in Jerusalem: A Report on the Banality of Evil* (New York: Viking Press, 1963), 89.

Often these fears and anxieties are socially engineered and are, therefore, unreal.[27] Thus, spectral politics is a hauntology. It is never real. It is ghostly and cryptic. Fear of death of inheritance and identity lives in each of us, and we live our life to save its death. The death of inheritance and identity are yet to come. In fact, it will easily come. It always remains in its coming. But we jump to a foreclosed thought and belief that a disaster is knocking at our door. The fact is that it is in an already and not yet mode of being. This already and not yet dynamism is phantomic and triggers a politics of recovery that has to be addressed and deconstructed. To do this we need to deconstruct the reigning hauntology(ies).[28] Thus to be able to deconstruct the reigning hauntology, we need the spectres of Jacques Derrida. We need to allow ourselves to be haunted by the spectres of Derrida so that we are enabled to interrogate how we are taken captives by ghosts and phantoms that are induced by unrealistic fears and anxieties. We need the spectres of Derrida to enable us to understand and respond effectively to the hauntolgies that are afflicting us today. It is by distantiation[29] that we can see what these hauntologies are doing to us and our society. This awareness achieved through distantiation is therapeutic. It can emancipate us from our chains of enslavement to the politics of spectrality that is ruining our society

(Dis)figures of Hope

Fear seems to rule our understanding of death.[30] It takes us to the edge of our life and we await for what is there still to come. It being a threshold that separates us from everyone and everything, it becomes a domain of darkness and fear. It even appears that this threshold separates one from oneself. One seems to have to leave one's death. This is why maybe Heidegger views death as a possibility of impossibility which was rephrased by Maurice Blanchot who sees death as the impossibility of all possibilities.[31] Blanchot appears to be talking about the moment of death and sees it as a closure. Heidegger's understanding still remains open and opens us to understand death as the fullest understanding of being human. It is the moment of death where we become fully what we as humans, hope for. Our hope at death

27 Derrida, *Specters of Marx*, 25.

28 Jacques Derrida, *Of Grammatology*, trans. Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1976), 158.

29 Ricoeur, *Time and Narrative*, Vol. 1, 67.

30 Heidegger, *Being and Time*, 294.

31 Maurice Blanchot, *The Space of Literature*, trans. Ann Smock (Lincoln: University of Nebraska Press, 1982), 101.

reaches its final fulfilment. This is why, perhaps, we might try to understand hope with the help of Jacques Derrida's notion of trace.[32]

Trace is waiting for what is to arrive and is always already its own erasure. Hope is a longing. A longing is a trace of what is to come. What is to come is already and not-yet. It is Derrida's *différance*. It is different and is delayed.[33] Hence, hope remains hope because what is to come is undecidable and open. What is to come remains in the zone of contingency, and therefore, we actively hope for its coming. Therefore, hope makes us wait for the other and not the same. Same belongs to everyday life. The other is not the same. Hope transcends sameness. Hope, therefore, cannot be totalised. I live my death but this death remains at a distance and remains other to me all my life. Death indeed is our ultimate hope.[34] To take the side of death is to take the side of hope. It is to take the side of all that is possible of me. Death in some way is the ultimate possibility of possibilities. It is our final way of being Human-in-the-world. Hope is thus, always haunted by the other. It is haunted by death. We are waiting for the fulfilment of the other. Hope in many ways becomes a hauntology. In this context, it is a benevolent hauntology.

Hope is (dis)figured to the point of death. It does not figure out death. It remains a secret to it until it unfolds.[35] Hope, therefore, is a figuration or (dis)figuration of death. What we assume death is, what we hope death is, is ultimately figured out or (dis)figured by death. This is why it is said that one who knows how to die knows how to live.[36] Learning to die lets us learn to live. We do try to figure or (dis)figure out death. It informs our deepest beliefs and values. We do hope and live for these beliefs and values. It is only in death that we figure out or (dis)figure out if our beliefs and values were worth living for. This is why taking the side of death (hope) is also taking the side of life. Paradoxically, death being a fulfilment, of our hopes, is kept aside that which does not truly belong to us. At death, all our inauthentic beliefs, values, and hopes remain aside as unfulfilled. Authentic hope fully flowers at the moment of not-being-able-to-be-there death. Hope does not see death as an absence. It ties death to the ultimate fulfilment of being-human-in-the-world. Death does involve being-not-able-to-be-there.

32 Derrida, *Of Grammatology*, 70.

33 Jacques Derrida, *Margins of Philosophy*, trans. Alan Bass (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1982), 12.

34 Ricoeur, *Time and Narrative*, Vol. 1, 67.

35 Jacques Derrida, *The Gift of Death*, trans. David Wills (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1995), 45.

36 Michel de Montaigne, *The Complete Essays*, trans. M. A. Screech (London: Penguin Books, 1991), 56.

But it opens us to the un-nameable fullness. It is un-nameable fullness because it stands beyond the calculus of exchange of the market (economy of the market) or either/or thinking (economy of reason) of our everyday thinking. It stands into the excess that is truly immeasurable. In some way, hope is, therefore, a hope for death. By taking the side of death, it takes us beyond the economy of the market and that of reason. This is why hope cannot be figured out. It can only be (dis)figured, and by living and dying.

This means death is hope that opens to un-nameable fullness. Death, thus, becomes an impossibility of being Dasein in the world but does not close other modes of being in and beyond the world. We, as beings-towards-death, move to the un-namable fullness. In this sense, hope is a spectre.[37] It is pointing to and leading us to something infinite, something surplus, something excess. With death, when one is no more, one becomes absent present. One is absent but present in multiple ways through memories and lives. One through death becomes spectral, the invisible visibility, an absent presence, a death in the living. There is an afterlife of every dead person. This afterlife is not just in heaven or hell. It lingers in our world, in our memory, and in our lives. After death, thus, everyone becomes a spectre that we may call a lost presence. But as a lost presence, one returns as hope to those who are left behind. Being spectral or figural, one turns into hope for one's dear and near ones. The dead, therefore, are spectres and hence, hope too becomes spectral. To be a spectre one cannot be fully present, hope too cannot be fully present. Spectre is the lost presence. Hope too is a lost presence. It is spectral. Hope is a gift.[38] It cannot be a gift before it is given. It becomes a gift in the giving. Hope becomes hope in the very act of hoping. Hoping requires us to leran to die. Montaigne rightly says, 'to philosophise is to learn to die.' Learning to die is learning to hope. Hope, therefore, in some way involves the ability to philosophise. It involves the challenge to take the side of life for learning to die is learning to live. Let us give ourselves the gift of hope.

Hopeful Philosophising

Thinking has a deep relation to hope.[39] All thinking is hopeful thinking. Even conservative thinking is hoping that change will not happen and works to prevent it. Philosophising is a way of hoping. Usually, hope enables us to imagine a different life from present circumstances. The catch is in the circumstances. It is in the manner we view our circumstances that

37 Derrida, *Specters of Marx*, 25.

38 Ricoeur, *Time and Narrative*, Vol. 1, 67.

39 Hannah Arendt, *The Human Condition* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1958), 12.

hope becomes an illumining vision. This is why, whatever may be our orientations, we can still find latencies and tendencies within the horizons of the circumstances that can enable us to imagine a different future. This is why, all thinking can be characterised as hopeful thinking. But we have to take care. Hannah Arendt teaches us that hopeful thinking can be contaminated by messianism which promises to offer redemption from ills of the present in the future.[40]

When messianism takes control over us, hope becomes dark. This is a condition when hope is bent to serve vested interests. Walter Benjamin cautions us to guard ourselves against the messianic arrest of our thought.[41] In such a condition, we give up thinking. We give up philosophising. We think that the messiah will come and put things in place. Our life then becomes a hauntology. We are hopefully waiting for the messiah to come. Such a condition is indeed a messianic arrest of our hope. Under such a condition, we have the challenge to hope against hope. It is an imperative to philosophise. When we stop philosophising, we stop thinking hopefully.

Hope is a promised land. It also offers a happy ending. It enables us to go through what we may call catharsis in search of the promise of hope. We usually link hope with utopia.[42] The dialectics of hope is always thought to be positive and progressive. But this is not always true. Hope can deceive us. Hope can run on a negative dialectics. It can become a trap and deception. This is why Žižek invites us to embrace the courage of hopelessness.[43] He tells us hope often looks like a light at the end of the tunnel. But light at the end of the tunnel can be the headlight of a new engine that is coming to crush us. That is why we cannot blindly embrace any messiah who is offering us hope and give up thinking. Arendt says that hope, under such conditions, can become a dangerous barrier for acting courageously in dark times. Hence, we have the challenge to embrace the courage of hopelessness. We cannot allow hope to overleap our thinking and our reality. Hope, within the bounds of critical thinking and not removed from our reality, is sure hope.

The courage of hopelessness is a thinking that is critically alert to the ways hope can be employed deceptively by vested interests.[44] Hopeful critical philosophising is a courage of hopelessness. It is authentic hopeful

40 Walter Benjamin, *Illuminations: Essays and Reflections*, ed. Hannah Arendt (New York: Schocken Books, 1968), 257.

41 Benjamin, *Illuminations: Essays and Reflections*, 257.

42 Bloch, *The Principle of Hope*, 45.

43 Slavoj Žižek, *The Courage of Hopelessness: Chronicles of a Year of Acting Dangerously* (London: Allen Lane, 2017), 89.

44 Slavoj Žižek, *The Courage of Hopelessness*, 89.

thinking. Such thinking generates a sure hope. But thinking that we call hopeful thinking, being a courage of hopelessness, is not a rationally measured response. It is one that emerges on the edges of desperation. Therefore, it is not Hegelian *Aufhebung*. It is the courage of hopelessness that enables us to refuse to escape into what may be called the fool's paradise. Unfortunately, when we stop thinking at hopeless times, the world steps into totalitarianism.[45] Hence, we have to remember that sometimes hope takes us away from the reality of the world, and, bewitched by the promise of a happy tomorrow, we enter the road of self-destruction.

Deviated hope, thus, can prevent us from acting in dark times. Hope that springs from the courage of hopelessness flows from the no longer (past) and the not yet (future). It is taking us into the present. This thinking rooted in the courage of hopelessness is deeply embedded in love. Such thinking produces our ability to save humanity and the world. This hope does not passively wait for a future outcome. It embraces the challenges of the living present and takes us to the task of saving the day. Thus, hope is not an article of belief that makes us wait for the opportune time to unfold. It is an article of action that learns to respond to the imperative of the here and now. This means hopeful thinking is not simply waiting for the promise of the future. It is action that initiates the coming of the promised change.

It is this hope-filled action that has the power to save us in dark times. Hopeful thinking that generates hope-filled action does not hope that the dark times will disappear. It is the courage of desperation that puts up action to do one's bit to push the darkness away by lighting a wick. Arendt calls this action *natality*, as it initiates new beginnings and its destination is not closed.[46] What we have called hope-filled action, emerging from hopeful thinking or philosophising, can also dynamically generate new beginnings, and its destiny is not fully determined. It is through constant and continuous hopeful thinking that new hope-filled actions will emerge that can take us to unimagined emancipative destinations. Hope is elusive and profoundly political. It requires thinking that we call hopeful thinking that has the courage of hopelessness. To engage in such hope-filled action, we have the challenge to belong to the unchosen people. This means we have to embrace the courage of hopelessness, even when the chosen people choose to live with hope that will only chain them.[47]

45 Hannah Arendt, *The Origins of Totalitarianism* (New York: Harcourt, Brace & World, 1951), 323.

46 Arendt, *The Human Condition*, 247.

47 Bloch, *The Principle of Hope*, 45.

After Hope

When we perceive a failure of the future, when we begin to feel that we have no future, we lose hope and experience acute anxiety. Do we then reach a point that may describe as After Hope? We do not like to have a dead end to our future. Shakespeare's *Hamlet* portrays this anxiety through a scene where Hamlet, on encountering his dead father says: 'time is out of joint.'[48] Something is not alright about the flow of life. Life seems to be falling apart. We seem to experience a haunted present. The future being closed, we only have the past to rely on. The past irrupts through its spectres. This makes our present feel strange and dissonant. We seem to be living in a state that has been rightly called After Future, by the Italian thinker Franco Berardi.[49] What is After Future is our experience of the present. The present is haunted by a sense of lost futures. The disappearance of the future has crippled our imagination. This is why the ability to hope is also disabled. We seem to have lost our capacity to imagine that the world could be radically different from what it is now. We have reached the end of history that was described by Francis Fukuyama.[50] Time has ended. We have touched the sky. History has come to its closure.

Future is always experienced as a haunting. As it stays in the coming, it impinges on our present. Can we substitute the term future with Hope? Hope too stays in the coming and is, therefore, softly haunting the present. With the disappearance of future, perhaps, we are experiencing the disappearance of hope. We seem to be left with disoriented hope. This means future is no longer what it was and hope is also no longer what it was. Our ability to hope is weakened under this new condition that we find ourselves in. We have to come to terms with the collapse of time. Time is indeed out of tune. We have stepped into what we may call After Future Society/Post Future Society. We have become children of After Future. This means history has ended, and we only seem to have a past and the present to work with. This is why we experience alienation or unwelcome in the present. It follows from the broken sense of time that has taken a hold over us.

Jacques Derrida tries to understand our broken experience of time. His understanding stays within his project of overcoming the privileging of the present in his thinking.[51] He calls this privileging of presence the

48 William Shakespeare, *Hamlet*, ed. Ann Thompson and Neil Taylor (London: Arden Shakespeare, 2006), 1.5.188.

49 Franco "Bifo" Berardi, *After the Future*, trans. Arianna Bove et.al. (Oakland, CA: AK Press, 2011), 14.

50 Francis Fukuyama, *The End of History and the Last Man* (New York: Free Press, 1992), xiii.

51 Derrida, *Of Grammatology*, 70.

Metaphysics of present. We never experience presence as fully given. It is also mixed with the past and future. To identify the same we have to examine the latencies and tendencies embedded in the present. Present, therefore, can never be fully present, but we have the challenge to critically discern it. Now that we are experiencing a disappearance of the future, we are experiencing a distorted present. We do not just feel dislocated from time, we also feel displaced from space. We might get an insight into this state of affairs, if we explore the notion of non-place developed by Marc Augé.[52] Maybe we are living in non-time and non-place in what we have come to call After Future Societies. Haunting, therefore, may be our resistance to the constriction and disappearance of time and space. We are drawn into a never ending now and homogeneous drapery of space with everything rewinding and recycling again and again. The constriction of time and space results in the constriction of hope.

Derrida's turn to hauntology has inaugurated an important aspect of the ethical turn of deconstruction.[53] It leads us to accept that our living present is not as self-sufficient as it appears to be. Therefore, we have to examine the latencies and tendencies that inhabit it and scrutinise how they animate our hope so that we can come to discernment of authentic hope. The scrutiny of the latencies and tendencies can lead us to envision alternate futures. Instead of staying confined to the dead end necronomy of After Future Societies,[54] we have to find our autonomy, that will become an out-nomy from the Platonic cave's closure of a future. The push to out-nomy will enable us to exit from strangulating norms (Nomy) of the After Future Societies and enable us to imagine alternate futures. These alternate futures will ignite new vistas of hopes, and we might be enabled to break the barriers of the After Future Society and, thus, break open the closed future imposed by late capitalism on our societies.[55] This means we have to awaken to the fact that past is never really dead. The past is never past, nor the future is never closed. The future is not just in the future. We anticipate it as well as walk towards it. We also access the past in the present and project a future. Therefore, we can indeed reimagine alternate futures and work to actualise the same in the living present without waiting for the opportune time to arrive.[56] This sense of the present will give us energy to invest our present to

52 Marc Augé, *Non-Places: Introduction to an Anthropology of Supermodernity*, trans. John Howe (London: Verso, 1995), 34.

53 Derrida, *Specters of Marx*, 10.

54 Berardi, *After the Future*, 14.

55 Fredric Jameson, *Postmodernism, or, The Cultural Logic of Late Capitalism* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 1991), 25.

56 Derrida, *Of Grammatology*, 70.

cultivate alternate futures that are emancipative and work to bring them into actuality. We may call this hope, in an After Future Society, as After Hope.

Conclusion

Our experience of time is complex. We do have a broken experience of time and, hence, are haunted by the past and the future. Even when we experience and envision a closed future, we do not reach the death of Hope. Hope is undying and continues to lead humanity even at times when late capitalism seemed to have led us to an After Future Society. The courage of Hoping under Hopelessness is indeed an After of Hope.

4

A Metaphysics of Hope Reading of Gabriel Marcel

Francis Arackal Thummy

Abstract

Gabriel Marcel's philosophy is far removed from mere abstraction. His philosophy enters into dialogue with everyday, ordinary experiences of people. Marcel has succeeded in making our thinking "more thinking" and makes us more believing-mystery, other worlds, contemplation, faith, hope, and love. Marcel emphasises the communal dimension of hope: "I hope in you for us." One has to hope in others and for others. Hope is other-oriented. At the same time, he has rendered hope a transcendental dimension as well. Here, hope goes beyond all objects in the world to the source of our lives. Hope has to be anchored in God, the absolute Thou. Marcel argues that this type of hope can never be disappointed, precisely because it goes beyond all objects to the Person who is the Ground of my being. Hope verifies the truth that the human person is ordered to being and not to having. Being has to do with persons, having with objects or things. Since hope is an act of self-surrender, it is not egoistic. Human hoping reveals that human beings are radically future-oriented. We do have a future, not in things or objects, but

in God, who summons us to His own future. This contribution has tried to explore all these aspects.

Keywords: *Being, Courage, Desire, Despair, Essence, Existentialism, Gabriel Marcel, God, Hope, Mystery.*

Introduction

For Gabriel Marcel philosophising was not a mere abstract activity; it had to do with genuine human concerns. "He who notices the trend in my philosophical work must see it in its entirety as a persistent, unceasing fight against the spirit of abstraction," Marcel wrote in the Preface of his book *Les hommes contre l'humain* (Man Against Mass Society).[1] It is one of the great merits of Marcel that his philosophy and his way of philosophising are not only accessible to the professional philosopher, but also to anyone who wants to reflect on the meaning of his own personal experience. Popularly speaking, philosophy for Marcel means "going out in the street," entering into conversation with people. That's why Marcel would like to characterise his thinking as a form of neo-Socratism.[2] The present paper would attempt to reflect Marcel's own characterisation of philosophy.

In the third decade of the 21st century, the world is increasingly seeming like a hopeless place. The decade itself began with the battering received from the Covid pandemic, which took away millions of lives from almost every continent and country, with the spiralling decline of the world economy resulting in job losses and massive unemployment. Divisions based on religion, race, and nationality became more pronounced. To cap it all, territorial disputes, claims and counter claims unleashed wars between Russia and Ukraine and between Israel, Palestine, Lebanon, and Iran, causing destruction, the loss of thousands of civilian lives, and wounding millions. In such a grim scenario, engaging with the philosophy of Gabriel Marcel through the lens of hope becomes both relevant and meaningful.

1 As cited in Thomas J. M. Van Ewijk, *Gabriel Marcel: An Introduction* (New York: Deus Books, 1965), 14.

2 In the first chapter titled 'On the Ontological Mystery' in his book *The Philosophy of Existentialism*, this is precisely what Marcel states: "Rather than to begin with abstract definitions and dialectical arguments which may be discouraging at the outset, I should start with a sort of global and intuitive characterisation of the man in whom the sense of the ontological – the sense of being – is lacking …" Gabriel Marcel, *The Philosophy of Existentialism* (New York: The Citadel Press, 1966), 9; *also see* Van Ewijk, *Gabriel Marcel*, 11.

1. Life of Gabriel Marcel

Most often, the writings and philosophy of an author border on the autobiographical. Hence, it is pertinent to at least briefly look at the life of Gabriel Marcel. Marcel was born in Paris on 7 December 1889. He spent a major part of his youth in Sweden. He also stayed often in Germany, England, and Italy. Due to his visits to many countries and cities, even at an early age, Marcel came into contact with well-known personalities in the political and literary worlds. He was an avid and penetrating reader.

The agnostic atmosphere in which he grew up, however, was not a happy one for this extremely sensitive and very intellectual boy. Such an atmosphere may have been due to the passing away of his mother when he was only four years old. The sudden death of his mother had a profound influence on his childhood and was continuously on his mind. Later in life, he would admit that she had always been "with him." His mother's death marks the beginning of Marcel's thinking about God and the hereafter. What happens to us after we die? It is literally a question of life and death. And what is Philosophy but a question of life and death? Perhaps due to the experiences of his childhood, Marcel took a lively and spontaneous interest in "the other one," for whom he felt interest and sympathy. "Nothing is lost for a man – I am convinced of this, and I firmly believe it – if he experiences a great love or a true friendship, but everything is lost for the one who is alone," he confided to Roger Troisfontaines.[3]

On 23 March 1927, at the age of 39, he made a definite choice with regard to his faith. At first, he had felt more attracted to Protestantism, but he was finally baptised and received into the Catholic Church. His Philosophy was very much determined by this choice of faith. He began looking at mysticism and for every expression of the Spirit who breathes where He wills of God's activity in this world. Marcel resolutely refuses to be labelled an "existentialist"; rather, through a psychological and phenomenological approach to human existence, he wants to penetrate the extra-sensual, the metaphysical reality of "being."

2. Works of Gabriel Marcel

Marcel's works reflect that he was widely read, and for this reason alone, they make a favourable impression. His works are open-minded; he engages us in a dialogue, not as a Frenchman but as a man, as a neighbour.

To introduce and speak about Marcel's works, we would like to quote Martin Heidegger, who has coined an unforgettable word when he says in his

3 Van Ewijk, *Gabriel Marcel*, 20–21. *De l'existence à l'être: La philosophie de Gabriel Marcel (From Existence to Being: The Philosophy of Gabriel Marcel). See De l'existence à l'être*, Vol. 1, p.18.

main work *Sein und Zeit* (Being and Time): "Thinking should become more-thinking." It is precisely the pre-eminently Christian thinker Gabriel Marcel who has succeeded, in spite of the capricious and unsystematic character of his philosophy,[4] in making our thinking "more thinking." Perhaps he also makes us more believing–mystery, other worlds, contemplation … being very much part of Marcel's Philosophy.[5]

In his introduction to Marcel's book *L'homme problématique* (*The Problematic Man*), Dr Bernard Delfgaauw writes:

> Here we see no search for an impersonal system, but a system of thinking from one's own personal being. The author of this book is not in the first place someone who contemplates the world, but one who has been struck by the world, the world here having the double meaning of internal and external world, of microcosm and macrocosm. Thinking is for the author not just an optional game, but a necessity in order that he may clarify existence.[6]

Apart from his philosophical works, Marcel has also written a great number of plays for the stage and worked as a literary critic.

3. What is Existentialism?

Before we deal with Marcel's existentialism, let us try to make clear what Existentialism is. According to Existentialists themselves, certain elusiveness is built into it. For instance, Jean-Paul Sartre would comment: "My Philosophy is a philosophy of existence; I don't even know what Existentialism is." In the existentialist understanding, reality cannot be packaged into neat concepts, as perhaps the Scholastics would do. There are loose ends, incomplete and fragmentary thoughts in the system. The very title of the work of Danish philosopher Søren Kierkegaard (1813–1855)–*Philosophical Fragments*–is evidence of that. For many of them, it is an admission that only a divine mind would know reality as such.

3.1. Basic Characteristics of Existentialism

a. Existentialism has its starting point from human beings, rather than from nature. In Existentialism, human beings are the subject (centre/focus) of consideration; most philosophies prior to Existentialism (especially scholastics, drawing inspiration from the great masters Socrates, Plato and Aristotle) prioritised nature, treating it as an object of contemplation and human beings were included as part of that nature, contemplated almost in a detached manner. Philosophical reflections started from the statement: 'Things exist'. Existentialism considered human beings in the whole range of their exigencies–climate, environment, world–and the actualities of existence: economic, political, religious, social … The most important question to be pondered was: Where am I? Where am I in the scheme of things?

b. Human beings were considered as the existent. Primacy was accorded to the human beings not as a thinking subject (as Descartes would have considered) but as persons very much rooted. Such considerations would not allow us to posit a universal 'nature' or 'essence. For, such a position gives rise to the questions: Where is this 'nature'? Where is this 'essence'? As far as Existentialists are concerned, no such 'nature' or 'essence' exists. For them, human beings' *Existence precedes their Essence*.

c. "Existentialism does not put object against subject; it does not objectivise in the developing process of knowing; it attempts to approach the object through existential experiences such as fidelity and infidelity, hope and despair, courage and fear. … Existentialism is loaded with sentiment."[7]

Marcel's method of philosophy is a "Christian existentialism," in which faith and hope play the principal parts. He is present in his philosophy as a person in whom we can recognise and understand ourselves, and the events that take place around us. Elsewhere we have called his philosophy capricious and unsystematic. Marcel's philosophical work should indeed be called one great flight of thought rather than an easily surveyable system, neatly put together in large and small compartments. In his main work *Homo Viator* Marcel gives expression to this: "I feel a certain annoyance with myself, when I find that I certainly have not kept to the rules of the philosophical game, which have been followed almost without exception until this day."[8]

4. Hope as Resistance to Dehumanisation

It can be asserted: "Hope is life." It is hope that energises our goals, vision, and above all, life itself. Even during the lifetime of Marcel (1889–1973), he expressed the following ideas which are ever more relevant in the contemporary world. "Life in this world has become more and more widely looked upon as a sort of worthless phenomenon, devoid of any intrinsic

4 This, as we shall see later, is a basic characteristic of existentialism as a whole.

5 Van Ewijk, *Gabriel Marcel*, 17.

6 As cited in Van Ewijk, *Gabriel Marcel*, 17.

7 Van Ewijk, *Gabriel Marcel*, 25.

8 Gabriel Marcel, *Homo Viator: Introduction to the Metaphysic of Hope* (Indiana, US: St. Augustine's Press, 2010), 11.

justification, and as thereby subject to countless interferences which in a different metaphysical context would have been considered sacrilegious."[9]

Marcel noticed the dehumanising trend, in multiple ways, in a world which is more and more enslaved to the demands of technocracy. The society and the world lost the transcendent dimension of life.

> In a world in which the arid influence of technique[10] seems to prepare the radical disappearance of intersubjective relations, death would no longer be a mystery, it would become a raw fact like the dislocation of some piece of mechanism.
>
> We seem to be saying that the modern world has chosen death, but should one not rather say that under the impulse of positive science on the one hand, and perhaps also on the other, of a philosophy which on the whole one may describe as critical, the keenest minds have been forced to discard as imaginary the dreams of the beyond, of the so-called hereafter, in which our ancestors found consolation? …We must state as categorically as possible, even though we shock some semi-agnostics whose reflection is faulty or who often have not reached the depths of human experience, that it is on the ground of immortality that the decisive metaphysical choice must be made.[11]
>
> *L'enfer c'est les autres"* (Hell is the other person) says Jean-Paul Sartre. Marcel speaks of "a certainty which seems to have been lost in our time: the honour of being man. … In the political sphere, in our family life, in our daily work – whether we are manager or subordinate – we experience all the time that infidelity and treason are the order of the day, and it looks indeed as if we simply cannot help being hell to the other man.[12]

Against this certainty of Sartre, Marcel puts his brand of certainty: the honour of being a man. Sartre's 'hell' shuts off, Marcel's 'honour' opens … what a number of possibilities, all of a sudden! Possibilities of fidelity, faith, hope, and especially love. Marcel's optimism helps us to discover in our fellowman something other than our hell.

9 Gabriel Marcel, *The Mystery of Being* (Chicago, Illinois: Gateway Edition, 1960), 166.

10 I would say technology, especially in the time of AI.

11 Marcel, *The Mystery of Being*, 169–170, 168.

12 Van Ewijk, *Gabriel Marcel*, 65.

5. Preliminary Views on Hope

"I am inclined to believe that hope is for the soul what breathing is for the living organism."[13] "Hope is the property of disarmed people. It is the weapon of the disarmed, or rather it is the opposite of a weapon, and that is why it operates in a mysterious way … The scepticism of our time with regard to hope consists in an essential inability to understand that something can work effectively without being in any way a power in the usual sense of the word."[14]

"We must not forget that the outcome of hope is in the invisible world. We must not identify hope with an emergency path, a detour for pedestrians, which we use when the main road is blocked, and which behind the obstruction brings us on that road again."[15]

Marcel doesn't imagine hope as being free from trial, whether this trial is individual or social—for instance, sickness, imprisonment, and so forth. In both cases, one hopes for deliverance, liberation. Therefore, hope has to be seen in the situation in which one finds oneself, it is the answer to trial, and every trial of the kind mentioned above is a form of imprisonment. "The subject of hope is a simple *je* (I) without any pretension … The one who hopes does not always know things better than the other one, he does not foresee all things so accurately and does not count on a satisfactory ending."[16]

> The one who hopes sees himself as taken up in a certain process, at least when he really hopes and does not confine himself to platonic wishing. From this point of view alone one can understand what strictly the proper, specific, suprarational quality of hope are, and perhaps even where it escapes all relations. Then hope appears to us not as a problem, but as a mystery … One may—from the naturalistic point of view—belittle hope, so that this experience becomes merely some kind of a symptom of vitality in oppressive or intolerable situations such as sickness, separation, imprisonment, etc. But if exhaustion sets in, then hope disappears."[17] "The authentic existential experience 'I Hope', however, refuses to cling to one thing or another; it does

13 Marcel, *Homo Viator*, 16.

14 Gabriel Marcel, *Being and Having* (Paris: Marcel Press, 2008), 76.

15 Marcel, *Being and Having*, 78.

16 Van Ewijk, *Gabriel Marcel*, 55.

17 Marcel, *Homo Viator*, 53–54.

> not weigh out the possibilities against one another, it rises above illusions and thus bans disappointments.[18]
>
> We must therefore guard against the conviction that one can define hope by means of a psychological way of thinking; such thinking will always be based on hindsight, in order to explain something that in itself remains a mystery. If anyone wants to convince himself of this, it may suffice to remark that before the trial, we have no way of knowing how we will undergo it, and what forces we will appear to have at our disposal in order to resist it.[19]

To hope also contains the temptation to despair. Despair is the opposite of hope.

> To despair means to lay one's head down, to capitulate, to resign oneself to a certain fate. … Suppose that I am incurably ill, that the doctors have given me up. What next? Well, I can accept my condition stoically. Even though I am no more than 'a little heap of dirt in the festival hall' (to use an image of the author Willem Elsschot), I can still put against this my will to remain who I am; of my own free will I squarely face my fate.[20]

Hope is not haughty, nor rebellious, and still it does not accept destruction. It is patient, it 'takes its time' to overcome the trial.[21] "I believe that at the root of despair there is always this affirmation: 'There is nothing in the realm of reality to which I can give credit – no security, no guarantee.' As against this, hope is what implies credit."[22] Marcel goes on to say,

> … fear is correlated to desire and not to hope, whereas what is negatively correlated to hope is the act which consists in putting things at their worst – an act which is strikingly illustrated by what is known as defeatism. Hope consists in asserting that there is at the heart of being, beyond all data, beyond all inventories and all calculations, a mysterious principle which is in connivance with me, which cannot but will that which I will, if what I will

18 Van Ewijk, *Gabriel Marcel*, 55–56.

19 Marcel, *Homo Viator*, 55.

20 Van Ewijk, *Gabriel Marcel*, 56.

21 Van Ewijk, *Gabriel Marcel*, 56–57.

22 Gabriel Marcel, *The Philosophy of Existentialism* (New York: The Citadel Press, 1966), 27.

> deserves to be willed and is, in fact, willed by the whole of my being.[23]

Marcel gives a simple illustration:

> To hope against all hope that a person whom I love will recover from a disease which is said to be incurable is to say: It is impossible that I should be alone in willing this cure; it is impossible that reality in its inward depth should be hostile or so much as indifferent to what I assert is in itself a good … I do not wish; I assert; such is the prophetic tone of true hope.[24]

In Marcel's view the correlation of hope and despair subsists until the end; they seem inseparable. He explains this by stating, "while the structure of the world we live in permits – and may even seem to counsel – absolute despair, yet it is only such a world that can give rise to an unconquerable hope."[25] Marcel characterises hope as a mystery, but "its mystery can be ignored or converted into a problem. Hope is then regarded as a desire which wraps itself up in illusory judgments to distort an objective reality which it is interested in disguising from itself."[26]

"The fact is that desire and hope are to be found in completely distinct spheres of spiritual life. The opposite of hope is not fear, it is a state of dejection – the state of being who expects nothing either from himself, or from others, or from life."[27] To clarify the specific qualities of hoping, Marcel distinguishes it from desire. Whereas desire is always geared to definable objectives, hope is not concerned with particular states of affairs. Desire is the anticipation that we will acquire a given object, whereas hope does not predict or even try to imagine outcomes. Far from basing itself on calculation of what is possible in this or that situation, hope consists in a refusal to be bound by the limits which calculation would set. As such, it is for Marcel our most direct means of apprehending the meaning of the word 'transcendent.'[28]

23 Marcel, *The Philosophy of Existentialism*, 27–28.

24 Marcel, *The Philosophy of Existentialism*, 28.

25 Marcel, *The Philosophy of Existentialism*, 28.

26 Marcel, *The Philosophy of Existentialism*, 29.

27 Marcel, *The Mystery of Being*, 177.

28 Aidan Nicholas, "Gabriel Marcel: Philosopher of Mystery–A Centenary Appraisal," *New Black Friars* 70, no. 828 (June 1989), 296.

Marcel reiterates,

> In Christian Ethics, hope is regarded as a virtue in the same way as faith and charity. How is this possible? One might point out in the first place that hope is akin to courage. But what sort of courage is meant? … One might say that in every instance courage consists primarily in facing something. … The man who has hopes of the coming of a world in which justice will be paramount does not confine himself to saying that such a world is infinitely to be preferred to an unjust world – he proclaims that this world shall come into existence; in this lies the prophetic nature of hope.[29]

Courage is the driving force behind hope. Marcel says,

> … at the back of hope lies some sort of tragedy. To hope is to carry within me the private assurance that however black things may seem, my present intolerable situation cannot be final; there must be some way out. … It is well to bear in mind the ordeals of those whose country was for a time enslaved and who yet persisted in their hope of liberation. Hope was not simply a hope for one's own self; it meant spreading one's hope, keeping its flame a radiance of hope burning around one. We may go further and say that it is probably only by so doing that a man can keep it alive in the depths of his own being.[30]

It's clear that each man's personal reality is itself intersubjective. Every man finds within him another self which is only too inclined to give up the struggle and despair; thus it is that in his own interior citadel he has to extend the same effort as in the so-called exterior zone in which he is in communication with his neighbour. A sick man who hopes he will recover, does not simply wish to be cured. He does not stop short at saying, 'I wish I could be cured'; he tells himself, 'You shall be cured', and it is precisely when this happens that such a hope can sometimes become a real factor in the cure.[31]

Marcel says there will be people who will ask: what is this hope and to what is it directed. Is it a solution of our difficulties in this world? Or is it

29 Marcel, *The Mystery of Being*, 177–178.

30 Marcel, *The Mystery of Being*, 179. Marcel's thought takes us to the political, economic, religious and social situation in India for the last 10 years. Till the general elections 2024 many had given up hope; but since June 2024 hope is revived with the thought that such a tragic situation of my nation cannot continue for long.

31 Marcel, *The Mystery of Being*, 180.

on the contrary to a development in the unseen which will perhaps take its start only after our death? The first answer is: to hope is not essentially *to hope that* …whereas to desire is always *to desire something*. I once wrote that hope is the stuff of which our soul is woven.[32]

Next, Marcel tries to indicate the social dimension of hope. "Hope requires from us a positive attitude. To hope is a dialogue between the 'I' and the 'Thou'; there is a question of a 'we'! That means, therefore, that the hoping man does not reject his fellowman, but rather tries to rise above himself and seeks to come in touch with society, of which as a man he is a part."[33] He who hopes makes himself available: "The less someone is available, the less room he has for hope."[34] Suicide is the most radical act of despair, of not-being available. Marcel wonders whether the man who despairs of himself, has not already committed suicide in advance.[35]

6. A Metaphysics of Hope

The metaphysical status of hope means hope taken in its specific character, as opposed to desire.[36]

Even during Marcel's lifetime there was great technological progress. According to him many will see this optimism of technical progress as animated by great hope. But then Marcel asks: How is hope in this sense to be reconciled with the ontological interpretation of hope? Marcel answers: "speaking metaphysically, the only genuine hope is hope in what does not depend on ourselves, hope springing from humility and not from pride."[37] Marcel speaks of the connection between the will and hope. In this way he defines, "hope as the will when it is made to bear on what does not depend on itself."[38] "The experimental proof of this connection," he says, "is that it is the most active saints who carry hope to its highest degree; this would be inconceivable if hope were simply an inactive state of the soul."[39]

Faith enhances hope:

> To take a very simple example: the man who sacrifices himself for his child is in reality possessed by a faith whose content he cannot in the first place make clear: this faith turns on a certain

32 Marcel, *The Mystery of Being*, 181–182.

33 Van Ewijk, *Gabriel Marcel*, 57.

34 Marcel, *Being and Having*, 78.

35 Marcel, *Being and Having*, 80.

36 Marcel, *The Mystery of Being*, 173.

37 Marcel, *Philosophy of Existentialism*, 32.

38 Marcel, *Philosophy of Existentialism*, 33.

39 Marcel, *Philosophy of Existentialism*, 33.

> supra-personal unity between his child and himself. To put it more simply, I would say that he feels sure, without knowing it – and perhaps essentially without knowing it – that there will not be an end of him, but rather that he will survive in his child.[40]

Marcel presents a character who asserts that to love a being is to say, "Thou, thou shalt not die." But what can be the exact meaning or relevance of such a statement? It certainly cannot be taken simply as a wish, a choice; the emphasis of it is that of a prophetic assurance. But on what guarantee could one base such an assurance? From the point of view of the empiricist or positivist it sounds absurd, for it is in contradiction with the data of experience. Marcel asserts, "It is not from the noumenal point of view that the indestructibility of the loved being can be affirmed: The indestructibility is much more that of a bond than that of an object."[41]

The prophetic assurance Marcel speaks of is expressed as follows:

> Whatever changes may intervene in what I see before me, you and I will persist as one: the event that has occurred, and which belongs to the order of accident, cannot nullify the promise of eternity, which is enclosed in our love, in our mutual pledge. … beings who love one another are united by a common bond implies within itself the inherent need for eternity.[42]

Hope is akin to life. "All life holds within itself a promise of resurrection." "What matters today is that man should rediscover the sense of the eternal and withstand those who would make his life subservient to an alleged sense of history."[43] Marcel speaks of a hope in a life beyond:

> My span of life literally runs into a dead end. In this respect time is for me a trial. Especially when I remember that in an objective and technological world, death is a meaningless and physical affair. But why then the fear of death? If I experience death existentially as the end of my life and the negation of my 'being', as the 'ultimate problem of nothingness', then my trial

40 Marcel, *The Mystery of Being*, 168.

41 Marcel, *The Mystery of Being*, 171–172.

42 Marcel, *The Mystery of Being*, 173.

43 Marcel, *The Mystery of Being*, 183 &185. This has clear reference to the Jewish Holocaust and of course reference to all future holocausts a tyrant/dictator would like to unleash on an imaginary enemy drawn out of a particular religion or race. Marcel denounces it in the strongest of words: "A human future which is founded on the deliberate extermination of millions of individuals can only be corrupt in its own principle, and it is that future which we must wholeheartedly reject" (p. 184).

> will be increased to the point of despair. Here lies for Marcel the seed of metaphysics – the exorcism of despair.[44]

Finally, Marcel speaks of an exclusive Christian Metaphysic of Hope:

> The metaphysics of hope cannot be other than Christian. It is therefore clear that hope, of which we just said now is a dialogue between the 'I' and the 'Thou', appeals to the Absolute Thou that does not know infidelity. Hoping in God enables me to ward off the menace of despair. Because without Him I am nothing, and when I would declare that there is no longer any hope for me, this has the same meaning as: God has turned His back on me. And that is exactly what is so awful and absurd in despair. … Rising above time and this earthly life, our hope, like Moses on Mount Nebo, already sees the Promised Land before us.[45]

In a way Marcel challenges the other Existentialist Philosophers: "Have the existentialist philosophers, who take fear as their starting point, had their day? Marcel thinks so, if with some hesitation. In *The Problematic Man* he gives expression to this fear that they have shunted man on a dead track: 'If they are able to renew themselves, then I am firmly convinced of it, they will have to do this by beginning to think about hope and joy.'"[46]
To hope, in the pregnant Marcellian sense, is to have an 'absolute' not a calculating, confidence:

> We can conceive, at least theoretically, of the inner disposition of one who, setting no condition or limit or abandoning himself in absolute confidence, would thus transcend all possible disappointment and would experience a security of his being, or in his being, which is contrary to the radical insecurity of having. This is what determines the ontological position of hope – absolute hope, inseparable from a faith which is likewise absolute.[47]

In his famous essay "*Sketch of a Phenomenology and a Metaphysic of Hope,*" Marcel gives an account of hope that reveals the essential connection of the mystery of the human being to transcendence.[48] It doesn't mean that he is

44 Van Ewijk, *Gabriel Marcel*, 39–40.

45 Van Ewijk, *Gabriel Marcel*, 57.

46 Gabriel Marcel, *The Problematic Man* (Providence, Long Island: Cluny Media, 1955), 161.

47 Marcel, *Homo Viator*, 36.

48 Patrick L. Bourgeois, "Marcel and Ricoeur: Mystery and Hope at the Boundary of Reason in the Postmodern Situation," *American Catholic Philosophical Quarterly* 80, no. 3 (2006), 431.

a Christian philosopher. In fact, many of his philosophical categories were developed prior to his conversion to Catholicism.

The preservation of our humanity has certain transcendental conditions. Professor Peter Berger echoing Marcel's interconnected themes – the mystery of personhood, inter-subjectivity and hope writes:

> Man's 'no!' to death – be it in the frantic fear of his own annihilation, in moral outrage at the death of a loved other, or in death-defying acts of courage and self-sacrifice – appears to be an intrinsic constituent of his being. There seems to be a death-refusing hope at the very core of our *humanitas*. … In a world where man is surrounded by death on all sides, he continues to be a being who says 'no!' to death – and through this 'no!' is brought to faith in another world, the reality of which would vindicate his hope as something other than illusion.[49]

7. General Objection to Marcel's Philosophy

In Marcel's own words, a serious objection that could be raised against his philosophy is: All that he says implies an unformulated reference to the data of Christianity and can only be understood in the light of these data. Besides, what can be the value of such a Philosophy for those who are a-Christian – for those who ignore Christianity or who do not accept it? Marcel defends himself saying: it is quite possible that the existence of the fundamental Christian data may be necessary *in fact* to enable the mind to conceive some of the notions which I have attempted to analyse; but these notions cannot be said to depend on the data of Christianity, and *they do not presuppose it*.[50] At the same time he adds:

> The philosopher is placed in a historical situation from which he is most unlikely to abstract himself completely; he would deceive himself if he thought that he could create a complete void both within and around himself. Now this historical situation implies as one of its essential data the existence of the Christian fact – quite independently of whether the Christian religion is accepted, and its fundamental assertions are regarded as true or false.[51]

49 As cited in Aidan Nicholas, "Gabriel Marcel," 297.

50 Van Ewijk, *Gabriel Marcel*, 44.

51 Van Ewijk, *Gabriel Marcel*, 45.

Thus, "Marcel's Philosophy is quite relevant today for all those who, following his lead, appropriate the philosophy of mystery and incorporate it into concrete reflection as a hermeneutic of existence…"[52]

Conclusion

In the foregoing pages we have tried to look at Marcel's view on hope and a metaphysic of hope, drawing from many of his works and the views expressed on them by some prominent scholars. It is evident that many of Marcel's works speak of hope, but it is *Homo Viator*, which explores the nature of hope. The nature of hope as expressed by Marcel in the post-World War II is very relevant for our times, the third decade of the 21st century. Our world is faced with multiple problems, many of which seem to have almost reached the point of no return. Now, to state that our world has insurmountable problems, especially in the wake of the two wars that have been on, is not exactly to 'hope' as Marcel has outlined above. Ultimately, according to Marcel, human beings need to have faith in an absolute. What gives courage to a human person in the face of darkness is God, who is light—that exactly is a Metaphysic of Hope.

52 Patrick L. Bourgeois, "Marcel and Ricoeur," 429.

5

Concept of Faith and Hope in the Writings of Søren Kierkegaard

Biju Rockey Pallippadan

Abstract

Faith and hope have commonly been grouped together in the Christian tradition as the three 'theological virtues.' This classification being mainly based on the authority of St Paul who wrote: "And now faith, hope and love abide, these three, and the greatest of them is love" (1 Cor. 13:13). Kierkegaard has much to say about all three, considering them crucial elements in the Christian life. In this paper, I will examine his account of hope and its relation to faith, though it will become clear that he sees both as intimately related to love as well. The question of how hope and faith relate for Kierkegaard is posed in an interesting way in "The Sickness Unto Death." It is a book about despair, and it might intuitively seem natural to think of hope as the opposite of despair. And Mark Bernier has indeed argued that, for Kierkegaard, "despair is essentially an unwillingness to hope."[1] *However, in "The Sickness Unto Death," Kierkegaard says relatively little explicitly about hope, while he claims that*

1 Mark Bernier, *The Task of Hope in Kierkegaard* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2015), online edition, https://doi.org/10.1093/acprof:oso/9780198747888.001.0001, accessed 27 July 2025.

despair, considered to be an ontological state, rather than a mood, is equivalent to sin and that faith is the opposite of sin and therefore, of despair. But, if despair is defined in opposition to both faith and hope, then, as Bernier says, "it is unclear precisely how faith and hope relate to one another. Is one the necessary condition for the other? Is one of them superfluous?"[2] *One might add other possibilities; perhaps, for instance, they are in fact the same reality, viewed from different perspectives? But in order to address the question of how faith and hope relate, we first need to consider what faith and hope are.*

Keywords: *Faith, Hope, Immediacy, Expectancy, Passion, Objectivity, Subjectivity*.

Introduction

Søren Kierkegaard (1813–1855) was a Danish philosopher, theologian, poet, social critic, and religious author. He is widely considered to be the first existentialist philosopher. He wrote critical texts on organised religion, Christendom, morality, ethics, psychology and philosophy of religion. He showed a special interest in metaphor, irony and parables. Much of his philosophical work deals with the issues of how one lives as a 'single individual,' giving priority to concrete human reality over abstract thinking, and highlighting the importance of personal choice and commitment. This paper will now explore Kierkegaard's basic concepts of faith and hope.

1. Kierkegaard's Concept of Faith

Faith, according to Kierkegaard, is the full realisation of the relationship between the human self and God, "that the self in being itself is grounded in transparently in God.[3] In the first of the *Edifying Discourses*, "The Expectation of Faith", Kierkegaard presents a fourfold characteristic of faith:

> It was the new glory of faith that no man can give it to another; (2) but that what is highest, noblest, most scared in man that every man has; it is inherent in him; (3) every man has it if he wills to have it; (4) and this is the glory of faith that it can only be had on this condition; therefore it is the only unfailing good, it can only be had through being constantly acquired, and can only be acquired by being constantly developed (or more correctly "brought forth").[4]

Here we have a delineation of four aspects of faith. It is the highest unfailing good; it is immanent; it is incommunicable; and it is qualified by an act of the will. Faith is the only unfailing good because it can only be had by being constantly acquired and brought forth. This is a determination of faith in terms of personal existence and not in terms of reflection. Faith is not merely an appropriation of something but a creative activity. Again, faith is determined as an act of the will.

If a man does not possess it "there is but a single expression which explains his failure – that he did not, will it."[5] If he loses his faith, he alone is responsible, no one can else can deprive him of it. Faith is not only the highest good but it is potentially and equally available to all. It is a good in which all can share.[6] Faith is the quality by virtue of which a man is identical with every other man. The universality of faith is of course based upon the assumption that faith is immanent or inherent in all men. And again, faith is something which cannot be communicated from one man to another. "One man can do much for another but he cannot give him faith."[7] Faith is furthermore a quality which "makes a man more lonely, than do the greatest sufferings."[8]

1.1. Faith as Immediacy after Reflection

According to Kierkegaard the immediate consciousness of God has nothing to do with faith. He explains that what Schleiermacher calls "religion" and certain Hegelian dogmaticians call "faith" is nothing but the first immediacy (the unreflected, spontaneous awareness of God). In this way, faith comes into the rather cheap company of feeling, mood, and idiosyncrasy.[9]

Kierkegaard maintains that faith, in the Christian sense, is neither continuous with rational belief nor to be identified with a spontaneous awareness of God. Christian faith is "the second immediacy" or "immediacy after reflection."[10] By the term "immediacy after reflection" he means

2 Bernier, *The Task of Hope in Kierkegaard*, https://doi.org/10.1093/acprof:oso/9780198747888.001.0001, accessed 27 July 2025.

3 Søren Kierkegaard, *The Sickness Unto Death: A Christian Psychological Exposition for Upbuilding and Awakening* (New Jersey: Princeton University Press, 1983), 132.

4 Søren Kierkegaard, *Edifying Discourses*, trans., David F. Swenson and Lillian Marvin Swenson, vols. I-IV (New York: Harper and Brothers, 1958), 15.

5 Kierkegaard, *Edifying Discourses*, 17.

6 Kierkegaard, *Edifying Discourses*, 30,10.

7 Kierkegaard, *Edifying Discourses*, 13.

8 Kierkegaard, *Edifying Discourses*, 10.

9 Søren Kierkegaard, *Fear and Trembling*, trans., Howard V. Hong and Edna H. Hong (New Jersey: Princeton University Press, 1983), 104.

10 Kierkegaard, *Fear and Trembling*, 125.

exactly the "repetition", namely, the restoration of the personality to its perfect integrity. However, the immediate consciousness of God must be completely destroyed by the consciousness of sin before there can be any question of a second immediacy of God. Only when the individual has found himself before God can he arrive at faith and the mystic union with God in Christ. The "reflection" is here the process by which the consciousness of sin completely destroyed every possibility of finding God in the immediate experience of life. Once again, Kierkegaard appears to reject all possibility of arriving at faith through a rational experience as a form of cognition.[11]

Faith is not regarded as a form of cognition. It is not an intellectual observation but an expression of the will. There is in Kierkegaard's concept of faith as well as in his concept of choice a pronounced tendency towards voluntarism. At the same time Kierkegaard maintains that faith and the new immediacy with God is a divine gift. Faith, says Kierkegaard, is a transcendent point of departure.[12]

1.2. Faith as Contemporaneity with Christ

What Kierkegaard terms contemporaneity with Christ is not a historical or immediate contemporaneity. God cannot be immediately known. It is not arrived at through a critical study of the historical sources; nor is it the sensing of a contemporary spirit. It is impossible to be an immediate contemporary of Christ. Only the believer, the non-immediate contemporary, knows the teacher for he alone has received the required condition for a spiritual and true contemporaneity, namely, faith.[13] He does not see through the eyes of another, but the eyes of faith. He is a contemporary in the autopsy of faith, and in this autopsy every non-contemporary becomes a contemporary.[14] The relationship between the believer who lived contemporarily with Christ in the immediate sense and those who became believers in the later generation is that the later believers believe by means of the testimony of the contemporary disciple, but also by virtue of the condition, namely, faith, which God himself bestows upon them. From the point of view of religious education, the historical testimony furnishes the occasion for becoming a

11 Mbiku Deogratias, "Religiosity in Kierkegaard" (PhD diss., Pontifical Urbaniana University, 1981), 37.

12 Deogratias, "Religiosity in Kierkegaard," 37.

13 Søren Kierkegaard, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript to Philosophical Fragments*, trans. Howard V. Hong and Edna H. Hong (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1992), 54–55.

14 Kierkegaard, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript to Philosophical Fragments*, 57–85.

believer, but the condition itself is transcendental. "Only one who believes the condition from God is a believer."[15]

2. The Conflicts of the Kierkegaardian Faith

In Kierkegaard's thoughts, faith indeed is one of the most significant and crucial themes. It is on faith that the entire edifice of his religious thought is founded. But his own rhetorical and ironical style of expressing his ideas often leads to misunderstanding of his thought and misinterpretation of his intention. He has freely used words like 'madness', 'paradox', or 'passion' to characterise faith, which may lead not so sympathetic readers to conclude that faith is not only unintelligible or meaningless but sheer absurdity—in ordinary meaning of the term and not in the responsible existential sense. In order to understand the concept of faith and its place in Kierkegaard's dialectics of religious experience, one needs to probe into his overall understanding of the nature of philosophical reflection.

3. Objectivity and Subjectivity in Relation to Faith

In an attempt to thematise the concept and our understanding of faith, it may be necessary to introduce his distinction between the objective and the subjective way of thinking. Kierkegaard formulates his understanding of philosophical thinking by categorising it as subjective and objective. The intellectual background against which his fundamental polemics concerning the nature of subjective and objective reflection are situated in Hegelian philosophy. In the latter, objectivity and the universality are the most important or rather overarching theoretical constructs.[16]

According to Kierkegaard, the role of objective thought in logic, mathematics or sciences is unquestionable, but insignificant for the one whose main concern is to understand man's existence. What is important is his religiosity and truth as it relates to the concrete individual in his existence which is inalienable from his subjectivity. Therefore, we scarcely find any discussion of formal a priori disciplines or of natural sciences which concern merely material or physical phenomena.[17]

Kierkegaard explains, objective reflection is in opposition to subjective reflection. He says: "For an objective reflection the truth becomes an object, something objective, and thought must be pointed away from the subject. For a subjective reflection the truth becomes a matter of appropriation, of inwardness, of subjectivity, and thought must probe more and more deeply

15 Kierkegaard, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript to Philosophical Fragments*, 85–86.

16 S. A. Shaida, "Kierkegaard's Ontology of Faith," *Indian Philosophical Quarterly* 29, no. 2 & 3 (April–July 2002): 254.

17 Shaida, "Kierkegaard's Ontology of Faith," 255.

into the subject and his subjectivity."[18] Inwardness of the existing individual is subjectivity, and therefore, the existing individual is the subject. Whereas, the objective reflection which is adequate for formal logic, mathematics and historical knowledge, makes the existence or non-existence of the subject completely irrelevant.[19]

Kierkegaard understood faith as something purely subjective, proceeding from within an emotional-voluntaristic attitude to "truth." "Faith is the highest passion of subjectivity."[20] In his view, "passion" is subjectivity and does not exist objectively. He further states that subjectivity is an existing subjectivity: "Subjectivity culminates in passion, Christianity is the paradox, paradox and passion are a mutual fit."[21] Kierkegaard says that objective comprehension of God would only attest unbelief in him, since God is to be believed in just because it is impossible to know him.[22] Faith, extreme subjectivity becomes "absolute objectivity."

Kierkegaard uses the term "subjectivity" to emphasise the will as the vital organ for spiritual development. The essential aspect of subjectivity is that, in resolution and choice, one takes a risk. This is the absolute decision. Every instance of subjectivity involves the will, though every act of the will need not necessarily involve subjectivity. Subjectivity may be a sub-category of the activities included by will, having to do with the activities of the spiritual life.[23] Kierkegaard says, "The truth is subjectivity." Thus, to him, subjectivity is indicated by the intensity of passion with which one holds to an object. This intensity of passion is subjectivity and inwardness.[24]

4. Faith as Passion

De Silentio and *Climacus* agree that faith is a special kind of passion. As such faith is not a matter of detached cognition or reflection. Religious faith is neither equivalent to knowledge about the facts of a religion nor the ability to defend proofs for God's existence, though it undoubtedly contains some epistemic component. Faith as a passion has an affective component, an inner sense that one best understands when one experiences or feels

18 Kierkegaard, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript to Philosophical Fragments*, 171.

19 Shaida, "Kierkegaard's Ontology of Faith," 256.

20 Kierkegaard, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript to Philosophical Fragments*, 110.

21 Kierkegaard, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript to Philosophical Fragments*, 206.

22 Bernard Bykhovski, *Kierkegaard*, trans., Henry F. Mins (Amsterdam: B. R Grüner, 1976), 61.

23 Meri Gala Gabriel, *Subjectivity and Religious Truth in the Philosophy of Søren Kierkegaard* (Mercer: University Press Mercer, 2010), 91.

24 Gabriel, *Subjectivity and Religious Truth in the Philosophy of Søren Kierkegaard*, 98.

it for oneself.[25] *Climacus* holds the concept of passion in high regard. He says, "Passion is existence at its highest."[26] Further he says, "Faith is indeed the highest passion of subjectivity." "There is no stronger expression for inwardness than – to have faith."[27] To have faith or to have passion for something is to be impressed by that thing, personally and intimately affected in a way that arouses care, concern and an appropriate response.

The human being exists as a 'passionate' individual-master of his own life and having the creativity of making his own values. His personal freedom with its consequent commitment and responsibility enables him to transcend his mere existence within his own subjectivity. This realisation he always calls 'passionate' as it is the mode of Being within which he moves and breathes with the sincerity and authenticity of a 'lover.' It is this sort of inwardness with which he exists.[28]

The one who lacks passion for existence tends to approach life and its decisions with an indecisive, even blasé attitude. In *Two Ages* Kierkegaard writes, "The single individual (however well-intentioned many of them are, however much energy they might have if they could ever come to use it) has not fomented enough passion in himself to tear himself out of the web of reflection and the seductive ambiguity of reflection."[29] The one who reflects in this disconnected way, floats through life without serious commitment, while the person with passion, approaches what he understands to be true, good, and right, with earnestness and care. De Silentio writes, "The conclusions of passions are the only dependable ones – that is, the only convincing ones."[30] Faith, therefore, is a passion distinct from and significantly higher than the breed of philosophical reflection in de Silentio's sights because it is concerned and approaches its object with conviction and decisiveness.

4.1. Faith as Conflicting with the Ordinary Understanding

As we have seen, De Silentio situates the passion of faith in opposition to disinterested philosophical reflection, whereas Climacus explores faith's passion as a particular kind of faculty, in tension with that of the human understanding. One cannot understand Climacus's view of faith as a passion

25 While both de Silentio and Johannes Climacus personally lack the "highest passion" of faith, they certainly are passionate about the concept and getting it right, as is exemplified by their deep understanding of faith.

26 Kierkegaard, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript to Philosophical Fragments*, 197.

27 Kierkegaard, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript to Philosophical Fragments*, 132,210.

28 Shaida, "Kierkegaard's Ontology of Faith," 256.

29 Bykhovski, *Kierkegaard*, 69.

30 Kierkegaard, *Fear and Trembling*, 100.

without grasping the notion of paradox. "The paradox is the passion of thought, and the thinker without the paradox is like a lover without passion."[31] A paradox is "something that thought itself cannot think."[32] That an eternal God should enter time and even more, become a human being—this is what Climacus calls the "absolute" paradox.[33] It defies thinking – rubs human intuition and reason the wrong way. But if it defies our faculty of reason or understanding, how are we to approach it? We saw above that one cannot approach this paradox with the minimal passion required by philosophical speculation.[34] One must confront the paradox in faith, with utmost passion. This is clear from Climacus's definition of truth, which he then calls a paraphrasing of faith: "An objective uncertainty, held fast through appropriation with the most passionate inwardness, is the truth, the highest truth there is for an existing person."[35] Climacus thus qualifies the earlier statement that passion is existence as its highest, and claims that faith is the passion that is the highest form of existence.

Faith, then, is a non-natural[36] human faculty just in the sense that it has a particular domain as human reason or understanding has a particular domain. Whereas philosophical, historical, and even theological speculation belongs in the domain of the understanding, one's relation to God belongs in the domain of faith. Moreover, as with de Silentio's maxim that faith relates absolutely to the absolute and relatively to the relative, one's relation of faith to God must transform the domain of human reason; one becomes equipped to carry out various kinds of speculation through the eyes of faith. Thus, approaches to ethics or religion that are fundamentally "objective"—that

31 Kierkegaard, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript to Philosophical Fragments*, 37.

32 Kierkegaard, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript to Philosophical Fragments*, 37.

33 Climacus also refers to this as "the absurd." "The absurd is that the eternal truth has come into existence in time, that God has come into existence, has been born, has grown up, etc., has come into existence exactly as an individual human being, indistinguishable from any other human being…." See Kierkegaard, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript to Philosophical Fragments*, 210.

34 Again, there is nothing immoral about having passion for one's academic discipline, nor do de Silentio or Climacus's view preclude that possibility. The problem with philosophical reflection for Kierkegaard and his pseudonyms comes when it replaces or diverts attention from what Climacus calls "essential truth" – truth that is central to what it means to be a human. For Kierkegaard this implies truth of an ethical or religious nature that should be lived, not merely studied. See Kierkegaard, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript to Philosophical Fragments*, 189.

35 Kierkegaard, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript*, 203.

36 By non-natural, I mean that it is not innate or present from birth, but is instead a gift made possible by God. Of course, it is natural in the sense that it is a trait that belongs to humans and not, for instance, animals.

proceed from human understanding—are liable to result in misconceptions of the notion of faith.

4.2. Faith as Task for Life

What we so far explored is that, not only is faith a passion, but to have faith, one must first exist in passion.[37] Climacus says, "To understand oneself in existence is also the Christian Principle." Central to the task of self-understanding in Religious A and Christianity is what Climacus calls "the practice of the absolute distinction," where, similar to de Silentio's "first movement" of faith, one (infinitely) gives up all finite things before God. Reinforcing de Silentio's view, Climacus criticises an aesthetic view of life that fails in the fundamental task of self-knowledge. "It is demented… for a being who is eternally structured to apply all his power to grasp the perishable, to hold fast to the changeable, and to believe that he has won everything when he has won this nothing—and is duped—to believe he has lost everything when he has lost this nothing—and is no longer duped."[38] The "practice of the absolute distinction" where on relinquishes the value of all finite goods is such a challenging task that it results in a sort of conversion of the individual who accomplishes it. "The daring venture is not one among several undertakings, one more predicate about the one and the same individual—no, through the daring venture he himself becomes someone else."[39] One can easily see how the "practice of the absolute distinction" or "the first movement of faith" is a task to work on throughout all of life.[40]

In other words, it will always be a challenge to rank one's life's interests with one's relation to God. Even though infinite resignation is the first movement or, as Climacus calls it, the "initial expression" of existential pathos, one never completes this task. The same holds true for faith proper. "To relate oneself existentially with pathos to an eternal happiness is never a matter of occasionally making a huge effort but is constancy in the relation, the constancy with which it is joined together with everything."[41] Just as

37 In *The Sickness unto Death*, Anti-Climacus writes, "But the more passion and imagination a person has – consequently, the closer he is in a certain sense to being able to believe…." See, Kierkegaard, *The Sickness Unto Death: A Christian Psychological Exposition for Upbuilding and Awakening*, 86.

38 Kierkegaard, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript to Philosophical Fragments*, 353.

39 Kierkegaard, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript to Philosophical Fragments,* 353.

40 Anti-Climacus expands on how faith's task of "living the truth" of Christianity is on-going. His polemic is directed toward the contemporary fallacy where, "Christianity has been regarded as truth in the sense of results instead of its being the truth in the sense of the way." This is the incorrect view of Christianity.

41 Kierkegaard, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript to Philosophical Fragments*, 535.

constancy is required between spouses, so in one's faith relation to God the individual must renew his commitment to "the absolute" over and over again, must never consider this relation to be one he will eventually move beyond. This is why de Silentio claims that one cannot "go further" than faith.

4.3. Faith as On-going Relationship with Christ

Climacus's argument in *Philosophical Fragments* seems to run into trouble with the concept of the teacher-as-saviour. In the Socratic scheme, the teacher only provides an occasion for the learner to recollect the truth one has forgotten. That is, the learner possesses the truth, and just needs to be reminded. As such, the teacher is 'accidental' or unessential to the learner's recollection of the truth. Socrates might assist the learner, or perhaps another pedagogue could. The particular identity of the teacher does not matter. In Christianity, however, since humans are in a state of untruth, they cannot simply recall or remember the truth; it must be given to them. Christ, who is the truth, is thus essential to the learner's gaining the truth. However, what each person needs is not a lesson about the truth, but Christ himself—his presence.

How can a human be present with someone who no longer walks on the earth? This problem is not addressed by Climacus until more than half-way into the book, and it reflects the primary inquiry of Fragments, stated on the title page*:* "Can a historical point of departure be given for an eternal consciousness; how can such a point of departure be of more than historical interest; can an eternal happiness be built on historical knowledge?"[42] Let us momentarily withhold a response to these questions and return to them below. Climacus describes the relationship between Christ and each human as one of contemporaneity. Faith as contemporaneity with Christ does not mean "physically present," but "spiritually present"; faith is a state of communion or presence with the Son of God."[43] And, as a gift, faith's state of contemporaneity with Christ is initiated by Christ. Climacus considers the objection that someone who lived during Christ's time on earth might have an advantage, and that a follower "at second hand" might be at a disadvantage. He thinks that this objection misunderstands the concept from the start. One might very well have witnessed Christ's miraculous works and his claims to be the Son of God, yet this does not entail a response of faith.[44]

42 Kierkegaard, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript to Philosophical Fragments*, 1.

43 Robert C Roberts, *Faith, Reason, and History: Rethinking Kierkegaard's Philosophical Fragments* (Macon, GA: Mercer University Press, 1986), 9.

44 Anti-Climacus expands upon this: "Christ makes it clear that in relation to him there can be no question of any demonstrating, that we do not come to him by means of demonstrations, that there is no direct transition to becoming a Christian, that

Climacus says that the only sense in which the "immediate contemporary" has an advantage is that he has avoided the endless 'chatter' about Christ that has promised since his time on earth.[45] Since one cannot approach Christ through the faculty of human understanding or common sense,[46] but only through faith, then what makes someone a "genuine contemporary" is the fact that God gives him the condition of faith.[47]

5. Faith and the Absolute Paradox

According to Kierkegaard, Christian faith is a faith in the incarnation, the fact of the God-man, which he sees as the "absolute paradox."[48] Here, Kierkegaard affirms that the Absolute Paradox reveals the radical transcendence of God and the heterogeneity of the divine and the human. The incarnation is a unique and unrepeatable event. It is the particular historical moment in which the universal, eternal God freely appears in the form of a particular, temporal individual.[49] "The God-Man," Kierkegaard states, "is the unity of God and an individual man."[50] Kierkegaard says, any attempt to explain paradox, "is … tantamount to reducing the term paradox to a rhetorical expression, to something which the worshipful speculative philosopher asserts."[51] Therefore, Kierkegaard argues that only those who have faith can appropriate the paradox completely as the truth of the God-man event with absolute certainty.

A way to distinguish the paradox of God-in-time from other ordinary objects, then, is what Climacus calls the way of "eminent" or true faith in the paradox. This true faith is different from ordinary faith in that the former—true faith—can move from uncertainty to certainty regarding the event. According to Climacus, this form of true faith can resolve the paradox of God-in-time because it responds to the paradox in full certainty about it. The importance of faith in the paradox can also be seen when Kierkegaard

demonstration can at best serve to make a person aware, so that made aware he can now come to the point: whether he will believe or he will be offended… Only in the choice is the heart disclosed …." D. Antony Storm, "Kierkegaard," https://sorenkierkegaard.org/philosophical-fragments.html, accessed 27 July 2025.

45 Kierkegaard, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript to Philosophical Fragments*, 71.

46 David E. Roberts, *Faith, Reason, and History: Rethinking Kierkegaard's Philosophical Fragments* (Macon, GA: Mercer University Press, 1986), 9–10.

47 Kierkegaard, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript to Philosophical Fragments*, 69.

48 Kierkegaard, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript to Philosophical Fragments*, 194.

49 Mark C. Taylor, *Journeys to Selfhood: Hegel & Kierkegaard* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1980), 131.

50 Søren Kierkegaard, *Training in Christianity*, trans., Walter Lowrie (Princeton, New Jersey: Princeton University Press, 1974), 84.

51 Kierkegaard, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript to Philosophical Fragments*, 197.

says that "Paradox exists only for faith."[52] In faith, one comes to believe fully in the paradox as God's historical revelation in time. It resolves the paradox's problem of logical contradiction.

6. Anxiety and Faith

The fifth chapter of *The Concept of Anxiety* carries the title "Anxiety as Saving through Faith." We must understand the title this way: faith saves us from anxiety that makes us unfree. So, we may reasonably expect that Kierkegaard would provide an answer to all the loose ends raised by four previous chapters—but almost the opposite occurs because the fifth chapter is disappointing which does not provide much information on the relation to God and faith.

The question is whether anxiety is annulled by faith. In so far as faith should be the answer to the anxiety that makes us unfree, the answer seems to be "yes." But faith saves through anxiety—or rather anxiety saves through faith. What does this mean? What role does anxiety have in this situation? The meaning of anxiety that we are dealing with in the final chapter of *The Concept of Anxiety* is anxiety as the possibility of freedom, or to put it more precisely, it is anxiety that anticipates the possibility. When we feel comfortable or safeguarded in our lives, anxiety anticipates the possibility that we can lose that on which this life depends. Anxiety anticipates the possibility of loss. In anxiety we can, therefore, see through what we otherwise stop at.[53] But the question is, where does the look of anxiety stop? What do we have to hold on to?

The role anxiety plays is that of evoking a threatening nothingness. But again the question is, how can this nothingness save or make us free? What we need to examine is that anxiety not only anticipates and therefore, evokes nothingness; it also educative. Anxiety is even educative by bringing out the threat of nothingness. The point here is that: an individual can be absorbed by the circumstances in his life, and perhaps even by the things with which he surrounds himself. Thus, the individual must learn not to identify himself with the "finite relations" of life that are mutable. In other words, the individual learns in anxiety that he is something other than what he identifies himself with. Anxiety can therefore, lead an individual to faith. It can do this since "anxiety enters into his soul and searches out everything and anxiously torments everything finite and petty out of him."[54] This also means that "the individual through anxiety is educated unto faith."[55] The

52 Kierkegaard, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript to Philosophical Fragments*, 189.

53 Kierkegaard, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript to Philosophical Fragments*, 189.

54 Kierkegaard, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript to Philosophical Fragments*, 148–149.

55 Kierkegaard, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript*, 149.

education to which Kierkegaard is referring is not the education of his age that he otherwise ridicules. His own age speaks of the education to distinguish between "the educated" and the common man. Education in this case is based on views about what is wise to do and what we should do when we belong to the educated class. But anxiety consumes the common views and calculations of wisdom. When anxiety is educative, we have "possibility's course in misfortune" where we lose our footing in this common world.[56] Anxiety frees the individual in a sense. In a passage in *Fear and Trembling*, Kierkegaard asks, "What, then, is education?" His answer is, "I believe it is the course the individual goes through in order to catch up himself, and the person who will not go through this course is not much helped by being born in the most enlightened age."[57]

Even though anxiety in this way seems to be subordinated to faith, anxiety is necessary to get to faith. What is important is to take anxiety on ourselves and even to take its course. We only become free of anxiety by first going through anxiety, and not just the anxiety that can appear every now and then, but the anxiety of possible. "Only he who passes through the anxiety of the possible is educated to have no anxiety."[58]

But are we then free of anxiety in faith? An earlier passage in *The Concept of Anxiety* states that only faith is able "to renounce anxiety without anxiety…faith does not thereby annihilate anxiety, but, itself eternally young, it extricates itself from anxiety's moment of death."[59] If we maintain that anxiety concerns the possibility, the next question is then whether faith comes with an anxiety, namely, an anxiety that is a paradoxical possibility. We can here go from *The Concept of Anxiety* back to *Fear and Trembling* in which Kierkegaard discusses "the distress and anxiety in the paradox of faith." In the *Fear and Trembling* a connection is made between faith as "a task for a whole lifetime" and anxiety "that no man outgrows"[60] and that the heart must be young enough not to forget.

7. Faith Does Not Terminate Anxiety

Faith does not extinguish anxiety, but rather overcomes it. "When salvation is posited, anxiety, together with possibility, is left behind. This does not mean that anxiety is annihilated, but that when rightly used it plays another

56 Arne Grøn, *The Concept of Anxiety in Søren Kierkegaard* (Macon, GA: Mercer University Press, 1997), 149–150.

57 Kierkegaard, *Fear and Trembling*, 46.

58 Kierkegaard, *Fear and Trembling*, 157.

59 Kierkegaard, *Fear and Trembling*, 117.

60 Kierkegaard, *Fear and Trembling*, 75.

role."[61] Whereas anxiety under the dominion of sin entangles a person ever more deeply in sin, ultimately causing that person to lose the consciousness of freedom, but anxiety under the auspices of faith becomes a redemptive power bestowing freedom.[62]

A characterising feature of faith, according to Kierkegaard, is the ability to be anxious in the right way, while the absence of anxiety would be a sign of inhumanity or of a destroyed personality. "That there may be men who never experience anxiety must be understood in the sense that Adam would have perceived no anxiety had he been merely animal."[63] "If a human being were a beast or an angel, he could not be in anxiety. Because he is a synthesis, he can be in anxiety; and the more profoundly he is in anxiety, the greater is the man."[64]

Faith that extinguished anxiety would at the same time extinguish the person, who according to Kierkegaard is a synthesis of body and spirit. According to Kierkegaard, however, the disposition of the Christian faith consists in allowing anxiety—which is not a defect, but rather a constituent part of our humanity—to become fruitful, and in helping us to deal with anxiety in a new way. The Christian faith—thus Kierkegaard's probable meaning here—overcomes anxiety by courageously living through it. Even though Kierkegaard does not employ the term "courage" in this context, his statements can nonetheless be interpreted to mean that faith is a mode of courage. Faith is the courage to be in anxiety.[65]

8. Kierkegaard on Miracles

In *Works of Love* Kierkegaard talks about how "faith always relates itself to what is not seen." A person by faith believes the unseen into what is seen. The clearest statement is, however, that "the miracles of faith happen (and every miracle is then a miracle of faith—no wonder, therefore, that along with faith miracles also have been abolished)."[66] Without engaging in a direct defence of the miracles per se, Kierkegaard presupposes that once the miracle is removed, there really remains no Christianity. The Christian

61 Søren Kierkegaard, *The Concept of Anxiety: A Simple Psychologically Orienting Deliberation on the Dogmatic Issue of Hereditary Sin*, trans. and ed. Reidar Thomte in collaboration with Albert B. Anderson (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1980), 53.

62 Kierkegaard, *The Concept of Anxiety*, 155.

63 Kierkegaard, *The Concept of Anxiety*, 52.

64 Kierkegaard, *The Concept of Anxiety*, 155.

65 Kierkegaard, *The Concept of Anxiety*, 52.

66 Kierkegaard, *Works of Love,* 295.

faith involves beliefs not only ordinary historical occurrences, but also in extraordinary occurrences, such as miracles.

Elaborating upon the extent of the extraordinariness, Kierkegaard contrasts the birth of Jesus and that of John the Baptist in *Eighteen Up-Building Discourses*. He says that the origin of John the Baptist was a marvellous as the origin of the one whose coming he proclaimed, but the difference again here was the same as the difference between that an aged woman becomes pregnant which is contrary to nature.[67]

In *Three Discourses at the Communion on Fridays,* Kierkegaard writes, "no gaze is as sharp sighted, as that of faith, and yet faith, humanly speaking, sighted, but faith is against the understanding."[68] Natural laws, it may be noted, are observed by observation or experience or custom, and not by a priori reasoning. Conversely, Kierkegaard suggests that it is natural for a believer to expect a miracle, which in this case, is merely God's invention in the created world.[69]

9. Hope According to Søren Kierkegaard

Faith, hope and love have commonly been classed together in the Christian tradition as the three "theological virtues", this classification being mainly based on the authority of St Paul: "And now faith, hope and love abide, these three, and the greatest of them is love." Kierkegaard has a good deal to say about all three as crucial elements in the Christian life. In this paper, I will look at his account of hope and also at its relation to faith—though, it will turn out that he sees both as intimately related to love also.

The question of how hope and faith relate for Kierkegaard is posed in an interesting way by *The Sickness Unto Death*. This is a book about despair, and it might intuitively seem natural to think of hope as the opposite of despair. And Mark Bernier has indeed argued that, for Kierkegaard, "despair is essentially an unwillingness to hope."[70]

9.1. Hope as Expectancy

Kierkegaard defines hope as an expectancy (watchfulness, openness) for the possibility of the good. There are three senses of the good that can be the object of hope: aesthetic, ethical, and spiritual (the afterlife, the eternal, relating to God). However, there are two forms of hope: mundane

67 Robert L. John, *Truth and Subjectivity, Faith and History: Kierkegaard and the Theology of Transformation* (New York: Peter Lang Press, 2000), 96.

68 Søren Kierkegaard, *Without Authority*, trans., Howard V. Hong and Edna H. Hong (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1997), 132.

69 John, *Truth and Subjectivity, Faith and History*, 97.

70 John, *Truth and Subjectivity, Faith and History*, 98.

and authentic. Mundane hope looks to the good attainable in temporality (aesthetic or ethical), and is consistent with despair.

Only authentic hope is inconsistent with despair. Hope, in this authentic sense, requires that we see the good in every possibility (no matter what our circumstances). A further condition of this hope is love: one can only hope for oneself if one hopes for the other, and continually sees the possibility of the good for the other; to give up on the other is to despair, to close oneself off from the possibility of the good.[71]

9.2. Despair and Hope

Kierkegaard characterises the relation between despair and hope in two ways: as hopelessness, and as an unwillingness to hope. Using Aquinas' account of hope and despair, Kierkegaardian despair may be seen fundamentally as hopelessness. However, when despair is seen in this way, a problem may emerge: only weakness would count as genuine despair, with defiance reduced to a preliminary stage. Such a result could even threaten Kierkegaard's larger narrative: that despair involves the loss of meaning for the self, with faith positioned as the only solution. This narrative requires that both weakness and defiance be genuine forms of despair. Against this conclusion, the argument is made that despair is better characterised as fundamentally an unwillingness to hope. This secures defiance as a form of despair, and explains the most basic opposition between despair and hope.[72]

9.3. Hope against Hope

Following Paul, Kierkegaard understands Christian hope as 'hope against hope' Kierkegaard interprets this as hope in 'the night of hopelessness,' that is, hope when there is no human hope. Man must die to the world and lose all trust or hope in human assistance before there is the hope of Christian faith. Christian hope is presented as a gift of the Holy Spirit. That is, when there is no hope from the pre-Christian perspective, the Holy Spirit offers new hope.

Rather than involving miracles or wonders, Christian hope relies on divine grace—in particular the forgiveness of sins, Presumably, the point is that forgiveness makes possible not only salvation but also the realisation of the Kingdom of God. Kierkegaard stresses that hoping against hope is a task that involves hoping for divine assistance against understanding. Religious hope transcends understanding and is at odds with hope that is based on

71 Bernier, *The Task of Hope in Kierkegaard*, https://doi.org/10.1093/acprof:oso/9780198747888.001.0001, accessed 27 July 2025.

72 Bernier, *The Task of Hope in Kierkegaard*, https://doi.org/10.1093/acprof:oso/9780198747888.001.0001, accessed 27 July 2025.

calculation and probability. "Hope against hope" means to perceive one's powerlessness without giving up one's enthusiasm. Hope that goes against hope saves the one in despair, by means of an "open-hearted courage" that only comprehends the mercy of God.[73]

Critical Appraisal and Conclusion

Although it has not received much attention, hope plays an important role within the theory of Kierkegaard. In particular, Kierkegaard's analysis of hope can help us get a better understanding of how he interprets despair, as well as moral agency and religiousness. Kierkegaard takes moral agency as presupposing hope, and grounds hope in religiousness rather than empirical evidence. It is argued that, for Kierkegaard, neighbour love can be used to distinguish between a general hope that is justifiable and one that is not. Kierkegaard suggests that whereas unjustified hope is characterised by giving up on others, by evaluating them as hopeless, justified hope is characterised by always hoping for others.

In the philosophical writings of Søren Kierkegaard, there is a close relationship between faith, anxiety, and hope. Faith is described as a leap into darkness. It provides the ambience for certain amount of personal freedom, arising from anxiety. The co-relation is much in question in the modern philosophical thought, as there arise more tensions and worries in modern pragmatic situations. So, the critique of Kierkegaardian understanding of the co-relation among the three provides the basic platform for a philosophical endeavour to solve these stressful events. Thus, we can say that the co-relation among faith, anxiety, and hope in the philosophical writings of Søren Kierkegaard indicates that faith heals anxiety and leads to a person to an authentic freedom or a person to be authentic.

73 Roe Fremstedal, *Kierkegaard on the Metaphysics of Hope* (Trondheim, Norway: Norwegian University of Science and Technology Press, 2012), 180.

6

Hope and Absurdity
Camus and Sartre

Suresh

Abstract

Does life have an intrinsic meaning? Do we need to search for it? For some, it is redundant to ask. However, Existentialists in general, and Camus and Sartre in particular, in their attempt to discover the meaning of life, sighed about the absurdity of human existence. Absurdity is understood in the meaninglessness of life in its varied aspects. The explication of the absurd that is intrinsic to human existence continues to haunt humans till one conquers it, which is one's death. For Camus, since the absurd has no meaning, humans must revolt against it. Succumbing to absurdity involves suicide, but Camus advocates a philosophical suicide, which is the only way to "revolt" against it. Sartre, even though he accepts the notion of absurdity in the same line as Camus, modifies it by infusing with hope. For him, the absurd reflects our theoretical inability to explain the events and conditions that constitute our existence. He concludes that although human existence is looked through the prism of absurdity and meaninglessness, one can ascribe meaning and purpose to life. By one's free choice of actions, one can propel the self to whatever heights one wants to reach. But if one chooses 'not to', then such a person is 'not

free', making a choice to live in 'bad faith'. This paper attempts to evaluate the understanding of "absurdity" in both Camus and Sartre, and it adopts an expository and analytical approach. It aims to conclude that even though human life and existence are absurd and meaningless, making the right 'choice' of life in 'freedom' can lead to a hopeful life and a hope-filled world.

Keywords: *Absurdity, Meaning, Hope, Being, Despair, Death, being-for-itself, being-in-itself, Mystery.*

Introduction

Our planet is divided now between the poor, who are extremely poor, who are dying of hunger, on the one hand, and on the other hand, the small number of rich people, who are beginning to be less rich but who, even so are still comfortably off.

What with the third world war that can break out any day, and the wretched mess our planet has become, despair has come back to tempt me with the idea that there is no end to it all, that there is no goal, that there are only small, individual objectives that we fight for. We make small revolutions, but there's no human end, there's nothing of concern to human beings, there's only disorder. A person can think something like this. It tempts you constantly especially when you're old, and you think, "Well, anyhow, I'm going to die in five years at the outside" —actually, I'm thinking in terms of ten years, but it could well be five. In any event, the world seems ugly, evil, and hopeless. Such is the calm despair of an old man who will die in that despair. But this hope must be grounded.

We must try to explain why the world of today, which is horrible, is only one moment in a long historical development, that hope has always been one of the dominant forces of revolutions and insurrections, and how I still feel that hope is my conception of the future.[1]

These were the last words of Jean-Paul Sartre in an interview before his death. These words are still relevant today, as we begin to realise that things are becoming more and more hopeless and meaningless. Humanity is at the brink of confusion and anxiety about its future, as the world is facing wars between Russia and Ukraine, Israel and Palestine and Iran, etc. Migration and poverty are at their peak, forcibly pushing millions into hopelessness and meaninglessness. Nations are facing internal wars between orthodoxical and progressive forces in many spheres. The world has not still recovered fully from the effects and aftermaths of COVID. Is this world a better place

1 J. P. Sartre and Benny Lévy, *Hope Now: 1980 Interviews*, trans. Adrian van den Hoven (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1996), 109–110.

to live in? What is the meaning of human life in these paradoxical events unfolding? Human life, as such, seems to be absurd and hopeless. Human existence continues to remain unexplained. Amidst all these hopelessness and absurdity, can we still find hope for the existence of humans and human life as such? This paper attempts to answer these questions from the prism of Sartre and Camus.

1. Meaning of the term 'Absurdity'

The term *absurd* has various meanings and connotations, especially in the philosophical writings of various philosophers. It has its etymological origin in the Latin word *absurdum-a-um,* which means foolish, discordant, ridiculous, out of place, unreasonableness, etc.[2] Therefore, *absurd* means that which is contrary to common sense, reason, or any accepted ideas. It is also used as illogical or logically contradictory, thus meaningless. In existential philosophy, *absurdity* is used to underscore the irrationality that exists as an irreplaceable existential component of human existence. Existentialists, in general, have explored this irrational underlying element by its varied manifestations. What is profound in all these approaches is finding the meaning of the meaninglessness. The absurdity of our lives comes from the idea that there is no meaning to be found in the world beyond what meaning we give to it. This meaninglessness is due to the 'unfairness' of the world. Humans would always dream of having things and expect the results in their own way, but, unfortunately, the world will always be hostile and indifferent to them. The *absurd* refers to this experience of conflict between the human tendency to seek value and meaning, and the failure to find it in concrete lived experiences. Therefore, *absurd* refers not to the 'logical impossibility', but the experience of 'human impossibility', which is realised in the discrepancy between aspirations and actualities.

Existentialists have attempted to explore this discrepancy of human life as meaninglessness and hopelessness in two levels: theoretical and practical. At the theoretical level of understanding, this absurdity points to the human inability to uncover the principles of functioning of the world in its relation to humanity. One might ask many questions regarding one's life and the world, but the expected answer is silence. This silence arises from the most fundamental level, which makes one believe that everything in this vast universe exists for no reason; they are simply there. It might also point to the human limitations of reason, and if one tries to ask further questions, one might even end up mad at this ungrounded circularity of reality.

2 A. T. Arinze and I. N. Onwuatuegwu, "The Notion of Absurdity and Meaning of Life in Albert Camus Existentialism," *Open Journal of Philosophy*, 10 (2020): 528–538. https://doi.org/10.4236/ojpp.2020.104037, accessed 28 June 2025.

At the practical level, absurdity can be interpreted by people's seriousness about things in life. People are serious and consider many people and things as 'important', on a personal level and regarding others. This is reflected in how we respect and care about things and people. Later, one realises all that was considered 'serious' and 'important' was a waste of time. The collision between these two sides can be considered as absurd. An essential aspect of the absurd is that whatever higher end or purpose one chooses to pursue, no justification for the higher end can ever be possible, and, therefore, this results in a conflict between man's desire for meaning and the absence of meaning. Camus and Sartre elaborately explored this absurdity in their philosophies. Let us begin with Camus.

2. Camus' Understanding of 'Absurdity'

Camus maintained in most of his works that human existence is absurd. By nature, a human is curious to find the answer to the question, 'Why am I existing?' In his/her attempt to find the answer, he/she faces an existential fact of meaninglessness and the unreasonable nature of the world. In the words of Camus, "the feeling of absurd can arise in many ways from the perception of the inhumanity and indifference of nature, from the realisation of man's temporality or death which reveals the uselessness of human life or from the shock occasioned by perceiving the ultimate pointlessness of daily life and its routine."[3]

Only a human person finds the absurdity of this universe. The world in itself is not absurd, but simply irrational. Does this mean absurdity exists only in the human mind? Surely not! The absurd exists not in the human mind alone or the extra-mental world, but in their meeting point. That is to say, the human person, in his/her search for meaning, finds this world and the events beyond the scope of rational explanation and, thus, totally meaningless. And this is the birthplace of absurdity. It brings into focus what Camus calls "the fundamental question of philosophy," is it worth living? Is there meaning in life? etc.

This is explained clearly in the *Myth of Sisyphus* and *The Stranger*. In his effort to explain the absurdity of human nature and human existence, Camus uses the ancient Greek myth of Sisyphus, in which Sisyphus committed numerous sins against the gods. He was cursed by Zeus and punished by rolling the rock up to a hill and allowing it back to its starting point. Sisyphus accepted this eternal task in faith and continued to do so. What is interesting to note in this myth is that Sisyphus was fully aware of the futility of his labour. In another novel, *The Stranger,* Camus uses Meursault as an absurd character. He was indifferent to life and showed no

3 Albert Camus, *The Stranger,* trans. S. Gilbert (New York: Vintage Books, 1942), 141.

remorse for whatever happened. On a fine day, when he got the telegram that conveyed the demise of his mother, he showed no sorrow or shed no tears. He never visited his aged mother, and even during the burial, he found it meaningless to cry. Immediately after the burial, he preferred smoking cigarettes and making love to Maria. As seen in his answer to Maria when she proposed marriage to him, he lacked feeling. He consented to marry her if that would make her happy. Through these two characters, Camus brings out the absurdity of human life.

Theists might ask: Can the Supreme Power/God do something to help human out of this absurdity? For Camus, human's salvation is to be achieved on earth by his/her hands. This world is devoid of God, and God is dead and is no longer in existence and can no longer guarantee our existence. Camus believes that life comes to an end with death, but until then, everything is up to us. We can live as we choose and let the world become entirely ours if we overcome that natural belief in a Supreme being who determines right and wrong and assures any reward or punishment.

3. Sartre's Understanding of Absurdity

Sartre conceptualised the absurd differently due to his failure to discover the direction of Camus' understanding of the absurd. Sartre wrote a commentary on *The Stranger*, published in 1942, in which he distinguishes between conveying an idea and a feeling. He observes that *The Stranger* attempts to convey the feeling of the absurd while *The Myth of Sisyphus* attempts to convey the idea of the absurd.[4]

Camus and Sartre both used the term *absurdity* but with different connotations. Sartre considered "the absurd a failure of a project, while Camus considered the absurd a product of lucidity."[5] As noted in the previous section, Camus understands the absurd as a mismatch between theoretical and practical reasoning,[6] which makes one face this meaningless and indifferent world. Sartre considers the absurd as the theoretical inability to explain the rationale behind the functioning of this world. He observes that there are no sufficient grounds or reason to explain this world's happenings, which makes one feel this world as absurd. In *Nausea,* he affirms that the inability to explain existence is the experience of the absurd. Interpreting *The Stranger*, he argues that "our inability to conceive, using our concepts and our words, what occurs in the world" is "the source of the feeling of

4 Hannah H. Kim, "Camus and Sartre on the Absurd," *Philosophers' Imprint*, 21, no. 32 (2021): 2.

5 Kim, "Camus and Sartre on the Absurd," 2.

6 Kim, "Camus and Sartre on the Absurd," 2.

the absurd."[7] "Chance, death, the irreducible pluralism of life and truth, the unintelligibility of the real—all these are extremes of the absurd,"[8] Sartre writes, each example highlighting our inability to answer why questions regarding chance, death, the myriad lives and truths, the seeming unreachability of the real.

Sartre believes that there is only relative absurdity in reality. Absurdity is not a universal phenomenon that happens everywhere and at every time, but appears only as isolated and particular phenomena due to the loss of meaning temporarily. He uses the glass partition analogy. When we see people talking behind a glass, it is evident that they are talking, but we cannot hear what they say. Similarly, Sartre interprets that meaning is not absent, but epistemically unreachable for the time being, because we lack an epistemic capacity to understand in its entirety. For Sartre, "the meaning of an action is settled by the network of meaningful connections to other actions, and the failure to organise one's experience in a way that enables one to understand it leads to the absurd. Meaning is drained from things when we are no longer practically engaged."[9]

Sartre treats the absurd as a starting point, which presupposes his thinking that the absurd is something that human consciousness can discover in everyday experience. He compares it with a landscape already laid out to be seen and explored.[10] It is left to the individual consciousness to discover. However, we must notice that this way of understanding absurdity as having a particular meaning that points to the inexplicable and unjustified existence of things is in direct contrast with the Camusian understanding of absurdity. Camusian absurd goes beyond the mystery of existence. It challenges our ability to live peacefully and coherently, because absurdity arises when concepts we normally use in conversations and our practices become impotent. However, we may try to move away from seeing the absurd, yet we cannot escape but face it. Neither reason nor the world can answer why we must face it or how to overcome it. For Camus, the absurd is not out there as a ready-made feature; each individual must discover it.[11] It has to be felt first, and then only one can try to find meaning of one's existence in facing and overcoming the absurdity of one's existence. Therefore, we may say, for Camus, the absurd is partly internal and external to human consciousness: internal because it refers to the internal struggle

7 Jean-Paul Sartre, "A Commentary on The Stranger," in *Existentialism is a Humanism*, ed. John Kulka (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2007), 86.

8 Kim, "Camus and Sartre on the Absurd," *Philosophers' Imprint*, 9.

9 Kim, "Camus and Sartre on the Absurd," 9.

10 Kim, "Camus and Sartre on the Absurd," 10.

11 Avi Sagi, *Albert Camus*, trans. Batya Stein (Amsterdam: Rodopi, 2002), 592.

of not able to understand the rationale and external because it discovers the inconsistency in the world out there.[12]

4. Ways of Dealing with Absurdity in Camus and Sartre

Seeing the meaninglessness hidden in life, Camus declared that human existence is absurd. He holds that human existence cannot be understood and is unreasonable, and thus absurd. He is convinced that this world is constructed with no meaning, yet this fact does not impel any person to commit suicide. We have to face this absurdity with no respite. Camus holds that absurdity is the feeling one must experience at some point. When familiar things are faced unexpectedly, absurdity appears, which often seems funny and surprising and, at times, even shocking. Thus, anything out of place creates a sense of disharmony. Our perception and conception might differ, but the world's reality is familiar. If we deny that absurdity exists, we have nothing to lose. The only fact that may continue to remain is the reality, which is inexplicable in nature. Even when we are confronted by it, we will not know. Denial can be a solution to overcome this confrontation of absurdity, but it certainly is not the solution in the long run. In moments of uncertainty in life's situations, we might ask what point is in doing anything. The mere presentation of this query is necessarily the awareness of absurdity, the awareness that, from at least one point of view, there is a need to do anything. Following lines depict this well: "Once we have acknowledged the validity of the perspective of a world without values, ..., there is no turning back. We cannot simply forget or ignore this perspective. The absurd is a shadow ...; even if we choose to live as if life has a meaning as if there are ..., the absurd will linger in the back of our minds as a nagging doubt that perhaps there is no point for ..."[13]

Reflecting on the above passage, one may end up at utter frustration and may find this world as essentially ridiculous. To the question of what part is essentially ridiculous, Camus thus emphasises: "This world in itself is not reasonable; that is all that can be said. But what is absurd is the confrontation of this irrational and wild longing for clarity whose call echoes in the human heart. The absurd depends as much on man as on the world. For the moment, it is what links them together. It binds them one to the other as only hatred that welds two creatures together."[14]

12 Thomas Polzler, "Camus' Feeling of the Absurd," *Journal of Value Inquiry*, 52 (2018): 483.

13 Albert Camus, "The Myth of Sisyphus and Other Essays," in *The Plague, The Fall, Exile and the Kingdom and Selected Essays*, trans. Justin O' Brien (London: Everyman's Library, 1955), 517.

14 Albert Camus, "The Myth of Sisyphus," accessed 2 July 2025, https://www2.hawaii.edu/~freeman/courses/phil360/16.%20Myth%20of%20Sisyphus.pdf.

What about Sartre? What are his suggestions for handling the absurdity in all aspects of human life? For Sartre, the absurd is a breakdown of one's engagement with the world, a theoretical and practical failure. Human persons exist, but they make their essence by engaging with this absurd world every day and at every moment. Sartre emphasises the choices in our actions and lives. Just because one finds this world absurd does not mean we can refuse to choose and live life-akin to the child refusing to create anything with a blank paper. Sartre calls that living in bad faith. He explains that such a person willfully refuses to explore the overwhelming number of choices available to give one's life meaning. Such a person is not truly free.

5. Hope and Absurdity

For Albert Camus, life is full of absurdity. But this does not and should not make any human person choose suicide, and eventually death. Death is definitely the final destination of humans, but there is always some ray of hope, hope of tomorrow. Albert Camus maintained that anyone who is struggling to make meaning out of this absolute reality of absurdity and ends up choosing suicide is a total failure, because only the losers, in the face of absurdity, will make such choices. Hence, he advocates a total "revolt" against the absurd, even though we have no hope of ultimate victory.[15] Humans are free, and therefore, he/she can always make choices toward finding meaning by revolting against absurdity. The mere realisation that life is absurd in itself is already a free move toward finding meaning in life.

Freedom, for Camus, is unachievable beyond what the absurdity of existence permits; however, the nearest one could approach being absolutely free is by way of accepting the absurd.[16] He, therefore, introduces the idea of "acceptance without resignation" as a means of dealing with the recognition of absurdity. In a world, devoid of higher meaning, the human nature becomes as close to absolutely free as is humanly possible.[17] With this Camus' notion of "acceptance without resignation" in mind, the only means through which human can be free from absurdity of life, Brad admits that we are slaves to our uniquely human condition. The absurd binds us to its terms, and we protect ourselves from the temptation of treating sources of meaning or values as absolute.[18]

15 Arinze and Onwuatuegwu, "The Notion of Absurdity and Meaning of Life in Albert Camus Existentialism," 528–538, https://doi.org/10.4236/ojpp.2020.104037, accessed 28 June 2025.

16 Camus, *The Myth of Sisyphus and Other Essays*, 138.

17 Camus, *The Myth of Sisyphus and Other Essays*, 139.

18 Brad Peters, "Absurdity (Part 4 of 4): Living with the Absurd," *The Modern Psychologist*, October 31, 2011, https://modernpsychologist.ca/absurdity-part-4-of-4-living-with-the-absurd, accessed 28 June 2025.

For Sartre, there is no *a-priori* essence of a human, so what a human being is has not yet been established. We are not complete beings. We are *beings-for-itself*, struggling to develop human relations and arrive at a definition of what is human. In this process, what is striking is, *for-itself* has to face death, the absurdity of death. Sartre said, "I don't see myself as so much dust that appeared in the world, but as a being who was expected."[19] The secret he proposes is to ignore death. All of Sartre's characters affirm this and bear witness to this: only one thing counts, knowing what we must do. Does it promise success always? Sartre struggles with these ideas: on the one hand, he holds that a man's life itself is a failure; he doesn't succeed in what he tries to do (ultimate pessimism), and, on the other hand, an essential element of any action undertaken is hope. Hope means that one can't undertake an action without expecting that one is going to complete it. Hope is not a lyrical illusion, but it is the very nature of action. Of course, there would be failures, but hope succeeds in so far it is the relation of human to his/her goal - a relation that exists even if the goal is not attained.

Conclusion

Though the main focus of this paper is not comparative, but shedding light on the notion of absurdity as understood by Camus and Sartre, it makes sense to summarise by comparing their views on absurdity and how they tried to overcome towards hope. Sartre finds the absurd as a factual reality one discovers when he/she engages with this world consciously, whereas Camusian absurd underscores the underlying mystery of human existence as absurd. It constantly challenges our ability to live meaningfully and coherently, because absurdity is bound to arise at every moment when faced with an incomprehensible duality of expectation (desire/dream) and reality. Howsoever, we may try to move away from seeing the absurd, yet we cannot escape but face it. Neither reason nor the world can answer why we must face it or how to overcome it. For Camus, the absurd is not out there as a ready-made feature; each individual must discover it.[20] It has to be felt first, and then only one can try to find meaning in one's existence by facing and overcoming the absurdity of one's existence. The ways to overcome the absurdity both by Sartre and Camus are also relevant to us as we philosophise on hope. Camus suggests that we need to leap to faith and enter into that hopeless confrontation between human's search for answers to the questions about absurdity and the total silence we receive as an answer. He suggests that the fundamental human act, which is a natural

19 Simone de Beauvoir, *Adieux: A Farewell to Sartre*, trans. Patrick O'Brien (New York: Pantheon, 1985), 438.

20 Sagi, *Albert Camus*, 592.

revolt, is to choose life and establish it as the only necessary good. This alone can give us meaning and value in our lives. Sartre, on the other hand, suggests that humans are totally free to make what he/she wants, for he/she is for-itself. By one's agency, one can ascribe purpose to life or a world that is intrinsically devoid of any. A human, living in good faith, must exercise his/her freedom to make the right choices and, thus, find meaning to one's life. Let us hope that humans may not succumb to the absurdity of life and world, but leap to a hope-filled world and walk to a hopeful future.

Part II

Offshoring of Hope: Psycho-Somatic Dimensions

Unveiling Hope in the Experience of Illness and Suffering
A Phenomenological Inquiry

Shibu T. S. (Anudeep)

Abstract

This article, 'Unveiling Hope in the Experience of Illness and Suffering', examines the profound impact of illness and suffering, which remains an inevitable part of human life and echoes in the cries of those affected by wars, death, exploitation, and other forms of suffering. Utilising the phenomenological method, the article aims to construct a framework of hope that enables individuals to find meaning and resilience amidst their challenges. The phenomenological approach provides a philosophical description of consciousness and the life-world, allowing for an exploration of the structure of subjective experience without assumptions. By integrating the paradigms of Leibniz, Kierkegaard, and Paul Tillich with insights from Albert Camus, Karl Marx, Nietzsche, and Viktor Frankl, the article highlights the necessity of suffering for meaningful existence. Ultimately, it proposes that a phenomenology of hope can serve as a foundational framework for understanding how individuals can navigate their struggles and cultivate a sense of purpose.

Keywords: *Horizon of Hope, Illness, Phenomenology of Hope, Suffering*.

Introduction

Mahatma Buddha was profoundly troubled by the sickness and suffering he witnessed in the world, which drove him to leave the security of his palace in search of answers. Even after his enlightenment, illness and suffering remain an unfathomable mystery in human life. Even today, we continue to hear the cries of humanity, echoes of suffering inflicted by nature and fellow human beings. These cries arise from wars, death, exploitation, and illness. Such conditions call on us to leave our comfort zones and become a source of hope for our fellow beings who are ill and suffering.

The paper, "Unveiling Hope in the Experience of Illness and Suffering," offers a phenomenological inquiry into human suffering. It aims to construct a framework of hope that enables individuals to live meaningfully despite their challenges. This paper uses the phenomenological method to study the depth of meaning of illness and suffering.

1. Phenomenology of Embodiment

Illness and suffering are linked to the human experience of embodiment. Merleau-Ponty a key figure in phenomenology says that embodiment is the fundamental characteristic of human existence.[1] Embodiment, as a concept, is the subjective experience of one's own body, which is different from the objective or scientific picture of a body in physiological terms. It is a specific way we experience ourselves as embodied, and thus, it becomes the prime data for theorising about knowledge and experience. Our physical bodies fundamentally shape the world.[2] It emphasises that consciousness and perception are not just mental processes but are deeply interconnected with our physical presence.

Merleau-Pony speaks about the spatiality of the body. According to him, the body is not an assemblage of organs juxtaposed in space but an undivided body which is known through a *body image* in which all are included.[3] We have this *body image* through our body experience. He further states that the *body image* is the physiological and experiential representation of the body situated in a spatial situation. This physiological representative *body image*

1 Havi Carel, "The Philosophical Role of Illness," *Metaphilosophy* 45, no. 1 (January 2014): 22.

2 Maurice Merleau-Ponty, *Phenomenology of Perception*, trans. Colin Smith (London and New York: Routledge, 1945), 80.

3 Merleau-Ponty, *Phenomenology of Perception*, 112–113.

expresses the idea that my body exists 'in-the-world.'[4] Consequently, our body becomes the epicentre of all experiences. He states that our perception of objects is deeply intertwined with our bodily experience. Just as the heart sustains the organism, our body keeps the world's visual spectacle alive and coherent.[5] When we are moving around in a space, such as a flat, we understand it as a unified whole through our embodied perspective which is the key element for the body's existence 'in-the-world'. This embodied perception allows us to grasp the unity of objects like a cube despite their changing appearances. This embodied perspective enables us to perceive and conceive objects in their full reality, not just as abstract geometrical forms.

The lived experience of illness and suffering from the phenomenological perspective requires a deep engagement with the ontology of embodiment—the primacy of the body in experience. This ontological approach can reveal how illness and suffering are fundamentally intertwined with our bodily existence. In the context of chronic illness and prolonged suffering, phenomenological reflection can prompt the existential question, 'What does suffering mean for me?'—as each experience of suffering is embodied, fundamentally altering our sense of self and our perception of the world. Consequently, in unveiling hope amongst illness and suffering, the perception of embodiment plays a crucial role in addressing these perennial questions.

2. Phenomenology of Illness

Illness is a condition affecting one's mental or physical health, representing the subjective experience of symptoms and suffering. It encompasses how the individual, family, or social network perceives, lives with, and responds to symptoms and disability. This experience of illness deeply affects a person's sense of embodiment, marking a radical shift in how they live in and manage their body.

Dr Hevi Carel (born 1971), a professor of philosophy at the University of Bristol, who specialises in the phenomenology of illness, describes "Illness as the experience of disease, the 'what it is like' qualitative dimension as it is experienced and made meaningful by the ill person."[6] This qualitative dimension includes not only the experience of one's symptoms and bodily changes but also the experience of receiving healthcare and experiencing social attitudes towards illness. It moreover focuses on the lived experience of being ill. She further states "Illness is not just about the physical symptoms or medical diagnoses, but also about how these experiences are

4 Merleau-Ponty, *Phenomenology of Perception*, 115.

5 Merleau-Ponty, *Phenomenology of Perception*, 235.

6 Havi Carel, *Phenomenology of Illness* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2016), 17.

subjectively perceived and interpreted by the person who is ill what may become a hostile world."[7] In essence, Carel's definition of illness highlights the qualitative dimension of illness and how individuals interpret and find meaning in their condition, interact with their surroundings, and cope with the broader impacts of being ill.

Dr Hevi Carel's phenomenological description helps us to identify how illness is apprehended in the 'natural attitude.' The natural attitude of illness refers to the everyday, taken-for-granted way in which most people experience illness. In ordinary cases, individuals with illness accept their symptoms as a fact without deeply questioning or reflecting on the subjective experience of being ill. Phenomenological study suggests that it is essential to understand illness as a personal, lived experience rather than merely an objective medical condition.[8] The natural attitude discloses that the reality of illness means much more to the patient rather than simply a collection of physical signs and symptoms which define a particular disease state.

Phenomenological analysis reveals that during illness, the altered state of existence can shift one's fundamental way of being in the world. The ill person often finds themselves unable to perform routine tasks or participate fully in daily work, social life and other activities that were once taken for granted.[9] For example, in the case of chronic illness, an individual's life will be fully altered and leave a deep impact on the individual's ability to engage with the everyday world.

2.1. Profound Loss of Wholeness

At the heart of this altered state, is the first level of phenomenological experience is the profound loss of wholeness. It is an experience of a sense of fragmentation that extends beyond specific symptoms of sickness. While the person may recognise particular impairments, like shortness of breath or physical pain, the experience of illness is more fundamentally about the disintegration of bodily integrity.[10] The loss of wholeness manifests in several ways. Physically, the body becomes an object of attention and concern, something that no longer operates smoothly in the background of experience. Psychologically, this disruption of the body triggers a deeper emotional response, where the individual feels as though their entire sense of

7 Carel, *Phenomenology of Illness*, 17.

8 Marc Applebaum, "Key Ideas in Phenomenology: The Natural Attitude," *Unbound* (Blog), 20 August 2012, https://www.saybrook.edu/unbound/phenomenology/, accessed 13 August 2025.

9 S. Kay Toombs, *The Meaning of Illness: A Phenomenological Account of the Different Perspectivs of Physician and Patient* (Texas: Kluwer Academic Publishers, 1992), 90.

10 Toombs, *The Meaning of Illness*, 90.

self has been undermined. The once seamless integration of body, self, and world is fractured, leaving the person in a state of uncertainty, vulnerability, and reduced agency.

2.2. Profound Loss of Certainty

The second level of experience is a profound loss of certainty. The unpredictable nature of the body during illness disrupts the individual's sense of stability and security. In good health, people generally take for granted that their bodies will function in predictable ways, allowing them to navigate daily life with confidence.[11] As the body becomes unreliable, the individual can no longer depend on it to behave as it once did. The once effortless actions, like walking, breathing, or even thinking clearly, may now be fraught with difficulty or discomfort. Moreover, this loss of certainty extends beyond the present moment to the future. The person living with illness is often confronted with an overwhelming sense of insecurity about what lies ahead.

2.3. Profound Loss of the Familiar World

The final Phenomenological experience of illness is the loss of the familiar world. In this experience the routines, spaces, and environments that once felt natural and comfortable become unfamiliar or even inaccessible. This profound shift in perception occurs as the individual's physical and mental capacities are altered by illness, changing how they engage with their surroundings. What was once routine, such as walking through the home, navigating the workplace, or interacting with friends, can now feel strange, distant, or unachievable. This estrangement from the world is not just about the physical barriers illness creates; it also involves a deep psychological disconnection.[12] Familiar places, objects, and activities, which were once part of the individual's daily life, may now evoke frustration or sadness due to their inaccessibility. Everyday spaces that were once effortlessly navigated, like the kitchen or the street outside, now seem like obstacles. During. The loss of the familiar world is not merely a byproduct of physical incapacity; it reflects a broader shift in the individual's relationship to both their environment and themselves. Illness challenges the individual's sense of continuity and belonging, reshaping their experience of the world and contributing to the overall isolation and emotional turmoil that often accompany serious illness.

The above-mentioned phenomenological experiences can heighten the sense of alienation during illness where the body is viewed as an external

11 Toombs, *The Meaning of Illness*, 93.

12 Toombs, *The Meaning of Illness*, 96.

entity rather than a part of the self. Illness forces an explicit recognition of the body's fragility and the lack of control over its functioning.[13] The loss of bodily integrity involves both an alienation from the self and an unavoidable identification with the malfunctioning body. One cannot completely disassociate from this impaired body, which disrupts all engagements with the world.[14] As illness disrupts the lived body, the center of one's intentions and actions, it results in a fundamental disruption of the self.

3. Phenomenology of Suffering

Suffering is one of the most abstruse and disturbing experiences of human existence. Although physical pain and human suffering are not identical, they are interlinked. The International Association for the Study of Pain (IASP) defines pain as, "an unpleasant sensory and emotional experience that can be associated with actual or potential tissue damage."[15] Pain is a physical or emotional sensation while suffering encompasses the broader, deeper experience of distress, including emotional, psychological, and existential dimensions. This pain arises from direct damage to tissues. It is always a personal experience influenced by biological, psychological, and sociological factors.

In comparison to pain, suffering is defined as a state of undergoing pain, distress, or hardship. It encompasses not only physical pain but also emotional and psychological distress. In medical contexts, suffering is explained as the experience of distress or pain resulting from illness injury or other health issues.[16] The medical perspective on suffering shows its multifaceted nature. It emphasises the importance of addressing not only physical pain but also psychological, social, and spiritual dimensions to improve patient care and enhance overall well-being.

From a philosophical perspective, suffering has a deep meaning. Stan Van Hoof, Viktor Farnkl and James Davies have expressed their view on Suffering. Stan Van Hoof, an Emeritus Professor of Philosophy at Deakin University in Melbourne, Australia has considered suffering as an inherent part of the human condition. He says that the very word suffering has a resonance that relates to our sense of meaning in life at the same time poses

13 Toombs, *The Meaning of Illness*, 91–92.

14 Toombs, *The Meaning of Illness*, 91.

15 "What Is the Definition of Pain?," *EFIC Congress* 2022, https://europeanpainfederation.eu/what-is-pain/#:~:text=Pain%20is%20an%20unpleasant%20sensory,biological%2C%20psychological%20and%20social%20factors, accessed 13 August 2025.

16 "What Is the Definition of Pain?," *EFIC Congress* 2022.

a threat to our hopes of happiness.[17] According to him, suffering affects the worldview of individuals which tends to redefine one's identity, beliefs and purpose in life. On the contrary, James Davis, a practising psychological therapist as well as the author of *The Importance of Suffering*, examines emotional suffering as an essential aspect of the human experience and discusses its role in personal development. He observes that contemporary society is confused with their emotional suffering.[18] According to him, suffering arises when we find ourselves in various painful situations while striving to realise our potential.[19] Moreover, he asserts that suffering deepens when circumstances lead to isolation, confusion, or strained relationships with our social group.[20] Viktor Frankl, the founder of logotherapy, also enhances the understanding of suffering. He views suffering as an inevitable part of human life but one that gives meaning to life. In his book *Man's Search for Meaning*, Frankl emphasised that suffering, while often unavoidable, provides an opportunity for personal growth.[21] He believed that if individuals can find a purpose or meaning in their suffering, it can be endured with dignity.

Hoof, Frankl, and Davies argue that suffering is an inevitable part of life and can lead to profound personal growth and meaning. Frankl's experience in the Holocaust illustrates how individuals can find purpose even in extreme pain. Similarly, James Davies highlights that suffering intensifies when our circumstances hinder the fulfilment of our potential and isolate us from social support. Looking at their experiences and explanations, the phenomenological study of suffering is crucial to understanding the lived experience of pain, and to explore how it shapes our existence and affects our capacity to engage with the world. By understanding suffering as a fundamental aspect of the human condition, we can better grasp its role in personal and collective development. In the following ways, we can look at the phenomenology of suffering:

3.1. Pure Suffering: Intrinsically Meaningless

Albert Camus speaks about futile suffering in *The Myth of Sisyphus*. He sees Sisyphus as a symbol of human existence and the futility of suffering. Sisyphus is simply condemned to endlessly roll a boulder up a hill only for

17 Stan Van Hooft, "The Meanings of Suffering," *The Hastings Center Report* 28, no. 5 (October 1998): 13.

18 James Davies, *The Importance of Suffering: The Value and Meaning of Emotional Discontent* (London and New York: Routledge, 2012), 29.

19 Davies, *The Importance of Suffering*, 30.

20 Davies, *The Importance of Suffering*, 33.

21 Viktor E. Frankl, *Man's Search for Meaning* (New York: Pocket Books, 1985), 135–136.

it to roll back down each time it nears the top. For Camus, the repetitive and purposeless task represents the human condition, where people strive for meaning in an absurd universe.

Camus views the inevitability of suffering and life's apparent meaninglessness as central to the absurd. He argues that human beings curve for meaning yet the universe offers none. In this light, suffering becomes futile because it lacks a higher purpose or transcendental justification. However, Camus concludes that Sisyphus can find freedom in his acceptance of his fate and look for personal freedom.[22] Thus the futile suffering, for Camus, reflects the tension between humanity's search for meaning and the universe's silence; but by accepting the absurdity individual can find meaning in the struggle itself.

3.2. Suffering as Alienation (Karl Marx)

Karl Marx approaches suffering through the concept of alienation, particularly in a capitalist society. Alienation refers to the estrangement individuals experience under capitalism, affecting their labour, social relationships, and sense of self. Workers suffer because they are alienated from the products of their labour, their creative potential, each other, and human beings. Such alienated forms of economic and social suffering are structural and involve a revolutionary transformation of society to eliminate class divisions.[23] Marx points out that under capitalism, workers are alienated from the products of their labour. Instead of seeing their output as a reflection of their creativity and effort, workers become mere machines in the production process. They produce goods that they do not own and have little control over them. This separation leads to a sense of powerlessness. This estrangement is exemplified in Marx's famous phrase from Economic and Philosophic Manuscripts of 1844, where he argues that the worker is 'exiled from his product.'[24]

Marx analyses the structural nature of suffering. He says that alienation is not merely a series of individual experiences but a structural condition embedded in capitalist society. He observes that economic and social suffering is systemic and rooted in the exploitative relations of production. For Marx, addressing these forms of suffering necessitates a revolutionary

22 Albert Camus, *The Myth of Sisyphus and Other Essays*, trans. Justin O'Brien (London: Hamish Hamilton, 1955), 35–38.

23 Karl Marx, *Capital*, ed. Fredrick Engels, trans. Samuel Moore and Edward Aveling, Vol. 1 (Moscow: Progress Publishers, 1887), 61–65.

24 Karl Marx, *Economic and Philosophic Manuscripts of 1844*, trans. Martin Milligan (New York: Dover Books on Western Philosophy, 2007), 28–30.

transformation of society; specifically, the abolition of class divisions.[25] His approach to suffering through the lens of alienation provides a profound insight into the human condition within capitalist societies.

3.3. Suffering as Search for Meaning

Viktor Frankl who survived the Holocaust, argues that suffering can lead to a deeper understanding of life and one's purpose. In his book, *Man's Search for Meaning* Frankl posits that even in the most painful circumstances, individuals can find meaning through their suffering. In the midst of suffering, Frankl lost the feeling of being an individual and even his/her values and existence were reduced to a level of animal life.[26] He further said, "Suffering is an ineradicable part of life, even as fate and death. Without suffering and death, human life cannot be complete."[27] His realisation in the concentration camp states that suffering is an unavoidable part of human life. It depends on the way we accept suffering adds deeper meaning to life. Since suffering is an unavoidable part of human life, often it stretches beyond everyday experiences. Human beings have long struggled with the mystery of suffering and sought ways to eliminate it, including spiritual practices. Despite their efforts, suffering tends to return, often more intense than before, trapping individuals in a cycle. The phenomenology of suffering attempts to understand suffering as the mood that involves bodily pains, and the inability to carry out everyday actions.

4. Horizons of Hope

The Greek word ἐλπίς (*helpis*) is the root word that is translated into English as hope. *Helpis* can be translated as 'expectation.'[28] Ernst Bloch, the author of the *Principles of Hope* defines hope as an essential and constitutive element of the human condition, deeply intertwined with the possibilities for change and progress in both individual and societal contexts. For Bloch, hope is not just an emotion as the opposite of fear but more essentially a directing act of a cognitive kind.

The 'horizon of hope' refers to a vision of optimism and a forward-looking perspective, often linked to overcoming challenges or imagining a better future. This concept is prominent in diverse contexts, including religious discourse, motivational frameworks, and humanitarian efforts. It represents a distant point where expectations, aspirations, and faith

25 Marx, *Capital*, Vol.1, 66.

26 Frankl, *Man's Search for Meaning*, 70.

27 Frankl, *Man's Search for Meaning*, 88.

28 "Hope," *Turning to God's Word: Serious Bible Study for Serious Catholics*, 2001, https://turningtogodsword.com/hope/, accessed 13 August 2025.

converge, symbolising the promise of new opportunities, recovery, and positive transformation.[29] To gain a deeper understanding of its constitutive elements, we will examine the structural paradigms provided by Leibniz, Kierkegaard, and Paul Tillich.

4.1. Libeinz's Paradgim of the Best World Possible Theory

Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz (1646–1716) proposes God as the ultimate ground for all existence.[30] If we consider God as the ultimate ground of all existence, the problem of evil like illness and suffering is a thread to such ideas. The problem of evil essentially raises the question of how could an all-knowing, omnibenevolent, all-powerful God create a world in which there is evil of all kinds. Leibniz addresses the problem of evil by proposing that this world is the best of all possible worlds, chosen by God from an infinite number of possibilities. According to Leibniz, God, being omniscient (all-knowing), omnibenevolent (all-good), and omnipotent (all-powerful), chose to create this particular world because it has the optimal balance of good and evil. By creating this possible best world, God maximises overall goodness and minimises suffering and imperfection in this world.

Leibniz argues that, in this best possible world, everything happens for a reason. It serves a greater good, even if human beings cannot fully comprehend the larger plan.[31] He maintains that illness and suffering are inevitable due to the limitations inherent in created beings. These limitations ultimately contribute to the perfection of the world in ways that only God can fully understand. Therefore, despite the presence of evil, this world is the most perfect one God could have actualised.[32] He further argues that suffering exists because it is part of the most perfect world, and removing any kind of suffering would make the world less perfect. Leibniz explains that suffering arises from the inherent limitations of created beings, as imperfection is a necessary condition of existence. God, in His omniscience, knows that even illness or suffering contributes to the overall good of the universe. While this philosophical response may not comfort those suffering, it upholds the idea that evil serves a greater cosmic purpose.

29 Loren Goldman, *The Principles of Political Hope: Progress, Action, and Democracy in Modern Thought* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2023), 9.

30 Frederick Copleston, *A History of Philosophy*, Vol. IV (New York: Doubleday, 1994), 324.

31 Copleston, *A History of Philosophy*, Vol. IV, 324.

32 Copleston, *A History of Philosophy*, Vol. IV, 327.

4.2. Kierkegaardian Paradigm of Transcendence through Religious Faith

In the context of illness and suffering, Kierkegaard's paradigm of transcendence provides an existential framework to understand human fragility and despair. Through religious faith, this paradigm offers a way to transcend despair and find meaning in it. For Kierkegaard religious faith is a deeply personal and existential commitment to God that goes beyond rationality and logic. It involves a 'leap of faith,' where the individual trusts in God despite the apparent absurdity or lack of evidence.[33] He views despair as a universal human experience and a condition of life in which pain, suffering and illness are inevitable. It arises from the tension between the finite and infinite aspects of existence. Illness intensifies this despair by highlighting human fragility.

Phenomenologically, Kierkegaard believes that the confrontation with suffering and illness brings individuals face-to-face with the lived experience of their finitude. This encounter reveals the limits of their physical and temporal existence, making them acutely aware of their vulnerability, mortality, and dependence on forces beyond their control.

Suffering can seem absurd and create paradoxes in religious faith. Despite the lack of logical coherence, the finite human must trust the infinite God. This requires a leap of faith, where the individual turns to God to find meaning beyond the physical world.[34] The leap of faith transcends reason and human understanding of suffering, trusting in God's presence and purpose, even when illness seems meaningless. It involves recognising that suffering is part of the human condition and beyond control. He believes true transcendence transforms suffering into an opportunity for divine encounter and hope.

4.3. Paul Tillich's New Paradigm of Eschatological Hope

The new paradigm of eschatological hope, that Tillich proposes, transcends the limitations of individual experiences of suffering, illness, and death, offering a vision of ultimate reconciliation and renewal in the presence of God. Tillich questions whether we have 'the right to hope, even against hope', when we are faced with the existential weight of sickness, poverty, and death.[35] He says that these existential realities strip away illusions of control and confront individuals with the fragility of their existence. Yet, even in

33 Søren Kierkegaard, *Fear and Trembling and the Book on Adler*, trans. Walter Lowrie (New York and London: Alfred A. Knopf, Inc., 1994), 28–29.

34 Kierkegaard, *Fear and Trembling and the Book on Adler*, xvii.

35 Paul Tillich, *Systematic Theology*, Vol. 3 (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1968), 369.

these conditions, Tillich argues that hope must persist as an indispensable force, grounding itself not in an abstract future but in the present, where the eternal manifests through our struggle and search for meaning.[36]

According to Tillich hope is not a passive wish but an active engagement with the reality of life. It is seen as the strength that is acquired from the shared human condition, what Tillich calls the unity of all beings, rooted in the divine ground of existence. This communal aspect of hope, he says transcends the individual and links with the personal experience of the reality of life.[37] Illness is a form of suffering that can be shared with others who endure similar pain or have lost all hope. For him, eschatological hope, therefore, is not just a personal survival mechanism; it is a collective affirmation of life, meaning, and connection with the broader world.

By examining the paradigms proposed by Leibinz, Kierkegaard and Paul Tillich, we can develop a phenomenology of hope. Leibniz argued that this is the best possible world, offering a foundation for enduring hope even amidst illness. Kierkegaard emphasised that a leap of faith can restore hope in our lives, while Paul Tillich described eschatological hope as a guiding force capable of navigating us through challenging situations. Building on these frameworks, we aim to construct a phenomenology of hope within the context of illness and suffering.

5. Phenomenology of Hope

Phenomenology of hope refers to the systematic study of the structural experience of hope, examining how individuals consciously experience, perceive, and live hope in their everyday lives. In the context of illness and suffering, a phenomenological understanding of hope emerges from the lived experience of pain, vulnerability, and limitation. Leibniz sees suffering as essential for the best world, Kierkegaard emphasises transcendence through faith, and Tillich views eschatological hope as active engagement rooted in shared human experience and divine connection. These experiences can be analysed through four perspectives: intentionality, embodied experience, temporal horizon, and transformative power.

5.1. Intentionality of Hope

Intentionality refers to the focus of consciousness on a specific object or anticipated future state. In the context of illness and suffering, hope acts as a positive commitment to envision and strive for a better future. Through intentionality, hope connects an individual's present suffering to their aspiration for a future state of well-being, meaning, or transcendence.

36 Tillich, *Systematic Theology*, Vol. 3, 369.

37 Tillich, *Systematic Theology*, Vol. 3, 370.

This experience of hope invites individuals to take a leap of faith, directing their conscious intention toward trust in a transcendent reality, even when faced with apparent meaninglessness. Leibniz's perspective on suffering based on the best possible world theory further deepens this understanding by emphasising the cosmic good, illustrating how intentionality helps individuals interpret suffering as part of a divine order. Through the intentionality of hope, one can do away with the Marxian understanding of alienation and reclaim the focus in life.

The intentionality of hope provides a way to transcend the Marxian concept of alienation by reorienting an individual's focus toward meaningful goals and aspirations. Hope, with its intentional focus, acts as a powerful antidote to this alienation. Through the intentionality of hope, individuals are empowered to project themselves into a future that they envision, giving them a sense of agency and direction. In this way, hope restores the individual's connection to their desires, goals, and values, which are often suppressed or overshadowed by alienation. Hope, therefore, provides a pathway for reclaiming agency, reconnecting with one's self, and engaging in life with renewed purpose, moving beyond alienation toward fulfilment and self-actualisation.

5.2. Embodied Experience of Hope

The embodied experience of hope refers to how hope manifests not just in thoughts or emotions but through the body itself. In moments of illness or suffering, hope is felt in physical sensations, such as the tension between fear and anticipation, and expressed through bodily gestures like perseverance or calmness. In illness, the body becomes a site of vulnerability, where sensations of pain and discomfort are intertwined with the emotional and cognitive anticipation of healing or transcendence. Embodied experiences of courage, fear, and vulnerability arise from the confrontation with physical limitations, as seen in both Kierkegaard's confrontation with finitude and Paul Tillich's eschatological engagement with suffering. These bodily experiences shape the way hope and faith are lived and expressed, not just abstractly but through the flesh and the physical encounter with pain.

Through the embodied experience of hope, one can transcend Albert Camus's understanding of pure suffering as intrinsically meaningless by reorienting the individual's perspective on suffering and its role in the human experience. The embodied experience of hope offers a way to reframe suffering. Hope is not just an abstract idea but an active, lived experience that connects the body, mind, and spirit. It is grounded in the human capacity to envision a future, to trust in possibilities beyond immediate pain or hardship, and to find meaning even in difficult circumstances. The

very act of hoping not only involves engaging with suffering in a way that acknowledges its presence but also sees it as something that can be endured, transformed, or transcended.

5.3. Temporal Horizon of Hope

The concept of the temporal horizon emphasises how hope is future-oriented but shaped by present and past experiences. Hope is an anticipation of a future outcome, which stretches forward beyond the immediate present. It is the horizon of possibility that transforms the current experience of suffering. Leibniz's best world paradigm situates illness and suffering within a broader cosmic and temporal framework, suggesting that present pain contributes to the perfection of the world in the long run. Kierkegaard's approach to faith also ties hope to the infinite, requiring individuals to look beyond the present limitations of life and illness toward a transcendent future. Eschatological hope, described by Paul Tillich, links this temporal horizon to a collective experience, drawing individuals into a future that extends beyond their personal suffering and into a communal and eternal engagement.

5.4. Transformative Power of Hope

The transformative power of hope refers to hope's ability to change one's experience of suffering and adversity. Hope has the potential to transform one's relationship with illness and suffering. It shifts the focus from despair to possibility, from passive suffering to active engagement. In Kierkegaard's account, the 'leap of faith' in the face of suffering offers a path to self-realisation and divine encounter, transforming suffering into an opportunity for transcendence. Similarly, the phenomenology of hope in illness points to transformation through solidarity, struggle, and communal support, as Tillich argues. Similarly, Viktor Frankl calls to transcend and transform suffering. He argues that the search for meaning is the primary motivator in life, even in the face of suffering. By connecting suffering with this larger vision of hope, individuals can endure hardship while maintaining faith in eventual redemption or resolution. Hope enables individuals to reinterpret their suffering as part of a larger, meaningful context. Therefore, hope is e not only future-directed but also a transformative presence in the here and now.

Conclusion

In conclusion, this article has examined the potential for constructing a phenomenology of hope through the frameworks of Leibniz, Kierkegaard, and Paul Tillich, together with insights from thinkers like Camus, Marx, and Frankl on the meaning of illness and suffering. These perspectives affirm that suffering is integral to a meaningful existence. This phenomenology of hope

offers a foundational approach for envisioning a better future, confronting suffering, and stretching hope across time, using it as a transformative power to foster meaning, resilience, and growth among challenges in the life-world.

8

Emotions and Hope
A Philosophical Study of Their Interplay

Lisbert D'Souza

Abstract

Emotions are an essential dimension of human living and we ignore or neglect them at our peril. But what about hope? Is hope an emotion? Whether it is or is not, what bearing might human hope have on human life and human emotions? Is hope a boon or a bane? This paper attempts to respond to these questions through seeking a more comprehensive understanding of emotions, phenomena whose nature seems to elude adequate formulation. It advances a Wittgensteinian view of emotions as being a very fruitful path to follow. Against this background, the paper argues that hope is entitled to inclusion in the list of emotions and, indeed, seems to have connectivity with many emotions. Moreover, the paper contends that life without hope would be meaningless, even impossible. Nevertheless, hope is a double-edged sword and can impact human life for good or ill.

Keywords: *Belief, Cognitivist, Constitutive, Emotions, Fear, Feelings, Hope, Motivator.*

Introduction

The topic 'Emotions and Hope: A Philosophical Study of Their Interplay' is ambiguous; it could mean the interplay between emotions and hope—which is not an emotion—or the interplay between emotions and hope which is one of the emotions. In this paper, I argue that hope is an emotion, indeed an emotion that greatly impacts human living, and that hope, in some sense, has a place within many other emotions.

The route I take is to present a holistic view of emotions, drawn from Wittgenstein, that sees emotions as rooted in human activities and as deriving their meaning from this rootedness, rather than as phenomena whose nature is best understood by analysing the components that constitute them. This holistic view of emotions will support our inclusion of hope as belonging to the phenomena we call emotions and illuminate the role hope plays—for good or ill—in human living.

Nature of Emotions

"The manner in which we conceive of a certain context or a certain person plays a crucial role in the generation of our emotions…hence, no single essence is necessary and sufficient for all emotions,"[1] as Aaron Ben-Ze'ev correctly observes. Nevertheless, over the past few decades, philosophers, psychologists and neuroscientists have laboured to investigate the phenomena we call emotions and provide comprehensive, albeit differing, definitions.[2] The lack of agreement on how to define emotions underscores the complexity that Ben-Ze'ev notes. Nevertheless, their efforts have merit in that each view puts into prominence one or another aspect of emotions and this helps us gain a deeper insight into happenings that touch the core of our being.

Most contemporary views claim that emotions involve some or all of these four elements: feelings of a certain kind (which are distinct from feelings that are sensations such as hunger, a headache, stomach ache, etc.), bodily changes, perceptions of some form and motives for action. If we divide these theories into two distinct, but not separate, baskets we have behavioural and cognitive views on the nature of emotions. The behavioural interpretation has its most known articulation in the writings of William James. Emotions, for him, are feelings caused by bodily changes. This

1 Aaron Ben-Ze'ev, *The Subtlety of Emotions* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2001), 3.

2 *See* Nicolae Sfetcu, "Models of Emotion," *Research Gate*, August 2020, http://dx.doi.org/10.13140/RG.2.2.28869.06881, accessed 18 July 2025. This article gives numerous and bewildering interpretations of emotions down the centuries.

approach has received a new lease of life in the neurological studies of theorists such as António Damásio, Joseph E. LeDoux and Robert Zajonc.[3]

An important criticism of this behavioural position is that it does not explain the difference in emotions such as pride and gratitude, for instance, as there are no bodily changes that distinguish one from the other. A behavioural interpretation is found wanting also because there is no basis for critiquing an emotional experience as warranted or not, rational or not. This position may argue that the mode or degree of expressing the emotion is unwarranted, but there seems no way to evaluate the emotion itself. Nevertheless, the behavioural approach has led to advances in dealing with mental health issues since medication that changes brain chemistry impacts emotions and moods.

The alleged limitations of a behavioural position have provoked a cognitive explanation.[4] The cognitivist approach argues that emotions are intentional, i.e. they are directed to that which the emotion is about. We are afraid of snakes, angry at people who insult us, grateful for gifts. Moreover, in each such case, there is an appraisal of a particular kind. Fear is related to appraising a situation as a threat, gratitude to being undeservedly favoured, pride to heightened self-esteem, etc. The object which is the focus of an emotion is called its 'material object' and the kind of appraisal made constitutes the 'material object' as the 'formal object' of an emotion. The snake that I see is the 'material object' of my fear, while perceiving it as a threat makes it the 'formal object' of my fear. The kind of assessment I make of the 'material object' determines the nature of my emotion (one who is afraid of dogs will perceive a dog very differently from a dog lover). This also serves in considering if the emotion is appropriate i.e. rationally justifiable. If you are afraid of a rope which you misperceive as a snake and now realise it is a rope, then your continuing fear would seem questionable. Similarly, if you are angry at someone because he has stolen your pen and your anger does not subside on discovering that your pen was in your bag all along, your anger would not be justified.

3 *See* Sfetcu: "Models of Emotions," 9.

4 *See* P. M. S. Hacker, "The Conceptual Framework for the Investigation of Emotions," in *Emotions and Understanding: Wittgensteinian Perspectives*, eds. Ylva Gustafsson, Camilla Kronqvist and Michael McEachrane (Hampshire: Palgrave Macmillan, 2009), 43–59. Hacker presents a strong case for the cognitivist view while highlighting the limitations of the behavioural position.

The cognitivist theory has much to commend it and is generally considered the most satisfactory account of emotions. However, as Wittgenstein observes, "Emotion can colour thoughts."[5] This invites us to appreciate that, in our appraisal of situations, what the 'facts' are is not a 'given' but determined through an assessment that is itself emotionally textured. As Camilla Kronqvist amply demonstrates, "This case, (the interaction between Tertius Lydgate and Rosamond Vincy, two characters in George Eliot's *Middlemarch*) then, reveals an important indeterminacy in what we can come to think of as relevant facts in a situation, since what we come to think of as facts in the first place is itself dependent on our ways of emotionally being engaged in our situation."[6] Awareness that our appraisal in emotional experiences is itself emotionally charged helps us make sense of recalcitrant emotions such as fear that persists even when we know the situation does not pose a threat.

In a similar vein, the spontaneous delight a child expresses in a gurgle or smile or the animal-like fear we feel at a cloudburst or similar terrifying sounds goes against a distinction between emotion and appraisal, even if the link is said to be logical, not causal. I would like to say that, in many cases, an emotion shows the appraisal that defines its nature rather than rest on it. In fact, one may convincingly argue that an appraisal involved in emotion is more relevant when considering its appropriateness and justification rather than its origin.[7] Hence, while the cognitivist analysis is insightful, it fails to capture the wholeness that constitutes an emotional experience.

Some theorists espouse a motivational view of emotions which presents an emotion as a propensity to act in ways relevant to the situation; an emotion is a guide to action in these circumstances. These theorists prescind from the cognitive aspect for they regard the spontaneous attitude adopted as already encapsulating an appraisal which renders any further cognitive stance unnecessary. This theory seems to fit best the emotions which humans share with the animal world where a propensity to flight is symptomatic of fear and to retaliate, of anger. However, one cannot easily extend this theory to emotions like grief, disappointment or even pride. One

5 Ludwig Wittgenstein, *Remarks on the Philosophy of Psychology,* Vol. II (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1980), 153.

6 Camilla Kronqvist, "The Reasons of Emotion," presented at the XXII Deutscher Kongress für Philosophie, September 11–15, 2011, Munich. The author offers a brilliant analysis of the relationship between two characters in George Eliot's Middlemarch to make this point.

7 *See* Justin D'Arms and Daniel Jacobson, "The significance of recalcitrant emotion (or, anti-quasi-judgmentalism)," in *Philosophy and the Emotions,* ed. Anthony Hatzimoysis, Royal Institute of Philosophy Supplement: 52 (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2003), 145.

can experience pride in seeing something as enhancing self-worth without wanting to do anything about it. Moreover, if I am filled with joy, there seems no symptomatic activity I am inclined to indulge in.

The elements I have presented are certainly helpful in getting a hold on this protean entity that is emotion but an emotion does not reduce to any one of these components or all of them jointly. As Wittgenstein notes, the temptation to single out one or a determinate set of qualities as defining characteristics of every emotion results from a one-sided diet.[8] We should rather, as he recommends, 'look and see.'[9]

Emotions: A Wittgensteinian Perspective

What shall we discover if we "look and see" as Wittgenstein recommends? I begin by referencing a comment in Wittgenstein's *Tractatus Logico-Philosophicus*, an unlikely place, one would think, for a reflection on emotions. "The world of the happy man is a different one from that of the unhappy man."[10] The happy person does not see a different world ontologically from the one the unhappy person sees. Both may experience the same vicissitudes of life such as heat, loss of a job, poor housing, poor health. None of this destroys the happy person's joy in living.

This commonplace observation puts into focus the subjectivity that imbues an emotion, a dimension which the cognitivist approach, with its duality of thought and emotion (even if logical and not causal), threatens to undermine. Though Wittgenstein directly discusses the human will in these paragraphs in the *Tractatus,* his observations are readily adaptable to emotions. So, rewriting his text, I would say, "the emotion does not deny the facts, i.e. the world as language describes it: the effect must be that it becomes an altogether different world."[11] The subjectivity I discern in Wittgenstein's comment does not deny the world out there; rather, it apprehends this world with new eyes.

8 Ludwig Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Investigations*, trans. G. E. M. Anscombe (Oxford: Blackwell, 2001), 593.

9 *See* Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Investigations,* 66.

10 Ludwig Wittgenstein, *Tractatus Logico-Philosophicus*, trans. D. F. Pears and B. F. McGuinness (New Jersey: Humanities Press, 1974), 6.43.

11 *See* Wittgenstein, *Tractatus*, 6.43.

Wittgenstein does not elaborate a theory of emotions but he does seem to subscribe to the Sartrean view that "Emotion is a certain way of apprehending the world."[12] As Wittgenstein expresses it, "What makes them (emotions) different from sensation: they do not give us any information about the external world (A grammatical remark).[13] Wittgenstein, therefore, moves away from his attempts in earlier writings to identify the characteristic features of emotions.[14] As Schulte notes, Wittgenstein refrains from discussing the nature of emotions in general and opts, rather, to focus on specific kinds of emotions, relating them to the various and complex situations in which they are embedded.[15]

This approach helps us realise that there can be no single, all-encompassing definition of all the phenomena we call emotions. Nor is a particular kind of emotion, fear for instance, identical in all its instances. Fear of snakes, fear of failure and fear that my bank is going to collapse are all 'fears' and yet the similarities are interlaced with dissimilarities. Rather, as in other concepts like games, for instance, we have a complex 'network of similarities overlapping and crisscrossing' of features where no one feature is common to all, and yet there are enough points of similarity to permit us to use the same term for a spectrum of cases. Wittgenstein calls these interrelated similar features 'family resemblances.'[16]

Wittgenstein concedes that this way of treating such phenomena leaves us with concepts which have 'blurred edges.' This does not make the concepts unusable;[17] rather, it highlights that many concepts are shaped by our use, not vice versa. Wittgenstein is mindful that there are features which commonly attach to our talk about emotions but rejects any claim that there is a set of features that must be present for something to qualify as an emotion. Emotions have 'objects,' which he calls their 'target'. However, while the object of an emotion is evident in emotions like anger (at an insult, a shove in the back when boarding a train) and fear (of a snake, of failure, of death), there is no identifiable 'object' when one is happy with life (as distinct from being happy at one's safe return home or at one's team's victory), nor is there always a definable 'object' when one is sad, regretful, disappointed, ashamed, grateful.

12 Jean Paul Sartre, *The Emotions: Outline of a Theory,* trans. Bernard Frechtman (New York: Carol Publishing, Group Edition, 1993), 52.

13 Wittgenstein, *Philosophy of Psychology,* Vol. II, 148.

14 *See* Ludwig Wittgenstein, *Remarks on Philosophy of Psychology* Vol. I, eds. G. E. M. Anscombe and G. H. von Wright, trans. G. E. M. Anscombe (Oxford: Blackwell, 1980), 836.

15 Joachim Schulte, "Wittgenstein on Emotion," in *Emotions and Understanding,* 37–38.

16 Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Investigations*, 66–67.

17 Wittgenstein*, Philosophical Investigations*, 71.

To defend the claim that emotions necessarily take 'objects' by classifying the above as moods, not emotions, would be inaccurate and, in a manner of speaking, a Pyrrhic victory. Similarly, Wittgenstein sees that emotions involve appraisals, *seeing an aspect*. However, we can only with artificiality press the claim that emotion and appraisal are distinguishable either logically or causally when we experience fear at a thunderburst, see a baby's spontaneous smile or hear its gurgle of pleasure.

To enter the right way in understanding emotions, we must go deeper than trying to identify the components that belong to phenomena we call emotions. We need to go right down to the foundations, says Wittgenstein.[18] And when we go deeper we will arrive at an intuition which Wittgenstein considers foundational and which he expresses in the words of Goethe's *Faust*, "In the beginning was the deed."[19] The bedrock of human emotions is human doing, the plethora of actions we engage in which Wittgenstein calls 'forms of life.'[20] The role that our human doings play in emotions is well summed up in these words: "Only surrounded by certain normal manifestations of life, is there such a thing as an expression of pain. Only surrounded by an even more far-reaching particular manifestation of life, such sorrow or affection (sic) And so on."[21]

Emotions and Hope

Let me now address my earlier question: is hope an emotion? There are many who would respond in the negative. Those who favour a behavioural interpretation argue that, unlike in fear and anger which are paradigmatic emotions, there are no significant bodily changes when one hopes. Nor is there any characteristic inclination to act. Cognitivists, who rule out hope as an emotion, point out that hope is better seen as an attitude, akin to optimism, as it lacks a clear 'formal object.' Before we essay a rebuttal of this position, we need to understand the phenomenon we call hope.

In recent years, Anglo-Saxon philosophy has shown a lot of interest in 'hope'. Having reviewed several definitions of hope proposed by contemporary philosophers, I find the view of Thomas Aquinas the most comprehensive and suggestive. In the *Summa Theologiae*,[22] he identifies four elements that belong to hope: it seeks something good, it refers to

18 *See* Ludwig Wittgenstein, *Culture and Value*, ed. G. H. von Wright in collaboration with Heikki Nyman. Revised Edition of the Text by Alois Pichler trans. Peter Winch (Oxford: Blackwell, 1998), 71.

19 Wittgenstein, *Culture and Value*, 36.

20 Wittgenstein*, Philosophical Investigations*, 23, 241, 226e.

21 Wittgenstein, *Philosophy of Psychology,* Vol. II, 151.

22 Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae,* I–II, 40 and II–II, 17.

the future in that it is not yet attained, it must be something arduous and difficult to obtain, and yet possible. Aquinas notes that attaining this good may well need assistance from some source, human or divine, other than our own capacities.

Teasing out the elements in Aquinas' definition, we might say that it belongs to the concept of hope that the hoped-for object is something good; one does not hope for something that one considers undesirable. Further, one needs to believe that the desired good is possible; one does not hope for what is impossible. I cannot hope that I will be able to swim the Palk Strait as I am unable to swim and am over 80 years old. Again, what I hope for must be possible, but its realisation is not certain (or known to have occurred). It could be an event yet to take place or one that has taken place but whose outcome is not known to me. I can hope that I have got the position I applied for, though that decision is already taken, as long as I am not aware of what the decision is. Hence, hope is about a good that is possible and uncertain. One does not hope for what one is certain one can achieve. Precisely because realising what we hope for is not fully within our capacity to achieve, there is space for assistance from outside, human or divine.

A particularly relevant and instructive case is the hope that climate change enthusiasts (hopefully, we are in that group) entertain about the future of our planet. There seems so little room for hope to gain purchase and yet we, and millions of others, refuse to succumb to doomsday talk though we seem to be fighting a losing battle. A research study among climate change advocates reveals how crucial the community dimension is in sustaining hope in the face of crises: hope is nurtured and built through sharing stories of the power of working together; hope is fed and sustained by being part of a community and movement that strives to achieve the hoped-for end; optimism that we have the ingenuity and ability to solve the challenges of human-induced climate change sustains hope; the conviction that ultimately humanity will not just survive, but thrive despite the enormous challenges ahead is yet another significant factor.[23]

I return to the question: Is hope an emotion? For Aquinas and Spinoza, Hume and Sartre the answer is yes. For others, especially psychologists, the answer is in the negative. Clearly, hope meets the criteria for emotions such as having a 'material object': our hope is about events or persons. We hope we may have a long life, succeed in our undertakings, etc. Hope has a 'formal object' as these hoped-for things or events are seen as desirable, and

23 Mandy Scotney, *The Experience of Hope for Climate Change Advocates,* https://researchers-admin.westernsydney.edu.au/ws/portalfiles/portal/94895063/uws_68921.pdf, accessed 31 January 2025.

possible, though not certain. What seems lacking are the feelings evident in anger, fear, joy and sadness. There also seem to be no characteristic bodily expressions. However, this may also be said of gratitude and pride which we do not hesitate to include as emotions. As Aaron Ben-Ze'ev explains, the temporal distance between hoping and its object explains such lack of feeling. However, one can become intensely imbued with feeling when the event hoped for draws near.[24]

Wittgenstein seems clear on the issue. "Compare the expression of fear and hope with that of 'belief' that such-and-such will happen. —That is why hope and fear are counted among the emotions: belief (or believing), however, is not."[25] He notes that hope is incomprehensible apart from the forms of life in which it is embedded.[26] Döring sums up the issue well when she observes, "Primarily, hope is an emotion: a felt evaluation whose felt aspect necessarily involves feelings of confidence of a certain degree. Now, to feel confidence in hoping means seeing what one hopes for as being possible. Clearly, this kind of seeing something as possible essentially differs from the assignment of subjective probability."[27] This kind of "seeing something as possible" points up an emotional investment that the neutral assessment that something is possible lacks.

Hope is a phenomenon of human life. Is it a phenomenon that contributes to or negates human well-being? Nietzsche roundly condemned hope as 'the worst of all evils,"[28] Spinoza, too, has a negative assessment of hope in that it arises from our fragmentary and inadequate cognitions. Hope, he says, is "inconstant pleasure arising from the idea of a thing future or past, of whose outcome we are in some doubt."[29] As such it is a passive emotion and holds us in bondage for, though it is a kind of joy, it is always accompanied by fear of a future evil. We must strive to live under the guidance of reason so that hope weakens its hold on us.[30] Hope participates in an uncertainty that is unsettling to one seeking serenity.

The fact of the matter seems to be that hope is a two-edged sword. On the one hand, hope is a powerful tool for manipulation and exploitation. Financial scams are rooted in the "get rich quickly" hopes that people entertain, and come election time, exploiting hope is often the key to

24 *See* Ben-Ze'ev, *The Subtlety of Emotions*, 475.

25 Wittgenstein, *Philosophy of Psychology,* Vol. I, 596.

26 Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Investigations*, 583.

27 Sabine Döring, "What May I Hope? Why it can be rational to rely on one's hope," *European Journal for Philosophy of Religion* 6, no. 3 (2014): 125.

28 Quoted by Döring, "What May I Hope?", 119.

29 Baruch Spinoza, *Ethics* (London: J. M. Dent & Sons, 1941), III, Def. XII.

30 Spinoza, *Ethics,* IV, Proposition XLVII and Note.

political success. On the other hand, if we were bereft of hope, we would have no reason to live. One may even claim that hope is the best possible emotion as it instils in us a positive outlook on life, inviting us to believe that good things will happen to us. Hope is a huge motivator to act in the pursuit of values that we esteem and which make humanity move ahead on the path of peace and justice. There is such a thing as "hoping against hope"—which gains sustenance from faith in other human or divine agents. Hence, hope can lead to astonishing success —but it can also be entertained to a point where it destroys lives. For instance, a woman who is diagnosed as physically unable to have a child may spend the entire family resources in the futile hope that some treatment will make her a mother. Like all powerful instruments, hope must be handled with care and discernment.

Hope and Emotions: Interplay

I now address my final theme. Not only is hope an emotion, but it seems to lodge within many emotions and also to mitigate emotions that we consider need husbanding.

The bond between hope and fear is clear. Spinoza sees them as passive emotions that look to the unknown but in opposite ways. Fear regards the unknown with a negative feeling while hope does so with joy. In each case, the other looms large! When I hope I will get the job, I at the same time fear I may not; my fear that I will be late for a crucial appointment is tinged with the hope that I somehow will get there in time.

Hope is linked with joy. Nobody hopes for what will distress one. So, hope is seen as bringing joy on its fulfilment. Equally, joy encapsulates hope. When one is enjoying oneself, one hopes this happy situation will endure —the party will never end. Hence, love too will contain the hope that this satisfying situation may go on and on.

Strangely, hope is connected with anger, for within anger resides the hope that retaliation will remove the provocative situation. This is why when we retaliate in anger, verbally or physically, we may experience a sense of satisfaction; we have evened the score! Massive and abiding anger can result in hatred and here one's hope of attaining serenity seeks the total annihilation of the other. One may say that this hope underlay the exterminations we saw in the Nazi and Khmer Rouge programs—and which continues to infuse xenophobic attitudes and practices.

Moving to more pleasant climes, the adage 'gratitude for favours done is the surest means to bring new favours on' hints at the hope that one's expressed gratitude will prompt one's benefactor to continue to favour one.

Surprisingly, regret is also hope-related, as regret, in an important sense, signifies the wish that one had behaved differently and the hope that one will do so in future if circumstances arise. Envy is the unhappiness we

feel when another has personal qualities, possessions, etc. which we wish we did. There is, so to say, a double hope in envy. We hope the other will somehow lose what we deem makes the other better off than us! We also hope we may somehow come to have that which makes us envious. Jealousy too seems to contain hope, for when I am jealous I believe, for instance, that my beloved cares more for another than for me. However, I do not know this for certain, and part of me hopes I am wrong.[31] Shame involves the hope that my future conduct will be praiseworthy or at least not blameworthy and that the negative impression I have created will be erased. Resentment implies the hope that bad, not good things, will happen to the one who has injured me.

I briefly indicate how hope can modify certain negative emotions. Hope can make an envious person proactive; instead of wallowing in self-pity, hope can motivate action that will achieve results that boost one's self-esteem. Similarly, hope can help us transcend the negativity of shame by leading us to act in praiseworthy ways. Hope in an after-life is our great consolation in managing grief. Hope can hold fear in check by emphasising the positive. This would hold good in cases of fear about being laid-off or not receiving promotion, for instance, for recalling the positive evaluation in the past can generate a hope that trumps fear. Hope that a world of peace and harmony is possible or that refugees can be integrated and contribute to a nation's prosperity can help overcome communal hatred and animosity towards the "outsider." Hope can temper pride, as future success is by no means certain; hope which implies uncertainty, can bring in a healthy humility. Finally, embarrassment, disappointment and similar emotions yield to the hope that we will give a better account of ourselves in future situations.

Conclusion

I trust this paper has increased our awareness of the pivotal role the emotion of hope has in life. One may say that hope not only facilitates positive outcomes since those motivated by hope usually perform better than those who are not, but is constitutive of who one is. The hope that her children will have a better future not only sustains a single, economically disadvantaged mother who works herself to the bone, but is constitutive of her identity as a good mother, one who cares deeply about her children's future. So also, the hope of those who train to be doctors, social workers, and socially-minded lawyers not only facilitates dedicated study but is at the core of their self-understanding as people who want to make a difference. In fine:

31 *See* Ben-Ze'ev, *The Subtlety of Emotions*, 301. I have benefitted greatly from his magisterial study. *See* Chapters 10–18, 81–529.

Hope is philosophically significant by virtue of the fact that it constitutes a fundamental and central mode of human existence; it is the principal driving force of the historical-temporal human being in via. A human being without hope is like a walking corpse, which is both physiologically and metaphysically absurd.[32]

32 Bernard N. Schumacher, *Philosophy of Hope*, trans. D. C. Schindler (New York: Fordham University Press, 2003), 2.

9

The Interplay of Hopeful Fear and Fearful Hope
A Psychoanalytic Philosophical Examination

Jacob Palaparambil

Abstract

Emotions play a crucial role in human existence, profoundly affecting our perceptions, decisions and actions. Among the wide range of emotions, hope and fear are particularly striking, often existing together in complex ways that highlight the paradoxes of the human experience. This paper explores the philosophical dimensions of hopeful fear and fearful hope, terms that encapsulate the intricate interplay between these emotions in uncertain and critical situations. By investigating these emotional extremes, the paper aims to understand how they influence our lives, reflect our existential conditions, and contribute to humanity's quest for meaning. Its findings hold significant implications for philosophy, psychology and our overall understanding of human nature.

Keywords: *Amygdala, Adrenaline, Cognitive dissonance, Dualities, Fight-or-flight response, Freeze response, Human existence, Motivators, Neurobiological stress, Perception of reality, Physiological arousal, Vulnerability.*

Introduction

One cannot deny the fact that feelings represent the largest part of who human beings are. Apart from affecting our thinking, emotions also characterise our ways of acting and relating to other human beings. Among all the emotions, hope and fear stand atop, as they both are unquestionable opposites but are in reality closely related. These words, *hope* and *fear*, are not opposing things. Rather, hope is generally accompanied by positive expectations about the future, while fear is linked to the expectation of possible damage or loss. That is why hope and fear entwine as reactions to uncertainty and to things unknown—making them so richly human.

Hope and fear have, for long, formed staple themes for several philosophical discussions and explorations by the likes of Plato,[1] Aristotle,[2] Augustine,[3] Thomas Aquinas,[4] Søren Kierkegaard,[5] and Heidegger[6] in terms

1 Plato's dialogues portray hope and fear as double-edged swords, capable of both motivating and misleading. Hope can inspire positive action but also lead to false expectations, while fear can deter wrongdoing but also paralyse individuals. Cf. Plato, *The Dialogues of Plato, Vol. 2*, trans. Benjamin Jowett (New York: Random House, 1937).

2 In his work *Nicomachean Ethics*, Aristotle defines fear as a natural response to danger and explains courage as the ability to face it bravely. While he does not discuss hope in detail, he suggests it's related to self-control and the desire for good things. Cf. Aristotle, *Nicomachean Ethics*, trans. W. D. Ross (Oxford University Press, 1925).

3 Augustine, in his treatise *Enchiridion*, posits hope as a foundational virtue for Christians, alongside faith and love. He contrasts this with fear, which he identifies as a natural human response to our vulnerability and the inevitability of death. Cf. Augustine, *Enchiridion on Faith, Hope, and Love,* trans. Albert C. Outler (Louisville: Westminster John Knox Press, 1955).

4 Thomas Aquinas regarded hope and fear as fundamental human emotions, especially within the framework of faith. He considered hope to be more than mere wishful thinking; it was a resolute belief rooted in faith. In contrast, Aquinas differentiated between healthy and unhealthy fear. Healthy fear was a reverence for God that directed one's actions, while unhealthy fear could lead to despair or anxiety. Cf. Etienne Gilson, *The Christian Philosophy of St. Thomas Aquinas* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1956); Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologica*, trans. Fathers of the English Dominican Province (New York: Benziger Brothers, 1947).

5 Kierkegaard argues that anxiety (fear) is a defining feature of the human experience because we are constantly faced with choices in the face of uncertainty. Fear is a natural response to this existential uncertainty, but hope arises from faith or belief in meaningful outcome, even when it seems unknown. For Kierkegaard, faith requires embracing both fear and hope in what he calls a 'leap of faith.' Cf. Søren Kierkegaard, *The Sickness Unto Death: A Christian Psychological Exposition for Upbuilding and Awakening*, trans. Howard V. Hong and Edna H. Hong (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1980).

6 Heidegger's analysis of *Being-toward-death* from *Being and Time*, reveals how human existence is oriented toward the future, with the awareness of death casting a shadow of

of their implications for human existence. Traditionally hope is understood as a forward-looking emotion, an optimistic expectation that something good will come about and is thought possible to be attained. Hope is characteristically accompanied by optimism and an active attitude toward the future. Fear is characteristically understood as a response to potential dangers or threats and goes with heightened awareness of vulnerability and interest in potential negative consequences. Hope and fear are seen as mutually integral parts of human nature and thus as reflected fundamental metaphysical dualities—life and death, being and non-being, etc.

This does not make hope and fear simple opposites, as seems intuitively obvious. It is rather this kind of complexity that reflects all the contradictions and ambiguities intrinsic in human existence. As emotions toward the future, hope and fear both originate in response to uncertainty, but they do so in sharply different ways. Hope can be tainted by fear when the result is one which cannot be known, and fear can be tinged with hope when what is hoped for is a pleasing thing. This interplay puts a kind of lived experience on the spectrum which cannot be so easily labelled as hope or fear alone. In this paper, by bringing out the concepts of *hopeful fear*[7] and *fearful hope*,[8] an attempt has been made to explore the philosophical aspects of these extreme emotional conditions.

Hopeful fear emerges when the person experiencing fear still holds hope for a better result. In this state, the individual may fear potential negative consequences while simultaneously believing there is a chance for success or relief.[9] This tension creates a conflict in the mind because fear typically signals danger or setbacks, while hope represents optimism and possibility. People use various strategies to manage the conflicting emotions of hopeful fear. Some may focus more on the hopeful aspects

fear over life. In this fear, there is also hope for a meaningful life before death. Here, hopeful fear represents the anxiety about death but the hope for a life well-lived for a purpose. Cf. Martin Heidegger, *Being and Time,* trans. John Macquarrie and Edward Robinson (New York: Harper & Row, 1962).

7 Hopeful fear: This term describes a situation where fear is the dominant emotion, but it is tempered by a sense of hope. For example, a person might fear a medical diagnosis but still hold onto hope for a favourable outcome. In this case, fear is not entirely paralysing because it is accompanied by the possibility of a positive resolution. Hopeful fear reflects a recognition of danger or uncertainty but also a refusal to succumb to despair.

8 Fearful Hope: This term captures a state where hope is the primary emotion, yet it is accompanied by an underlying fear of disappointment or setback. For instance, someone might hope for success in a new venture but also fear the potential for setbacks or obstacles. Fearful hope reflects an aspiration for a better future while acknowledging the risks and uncertainties that come with it.

9 Example: I hope it does not rain today because I want to wear my new dress.

and downplay the fearful ones, reducing conflict by allowing the hopeful narrative to dominate their thinking. Others may rationalise the situation by telling themselves that fearing the worst prepares them for any outcome, but holding onto hope keeps them mentally resilient. By finding mental ways to manage or justify the coexistence of fear and hope, individuals can maintain a sense of balance, even in the face of uncertainty.

Fearful hope occurs when a person is hopeful about a situation but harbours underlying fears about negative outcomes.[10] Unlike *hopeful fear*, where fear dominates with a glimmer of hope, *fearful hope* is primarily an optimistic state that is undermined by doubt and worry. The mental conflict in fearful hope comes from the clash between optimistic expectations and the fear of disappointment. People manage this by consciously lowering their expectations, telling themselves not to get too attached to the outcome. This reduces the gap between hope and fear, diminishing the conflict.[11] Some individuals may even brace themselves for a setback as a coping strategy. This does not eliminate hope but softens the potential emotional blow of a negative outcome, reducing psychological discomfort. Others may compartmentalise their hopeful and fearful thoughts, allowing themselves to focus on hope at certain times and worry about fears later. This separation of conflicting emotions helps reduce the conflict by preventing the two states from directly clashing at the same time.[12]

While fear and hope may seem distinct at times, our experiences teach us that this distinction is largely a matter of perception rather than a substantive difference. Hope and Fear are both motivators, one driving us toward something, the other away from something.[13] One could say that hope and fear are like Bruce Wayne and Batman; although they wear very different outfits and exhibit contrasting, extreme personalities, they are in fact one and the same. Therefore, to explore the potential relationship between hope and fear more deeply, this paper will begin by outlining the origins of hope, followed by an examination of the role of cognitive dissonance, hope as a moderator of fear, fear as a limitation of hope, stress, anxiety and optimism in *hopeful fear* and *fearful hope*, and finally the long-term psychological effects of living with *hopeful fear* or *fearful hope*. Thus,

10 Example: I hope it rains, because if it does not rain, then I will not be able to grow my crops and feed my family.

11 Gabriel Marcel, *Homo Viator: Introduction to a Metaphysic of Hope* (London: Harvill Press, 1951), 30–32.

12 Richard Lazarus, *Emotion and Adaption*, (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1991), 275–280.

13 Marcel, *Homo Viator*, 15–18.

this paper invites us to reflect on the paradoxical nature of hope and fear, and their roles in shaping our perception of reality and our place within it.[14]

The Origins of Hope

The earliest origins of hope could be said to be embedded in the concepts of faith and religion.[15] It seems that the idea of having faith in something beyond this physical life is universal across cultures, perhaps even rooted in our genetics and evolutionary history. It is often observed that when people experience despair, their immediate response is to turn to hope and prayer, even if they have never practised or with a religion before.[16] In such moments, praying reflects our hope in a miracle, despite all logical evidence to the contrary. We seek comfort through prayer, and it seems that comfort is indeed found, even if it comes from this seemingly irrational hope. Does this mean that hope is a form of delusion, a positive illusion, and if so, is it harmful?

In comparison to fear which on its own can be counterproductive, it would be better to term hope as evolutionary. A hopeful form of fear could sharpen the mind, enabling an individual to tap into their potential and navigate challenges or threats.[17] Could hope, then, be a way to moderate fear? This leads us to an interesting argument where fear becomes too overwhelming to inspire meaningful action, hope steps in to ease the fear just enough to break through inaction. One common theme is that hope and faith tend to rise when we feel a lack of control or influence over an outcome that holds significant meaning for us. A lack of control, especially over uncertain outcomes, often gives rise to either hope or fear, a pattern so tangibly verifiable in our day-to-day life experiences.[18]

When we hope, we are trusting that the outcome will be favourable, even when we have little or no ability to influence it.[19] Therefore, hope cannot exist when we have reason to believe we have a guaranteed path forward or full control over the outcome. At its extreme, the idea that hope arises when there seems to be no logical way forward may appear to contradict hope theory, which suggests that hope involves both a 'will' and a 'way.'[20] When

14 Lazarus, *Emotion and Adaption*, 275–277.

15 Marcel, *Homo Viator*, 7–9.

16 Viktor Frankl, *Man's Search for Meaning* (Boston: Beacon Press, 2006), 42–45.

17 Rick Hanson, *Hardwiring Happiness: The New Brain Science of Contentment, Calm, and Confidence* (New York: Harmony Books, 2013), 122–124.

18 Charles R. Snyder, *The Psychology of Hope: You Can Get There from Here* (London: Free Press, 1994), 78–80.

19 Marcel, *Homo Viator*, 18–20.

20 Snyder, *The Psychology of Hope*, 5–8.

we begin to suspect that the outcome will be negative, we tend to focus on the likelihood of that negative outcome, leading to fear. From this fearful mindset, it is possible to shift from fearing that the outcome will happen to hoping that it will not. Some may argue that this shift is merely semantic, a re-labelling of fear. However, others suggest that this shift in perspective goes beyond semantics, creating a different mental state that is more useful to finding a path forward, despite the odds. If the latter view is correct, one would expect to experience very different emotions and altered sense of meaning between the two perspectives.[21]

The Role of Cognitive Dissonance in Managing Hopeful Fear and Fearful Hope

Cognitive dissonance is the psychological discomfort a person experiences when s/he holds two beliefs that are incompatible, attitudes, or behaviours at the same time. This theory was first stated by Leon Festinger in 1957 and was based on the premise that people were motivated to decrease such discomfort: either they changed their beliefs or behaviours, or rationalised this inconsistency. Applied to *hopeful fear* and *fearful hope*, cognitive dissonance can help explain how a person manages the contradictory nature of these two emotional states.

To equalise an attitude that reduces this dissonance by *hopeful fear* and *fearful hope*, people do identify the chance of a bad result and the possibility of success. This way, they temper the tension in the two opposing feelings. Most people believe that the outcome of incidents is due to causes beyond their control, relieved that everything possibly done has been done.[22] This attitude removes some of the weight and effects of dissonance to some degree. Attention to the unforeseen future causes one to realise that the near-at-hand results do not represent one's entire life—thus dissolving the stakes of present fear or hope. According to cognitive dissonance theory in most situations, people change their behaviours either to ensure beliefs or to diminish emotional pain. For instance, those experiencing *hopeful fear* may take proactive steps to manage their risks, while individuals in a state of *fearful hope* might seek reassurance from others to bolster their optimism. Positive feedback from trusted sources reinforces hope, helping to resolve dissonance.[23]

Self-justification also plays a key role in managing cognitive dissonance, allowing individuals to rationalise conflicting feelings. For example: in *hopeful fear*, one might think that it is natural to be afraid, but

21 Lazarus, *Emotion and Adaption*, 278–281.

22 Frankl, *Man's Search for Meaning*, 74–76.

23 Snyder, *The Psychology of Hope*, 112–115.

there are reasons to remain hopeful. In *fearful hope*, one may justify their optimism by stating that even though there is fear, hope is essential because without it everything would be meaningless. Such rationalisations enable individuals to maintain both emotions without overwhelming cognitive tension.[24]

Thus, cognitive dissonance is significant in managing *hopeful fear* and *fearful hope*. By employing strategies like rationalisation, selective focus, and self-justification, individuals can ease the discomfort caused by conflicting emotional states.

Hope as a Moderator of Fear

Several psychological theories explore how hope moderates fear, enabling an individual to avoid paralysis or panic during a crisis. One prominent framework is 'Hope Theory', developed by psychologist Charles Snyder, which posits that hope comprises two key components: the belief in one's ability and motivation to achieve desired outcomes, and the belief in multiple ways to reach those outcomes despite obstacles. This sense of hope, in crisis situations, helps counterbalance the feelings of fear and fosters a proactive mindset.[25]

Hope allows an individual to focus on the problem rather than succumbing to fear, where a threat is not going to hinder somebody and might even continue maintaining solution-focused behaviour intact. Cognitive Appraisal Theory of Richard Lazarus outlines how people evaluate threats and react to them. In this case, hope can be integrated into the process and convert the overwhelming threat into a manageable challenge, which would reduce the intensity of fear.[26]

The *Broaden-and-Build Theory* of positive emotions as proposed by Barbara Fredrickson suggests that hope expands the cognitive resources of the individual with creativity and flexibility in solving problems when faced with adversity, whereas fear narrows an individual's cognitive resources. This led to the opening up of avenues in a much greater multitude of solutions and actions. Self-efficacy—the belief that one can succeed—adds to it.[27] According to Albert Bandura's *Self-Efficacy Theory*, confident and hopeful approaches of those with a lot of self-efficacy about challenges reduce fear responses in crises. If people believe they can make a difference

24 Lazarus, *Emotion and Adaption*, 284–287.

25 Snyder, *The Psychology of Hope*, 5–9.

26 Lazarus, *Emotion and Adaption*, 270–274.

27 Barbara L. Fredrickson, *Positivity*, (New York: Crown Publishers, 2009), 103–106.

and effect change, then there will be less helplessness; panic and paralysis are avoided.[28]

Thus, psychological theories highlight the powerful role of hope in moderating fear, particularly in crises. By enhancing agency (Hope Theory), reframing challenges (Cognitive Appraisal Theory), and fostering resilience (Broaden-and-Build Theory), hope motivates action, problem solving, and adaptive responses, thus helping individuals navigate even the most difficult challenges with confidence and resilience.

Fear as a Limitation of Hope

Fear and hope often shift and influence decision-making and resilience during times of crisis. Fear, being an evolutionarily well-proved emotional tool to scan and react to danger, stimulates the amygdala within the brain, increases alertness, but makes a person focus on immediate dangers by dissipating their attention. This results in worst-case thinking, which oftentimes concentrates thoughts and thinking on a negative outcome while pushing aside hopeful possibilities.[29]

Such fixation can escalate anxiety and foster catastrophising, making even small challenges feel overwhelming. As fear magnifies potential risks, it generates doubt and hesitation about the belief in one's ability to achieve desired outcomes. This doubt diminishes hope, leading to an expectation of setback and a reluctance to take risks.[30]

Fear also disrupts rational decision-making, prioritising short term safety over long term goals. Though helpful in survival as a short-term tactic, this mechanism during instant danger becomes a hindrance in situations where people need to persist. Risk-averse behaviour becomes overwhelming as people avoid ventures which might prove them winners. Physiologically, it activates the fight or flight response that releases stress hormones such as cortisol and adrenaline, that work to compromise some of the cognitive functions necessary in maintaining hope. Chronic fear may lead to exaggerated anxiety such that it becomes challenging to develop a hopeful mentality. In extreme cases, it triggers the freeze response, paralysing people in indecision.[31]

Hope is a fragile and belief-dependent emotion that moves in tandem with the idea of positive outcomes being fully realised and, perhaps, often defined by fear. While hope does flower on fertile soil of uncertain events,

28 Albert Bandura, *Self-Efficacy: The Exercise of Control*, (New York: W.H. Freeman and Company, 1997), 37–40.

29 Lazarus, *Emotion and Adaption*, 242–245.

30 Snyder, *The Psychology of Hope*, 45–48.

31 Fredrickson, *Positivity*, 110–113.

fear magnifies ambiguity, and what could be a great opportunity becomes something to fear. Once hope recedes into the background, one focuses more on what could go wrong than on what could be done. People may be locked into unproductive bad cycles that reinforce their fears and drain motivation from good changes.[32]

The Psychological Consequences

The emotional weight of *hopeful fear* and *fearful hope* has the potential to encapsulate a person into different corners of their mental health, acting as an impetus on how they channelise their stress, anxiety or optimism. The ratio of fear to hope determines whether people feel empowered or overwhelmed during uncertain situations. In either case, it is an interplay between optimism and pessimism, where both represent psychological states with consequences.[33] Being in a state of fear and hope creates a great deal of stress. For many of us, stress is the body's natural reaction to potential threats, be it real or simply imagined. They generate both *hopeful fear* and *fearful hope*, increasing stress by putting people in ongoing emotional conflict between the expectations and prospect of positive outcomes on one hand, and the reverse on the other.[34]

Stress in Hopeful Fear and Fearful Hope

In *hopeful fear*, stress is primarily driven by the looming presence of fear. The mind remains on high alert, bracing itself for potential negative outcomes. Although hope provides some relief, it does not fully alleviate the tension. The body's fight-or-flight response may be chronically activated due to the fear of impending danger.[35] Even if hope tempers the intensity of this fear, the stress response persists because the threat is not completely removed. This outcome of physiological and psychological arousal can push people into chronic stress, along with related health issues like headaches, muscle tension, or even fatigue. There is also a chance that *hopeful fear* may make one uneasy and incapable of resting or dropping guard. When people are hopeful, the deep-seated fear keeps them vigilant. It leaves them cut off from periods of both mental and emotional rest, thereby exacerbating the feelings of exhaustion and burnout.

In fearful hope, the stress arises from the constant background presence of doubt. While hope dominates, there is a persistent undercurrent of fear that makes it difficult to fully embrace optimism. Individuals in a state of *fearful*

32 Marcel, *Homo Viator*, 23–25.

33 Snyder, *The Psychology of Hope*, 120–123.

34 Fredrickson, *Positivity*, 117–120.

35 Lazarus, *Emotion and Adaption*, 284–286.

hope experience a fluctuating emotional state. At times, they feel confident about positive outcomes, but this confidence is quickly undermined by fear and doubt.[36] The inconsistency of their emotions creates stress, as they are never fully certain of their situation. This unpredictability can increase cortisol levels, the body's primary stress hormone, which contributes to feelings of unease and tension. People living in *fearful hope* often experience **anticipatory stress,** wherein they constantly prepare for potential setbacks or negative outcomes, despite feeling mostly hopeful. This anticipation of possible danger could create a lingering sense of discomfort that erodes emotional well-being.

Anxiety in Hopeful Fear and Fearful Hope

In *hopeful fear*, anxiety tends to be more pronounced because fear takes precedence over hope. The mind remains fixated on the possibility of negative outcomes, even if hope provides a glimmer of optimism.[37] The fear component in *hopeful fear* would lead to hypervigilance, wherein the person is ever on the watch for symptoms or signs of danger. This increases their anxiety because in this condition, they are compelled to be prepared for the worst at all times. Even when there isn't a threat, it is the fear of what may happen that keeps the individual in anxious anticipation.[38] The hope as an emotion characteristically results in catastrophising, a situation where people see the worst even though hopeful outcomes are evident. Their anxiety is due to the fact that things may turn out badly, thus making them keep an imbalanced or pessimistic outlook. The constant *what if* thinking increases generalised anxiety, as they struggle to reconcile their fear with their hope.

In *fearful hope*, anxiety is not so evident, though always lurking in the background. Underlying fears constantly undermine the dominant hopeful outlook, introducing insecurity.[39] Outwardly, they may appear confident or hopeful, but inwardly they deal with anxieties and disappointment. This internal conflict leads to chronic, low-grade anxiety which, over the passage of time, can accumulate. *Hopeful fear* springs in part from the very nature of situations of hope—being unpredictable.[40]

On the one hand, one hopes that something might work out one way or another; on the other hand, a look in the mirror discloses to oneself that it may not. It is this tension of wanting to believe a good outcome is possible

36 Fredrickson, *Positivity*, 117–120.

37 Snyder, *The Psychology of Hope*, 91–93.

38 Lazarus, *Emotion and Adaption*, 285–287.

39 Fredrickson, *Positivity*, 113–116.

40 Marcel, *Homo Viator*, 27–29.

versus knowledge that sometimes things will go wrong which eventually translates into anxiety. This can never be resolved, and one remains at that moderate level of anxiety. While fear is central to both *hopeful fear* and *fearful hope*, the presence of hope introduces an element of optimism, which can moderate negative psychological effects.[41] However, the extent to which optimism influences mental health depends on whether hope or fear is dominant.

Optimism in Hopeful Fear and Fearful Hope

Optimism often breeds hope tinged with fear. The fearful elements very easily overshadow the hopeful feeling in people's lives, and thus the positive attitude of optimism cannot be completely achieved. Optimism in *hopeful fear* is quite often even conditional. People might feel hopeful as long as the circumstances surrounding that hope continue to be true, but their optimism wears off right away once those circumstances change. This fragile optimism can again be overthrown and plunge the scale the other way—to fear. While fear governs, hope operates as a psychological cushion of optimism that provides resistance against total desperation, even in the presence of fear.[42] Hope for a positive ending gives emotional resilience; moving on with fear is still possible. However, such optimism in many cases is tentative and vulnerable to new threats or new uncertainties.

Optimism is more dominant but mixed with fear in *fearful hope*. It provides a firmer foundation for resilience because of a hopeful outlook; however, it is not impenetrable to doubt. Optimism in *fearful hope* tends to be more resilient in the sense that the dominant force is hope. Although people are aware of the negatives, they tend to focus on the positive outcomes.[43] This kind of optimism balances them out, so that while taking risks, they do not lose their confidence amidst the fearful notion. Here, in *fearful hope*, optimism often acts as an inspiration for action. The hopeful view encourages people to pursue their goals or face the challenge despite having the fears. It is only with the hope of things getting better that forces the emotional and psychological muscles to work through the hoops, and the apprehension lingers on as an undeletable note to be watchful and prepared.

Long-Term Psychological Effects of Living with *Hopeful Fear* or *Fearful Hope*

The long-term psychological effects of dwelling in *hopeful fear* or *fearful hope* vary naturally with how well the person manages the struggle between

41 Fredrickson, *Positivity*, 122–124.

42 Lazarus, *Emotion and Adaption*, 292–294.

43 Snyder, *The Psychology of Hope*, 123–126.

the two conflicting emotions. Chronic stress and anxiety can result from both types of states if not managed appropriately, but the states can also foster resilience and adaptability, developed as hope grows and fear is managed. Emotional exhaustion may become a by-product of the constant balancing between fear and hope.[44] Such a long process of fear management may drain the individual, making him/her suffer from burnout or irritation even further when he is assailed by future challenges.

If fear dominates, then there is a potential for chronic anxiety because people can never fully trust in hopeful outcomes.[45] Persistent worst-case scenarios may deteriorate mental health and result in conditions such as generalised anxiety disorder or panic attacks. When hope is repeatedly smashed by fear, negative outcomes, and the opposite of what is supposed to happen, then a person becomes discouraged or even eventually loses his/her optimism. As such, the implications result in helplessness and depression since they now lose hope about positive change. Indeed, if fear is kept at bay and there's always hope more than fear, these people may move toward emotional resilience.[46]

Learning with *hopeful fear* or *fearful hope* may teach individuals the skills of coping with uncertainty, fluidity, and changing circumstances. It teaches them to be optimistic in adversity. Possessors of *hopeful fear* or *fearful hope* may actually find a way to reach a type of realistic optimism. They remain hopeful about the future, despite being aware of the enormous challenges and risks that may lie ahead. Such an equilibrated attitude can also create trust, perseverance, and emotional strength. In this connection, a life of *hopeful fear* or *fearful hope* is one particular psychological environment in which optimism must be kept in balance with caution. Both states are charged with tension and fear, but it is hope which becomes the most essential means of resistance against utter despondency. Should fear triumph, these psycho-emotional states might lead to chronic anxiety, emotional depletion, even depression.[47]

Conclusion

As we move forward, it is quite interesting to note how the play of *hopeful fear* and *fearful hope* strikes at a nuanced balance regarding how these two might coexist and are formulated into human experiences, especially when placed in uncertain contexts. The paper argues that fear cannot serve as an immobilising force, but rather becomes a motivation for preparation, even

44 Lazarus, *Emotion and Adaption*, 292–294.

45 Fredrickson, *Positivity*, 113–117.

46 Snyder, *The Psychology of Hope*, 117–119.

47 Marcel, *Homo Viator*, 32–34.

as hope—whetted by such uncertainty—is a way to be more resilient to uncertainties in life. Rather than simple opposites, hope and fear reside in an interwoven complex of forces that shape our reactions to uncertainty and challenge our perception of existence.

Exploring the concepts of *hopeful fear* and *fearful hope* not only gives us essential insights into research that is interdisciplinary, drawing from psychology, philosophy, and even neuroscience, but also tells how individuals work within those extremes, using different strategies to acquire some balance and resilience. We are provoked to think about how these dual realities of human experience affect our lives as we continue to examine the source, psychological implications, and existential meaning of hope and fear. Where fear constricts perception and produces a paralysing inertia that causes one not to act, hope expands awareness, fosters innovative thinking, and presents several lines of approach to achieving positive results.

Hence, what matters is learning to live with extreme emotions and a balanced and realistic life.

10

The Neurobiology of Hope and the Neuroethical Challenges

Augustine Pamplany

Abstract

Recent advancements in neurobiology reveal that hope, as an emotional and cognitive mechanism, is rooted in specific neural circuits within the brain, including the medial orbitofrontal cortex (mOFC), supplementary motor area (SMA), prefrontal cortex (PFC), striatum, medial prefrontal cortex (MPFC), and dorsal raphe nucleus (DRN). These brain regions are intricately involved in reward processing, emotional regulation, and the execution of goal-directed actions. A combination of brain chemistry, structural abnormalities, and functional disruptions in key regions can challenge an individual's ability to feel hopeful. While hope is related to future mindedness and optimism, neurologically speaking, hope is not identical to them. The neurology of hope has far-reaching implications for a broader understanding of love and sex. Current findings on the neurology of hope raise ethical issues related to mental well-being, justice, autonomy and moral agency.

Keywords: *Future-mindedness, Hope, Neurobiology, Neuroethics, Optimism.*

Introduction

Hope, a fundamental human experience, plays a critical role in our ability to set goals, maintain motivation, and make decisions. It serves as an emotional and cognitive mechanism that not only supports resilience in the face of adversity but also fosters a sense of well-being. While hope is often considered an abstract concept, recent advances in neurobiology reveal that it is grounded in specific neural circuits. Various brain regions, including the medial orbitofrontal cortex (mOFC), supplementary motor area (SMA), prefrontal cortex (PFC), striatum, medial prefrontal cortex (MPFC), and the dorsal raphe nucleus (DRN), have been found to play a role in fostering hope. These areas are intricately involved in motivation, decision-making, reward-related processing, and even complex motor programming. By understanding how these regions work together to promote hopeful thinking, we gain insight into the biological underpinnings of one of humanity's most essential emotional resources. Having discussed the neurological roots of hope and the neural impediment to being hopeful, this paper moves on to distinguish between hope and optimism from a psychological and existential point of view and spell out some neuroethical implications of the neurological approaches to hope.

1. Neurological Grounds of Hope

Hope is increasingly recognised as a psychological state grounded in specific neurological processes. Traditionally viewed as a philosophical or theological virtue, hope is now also understood as a biologically mediated condition that arises from the coordinated activity of several brain structures. These neural substrates of hope underlie an individual's capacity to simulate future rewards, sustain motivation, regulate emotion, and convert desire into purposeful action. Advances in neuroimaging and neuropsychology have enabled researchers to isolate the regions most implicated in hopeful cognition, such as the medial orbitofrontal cortex (mOFC), the supplementary motor area (SMA), the prefrontal cortex (PFC), the striatum, the medial prefrontal cortex (MPFC), and the dorsal raphe nucleus (DRN).

The medial orbitofrontal cortex (mOFC), situated in the frontal lobe, plays a central role in reward processing, decision-making, and goal-directed behaviour. These functions are crucial for sustaining hope, which often involves anticipating positive future outcomes. The mOFC enables individuals to simulate desired future scenarios and links them with feelings of reward, thereby reinforcing the motivational aspect of hope. It is also involved in evaluating the emotional value of different choices and weighing risks and rewards, making it essential for determining whether a goal is

worth pursuing.[1] By supporting these evaluative processes, the mOFC helps individuals assess the viability and desirability of their aspirations. Importantly, the mOFC is not limited to processing external rewards such as food or money; it also evaluates abstract or long-term rewards, including personal achievements.[2] This capacity allows hopeful individuals to remain motivated even during periods of adversity by drawing strength from envisioned success.

Closely related to this function is the supplementary motor area (SMA), located in the dorsomedial frontal cortex. Though traditionally associated with planning and executing voluntary movements, the SMA also contributes to mental preparation for goal-oriented action.[3] When individuals engage in hopeful thinking, they often simulate the steps required to attain future goals. This involves more than abstract reflection—it entails a form of cognitive rehearsal that the SMA helps structure.[4] For example, someone preparing for a marathon or job interview mentally rehearses a sequence of steps, and the SMA integrates these plans with the motor systems necessary for action. In this way, the SMA helps bridge the gap between hope as a mental state and hope as actionable resolve.

The prefrontal cortex (PFC) is also a major hub in the neural network of hope. As one of the most evolutionarily advanced brain regions, the PFC governs higher-order cognition, including long-term planning, problem-solving, self-regulation, and sustained attention. Hope often involves long-term goals that require effort and delayed gratification.[5] The PFC supports this by maintaining focus, regulating distractions, and organising sequential behaviours toward achieving a desired outcome. It also modulates emotional responses to failure or delay, allowing individuals to remain optimistic when faced with setbacks.[6] Additionally, the PFC is essential for adaptive

1 Morten L. Kringelbach, "The Human Orbitofrontal Cortex: Linking Reward to Hedonic Experience," *Nature Reviews Neuroscience* 6, no. 9 (2005): 691–702.

2 Edmund T. Rolls, "The Orbitofrontal Cortex and Reward," *Cerebral Cortex* 10, no. 3 (2000): 284–294.

3 Jun Tanji and Eiji Hoshi, "Role of the Supplementary Motor Area and Pre-SMA in Planning and Executing Actions," *Current Opinion in Neurobiology* 11, no. 6 (2001): 685–690.

4 Keisuke Shima and Jun Tanji, "Both Supplementary and Presupplementary Motor Areas Are Crucial for the Temporal Organization of Multiple Movements," *Journal of Neurophysiology* 80, no. 6 (1998): 3247–3260.

5 Earl K. Miller and Jonathan D. Cohen, "An Integrative Theory of Prefrontal Cortex Function," *Annual Review of Neuroscience* 24, no. 1 (2001): 167–202.

6 Kevin N. Ochsner and James J. Gross, "Cognitive Emotion Regulation: Insights from Social Cognitive and Affective Neuroscience," *Current Directions in Psychological Science* 17, no. 2 (2008): 153–158.

problem-solving, which enables individuals to overcome obstacles on the path to their goals. People with strong PFC activation are more likely to see challenges as temporary, whereas those with PFC impairments may experience helplessness or cognitive rigidity.[7]

Another vital structure is the striatum, composed of the dorsal and ventral striatum, including the nucleus accumbens. This subcortical structure is central to the brain's reward circuitry and is activated during the anticipation of positive outcomes.[8] Activation of the striatum during hopeful thinking reflects not just a passive emotional state, but an active pursuit of goals. It helps translate the expectation of reward into goal-oriented behaviour, reinforcing the association between effort and outcome.[9] For example, an individual hoping for professional advancement may work harder and seek opportunities due to striatal activation that maintains motivational momentum. Moreover, the striatum supports a sense of agency and control, both of which are foundational to the hopeful mindset.[10]

The medial prefrontal cortex (MPFC) is instrumental in emotional regulation, self-referential thinking, and social cognition—all of which are necessary for maintaining hope in the face of adversity. The MPFC enables individuals to balance negative and positive affect, enhancing the ability to stay optimistic when facing challenges.[11] It allows for a selective focus on possible successes while minimising emotional fixation on potential failures. This emotional regulation fosters resilience, an essential quality for hopeful individuals.[12] Additionally, the MPFC helps individuals reflect on their own role in shaping the future. By enabling self-referential thought, the MPFC supports the belief that one's own actions can make a difference, reinforcing the agency component of hope.[13]

7 C. R. Snyder et.al., "Hope Theory: A Member of the Positive Psychology Family," *Handbook of Positive Psychology*, ed. C. R. Snyder and Shane J. Lopez (New York: Oxford University Press, 2002), 257–276.

8 Mauricio R. Delgado, "Reward-Related Responses in the Human Striatum," *Annals of the New York Academy of Sciences* 1104, no. 1 (2007): 70–88.

9 Brian Knutson et al., "Anticipation of Increasing Monetary Reward Selectively Recruits Nucleus Accumbens," *Journal of Neuroscience* 21, no. 16 (2001): RC159.

10 Albert Bandura, *Self-Efficacy: The Exercise of Control* (New York: W. H. Freeman, 1997).

11 Arnaud D'Argembeau et.al., "The Role of the MPFC in Personal Goal Processing," *Social Cognitive and Affective Neuroscience* 5, no. 3 (2010): 305–313.

12 Naomi I. Eisenberger et al., "Neural Pathways to Resilience: Insights from Functional Neuroimaging," *Biological Psychiatry* 64, no. 4 (2008): 307–315.

13 Georg Northoff et al., "Self-Referential Processing in Our Brain—A Meta-Analysis of Imaging Studies on the Self," *NeuroImage* 31, no. 1 (2006): 440–457.

Finally, the dorsal raphe nucleus (DRN), located in the brainstem, serves as a principal source of serotonin in the brain. Serotonin plays a key role in modulating mood, anxiety, and stress response.[14] The DRN helps maintain a stable emotional environment by regulating serotonin levels, thereby supporting the emotional tone necessary for sustaining hope. When serotonin levels are optimal, individuals are more capable of imagining and working toward positive outcomes. The DRN also helps reduce the intensity of negative emotions such as fear or despair, which often undercut hope.[15] Additionally, during stressful situations, the DRN moderates the release of serotonin to buffer the brain against excessive emotional reactivity, allowing individuals to remain focused on long-term goals.[16]

These interconnected brain structures form a complex neural architecture that supports the cognitive, emotional, and motivational aspects of hope. The mOFC links goals to reward; the SMA turns thoughts into plans for action; the PFC sustains long-term focus and regulates emotion; the striatum connects desire to motivation; the MPFC manages affect and self-perception; and the DRN supports mood stabilisation. Together, they render hope not merely an abstract aspiration, but a biologically supported capacity essential for human flourishing.

2. Neurological Challenges to Being Hopeful and Optimistic

While hope and optimism are powerful psychological states that promote well-being, resilience, and motivation, certain neurological factors can make it difficult for some individuals to maintain these positive outlooks. A combination of brain chemistry, structural abnormalities, and functional disruptions in key regions can challenge an individual's ability to feel hopeful. These challenges are often seen in mental health disorders such as depression, anxiety, and Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD), where the ability to sustain positive thinking is significantly impaired.

2.1. Dysfunction in the Prefrontal Cortex (PFC)

The prefrontal cortex (PFC) is crucial for goal setting, decision-making, and regulating emotions—key components in fostering hope and optimism. Dysfunction in the PFC can lead to difficulties in maintaining a future-

14 Christopher A. Lowry et al., "Modulation of Anxiety Circuits by Serotonin: Implications for Psychopathology," *Current Topics in Behavioural Neurosciences* 21 (2015): 87–112.

15 Peter Dayan and Quentin J. M. Huys. "Serotonin in Affective Control," *Annual Review of Neuroscience* 32 (2009): 95–126.

16 Francis Chaouloff et.al., "Serotonin and Stress," *Neuro psycho pharmacology* 21, no. 2 (1999): 28S–32S.

oriented, goal-driven mindset.[17] For example, individuals with depression often exhibit hypoactivity in the PFC, which can impair their ability to focus on long-term goals or positive future outcomes. This can make it difficult for them to feel hopeful or optimistic, as their brain struggles to sustain attention on constructive plans and possibilities.

The PFC plays a role in regulating emotions and overriding negative thought patterns. When the PFC is underactive or impaired, negative emotions—such as hopelessness or despair—can dominate, making it harder for individuals to adopt an optimistic outlook. This emotional dysregulation often leads to rumination, where people become stuck in cycles of negative thinking, further eroding hope.

2.2. Imbalances in Neurotransmitters: Serotonin and Dopamine

Neurotransmitter imbalances, particularly involving serotonin and dopamine, are significant contributors to challenges in maintaining hope and optimism. Serotonin is a key neurotransmitter that helps regulate mood, and low levels are commonly associated with depression and anxiety.[18] In these states, the ability to sustain positive emotional states is compromised, leading to feelings of pessimism, helplessness, and a general lack of hope.

Dopamine, on the other hand, is closely linked to reward, motivation, and pleasure. It plays a critical role in reinforcing behaviours that lead to positive outcomes, which in turn support hope and optimism. When dopamine levels are low, as in conditions like depression, individuals may find it difficult to feel motivated to pursue goals or to anticipate positive outcomes, which can undermine their sense of hope. Without the reward signals that dopamine provides, it becomes harder to envision a positive future or to stay motivated in the pursuit of goals.

2.3. Hyperactivity in the Amygdala

The amygdala is the brain's emotional processing centre and is particularly responsive to fear and threat. In individuals with anxiety disorders or PTSD, the amygdala is often hyperactive, which leads to an exaggerated focus on potential threats and negative outcomes. This can severely limit one's ability to remain hopeful or optimistic because the brain is constantly signalling danger or anticipating worst-case scenarios. Hyperactive amygdala function

17 Y. Zhou & T. Kuo, "Dysfunction of the Prefrontal Cortex in Depression and Anxiety: A Neurocognitive Perspective," *Frontiers in Human Neuroscience* 14 (2020): 162.

18 M. Pessiglione, B. Seymour, G. Flandin, R. J. Dolan and C. D. Frith, "Dopamine-Dependent Prediction Errors Underpin Reward-Seeking Behaviour in Humans," *Nature* 442, no. 7106 (2006): 1042–1045.

can create a mental environment dominated by fear, worry, and negativity, crowding out the mental space needed for hopeful or optimistic thinking.[19]

2.4. Impaired Connectivity Between Brain Regions

The brain's ability to foster hope and optimism depends on smooth communication between various regions, particularly between the prefrontal cortex, amygdala, and limbic system. When these regions are poorly connected or communication between them is disrupted, it becomes more difficult for the brain to regulate emotions and maintain positive thinking. For example, in depression and PTSD, there is often reduced connectivity between the PFC and the amygdala, which weakens the PFC's ability to downregulate negative emotions and promote more balanced, hopeful thinking.[20]

2.5. Chronic Stress and Cortisol Levels

Chronic stress can also affect the brain's ability to sustain hope and optimism. When the body is exposed to prolonged stress, cortisol levels remain elevated, which can damage brain structures such as the hippocampus and impair cognitive functions. The hippocampus is involved in memory and in contextualising emotions, and its damage can lead to difficulty recalling positive experiences or envisioning a hopeful future. Elevated cortisol can also reduce PFC functioning, leading to impaired emotional regulation and goal-setting abilities.

3. Hope, Future Mindedness and Optimism

Humans have the unique ability to envision and plan for the future—highlighting both its evolutionary roots and its contemporary importance. Humans are not alone in forward planning; certain animals, such as ravens and orangutans, demonstrate anticipatory behaviours by "setting aside tools for later."[21] 1 However, the human capacity for abstract anticipation and deliberate preparation is far more sophisticated and socially transformative.

19 E. A. Phelps and J. E. LeDoux, "Contribution of the Amygdala to Emotion Processing: The Role of the Amygdala in Fear and Anxiety," *Annual Review of Psychology* 56, no. 1 (2005): 271–299; S. L. Rauch and L. M. Shin, "Functional Neuroimaging of the Amygdala in PTSD," *Journal of Traumatic Stress* 10 no. 4 (1997): 635–643.

20 G. Deshpande and V. Sinha, "Altered Resting State Connectivity of the Amygdala in Posttraumatic Stress Disorder," *Journal of Affective Disorders* 147, nos.1–3 (2013): 179–184; D. S. Mennin and R. G. Heimberg, "Emotion Regulation and the Role of the Prefrontal Cortex in Anxiety Disorders," *Psychological Science* 20, no. 6 (2009): 804–809.

21 John Templeton Foundation, "Future Mindedness," *Discoveries: Templeton Foundation*, April 3, 2023, https://www.templeton.org/discoveries/future-mindedness, accessed 29 June 2025.

"Futuremindedness" is presented as a mindset that prioritises long-range goals over immediate gratification or presentoriented impulses. While the future is inherently uncertain, cultivating an orientation toward longterm outcomes enables societies - and individuals - to act in ways that benefit both present and future generations.

One of the most urgent challenges identified is selfsabotage—the tendency to undermine one's own future wellbeing through impulsive or negative behaviours. This concept extends beyond individuals to society at large, where "shorttermism" in decisionmaking - whether in consumer habits, environmental policy, or governance—can yield immediate gains at the cost of enduring harm.[22]

Psychological studies have shown that individuals can be trained to see their behaviours and decisions through the lens of longterm consequences rather than immediate rewards. These studies suggest that institutions can build structures—such as incentive systems and educational curricula—that reward forward thinking and discourage shortsighted choices. The study advocates storytelling as an important tool in future mindedness. Narratives that emphasise our legacy to future generations help frame our decisions as part of a larger, intergenerational tapestry.

Michael Milona's white paper, *Hope and Optimism*, was commissioned by the John Templeton Foundation as part of a three-year research initiative exploring the philosophical and psychological dimensions of these two closely related yet distinct virtues.[23] Optimism is characterised by Milona as a disposition to expect good outcomes. It is often discussed in two forms: a general trait, known as dispositional optimism, and a more context-specific form that pertains to particular goals or outcomes. Optimism, Milona explains, plays a beneficial role in increasing motivation, improving health outcomes, and enhancing resilience. However, optimism can also become counterproductive if it results in unrealistic expectations or underestimation of risks. It may cause individuals to overlook challenges, fail to prepare adequately for negative outcomes, or fall into complacency. As Milona notes, "Optimism is not always rational, and its benefits depend on how well it is grounded in one's reality."[24]

Hope, in contrast to optimism, is not merely an expectation of good outcomes but a more complex state that involves desire, belief in possibility,

22 John Templeton Foundation, "FutureMindedness," *Discoveries: Templeton Foundation*, April 3, 2023, https://www.templeton.org/discoveries/future-mindedness, accessed 29 June 2025.

23 Milona Michael, *Hope and Optimism*, https://www.templeton.org/wp-content/uploads/2020/10/JTF-Hope-Optimism.pdf, accessed 29 June 2025.

24 Michael, *Hope and Optimism,* https://www.templeton.org/wp-content/uploads/2020/10/JTF-Hope-Optimism.pdf, accessed 29 June 2025.

and often a motivational or emotional ingredient. Milona aligns with what is called the "standard account" of hope, in which hope involves desiring a certain outcome while believing that the outcome is possible, though not certain. Importantly, hope differs from mere wishing because it typically entails an engagement with reality, including emotional investment and openness to action.

Milona emphasises that while hope and optimism often occur together, they are conceptually and functionally distinct. Optimism involves an expectation that things will turn out well, often irrespective of desire. Hope, however, is always desire-laden and rooted in emotional vulnerability. It allows for persistence even when the odds are slim, offering a source of resilience that does not rely on strong beliefs in favourable outcomes. Thus, while optimism can motivate under certainty or likelihood, hope sustains engagement in uncertainty and adversity.

It is opined that both optimism and hope carry potential risks. Excessive optimism may lead to disillusionment, poor planning, or denial of reality. Likewise, hope can sometimes become wishful thinking if it is disconnected from action or realistic possibility. Milona warns that unchecked hope can morph into a passive state, in which people wait for change without taking meaningful steps toward it. Nevertheless, he maintains that hope, when properly understood and cultivated, is a rational and morally significant virtue.

Milona explores the value of optimism and hope across several domains of life. In healthcare, optimism has been shown to improve coping strategies and support recovery, while hope enhances treatment adherence and psychological resilience. In education, both virtues support academic success and personal development, especially among students facing significant barriers. Politically, hope inspires civic engagement and long-term commitment to social justice, even when outcomes are uncertain. In religious contexts, especially within Christianity, hope often takes on a theological character, entailing trust in divine promise and ultimate redemption despite present suffering.

Milona identifies different philosophical forms of hope. Christian hope, he notes, is grounded in eschatological promise and theological faith. It entails confident expectation of a future fulfilled by divine agency, even when that future appears implausible by human standards. Pragmatist hope, by contrast—is secular and active—involves a dynamic, participatory stance toward the future, one that acknowledges hardship while remaining committed to moral and social ideals. Milona quotes Cornel West, who describes hope as "wrestling with despair, not yielding to it," highlighting the tenacity and courage embedded in this virtue.

Milona concludes that a better understanding of hope and optimism requires us to separate their conceptual elements and consider their real-world applications. Optimism offers expectancy and motivation but is susceptible to distortion. Hope, more emotionally nuanced, provides continuity and purpose even in the absence of favourable expectations. The responsible cultivation of each virtue requires careful self-reflection, engagement with reality, and commitment to action. Ultimately, Milona argues that the moral and psychological significance of hope makes it a necessary virtue for both personal and collective flourishing.

4. Neurobiology of Hope and Neuroethics

In this section we shall briefly touch upon some of the interdisciplinary issues related to the neurology of hope, especially those related to ethics. Neurology of hope has far-reaching implications for a broader understanding of love, sex, marriage, violence, etc. Current investigations into the neurological enhancement of hope raise further ethical issues.

The neurobiology of hope is intricately linked to various aspects of human behaviour and emotion, including love, sex, and violence.[25] Love, often characterised by deep emotional connections and bonds, is influenced by the neurobiology of hope. Neurotransmitters such as oxytocin and dopamine, which are associated with feelings of affection and pleasure, play a crucial role in the experience of love. When individuals feel hopeful about their romantic relationships—believing in the potential for growth, intimacy, and shared futures—they activate brain regions linked to motivation and reward, such as the medial orbitofrontal cortex and the striatum.

Hope also plays a significant role in sexual relationships and experiences. A hopeful outlook can foster a sense of security, trust, and intimacy between partners, making sexual experiences more fulfilling. The brain's reward system, particularly the striatum, becomes activated during sexual arousal and satisfaction, reinforcing the emotional and physical connection between partners.[26] Researchers have found that when individuals have hopeful expectations about their sexual experiences, they are more likely to engage openly and authentically, leading to enhanced intimacy and satisfaction. Moreover, hope can influence sexual health and behaviour.

While hope is generally associated with positive outcomes, its absence or distortion can contribute to violent behaviours. When individuals

25 Fred Nour, *True Love: How to Use Science to Understand Love* (New York: The Experiment, 2017).

26 S. D. Cohen and S. R. Ginsberg, "The Neuroscience of Love and Lust: Understanding the Interplay Between Sexuality and the Brain," *The Journal of Sexual Medicine* 17, no. 7 (2020): 1352–1364. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jsxm.2020.04.001, accessed 29 June 2025.

experience hopelessness—particularly in contexts of poverty, abuse, or societal marginalisation, they may resort to violence as a means of expressing frustration or seeking control. The amygdala may become hyperactive in individuals experiencing hopelessness, leading to heightened emotional responses and impulsivity.[27] Studies have found that when hope is absent, individuals may adopt a defeatist attitude, perceiving violence as the only avenue for achieving their goals or expressing their grievances.[28] In contrast, fostering hope within communities—through access to education, social support, and mental health resources—can act as a protective factor against violence, encouraging individuals to pursue constructive solutions to their challenges rather than resorting to aggression.

The intersection of neurology and hope opens new philosophical and ethical frontiers, especially within the domains of moral theology, neuroethics, and mental health care. As neuroscience progresses in mapping the cognitive and affective dimensions of hope, the implications of manipulating this emotion therapeutically merit careful reflection. In particular, ethical tensions emerge around the use of pharmacological and neuromodulatory interventions to enhance hope, especially in individuals who may not present with clinical symptoms of hopelessness. Simultaneously, the socio-political implications of unequal access to such interventions necessitate broader discussions concerning justice and vulnerability in the distribution of care. The dual potential of hope to serve as a vehicle for human flourishing and as a locus of ethical contention illustrates the complexity of translating neuroscientific knowledge into practice.

The application of such knowledge raises profound ethical questions. Should hope be pharmacologically enhanced or neurostimulated in therapeutic contexts, particularly when patients do not exhibit pathological despair? For instance, deep brain stimulation (DBS) and transcranial magnetic stimulation (TMS) have shown efficacy in treating major depressive disorder by modulating dysfunctional neural circuits.[29] The incidental effect of increased hope in such patients is often welcome. However, the deliberate aim to enhance hope through these techniques—especially when no clinical disorder is present—veers into the contentious territory of human enhancement. Philosophers and ethicists caution that

27 R. J. Davidson and B. S. McEwen, "Social Influences on Neuroplasticity: Stress and Recovery," *Nature Neuroscience* 15, no. 5 (2012): 689–695, https://doi.org/10.1038/nn.3096, accessed 29 June 2025.

28 B. A. van der Kolk, *The Body Keeps the Score: Brain, Mind, and Body in the Healing of Trauma* (New York: Viking, 2014).

29 Erik Parens, "Authenticity and Ambivalence: Toward Understanding the Enhancement Debate," *The Hastings Center Report* 35, no. 3 (2005): 34–41.

such interventions may risk undermining patient autonomy by fostering dependency on artificial means of emotional regulation.[30]

Moreover, the distinction between therapeutic restoration and enhancement is not always clear-cut. While some argue that enhancing hope in the absence of illness contributes to overall well-being and human flourishing, others contend that doing so might distort an individual's authentic response to existential challenges. Hope, when artificially induced, may lack the grounding in realistic appraisal or moral commitment traditionally associated with its virtue-based understanding in moral theology. In Christian thought, for instance, hope is more than mere optimism; it is a theological virtue oriented toward ultimate ends, involving trust in divine providence and perseverance in moral striving.[31] Thus, manipulations of neurochemical or neuroelectrical states to generate hope may be seen as undermining the moral integrity of human experience.

These concerns become even more pressing when considering vulnerable or marginalised populations. Access to advanced neurotechnologies is often stratified along socio-economic lines, leading to a widening of existing health disparities. In many societies, marginalised groups already face structural barriers to adequate mental health care, including limited insurance coverage, geographical inaccessibility, and stigma.[32] If interventions to enhance hope become commodified or restricted to affluent populations, the therapeutic promise of neuroscience risks reinforcing patterns of exclusion. The ideal of equitable care demands that neuroethical frameworks account for both access and agency in the distribution of novel treatments.

Furthermore, the therapeutic deployment of hope enhancement among vulnerable populations—such as incarcerated individuals, psychiatric patients under guardianship, or those in palliative care—raises questions about coercion and consent. Could such interventions be used to placate rather than empower, or to control rather than heal?[33] While instilling hope may have beneficial outcomes in terms of compliance, social stability, or psychological peace, the instrumentalisation of hope for institutional ends undermines its ethical legitimacy. In such cases, hope becomes a tool of biopolitical management rather than a facilitator of personal growth and moral autonomy.

30 Nicholas Agar, *Humanity's End: Why We Should Reject Radical Enhancement* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2010), 112–125.

31 Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, II–II, q. 17, a. 1–5.

32 Jonathan Metzl and Helena Hansen, "Structural Competency: Theorizing a New Medical Engagement with Stigma and Inequality," *Social Science & Medicine* 103 (2014): 126–33.

33 Ilina Singh and Wouter V. Vries, "Bioethics and Neuroethics: Unmet Promises and New Horizons," *Cambridge Quarterly of Healthcare Ethics* 23, no. 1 (2014): 36–47.

At the same time, the potential of neuroscience to illuminate the biological substrates of hope should not be dismissed outright. Understanding how neural pathways support hope can inform the development of more compassionate and effective treatments for mental illness, especially for conditions like depression, post-traumatic stress disorder, and addiction, where hopelessness is both a symptom and a barrier to recovery. In this respect, neuroscience contributes to the broader moral imperative of alleviating suffering and restoring dignity to the sick.[34] However, these scientific gains must be integrated within ethical frameworks that prioritise the holistic well-being of the patient, including their spiritual, emotional, and socio-political dimensions.

A critical ethical stance thus demands balance. On the one hand, we must recognise the capacity of neurotechnologies to foster hope as a salutary affective state, essential for motivation, resilience, and recovery. On the other, we must guard against the reduction of hope to mere neurochemical states subject to external control. Ethical neuroenhancement must resist both the over-mechanisation of normal emotional processes and the commodification of existential goods. As the field of neuroethics continues to evolve, a richer dialogue between science, philosophy, and theology will be necessary to preserve the depth and dignity of the human experience.

Conclusion

This paper has attempted to highlight the neurobiology of hope. It is deeply rooted in the brain's complex neural circuitry. The medial orbitofrontal cortex, supplementary motor area, prefrontal cortex, striatum, medial prefrontal cortex, and dorsal raphe nucleus work together to create the emotional and cognitive conditions necessary for hope. Understanding the neurobiology of hope reveals how essential this emotional state is to human flourishing, offering insights into how we can nurture hope to promote resilience and personal growth. The paper also explored to highlight some significant implications the neurology of hope for our understanding of love and sexuality. Recent research on hope's neural mechanisms raises ethical considerations surrounding personal autonomy, and moral agency. These findings invite deeper exploration into how hope influences behaviour and interpersonal relationships, prompting important discussions about its role in shaping human experiences and decisions.

34 William Breitbart, "Reframing Hope: Meaning-Centered Care for Patients Near the End of Life," *Journal of Palliative Medicine* 8, no. 5 (2005): 982–87.

The Freedom of Forgiveness
A Transcendental Invitation

Keith D'Souza

Abstract

Forgiveness seems to be more of a spiritual or religious phenomenon rather than one deserving of philosophical consideration. It features as a religious or spiritual mandate in Christianity in particular, but also in some form or other in numerous other religious traditions. However, numerous philosophers have attempted to analyse the contours of forgiveness, the conditions for the same, and the obstacles which prevent its realisation.

The article argues for the existential freedom which the attitude and the act of forgiveness bring about in persons and communities. There are three primary claims made in the article. Firstly, that forgiveness may be best considered as an existential invitation towards wellness, rather than a divine mandate or command. Secondly, that this invitation is offered to all humans—something intrinsic to human nature—and in this sense may be considered to be "transcendental," or a phenomenon which transcends particular persons or communities. In this regard, forgiveness may be considered to be a subset or aspect of one of the three primary transcendentals, namely, the "good"—the others being

the "true" and the "beautiful." Thirdly, that the attitude and act of forgiveness bring about a heightened sense of existential and affective freedom—to both, the agent or community which forgives, and the agent or community which is forgiven. In the first case, the freedom comes from engaging in or offering some form of the gift of amnesty. When received, forgiveness takes on the form of a debt which has been released. Both the giving of this gift and its reception bring about a heightened sense of existential freedom in the lives of the persons and communities involved.

Keywords: *Amnesty, Forgiveness, Freedom, Gift, Invitation, Recollection Memory, Reconciliation, Repetition Memory, Transcendental, Wound.*

Introduction

Human beings are blessed with the ability to socially co-create their lives and their environments. Human societies are thus social constructions, even though habit, custom, and tradition may give the impression that social relations are something set or "given"—either by human predisposition—some form of natural law—or divine command.

This freedom to co-create lives is something that sets humans apart from other animated life forms. However, this freedom has its own challenges. One of the biggest such challenges is the ability to live together harmoniously with other humans—both within and outside the various communities and sub-communities humans inhabit, physically or virtually. The scriptures of various religious traditions speak of initial ruptures in human relationships, which are presented as reasons why we face similar and contemporaneous forms of alienation.

However, scriptural, literary, legal, and socio-political texts and practices down the centuries have offered remedies to these social ruptures and forms of alienation. One of the remedies is the possibility and ability of persons and communities to engage in various forms of amnesty, in order to ameliorate abiding inter-personal and social tensions. One of these forms of amnesty is forgiveness—in simple terms, the phenomenon of setting aside just and even compensation for a wrongdoing, with a view to ushering in greater personal or common wellbeing.

This article explores the nature of forgiveness, first as an incipient personal and existential invitation, then—by extension—as a transcendental invitation, common to all persons and communities. Furthermore, it highlights aspects of affective freedom which result from decisions and

actions related to forgiveness. However, each of these terms (invitation, transcendental, freedom, and forgiveness itself) are not to be understood in a reified or essentialised manner. In fact, the intensity, duration, and frequency associated with each of these terms and their relative or resultant manifestation in human consciousness and relations vary from person to person and community to community. A diversity of contextual and temporal circumstances too provides significant nuances as to how these aspects of human consciousness and relations are experienced.

Instead of binary differentiations (e.g., forgiveness or the lack of it), what is often the case are experiences which may range from one extreme (unforgiveness) to the other (total or comprehensive forgiving). Furthermore, the quality of forgiveness, or its lack, may be differentiated—and continually developing—in the lives of individuals and communities, based on various circumstances. Neither "freedom" nor "forgiveness" are either/or experiences. Instead, they are often ongoing personal and social commitments or projects, which may continue to be modified—diminished or enhanced—over time, and in differing contexts.

1. Forgiveness as Existential Invitation

Primary social goods include cultural recognition, economic redistribution, and political representation. Multiple social contract theories—especially during the "modern age"—have been offered as templates to ensure the smooth realisation of these ideals. These theories have often been in sync with contemporaneous socio-political developments—witnessing the transition during modernity from monarchy to constitutional democracies.

Today, the world experiences a chequered political landscape, ranging from dictatorships in various degrees and forms to democracies in various degrees and forms. Monarchies have become, for the most part nominal. However, whatever the professed or stylised forms of public and political organisation, the human journey continues to be rife with gross violations of the realisation of these primary goods—by individuals, organised communities, and political, economic, and cultural leaders who have the power to make a difference. As a result, social fissures and conflicts take place within and between societies. Much of mythology, and oral and written history, as well as communitarian and personal narratives, provide testimony to the various such tensions which seem part of the human condition—as humans through time have faulted in some way or the other in terms of the provision for these aspects of inter-personal wellbeing and the common good.

Opposite—though not equal or proportionate—social forces or movements have been inspired to address and ease the tensions which result from such fissures or ruptures. The greater the intensity and frequency

of such disruptions, the more the efforts which need to be invested in providing a remedy to the wounds inflicted on personal and communitarian consciousnesses. One of the aspects of a "remedy to the wounds inflicted" is the phenomenon of forgiveness—other aspects may include compensation in some other manner, viz. legal, financial, material, etc. What follows are primary aspects of the phenomenon of forgiveness.

Forgiveness is primarily a gift. All humans may not spontaneously be comfortable with the existential phenomenon of gift giving and receiving. Some may engage in gift-giving primarily among an intimate circle of family, friends, and transactional associates, but not much beyond. Sometimes, gift-giving may take on forms of reciprocity—the mutuality of gift-giving—rather than generosity or benevolence. In other instances, gift-giving takes on the form of a formal statement of mutual regard, as when international dignitaries offer gifts to one another during formal visits. Forgiveness is a gift. The word "forgive" comes from the Old English *forgiefan* (to give, to grant).[1] Forgiveness is a gift which goes beyond the materiality of gift giving, and in some cases (as when one forgives another community or a person or community in the past) goes beyond the usual experience of gift-giving which is a tangible experience. In all of these cases, there is no compulsion or obligation to offer such a gift—indeed, a genuine gift speaks of the surplus or superfluity of the intention and act involved.

The gift of forgiveness goes beyond most types of formal and superficial forms of gift giving and receiving. It is far subtler, as it involves a lot more investment within the intentional realm rather than the material manifestation of gift giving. Forgiveness is typically a gift which wounded and grieved persons and communities offer to perpetrators who have inflicted specific wounds on the persons and communities concerned. Paul Ricoeur argues that there is a "vertical asymmetry inherent in the initial equation of forgiveness."[2] This is true for normal cases when forgiveness transcends the projected evenness of justice, but especially when it comes to forgiving more grievous wounds, or one's personal or collective enemies. To forgive is to "forego" or "overlook" a transactional or relational debt. The root word of "pardon" and "condone" is the Latin "donare," to give. The English word "donation" too is related to the same root word.

The gift or donation of forgiveness features prominently in the Lord's Prayer. In the Gospel of Luke, it is more spiritualised, viz. "forgive us our sins" (Lk. 11:4), as compared to the Gospel of Matthew, viz. "forgive us our debts" (Mt. 6:12). Matthew, as a tax collector, was well aware of the comprehensive notion of "debt," which included not just spiritual obligations, but also material ones. However, the gift of forgiveness goes far beyond the spiritual and material, including other significant aspects of life such as the legal, cultural, colonial, national, racial, gender-based, class-based, inter-generational, etc.

1 Robert Barnhart, ed., *Chambers Dictionary of Etymology* (New York: Chambers, 1988), 401.

2 Paul Ricoeur, *Memory, History, Forgetting*, trans. Kathleen Blamey and David Pellauer (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2004), 459.

Forgiveness is a form of the gift of amnesty. Forgiveness has to do with forfeiting the right for just or even compensation in one way or the other. It entails a form of conscious amnesty, or a pardoning or exoneration of a wound which has been inflicted unjustly. Amnesty or pardoning goes beyond the logic of justice or due recompense—and of course completely transcends the dynamics of retribution and revenge.

Forgiveness is the gift of informal amnesty. Formal amnesty is granted by juridical and political institutions—and financial institutions in the matter of debt cancellation. There are often strings attached with cases of formal amnesty. Informal amnesty, however, is granted by non-state or non-institutional agents. In keeping with the "gift" aspect of informal amnesty, it is ideally unilateral—not dependent on reciprocity. Jacques Derrida understands forgiveness in this radical and limited sense alone: "forgiveness forgives only the unforgivable. One cannot, or should not, forgive; there is only forgiveness, if there is any, where there is the unforgivable. That is to say that forgiveness must announce itself as impossibility itself. It can only be possible in doing the impossible."[3]

Forgiveness entails a conscious, productive "forgetting." Even though we may use the phrase "forgive and forget" loosely, if one really forgets the past, then it is not possible to forgive. How may one forgive what one does not remember? Forgiveness, then, does not entail the forgetting of past wounds; instead, it consciously factors in the past as part of the process of amnesty. In a powerful statement recommending the gift of forgiveness, Desmond Tutu asserts: "the invitation to forgive is not an invitation to forget. Nor is it an invitation to claim that an injury is less hurtful than it really was. Nor is it a request to paper over the fissure in a relationship, to say it's okay when it's not. It's not okay to be injured. It's not okay to be abused. It's not okay to be violated. It's not okay to be betrayed. But it is okay to forgive."[4] Ricoeur, following Freud, uses the distinction between "repetition memory" and "recollection memory" to help understand the

3 Jacques Derrida, *On Cosmopolitanism and Forgiveness*, trans. Mark Dooley and Michael Hughes (London: Routledge, 2005), 24.

4 Desmond Tutu, "An Invitation to Forgive," *The Huffington Post*, December 5, 2014, https://www.huffpost.com/entry/an-invitation-to-forgive_b_5050747, accessed 21 July 2025.

dynamics of a productive informal amnesty.[5] "Repetition memory" retains both the cognitive and affective aspects of the retention of the memory of a past wound, while "recollection memory" retains the cognitive aspect of the wound, while the affective intensity of the response to the wound gradually reduces. This is similar to the process of mourning for someone who has passed away—as time goes by, one still remembers the loss, but the pain is much less. "Recollection memory" has a far greater chance to allow therapy to materialise, as compared to "repetition memory."

Forgiveness may be unilateral or bilateral. Sometimes, gift giving is mutual, and may have mutual expectations. So also, with forgiveness—the act of forgiveness in many cases may explicitly or implicitly demand reciprocity. This is especially true if forgiveness is manifested in the public domain. However, there may be forms of forgiveness which are not only unilateral, but also not publicly or personally known to the other party involved. One may forgive without anyone else knowing this. For example, while commenting on his father's abusive behaviour towards his mother on account of his alcohol-induced violence, Bishop Desmond Tutu states, "whether he asked for forgiveness or not, and even if he refused to admit that what he had done was wrong or could not explain why he had done what he did, I would still forgive him. Why would I do such a thing? I would walk the path of forgiveness with him because I know it is the only way to heal the pain in my boyhood heart. Forgiving my father frees me."[6]

Forgiveness goes beyond reconciliation. Especially in cases of unilateral forgiveness, and in cases when the agents involved in the process of forgiveness cannot be present to each other, reconciliation may be either impossible or unnecessary. Even if the other party is actually or possibly present, reconciliation may not be considered a possible or valuable goal. It is not necessary in all cases that the one who forgives declares this publicly or even privately.

Forgiveness can be inter-personal, inter-communal, and inter-generational. The normal template of forgiveness seems to be housed within inter-personal relations. However, forgiveness is also possible between communities, even though this is far more complex than inter-personal forgiveness. Furthermore, forgiveness can also be offered to past perpetrators, both individuals and communities.[7]

5 *See* Paul Ricoeur, *Memory, History, Forgetting*, Part I, Ch. 2, where Freud's reflections on the difference between repetition and recollection are featured.

6 Desmond Tutu, "An Invitation to Forgive."

7 For a fuller discussion and evaluation of the possibilities of inter-communal forgiveness, see Pol Vandevelde, "Forgiveness in a Political Context: The Challenge and the Potential," in *Philosophy and Social Criticism* 39, no. 3 (2013): 263–276.

Forgiveness falls under the transcendental of the "good." Among the three transcendentals of the good, beautiful, and true, forgiveness is more closely linked to that of the "good." The good has to do with practical action, and is more directly linked with the realms of ethics and morality. Forgiveness fits well within these realms of inter-personal and social relations.

Forgiveness is an implicit, if not an explicit, sub-set of the good. Some cultures and religions may place more of an emphasis on forgiveness than others. This does not automatically imply that cultures or religions which stress forgiveness have in practice been forgiving within and without their communities. It may well be the case that cultures and religions in which forgiveness is implicit rather than explicit have been more forgiving in practice, without having a spiritual or ideological framework which specifically emphasises forgiveness. However, whether explicit or implicit, forgiveness is a *sine qua non* for persons and communities to live in harmony. In this sense, forgiveness may be considered to be a transcendental invitation—applying to one and all, transcending the particularities of human context—if one is to live a good life.

2. Forgiveness as Transcendental Invitation

Christianity is perhaps the religion which places the most emphasis on forgiveness, as compared to any other religion. In the Gospels, Jesus quite clearly issues several injunctions about the need to forgive, and practices what he preaches by way of a multitude of examples. The Gospels record several anecdotes, parables and encounters of Jesus with those who need forgiveness-related healing. Powerful examples of multiple types of amnesty employed by Jesus include the interaction with Zacchaeus and Matthew, both tax collectors (amnesty of corrupt trade practices), the incident of the woman caught in adultery, and the woman who washed Jesus' feet with her tears (amnesty of moral weakness), the visit to the home of Mary and Martha, and the condoning of the behaviour of Mary, who preferred listening to religious instruction rather than assume a feminine role of tending to the guests (amnesty of stereotypical gender roles), and the parable of the Good Samaritan (national amnesty towards the rival Samaritan community, overcoming typical xenophobia).

Besides these powerful scriptural instances of forgiveness, the term "forgiveness" and its derivatives feature several times in the primary liturgies or celebratory rituals of the different denominations and rites of the multitude of Christian communities which exist today. By way of example, the Catholic Liturgy of the Eucharist features a "Penitential Rite" at the very start of the service; the words of Jesus at the consecration feature the term "forgiveness of sins"; and the Lord's Prayer recited at the Eucharist features

forgiveness prominently ("forgive us our sins as we forgive those who sin against us").

While other religions may not enunciate this mandate as powerfully and repetitively in their core texts, traditions, or rituals, forgiveness is a *sine qua non* for the realisation of key goals of spiritual or religious traditions, especially those of peace, wellbeing, harmony, etc. If not explicitly, forgiveness is implicitly and necessarily mandated for the wellbeing proposed and promised by various religions.

However, the wellbeing proposed by religions is not something restricted to the religious sphere of existence. While various religions enunciate the cultural conditions which promote and enhance personal and social development, wellness is a personal and social goal which transcends the particularities of specific religions or cultures. According to Hannah Arendt, "The discoverer of the role of forgiveness in the realm of human affairs was Jesus of Nazareth."[8] However, Arendt goes on to add: "The fact that he made this discovery in a religious context and articulated it in religious language is no reason to take it any less seriously in a strictly secular sense."[9]

The impetus to forgive is foundational or fundamental to a developed or enlightened human consciousness. Even if we may concur with Hannah Arendt's sad assessment of the "banality of evil,"[10] as humans we are nevertheless invited to consider alternative scenarios. In contrast to the creation and existence of evil in our lives, we are invited to transcend our limited and limiting situations in favour of more sublime existential and social situations. The development of better socio-political systems—or at least the attempt to develop better systems—over millennia is proof that the human spirit is not content with living sub-human relational lives.

In the conclusion of a fundamental article on the metaphysics and morality of forgiveness, Keith Yandell states: "people either forgive one another or else wither as persons; they reconcile or perish."[11] I would reformulate and widen this affirmation to state that both individuals and communities need to forgive one another; else they risk diminishment or impoverishment as persons and communities. Bishop Desmond Tutu asserts: "hurting back rarely satisfies. We think it will, but it doesn't . . .

8 Hannah Arendt, *The Human Condition*, 2nd ed., intro. Margaret Canovan (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1998), 238.

9 Arendt, *The Human Condition*, 238.

10 *See* Hannah Arendt, Eichmann in Jerusalem: A Report on the Banality of Evil (New York: Viking Press, 1963).

11 Keith Yandell, "The Metaphysics and Morality of Forgiveness," in *Exploring Forgiveness*, ed. Robert Enright and Joanna North (Madison, Wisconsin: University of Wisconsin, 1998), 45.

Retaliation gives, at best, only momentary respite from our pain. The only way to experience permanent healing and peace is to forgive."[12] This is applicable for both inter-personal and inter-community healing.

Paul Ricoeur points out that "the place of forgiveness [is] at the margins of the institutions responsible for punishment . . . forgiveness can find refuge only in gestures incapable of being transformed into institutions."[13] Institutions and juridical procedures can only go to a certain extent to ensure justice—which is in any case too often an elusive goal. Besides inter-personal and inter-community injustices, there are various other more nuanced forms of social injustices, based on gender-bias, racism, colonialism, casteism, inter-generational irresponsibility (e.g., climate negligence), etc. There are various attempts to address these issues from the perspective of justice, but not too many from the perspective of forgiveness. The "Truth and Reconciliation Commission" project of South Africa and the "Truth and Justice Commission" of Mauritius are examples of addressing the issue of systemic racial discrimination (apartheid) and indentured labour (slavery) respectively, both from the point of view of justice and reconciliation. Forgiveness is a distinct yet persistent sub-text in this process, entailing a form of therapeutic amnesty.

Forgiveness, like several aspects of human wellbeing, may find more expression in specific cultures and contexts, but this does not diminish its transcendental value. When political and cultural leaders of some non-Western nations and communities assert that the issue of human rights is a Western cultural product and not something that stems from their own traditions, this is often a ploy to deflect corrective counter-cultural critique. Similarly, if forgiveness is primarily or solely associated with a particular religion or culture, this could be an excuse by other religious or cultural adherents to justify and gloss over the logic of vendetta and the reiteration of violent relationships in their own social settings. However, just as we are all transcendentally invited to be good, to become good, to be drawn by the good, etc., we are all transcendentally invited to forgive.

3. Blocks to Forgiveness

Like almost all of the terms analysed in this paper, the term "block" (or obstacle) too varies from person to person and community to community, and may further vary depending on the particular context in the lives of persons and communities.

Blocks may depend on a wide variety of factors. One of them is the gravity of the wound caused—both perceptual and objective. Another is the

12 Desmond Tutu, "An Invitation to Forgive."

13 Paul Ricoeur, *Memory, History, Forgetting*, 458.

condition of the relationship and the trust levels shared within the relationship of both the one forgiving and the one to be forgiven. The maturity—or lack of it—of the parties involved is another major factor which could constitute a block towards forgiveness. Time is often considered to be a great healer of wounds, but this in only when one is able to gradually withdraw emotionally from the effects of the wound. Otherwise, time could worsen a situation, with more rumination on the wound, and the intervention of external forces which may not want to achieve peace but instead foment disquiet and even conflict. Beyond these basic reasons, what follows is an overview of some more primary blocks to forgiveness.

If forgiveness has to do with the giving of a gift, it would be good to examine how wide gift-giving typically takes place. Usually, gift giving takes place in intimate circles, and with those for whom one has a special regard. Of course, there are also formal instances of gift-giving, which do not necessarily entail special regard or affection for the recipient. Just as one does not gift gifts to all and sundry, but mainly to those with whom one has some commitment or from whom one has something to gain, so also forgiveness may be rationed out in a circumspect manner.

The regard of the value and dynamics of justice as the normal benchmark which is meant to oversee human relations may constitute a block towards forgiveness, as the latter is most often based on the value and dynamics of mercy, which transcends the mutuality of justice. When greater regard is bestowed upon justice as the appropriate arbiter or mediational standard, what prevails is an attitude of mensuration or calculation, to examine whether evenness has been realised. Having asserted this: within the human lifeworld there are very few relational phenomena which typically manifest perfect justice. To be human is to be born and to live in a world of disproportion—of talents, material possessions, educational and professional achievements, etc. Human life is radically unjust. To create a benchmark of justice as a normal and desirable goal is to set oneself up for grief. While there may indeed be very valuable and necessary objectives and policies which uphold the value of justice—especially in cases of grave personal and physical injury—the value of mercy also needs to be given its due place in human relations.

It is said that "time heals." Freud uses the analogy of death and mourning to explain how trauma may be overcome through the passing of time. However, time could also be the problem that healing does not take place. The re-imagining and re-living of the wounded narratives of the past may not allow for healing to take place. As pointed out above, Freud—and Ricoeur following him—uses the distinction between "repetition memory" and "recollection memory" to explain why and how therapy could take place when recollection memory is more operative, rather than repetition

memory.[14] If one's memory is more like a "broken record," harping on the same wound (repetition memory), it becomes very difficult for healing to take place. "Recollection memory," on the other hand, allows the affective effect of the wound to diminish with time—while retaining the memory of the event.

"Repetition memory" is a form of cathexis, another block to forgiveness. Cathexis has to do with investing emotional energy in attaching to, or fixating upon an external object—in this case, the memory of a wound. Forgiveness is the act of releasing that object from oneself. But this can only happen when there is sufficient developmental maturity and emotional security. Holding on to a wound may have its apparent emotional and social benefits, but these are only myopic and not beneficial in the long—or even short—run.

Perhaps the biggest block to forgiveness is egotism—or in the case of a social wound, a collective sense of misguided pride. This may arise from a sense of emotional insecurity—or cathexis, as just pointed out—which is built upon and worsened when there is a sense that one's dignity has been violated in some way or the other by one who has inflicted a wound. Forgiveness requires both humility as well as emotional maturity, to avoid getting trapped into toxic patterns of unforgiveness.

The invitation to forgive needs to be reciprocated by the invitation to allow oneself to be forgiven. Sometimes pride or misguided honour prevents the acceptance of the invitation to be forgiven. In such cases, various forms of justification and rationalisation reinforce the sense of pride or honour involved. The perpetrator feels justified in the action which caused the wound. Sometimes, the perpetrator is aware of the wound that is caused; in other cases, the perpetrator may not even be aware of this.

The original wound leaves one vulnerable. To allow for processes of forgiveness may, in some cases, put the one forgiving in yet another vulnerable position, if the one who has wounded is not sufficiently mature to understand the dynamics of the process of amnesty, and its allied reciprocal responsibilities. Forgiveness of the perpetrator, if not received with wisdom, may be misunderstood, or underappreciated, or abused. It may be looked upon as a sign of weakness.

Sometimes there is a general sentiment of being wounded by the vagaries of life, because of one's social position, as well as because of particular instances of the past. One may be possessed by this sense of victimhood, while at the same time wish to consciously hold on to this sense. This feeling of "ressentiment" stems from a combination of cathexis

14 *See* Paul Ricoeur, *Memory, History, Forgetting*, Part I, Ch. 2.

as well as a convoluted and over-idealistic sense of justice—two blocks we have highlighted above.[15]

Another block to forgiveness is the possibility of taking the law into one's hands. Even if the law is entrusted to authoritative implementation, inter-personal and inter-community justice are not easy to specify and measure. Also, it takes long processes in courts of law to adjudicate and apportion just penalties, and these are often contested. Both restitution and reconciliation are often distant goals, which are most often not met within normal juridical procedures. Why be merciful when one can exact revenge and experience a different kind of catharsis?

Sometimes those in authority prefer to allow past wounds to fester, rather than invite their followers to forgive and reconcile. This repetition of the wounded memory of the past is often in tandem with the projection of a gilded future, however utopian it may seem—a utopia often based on a partisan "divide and rule" strategy. This approach creates ripe conditions for conflict to be perpetuated, and the consequent cultivation of passive aggression reaps rich benefits for vested interests whose primary goals are the increase of power and wealth.

An attitude of "one deserves what one gets," based on a warped understanding of karma may not allow for divine grace or human forgiveness to short-circuit the logic and dynamics of retributive justice. A consequence of this attitude is a nonchalance or indifference towards rectifying the social ills of the past, by way of a justification based on this warped understanding of karmic flow. However, both karma (causal necessity) and punya (grace) are not fixed in stone. While every religion emphasises some form of accountability related to moral action, there is also the possibility of divine grace and human benevolence which have the power to wipe away the apparently set stream of causal moral necessity and due justice.

Like many other human experiences, forgiveness builds upon past experiences and learnings from these experiences. The adage "nothing succeeds like success" may be aptly applied to the realm of forgiveness. Those who have tasted the joy and freedom that comes from forgiving and/or being forgiven will be prompted to continue to act in this manner in the future. However, if one has rarely been forgiven, or if one did not develop the courage to forgive, this would only hamper the ease in future forgiving. In the words of Jesus, "he who is forgiven little, loves little" (Luke 7:47).

15 *See* Friedrich Nietzsche, *The Genealogy of Morals*, trans. Michael Scarpitti, ed. Robert Holub (London: Penguin, 2013); and Max Scheler, *Ressentiment* (Milwaukee: Marquette University Press, 1994).

4. The Freedom of Forgiveness

The development of human consciousness—as applied to persons and communities—entails the adoption of progressive stages of transcendence: from a myopic personal stage, through a collective communitarian stage, towards a more inclusive and expansive human and global stage.[16] Developed or enlightened human consciousness features a greater awareness of the superfluity or surplus of life itself, and applied collaterally, of the various facets of the surplus of life. One of these collateral surpluses is the surplus of the existential act of forgiveness.

4.1. Aspects of Freedom as a Positive Outcome of Forgiveness

What may be the nature and scope of freedom associated with the phenomenon of forgiveness? What follows are major positive aspects associated with the freedom that comes from the experience of forgiveness.

Forgiveness primarily ushers in a freedom from emotional bondage anchored in the past. Keith Yandell asserts: "Often an important feature of a victim's forgiving an offender is that the victim's life is no longer dominated by thoughts, memories, and negative feelings regarding the harm done by the offender."[17] This freedom from the bondage of the past enables one to invest the time and energy thus saved in terms of pursuing other interests and passions. One is better able to move on with one's life.

A rare, but striking example of such freedom is that of Gladys Staines, who was able to forgive the murderer of her husband and two boys in a blatant act of communal violence. By means of her example, the possibility of radical forgiveness is illustrated, amidst the usual incredulity of assuming this disposition in the light of such tragic and needless violence inflicted upon oneself and one's loved ones. If such forgiveness is humanly possible, then it could be emulated by others as well.

The freedom of forgiveness contains the possibility of enhancing freedom for both parties. In the words of Bishop Desmond Tutu: "The victim cannot have peace without forgiving. The perpetrator will not have genuine peace while unforgiven. There cannot be peace between victim and perpetrator while the injury lies between them. The invitation to forgive is an invitation to search out the perpetrator's humanity."[18]

16 *See* my article titled, "Levels of Existential Development" in *The Dynamics of Development: Negations and Negotiations*, ed. Keith D'Souza (Bangalore: ATC, 2014), 287–309, which highlights the features of these different stages—or more appropriately states—of human consciousness.

17 Yandell, "The Metaphysics and Morality of Forgiveness," 39.

18 Desmond Tutu, "An Invitation to Forgive."

The gift of forgiveness has the possibility of affecting the perpetrator in a positive manner, and is often a source of healing for the latter. A good example of this phenomenon may be found in the life of the murderer of Sr Rani Maria—who relented his grave misdeed and eventually befriended his victim's family, on account of their forgiveness of his heinous crime.[19] Again, if such an incredible act of forgiveness is possible, then others could emulate this as well.

The gift of forgiveness has the potential to bring about healing between communities. In the words of Bishop Desmond Tutu,

> In my own family, sibling squabbles have spilled into intergenerational alienations. When adult siblings refuse to speak to each other because of some offense, recent or long past, their children and grandchildren can lose out on the joy of strong family relationships . . . Forgiveness among the members of older generations will open the door to healthy and supportive relationships among younger generations.[20]

This same dynamic of the healing of family relations affected by the wounds of the past could similarly be applied to relations between communities which have experienced or have had a history of violence or woundedness—as perpetrators or victims. The healing of wounded narratives between neighbouring nation states, between cultural and religious communities sharing the same socio-political space, between colonial powers and the colonised, etc., could bring about a significant sense of freedom and security within these communities.[21]

The significant material development of nations such as Germany and Japan after the Second World War is testimony to the collective consideration of the Allied powers which provided adequate support for these countries to prosper over time. The recognition that the creation of wholesome conditions of peace and goodwill between nations is important for the economic development of parties on all sides is an important factor for wholesome collective development. It is important for communities to

19 *See* "Biography of Blessed Sr. Rani Maria," *Kerala Catholic Bishops' Council*, https://kcbc.co.in/KCBC/SaintsDetails/6, accessed 21 July 2025.

20 Desmond Tutu, "An Invitation to Forgive."

21 *See* Bishop Desmond Tutu, *No Future Without Forgiveness* (NY: Doubleday, 1999), where the author highlights the systemic injustice of apartheid in South Africa, and the necessity of the pathway towards forgiveness which the Truth and Reconciliation Commission represented. *See also* Simon Wiesenthal, *The Sunflower: On the Possibilities and Limits of Forgiveness* (NY: Schocken Press, 1997), where the author narrates his experience of being a Nazi prisoner, and the complexities of granting forgiveness against the strong desire to seek and obtain justice.

develop this sense of collective wisdom, and more importantly, to call out and restrain their more bellicose leaders who wish to sustain animosities because of their petty political and economic interests.

4.2. Aspects of the Nature of the Freedom of Forgiveness

The freedom associated with forgiveness is not necessarily a uniform phenomenon. In fact, it varies in quality from person to person and community to community, and from context to context. We will highlight important aspects of the nature of the freedom of forgiveness itself.

The freedom of forgiveness could take various forms, from a stance of "positive indifference" to that of an "inter-personal or public attestation." Personal and affective indifference entails a distancing from the dynamics of the unfolding narrative which records—consciously or unconsciously—a trajectory from the infliction of a wound to its healing. At the other extreme, we could have a much more publicly attested and witnessed display—almost a ritual—of forgiveness. The "Truth and Justice Commission" of South Africa and similar public and formal Commissions or official bodies are examples of this type of forgiveness.

This decision to "let go" of the wounds of the past—whether private or public—results in inter-personal or social amnesty, which in turn results in the diminishment of the frequency, intensity, and duration of the memory associated with the wound. This results in psychological or emotional release—akin to the public "release" of a prisoner from the prison after serving a due and just term of confinement, as compensation for an inter-personal or social wound being inflicted.

Connected with the formal diversity of freedom, there is also a practical diversity of freedom. Like other terms in the title of the article, freedom is not invariant. It will quite usually differ in intensity, duration, and frequency. It may also differ along a life trajectory: one may find oneself freer at one time and less at another time, with reference to a specific wound, and a specific relationship. This applies to both individuals and communities.

The freedom associated with forgiveness is thus tenuous or fragile—hard to attain, and easily compromised. It is somewhat like a good reputation—hard to earn, yet can vanish with a single bad decision or behaviour. It requires discipline and ongoing mindfulness, aimed at the cultivation of a consistent character or basic disposition, which facilitates forgiveness.

Despite forgiveness being a transcendental invitation, the phenomenon of forgiveness is more rare than common. It seems to have eluded most individuals and communities over the millennia. The Biblical story of the tragic conflict of intentions between Cain and Abel is a good representative

of the typical human narrative that has unfolded through the ages and across diverse communities and contexts.

Even though forgiveness is an invitation—and even more so, a transcendental invitation—it cannot be enforced, especially against the will of persons and communities. This holds true in the most banal cases of transgression, but more so and especially when the wounds seem to be gruesome and too deep to overlook, not only when they are ripe, but even years later. Examples of such wounds are physical wounds (murder, rape), cultural wounds (extreme gender, caste, and racial discrimination), economic wounds (financial extortion and bonded labour), political wounds (betrayal and treason), personal wounds (false accusation or testimony, embezzlement, character assassination), etc. It is often difficult and even unacceptable to assume an idealistic, naïve, sanctimonious, or patronising attitude when attempting to convince the other person or community of the need to forgive—especially if one has been spared such egregious woundedness in one's personal or collective journey. Hannah Arendt and Vladimir Jankelevitch thus contend that some wounds, such as "crimes against humanity" may be considered to be unforgivable.[22]

It is also important not to engage in the act of forgiveness in a superior or patronising manner—that is, not to create forgiving, yet subaltern relations with persons or communities. Jacques Derrida ends his essay on forgiveness by asserting that, "What I dream of, what I try to think as the 'purity' of a forgiveness worthy of its name, would be a forgiveness without power: unconditional but without sovereignty. The most difficult task, at once necessary and apparently impossible, would be to dissociate unconditionality and sovereignty."[23]

As forgiveness is often elusive, it may not be considered as an act or event that is "done and dusted." It needs to be understood as an ongoing task—not something that is attained to full completion. This is because memory can be stirred again, renewing old passions associated with former wounds.

Conclusion

Forgiveness is both a gift and a task. It is the phenomenon of the gifting of intentional amnesty, and of receiving this gift. Both giving and receiving such a gift entails human maturity and sensitivity. Such gifting creates conditions for personal, inter-personal, and social peace and amity—and more fundamentally, conditions for hope. The invitation to engage in both gifting and receiving amnesty is universal—transcending cultures

22 *See* Vladimir Jankelevitch, *Forgiveness* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2005).

23 Derrida, *On Cosmopolitanism and Forgiveness*, 38.

and communities. Human rationality and social empathy lean much more towards the cultivation of such conditions—even though their attainment is quite demanding and fragile.

The existential choice for forgiveness is also a task—fraught with difficulties and limitations. However, if peace and harmony are to prevail, and furthermore, if grounds for wholesome communication are to be sustained, there does not seem to be much of an alternative. The choices to be personally free and to create social conditions of freedom are based upon foundational and collective attitudes, actions and behaviour patterns which are oriented towards the fostering of harmony, goodwill, and the realisation of the common good. Forgiveness is a significant element of, and contributor towards such choices.

12

Kinesis of *Karma*
Hiking Towards Hope

Ivan D'Souza

Abstract

The present paper proposes that the law of karma is a hopeful situation for humans to create and recreate themselves in the path of reaching the destiny. While critics argue that karma binds individuals to their past and fuels societal injustices, the spiritual essence of karma encourages resilience and growth. Karma is not a closed system of despair but rather a dynamic process of ethical evolution. Taking cue from Derrida's concept of différance, karma can be seen as "meaning in the making." The consequences of actions are never final or fixed; they continuously unfold, opening new vistas for transformation and spiritual growth. It provides hope through continuous opportunities for purification, self-realisation, and the eventual release from the cycle of rebirth. Karma is not a hopeless condition but an open-ended system that aligns with hope—fuelling aspirations, dreams, and the belief in a higher purpose. It is a philosophy which offers a journey towards hope and liberation (mokṣa).

Keywords: *Bhagavad-gītā, Bhakti, Bodhisattva, Buddhism, Différance, Hinduism, Hope, Jainism, Karma, Mokṣa*.

Introduction

The doctrine of *karma* is widely popular and it is ingrained in the hearts and minds of Indian masses. People often use the expressions such as "Oh! What a *karma*!", "This is what is written on his forehead" to communicate the idea that one has to experience the fruits of one's actions. The general understanding of *karma* is that all our actions have results. In simple words, the law of *karma* is the extension of the law of causation into the moral realm. In Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism, and Sikhism, *karma* drives the continuous cycle of birth, death, and rebirth. There have been never-ending questions and discussions on *karma* and its implications. The present paper attempts to show the intricate relationship between hope and the law of *karma*. It grapples with the following questions: Does *karma* offer hope if it is cyclic and circular? Are rebirths leading to better and higher hopes? Is every birth an experience of bondage and suffering, or does it provide a way out to look and aspire for liberation? Is it a hopeless situation or hopeful opportunity? Is *karma* leading towards hope or hindrance to hope? Is *karma* individualistic or societal? These questions are dealt in the paper mainly from the background of Hinduism but taking into account also the teachings of Jain and Buddhist traditions.

1. Meaning and Scriptural References of *Karma*

The word '*karma*' is derived from the Sanskrit root-verb 'kṛ,' which means 'to do, make, perform, accomplish, cause, effect, prepare, undertake' etc. Therefore, it stands for act, action, work, duty, profession, performance, etc. S. Radhakrishnan defines *karma* as "the principle that governs this world of becoming."[1] During the Vedic period, *karma* was conceived as sacrificial or ritual action (*yajña*), with each rite producing its specific rewards. It was the action performed by priests to make a sacrifice effective. But gradually, *karma* evolved to embody an ethical dimension in rituals and actions, and a deeper focus on the inner spiritual life.

Upaniṣads and later texts construe *karma* as having moral implications, which not only stands for action but also for the results of the action. *Bṛhadāraṇyaka Upaniṣad* provides one of the earliest references to the principle of *karma*. It says that it is human actions or conduct that makes one good or bad. One gains merit through good action and procures demerits due to evil action (BU 3.2.13).[2] *Kauṣītaki Upaniṣad* proclaims that a being

1 S. Radhakrishnan, editor and trans. *The Principal Upanisads* (London: Allen and Unwin, 1969), 113.

2 "*puṇyo vai puṇyena karmaṇā bhavati, pāpaḥ pāpeneti*" (BU 3.2.13). Swāmī Mādhavānanda, *The Bṛhadāraṇyaka Upaniṣad* (with the Commentary of Śaṅkarācārya), Wisdom Library, 1950. https://www.wisdomlib.org/hinduism/book/the-brihadaranyaka-upanishad/d/doc118304.html accessed 17 October 2024.

becomes a worm, an insect, a fish, a bird, a lion, a bear, a dog, a tiger or a human being, etc., depending on his *karma*s and his knowledge (KU 1.2).[3]

Bhagavad-gītā speaks about the metaphysical significance of *karma* by considering action as cause and fruit of the action as effect. It emphasises the need of desireless action (*niṣkāma karma*) for liberation. Duty without attachment to the results creates positive *karma*s. The approach of *niṣkāma karma* is the middle path between the two paths of *pravṛtti* (approach of action) and *nivṛtti* (approach of withdrawal from action or renunciation) discussed in the Hindu texts. *Niṣkāma karma* basically promotes actions of public welfare or well-being. It restricts all the narrow egoistic desires.[4] "The law of *niṣkāma-karma* is a philosophical antidote to the evil of bondage to the law of *karma*. While the law of *karma* binds the doer to the fruits of his deeds, the practice of *niṣkāma-karma* frees him from this thralldom."[5] The non-attached living counteracts the effects of *karma* and leads to liberation.

2. Classification of *Karma*

According to Hindu understanding, there are three types of *karma*s, namely, *sañcita karma*, *prārabda karma* and *āgāmī karma*.[6] *Sañcita karma* is accumulated *karma* of the past. The effects of past deeds which are in store. *Prārabda karma* is the *karma* in fruition. It is the fructified action or that which is the cause of present birth. It is portion of past *karma* which is responsible for the present body. *Āgāmī* or *kriyamāṇa karma* is the result of acts performed during this present life which decides the future. It is the current *karma* that is being gathered at present.

The well-known example that is used to explain the kinds of *karma* is about the archer or bowman. The bundle of arrows in his quiver refers to *sañcita karma,* the arrow that is shot is *prārabdha karma* and the one which is about to be sent forth from the bow is *āgamī karma*. One can act freely and responsibly to generate new good *karma*, though one remains bound by

3 "*sa iha kīṭo vā pataṅgo vā matsyo vā śakunir vā siṁho vā varāho vā paraśvāna vā śārdūlo vā puruṣo vā anyo vā teṣu teṣu sthāneṣu pratyājāyate yathā karmam yathā vidyām*" *See* Yuvraj Krishan, "The Vedic Origins of the Doctrine of *Karma*" *South Asian Studies* (51-55), 51.

4 Kedar Nath Tiwari, *Classical Indian Ethical Thought* (Delhi: Motilal Banarsidass Publishers Private Limited, 2007), 128-129.

5 S. K. Saksena, "Relation of Philosophical Theories to the Practical Affairs of Men," *The Indian Mind* ed. Charles A. Moore, 34.

6 T. M. P. Mahadevan, *Outlines of Hinduism* (Bombay: Chetana Pvt. Ltd., 1954), 60-61.

the *karma* already accumulated and being experienced. Buddhism speaks of threefold *karma*s, viz., *karma*s of body, speech and mind.[7]

3. Nature and Dynamics of *Karma*

Bhagavad-gītā says that the complexities of *karma* are hard to grasp (BG 4.17).[8] *Karma* is not just a physical law of cause and effect but also ethical law of action and the results of the action. From a general perspective, law of *karma* asserts that every action whether good or evil produces merits or demerits, reward and punishment, happiness or suffering, pain or pleasure. *Karma* involves both outward physical actions and the inner realm of thoughts and intentions. What one is at present is due to past *karma* and what one becomes in future is due to present *karma*.

Karma binds an individual to the worldly existence. Hindu tradition treats *karma* as beginningless (*anādi*). Theistic systems of Hinduism teach that it is the basic desire to be oneself which resulted in separation from God and addiction to matter.[9] To the question whether birth comes first or *karma* comes first, no definite answer is available. The relation between birth and *karma* is compared to the relation of seed and tree.[10] There is no birth without *karma* and no *karma* without birth.

The doctrine of reincarnation or transmigration (*saṁsāra*) is intrinsically related to the law of *karma*. The actions and their consequences make the self to be in the cycle of multiple births and deaths. The succession of births in the world in Buddhist terminology is called 'bhava-chakra'. *Bhagavad-gītā* says, "As the embodied soul continuously passes, in this body, from childhood to youth to old age, so too, does that same soul pass into another body at the time of death" (BG 2.13).[11] It further compares our bodies to clothes. As we change our clothes on our body, so too soul gets embodied with new one (BG 2.22). The association of soul with the body is not substantial but accidental.

7 There are many kinds of classifications of karma in various Indian religious traditions and texts. They are not dealt in this paper as it does not come within its scope.

8 "*gahanā karmaṇo gatiḥ*" (BG 4.17).

9 V. F. Vineeth, *Self and Salvation in Hinduism and Christianity* (New Delhi: Intercultural Publications, 1997), 192.

10 The relation of seed and tree is known as "*Bīja-vṛkṣa-nyāya*." It means the seed is the cause of the tree and the tree is the cause of the seed. It cannot be definitely concluded that one has caused the other.

11 "*dehino 'smin yathā dehe kaumāraṁ yauvanaṁ jarā tathā dehāntara-prāptir dhīras tatra na muhyati*" (BG 2.13). Swami Mukundananda, *Bhagavad Gita - The Song of God*, 2014. https://www.holy-bhagavad-gita.org/chapter/2/verse/13 accessed 17 October 2024.

Kārmic law is kinetic in nature. *Bhagavad-gītā* mentions that individuals may go to the world of gods, ancestors or spirits (BG 9.25). Due to *karma* one has to ascend and descend into various realms of existence. Individual soul does not acquire new *karma* in non-human physical forms, because *karma*s get accumulated only where consciousness and intention are operative. According to the *Upanisads*, after the depletion of the effects of *karma*, individuals enter the cycle of birth, death and rebirth from other worlds.[12] It is a constant and continuous cycle till the results of one's actions get exhausted. Ultimately, from the state of human existence one can reach to the state of hope—viz., *mokṣa* or liberation.

Jain philosophy asserts the material nature of *karma* (*pudgala*). *Karma*, being atomic and subtle in nature, unites the soul to the body. It has the property of down gravity and soul has the property of upward gravity.[13] *Karma*s are fruits of good and evil actions of mind, body and speech. There are auspicious *karma*s (*puṇya karmas*) and inauspicious *karma*s (*pāpa karmas*). Just as a wet cloth collects dust from its surroundings, the soul attracts atoms of matter driven by the force of passions (*kaṣāya*).

Karma in Buddhism is defined as "intentional impulse (*cetanā*) and the act which follows upon it."[14] Therefore, *karma* is essentially mental in nature. The merits and demerits of *karma* depends on will or intention of the agent. Buddhist scriptures say, "The fruit of a deed is threefold, it may arise here and now, or later or in a succession of lives."[15] *Karma* is a subtle material element which causes inequality and suffering. "One becomes what he is, not through birth, but rather because of past acts."[16] Buddha maintains that ignorance (*avidyā*) is the root of all *karma*s. *Karma* arises from *tṛṣṇā* (desire, attachment, craving, passion) and cessation of desire leads to the hope of *nirvāṇa* or liberation. *Dhammapada* states, "If a man speaks or acts with an evil thought, pain follows him, as the wheel follows the foot of the

12 Anantanand Rambachan, "Hinduism," in *Life After Death in World Religions*, ed. Harold Coward (New York: Orbis Books, 1997), 66-86. p. 78-79.

13 Yuvaraj Krishan, *The Doctrine of Karma* (Delhi: Motilal Banarsidass Publishers Private Limited, 1997), 41.

14 James P. McDermott, "*Karma* and Rebirth in Early Buddhism," in *Karma and Rebirth in Classical Indian Traditions*, ed. Wendy Doniger O'Flaherty (Delhi: Motilal Banarsidass, 1983), 182.

15 Yuvaraj Krishan, *The Doctrine of Karma*, 74.

16 James P. McDermott, "*Karma* and Rebirth in Early Buddhism," in *Karma and Rebirth in Classical Indian Traditions*, ed. Wendy Doniger O'Flaherty (Delhi: Motilal Banarsidass, 1983), 174-175.

ox that draws the carriage… If a man speaks or acts with a pure thought, happiness follows him, as the shadow that never leaves him."[17]

In practical terms, good actions lead to merits and evil actions to demerits. However, Buddhist texts explain that even someone who has committed evil may still inherit a heavenly realm, while those who avoid immoral acts might not always be reborn in a good state. This is because the effect of a weaker deed (*dubbalakamma*) can be overridden by a stronger one (*balavakamma*) or by the accumulated effects of past deeds. Thus, a person who has done wrong may still be reborn in a pleasant state if their merits outweigh the demerits. The effects of the bad deeds will then be felt later, once the results of the good deeds are exhausted.[18]

Karma connects past, present and future. In the words of Panikkar, "In a way I am as much what I 'was' and equally what 'I shall be' as what at present I 'am.' Both past and future are already present in my present real situation."[19] According to Radhakrishnan the principle of *karma* has both retrospective aspect and a prospective aspect—i.e., continuity with the past and creative freedom of the self for future.[20]

Therefore, the theory of *karma* has to be looked from a panoramic perspective by transcending the binaries and boundaries. *Karma* sees in everything the working out of a great Cosmic Plan whereby everything rises from lower to higher, and still higher.[21]

4. Debatable Issues of *Karma* Theory

There are many debatable topics related to the theory of *karma*. One of the criticisms against the theory of *karma* is that it has influenced both the exploiting and the exploited classes and thus has justified caste system and perpetuated poverty in the society considering it as divinely ordained. From this background, being born as a person in the lower strata of society is viewed as a consequence of one's past *karma*. The oppressed classes accepted their victimisation and misery as a result of *karma*. Hence, it is said that *karma* is an invention of Hindu Brahmins to claim themselves as higher and better than those who are in the periphery of the society. It can also be applied to other existential situations of Indian people. However, we

17 *Dhammapada*, I, 1-2, trans. F. Max Muller (ed.), *The Sacred Books of the East* (Oxford, 1884).

18 James P. McDermott, "*Karma* and Rebirth in Early Buddhism," in *Karma and Rebirth in Classical Indian Traditions*, 176-177.

19 Raimon Panikkar, *Myth, Faith and Hermeneutics: Cross Cultural Studies* (New York: Paulist Press, 1979), 383.

20 Nirmala Jha, *Law of Karma* (Delhi: Capital Publishing House, 1985), 117.

21 William Walker Atkinson, *Reincarnation and the Law of Karma* (New York: Cosimo Classics, 2007).

cannot entirely dismiss the origins of the ancient class system, which aimed at social stratification and division of labour based on a person's inclination, aptitude, and interest in work. It should also be noted that *karma* gives scope to establish social order by resisting the current evil of oppression and exploitation. Buddhism opines that it is not birth that makes one superior or inferior but his actions and conduct lead him to a particular state. Thus, we can assert that law of *karma* operates impartially irrespective of caste or background of a doer. Humans have the freedom, duty, and responsibility to intervene and work against all kinds of unjust structures and oppressive forces. Looking *karma* from a wider perspective, Anand Amaladoss is of the view that in the Hindu world view both the universe and beings in the world including humans are always in the process of becoming. Humans are just a part of the universe as other beings are. As humans are at par with the rest of the universe, *karma* applies to all the beings in the cosmos. It does not degrade humans to any lower level of human dignity.[22]

Another objection to the law of *karma* is that it propagates a sense of fatalism. A person can become indifferent to the realities of the present life, remain passive or inactive and indolence may creep in. Radhakrishnan writes, "Unfortunately, the theory of *Karma* became confused with fatality in India when man himself grew feeble and was disinclined to do his best. It was made into an excuse for inertia and timidity and was turned into a message of despair and not of hope."[23] Humans can always use their freewill to make their prospects creative and worthy. As Radhakrishnan puts it, "The cards in the game of life are given to us. We do not select them. They are traced to our past *karma*, but we can call as we please, lead what suit we will, and as we play, we gain or lose. And there is freedom."[24] In this connection we can posit that world is more a playground for the individual to perform well, than a prison cell of penalty and punishment.

While *karma* is often perceived as fatalistic or determined force, it doesn't restrict human freedom completely. Though each individual's present is determined by past, one can change the course of one's future by making right choices and living responsibly. We are governed by our past, but we govern our future. Thus, the *karma* doctrine as principle of responsibility, provides scope for the operation of the free will of an individual to create his or her own destiny. The determinism which the theory of *karma* enforces can be called as 'self-determinism'—a determinism which is affected by our

22 Anand Amaladass, "A Cross-Cultural Look at the Doctrine of *Karma* in the Modern Context," *Vidyajyoti Journal of Theological Reflection 86*, no. 10 (2022): 751-763.

23 Sarvapalli Radhakrishnan, *The Hindu View of Life*.

24 S. Radhakrishnan, *The Hindu View of Life* (London: Unwin Books, 1960), 75.

own past *karma*s.[25] Thus, law of *karma* does not hinder human creativity and freedom. For Aurobindo the theory of *karma* is non-fatalistic because the true self always transcends and escapes to another state. It is never entangled. The self is always in process.[26]

Generally, Indians who accept the theory of *karma* do not passively resign themselves to fate; instead, human agency takes precedence over predetermined destiny. Rajeev Bhargava, one of the leading Indian Political thinkers writes, "The more humans are able to control their destiny, the less room in their perspective they have for fate."[27] He further states, "Individuals, societies and, indeed, humanity must have a realistic view of what is given and the extent to which it can be altered."[28]

5. *Karma*: Hopeless End or Endless Hope?

The theory of *karma* can depress and disparage a person, trapping them in the labyrinth of worldly life due to a series of births, deaths and rebirths. One may look at it negatively or pessimistically as hopeless end. Even if one believes they are in a hopeless situation, they can be reborn anew and reach their final destiny. *Kārmic* law is an ongoing process of becoming. Jaques Derrida vibrates with the dynamics of *karma*. Through the philosophical approach of deconstruction, he challenges and dismantles the fixed meanings of texts or history that were once considered absolute or definitive. In this context, we can consider the term 'différance,' which he coined, conveying two meanings: 'to differ' and 'to defer.' It indicates difference or distinction as well as delay or postponement. On the one side, the meaning in language is not the same and on the other side meaning gets shifted and delayed. In other words, the meaning is never closed, conclusive and complete.

Karma theory follows this principle of constant twists, turns, shifts and so on. Hope is always open and remains continuous in *karma*. It doesn't lead to a hopeless end. In Derridean sense, as meaning is not final, so also hope is not final. There is more meaning to come—and there is always hope to come. Hope presents hopeful all the time till we reach the climax. *Karma* leaves the future open to infinity and to plurality. But fullness and

25 Kedar Nath Tiwari, *Classical Indian Ethical Thought* (Delhi: Motilal Banarsidass Publishers Private Limited, 2007), 141.

26 Robert N. Minor, "In Defense of *Karma* and Rebirth: Evolutionary *Karma*," in *Karma and Rebirth: Post Classical Developments*, ed. Ronald W. Neufeldt (New York: Sri Satguru Publications, 1986), 25.

27 Rajeev Bhargava, *Between Hope and Despair: 100 Ethical Reflections on Contemporary India* (New Delhi: Bloomsbury, 2023), 261.

28 Rajeev Bhargava, *Between Hope and Despair*, 262.

fulfillment of hope is found in *mokṣa*. K. E. Parthasarathy describes the doctrine of *karma* as "an incentive to action and a source of consolation."[29]

Karma is an endless hope as it sustains us through the cycles of birth and death. It promises freedom and liberation even amidst worldly bondage and suffering. In worldly existence hope defers and shifts its destination. *Karma* instills hope in individuals providing them opportunities for growth, transformation, purification and realisation in different births. It is not a closed system but an open-ended process of evaluation and evolution. Radhakrishnan views, "*Saṁsāra* is only a succession of spiritual opportunities. Life is a stage in spiritual perfection, a step in the passage to the infinite. It is the time for preparing the soul for eternity."[30] He also says, "The history of man in not a puppet show. It is a creative evolution."[31] So, *karma* is integral to becoming and growing.

The consequences of *karma* are never realised in the present moment but are continually get unfolded in various births. Derridean reading of *karma* also teaches us that there can be no hope without the presence of despair, and no despair without the possibility of hope.

6. Horizontal Dimensions of *Karma* in the Journey of Hope

Brian Treanor, American Philosopher describes hope as "that which allows me not to despair, that which gives me the strength to continue to create myself in availability to the other."[32] In the words of Will Durant, "*Karma* is one of those inventions by which men have sought to bear evil patiently, and to face life with hope."[33] The law of *karma* demands personal responsibility. One has to bear the results of the action in this birth or in future births. No one bears the consequences of actions which one has not done. One has to undergo oneself. One gets what one deserves for his actions. *Bhagavad-gītā* suggests, "One should raise oneself by one's own self alone; let not one lower oneself; for the self alone is one's own friend, and the self alone

29 K. E. Parthasarathy, "Law of *Karma* in Vedanta," *Aryan Path* 40 (April 1969), 163-164.

30 Quoted in Robert N. Minor, "In Defense of *Karma* and Rebirth: Evolutionary *Karma*," in *Karma and Rebirth: Post Classical Developments*, ed. Ronald W. Neufeldt (New York: Sri Satguru Publications, 1986), 36.

31 S. Radhakrishnan, *Indian Philosophy*, Vol. II (London: George Allen & Unwin Ltd., 1927), 635.

32 Treanor, Brian and Brendan Sweetman, "Gabriel (-Honoré) Marcel," *The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy* (Summer 2021 Edition), Edward N. Zalta (ed.), URL = https://plato.stanford.edu/archives/sum2021/entries/marcel/.

33 Will Durant, *The Story of Civilization: Our Oriental Heritage* (New York: Simon and Schuster, 1954), 516.

is one's own enemy."[34] Jaina law of *karma* attaches great responsibility to individual actions as it is the religion of self-help. What about the other—the society, the community, the humanity? There is an inseparable relationship between an individuals and society. The more one contributes to society, better it is for the individual self. It is true that one's life is determined by one's own *karma*—but without 'the other' life cannot be lived and good *karma*s be gathered. Each time one does good *karma* (*satkarma*) and avoids bad *karma*, they enhance their future life's state.[35] While living the life with givenness, humans are also called to instill hope in others, not just groan over for the miserable state of affairs they undergo as punishment or experience of *karma*.

The contemporary discussion on *karma* gives importance to the social aspect of *karma*. Nilima Sharma writes,

> The contemporary Indian philosophers do not preach the negation of empirical life and its activities for the attainment of one's ultimate goal. The liberation of the individual, according to them, does not only mean the attainment of freedom from *karma*, ignorance, birth and death, but it also means the attainment of harmony with society and it necessitates constant effort on the part of the liberated man to work for the progress and perfection of society as a whole.[36]

The vertical realisation of oneself necessarily involves the horizontal reaching out to the other. Welfare of humanity goes along with self-realisation. Traditionally the theory of *karma* was individual oriented but later on Sri Aurobindo and Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan have given a progressive and evolutionary interpretation to it. They assert that an individual in the universe is a partner and pilgrim in the evolutionary process of the world—towards a hopeful hope. In this sense, *karma* is an opportunity to grow and progress in a purposeful path.[37] Aurobindo views rebirth as an evolutionary process, not a mechanical cycle driven by *karma*. It serves as a meaningful path for spiritual growth, where each life offers opportunities for the soul's

34 "*uddhared ātmanātmānaṁ nātmānam avasādayet ātmaiva hyātmano bandhur ātmaiva ripur ātmanaḥ*" (BG 6.5). Ved Vyas Foundation, 2024. https://bhagavadgita.io/chapter/6/verse/5 accessed 20 October 2024.

35 Mark W. Muesse, *Getting to Know Hinduism* (New Delhi: Aleph Book Company, 2018), 86-87.

36 Nilima Sharma, *Twentieth Century Indian Philosophy: Nature and Destiny of Man* (Varanasi: Bharatiya Vidya Prakasana, 1972), 253.

37 Robert N. Minor, "In Defense of *Karma* and Rebirth: Evolutionary *Karma*," in *Karma and Rebirth: Post Classical Developments*, ed. Ronald W. Neufeldt (New York: Sri Satguru Publications, 1986), 15-16.

ascension. The soul progresses from matter through plant and animal life to the human stage, with each rebirth offering a chance for higher spiritual evolution.[38] Radhakrishnan looks at *karma* not from the usual pattern of reward and punishment. There can be suffering in love and satisfaction in hatred.[39] Mahatma Gandhi advocates that *karma* makes one responsible as one creates one's own destiny. It makes humans loving, kind and benevolent beings—even amidst strife and suffering.[40]

No action exists in isolation when it comes to *karma*, as every deed, is interconnected with the web of cause and effect, influencing not only the individual but also the broader universe. Every action sends ripples through the universe.[41] Raimon Panikkar states, "karmic law centers its attention *not on what human beings did,* but on *what happened to them as they did it*."[42] Hence, everything seen as a united whole.

Swami Vivekananda conceived *karma* as serving others. He hints that through *karma* yoga—i.e., by serving the needy and the suffering—the merit of action is transferred to the doer and it also lessens the negative effects of another's *karma*.[43] In BG, *karma* is the selfless action which is undertaken for the welfare of all beings—*lokasaṅgraha* (BG 3.25). *Mahābhārata* says, "*paropakāram puṇyāya, pāpāya parapīdanam*" i.e., helping others is meritorious, and hurting others is a sin.

Though Jainism gives attention to individuals, it calls for practice of five vows, namely, non-violence, truth, non-stealing, celibacy and non-possession, which ensures hope and space for beings from all the realms. In Buddhism, the *bodhisattvas* (enlightened being) transfer their merits for those who are in *kārmic* captivity. *Theravāda* and *Mahāyāna* schools of Buddhism teach that the merit can be transferred (*puṇyapariṇāmnā* or *puṇyadāna*) which produces further merits to the donor and the demerits of *karma* can be annulled through the grace of *bodhisattva*. However, the transfer of merits cannot be done in the case of evil deeds.[44] The *bodhisattvas* dedicate themselves to the task of universal emancipation by delaying their

38 Yuvaraj Krishan, *The Doctrine of Karma*, 478.

39 Nirmala Jha, *Law of Karma*, 119.

40 Nirmala Jha, *Law of Karma*, 82.

41 Anand Amaladass, "A Cross-Cultural Look at the Doctrine of *Karma* in the Modern Context," *Vidyajyoti Journal of Theological Reflection 86*, no. 10 (2022): 751-763.

42 Raimon Panikkar, *Myth, Faith and Hermeneutics*, 4.

43 George M. Williams, "Swami Vivekananda's Conception of *Karma* and Rebirth," in in *Karma and Rebirth: Post Classical Developments*, ed. Ronald W. Neufeldt (New York: Sri Satguru Publications, 1986), 53.

44 Yuvaraj Krishan, *The Doctrine of Karma*, 76-78.

own *nirvāṇa*. The *bodhisattvas* own great surplus of *kārmic* merit which has the potential to reduce the *karma*s of an aspirant.[45]

7. Hope and *Karma* in Bhakti Traditions

In the *Bhakti* traditions, devotion to God is coupled with grace of God. One can hope for grace and divine intervention as the fruits of one's *bhakti*. *Bhagavad-gītā* declares, "He quickly becomes righteous and attains lasting peace. O son of Kuntī, declare it boldly that My devotee never perishes" (BG 9.31).[46] *Viśiṣtādvaita* School of *Vedānta* presents that sincere devotion to God can mitigate the effects of negative *karma* and secure a better future. Faith has the potential to create hope in the devotee. Ramanuja in his *Sri Bhasya* (SB 3.4.27) indicates that grace can be obtained by the right performance of *karma* done as loving worship.[47] Srinivasadasa in his *Yatīndramatadipika* proposes that *bhakti* is a continuous stream of remembrance of God, like the uninterrupted flow of oil in the lamp.[48] *Prapatti* or total surrender to God is always the climax of atonement for sins.[49] Sacrifices, gifts, and offerings serve as indirect means of appeasing the Supreme Being, while praise, worship, and meditation are direct methods of honouring and connecting with Him. In theistic systems, God is considered to be the dispenser of the fruits of action or presider or supervisor (*karmādhyakṣa*) over the working of the law of *karma*.[50]

Conclusion

Hinduism calls the land we dwell and work as "*karma-bhūmi*." The whole cosmos is a place of action and operation of *karma*. Every self has a place and prospect in it. We are the products of our past but the makers of our future. No actions, efforts, or aspirations go waste in the realm of *karma*. We are both determined and free: determined by the past but free to create the future. *Karma* theory infinitely creates hope and keeps the possibility of hope open for eternity. Compared to the eternity of self, one birth is a small duration for those who uphold *kārmic* theory. *Karma* is hope which is directed towards something desirable, worthwhile, and meaningful. Hence, one can celebrate *karma* as an opening for eternity or a plurality of hope.

45 Norman C. McClelland, *Encyclopedia of Reincarnation and Karma*, North Carolina: McFarland & Company, Inc., Publishers, 2010, s.v. "*Karma* versus grace."

46 "*kṣipraṁ bhavati dharmātmā śaśvac-chāntiṁ nigacchati kaunteya pratijānīhi na me bhaktaḥ praṇaśyati*" (BG 9.31).

47 John C. Plott, The Philosophy of Devotion (Delhi: Motilal Banarsidass, 1974), 215-216.

48 John C. Plott, *The Philosophy of Devotion*.

49 John C. Plott, *The Philosophy of Devotion*, 266.

50 Yuvaraj Krishan, *The Doctrine of Karma*, 247.

Karma theory teaches us that I need not lose hope because I am born again. The kinesis of *karma* helps us to hike towards hope. *Karma* keeps the possibility of *mokṣa* open. There is a symbiotic relationship between *karma* and hope. Hope is ever present in *karma* and *karma* ever creates hope. I have to move the wheel of *karma* with hope through dynamism, movement, becoming, going, growing, otherness—and take it to the destiny.

The waves and winds in the sea may aid or hinder the progress of a boat but the sailor has to control the rudder and sails, to navigate it to the shore. Every birth is a sailing in the vast sea. The waves and winds of *karma* may help or hinder one's journey but one has to direct oneself towards the hopeful hope with freedom and responsibility.

13

Islamic Perspectives on Hope

Jose Pennaparambil

Abstract

In Islam, hope, or raja in Arabic, is a concept that is associated with Allah and the belief in His mercy and forgiveness.Muslims believe that hope is a driving force that can help them achieve great things in life, and that it can motivate them to strive to please Allah. Hope is also seen as a way to face challenges with resilience and optimism, and to find solace and inspiration. Hope is a way to demonstrate our servitude to Allah. Hope makes people turn to Allah and humble themselves in need, placing their hope only on Allah. However, both hope and fear should be in complete balance. Excess hope, which is feared to deceive individuals and make them delusional. On the contrary, excess fear will lead them to hopelessness and despair. In Islam, there is no guarantee that Allah will save or forgive a Muslim, and there is no purification process of the soul in this earthly life, like that of renunciation of the worldly goods and self-emptying of the person for spiritual perfection, as we see in many other religions like Christianity, Hinduism, and Buddhism etc.—foreseeing a life of bliss in the life after. In these religions, heaven is a spiritual abode where one enters in after life. On the contrary, in Islam the jennah or Paradise is purely material, where all pleasures,

including kinds of food, drinks, and companions, are described as rewards (Cf. Suras 5:119, 13:23–24, 55:72). Muslims hope that Allah's help comes from unknown sources to take them out of difficult situations. If they are destined to be affected by that eventuality, Muslims believe that they will be rewarded abundantly in their life after death as their prayers will never go unanswered. But Muslims are not fully certain that Allah will help them. The Qur'an and Hadiths do not give any certainty or surety in this regard.

Keywords: *Amal, Dua, Dhikr, Hadiths, Iman, Jihad, Rahim, Rahman, Raja, Tadabbur, Tamanna, Tawakkul, Tawhid, Ubudiyyah*.

Introduction

Hope contributes positively to an individual's outlook and his/her capability in dealing with difficult moments in life. Even so, the future is still uncertain. One might argue that hope may hurt the person more in the long run if the outcome is not like what he expected it to be. In Islam, hope, or *raja* in Arabic, is a concept that is associated with Allah and the belief in His mercy and forgiveness. Muslims believe that hope is a driving force that can help them achieve great things in life, and that it can motivate them to strive to please Allah. Hope is also seen as a way to face challenges with resilience and optimism, and to find solace and inspiration. In other words, hope is the belief that Allah is the only one who has power in the world and the heavens, and that he can provide forgiveness, prosperity, peace, and happiness in this life and the afterlife.

The Qur'an and the Hadith (the words and deeds of Mohammad that are not recorded in the Qur'an) are the primary sources for defining hope in Islam. Some say that hope is closely connected to the concept of *tawhid,* or the belief in the oneness of Allah. Others say that hope is a profound trust in Allah's wisdom and divine plan, and that it is intertwined with patience in times of adversity. In this paper, we deal with different aspects of hope, its basis in the Qur'an and the Hadiths, the philosophical implications and the practical aspects of hope.

1. The Islamic Expressions of Hope

The word hope can be elucidated by different Arabic words. It will enable us to have a comprehensive idea of hope in the Islamic perspective.

Raja: The Arabic word *raja* means hope and refers to the hope that Muslims have for Allah, who is the only one who is powerful on earth. Muslims hope for Allah's forgiveness, prosperity, happiness, and mercy.

Amal: The word *amal* means desire and refers to a wish that requires a long wait. The Qur'an says that enduring good deeds are better for reward and hope.

Tamanna: The term *tamanna* means request and refers to asking for something while appreciating its essence.

***Ubudiyyah*:** It means servitude to Allah. Hope is a way to demonstrate our servitude to Allah. Hope makes people turn to Allah and humble themselves in need, placing their hope only on Allah—in other words—complete dependence on Allah for everything.

2. Qur'anic Basis of Hope

There are many Qur'anic verses and prophetic narrations that mention hope and stories of people from the previous communities. In those verses and narrations, the people of God are never described as being despair and hopeless. The aim is to encourage Muslims not to give up in life and to rekindle hope in them.

"Do not lose hope in Allah's mercy, for Allah certainly forgives all sins. He is indeed the All-Forgiving, Most Merciful. New! Turn to your Lord in repentance, and fully submit to Him before the punishment reaches you, for then you will not be helped" (Cf. Sura 39:53–54).[1] This Qur'anic verse gives assurance to Muslims that Allah will forgive their sins if they repent. The mercy of Allah is expressed in this verse too. Say: "O my Servants who have transgressed against their souls! Despair not of the Mercy of Allah: for Allah forgives all sins: for He is Oft-Forgiving, Most Merciful" (Sura 39:53).

"And whoever fears Allah—He will make for him a way out and will provide for him from where he does not expect. And whoever relies upon Allah—then He is sufficient for him…" (Sura 65:2–3). This verse says that the God-fearing people will get all the assistance from Allah if one relies upon Him.

Faith and hope are closely related; a true believer is the most hopeful and the most optimistic person among people, and the farthest one from pessimism, complaining, and dissatisfaction. This is because true faith indicates the belief in the power of Allah that controls this universe. "So do not lose hope, nor fall into despair, for you will be superior if you are true in faith" (Sura 3:139). "And who despairs of the mercy of his Lord, but such as go astray" (Sura 15:56). These verses give new light in the minds of the people—those who are in despair.

1 *The Quran*, trans. Abdullah Yusuf Ali (New Delhi: Kithab Bhavan, 1996), Qurʾān 39:53. All Qurʾānic verses (*ayat*) are taken from this book.

"Those who have believed migrated, and fought in the path of Allah, it is they who can hope for Allah's mercy: Allah is All-forgiving, Most Merciful" (Sura 2:218). Allah gives comfort and mercy to those who do *jihad* (striving hard to gain a goal) and migrate to another place.

3. Hope and Despair

In Islam, hope has a partner, and its partner is fear. The true believer must allow fear and hope to consistently accompany him in all his affairs. This is because he possesses two outlooks. When he looks inwardly, he sees his own deficiency in the fulfilment of Allah's rights. This instils fear. Then, his second outlook is towards the blessings of Allah upon him, and the goodness He has shown. This instils hope within him. Also, he must look towards His attributes of greatness, majesty, wisdom, and justice. This will also instil a sense of fear from the effects exerted by these attributes. Then, he looks towards His attributes of open-handedness, mercy, generosity and showing goodness, so he hopes for that which results from it. If he engages in a deed of righteousness, he combines fear and hope such that he hopes for its acceptance and fears its rejection. If he engages in sin, he fears its torment while hoping for it to be forgiven by the grace of Allah.

Imam Ibn al-Qayyim al-Jawziyyah says: "The heart in its journey towards Allah is like a bird whose head is love, and hope and fear are its two wings."[2] The righteous person would strengthen his wing of fear in the time of happiness, so God is always remembered, and recklessness is prevented. Whereas in time of calamities and nearing death, he will strengthen his wing of hope, for God is All-Merciful.

However, there are sayings of which both hope and fear should be in complete balance. Excess hope is feared to deceive individuals and make them delusional. On the contrary, excess fear will lead them to hopelessness and despair. These two situations are harmful to them both in this worldly life and, most importantly, the hereafter.

One of the reasons why we feel anxious is due to the fact that we have sinned. Sinning makes us feel bad, ashamed, and disappointed in ourselves. When we have that feeling over and over, it can easily result in hopelessness. We usually feel terrible when we think that Allah will never forgive us or is angry with us. This is a dark and heavy feeling—and is one of Satan's most useful weapons. Satan banks on our despair to push us further away from Allah. When a person thinks that he will not be forgiven, he responds

2 "Fearing and Hoping in Allah," *Life With Allah*, https://lifewithallah.com/articles/seasons-of-worship/ramadan/fearing-and-hoping-in-allah/#:~:text=Ibn%20al%2DQayyim%20(ra%E1%B8%A5imahull%C4%81h),two%20wings%20will%20fly%20well, accessed 18 July 2025.

by turning away from Allah. That is a catastrophe because turning towards Allah is the one thing that can restore hope.

Hopelessness is becoming more common. This phenomenon is not a new trait—it has been with us since time immemorial. But Allah has not left us unattended, for He sent down Messengers and Prophets to urge us to be hopeful. Verily, they gave us guidance and encouragement.

The Hadiths (the words and deeds of Mohammad that are not recorded in the Qur'an) are of some importance in this respect. "Whoever persists in asking for forgiveness, Allah will grant him relief from every worry, and a way out from every hardship, and will grant him provision from (sources) he could never imagine."[3] At the same time another Hadith says how one can dispel feelings of anxiety and despair. "O Allah! I seek refuge with You from worry and grief, from incapacity and laziness, from cowardice and miserliness, from being heavily in debt and from being overpowered by (other) men."[4] This is what Allah informed: "And we will surely test you with something of fear and hunger, some loss in wealth, lives and fruits (of your toil), but give glad tidings to those who patiently persevere" (Sura 2:155). Thus, Islam advises its followers to face tribulations with patience and hope. Hope will guide through darkness—but despair will only lengthen the journey. Those who lose all hope in life sometimes resort to taking their own life. That should not happen at all.

Furthermore, Islam teaches its followers to rely completely on God in every matter. *Tawakkul,* the Arabic term for reliance on God (trust in God), is taking our leap of faith into the unknown future with complete trust in God. One of the Hadith records, "If you were to rely upon Allah with the reliance He is due, you would be given provision like the birds: They go out hungry in the morning and come back with full bellies in the evening."[5] *Tawakkul,* in this sense, is not just to place trust upon God but also to make the right effort accordingly to the intended purpose. The Hadith did not mention that the birds wait in their nests and expect God's provisions to appear before them. Instead, they fly out in search of their daily provisions in the early mornings. This balanced outlook of *tawakkul* is, therefore, constituent of both effort and total reliance upon God. A true Muslim is someone who strives and works hard to get what he/she wishes for and rely on Allah for whatever the outcome is after one has made and exhausted all efforts.

3 Sunan Ibn Majah 3819 (Book 33, Ḥadīth 163), https://sunnah.com, accessed 10 August 2025.

4 Sunan Abi Dawud 1541 (Book 8, Ḥadīth 126); Sahih al-Bukhari 6369 (Book 80, Hadith 66), https://sunnah.com, accessed 10 August 2025.

5 Sunan Ibn Majah 4164 (Book 37, Hadith 65), https://sunnah.com, accessed 10 August 2025.

If we trust in God and rely on Him, we will not be overly concerned about the unpredictable future. As understood from the Hadiths Allah will take good care of us. If that is the case, Muslims should similarly place their hope ultimately in Allah alone. The moment we realise this, we shall understand none of our hope goes to waste. The believer is always in a state of both hope and fear. We have to balance the extremes of hope and fear. Too much hope can make us complacent and neglectful of our duties. And too much fear can cripple us with despair.

The pious people of the past would advise that during good times, when we are more likely to forget Allah, we should increase our fear of Him. And during difficult times, we should increase our hope in Him. Other scholars stated that throughout one's life, fear should be dominant over hope—but towards the end of one's life, hope should become dominant. Ṣaḥih Muslim states that he heard the Messenger of Allah saying the following three days before his death, "None of you should die unless he expects good from Allah."[6]

Unless the things we hope for are delusional, there is no such thing as false hope. According to an Egyptian scholar, Dr Amru Al-Wirdani, hope flies with two wings—the wing of guided optimism and the wing of realism. This illustrates us of what it means to be hopeful. An extended or excess form of optimism that is not grounded in the basis of reality, such as fantasising or wishful thinking is not part of what it means to be hopeful.[7]

4. Philosophy of Hope

As already understood in Islam, *raja* (hope) means aspiration or waiting for something that is loved. The aspects of the philosophy of hope in Islam are:

a. The Object of Hope: Hope in Islam is directed to Allah, who is seen as the only one who is powerful on earth. The hope is to obtain Allah's forgiveness, mercy, and good pleasure, and to achieve prosperity and happiness in this world and the afterlife.

Muslims believe that if we follow the guidance in the Qur'an and in the Prophetic traditions (Hadiths), we will be rewarded abundantly in this world as well as in the hereafter. To believe in the world after death is a part of the Muslim faith. The person who followed a virtuous path in this life will be rewarded with the permanent stay in Paradise where he will have all comforts of life at an unimaginable scale. This is the reason Muslims are taught that they should never despair even in most difficult moments.

6 Ṣaḥih Muslim 2877, *Daily Hadith Online* (blog), April 22, 2012, https://www.abuaminaelias.com/dailyhadithonline/2012/04/22/except-good-allah-death/, accessed 10 August 2025.

7 Shaykh Amr al-Wirdani, "May Allah Be Well Pleased with Him," *Scholars Quilt* (blog), 24 September 2015, https://scholarsquilt.wordpress.com/2015/09/24/shaykh-amr-al-wirdani-may-allah-be-well-pleased-with-him/ accessed 18 July 2025.

b. The Role of Hope: Hope is a way to demonstrate a servant's need for Allah, and to increase one's *iman* (belief) in Allah. Hope is also a way to affirm Allah's Oneness. The philosophy of hope in Islam is based on the idea that hope is a source of light and that Allah shows people how to create hope for lasting bliss in this life and the hereafter. Muslims believe in Allah who is the creator of this Cosmos and who sustains it. Therefore, to hope that Allah will listen to their calls and supplications is deeply rooted in Muslim belief.

c. The Role of Action: Hope is not just wishful thinking, but is accompanied by actions to realise that hope. Someone who hopes but does not take action is considered to be daydreaming. A philosophy of Hope demonstrates the capacity of hope to propel both individuals and the world in a positive direction. When a person hopes for something, he is expecting something desirable or good to happen. He or she is optimistic about his/her future. In difficult times, a person with hope believes there is light at the end of every tunnel. He/she believes that happiness always awaits him.

Norwegian philosopher, Lars Svendsen, in his book *A Philosophy of Hope* convincingly explains how hope offers us the capacity for both imagination and for action. It's a powerful antidote for a wildly pessimistic era such as ours. He argues that hope is rooted in the ability to shape one's own future, crucial for a society built on freedom instead of fear. Svendsen highlights hope's vital role in giving life meaning, and its intimate connection to identity.[8]

Rational hope is based on the trust in God (*tawakkul*) which should be complemented by human endeavour in achieving desired objectives. Trust in God should be complemented by action. When a flood warning is given to a city, it is important that we pray to our Lord to save us and at the same time move out of the city while the time permits. However, there are certain occasions when a human being becomes helpless and is caught unawares. In this situation, prayers are the only source that provides comfort and gives us the courage to face the eventuality boldly. At such situations, Muslims believe that Allah's help comes from unknown sources to take them out of difficult situations. If they are destined to be affected by that eventuality, Muslims believe that they will be rewarded abundantly in their life after death as their prayers will never go unanswered.

d. Supplications: The Prophet advised Muslims to make supplications to request the blessings of health, knowledge, good provision, and righteous progeny. These supplications are an expression of hope in Allah's mercy and grace.

8 Lars Svendsen, *A Philosophy of Hope* (London: Reaktion Books, 2023), 34.

Muslims believe that all their supplications are answered by their Lord. Qur'an says, 'your Lord has ordained, call upon Me, I will accept your supplication' (Sura 40:60). According to Ash Shaikh Mir Asedullah Quadri, all supplications are answered by Allah in four ways: (a) If the supplication is, as per the program of Allah in this Cosmos, and the time is also suitable, the supplication is granted right away. (b) Sometimes the supplications are granted after a delay when the time is appropriate. (c) Sometimes, a better thing is given than the one asked by the servant. (d) If the supplication is not answered in this life, he will be granted it in abundance in life after death.[9]

According to Qur'an and medieval Islamic writings, hope and fear are both single and paired concepts, made up of emotional, cognitive, and behavioural elements. When associated with God, both hope and fear are considered 'praiseworthy.' However, Islam rejects excessive hope and fear, which are considered 'pseudo' types and can lead to self-deceit, despair, and spiritual decline.

5. The Positive Outcomes of Hope in Allah

The word hope in itself has a positive connotation and it encourages us to face whatever difficulties one may face in life. There are many positive outcomes of hope.[10]

a. Hope as a Motivation for Worship

Hope drives one to worship Allah and enables him to do good deeds. The hope of getting a reward and the hope that one can meet Allah in the life after, encourages one to go forward with hopeful heart. It is also a vital component for finding delight and pleasantness in worship. Ibn al-Qayyim writes, "Hope is the caravan leader that spurs one to journey to Allah; it makes the journey more palatable and encourages him to continue going forward and stay on the path. Were it not for hope, no one would take up this journey, for fear alone does not motivate anyone. It is love that motivates, fear that drives, and hope that spurs."[11]

b. Hope as the Essence of *Ubudiyyah* (Servitude to Allah)

Hope makes us turn to Allah at all times and humble ourselves in desperate need, which is the essence of *ubudiyyah*. Hope demonstrates the servant's need for Allah – how he does not rely on himself for even the blink of an eye, but rather places his hope only on Allah. Instead of attaching his hope

9 Ash Shaikh Mir Asedullah Quadri, "The Philosophy of Hope and Optimism and Its Relationship with Faith," *CIFIA Global Journal* 5 (June 2022).

10 Ibn al-Qayyim, "Hoping in Allah," *Life With Allah*, https://lifewithallah.com/articles/the-pure-heart/hope-in-allah/, accessed on 5 July 2024.

11 Ibn al-Qayyim, "Hoping in Allah."

to the world or others, his heart is attached to Allah. Thus, hope increases our *iman* (faith) in Allah, and is a means of affirming His Oneness.

c. Hope as a Means of Attaching the Heart to Allah Alone

The more we hope and receive from Allah that which we hope for, the more our gratitude and love for Allah increases. When we have hope in Allah, we are eagerly waiting for something from Him. This makes us remember Him more often (*dhikr*). Hoping in Allah alone frees us from unhealthy attachments to His creation, who are ultimately weak and will often let us down.

d. Hope as the Driving Force of *Dua* (Asking Help)

Dua is one of the most important acts of worship and it is not possible without hope. Ibn al-Qayyim writes, "The basis of duʿā' is hope. If the person making duʿā' did not hope for his request to be granted, he would not make duʿā.'"[12] Thus, hope is not limited to matters of the hereafter, but also matters of this world, as we have been instructed to make *dua* for everything, including "the strap of the sandal when it breaks" (*Tirmidhi*). Our hope in Him (and not His creation) to fulfil our worldly requests is in fact a strong indication of our belief in Him.

6. How Does one can Attain Hope in Allah?

Islam proposes different ways to attain hope in Allah, by which a believer can have tranquillity and peace of mind in his/her life.

a. Reflecting on Allah's Blessings

Allah is ready to bless his faithful. "Indeed, Allah loves those who rely upon Him" (Sura 3:159). Relying on Him isn't weakness. It's the greatest strength. Reflecting on this, one can hope that Allah will surely bless his faithful because, each and every faithful live by the grace of Allah.

b. Contemplating the Promised Rewards

Qur'an and Hadiths many a times offer amazing rewards which awaits the faithful, who obey the commands of Allah. For example, if one partakes in *jihad* by the act itself one reserves a seat in *jannah* or paradise (Sura 9:21). Constantly reflecting on the recompenses that waits in paradise will help the believer to live in hope always.

c. Meditating on Allah's Mercy and Kindness

Each *Sura* in the Qur'an commence with the statement that Allah is always *rahman* and *rahim* (merciful and benevolent). Imam al-Ghazali beautifully

12 Ibn al-Qayyim, "Hoping in Allah."

says, "Hope is attained through recognising Allah's kindness, His generosity, His comprehensive blessings, and the subtleties of His creation… When one gains certainty (*yaqin*) in Allah's promise of reward, and one becomes aware of His kindness– both of these will undoubtedly lead to attaining hope."[13]

d. Drawing Hope from the Names of Allah

Islam proposes that reflecting on the ninety-nine attributes of Allah one can be in a constant state of hope. Increase your hope in Allah by reflecting on His Names. Reciting the 99 Names of Allah is a powerful form of *dhikr* (remembrance of Allah). It is said that those who regularly recite these names will be granted peace, protection, and a deeper understanding of their faith.

e. Deep Reflection on the Qur'an (*tadabbur*)

Qur'an is the guideline for the spiritual growth of the faithful in Islam, hence a faithful should reflect unceasingly on the Qur'anic verses which convey hope. By doing so one can be in constant touch with the commands of Allah and it will enable him to live in the hope that Allah will guide him in the times of tribulations and difficulties of his life.

According to many scholars, the ayat which inspires the most hope is: "Say, (O Prophet, that Allah says,): O My servants who have transgressed against their souls! Do not lose hope in Allah's mercy, for Allah certainly forgives all sins. He is indeed the All-Forgiving, Most Merciful" (39:53).

7. The Result of Hope

The Qur'an teaches that the result of hope is always excellent. The stories of Qur'an testify this fact. The story of Prophet Yusuf (Joseph) and his father Ya'qub (Jacob) as described in the Qur'an should be vividly present in our minds. "Allah, the Almighty and Exalted be He informed us: "O my sons (said Prophet Ya'qub)! Go and ascertain about Yusuf and his brothers, and despair not of Allah's comfort; verily none despair of the comfort of Allah except a people disbelieving" (Sura 12:87).

The story of Prophet Yusuf (Joseph) and his father Ya'qub (Jacob) as described in the Qur'an should be vividly present in our minds. "Allah, the Almighty and Exalted be He informed us: "O my sons (said Prophet Ya'qub)! Go and ascertain about Yusuf and his brothers, and despair not of Allah's comfort; verily none despair of the comfort of Allah except a people disbelieving" (Sura 12:87).

13 Abū Ḥāmid al-Ghazālī, *On Hope and Fear*, trans. Mohammad Nuri Abdus Salam (New Delhi: Kazi Publications Inc., 2003), 37.

Prophet Musa (Moses) had very high hope in Allah even after the terrified Israelites lamented that they have been overtaken by their enemies. He calmly said: "No! Indeed, with me is my Lord; He will guide me" (Sura 26:62). This means Allah will save us all. Prophet Yunus (Jonah) did not lose hope while in the depth of darkness, the belly of the whale. He cried out loudly to His Creator saying: "There is no deity worthy of worship except You; exalted are You. Indeed, I have been of the wrongdoers" (Sura 21:87). Allah responded to his call immediately and relieved his distress.[14]

Not everyone will be remembered like Yusuf or Musa but the lesson is that Allah has a plan for each of us. We may not comprehend why things happen to us now, but down the line we may look back and recognise that those challenges were necessary to make us a better person. We should look to these Noble Messengers as our role models so as to come out of every tribulation triumphant.

Conclusion

We are living in a scientifically advanced and sophisticated world which is developing at blink-of-an-eye speed. Change is taking place in every realm of life. However, modern humans are unable to sleep in peace and tranquillity in the midst of all types of advancements and facilities or comforts. Unpredicted natural catastrophes and human-made wreckages like terrorism, religious extremism, racism, and gender inequality make human life on earth miserable. However, in the midst of all these problems we all dream or hope for a better future by believing that everything will be okay. The pandemics, all the wars or calamities will be over. There is no lasting vice or evil. The victory will be always with the good and truth. The opposite of night is day, and summer is winter, and it is the inevitability that the summer should come before winter. It is the law of the nature. Likewise, all the disasters and failures will turn to victory and happiness. Let's hope for a better future. Sometimes stress and anxiety can turn into the type of hopelessness in our life and we fall into depression. All religions help us to have faith in God who is the controller and sustainer of the world, and believe that He will help us to overcome all these tribulations. Let's pray optimistically and work together for a better future.

14 Mohamed Abdalla Swaleh, "Message of Hope from the Muslim Chaplaincy," *University of Nairobi Student Life*, https://studentlife.uonbi.ac.ke/latest-news/message-hope-muslim-chaplaincy#:~:text=Technically%2C%20Hope%20is%20that%20element,the%20best%20in%20all%20things, accessed 18 July 2025.

Part III

Practices of Hope: Socio-Political Engagements

14

Hope in the Vision of Jürgen Moltmann

Henry Jose Kodikuthiyil

Abstract

This study examines Jürgen Moltmann's theology of hope, shaped by his experiences of suffering during World War II and his deep engagement with Christian eschatology. At the heart of Moltmann's vision is the conviction that Christian hope is not a denial of present suffering but a forward-looking trust rooted in the resurrection of Jesus Christ. This eschatological hope inspires believers to actively participate in God's redemptive work, seeking justice, healing, and transformation in a broken world. Moltmann's theology affirms the redemptive meaning of suffering through the cross, while proclaiming the victory and renewal of the resurrection. He interprets divine promises not as fixed predictions but as open invitations to shape history in light of God's coming kingdom. His approach challenges secular fatalism and passive resignation, offering a dynamic, future-oriented theology. However, this study also critically engages Moltmann's controversial ideas—such as the suffering of God and his optimistic view of progress—which some argue diverge from classical theological traditions and lack methodological clarity. Despite these criticisms, Moltmann's work powerfully reorients Christian faith toward active engagement with the

world, grounded in the expectation of God's final redemption. His theology remains a vital resource for contemporary Christianity, calling believers to live with courage, purpose, and hope.

Keywords: *Christian Eschatology, Contemporary Christian Thought, Divine Promises, Jürgen Moltmann, Resurrection, Suffering and Redemption, Theology of Hope.*

Introduction

The passing of Jürgen Moltmann on 3 June 2024 marked the end of an era in contemporary Christian theology. Widely regarded as one of the most influential Protestant theologians of the late 20th and early 21st centuries, Moltmann's thought continues to shape theological discourse across the globe. Deeply impacted by the horrors of war and inspired by Ernst Bloch, the Marxist philosopher of hope, Moltmann pioneered a theology of hope in the early 1960s that offered a radical reimagining of Christian eschatology.[1] His work emerged as a beacon of light in a world darkened by suffering, injustice, and despair.

This paper seeks to explore the central place of hope in Moltmann's theological vision. First, it examines how Moltmann articulated hope in the context of a world torn by war and violence. Second, it delves into his distinctive contribution to the Christian understanding of hope, particularly as grounded in the resurrection of Christ. Finally, the paper offers a critical evaluation of Moltmann's theology of hope, acknowledging both its groundbreaking insights and its contested aspects. Through this exploration, the paper aims to understand the enduring relevance of Moltmann's message for a world still in search of healing and redemption.

1. Hope in a World of War and Violence

Jürgen Moltmann, born on April 8, 1926, in Hamburg, Germany, is a prominent theologian renowned for founding the theological perspective known as "Theology of Hope." His intellectual journey was profoundly shaped by his experiences as a German soldier during World War II and

1 Ryan A. Neal observes: "While Moltmann credits Bloch for revealing the Bible's hope orientation, and also the fact that humanity is essentially utopia-minded, believing in a perfect world and anticipating the future with undying hope, it is a matter of difference between Bloch and Moltmann that shows the true nature of his hope at this early stage and reveals its inadequacies. A central difference between Bloch's conception of hope and Moltmann's is that, while Bloch's hope has a 'precarious nature,' Moltmann's does not, because the future fulfillment of the victory of the resurrection is a guaranteed certainty." Ryan A. Neal, *Theology as Hope: On the Ground and the Implications of Jürgen Moltmann's Doctrine of Hope* (Eugene, OR: Wipf and Stock Publishers, 2008), e-book.

subsequent imprisonment as a prisoner of war.[2] These harrowing experiences led him to a deep engagement with Christian theology, driving him to seek answers to human suffering and the hope for a better future. Moltmann's academic career includes influential tenures at the University of Tübingen, where he became a major voice in contemporary theology. His works, characterised by their integration of eschatological promise with present-day faith, continue to inspire and challenge both theological scholars and lay readers alike, situating him as a vital figure in the development of 20th and 21st century Christian thought.

How, then, does Moltmann understand hope? Hope, he argues, is the active expectation that God will heal and transform the world. Hope does not mean the denial of suffering or injustice, nor does it mean that human beings are able to heal creation apart from God's gracious empowerment. Rather, hope is based in what God has promised to do in the future, and it calls us to witness to those promises in actions of healing and justice in the present. When we are tempted to lose heart because of all we see in the present, we are called to remember the future that God has promised and press forward in hope.[3]

The truth of doctrinal statements is found in the fact that they can be shown to agree with the existing reality which we can all experience. Hope's statements of promise, however, must stand in contradiction to the reality which can at present be experienced. They do not result from experiences, but are the condition for the possibility of new experiences. They do not seek to illuminate the reality which exists, but the reality which is coming. They do not seek to make a mental picture of existing reality, but to lead existing reality towards the promised and hoped-for transformation. They do not seek to bear the train of reality, but to carry the torch before it.'[4]

2 Moltmann testifies thus: "In the last week of July 1943, Hamburg was destroyed in a firestorm as a result of the British Royal Air Force's 'Operation Gomorrah.' Forty thousand people perished. With my school class I was in a flak battery in the inner city as an auxiliary. It was wiped out, but the bombs which tore away the schoolfriend standing next to me spared me. In the night, for the first time I cried out to God. 'My God, where are you?' was my question. 'Why am I alive and not dead like the others?' During three years as a prisoner of war I looked for an answer, first in the Old Testament psalms of lamentation and then in the Gospel of Mark. When I came to Jesus' dying cry, I knew, 'There is your divine brother and redeemer, who understands you in your godforsakenness.'" Jürgen Moltmann, *How I Have Changed: Reflections on Thirty Years of Theology*, ed. Jürgen Moltmann, trans. John Bowden (London: SCM Press, 1997), 13.

3 Jürgen Moltmann, *Theology of Hope*: *On the Ground and the Implications of a Christian Eschatology* (London: SCM Press, 1967), 15.

4 Moltmann, *Theology of Hope*, 18.

The central theme of *Theology of Hope* is promise. The Christian faith is lived, Moltmann argues, in witness to the promises of a God who can and will make all things right. These promises are offered most clearly in the passion, death, and resurrection of Jesus Christ. Moltmann recognises that our present experience seems out of alignment with the future that God will bring to creation. When this experience tempts us to flee from the world in passive resignation, the cross reminds us that we are not alone in our suffering. Just as the young Moltmann found strength to press forward when he read about the God who encounters us on the cross, so also we are called toward a new future — even as the world is not what it should be.[5]

The concept of hope in the vision of Moltmann is not that of a transitory hope directed to different, not mutually connected aspects of life. The concept of hope corresponds to the mental attitude of the individual who receives God's promise of the resurrection from the dead and of the coming of the new kingdom. Hope becomes and is therefore the constitutive disposition of the individual considering reality, its direction, and its sense. A promise is a declaration which announces the coming of a reality that does not yet exist. Thus, promise sets man's heart on a future history in which the fulfilling of the promise is to be expected.[6]

2. The Christian Understanding of Hope

According to Moltmann, "The Christian hope for the future comes of observing a specific, unique event—that of the resurrection, and appearing of Jesus Christ." Thus, for him the resurrection is "the ground, power and goal of hope."[7]

In his exploration of hope, Moltmann views the cross and resurrection of Jesus Christ as the quintessential events that provide a foundation for Christian hope. The suffering and death of Jesus on the cross represent the profound depths of human despair, alienation, and suffering, yet they are not the final word. It is in the resurrection that hope finds its most powerful expression. The resurrection of Jesus is the ultimate declaration that death, suffering, and evil do not have the last say; rather, God's power to bring new life and redemption triumphs.[8]

For Moltmann, the cross is not primarily a symbol of defeat but a profound moment of identification where Christ aligns himself with human suffering. Christ's suffering on the cross reveals a God who is present in the midst of human agony, one who suffers alongside humanity. This event

5 Moltmann, *Theology of Hope*, 15–30.

6 Moltmann, *Theology of Hope*, 103.

7 Moltmann, *Theology of Hope*, 194.

8 Moltmann, *Theology of Hope*, 194–196.

demonstrates God's deep solidarity and love for the world, offering a powerful message that God does not abandon creation in its moment of greatest need. Instead, God enters into the very depths of suffering to bring about a future of hope and renewal. However, the cross alone would be insufficient to foster genuine hope without the resurrection. The resurrection signifies the definitive victory over death and the inauguration of a new creation. It is the pivotal event that guarantees the fulfilment of God's promises. In the resurrection, believers are given a foretaste of the eschatological future, where new life triumphs over death and the kingdom of God is ultimately established. This ultimate promise provides the assurance that the struggles and sufferings of the present are not meaningless but are connected to the transformative power of God's future.[9]

Understanding suffering and redemption through the lens of hope shifts the perspective from mere endurance to an active, forward-looking anticipation. It encourages believers to see their own suffering in the context of the larger narrative of redemption that God is weaving through history. The story of Christ's suffering and resurrection becomes a template for how God's redemptive power works. Redemption is not an abstract concept; it is deeply rooted in the concrete reality of Christ's own experience of suffering and triumph. Moreover, the resurrection as the ultimate promise challenges the community of believers to live in a state of active hope, continually expecting God's future intervention and transformation. It calls for a commitment to justice, peace, and reconciliation as reflections of the future kingdom. This anticipatory living is not passive but is characterised by actions that embody the values of God's promised future in the present. Believers are called to be agents of hope in a world marked by despair, taking part in God's redemptive mission. In sum, Moltmann's theology of hope is deeply anchored in the events of the cross and resurrection.[10]

Jürgen Moltmann introduces a profound exploration of the concept of promise as it is presented in the Bible and how these divine promises shape both history and human existence. Moltmann asserts that biblical promises are not mere predictions of future events but are dynamic declarations that engage humanity in a transformative relationship with God. These promises, grounded in the narrative of God's faithfulness, reveal a teleological perspective where history is seen as a purposeful journey toward fulfilment. Moltmann delves into the scriptural foundation of divine promises, particularly focusing on the Old Testament covenants with

9 Moltmann, *Theology of Hope*, 194–196. *See also* Jürgen Moltmann, *The Crucified God: The Cross of Christ as the Foundation and Criticism of Christian Theology*, trans. R. A. Wilson and John Bowden (London: SCM Press; New York: Harper & Row, 1974).

10 Moltmann, *Theology of Hope*, 194–196.

figures such as Abraham, Moses, and David. These covenants are marked by God's commitment to His people, outlining a future filled with hope and redemption. Through these promises, God establishes a framework within which history unfolds, providing humanity with direction and purpose. This divine-human interaction characterised by promise compels believers to live in anticipation, shaping their actions and outlook toward a future grounded in God's fidelity. The significance of promise in biblical theology lies in its capacity to create a horizon of hope. Unlike deterministic philosophies of history that view the unfolding of events as predestined or purely random, biblical promises invite active participation and trust in God's unfolding plan. Moltmann emphasises that divine promises introduce a sense of linear progress in history, where each moment is pregnant with potential and meaning, directed toward an ultimate fulfilment. In contrast to other philosophical concepts of history—such as those proposed by secular historicism or existentialism, which often view history as a cyclical process or an absurd progression without inherent purpose—the biblical notion of promise infuses history with divine intentionality.

Moltmann critiques these secular notions for their inability to account for the transformative power of hope, which is essential in navigating the realities of human existence. Where secular philosophies may succumb to nihilism or fatalism in the face of historical crises, the promise-infused view of history offers resilience and a forward-looking hope. Moltmann argues that the concept of promise reorients human existence from a retrospective analysis of the past to a prospective expectation of the future. This future-oriented stance encourages believers to engage with the present not as a static moment but as a dynamic intersection between past promises and future fulfilment. The divine promises, therefore, do not merely serve as future projections but actively shape lived experiences and ethical choices in the present.[11]

Furthermore, Moltmann discusses how divine promises challenge the status quo by providing a vision that transcends current realities. The hope engendered by promises encourages a critical perspective on existing social, political, and economic structures, urging believers to work toward a more just and compassionate world. Biblical promises, thus, become catalysts for positive change, empowering individuals and communities to envision and enact a reality that reflects divine intentions for humanity. Ultimately, Moltmann presents the relationship between promise and history as foundational to understanding the transformative power of hope in Christian theology. By anchoring history in the fidelity of God's promises, believers are invited to participate in a narrative that is both divinely orchestrated and

11 Moltmann, *Theology of Hope*, 194–196.

dynamically lived out. This perspective not only enriches the theological discourse but also instils a profound sense of purpose and anticipation in the life of faith. The promises of God, therefore, are not remnants of an ancient text but living words that continue to shape and guide the unfolding of history toward divine fulfillment.[12]

3. A Critique on Moltmann's Theological Vision of Hope

Moltmann's theology of hope develops from his own personal experience of sharing with God the experience of suffering abandonment, isolation, and absorbs his own identity and God's. His experience of suffering with God who suffers defines God's experience on the terms of his experience, and that experience resonates with a broad societal sense of loss. In this account, divine experience is close enough to human experience that it can be shared and understood as a shared experience. Moltmann explains that "if a person once feels the infinite passion of God's love which finds expression here, then he understands the mystery of the triune God. God suffers with us—God suffers from us—God suffers for us: it is this experience of God that reveals the true God."[13]

Long years after the publication of *Theology of Hope*, Moltmann realised the failures of hopes. In 1985 he wrote: "at the beginning of the 1960s, we were convinced and enthused by hope in action, an active, militant hope, which could ally itself with the friendly tendencies in the world process, in the realm of unlimited possibilities, to lead to success." Besides the cultural changes occurring around the globe another significant feature of this period is his concerted efforts to mingle the importance of the future and the resurrection with the importance of the cross.[14] It has also been observed that

> by his own confession Moltmann intends his theology to be "biblically founded, eschatologically oriented, and politically responsible." However, his methodology is somewhat more complex. In fact, there is reason to doubt whether he has a coherent theological method in any traditional sense. This lack of systematic approach arises partly from his lack of interest in correct doctrine (…) He sees the task of theology not so much as

12 Moltmann, *Theology of Hope*, 194–196.

13 Margrit B. Adam, "A Hope Diminished: Limitations of a Moltmannian Theology of Hope," *Pro Ecclesia: A Journal of Catholic and Evangelical Theology* 21, no. 4 (2012): 355.

14 Neal, *Theology as Hope: On the Ground and the Implications of Jürgen Moltmann's Doctrine of Hope*.

> to provide an interpretation of the world as to transform it in the light of hope for its ultimate transformation by God.[15]

Scholars are of the opinion that Moltmannian hope elides eschatological hope with the modern, secular model of hope in steady improvement. His hope readily sets aside wisdoms of the past in favour of the new and contemporary relevance. While other eras looked to the past for affirmation and authorisation, Moltmannian hope detaches itself from what it understands to be out dated and mistaken theology of hope offered by the classical tradition. The particular character of modern newness embraced by Moltmannian hope entails an ever-developing, new-and-improved version of the present.[16]

"Christian hope is not founded on the isolated event of Jesus' resurrection . . Cross and resurrection therefore inseparably belong together and interpret each other." According to Moltmann, Christian theology must go further; it discerns in the crucified Christ the deepest abyss of God-forsakenness and hopelessness on earth. But it also believes in Easter. . . . Out of the humiliated, poor, and abandoned Jesus who was crucified in disgrace, God makes his Messiah of the future, of freedom, and of life."[17]

The relationship between the cross and his doctrine of hope is made explicit, not merely in emphasis, but rather the ground has been arguably reconceived: "Jesus' resurrection is only indirectly, but the meaning of his cross is directly, the foundation of the Christian hope for justice and life." Indeed, Moltmann is now ensuring that together cross and resurrection ground hope. It has been observed that Moltmann turns away from the human and divinely redemptive suffering of Jesus Christ and instead places God and people together as those who suffer.[18] In this context, Thomas G. Weinandy's argument is noteworthy. As he writes:

> Those who espouse a suffering God often fail to perceive the richness of the Christian experience of human suffering, nor do they appreciate the depth of the Christian response to human suffering. Moreover, they do not fully grasp the glory embodied and the virtue expressed within the Christian account of suffering. They rightfully comprehend the immense suffering which evil causes. However, they frequently limit the meaning of suffering to that of merely being the suffering of a passive victim of grave injustice and evil. Having limited the meaning of such suffering to that of a passive victim, they attempt to compensate for its now seeming 'meaninglessness' by espousing a God who suffers in solidarity with the victim. This co-suffering of God with the suffering victim is intended to engender hope and consolation. At times one feels that what they wish is a God who feels sorry for them because of their plight - a God who authenticates and justifies their self-pity. Actually, such a view, as the above demonstrates, radically diminishes the salvific significance of Christ's redemptive suffering and so the import of his body, as the whole church and as individual members within it, which actively co-suffers with him for its own sanctification and for humankind's well-being and salvation.[19]

15 As quoted in Adam, "A Hope Diminished: Limitations of a Moltmannian Theology of Hope," 352.

16 Adam, "A Hope Diminished: Limitations of a Moltmannian Theology of Hope," 354.

17 Neal, *Theology as Hope: On the Ground and the Implications of Jürgen Moltmann's Doctrine of Hope*.

18 Adam, "A Hope Diminished: Limitations of a Moltmannian Theology of Hope," 362.

Conclusion

Jürgen Moltmann revolutionises contemporary Christian thought by presenting a vision of theology anchored in the future promise of God's kingdom rather than in the static doctrines of the past. He articulates that the essence of Christianity lies in its forward-looking perspective, which invigorates faith with the dynamic power of hope. This hope is not a passive or abstract wish but an active, transformative force that compels believers to engage with the world and work toward justice and renewal. By reimagining the role of eschatology, Moltmann shifts the focus from resignation to expectation, inviting readers to embrace a vibrant, life-affirming theology that breathes optimism and purpose into the human journey and challenges us to see the world not as it is, but as it can be. Moltmann helps us rediscover how Christian hope can become a driving force for change and a profound source of spiritual vitality. Through his vision of hope, Moltmann has opened new vistas of thought in Christian theology. Now it is our task to unearth and reinterpret the vast potentialities inherent in his splendid vision. The spirit of Moltmann continues to challenge us today to go beyond the boundaries of traditional Christian theology and to make Christian faith more dynamic and relevant to the modern world, so that people may see "the new heaven and the new earth" (Revelation 21:1).

19 Thomas G. Weinandy, *Does God Suffer?* (Notre Dame, IN: University of Notre Dame Press, 2000), 281.

15

Hope for the Subaltern
Dr Ambedkar–Gandhi Complementarity

Varan Vardhan

Abstract

This paper explores the complementarity between Dr B. R. Ambedkar and M. K. Gandhi in their respective Dalit emancipatory methodologies, despite their oppositional constructs. Dr Ambedkar's approach, rooted in methodological separatism, emphasised preferential treatment, self-empowerment, and the eradication of caste oppression through constitutional safeguards and religious conversion. Gandhi, on the other hand, sought Dalit liberation through change of heart, non-violence, and the organic integration of Dalits within Hindu society. Their diametrically opposite stances on issues such as separate electorates and varna-caste dynamics have historically been framed as conflicting. However, this paper argues that their differences should be celebrated rather than viewed as mere opposition. Gandhian persuasion and Ambedkarean assertion are not mutually exclusive but differential, forming a yin-yang interplay that is necessary for true Dalit emancipation. The already and not-yet aspect of their methodologies reveals the hope for the subaltern, as the synergy of their approaches provides a holistic strategy for Dalit liberation. Instead of seeking to annihilate these differences,

this paper capitalises on their interrelationship, presenting their contributions as complementary flames lighting the pitch-dark path towards equality, liberty, and fraternity.

Keywords: *Ambedkar-Gandhi Complementarity, Change of Heart, Dalit Emancipation, Dalit Self-Empowerment, Hope for the Subaltern, Methodological Separatism, Oppositional Constructs, Preferential Treatment, Varna-Caste Question, Yet-to-come*.

Introduction

The plight of the subalterns of India, the Dalits, is still in want of sincere attention and salient emancipation. The more the efforts of their empowerment have substantiated the need for the trio of liberty, fraternity and equality in the country, equally stronger have the counter-effects of casteism, oppression and inequality taken root. Such situation is blatant in the recent past, given the innumerable atrocities against the Dalits all over the country. The past decade has solidified the age-old caste culture among the minds of the citizens due to the political reasons associated with its social repercussions. This solidification raises the necessity of an imminent expectation of the long-awaited liberation for these subalterns, a hope for the oppressed.

The word 'Hope' in the Jubilee 2025 motto 'Pilgrims of Hope' is profoundly laden with meaning and activism. It is presumably the inspiration for the prime theme of this seminar: HOPE: Philosophizing from Multi-horizons. Hope can be understood both theologically and secularly; by its strong insistence of its eschatological significance, making it theological, and also equally secular by its practical dimension of the expectancy and the resulting activism. "Like a flame my hope is burning…"—the opening lyrics of the Jubilee hymn uses the imagery of the light which lightens up the path towards the future. It is such a flame that hope opens up the future for the subalterns who are awaiting justice, making all of us the pilgrims of such a hope.

This paper on the 'Hope for the subaltern,' though can be applied to all the subaltern in general, delineates itself to the Dalit subalterns of our subcontinent. An engagement with the Dalit terminology cannot but incite the name of Dr B. R. Ambedkar, who himself being a Dalit, was the champion of the Dalits by strenuously working for their uplift and working out a way out for the removal of their scar of untouchability. The very mention of Dr Ambedkar in connection with Dalit upliftment necessarily connotes another

important personality, M. K. Gandhi, who as a mass leader, had greatly contributed towards the emancipation of Dalits.

Gandhi and Dr Ambedkar were committed to the cause of Dalit liberation in their own respective styles and approaches, with several differences in their ideology, methodology and approaches. Their approaches were sometimes conflicting too and thus constructed as well oppositional. It is true that there were a lot of oppositional pointers between them even during their life-time. But those oppositional characteristics grew into two streams of thought and ideology soon after them and continue to persist even today. Both these camps are engaged with in diametrically opposite ways to the extent of branding Gandhi as "the enemy of the Dalits,"[1] in follow-up of Dr Ambedkar's own words.

This paper wishes to capitalise on the creative power of their oppositional engagement with regard to the question of Dalit emancipation, treating them as complementary, as any complementarity is primarily rooted in opposition and differences. Such complementary treatment of these two important personalities of Dalit liberation is in fact the flame of a small candle to lighten up the pilgrimage along the pitch-dark path of emancipation and equality.

This paper is divided into three parts to accomplish the task of arriving at their complementarity. Firstly, it tries to unfurl the Dalit emancipatory methodologies of these two leaders. The second part tries to unravel their oppositional engagement during their Dalit emancipatory project. The last part illuminates the new path of their complementarity for effective Dalit emancipation, thus becoming the hope for the subalterns.

1. Dalit Emancipatory Methodologies of Dr Ambedkar and Gandhi

1.1. Dr Ambedkar's Dalit Emancipatory Methodology

Dr Ambedkar had a steadfast commitment to the realisation of a final goal – the ideal of realising the trinitarian union of three ideals of equality, liberty and fraternity, which when lived would give way to an ideal society with justice as its cornerstone.[2] Such a just ideal society, while being directly opposed to the singular, fabricated, Hindu identity, entails a culturally and historically diverse identity.[3] This is his commitment for an Indian nationalism with a vision for the country in which all citizens are protected by its Constitution,

1 B. R. Ambedkar, "What Congress and Gandhi have Done to the Untouchables," (First published 1945), *Dr. Babasaheb Ambedkar Writings and Speeches*, Vol. 9, 261.

2 B. R. Ambedkar, "Philosophy of Hinduism," *Dr. Babasaheb Ambedkar Writings and Speeches*, Vol. 3, 25.

3 He substantiates this in his works *Philosophy of Hinduism* and *The Hindu Social Order (Dr. Babasaheb Ambedkar Writings and Speeches*, Vol. 3).

which will be the yardstick for justice.[4] According to him, such an ideal would be realised not by a notional and nominal equality for all citizens per se, but by the preferential option for the most-affected, i.e., the Dalits.[5] This preferential treatment granted even by the Constitution[6] and a self-imbibed methodological separatism[7] of the Dalits from the totalitarian Hindu identity would truly bring about real rectification of their downtrodden status.

With such philosophical foundation of the preferential option for the Dalits as a basis for his emancipatory praxis, Dr Ambedkar had a unique and novel methodology for their liberation. It is his philosophy of methodological separatism, as known by his multiplicity of separatist engagements with the oppressive system. He envisioned various separatisms for the Dalit masses such as social, linguistic, territorial, economic, educational, political and religious. Such a methodology of separateness of the Dalits did not rise all of a sudden. It had its own time and process as he tried various efforts within Hinduism, failure of which had compelled him to move away from it, thus to validly emancipate the Dalits. As the oppression caused mainly due to the tyranny of one section of the society namely the Brahminical, with caste system as their master key, coupled with the religious sanction of the *varna* system, this radical method of separatism allowed him to envision the total destruction of the whole structure of caste and its variety of roots, showing a lead by radically walking out of it by his conversion to Buddhism along with many other Dalits. This unique methodology of dissent must be appraised only in the perspective of the ideal society he had envisaged, failing which would characterize it to be destructive and flawed. Separatism as a method for realising the ideals of coexistence, endosmosis and community mode of living,[8] may seem contradictory and counter-productive too. This precisely is the uniqueness and distinctiveness of Dr Ambedkar's method of Dalit emancipation. This ought to be appreciated in the light of its final effect of

4 A. M. Rajasekhariah, *B. R. Ambedkar: The Politics of Emancipation* (Bombay: Sindhu Publications Private Ltd., 1971), 26–29.

5 Eleanor Zelliot, *Ambedkar's World: The Making of Babasaheb and the Dalit Movement* (New Delhi: Navayana Publishing Pvt Ltd, 2004), 107.

6 Marc Galanter, ""Protective discrimination" for Backward Classes in India," *Journal of the Indian Law Institute* 3, no. 1 (1961): 41; Marc Galanter, "The "compensatory discrimination" theme in the Indian commitment to human rights," *India International Centre Quarterly* 13, no. 3/4 (December 1986): 92.

7 Soumyabrata Choudhury names the Dalit emancipatory praxis of Dr Ambedkar as 'methodological separatism.' Please ref. Soumyabrata Choudhury, *Ambedkar and Other Immortals: An Untouchable Research Programme* (New Delhi: Navayana, 2018), 33.

8 These are some of the terms Dr Ambedkar used to signify fluidity of communications between social groups. Cf. B. R. Ambedkar, *Annihilation of Caste: The Annotated Critical Edition* (New Delhi: Navayana Publishing Pvt. Ltd.: 2014), 260.

Dalit liberation and thus leading to a life of equality and fraternity with the rest of the Indian fold.

1.2. Gandhian Approach Towards Dalit Liberation

Dalit liberation in the style of M. K. Gandhi is characteristically different from that of Dr Ambedkar, with a strong theoretical base for his profound Dalit activism. His thought could be organised into the traditional three-fold philosophical understanding of reality viz. world, self, and the divine. His conception of the world as the *advaitic* non-duality[9] of the whole creation setting up the platform for fraternity, aims at organic unification of the Dalits with the rest of the population. His conception of the self with the individual's autonomy and perfectibility[10] forming the strong basis for liberty, aims at the 'change of heart' of the oppressing population coupled with the liberative praxis of Dalits. And, his conception of the divine with his characteristic philosophy of truth-nonviolence duo[11] as the stronghold for equality, proclaims the ultimate equality of all humans especially the Dalits with the rest of the population. We can find that the Ambedkarean triad of liberty, equality and fraternity finds resonance in Gandhian counterparts. He had a vision of *sarvodaya* or 'welfare of all' to form the basis for *swaraj* (self-rule) along with *swadeshi* or 'self-reliance.'[12] *Sarvodaya* would be a mere blind notion of welfare of all in the country without its necessary corollary, the *antyodaya*, the welfare of the least and the last.[13] This is similar to the Ambedkarean 'preferential treatment of the unequals.' The welfare of the least and the last who are none other than the Dalits of the Indian population is a core philosophy of Gandhian liberative praxis.

With such theoretical basis, Gandhian praxis of Dalit liberation could be categorised into three phases of his life. The first preparatory stage (up to his South African activism) has a few markers towards his pro-Dalit perspective, with plenty of instances indicating such outlook in his South

9 *See* Glyn Richards, "Gandhi's Concept of Truth and the Advaita Tradition," *Religious Studies* 22, no. 1 (1986), 1–14.

10 *See* Raghavan N. Iyer, *The Moral and Political Thought of Mahatma Gandhi* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2000), 95.

11 *See* A. Pushparajan, "Gandhi's Trans-religious Concept of God," *Romancing the Sacred? Towards an Indian Christian Philosophy of Religion,* ed. George Karuvelil (Bangalore: ATC, 2007), 401–402.

12 *See* Stephen Murphy, *Why Gandhi is Relevant in Modern India: A Western Gandhian's Personal Discovery* (New Delhi: The Gandhi Peace Foundation & Hyderabad: The Academy of Gandhian Studies, 1990), 26.

13 *See* Naresh Dadhich, "The Postmodern Discourse on Gandhi: Modernity and Truth," in *Philosophy of Mahatma Gandhi for the Twenty-First Century,* ed. Douglas Allen (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2009), 195.

African activism[14] before returning to India in 1916, the starting of the second phase. In the second phase of his activism, he strategically ordained himself as ultra-orthodox with various pro-*varna* and pro-caste camouflages,[15] thus to get recognised by the Hindu orthodoxy who otherwise would have rejected his ideas as erratic and frantic. He tried to convince the oppressive population—the caste Hindus—to understand the Dalit reality, to purge themselves of the sin of untouchability and for their change of heart towards Dalit acceptance. He stressed equally on the oppressed population—the Dalits—to come up in life by emphasising equal rights in schooling and temple entry for them. But the third phase which would be after the Poona Pact, opened his eyes[16] to the hard-heartedness of the orthodoxy in accepting the Dalits, thus propelling him for radical Dalit liberative measures and uplift. He attempted uplift of Dalits by various methods as education, financial help, political power, constitutional protection, compulsory temple entry and reservation too. He called for the change of heart of the caste Hindus calling for an 'end of caste,' unification of *varnas*, inter-dining with the Dalits and even inter-marriage with them—to the extent of making Dalit intermarriage compulsory and obligatory, towards the end of his life. It reached its climax by inviting all Hindus to be as only one *varna* which is to be *Harijan-varna*,[17] making all Hindus be called the Dalits—exhibiting his own unique way of integration of the Hindu society in particular and the whole of the country people in general.

Gandhi's Dalit activism is to be understood in an evolutionary model,[18] alongside the signs of his times, growing participation cum interaction with the Dalit reality of India and his differential engagement with Dr Ambedkar. He moved from an ultra-orthodox mode to a hyper-radical style. It was a slow, steady, pre-meditated and strategic process from the side of Gandhi

14 A. Pushparajan opines that Gandhi worked for the Indian Dalits in South Africa during his 21 years of stay there. Cf. A. Pushparajan, "Gandhi and Ambedkar: Befriending the Other Respectfully," *Gandhi Marg* 38, no. 3&4 (October 2016 – March 2017): 274.

15 Nishikant Kolge, *Gandhi Against Caste* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2017), 113, 127–131 & 140–143.

16 Jad Adams argues the Poona Pact as the turning point for Gandhi's struggle against untouchability. *See* Jad Adams, *Gandhi: The True man Behind Modern India* (New York: Pegasus Books, 2011), 206.

17 Gandhi called it as '*Harijan varna*.' Ref. M. K. Gandhi, "Foreword to "*Varnavyavastha*"," May 31, 1945, as found in *The Collected Works of Mahatma Gandhi,* Vol. LXXX, 222–224.

18 Dennis Dalton and Nishikant Kolge have contributed to this field of understanding Gandhian evolving strategy towards *varna,* caste and untouchability. Ref. Dennis Dalton, "The Gandhian view of caste, and caste after Gandhi," in *India and Ceylon: Unity and Diversity, A Symposium*, ed. Philip Mason (London: Oxford University Press, 1967), 167; Kolge, *Gandhi Against Caste*, 101.

to make the oppressing population know their sin of oppression and thus liberating the oppressed. It is a two-pronged process: the removal of the oppressive clutches and the empowerment of the oppressed. But such intense activism intensified the orthodoxy's enmity on Gandhi, especially of the Brahmin-minority, culminating in the intensification through his assassination by one of them, masterminded by a few others—perhaps master-planned by an organisation itself. This dreadful act of vengeance by the orthodoxy on Gandhi—who was the disruptive force of Hinduism—is itself a strong proof of his avid Dalit activism, wishing to change the Hindu religion upside down, which was ultimately the dream project of Dr Ambedkar himself.

2. The Oppositional Construct Between Gandhian and Ambedkarean Approaches

Gandhi and Dr Ambedkar had been champions of Dalit liberation in their own ways. Both were valid ways and approaches, given to each one's core beliefs, ideologies, vision, and theoretical framework. But the ways and methods were so divergent to the extent that they were oppositional to one another. There are two principal issues in respect of which they manifested their diametrically opposite standpoints. These are: (1) the issue of separate electorates for the Dalits and (2) the issue of *varna* and caste. The first is blatantly visible in the controversies in which they were involved. The second is rather the worldview which prompted them to take up the stand they took. They represent two axes along which all of their praxis-attempts and the theoretical constructs can be measured on which they were diametrically opposed to each other in their perspective and programme of action.

2.1. The Issue of Separate Electorates for the Dalits

Oppositional stance between Gandhi and Dr Ambedkar manifested itself soon after the First Round Table Conference Gandhi which did not attend and Dr Ambedkar had staunchly demanded separate electorates for the Dalits. Dr Ambedkar's demand for separate electorates has a history by itself. With the starting of his political career, soon after his education abroad, he had proposed special representation for the Dalits in the Bombay Legislative Assembly while presenting his testimony before the Southborough Committee in 1919. Before the Simon Commission in 1928, his proposal was for the Dalits of the whole of India and that too for reserved seats, while arguing against separate electorates as it would divide the nation. In the All-India Depressed Classes Congress at Nagpur held on August 8 & 9, 1930, he had gathered other Dalit leaders and groups to decide on their proposal in the First Round Table Conference to which he was nominated by the British

as a representative. Here too, they had decided upon joint electorates with reserved seats. But during the First Round Table Conference, his position changed from joint electorates to separate electorates, in line with the Muslim representatives who claimed separate electorates.[19] It is due to his staunch extreme position during this Conference, that Gandhi had decided to attend the Second Round Table Conference which formally started their disagreements.

In the Second Round Table Conference, Gandhi and Dr Ambedkar stood at loggerheads over the issue of Dalit separate electorates, with Gandhi pledging to oppose it with his life and Dr Ambedkar firmly insisting on its necessity. Gandhi felt that separate electorates would eternally separate the Dalits from the rest of the Hindus. Dr Ambedkar had felt its utmost need for the political empowerment of the Dalits, thus to be politically assertive in the wake of their oppression. With the British playing in between this by the announcement of the Communal Award, followed by Gandhi's fast unto death and the subsequent Poona Pact, the oppositional stance between Gandhi and Dr Ambedkar had almost solidified.

Issues erupted again after the 1937 elections which went with the reserved seats for Dalits and not their separate electorates, amounting which Dr Ambedkar felt that the former was the reason behind the failure in elections and the latter would have been politically more beneficial for the Dalits. It is thus after this period Dr Ambedkar's abject criticism on the Congress and especially on Gandhi arose to full swing. Dr Ambedkar wrote two books (*Mr. Gandhi and the Emancipation of the Untouchables*, in 1943, and *What Congress and Gandhi Have Done to the Untouchables*, in 1945) attacking Gandhi-Congress duo. From the Congress side was written a book *Ambedkar Refuted* in December 1945, which attempted to highlight the darker side of separate electorates and the brighter side of joint electorates. Further, Dr Ambedkar wanted to make use of the British before they could leave the country to get Dalit separate electorates, which became impossible due to the Partition.

Dr Ambedkar's dream of separate electorates for the Dalits waned in due course of time, even as he tried to push it hard in Nehru's Cabinet as the Law Minister after the Independence. He had announced in October 1955 as stated in *The Times of India* that the time has come to demand the abolition of reserved seats for the Dalits and also for forming a new political party.[20] Thus he chose the path of religious conversion, about which he had announced already in 1935 in the Yeola Conference, but actualised 20

19 Eleanor Zelliot, *From Untouchable to Dalit: Essays on the Ambedkar Movement* (New Delhi: Manohar Publishers, 2001), 61.

20 Zelliot, *From Untouchable to Dalit,* 198.

years after, i.e., in October 1956. The next month itself he started a new political party, The Republican Party with aims and objectives in line with the Preamble of the Constitution. Unfortunately, within a week of starting it, he died on December 6, 1956, with which the claim of separate electorates died too.

2.2. The Issue of Varna and Caste

The issue of *varna* and caste is the most crucial oppositional pointer between Gandhi and Dr Ambedkar. The issue of separate electorates paved the way for their oppositional stance regarding *varna* and caste. This second opposition was actually of Ambedkar's on Gandhi given to the latter's orthodoxy disguise which he had put on during his second phase Dalit activism.

During the second phase of his activism starting from his return from South Africa upto the Poona Pact, Gandhi put on an ultra-orthodox camouflage, claiming his 'sanatani-ness' first time of his life in the age of 46.[21] Gandhi could be found to be hyper-orthodox with regard to the question of *varna* and caste during this period. Dr Ambedkar, while accusing Gandhi of upholding the *varna* system and thus the casteism too in two of his major works viz. *Annihilation of Caste,* 1936, and *What Congress and Gandhi Have Done to the Untouchables*, 1943, and in several other articles too, was reacting to Gandhi's position only from this facade of orthodoxy of Gandhi. Actually, we can find that Gandhi had shown much of an evolutionary approach in addressing the *varna*-caste question, thus having a strategy to address the issue. He had opted to first acquire the reputation of orthodoxy, by which he would be able to carry on with more liberal and radical reforms gradually and evolutionally.[22] Despite his orthodoxy camouflage during this phase, he did not falter to criticise Hinduism of its practices, customs and observances, even to declare non-belief of its *Shastras* if they support such inhuman practices and inequality.[23] His approach started with a reformist tone to save Hinduism of its excrescent and ugly practices of untouchability.

While during the second phase, Gandhi showed a tremendous strategic evolutionary process of his thoughts on *varna*-caste issue from an ultra-orthodox position to liberal one, the third phase is signified by a further evolution cum strategy towards radical position. The radicalism involved in this phase could be traced to the crucial encounter with Dr Ambedkar

21 Gandhi, "Speech at Gurukul Anniversary," March 20, 1916, as found in *The Collected Works of Mahatma Gandhi,* Vol. XIII, 260.

22 Kolge, *Gandhi Against Caste*, 101–102.

23 Gandhi was engaged with an argument with a Kumbakonam pundit (in Mannargudi, Tamilnadu in 1927) who argued for untouchability based on the *shastras.* Ref. M. K. Gandhi, "A 'Pandit'," *Young India*, September 29, 1927.

before and during the Second Round Table Conference and the subsequent fast culminating in the Poona Pact. He has moved away from his earlier stance with regard to the question of *varna,* caste and of inter-dining and inter-marriage towards a radical one, advocating inter-*varna* and inter-caste marriages especially with the Dalits towards the end of this phase. His evolutionary mode of reforming his own ideas with regard to the question of caste and *varna* came to a standpoint that *varna* system could be upheld with a characteristic of only one *varna,* i.e., the *Harijan varna,* to the vanishment of all other *varnas* who held themselves superior to the Dalits.[24] Thus, his call to all Hindus to declare themselves as Dalits, and to have cordial, even marital relationship with them was that of a super-radical one, surely not minimally reformist.

While Gandhi's approach towards the issue of *varna* and caste is such of internal renewal and reform within Hinduism, Dr Ambedkar moved quite contrary to this approach of a mass leader like Gandhi. Though he had a ray of hope within Hinduism during the early period of his activism, he moved away from it differently to the extent of declaring his exit from Hinduism in the 1935 Yeola Conference. That ray of hope did not quench until last, as he took such long years to actualise his exit. His conception of the Hindu religion is quite contrary to Gandhi's reformist conception. He considered Hinduism the source of all evils for Dalits and also for all Hindus given to its propagation and promulgation of caste system based upon its parent, the *varna* system. He held the Brahmins and their supremacy as the root cause of all the hierarchical segregations of the Indian society. Two important books can be mentioned to his credit for the above-said analysis. They are: *Who Were the Shudras? How They Came to be the Fourth Varna in the Indo-Aryan Society* in 1946, *The Untouchables: Who Were They and Why They Became Untouchables?* in 1948. Dr Ambedkar proved by his varied analysis that the Hindu religion as the parent of these issues under consideration and the religiosity involved in these issues had made them indispensable among the Hindus to practice and to have sustained it through the years. Such a view of these issues as comprehensive, inseparable and deeply religious has utmost significance in the Dalit emancipatory strategy of Dr Ambedkar, thus leading to his profound methodology of separatism from the Hindus and the solemn acceptance of Buddhism as the religion for their emancipation. He chose Buddhism to the rejection of Sikhism, Islam and Christianity, as a

24 Gandhi wrote this in his foreword to the book *Varnavyavastha,* the collection of his articles regarding *varna* thus declaring his final stand with regard to *varna*, decreeing all his earlier pronouncements null and void. In such occasion, he called for only one *varna* i.e., of Shudras or *Ati-Shudras*, or *Harijans* or untouchables. Ref. M. K. Gandhi, "Foreword to "*Varnavyavastha*"," May 31, 1945, as found in *The Collected Works of Mahatma Gandhi,* Vol. LXXX, 222–224.

religion to uphold morality of its believers, void of any unequal structures within it and with the necessary apparatus for the betterment of its believers. He thus moved quite contrary to the approach of Gandhi who chose to be within Hinduism to reform its believers of the curse of caste. Gandhi questioned Brahminical authority being internal to Hinduism. Shaking the power pillars of the Brahminical-caste-castle from the within is suicidal too, as proven by the fact of his annihilation by assassination. But Dr Ambedkar decided to quit the religion which perpetuated hierarchical segregation and separation than to be within it and die every day and night.

3. Complementarity Between the Approaches of Dr Ambedkar and Gandhi

This final part of the paper is a derivation from the previous one dealing with the oppositional constructions between the two leaders. As rightly worded, they are mere rational constructions and not ontological opposites, as would be the case in any binaries. Economising on this factor, the paper proposes an untrodden path, thus investing in the hope for the Dalit subalterns' effective emancipation and empowerment.

3.1. Celebration of Differences Between Gandhi and Dr Ambedkar

Binaries are fundamentally differences.[25] The differences among them are constructed to be oppositions while sidelining the multitude of sameness between them. Taking the classical example of gender opposites–man and woman, they are opposites only in a few areas while being the same (not identical) in many other aspects. A man is not considered oppositional to a donkey nor a woman to a monkey. This oppositional construct is applied only between man and woman because of their sameness of humanness, commonality of emotions, rational orientedness etc. Those that are same only could be oppositional on account of the particularity of a few differences.

The approaches of Gandhi and Dr Ambedkar are merely differences, constructed oppositional only in a few areas, masquerading their general sameness. The oppositional constructs are only in the issues of Dalit separate electorates and that of *varna,* caste and untouchability. But there are plenty of sameness between them, as to cite a few as the following. Both of them were persons of zeal, conviction and commitment to the cause that they have devoted themselves to. Both of them trust in the necessity of human reason for seeking truth.[26] Both held morality as very necessary for human existence

25 Jacques Derrida, *Positions*, trans. Alan Bass (Chicago: The University of Chicago Press, 1981), 9.

26 Dr Ambedkar held reason as one of the most powerful weapons of a reformer. (Please ref. Ambedkar, *Annihilation of Caste*, 303); Gandhi insisted on testing even the

and societal living.[27] Both insisted on the necessity of religion.[28] Both were hypercritical of Brahminism. Both were hyper critical of the '*Hindu Raj*' as held by the Hindu nationalists and the orthodox.[29] Both were positive about the British in their initial stages, but later grew suspicious over them as in the case of Dr Ambedkar or critical of them as Gandhi's case. Both had felt the necessity of the method of non-violence.[30] Both insisted on the necessity of conversion of mind and heart.[31] Both of them insisted on the necessary fellowship among the Indians. Both had insisted on the secular nature of India, as contrasted with Muslims' Partition or *Hindu Rashtra* of the Hindu nationalists. Both of them believed strongly in democracy.[32] The above list is just a few to cite as examples to prove the condition of sameness between the two, yet not identical. With such sameness condition, their oppositional structuring is done on the basis of only a few issues bypassing the manifold sameness among them.

scriptures with the tool of reason (Cf. M. K. Gandhi, "Dr. Ambedkar's indictment-2," *Harijan*, July 18, 1936.).

27 Dr Ambedkar, while commending Ranade in one of his articles, praised him for his choice of moral stamina over political freedom. {Ref. B. R. Ambedkar, "Ranade, Gandhi and Jinnah," (first published 1943) *Dr. Babasaheb Ambedkar Writings and Speeches*, Vol. 1, 223}; Gandhi gave utmost prominence to moral principles as enunciated in Subash Anand, *Postmodern Sage Premodern Wisdom: Some Gandhian Insights* (Delhi: Media House, 2019), 171, 253ff.

28 *See* Ambedkar, *Annihilation of Caste*, 307, where he held religion as the foundation of society; He necessitated religion for moulding an individual's character, determining one's actions and likes/dislikes (Ref. Ambedkar, *Mr. Gandhi and the Emancipation of the Untouchables,* 55); Gandhi held the religious outlook of life as the greatest and supreme as enunciated in Joan V. Bondurant, *Conquest of Violence: The Gandhian Philosophy of Conflict* (Bombay: Oxford University Press, 1959), 120.

29 Gandhi's case could be known by his assassination. Dr Ambedkar too considered the Hindu Raj to be the greatest calamity for the country and wanted it to be prevented at any cost. Please ref. B. R. Ambedkar, *Pakistan or Partition of India,* as found in *Dr. Babasaheb Ambedkar Writings and Speeches*, Vol. 8, 358.

30 Gandhi's nonviolent methodology is beyond proof. Dr Ambedkar shared the same sentiments by his insistence on constitutional methods without recourse to mass protests, violent action etc. After his conversion in 1956, he gave his last speech in Kathmandu where he praised Buddhism for its non-violent methods. Ref. Zelliot, *From Untouchable to Dalit*, 142.

31 Gandhi's insistence on conversion of heart is beyond doubt. Dr Ambedkar too had insisted on the same as found in B. R. Ambedkar, "Buddha or Karl Marx," *Dr. Babasaheb Ambedkar Writings and Speeches*, Vol. 17, Part III, 555 & 558.

32 Dr Ambedkar's strong belief in democracy is beyond doubt. Gandhi too had believed in democracy with nonviolence as its backbone. (*See* R. N. Iyer, *The Moral and Political Thought of Mahatma Gandhi*, 186ff.).

As both Gandhi and Dr Ambedkar are same (not identical), the differences of their approaches for Dalit liberation are to be celebrated. The unique contribution of Dr Ambedkar for Dalit liberation cannot be shared by Gandhi who in turn, has his own unique contribution towards the same goal of Dalit emancipation. The methodology of liberation as suggested by Dr Ambedkar is different from that of Gandhi towards the same goal of Dalit liberation. It is thus, their differences are profound to be allowed to interplay rather than annihilate one another, positing presence in it and anti-presence in the other. Dr Ambedkar's Dalit self-empowerment methodology and Gandhi's caste-Hindus conversion of heart towards Dalits are no more merely oppositional, but differential. Such rich differences of Gandhian-Ambedkarean approaches are to be celebrated on account of their Dalit emancipatory sameness, amounting to richness of the interplay and interrelationship.

3.2. Celebration of the 'Yet-to-come' in the Binary Oppositions

Celebration of differences does not demean the creative role of the binaries operated by their oppositions. The aspect of sameness ought not to lead to annihilation of their differences in a mad attempt at their convergence and conjunction. The oppositional nature of the binary differences could be capitalised for newness of meaning, the 'yet-to-come.' The opposition between Gandhi and Dr Ambedkar should never be sought to be annihilated or vanished by a famished desire for merging their approaches and methods. Their uniqueness and differences are to be preserved carefully.

Gandhian and Ambedkarean approaches were truly oppositional. Dr Ambedkar's politicisation of the Dalits made him demand separate electorates until his last breath. Such a demand stands contradictory to Gandhi's outright denial of it. Gandhi's method has its own reason for denying it, as there would be a perpetual separation in Indian society as untouchables and non-untouchables given the Dalit separate electorates. Gandhian denial by his historic fast should not be judged from the analysis and approach of Dr Ambedkar, which would amount to adjudging Gandhi to be anti-Dalit. Dr Ambedkar's vehement demand for separate electorates should neither be judged from the Gandhian mode of national integration, for it would decree the Ambedkarean approach to be anti-nationalistic and separatist. Both positions are actually at loggerheads.

The rich oppositional interaction between Gandhi and Dr Ambedkar had contributed to the enrichment of their respective methods and growth in their respective stances. Dr Ambedkar became more radical and revolutionary after his interaction with Gandhi during the Poona Pact, taking two important steps in his liberative mission – a religious step (declaration of his exit from Hinduism in 1935 Yeola Conference) and a

political one (starting various political parties – the Independent Labour party in 1937 and later in 1942, changing it into a Dalit-exclusive one as All-India Scheduled Castes Federation). It is the same case with Gandhi, who intensified his Dalit liberation methods and started many new efforts too, after the Poona Pact. It was after the interaction with Dr Ambedkar that his eyes were opened to the real plight of the Dalits and the real nature of the Hindu orthodoxy. Gandhi, the one who was against any scheme of special representation for the Dalits in his earlier days, grew later to demand reserved seats and necessary politicisation of the Dalits to the extent of expressing his deep-seated yearning for the first Dalit woman President of India[33] as well as his tactful move of Dr Ambedkar's inclusion, participation and contribution in the Independent India's first cabinet.[34] Dr Ambedkar's analysis of intermarriages as an antidotes against caste system was reflected later in Gandhi's call for compulsory intermarriages with the Dalits. Gandhian and Ambedkarean evolution of their stances was a fruit of their oppositional interplay. The oppositions are to be celebrated. The binary opposites proclaim a 'yet-to-come' thus acknowledging a non-presence in each of them. Such acknowledgment of a lacuna in oneself proclaims a complementarity among the binaries.

3.3. Complementarity of the Approaches of Gandhi and Dr Ambedkar

Celebrating not only the differences but also the oppositions of the binaries leads to a new dimension—the aspect of complementarity. Complementarity is all about difference; yet it exhibits the absence in one as the presence in the other, or the present in the first as absent in the other.

Plenty of complementariness between Dr Ambedkar and Gandhi could be pointed out. Ambedkarean insistence on parliamentary and constitutional methods stands in a complementary position with Gandhian persuasive techniques of *satyagraha*, mass mobilisation, fasting, non-violent protests, non-cooperation etc. Failure of constitutional methods in situations that occurred to Dr Ambedkar thrice in his own lifetime and his recourse to mass demonstrations is a living proof of such complementarity. Further, Gandhi's stress regarding the necessary duties of the individuals and Dr Ambedkar's stress on the rights of the citizens is another aspect of complementarity between them worth point out. Another point of complementarity is the role of the state and the individual for the common good. For Gandhi, it is the

33 M. K. Gandhi, "Speech at Prayer Meeting," June 27, 1947, *Prarthana Pravachan*-I as found in *The Collected Works of Mahatma Gandhi,* Vol. LXXXVIII, 224–225.

34 Christophe Jaffrelot, *Dr. Ambedkar and Untouchability: Analysing and Fighting Caste* (Delhi: Permanent Black, 2005), 100 and footnote no. 37, 188.

individual's responsibility to shape the society or the state for the welfare of all, even to the extent of anarchy when the individual becomes fully responsible. But for Dr Ambedkar, it is the state apparatus and mechanism that are to be the safeguards of the rights and welfare of the individuals. Neither of these positions is the most perfect, but the complementariness of these would be productive and fruitful for the welfare of all.

Likewise, their approaches towards Dalit emancipation are in fact complementary to one another, as neither of their methods are perfect by themselves alone. Dr Ambedkar had strongly insisted on the self-help empowerment of the Dalits to the extent of denying any external help which might have weakened their self-motivation, self-respect and self-action. Gandhi's approach of the necessary and zealous change of heart of the caste Hindus who practice untouchability towards the Dalits is meritoriously complementary to Dr Ambedkar's position regarding the liberation of the Dalits. These two views may seem absolutely contradictory, for self-help outrightly rejects external help and conversely the oppressor's conversion un-necessitates the uprisal of the oppressed. But the beauty of such incompatibility to be formed as a 'yin-yang'[35] coordination is actually creative. It is thus the binaries or bipolarities are no longer oppositions, but could be partners of interplay and interaction. It is in such creative coordination of the approaches of Gandhi and Dr Ambedkar that effective Dalit emancipation can be achieved in the present caste-bound Indian society. True Dalit emancipation lies in wait for such authentic complementarity between Gandhian and Ambedkarean methods and tactics.

Conclusion

Dalit emancipation is a long-time pending project in India, waiting for its full effervescence still. The aspect of hope enters into such wait. No approach or methodology is the most perfect. Each valid method has meaning in it alongside having the need for the 'yet-to-come.' Such 'already and not-yet' aspect is the true face of reality. Affixing meaning to only one method leads to a retardation of the total effectiveness of the emancipatory project due to the futile drain of energy by unfavourable and irrational contradictions. Though contradictions are necessary for the progression of meaning, they cannot become the basis for stagnancy and subsequent stinking. It is in such a situation of stalemate that the truly emancipatory approaches of Dr Ambedkar and Gandhi are caught up with. Seeing their disagreements creatively and constructively is part of the meaning-progression process.

35 ☯ - Yin-yang is a philosophical concept in Chinese Taoist philosophy to describe how obvious opposite forces may actually be complementary.

This paper on the 'Hope for the subaltern' is an attempt at rationally viewing the contradictions involved in true attempts at emancipation of the subalterns. Limiting itself to the Indian condition of the Dalits, it tried to view the contradictions involved in sincere and valid attempts of both Gandhi and Dr Ambedkar in their final aim of the good of the country to be with liberty, equality and fraternity as its backbone. The massive fume emerging from the fire of their oppositional engagement should not cloud their valid attempts at addressing the plight of the Dalits, the majority population of this country. Rather, their oppositional power could be utilised creatively for effective Dalit emancipation, lightening up the dark path of Dalit empowerment.

It is in such attempt that the complementariness of the approaches of Dr Ambedkar and Gandhi could be tapped for future effectiveness of Dalit emancipation. Ambedkarean approach insists upon the internal factor of Dalit emancipation which is the dire need for empowerment, self-help, self-respect and the resulting activism. Gandhian approach, though does not deny it outrightly, strongly insists upon the external factor of Dalit emancipation, which is the conversion of the heart of the oppressors, the caste Hindus. Failure of which would lead to perpetual continuance of the Dalit issue, as is the case obviously known at present. Mere conversion of the caste oppressors would lead to mere patronisation of the Dalits, as was the deep-down fear of Dr Ambedkar. It is at this point that arises the need for Dalit self-empowerment. It is this complementarity of these two prominent approaches that would lead to effective liberation of the Dalits, though not the fullest, necessitating thus the need for other approaches. In each of those approaches, Dalit liberation is already there; yet not fully present, not thus monopolising any one approach to be the best. Such 'already and not-yet' can definitively can be named as HOPE—the hope for the subaltern.

16

Hope and Recognition in Charles Taylor
A Philosophical Reflection on Identity Politics

Joswine Praveen D'Souza

Abstract

This paper addresses the significant duress on India's collective ethical identity, which is marked by a deepening divide over the nation's vision of the collective good. It proposes that the legitimate concerns of those disenchanted with pluralism can still be addressed within the framework of India's constitutional democracy by revisiting its original vision, with Charles Taylor's philosophical insights offering a robust theoretical lens for understanding and addressing contemporary identity crises. The paper explores Taylor's "philosophy of recognition," which posits that due recognition is a vital human need. It argues that the absence of recognition can distort individual and collective identities, leading to social and political alienation for marginalised and subaltern groups. The analysis delves into Taylor's concept of the "politics of recognition," which basically entails two ideas: the politics of universalism, founded on the principle of equal dignity and universal rights for all citizens and the politics of difference, which defines identity and seeks to protect unique cultural contributions. Applying Taylor's framework to the Indian context, the paper examines

how these theories are relevant to addressing challenges posed by multiculturalism and religious pluralism. His approach can help build inclusive societies where diversity is acknowledged, and unity is maintained through respectful dialogue and mutual recognition.

Keywords: *Charles Taylor, Identity Politics, India, Multiculturalism, Politics of Recognition.*

Introduction

India's collective ethical identity is currently under significant duress, marked by a deepening divide over the nation's vision of the collective good. On one hand, some groups have abandoned the belief that India is a pluralist, constitutional democracy, instead asserting that the country is rediscovering its Hindu identity, which they view as a positive step toward becoming a powerful nation-state. On the other hand, many who continue to hold faith in the inclusive vision that emerged during the anti-colonial struggle find this shift deeply troubling. For them, this transformation threatens to strip India of its civilisational character and undermine its democratic pluralism.[1]

This paper seeks to initiate a dialogue between these divergent perspectives, proposing that the legitimate concerns of those disenchanted with pluralism can still be addressed within the framework of India's constitutional democracy. By revisiting the ethical language and principles underlying the nation's original vision, there remains hope for healing divisions and preventing further polarisation. A shared commitment to collective dreams—dreams that give meaning to individual and communal lives—requires conversation, mutual recognition, and an exchange of views on the ideal society. It is within this framework of hope and recognition that Charles Taylor's philosophical insights become particularly relevant, offering a robust theoretical lens for understanding and addressing contemporary identity crises.

This paper entitled *Hope and Recognition in Charles Taylor*, explores Taylor's "philosophy of recognition," particularly its application to the socio-political challenges faced by India today. Taylor's philosophical enterprise emphasises the profound importance of recognition in human life, which is very much evident particularly in the work *The Politics of Recognition*. In fact, the concept of "the politics of recognition" was first introduced by Charles Taylor himself, in his seminal essay *Multiculturalism and the Politics of Recognition*. He insists that contemporary politics has

1 Rajeev Bhargava, *Between Hope and Despair* (New Delhi: Bloomsbury Publishing India Pvt. Ltd., 2022), 15.

become significantly shaped by the need or demand for recognition made by oppressed or marginalised individuals and groups. As he puts it, "Due recognition is not just a courtesy we owe people. It is a vital human need."[2] But the need for recognition has frequently gone unfulfilled, particularly among marginalised and subaltern groups. These communities have often been systematically denied acknowledgment of the value of their culture, the dignity of their personhood, and the inviolability of their physical integrity. In the context of identity politics, their struggles for recognition have become a central feature of the political discourse, highlighting the pervasive inequalities they face.[3] In this context, the ideal of politics of recognition is a source of hope for all those people who languish without due recognition. His social theory aims to provide an adequate motivation for their struggles within their social world and help them to reclaim their lost identity and recognition in society.

This paper will examine Taylor's theory of recognition, emphasising how the absence of recognition can distort individual and collective identities, leading to social and political alienation. It will then discuss how this framework of recognition serves as a source of hope for marginalised communities striving to reclaim their lost identity and dignity in society. The subsequent sections will analyse the practical applications of Taylor's theories by exploring two main themes: the politics of equal dignity and the politics of difference. By tracing the historical evolution of these ideas, the paper will argue that Taylor's concept of recognition bridges the gap between individual and collective identity, as well as between universal and particular rights. The paper will also engage with contemporary debates about nationalism, multiculturalism, and democratic pluralism, using Taylor's framework to explore the challenges faced by diverse societies, such as India and Canada. The discussion will conclude by highlighting the relevance of Taylor's thought for addressing current political and social tensions, with a particular focus on Dalit and minority struggles for recognition in India. In conclusion, the paper will argue that Taylor's politics of recognition offers not only a critical understanding of modern identity crises but also a pathway to fostering hope and solidarity in increasingly diverse and divided societies.

2 Charles Taylor, "The Politics of Recognition," in *Multiculturalism: Examining the Politics of Recognition,* ed. Amy Gutman (New Jersey: Princeton University Press, 1994), 26.

3 Axel Honneth, *The Struggle for Recognition: The Moral Grammar of Social Conflicts*, trans. Joel Anderson (Cambridge, MA: Polity Press, 1995), x.

1. Taylor's Politics of Recognition

The concept of the "politics of recognition" plays a crucial role in contemporary discussions on identity and social justice. At its core, this concept addresses the ways in which individuals, groups, or institutions seek public acknowledgment based on their distinctive characteristics. The first key element of the politics of recognition is the emphasis on *identity* or *difference*. Categories such as race, language, religion, and sexuality are often used as markers that distinguish one group from another. A second important feature of the politics of recognition involves equality and inclusion. Many marginalised groups feel excluded or invisible within society, leading to a demand for recognition as a means of asserting their presence and importance. This form of recognition is often driven by a desire to be treated equally, without distinction from other groups. And the third feature of the politics of recognition may seem to contradict the emphasis on equality. Some groups, while demanding recognition, also emphasise their "difference" from others and seek validation for their unique contributions or identities. Rather than aiming for equal treatment, they desire acknowledgment of what makes them distinct. These three elements—identity, equality, and difference—form the foundation of the politics of recognition and illustrate its complexity in addressing both the desire for inclusion and the need for validation of distinct identities. This concept is central to understanding how marginalised groups navigate their place within society, balancing demands for both equal treatment and acknowledgment of their unique characteristics.[4] Taylor's concept of "politics of recognition," entails basically two ideas: politics of universalism and politics of difference.

1.1. Politics of Universalism

The Politics of universalism is founded on the principle of equal dignity for all the citizens. It holds that human beings deserve to be treated with respect by their very nature, and it argues that such respect should be enjoyed equally. It is only in these circumstances that people can experience equal dignity. In Taylor's view, the politics of universalism requires respect for people in light of their human potential for autonomy. It follows Kant's assumption that our status defines our dignity as rational agents. This means we should respect people since they can act on principles after making rational decisions. People deserve respect because they can exercise rational control over their lives.[5]

4 Simon Thompson, *The Political Theory of Recognition: A Critical Introduction* (Cambridge: Polity Press, 2006), 7–8.

5 Thompson, *The Political Theory of Recognition,* 45.

Since all humans are endowed with the capacity for rational agency, they should be treated equally. There is no reason to single out any particular subset of individuals for better or worse treatment than others. For this reason, Taylor condemns any attempt to create a distinction between first-class and second-class citizens. In practice, this means each citizen is entitled to an identical set of rights and immunities. Thus, universalism favours universal rights, including civil, political, and socio-economic rights. Taylor suggests that the American civil rights movement is an example of this type of politics in action. Taylor believed that all citizens should enjoy equal dignity and that protecting citizens' fundamental rights is a crucial aspect of ensuring that dignity. Some rights are so fundamental that we can more or less commit ourselves in advance to upholding them in every situation. These include the rights to life, personal liberty, freedom of opinion.[6]

1.2. The Politics of Difference

According to Taylor, politics of difference define one's identity, both as an individual and as a culture.[7] It holds that it is in virtue of having this potential to receive recognition and that such recognition is expressed in measures designed to protect such identities.[8] Taylor's analysis of politics of difference deals with two very distinct issues. One concerns the proposition that all cultures should be judged of equal value. The other concerns the legitimacy of political measures designed to ensure the survival of a culture. According to Taylor, all individuals are necessarily situated in a horizon of meaning, framework, or frame that allows them to make sense of the world. He says, "the horizons within which we live our lives and which make sense of them have to include strong qualitative distinctions, and they articulate our sense of the good, the holy and the admirable."[9] These discriminations provide the material on which individuals' identities are built and form the ethical vocabulary through which they construct their identities in the world.[10] Taylor puts it this way:

> If withholding the presumption is tantamount to a denial of equality, and if important consequences flow for people's identity from the absence of recognition, then a case can be made for insisting on the universalisation of the presumption as a logical extension of the politics of dignity. Just as all must have equal

6 Thompson, *The Political Theory of Recognition,* 46.

7 Charles Taylor, *Philosophical Arguments* (London: Harvard University Press, 1995), 236.

8 Thompson, *The Political Theory of Recognition,* 70.

9 Taylor, *Philosophical Arguments,* 256.

10 Thompson, *The Political Theory of Recognition,* 71.

> civil rights and equal voting rights, regardless of race or culture, so all should enjoy the presumption that their traditional culture has value.[11]

Taylor uses the instance of Quebec to establish his thesis of politics of difference. Taylor rejects the version of universalism called procedural liberalism. Specifically, he rejects its assumption that a commitment to equality of concern implies a commitment to uniformity of treatment. Taylor believes that the Canadian Charter of Rights and Freedoms is based on the idea of forging an equal relationship between citizens and the state. His non-procedural liberalism, on the other hand, is devoted to equality of concern but not to uniformity of treatment. In the case now under consideration, Taylor contends that it is appropriate to recognise Quebec as a unique society within the scope of the Charter of Rights and Freedoms. According to the Charlottetown Accord of 1992, Quebec constitutes a distinct culture and legal system within Canada, including a French-speaking majority, unique culture, and a civil law tradition. By officially recognising Quebec's particular cultural identity, specific measures can protect this identity. The government of Quebec can therefore legitimise policies that protect the French language so long as they do not violate the rights of citizens.[12]

2. The Challenges of Multiculturalism and Religious Pluralism in India

India is a country with great religious, ethnic, cultural, and linguistic complexity and diversification. Pluralism is one of the main characteristics of Indian society since its birth, embodying the value diversity in its culture, the diversity of social stakeholders in its economy, and the ideological diversification in its politics.[13] Hence, Multiculturalism and religious pluralism have long been a defining characteristic of Indian society. But over the years, various threats and challenges have undermined the diversity and multiculturalism of the country. Let us analyse certain threats here.

2.1. Pluralism over Multiculturalism

The early post-independence years in India seemed to set the country on a path towards becoming a truly multicultural polity. However, multiculturalism was soon supplanted by what can best be described as pluralism. This distinction is significant. Pluralism merely acknowledges

11 Taylor, *Philosophical Arguments*, 253.

12 Thompson, *The Political Theory of Recognition,* 73.

13 Yishuang Yang, "Challenges Facing India's Pluralistic Society," in *Annual Report on the Development of the Indian Ocean Region (2016): Modi's India*, eds. Rong Wang and Cuiping Zhu (Beijing: Social Sciences Academic Press, 2016), 107.

the existence of diverse identities but stops short of addressing the deeper principles of justice and equality that are integral to multiculturalism. While pluralism seeks to create political frameworks for peaceful coexistence, it does so without necessarily ensuring fairness or equity among different communities. In a pluralistic arrangement, the dominant majority often dictates the codes of conduct in the public sphere, leaving minority groups to comply in exchange for limited cultural rights. These rights are conditional, subject to compliance with the majority's rules, and challenging these norms can lead to backlash and potential revocation of rights. Such a model of coexistence is inherently fragile, with minorities constantly navigating an uneasy peace, devoid of true recognition or equality.[14]

In contrast, multiculturalism is rooted in the principles of equality and justice, which must extend not only to individuals but also to entire communities. Under a truly multicultural system, it would be unacceptable for a majority community to unilaterally define public norms. Instead, these norms should be collaboratively shaped, grounded in a genuine recognition of the inherent rights of minorities. Multiculturalism asserts that the rights of minority and marginalised communities are not "granted" by the state or majority but exist inherently as part of universal human rights.

2.2. Rise of Hindutva Movement

The "Hindutva" Movement which sprang up after the 1980s, has formed a formidable challenge to India's multiculturism. Hindutva was first proposed in 1923 by the extreme right-wing Hindu political leader Vinayak Damodar Savarkar. Its core idea is to advocate that Hindus is a homogeneous nation, advocating the revival of traditional Hindu values and using it as a yardstick of social governance. Hindutva claims to represent all the noble and pure people of India, and it calls for the subordination and subjugation of all non-pure or defiling people. Its protagonists have given a new name and meaning to the term Hindu. In the name of Hindutva, they insist that this mythic Hindu majority will hold sole control over and absolute dominion over all that lies within the boundaries of the Indian subcontinent.[15] Because it only advocates Hinduism, "Hindutva" is inevitable to dramatically conflict with secularism. Secularism in India means that "the Indian Government equally supports all religious groups," and it proposes to establish a doctrine for a culturally diversified state. It is obviously contrary to the "Hindutva" idea.

14 Baljit S. Mann, "Globalization and the Politics of Identities in India," in *Globalization and the Politics of Identity in India*, ed. Bupinder Brar (New Delhi: Pearson Longman, 2008), 68.

15 Robert Eric Frykenberg, "Hindutva and the Aftermath of Ayodhya: Political Religion and Religious Nationalism," in *Nationalism and Hindutva: A Christian Response*, ed. Mark. T. B. Laing (Delhi: ISPCK, 2005), 14.

This tension has directly contributed to the increasing rise of sectarianism and the worsening of religious conflict.[16]

Hindutva can undermine and destroy the fundamental rights of people. Hundreds of millions of Indians who do not share their ideologies can be affected by it. The Hindutva followers have raced their own country down a path of destruction throughout the years. Millions of Muslims, Christians, Dalits and Adivasis are viewed with disdain and scorn. The Constitution of India serves as an instrument of positive involvement and participation for all communities in India but now has been jeopardised by the forces of Hindutva systematically —a fact especially evident under the present BJP regime.[17]

2.3. Communal Violence

Communal violence involves people belonging to different religious communities mobilising against each other and carrying feelings of hostility, emotional fury, exploitation, social discrimination, and social neglect. The targets of attack are the members of the "enemy" community. The main causes of communal violence are hatred, enmity, and revenge. Since politics became communal, violence has increased both quantitatively and qualitatively.[18]

Several political parties tolerate ethnoreligious communalism, while others even encourage it. Recent examples of political leaders and some political parties' tolerance, indifference, and even complicity with the activities of religious organisations include violence against Muslims and Christian missionaries in various parts of the country. Communal violence has permeated Indian politics to such an extent that religious fanaticism, casteism, and mixing of religion and politics have increased. Instead of taking a collective stand against the negative impulses affecting our society, political parties and leaders adopt a "holier-than-thou" attitude toward one another. Communal riots are more politically motivated than fuelled by religion. Politicians are desperate to take advantage of any opportunity to strengthen their political positions, enhance their prestige, and improve their public image by giving communal colour to such incidents and thus projecting themselves as the champions of their religion and community.[19]

The ultimate goal of communal politics is to transform the nation into a theocratic state in which the religion of one community becomes the

16 Yang, "Challenges Facing India's Pluralistic Society," 110–111.

17 Frykenberg, "Hindutva and the Aftermath of Ayodhya," 27–28.

18 Sarto Esteves, *Freedom to Build Not to Destroy: Attacks on Christians and Their Institutions* (Delhi: Media House, 2002), 203.

19 Esteves, *Freedom to Build not to Destroy,* 204.

only religion in the country. If a theocratic state is established, its adherents will try to impose their religion on other citizens; they will demand all the facilities and privileges, as well as a particular status as citizens; others will only be tolerated, treated as second-class citizens, and viewed with disdain; they will not be treated equally; they will be denied their rights and privileges as citizens. As enshrined in the Constitution, the equality of all citizens will disappear if India is turned into a theocratic State. No such policies can be enforced in our country because our Constitution distinctly forbids it, and our multi-religious society will not tolerate it. The Constitution states: *The State shall not discriminate against any citizen on grounds only of religion, race, caste, sex, place of birth or any of them*. But attempts are being made to turn India into a *Hindu Rashtra*, particularly during the last few years.[20]

2.4. Caste Discrimination

Hindu society is based on caste. India's social organisation has been dominated by caste since ancient times. Different castes are ranked according to their social dignity in the caste system. According to the ancient law of Manu, Hindu society is organised in different strata. Four varnas are listed in the social system. There are four classes of people in India: the *Brahmins*, the priestly and learned class; the *Kshatriyas*, the military and ruling class; the *Vaisyas*, the traders and farmers; and the *Sudras*, the servants and menials of the three higher orders. In addition to the four orders, there are many outcasts. They were not allowed to live within the village and were regarded as the scum of the earth. They were doomed to a miserable existence and exploited by the upper caste.[21]

Ambedkar was a vocal opponent of the graded inequality across classes, which prohibited the untouchables from entering temples, educational institutions, acquiring property, and occupying positions of authority. He proposed various measures for the successful working of democracy, including the elimination of glaring inequalities in society, equality before the law and the administration, no tyranny of the majority order in the society, and observing constitutional morality and public conscience. For minorities to feel secure and comfortable and exercise their rights freely, certain safeguards must be in place. The Constitution prepared by Ambedkar was founded upon these ideals for their emancipation.[22]

20 Esteves, *Freedom to Build not to Destroy,* 205.

21 Shakuntala Devi, *Caste System in India* (Jaipur: Pointer Publishers, 1999), 9.

22 Devi, *Caste System in India*, 76.

3. Taylor's Framework for a Politics of Recognition in Indian Context

Taylor's concept of *politics of recognition* has consistently revealed a strong sense of relevance and hope to our current challenges, and can help us better understand the disruptions and upheavals that have been the result of transformations and calamities in recent history, from recognising the importance of pluralism in modern society, through to the consequences of hate and divisive politics.[23] Taylor's political principles are helpful to achieve the ideals enshrined in the Constitution.

3.1. Politics of Recognition for Dalits, Minorities and Marginalised Communities

The legacy of contemporary Indian democracy is that it recognised the historically subordinate groups who suffered grave historical injustices by allowing poorer citizens to vernacularise their important norms, institutions, and practices.[24] The politics of recognition that deepened Indian democracy involved the traditional caste order. The postcolonial state legally abolished untouchability. It reformed various Hindu practices that denigrated the standing of members of formerly untouchable castes—Dalits, literally "the downtrodden," and Adivasis, indigenous tribal peoples—in various public domains. The most significant of these measures was the Hindu Code Bill, which legalised inter-caste marriage and divorce, granted equal rights of inheritance to sons and daughters, and banned polygamy. Other acts protected the right of Dalits to enter Hindu temples and authorised the state to handle their administrative affairs.[25]

Collectively, these provisions created a new single code of personal law that broke with the idea that traditional Brahmanical principles applied to all Hindus. Finally, the postcolonial state recognised these subaltern groups as deserving special treatment. It established strict numerical quotas—known as "reservations" in India—for the most historically oppressed communities in higher educational institutions, legislative assemblies, and government posts. Indeed, the state recognised these subaltern classes through constitutionally defined categories: Dalits as Scheduled Castes; Adivasis as Scheduled Tribes. The justification of such recognition was to

23 Craig Browne and Andrew P. Lynch, *Taylor and Politics: A Critical Introduction* (Edinburgh: Edinburgh University Press, 2018), 17.

24 Sanjay Ruparelia, "How the Politics of Recognition Enabled India's Democratic Exceptionalism," *International Journal of Politics, Culture and Society,* 12, nos. 1–4 (December 2008), 40–56.

25 Ruparelia, "How the Politics of Recognition Enabled India's Democratic Exceptionalism," 45.

compensate for, if not redress, the brutal historical injustices suffered by individuals in these groups and promote society's integration. Significantly, it was based on the grounds that one could lessen discrimination against specific individuals only by empowering the groups they belonged to.[26]

The political recognition that anchored Indian democracy after independence was rooted in the understanding of secularism: a regime that sought to maintain "principled distance" from and between different religious communities. As previously mentioned, the postcolonial state intervened in the affairs of the majority Hindu community in order to eradicate barriers against lower-caste groups. It also refused to reorganise states, allocate public quotas, or reserve electoral constituencies based on religion. But it allowed minority religious communities to retain personal laws governing their practices of marriage, inheritance, divorce, and so on. The state pursued this differential secular regime to protect minority communities against the spectre of majoritarianism by the dominant Hindu community, a palpable fear in the wake of Partition.[27]

In his concept of *politics of recognition*, Taylor argues that our identity "is partly shaped by recognition or its absence, often by the misrecognition of others."[28] The lack of proper social recognition could take various forms. It could mean the absence of significant cultural ties—bound by language, ethnicity, race, region, and religion—which diminished the lives of individuals in historically marginalised communities. It could also manifest itself through inferior, demeaning, or dehumanising beliefs and images of and behaviour toward particular social groups.[29] Hence, the politics of recognition based on caste, language, and religion has enabled India to recast ordinary people's common self-understandings, institutions, and practices in ways that made sense of their desire for equality.[30]

3.2. Call for Solidarity

Democratic societies cannot function without solidarity. They cannot function beyond mutual distrust or a sense that other members have abandoned them. This aspect of solidarity has been a pillar of Indian democracy since independence. Today, however, religious polarisation has

26 Ruparelia, "How the Politics of Recognition Enabled India's Democratic Exceptionalism," 45.

27 Ruparelia, "How the Politics of Recognition Enabled India's Democratic Exceptionalism," 46.

28 Taylor, "The Politics of Recognition," 25.

29 Ruparelia, "How the Politics of Recognition Enabled India's Democratic Exceptionalism," 42.

30 Ruparelia, "How the Politics of Recognition Enabled India's Democratic Exceptionalism," 53.

become the greatest threat to solidarity. It is also linked to a diminishing sense of shared identity as Indian citizens. From the ancient days, India has been a home to different religions such as Islam, Christianity, Judaism, Zoroastrianism, Sikhism, etc. People lived close to one another and shared a connection with neighbours and fellow citizens. The challenge today is maintaining a sense of solidarity amid growing religious divisions. One of the ways to preserve solidarity is to redefine our identity.[31]

Creating a sense of social solidarity in society requires that several different groups of people earnestly feel dedicated towards it: if Hinduism sees it as the central teaching of Hinduism, if Christianity sees it as the central teaching of Christianity, if Islam sees it as the central teaching of Islam, and even if each kind of philosophy sees it as central to its philosophy. Religion provides a profound and powerful basis for solidarity. Democracies, in their diversity, are propelled by many different sources of commitment to common ethics. If we wish to maintain a political community, we cannot switch any of these engines off.[32]

The challenge we face is unprecedented in human history: the creation of a powerful political ethic of solidarity based on the free acceptance of differing viewpoints. We can only achieve this by engaging in vigorous exchanges with each other in order to foster a sense of mutual respect between all of these different viewpoints. This kind of solidarity will enable us to value other individuals and prepare to enact equal treatment principles and make sacrifices for the least advantaged. The advancing force of Islamophobia and attacks on Christians in the name of conversions in our country will eventually tear our country into pieces on the grounds of religion and reduce the people into hate-mongering and victimisation. It is important to remember that our societies can only hold together if we communicate with respect and honesty, and re-create solidarity based on our differences.[33]

3.3. Toleration between Politics and Religion

Throughout the territory of a state, democracy regulates conflict by allowing citizens to embrace the values and goals they want to advance as freely as possible. A democratic society means that as long as groups do not use violence, do not violate the rights of other citizens, and adhere to the democratic rules, all groups should be allowed to advance their interests,

31 Charles Taylor, "All for One, One for All," *The Globe and Mail*, June 1, 2002, https://www.theglobeandmail.com/opinion/all-for-one-and-one-for-all/article4327522/, accessed 29 July 2025.

32 Taylor, "All for One, One for All."

33 Taylor, "All for One, One for All."

both in society and in politics. It is the minimal institutional criterion for what democratic politics entails. In this regard, Taylor speaks of "twin toleration" regarding religion and politics, which are the core institutional requirements of democratic politics. According to his perspective of twin toleration, a democratic institution must have the freedom to generate policy within the limits of the Constitution and human rights. A religious institution should not have special rights, whether constitutionally enshrined or not, allowing them to impose public policies on democratically elected governments unilaterally. Individuals and religious communities must have the right to worship privately, following the institutional definition of democracy.[34]

They must also publicly emphasise their values in society and sponsor political organisations and movements, as long as their actions do not negatively impact other citizens' liberties or violate democracy and the law. The institutional approach to democracy implies that no group in society, including religious groups, can a priori be barred from forming a political party. Any restrictions on political parties, religious or not, can only be imposed after a party violates democratic principles and the democratic Constitution by its actions. The judgement as to whether or not a party has violated democratic principles should not be decided by parties in the government but by courts interpreting a democratically crafted Constitution. Within this broad framework of the necessary tolerated freedoms of the democratic state from religion and tolerated freedoms of religious individuals and organisations from the democratic state, an extraordinary range of quite different patterns of state-religion relations can, and do coexist with the twin tolerations necessary for a democracy.[35]

3.4. Dialogical Exchange among Different Communities

A significant contribution of Charles Taylor to Canadian society is that he demonstrates a way to communicate and live together while negotiating their ethical relationships as citizens of a federation. Canada is especially interesting because it has both Anglophones and Francophones and more profoundly and widely diverse citizens—including Québécois, Crees, and Dene—each with their own language and history, and laws. Over the past half-century, this diversity, much deeper than multiculturalism, has repeatedly threatened to split the country. So, helping them to learn to negotiate these relationships was the greatest possible gift, which Taylor gave not via legislation, but by helping them to find a language of dialogue

34 Alfred Stepan, "Muslims and Toleration: Unexamined Contributions to the Multiple Secularisms of Modern Democracies," in *Boundaries of Toleration* eds. Alfred Stepan and Charles Taylor (New York: Columbia University Press, 2014), 268.

35 Stepan, "Muslims and Toleration," 269.

to describe to one another how they experience life, bringing together their similar and diverse modes of being and interacting as individuals. When we look at the Indian context, which is more widely pluralistic than Canada, this language of dialogue can help our democratic country keep united.[36]

"Dialogue" means "dia" (through) participation in and of "logos" (speech). According to Taylor, humans are dialogical animals. He/she is a dialogical self. Human beings are always talking to each other, always caught in complex webs of communication, and at our best, we experience a kind of "together-joy" when we communicate with each other, something Nietzsche called *Mitfreude*.[37] Taking a broad view of dialogue, Taylor explains the dialogical nature of human beings. Dialogue involves discussion, negotiation, bargaining, deliberation, communion, etc. Taylor's philosophical and political writings have been devoted to clarifying the conditions of mutual recognition, deep diversity, a fusion of horizons, common learning, and coming to an agreement and acting together.[38]

In Taylor's view, dialogue has particular importance when people come together not to argue, discuss, debate, or negotiate, but to try to suspend their emotional attachment to the deep-seated assumptions or prejudgements that pit them against one another. The goal is to bring their conflicting assumptions into the intersubjective space of dialogue and share and discuss them until they understand and trust one another. In modern societies, it is not easy to maintain this non-attachment. The idea is to create innovative, shared meanings to enhance cooperation and live together peacefully. This is the kind of dialogical "transvaluation" (*Umwertung*) that he said, "we should strive for."[39]

4. Critical Evaluation of the Politics of Recognition

Charles Taylor's philosophy is centred on the essential concept of "recognition" and its political and social implications, as extensively discussed in this paper. His work is particularly significant because it offers a comprehensive framework for addressing identity, multiculturalism, and the struggles of marginalised communities. Taylor insists that recognition is

36 James Tully, "The Philosopher who Showed Canadians How to Talk to One Another," *Zócalo Public Square*, November 28, 2016, https://www.zocalopublicsquare.org/2016/11/28/philosopher-showed-canadians-talk-one-another/ideas/nexus/, accessed 29 July 2025.

37 Nietzsche uses the expression *Mitfreude* in his work *Human, All Too Human*, to denote "*fellow-rejoicing*." Tully echoes this sense in his analysis of Taylor's philosophy of mutual recognition and civic dialogue. Cf. Tully, "The Philosopher Who Showed Canadians How to Talk to One Another."

38 Tully, "The Philosopher who Showed Canadians How to Talk to One Another."

39 Tully, "The Philosopher who Showed Canadians How to Talk to One Another."

not a mere courtesy but a vital human need. Misrecognition, or the denial of recognition, can lead to social and political alienation, distorting personal and collective identities.[40]

"Politics of Recognition" offers a balanced framework between the politics of equal dignity and the politics of difference. The politics of equal dignity emphasises the shared universal potential of human beings, particularly their status as rational agents capable of directing their own lives. This underscores the need for equal respect and human rights for all, regardless of individual differences. On the other hand, the politics of difference focuses on recognising the distinct identities of individuals and groups. Taylor highlights the importance of acknowledging these unique identities, arguing that the potential to form and define one's identity is fundamental to being human. By combining both universal dignity and individual distinctiveness, Taylor's concept addresses the need for equality while affirming the cultural and personal uniqueness that differentiates individuals and groups in pluralistic societies.[41]

Despite its strengths, the politics of recognition is not without its shortcomings. The main critique of Charles Taylor's politics of recognition is that it can restrict individual authenticity, limit self-exploration, promote deference to cultural norms, hinder empathy for others, and potentially lead to intergroup conflict rather than fostering genuine cross-cultural enrichment and understanding. Additionally, it tends to rigidify identity, fails to honour the distance between an individual's authentic self and socially recognised identities, risks depleting resources within the self for embracing diversity, encourages a deferential mindset among citizens, and may lead to a loss of individual authenticity and attentiveness to difference.[42]

Secondly, when a state recognises and promotes a particular group's identity, it enhances the power of that group's leaders to interpret their group's culture and to determine which of its aspects will be safeguarded. This can inadvertently strengthen the power of a group's leaders to define and control their culture, marginalising individual voices within the group. By promoting the recognition of a particular group's identity, the state may empower leaders to determine which cultural aspects are preserved, potentially stifling diversity and dissent within the group. This concentration of power risks undermining the liberty and autonomy of individual members,

40 Brenda Lyshaug, "Authenticity and the Politics of Identity: A Critique of Charles Taylor's Politics of Recognition," *Contemporary Political Theory* 3, (2004): 300–320.

41 Maeve Cooke, "Authenticity and Autonomy: Taylor, Habermas, and the Politics of Recognition," *Political Theory* 25, no. 2 (April 1997): 258–288.

42 Lyshaug, "Authenticity and the Politics of Identity," 308.

despite Taylor's assertion that fundamental rights should never be sacrificed for the sake of collective goods.[43]

Thirdly, a "politics of recognition" can lead to fragmentation and tension among groups, as seen in the Quebec's northern First Nations people have been overwhelmingly opposed to the province's independence. Taylor's concept does not adequately address how such conflicts would be managed, raising concerns about the feasibility and desirability of his approach.[44]

Conclusion

Charles Taylor's framework of the politics of recognition is not only a critical tool for understanding identity crises in modern societies but also a potential pathway for fostering hope and solidarity. The emphasis on recognition—both in terms of universal dignity and the politics of difference—provides marginalised communities with a philosophical basis for reclaiming their lost identity. Taylor's model is particularly relevant in contexts like India, where issues of caste, religion, and cultural diversity continue to shape social and political life. The paper ultimately argues that Taylor's politics of recognition offers a promising route towards building inclusive societies where diversity is acknowledged, and unity is maintained through respectful dialogue and mutual recognition. This approach has the potential to address ongoing tensions and promote a more just, equitable, and harmonious social order. As Ruth Abbey notes, Taylor's "work on the politics of recognition can be seen as continuing the traditional liberal concern with how a society can peacefully accommodate significant and enduring differences among its population with minimal recourse to coercion."[45]

43 Lyshaug, "Authenticity and the Politics of Identity," 309.

44 Lyshaug, "Authenticity and the Politics of Identity," 317.

45 Ruth Abbey, *Charles Taylor* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2004), 148.

17

Hope and Vulnerability
Walking with Transpersons

Jose D. Maliekal

Abstract

Under the wider horizon of the theme "Hope: Philosophizing from Multi-horizons," this paper entitled, "Hope and Vulnerability: Walking with Transpersons," attempts to present a philosophically grounded, socio-political and praxis-oriented, reflection on the condition of the Transpersons. After the brief introductory remarks, the work engages itself in a clarification of terms, which comes under the widely used canopy abbreviation LGBTIQ+. Following this exercise, the paper moves on to listening to the Transpersons, in their flesh and blood, autobiographical fragments. This is followed by the gathering of a philosophical bricolage, towards an empathic and programmatic response/a walk with, the Transpersons, beyond the ocular to the auricular mode and mood. In this elaboration of an empathic toolkit, the mainstay has been a dialogue with Judith Butler, the theorist of gender performativity, giving space for gender non-conformity, which is the right of transpersons. Also, Gilles Deleuze's and Felix Guattari's theory of becoming, grounded in the deeper theoretical framework of multiplicity is deployed in this section, to understand Transphobia and appreciate the Trans experience.

This empathic and praxis-oriented philosophical toolkit is applied in the ensuing section, centred around the theme, "Personal is Political," joining forces with the Transpersons and the LGBTIQ+ community, in their ongoing struggle against the Transgender Protection Act 2019, protest against the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA) and National Register of Citizens (NRC), which are interrelated in their oppressive nature, from an intersectional point of view. The concluding remarks reaffirm the resolve to walk ahead and with the Transpersons.

Keywords: *Gender Conformity, Gender Non-Conformity, Hijras, Human Rights, Intersectionality, LGBTQI+, Multiplicity, "Personal is Political," Transpersons, Transphobia, Tritiya Prakriti.*

Introduction

Pope Francis faced calls to overturn the Catholic Church's ban on gender-affirming care for transgender people when he held talks with LGBTQ activists at the Vatican. The 80-minute meeting included a Catholic sister who works with LGBTQ people, a member of the transgender community, and a U.S. medical doctor who helps run a clinic providing gender-affirming hormonal care for adults. The meeting with around a dozen LGBTQ activists came six months after the Vatican's doctrinal office firmly rejected gender-affirming care, saying it "risks threatening the unique dignity the person has received from the moment of conception."

LGBTQ+ groups sharply criticised the Vatican document and said the doctrinal office did not seek input from transgender people about their experiences before rejecting gender-affirming care. "We expressed that as the church makes policies in this area that it's very important to speak with transgender individuals," said Cynthia Herrick, an endocrinologist at a St Louis, Missouri, clinic who took part in the papal meeting. "The pope was very receptive," said Herrick. "He listened very empathetically. He also shared that he always wants to focus on the person, the well-being of the person."

Pope Francis, who died at the age of 88, was credited with leading the Catholic Church towards a more welcoming approach to the LGBTQ community, and had allowed priests to bless same-sex couples on a case-by-case basis. "The message really is that we need to listen to the experiences of transgender people," said Sister Jeannine Gramick, the group's co-founder, who had asked Francis for the encounter. The meeting "means that the church is coming along, the church is joining the modern era," she said.[1]

1 *Reuters*, Vatican City, 14 October 2024.

This above is indeed an example of listening to the vulnerabilities of the LGBTQI+ and raising their hopes and the Church's readiness to *Walk*, with them. The present paper, as the title indicates, is intended to be a moment/movement, in sharing the vulnerabilities of the Transpersons and walking with them in hope.

1. Clarification of Terms

Transgender is an umbrella term for persons whose gender identity, gender expression, or behaviour does not conform to that typically associated with the sex to which they were assigned at birth. Gender identity refers to a person's internal sense of being male, female, or something else; gender expression refers to the way a person communicates their gender identity to others through behaviour, clothing, hairstyles, voice, or body characteristics. "Trans" is sometimes used as shorthand for "transgender." While *transgender* is generally a good term to use, not everyone whose appearance or behaviour is gender-nonconforming will identify as a transgender person. The ways that transgender people are talked about in popular culture, academia, and science are constantly changing, particularly as the awareness, knowledge, and openness about transgender people and their experiences grow.

1.1. The Difference between Sex and Gender

Sex is assigned at birth and refers to one's biological status, as either male or female, and is associated primarily with physical attributes such as chromosomes, hormone prevalence, and external and internal anatomy. Gender refers to the socially constructed roles, behaviours, activities, and attributes that a given society considers appropriate for boys and men or girls and women. These influence the ways that people act, interact, and feel about themselves. While aspects of biological sex are similar across different cultures, aspects of gender may differ. Various conditions that lead to atypical development of physical sex characteristics are collectively referred to as intersex conditions.

Transgender persons have been documented in many indigenous, Western, and Eastern cultures and societies from antiquity until the present day. However, the meaning of gender nonconformity may vary from culture to culture. In India, however, the trans-world has always been acknowledged as a third category, the *Tritiya Prakriti* (TP). We find this in ancient literature, from *Panini* to *Kamasutra*. This category bundles every variant related to gender (trans, intersex) and sexuality (gay, lesbian, bi, asexual). It has been so for hundreds of years.[2]

2 Devdutt Pattanaik, *Trans Lore: History of Transgender Representation in Indian Scriptures*, https://www.justicenews.co.in/trans-lore-history-of-transgender-representation-in-indian-scriptures/#google_vignette, accessed 31 July 2025.

1.2. Categories and Types of Transgender Identities

Many identities fall under the transgender umbrella. The term *transsexual* refers to people whose gender identity is different from their assigned sex. Often, transsexual people alter or wish to alter their bodies through hormones, surgery, and other means to make their bodies as congruent as possible with their gender identities. This process of transition through medical intervention is often referred to as sex or gender reassignment, but more recently is also referred to as gender affirmation. People who were assigned female but identify and live as male and alter or wish to alter their bodies through medical intervention to more closely resemble their gender identity are known as transsexual men or *transmen* (also known as female-to-male or FTM). Conversely, people who were assigned male but identify and live as female and alter or wish to alter their bodies through medical intervention to more closely resemble their gender identity are known as transsexual women or transwomen (also known as male-to-female or MTF). Some individuals who transition from one gender to another, prefer to be referred to as a man or a woman, rather than as transgender.[3]

Other categories of transgender people include *androgynous*, *multigendered*, *gender nonconforming*, *third gender*, and *two-spirit people*. Exact definitions of these terms vary from person to person and may change over time, but often include a sense of blending or alternating genders. Some people who use these terms to describe themselves see traditional, binary concepts of gender as restrictive.[4]

1.3. Recognising Transgender Identity

Transgender people experience their transgender identity in a variety of ways and may become aware of their transgender identity at any age. Some can trace their transgender identities and feelings back to their earliest memories. They may have vague feelings of "not fitting in" with people of their assigned sex or specific wishes to be something other than their assigned sex. Others become aware of their transgender identities or begin to explore and experience gender-nonconforming attitudes and behaviours during adolescence or much later in life. Some embrace their transgender feelings, while others struggle with feelings of shame or confusion. Those who transition later in life may have struggled to fit in adequately as their assigned sex, only to later face dissatisfaction with their lives. Some transgender people, transsexuals in particular, experience intense

3 American Psychological Association, *Understanding Transgender people, Gender Identity and Gender Expression*, https://www.apa.org/topics/lgbtq/transgender-people-gender-identity-gender-expression, accessed 31 July 2025.

4 American Psychological Association, *Understanding Transgender People*.

dissatisfaction with their sex assigned at birth, physical sex characteristics, or the gender role associated with that sex. These individuals often seek gender-affirming treatments.[5]

2. Listening to the Transpersons in Flesh and Blood

In the battlefield we stand.
We do not seek sympathies
Understand our emotions—we
Demand our dues and nothing else.
Amma should accept us
Appa must accept us
Society should accept us—and
The world must accept us
Property we ought to get—sirs
Pleasures we must have
House we need—sirs
And jobs we need.[6]

People would surely wonder: can a hijra afford to fall in love? wonder: can a hijra afford to fall in love? Like my mother and sister wished, I wanted to marry and settle down. But how does it matter what I want? Who would want to marry a hijra? I kept these questions—and my answers—to myself. Some hijras boasted that they had husbands. This did not mean they were married. It only meant that two people liked each other and so had decided to live together in the same house. Even if I were to find myself such a husband, my nani and my guru would never approve of such an arrangement. There are hijras who do not mind alienating their gurus. And there are hijras who are on their own and could live as they pleased. But I was not like them—I was part of a household; a household with not even a trace of a man. Nani did not have the heart to send me to a house where sex work was done. At that time, I too did not want to do sex work. Till I had my *nirvaanam*, I had not acknowledged my sexual feelings. Whatever I felt within, I kept to myself. I had learnt to suppress desire and had told myself that it was important for me to become a woman first. Everything else would come later.[7]

> Look! I've had an operation and I'm a woman now. From now on, I'll live as I wish. You can't beat me as before, you have no right to. Don't you know that there are laws in this land that'll

5 American Psychological Association, *Understanding Transgender People*.

6 A. Revathi, *Our Lives, Our Word*s (New Delhi: Yoda Press, 2010), 1.

7 A. Revathi, *The Truth about me: A Hijra Life Story*, trans. Geetha (Gurgaon: Penguin India Books, 2010).

> punish you if you hit a woman? If you dare hit me, I'll go to the police,' I warned him. Undeterred, he raised his stick, 'Think you're a woman?' At which I lifted my sari and showed him. 'So, tell me am I a woman or a man?' 'Think you're a woman, just because you've cut your bud off?' My brother kept the stick raised, but did not dare hit me. Seeing me lift my sari, my mother hit her mouth with her hands and bawled out, 'He's cut it all off, the two and the third! Oh, how did he have the heart to? How is it that he's still alive? When he was a baby, I used to fondle and kiss his bud. How could he do this and come and stand in front of me like a barren tree! How dare he lift his clothes up and show it all in front of his mother and hurt her so… and he's here alive still, even after what he's done…[8]

"If society scorns us, then we turn to our families, if we have a family. But if family scorns us, who do we turn to? Is this why people like me do not stay in touch with their families? Could not God have created me as a man or a woman? Why did He make me this way? Why is He savouring this spectacle that He created? In a rage, hitting my head against the wall, I began to cry."[9]

Families respect you only if you have money, you look modern, wear nice clothes and jewels. If you are a hijra and poor, you must expect to be abused and humiliated. It is best I be with others like me, only that would ensure me of dignity. As I thought about returning to Mumbai or going to Delhi, I remembered what a hijra told me when I was in Kamatipura—that there was a *hamam* (bath house) run by hijras in Bangalore. I decided to go there."[10]

3. A Philosophical Bricolage for an Empathic Response: In Dialogue with Judith Butler, Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari

Judith Butler (born February 24, 1956, Cleveland, Ohio, U.S.) is an American academic whose theories of the performative nature of gender and sex have been influential within Francocentric philosophy, cultural theory, queer theory, and some schools of philosophical feminism from the late 20th century. In an interview with Cristan Williams, she expressed her views on feminism and the identity of the Transgenders, especially in

8 Revathi, *The Truth about me*.

9 Revathi, *The Truth about me*.

10 Revathi, *The Truth about me*.

contrast with Sheila Jeffreys, a Feminist writer, historian and activist and Janice Raymond, an American, lesbian radical feminist.[11]

In the opinion of Butler, Sheila Jeffreys likens Transsexual surgery to political psychiatry in the Soviet Union. She suggested that transsexualism should best be seen in this light, as directly political, medical abuse of human rights. The mutilation of healthy bodies and the subjection of such bodies to dangerous and life-threatening continuing treatment violates such people's rights to live with dignity in the body into which they were born, what Janice Raymond refers to as their "native" bodies. It represents an attack on the body to rectify a political condition, "gender" dissatisfaction in a male supremacist society based upon a false and politically constructed notion of gender difference… Recent literature on transsexualism in the lesbian community draws connections with the practices of sadomasochism.[12]

3.1. Transpersonal Identity – A Choice

Judith Butler never agreed with Sheila Jeffreys or Janice Raymond, and for many years has been on quite the contrasting side of feminist debates. For Butler, Jeffreys appoints herself to the position of judge, and she offers a kind of feminist policing of trans lives and trans choices. She stated that she opposed that kind of prescriptivism, which seemed to her to aspire to a kind of feminist tyranny. Butler noted, if Jeffreys made use of social construction as a theory to support her view, she very badly misunderstood its terms. In her view, a trans person is "constructed" by a medical discourse and therefore is the victim of a social construct. But this idea of social constructs does not acknowledge that all of us, as bodies, are in the active position of figuring out how to live with and against the constructions – or norms – that help to form us. We form ourselves within the vocabularies that we did not choose, and sometimes we have to reject those vocabularies, or actively develop new ones. For instance, gender assignment is a "construction" and yet many genderqueer and trans people refuse those assignments in part or in full. That refusal opens the way for a more radical form of self-determination, one that happens in solidarity with others who are undergoing a similar struggle.[13]

On the question of body's relationship to sexuality, Butler responded that most of what people say about those matters is rather speculative.

11 Judith Butler in Interview with Cristan Williams, "Judith Butler on gender and the trans experience: "One should be free to determine the course of one's gendered life," Blogpost, https://www.versobooks.com/en-gb/blogs/news/2009-judith-butler-on-gender-and-the-trans-experience-one-should-be-free-to-determine-the-course-of-one-s-gendered-life?srsltid=AfmBOoqo-IEE-VcuIUMjvM62kvMQJoGw9BQ3h1SVovtLTqQyojKrNMHMA, accessed 31 July 2025.

12 Butler, "Judith Butler on Gender and the Trans Experience."

13 Butler, "Judith Butler on Gender and the Trans Experience."

Some subjective experiences of sex are very firm and fundamental, even unchangeable. They can be so firm and unchanging that we call them "innate." But given that we report on such a sense of self within a social world, a world in which we are trying to use language to express what we feel, it is unclear what language does that most effectively. According to her, "innate" is a word that conveys the sense of something hired-wired and constitutive. One could wonder whether other vocabularies might do the job equally well. The assertion of the "innate" inferiority or women or Blacks, would be as if we were trying to "fix" a social reality into a natural necessity. And yet, sometimes we do need a language that refers to a basic, fundamental, enduring, and necessary dimension of who we are, and the sense of sexed embodiment can be precisely that.[14]

Gender: A Multi-Layered and Dynamic Category

As regards the relevance of gender as an analytical and lived category, Butler stated that sometimes there are ways to minimise the importance of gender in life, or to confuse gender categories so that they no longer have descriptive power. But other times gender can be very important to us, and some people really love the gender that they have claimed for themselves. If gender is eradicated, so too is an important domain of pleasure for many people. And others have a strong sense of self bound up with their genders, so to get rid of gender would be to shatter their self-hood. I think we have to accept a wide variety of positions on gender. Some want to be gender-free, but others want to be free really to be a gender that is crucial to who they are.[15]

This stance of Butler on the need to have a wide variety of positions on gender and the respect we need to have for persons, who have an autobiographical approach to gender, can be better understood, in the context of Butler's approach to gender as "Performativity."

Butler offers a critique of the terms *gender* and *sex* as they have been used by feminists.[16] They argue that feminism made a mistake in trying to make "women" a discrete, ahistorical group with common characteristics. Butler writes that this approach reinforces the binary view of gender relations. Butler believes that feminists should not try to define "women" and they also believe that feminists should "focus on providing an account of how power functions and shapes our understandings of womanhood not

14 Butler, "Judith Butler on gender and the trans experience."

15 Butler, "Judith Butler on gender and the trans experience."

16 Ian Buchanan, s.v. "Butler, Judith," *A Dictionary of Critical Theory*, Oxford Reference Online Premium, January 2010, DOI:10.1093/acref/9780199532919.001.0001, ISBN 97801995329199, accessed 31 July 2025.

only in the society at large but also within the feminist movement."[17] Finally, Butler aims to break the supposed links between sex and gender so that gender and desire can be "flexible, free floating and not caused by other stable factors."[18] The idea of identity as free and flexible and gender as performative, not an essence, has become one of the foundations of queer theory.[19]

Butler asserts that gender is performed without one being conscious of it, but says that it does not mean this performativity is "automatic or mechanical." They argue that we have desires that do not originate from our personhood, but rather, from social norms. They also debate our notions of "human" and "less-than-human" and how these culturally imposed ideas can keep one from having a "viable life" as the biggest concerns are usually about whether a person will be accepted, if their desires differ from normality. They state that one may feel the need of being recognised in order to live, but that at the same time, the conditions to be recognised make life "unlivable" and proposes an interrogation of such conditions so that people who resist them may have more possibilities of living.[20]

In the next section, integrate the open-ended framework, laid out by Judith Butler, for understanding and accepting the transpersons, in their desire to live and flourish, in their identities, with the Deleuzian and Guattarian themes of Multiplicity and becoming.

3.2. Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari on Multiplicity and Transfeminism

This section draws upon the critical parameters popularised by Deleuze and Guattari, namely, deterritorialisation, rhizome, and becoming, to show how such concepts find application in the rights of the third gender. Applying Deleuzian-Guattarian concepts to this situation brings into limelight the centre/periphery equation in the constitution of gender subjectivity with the male/female binary at the centre and the third gender at the margins. By deploying the critical parameters of feminism and Deleuzian-Guattarian philosophy, we seek to 'deconstruct' the monolithic nature of gender identity.

17 "Feminist Perspectives on Sex and Gender," *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, 2017.

18 Paul Butler, "Embracing AIDS: History, Identity, and Post-AIDS Discourse," *JAC* 24, no.1(2004): 102, https://www.jstor.org/stable/20866614, accessed 22 March 2024.

19 Li He, "The Construction of Gender: Judith Butler and Gender Performativity," *Advances in Social Science, Education and Humanities Research* 124, no.4 (2017), via Atlantis Press.

20 Judith Butler, *Undoing Gender* (New York: Routledge, 2004).

3.2.1. Transpersonal Identity – A Be-coming

Becoming is a creative process that invents something new. Although the world is in constant flux, cycles and rhythms do emerge that have the capacity to hold discontinuous things together: "A season, a winter, a summer, an hour, a date have a perfect individuality lacking nothing, even though this individuality is different from that of a thing or a subject."[21]

Becomings are not processes that we choose, although our choices may be swept up in becomings. A voluntary transformation would involve a subject who, by projecting an ideal future self, wills a series of actions. But we are constantly disappointed to find that our own efforts to actualise such ways of being are imperfect, if not complete failures. Judith Butler lends the name "despair" to this incomplete mediation of the subject through social processes of identification,[22] and for this reason, the history of gender can be characterised as a litany of failures.[23] In this context, we must briefly consider "becoming-woman:' which remains an important touchstone both for those who praise and criticise Deleuze and Guattari's relationship to feminist theory.[24]

Becomings do not involve moving from origins to destinations, but they can gather together and reassemble elements that have previously become sedimented. Gender is a sedimentation of this kind. For the patriarchal conception of woman to be undermined and dissolved, ideas about both masculinity and femininity need to be transformed, but this cannot happen simply through producing better representations of femininity, or even multiplying different versions of femininity.[25]

The exceptional aspect of transgender and nonbinary identities is not bodily change, but the discursive environment that frames gendered bodily changes as exceptionally open to scrutiny, interrogation, and-in many cases-violence. Not all of the transitions that attend the body are the same and not all of them are received socially in the same way. In invoking the broad concept of becoming, the purpose has not been to flatten out the specificity of trans lives or trans politics. A future oriented transfeminism needs to

21 Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari, A *Thousand Plateaus: Capitalism and Schizophrenia,* trans. Brian Massumi (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press. 1987), 261.

22 Judith Butler, *Senses of the Subject* (New York: Fordham University Press, 2015), 112 –13.

23 *See* Jack Halberstam, The *Queer Art of Failure* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2011).

24 Hannah Stark and Timothy Laurie, "Deleuze and Transfeminism," in *Deleuze and the Schizoanalysis of Feminism*, DOI:10.5040/9781350080447.ch-007, January 2019, https://www.researchgate.net/publication/336780260_Deleuze_and_Transfeminism, accessed 31 July 2025.

25 Hannah Stark and Timothy Laurie, "Deleuze and Transfeminism."

make space for the gaps, ruptures, dead ends, and lines of flight that produce political subjects.[26]

3.2.2. The Authenticity of/in Transpersonal Be-coming

> *Trans women differ greatly from one another. Perhaps the only thing that we share in common is a self-understanding that there was something wrong with our being assigned a male sex at birth and/or that we should be female instead. While some cisgender people refuse to take our experiences seriously, the fact of the matter is that transgender people can be found in virtually every culture and throughout history; current estimates suggest that we make up 0.2–0.3% of the population. In other words, we simply exist*.[27]

Trans individuals aim to establish an ontological concept of gender that includes themselves and their experiences, where those who aim to exclude them misrepresent this argument as one of literal interpretation, when trans women establish that they are women, it is absurd to assume that they mean they experience the exact same physical and social phenomena as cis-women, but what they do mean is that they hold equal claim to the ontological reality of 'womanhood' as cis-women.[28]

Judith Butler makes an important point about the political concept of "authentic" womanhood, admitting that it is necessary to define "woman" as a general signifier, yet no amount of inclusion within the term will result in perfect representation.[29]

Deleuzian feminism provides the most comprehensive bridge between Marxist feminism and Butlerian feminism. In the face of an epoch where LGBTQ+ individuals are becoming more and more visible, it is imperative that we unpack the essential functions of hierarchy. The mind, race, class, gender, and sexuality all stand to other individuals from the "authentic" human experience, and we are met at an impasse between two paths: on the first path we can allow ourselves to be domesticated and integrated into the superstructure that has always oppressed us; on the other path we

26 Hannah Stark and Timothy Laurie, "Deleuze and Transfeminism."

27 Eldritch Hat, "Deleuze, Gender, and the Authentic Experience" *(italics, author's)*, *Medium*, November 20, 2018, https://medium.com/@Eldritchhat/deleuze-gender-and-the-authentic-experience, accessed 29 July 2025.

28 Eldritch Hat, "Deleuze, Gender, and The Authentic Experience."

29 Judith Butler, *Gender Trouble: Feminism and the Subversion of Identity* (New York: Routledge, 1990), 4.

can continue to problematise the superstructure itself until we can properly dismantle its foundation.[30]

In the ensuing section, we apply this Butlerian and Deleuzian framework to enhance our empathic understanding of the Transpersons, into the Praxis mode—being in movement of resistance, celebrating the recent significant acts of protest.

4. Personal is Political: In Movement with the Transpersons

Both the Citizenship Amendment Act and Transgender Persons Act make our already precarious lives even more difficult. The Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act (TPA) was notified by the Government Gazette on 12 January 2020, two days after the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA) was notified. The rules for both Acts have not yet been released, and might affect the ways in which these legislations play out. In both cases, the passage and notification of the bills despite widespread protest from the affected communities is an act of supreme arrogance—a display of majoritarian might. Both acts affect the transgender community and make our already precarious lives even more difficult.[31]

The TPA effectively sets up transgender persons as a category of people upon whom various kinds of discrimination are directly institutionalised by the state. If a transgender person's family is "unable to take care" of them, such a person, even as an adult, may be placed in a "rehabilitation centre" by a court order. This clearly sets transgender persons as a category of people who may be institutionalised and held in custody by the state if not in the custody of family—in violation of our fundamental rights under Article 19 of the Constitution. This section accords sanctity to the family and the state, two of the main perpetrators of violence against the transgender community. Another discriminatory aspect of the bill pertains to punishments for violence against transgender persons, who face elevated rates of sexual and physical assault compared with most other gendered categories. With this bill, transgender persons become a legal category of persons upon whom sexual or physical assault would get punished with vastly lower sentences (from six months to two years) than equivalent sexual assaults upon women (seven years to life) or physical assaults upon people (three months to life).[32]

30 Eldritch Hat, "Deleuze, Gender, and The Authentic Experience."

31 K. R. Bittu, "India's Transgender Community Must Gear Up for A Long Fight," February 6, 2020, https://www.huffpost.com/archive/in/entry/transgender-citizenship-amendment-act_in_5e340c60c5b69a19a4ad9e15. accessed 31 July 2025.

32 Bittu, "India's Transgender Community Must Gear Up for a Long Fight."

4.1. Unmasking the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights Act)

This must be read in conjunction with the fact that under the Act, transgender persons are required to register themselves as "transgender" before the government, regardless of whether they identify as such or whether they want to be publicly known as such. This gendered registration will then extend to all official documents. This gendered registration cannot be altered to any other gender identity without proof of surgery. The government fails to specify what this mysterious surgery is that magically enables the government to recognise one's inherent sense of identity, and, of course the Act does not provide for free provision for the free surgical or medical care by the government. This is a blow to the right to self-identify gender, irrespective of hormonal or surgical interventions, that was enshrined in the Supreme Court's NALSA vs Union of India judgment.[33]

Under the TPA, transgender persons can no longer directly transition from assigned to chosen gendered categories under the radar; the registration as "transgender" with the state is information whose confidentiality is not guaranteed. Transgender persons, who attempt suicide at alarmingly high rates due to the punishing mismatch between an innate sense of one's gendered body and one's position in a gendered society, will now have punitive consequences of the life-saving gender transition process.[34]

There is also a less obvious link between these two acts of law: they are linked by an underlying Brahminism and Islamophobia. The particular form of religious syncretism practised by the traditional transgender community forbids the drawing of religious boundaries between members of the community. Instead, everyone who joins the hijra community has to adopt a common, mixed religious practice. It is common for people joining the community to adopt chosen names that differ from names associated with the religions and castes they were assigned at birth, even as these names also often differ in their gendered connotation. The provision in the TPA that restricts the changing of the last name, during a legal transition of one's official gendered markers, betrays the government's anxiety over this kind of fluidity. It also essentially restricts the trans citizen's right to change a name, if one is changing gender. The TPA is therefore largely written in a way that targets the sanctity of this syncretic community, and its traditions of living and labouring together in ways cutting across religion, caste, and class.[35]

33 Bittu, "India's Transgender Community Must Gear Up for a Long Fight,"

34 Bittu, "India's Transgender Community Must Gear Up for A Long Fight."

35 Bittu, "India's Transgender Community Must Gear Up for A Long Fight."

Conclusion

The journey of transgender individuals is marked by both vulnerability and hope as they navigate societal challenges and seek self-acceptance. Judith Butler's notion of gender performativity and the approach of Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari's perspective on Transfeminism grounded in Multiplicity suggest that gender is not a fixed identity but rather something enacted through repeated behaviours, allowing for a broader understanding of transgender experiences. This perspective highlights the hope for a politics of recognition and politics of representation, which will nurture space for the identity of the Transposons, in a society that often enforces rigid norms. We have to be moving with the Transpersons and their resistance against exploitation and assertion of their rights, in a spirit of intersectionality – listening to the multi-layeredness of their identities and struggles. Revathi poignantly captures this struggle, stating, "To be accepted for who I am is the deepest desire of my heart."[36]

36 Revathi, *Our Lives, Our Word*s.

18

Indigenous Worldview as Hope for a New Society

Raju Felix Crasta

Abstract

This paper explores the relevance of indigenous values and perspectives in addressing contemporary societal challenges. By drawing on the indigenous worldview, which emphasises harmony, communal living, and mutual respect, the paper argues that these values offer hope for creating a just and humane society. Further, it highlights the contrast between the technologically driven, individualistic modern society and indigenous peoples' sustainable, egalitarian practices. Through the lens of naturalism, idealism of freedom, and objective idealism, the indigenous approach to life provides valuable insights into resilience, communal support, and spiritual interconnectedness. These qualities are increasingly vital as the world grapples with issues such as environmental degradation, social inequality, and loss of cultural identity. The paper concludes by suggesting that indigenous wisdom, through its emphasis on balance, reciprocity, and collective responsibility, serves as a blueprint for fostering a new society that prioritises equality, sustainability, and respect for both humanity and the natural world.

Keywords: *Environmental Degradation, Hope, Indigenous People, Justice, Social Inequality, Tribals, Worldview*.

Introduction

Spes non confundit, "Hope does not disappoint" (Rom 5:5), carries significant meaning, intertwined with cultural beliefs and expectations about community, spirituality, and resilience in the indigenous world. In this context, hope may be linked to collective identity, communal support, social norms, spiritual beliefs, and future security as an assemblage of worldviews that affirm perseverance in challenging times. This idea resonates with concepts such as trust in the ancestors or the importance of unity and shared goals, emphasising that faith and hope foster a sense of belonging and potential for a better future.

Indigenous people share a common worldview irrespective of geographical distribution. According to the United Nations' "Factsheet," indigenous people are "those who inhabited a country or a geographical region at the time when people of different cultures or ethnic origins arrived."[1] Although the term is used in a generic sense, it includes various tribes, aboriginals, ethnic groups, *Adivasi*, hunter-gatherers, nomads, peasants, hill people, etc. This paper considers indigenous people predominantly as 'tribals' along with people aligned with tribaldom.

They are commonly termed 'primitive'[2] as compared to the general outlook, but the worldview is exceedingly insightful to the modern place and time vis-à-vis the bourgeoning brashness of the latter. Technological and colonial progress has distanced these 'primitive' cultures, turning them more technocentric or *homo techne*.[3] The influence of Modernism is reshaping their original indigenous worldview. However, it offers the next

1 Oisika Chakrabarti, "Who are Indigenous Peoples?," United Nations Permanent Forum on Indigenous Issues. Accessed 20 August 2024 https://www.un.org/esa/socdev/unpfii/documents/5session_factsheet1.pdf.

2 According to Samuel Lepcha tribals are generally irrational, illiterate, unscientific, subordinate and segregated homogenous groups of people. In the Indian context, they are called Bhumiputra, indigenous, autochthon and primitive people. But he prefers the word autochthon over primitive. *See* Samuel Lepcha, "Philosophizing from the Perspective of the Tribals," George Thadathil (ed.), *Subaltern Perspectives: Philosophizing in Context*, ACPI Series – 6 (Bangalore: Asian Trading Corporation: 2005): 181–182.

3 The term "*Homo techne"* refers to humans as toolmakers and tool users, emphasising the integral relationship between humanity and technology. It captures the essence of the human experience as heavily influenced by technological advancement and innovation. This concept highlights the story of humanity as fundamentally connected to the evolution and impact of technology.

generation a chance to reinvent their past values for a new society based on harmony, reciprocity, and respect rather than dominance and control. This paper attempts to understand the features of the indigenous worldview and show how it brings hope for the world estranged from basic values of humanity and thus proposes a just and humane society.

1. Hope and its Characteristics

The concept of hope, derived from the Greek *elpis* and Latin *spes*, is associated with the goddess of hope.[4] According to Greek mythology, the goddess *Elpis* saved mankind from all the evils of the world that Pandora had released when she opened her jar and scattered its contents. Only Hope remained inside the jar, anticipating the expectation of the future. In other words, it is a chimerical belief in good things to follow, or more generally an expectation.[5]

Philosophically, hope is an optimistic state of mind that is based on an expectation of positive outcomes. It is a belief that things will turn out well, even in the time of adversity. It is a desire accompanied by expectations of fulfilment. Essentially, it is a spark within (fire) that keeps one going, even when things seem bleak. It is the anchor that holds one steady during life's storms.

Hope can be understood from its four characteristics: resilience, faith, desire and expectation. Resilience is the foundation upon which hope is built. It is the capacity to withstand adversity, recover from setbacks, and emerge stronger. Resilient individuals possess inner strength, adaptability, and the ability to learn from failures. This quality is crucial to maintaining hope, as it fuels the belief that challenges can be overcome, leading to personal growth.

Faith is another key element that guides hope. Often, tied to belief in something greater than oneself—whether through religion, spirituality or personal philosophy—faith offers a sense of purpose and meaning. It creates a connection to a higher power or positive force, helping individuals find strength, courage, and optimism during tough times. By anchoring hope in faith, one can see beyond present difficulties and trust in the possibility of better days ahead.

Desire acts as the driving force behind hope. It represents the internal yearning for growth, fulfilment, and positive change. Desire motivates individuals to pursue their goals and provides a clear sense of direction and

4 The Sanskrit word for hope is *pratidhī* or *apekṣa* which means 'to expect or to look for.' S. Monier-Williams, *A Sanskrit English Dictionary*, "pratidhi" and "apekṣa."

5 Peter Slater, "Hope," *The Encyclopedia of Religion* 6 (1987): 459.

purpose. Without desire, hope can stagnate the future possibilities, losing its potency.

Finally, expectation serves as the anchor that grounds hope in reality. It involves believing that positive outcomes are achievable and assessing the likelihood of their occurrence. Expectation isn't wishful thinking, but a cognitive process that helps shape practical paths to success.

In a tribal worldview, hope is deeply intertwined with community, spirituality, and the natural world. Resilience reflects the collective strength to overcome adversity,[6] often rooted in cultural traditions and shared identity.[7] Desire and expectations are tied to communal well-being and the hope for future generations' prosperity. Faith is centred around spiritual beliefs, and connects tribes to a higher power or the land, reinforcing trust in life's processes. Optimism emerges from the tribe's historical perseverance, ensuring survival through challenges. These traits collectively shape the indigenous worldview.

2. Indigenous Worldview and its Characteristics

A worldview is a belief about fundamental aspects of reality that influence one's perceiving, thinking, knowing, and doing. At a cursory glance, it is a way of seeing or thinking. Seen deeper, it is a multidimensional network of strategies held by a particular society in a world of discourse, practice and association.[8] The German term *weltanschauung*— translated as *a look at the world*—shows how one looks and interprets what is perceived and experienced.

Worldview offers a lens through which we can see how one understands, evaluates, and lives in an existential human situation. Wilhelm Dilthey offers us three kinds of worldviews: i. Naturalism which gives importance to the perceptual and experimental determination of what is and allows contingency to influence how one evaluates and responds to reality, ii. Idealism of freedom as represented by Plato, Descartes, Kant, Bergson and others gives significance to freedom of the will, and iii. Objective idealism is monistic and seeks to discern the inner coherence and harmony among all things.[9] Dilthey's these three worldviews—Naturalism, Idealism

6 If we take the history of any tribe, it is associated with the fight for survival, be it with other tribes, nations, animals, land, natural calamities or sickness.

7 Myths are nothing but their existential indigenous life symbolically expressed in terms of stories, songs, anecdotes, events, festivals, etc.

8 Robert Redfleld, 1963. *Human Nature and the Study of Society* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1963), 270.

9 More on this, *see* Rudolf A. Makkreel, Frithjof Rodi, ed., *Wilhelm Dilthey: Selected Works: Ethical and World-View Philosophy,* Vol. 6 (Princeton University Press, 2019).

of Freedom, and Objective Idealism[10]—provide a valuable framework for understanding indigenous cultures. By examining these cultures through these lenses, one can gain unique insights into their distinct perspectives.

Naturalism[11] emphasises the tangible, observable world. The key principle here is, *seen as a basis for unseen.* Epistemologically, *pratyakṣa* (perception) is the *pramāṇa* (source of knowledge) par excellence. Indigenous societies, often deeply connected to nature, align with this worldview. Their experiential knowledge, shaped by environmental factors, informs their survival strategies, rituals, and spiritual practices. Naturalism highlights how these societies adapt to the rhythms of nature, allowing environmental conditions to influence their beliefs, social structures, and values.

Idealism of Freedom focuses on the human capacity for free will and intellectual organisation. While indigenous cultures often adhere to strict traditions, they may also incorporate notions of individual agency, particularly in leadership, spiritual practices, or shamanism. This worldview explores how individuals within these cultures exercise their will to interact with supernatural forces or spirits.

Objective Idealism emphasises the interconnectedness and harmony of all things. Indigenous worldviews are often holistic, viewing the natural, spiritual, human, and cosmic aspects of life as interrelated and balanced. Their belief in the spiritual significance of animals, plants, and natural phenomena reflects this interconnectedness.

This leads to understanding indigenous worldview as "relational" as against linear worldview.[12] In the linear worldview (as in the West), thinking is logical, systematic, and time-oriented, with a beginning and an end. It is based on the idea that the world can be understood through cause-and-effect relationships between events. But in the relational worldview life is seen with harmonious relationships, inter-relating in one's circle of life, involving collective thought patterns or processes. Here paradigms are linked with each other. In a way, the worldview is cyclic[13] where each stands equidistant from the other. Just as the circle has no beginning and

10 Makkreel and Rodi, ed., *Wilhelm Dilthey: Selected Works*, 43.

11 What I mean is not scientific naturalism that holds nature is the only reality and is comprehensively knowable through scientific investigation and observation, focusing on natural laws and forces that govern the universe. Conversely, metaphysical events can be understood through anthropological explanations. For example, the creation of the universe is by earthworm. It brought soil from deep waters and the Supreme Being created earth.

12 Ashis Mohapatra, "Tribal Traditions and their World View," *Global Research Analysis*, Vol. 2, No. 5 (May 2013): 247–248.

13 Lovely Awomi James, *Tribal Theology: Reviewing the Naga Traditional Worldview* (New Delhi: Christian World Imprints, 2017), 101.

end, each one—be it animate or inanimate—is equal and significant. This is clarified in their myths. For example, the Naga myth explains, "Once upon a time there lived a man, a tiger, a spirit with their mother Earth. They lived together as one family, having a single and common mother, the Earth."[14] This portrays the commonness of origin, defined by the core content of all traditions, that in the beginning, all forms of life lived together in peace and harmony in their original innocence and simplicity. There was no temporal binding nor spacial separation. Everything was a 'We and Us' phenomenon. There wasn't any animosity between them. Each had a shared vision of life.

When examining hope within the indigenous ethos through rational inquiry, one often finds a more pessimistic outlook than optimism. A positive sense of resilience is often lacking, with many experiencing feelings of lethargy and low self-esteem despite exposure to modernity. This contributes to lower literacy rates, health outcomes, and socio-economic growth. Their worldview tends to be more empirical, focusing on observable realities rather than deeper logical reasoning. As a result, natural and supernatural elements are given greater importance than inferential knowledge, shaping their understanding of life in ways that prioritise spiritual and experiential over abstract reasoning.

Thus, indigenous worldviews are a complex interplay of naturalism, idealism of freedom, and objective idealism. Their emphasis on harmony, interconnectedness, and the spiritual significance of all things demonstrates a unique perspective on the world. This cosmotheandric worldview[15] is rooted in their deep connection to nature and their understanding of the human capacity for agency offering valuable insights into the diverse ways in which people can perceive and interact with the world.

3. The Desire for a New Society

The concept of an ideal society is a perennial refrain in philosophy and often appears in the sociopolitical field. Plato, in his *Republic* outlines such an ideal where a society is governed by reason and justice. It is characterised by communal living sharing possessions among ruling, warrior and common people. Strict education that emphasises reason, virtue, and the pursuit of knowledge; and justice which he defines as each person performing their appropriate role in society are other features of such societies. Such an elitist perfect society is a utopia for its unrealistic, impractical and undemocratic flavour. In an authoritarian parameter, there is little room for individual

14 James, *Tribal Theology*, 102. Most of the tribal myths are of this kind where there was harmonious shared living in the beginning.

15 For more on tribal worldview, *see* Raju Felix Crasta, "Cosmotheandric Inter-relatedness in the Life and Culture of Tribals of Chotanagpur and Its Global Significance," *Sevartham*, Vol. 38 (2013): 105–122.

freedom or dissent. However, it does offer a provocative vision of a society based on reason, justice, and the pursuit of the good.

In a flawless community, individuals live in harmony, justice and peace. The key aspect of this ideal is equality where individuals are treated fairly and justly regardless of their socioeconomic or cultural background; laws and institutions are designed to ensure that everyone has equal opportunities and is protected from any harm; every individual is treated equally and all live in peace and cooperation, free from conflict and strife; everyone has access to resources and opportunities they need to live a fulfilling life; and individuals have liberty to pursue their goals and express their opinions without fear of reprisal. Though an ideal society is a dream, a society consisting of values can be visualised, and that will pave the way for a new society. This is essential, because of the kind of social milieu we are living. Lovely Awomi James expresses this concern in the following words:

> The crisis that our world is faced with right now is multifaceted in that it affects a wide range of existential relationships – of God with the world of Creation: God and the humans; Humans and non-human natural world of the environments; Humans with fellow-humans, i.e., between men and women; rich and poor; also includes the relationship between people divided by race, ethnicity, culture, political ideologies and so forth. Therefore, every aspect of life inevitably comes under the microscopic lens of scrutiny due to the fact that just as life in entirely is a webbed reality so also its problems (no matter where they are identified) are inter-connected and therefore require an inclusive diagnosis and treatment.[16]

Thus, the desire for a new and better society arises from several pressing issues that the world—in particular our country—is facing. It applies equally to both indigenous and non-indigenous communities.

a. *Economic inequality and poverty*: In recent years, the gap between the rich and poor has expanded, causing social unrest and dissatisfaction. The wealthy grow richer while the poor struggle more. Rural areas face challenges due to limited access to quality education, healthcare, and employment opportunities. As multinational companies exploit mineral-rich regions, the living spaces of ethnic groups shrink, forcing them to migrate in search of livelihoods. Many end up as bonded labourers or "modern

16 Lovely A. James, *Tribal Theology*, 115.

slaves."[17] This deepens the divide among people and perpetuates inequality.

b. *Social and Religious Discrimination*: Despite efforts to eradicate it, caste-creed-race-based discrimination remains global. Instances of religious intolerance and violence are increasing, leading to social polarisation. The Indian constitution recognises the predominant religions of the country, but the indigenous class was named "Scheduled Tribe" in 1950 (Article 342, 366§25). Previously, they were known as 'backward class, primitive tribes, tribes,' etc. One need not enlist discrimination done to these people over the years.
c. *Environmental Challenges*: Air, water, soil, and outer-space pollution are major concerns, affecting public health and the environment. Mother Earth is becoming vulnerable to the impacts of climate change, such as extreme weather events, rising sea levels, ozone depletion, carbon emissions, use of chemicals, wars and use of ammunition, etc.
d. *Political Corruption*: Corruption at various levels of government has eroded public trust in institutions. Corruption hinders development and hampers the delivery of essential services.
e. *Lack of Quality Education and Healthcare*: Many people, especially in rural areas, lack access to quality education and healthcare. The quality of education and healthcare often varies based on socioeconomic status.

In light of the above challenges, how do we foster the dream of a new society, which is equitable, inclusive, and sustainable where everyone has equal opportunities regardless of one's background, cultural ethos, moral and socio-economic well-being?

4. Pointers of Hope in the Indigenous Worldview

Indigenous worldviews offer valuable insights into building a harmonious and egalitarian society. Their traditional values of interconnectedness, communitarian living, respect, knowledge transmission, and environmental stewardship stand in contrast to modern individualism and provide alternative frameworks for addressing contemporary societal challenges.

17 Modern slavery also known as contemporary slavery or neo-slavery refers to situations where individuals are exploited by others for personal or commercial gain. This exploitation can occur through coercion, deception, or force, causing victims to lose their autonomy. It encompasses various forms such as forced labour, human trafficking, servile marriage, debt bondage, and sexual exploitation. *See*, "What is Modern Slavery?," in Hope for Justice [online] (23 December 2021), accessed 20 August 2024 https://hopeforjustice.org/modern-slavery.

4.1. Interconnectedness

The Indigenous tradition of Africa has a concept of *Ubuntu* in their constitution.[18] Though its constitution has not defined the word, *Ubuntu* refers to "a phenomenon of interconnectedness" and "a moral quality of a person,"[19] in the philosophical sense. It is a concept which advocates a plurality rather than singularity, "I am because We are." Archbishop Desmond Tutu explains *Ubuntu*, "One of the sayings in our country is *Ubuntu* - the essence of being human. *Ubuntu* speaks particularly about the fact that you can't exist as a human being in isolation. It speaks about our interconnectedness. You can't be human all by yourself, and when you have this quality - *Ubuntu* - you are known for your generosity."[20] Further, the Archbishop says,

> 'A person is a person through other persons.' It is not, 'I think therefore I am.' It says rather: 'I am human because I belong. I participate, I share.' A person with *ubuntu* is open and available to others, affirming of others, does not feel threatened that others are able and good, for he or she has a proper self-assurance that comes from knowing that he or she belongs in a greater whole and is diminished when others are humiliated or diminished, when others are tortured or oppressed, or treated as if they were less than who they are.[21]

Thus, humanity is defined through one's interactions and relationships with others. No one is born fully formed. Self-awareness and identity are developed by recognising and acknowledging others. This reinforces the interconnectedness of individuals within society.

The concept of communal living is deeply ingrained in the ethos of Asian Indigenous communities. For them, 'isolation is an unnatural state,' with solitude often viewed as the harshest form of punishment. Their lives are built around togetherness—families live in close-knit clusters, and cultivation is always a collective effort. No physical boundary walls separate

18 *Constitution of the Republic of South Africa*, Act 200 of 1993: Epilogue after Section 251.

19 Christian B. N. Gade, "What is Ubuntu? Different Interpretations among South Africans of African Descent," *South African Journal of Philosophy*, Vol. 31, No. 3 (2012): 484–503.

20 Desmond Mpilo Tutu, *No Future Without Forgiveness*, (New York: Doubledey: 1999), 31. *See also*, T. Taabu, "UBUNTU: Brief Meaning of African Word UBUNTU," in Ubuntu Women Institute USA Inc [Blog], 24 January 2012, accessed 20 August 2024 https://uwi-usa.blogspot.com/2012/01/ubuntu-brief-meaning-of-african-word.html.

21 Desmond Mpilo Tutu, *No Future Without Forgiveness*, 31.

their homes or lands; instead, markers like trees or stones define property lines. Group dances, communal celebrations, and village meetings reflect the importance of unity in decision-making. Festivals, religious worship, and even burial grounds are shared spaces, emphasising the significance of community in every aspect of life. Hunting, like other activities, is never a solitary pursuit, and the forest and its resources are considered communal, reinforcing the idea of shared responsibility and ownership.

This interconnectedness permeates every facet of their existence, underscoring the core belief that survival and prosperity are only possible through collective effort and communal harmony. While modern society tends to be individualistic, it often lacks a true sense of 'personhood.' The essence of personhood is "intersubjectivity,"[22] "consciousness,"[23] "possessing rights and duties,"[24] and "an individual substance of a rational nature."[25] When these characteristics are applied to humanity in today's context, it seems they have been lost in an increasingly intolerant world. Human classification within different worldviews reveals a troubling pattern: mutual recognition is often negotiated through violent strategies of subclassification, exclusion, and the elimination of the 'other.' In this context, there is an urgent need to rediscover and embody the true meaning of 'personhood.' Indigenous societies, with their deeply interconnected values, offer an important model for this ideal.

4.2. Communitarian Life

Indigenous communities are fundamentally communitarian people, wherein the concept of the common good forms the foundation of their social organisation. The cultural emphasis on the sense of sharing and communal living is deeply embedded, reflecting a collective approach to life in which resources, responsibilities, and benefits are equitably distributed among all members. This communal framework cultivates a strong sense of belonging and mutual support, ensuring the fulfilment of individual and collective needs through cooperative efforts. Traditional village setups exemplify this communal spirit. In the village, the community spirit is observed while ploughing, transplanting, reaping, building or repairing the houses, digging the well or any other difficult tasks which cannot be done by a family alone.

22 Nikolas Kompridis, "Technology's Challenge to Democracy: What of the Human?," *Parrhesia* 8 (2009), 27.

23 Charles Taylor, "The Concept of a Person," *Philosophical Papers*, Vol. 1 (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1985), 97–114.

24 Pollock, First Book of Jurisprudence, 110. Gray, "*Nature and Sources of Law*," Chapter II, *Black's Law Dictionary* (4th Edition), 1300.

25 Leonard Geddes, "Person," in *Catholic Encyclopedia*, Vol. 11 (New York: Robert Appleton Company, 1911).

Tribals have such concern and communion that the entire village comes forward to assist the needy. Such cooperation is called *Madait* (help) among the tribes of Chotanagpur. Singing and dancing ease their task on such occasions. After the tasks, they are given a meal and rice beer as a token of gratitude.

The common good also operates as a central principle in social and governance structures, sharing resources and the decision-making processes, prioritising the welfare of the entire community. This contrasts with the individualism characteristic of many modern societies, highlighting a distinct communal ethos.

A defining feature of indigenous life is the practice of communal sharing. Food, resources, tools, and labour are often shared among community members, reinforcing social bonds and fostering an inclusive environment where all have access to necessary means for survival and prosperity. These shared practices serve not only to meet material needs but also to strengthen social cohesion.

However, recent shifts in cultural dynamics have introduced consumerist tendencies. Despite the persistence of close-knit familial units, elements of egocentric behaviour have emerged, both within families and in interactions between tribes and non-tribal communities. The adoption of mechanised agricultural practices has diminished the communal sharing of manual resources. Ideally, the indigenous society is an egalitarian unit, yet most of them are either strongly masculine or feministic ones. The suppression of the opposite is a reality which cannot be negated. Furthermore, while village panchayats remain central to decision-making in many areas, political affiliations and party influence have increasingly affected these traditional governance systems.

4.3. Respectful Living

Respect permeates interactions with elders, peers, and the natural world. Elders are revered for their wisdom and experience, and their guidance is sought in all aspects of life. They are seen as custodians of knowledge and tradition, and their advice is sought on important matters. Young people show respect through various cultural practices: seeking blessings, listening attentively, performing acts of service, etc. Youngsters always seek blessings, elders bless and among the same age groups reciprocate equally. This respect ensures that the wisdom of the elders is passed down through generations.

The act of respecting tradition involves maintaining continuity with the past, thereby safeguarding the cultural heritage for future generations.

One such example is the dormitory system,[26] known as *dhumkuria* among the Uraons of Chotanagpur and *morung* among the tribes of Northeast India. Presently, this custom is becoming a thing of the past. These dormitories historically served as spaces where elders transmitted cultural knowledge to younger generations, teaching them songs, dances, stories, marital responsibilities, traditional weaponry, and tribal heroism. However, the rise of modern education systems and the prevalence of hostel culture have significantly contributed to the erosion of this traditional practice.

The Indigenous society, traditionally, embodies an unwavering commitment to equality, ensuring that all individuals, regardless of their socioeconomic or cultural background, are treated with fairness and dignity. This principle is woven into the very fabric of society's laws and institutions, which work diligently to provide everyone with equal opportunities. The emphasis on equality serves as the foundation for a community where justice is not an abstract concept but a lived reality, safeguarding individuals from harm and discrimination. Anyone who debunks this is punished brutally.

Personal dignity and gender sensitivity are integral social norms within indigenous communities. Each individual is valued for their contributions, and dignity is upheld through mutual respect and recognition. Gender roles, though often distinct, are complementary, and grounded in an understanding of the unique strengths and capacities of each gender, promoting a balanced and equitable social structure.

Although individual dignity and gender sensitivity are integral aspects of their cultural ethos, significant violence against vulnerable groups—such as widows, single mothers, children, and individuals who have converted to other faiths—remains prevalent within the society. Violence against women, often justified under the guise of 'witchcraft,' is frequently tied to disputes over land and longstanding animosities. Such violent behaviours are more common in regions with lower levels of literacy. Consequently, the implementation of a robust education system is crucial to elevate these communities from their socio-cultural and intellectual deprivation.

The indigenous society also ensures that every member has access to essential resources and opportunities, enabling them to live fulfilling lives. Justice and liberty coexist harmoniously, allowing individuals the freedom to pursue their aspirations while ensuring that their actions do not infringe upon the rights of others. This balance of individual liberty with the

26 V. Rami Reddy, "Problems and Perspectives of Tribal Education in India," in *Contemporary Society: Developmental Issues, Transition, and Change*, Georg Pfeffer and Deepak Kumar Behera, eds. (New Delhi: Concept Publishing Company, 1997): 216–217.

collective good reflects an ideal vision of a utopian society, where justice, equality, and freedom are not just values but everyday realities.

4.4. Knowledge as Personal Endeavor

In indigenous communities, knowledge is highly personal and carefully guarded, with its transmission often restricted to individuals who have demonstrated a profound commitment to collective values and traditions. Unlike cultures where knowledge is widely disseminated through written texts or public institutions, indigenous knowledge is primarily transmitted orally, usually within families or clans. This method ensures that knowledge remains within the community, shared only with those who have proven their adherence to its cultural values. However, this approach has a drawback: certain traditional practices, such as medicinal and herbal knowledge, though sometimes highly effective, remain obscured and fail to receive the global recognition they might otherwise deserve. The underlying issue may stem from a fear of cultural and social erosion upon contact with external languages and cultures. Additionally, the prevalence of a monolingual culture within individual villages can hinder broader dissemination and growth.

The oral transmission of knowledge emphasises the importance of personal relationships and the situational context in which learning occurs. Storytelling, songs, and oral recitations serve as the primary modes of knowledge dissemination, making the process interactive and personalised. This method not only conveys information but also strengthens communal bonds and ensures cultural continuity across generations. In indigenous communities, the transmission of knowledge extends beyond the mere acquisition of facts or skills; it is inherently tied to the inculcation of values and traditions. Those who receive knowledge are expected to uphold communal norms and contribute to the collective well-being. This focus on the ethical and responsible use of knowledge reinforces the community's social fabric and ensures that cultural wisdom is preserved and respected. However, with the encounter of colonialism and modernisation, the Indigenous identities have either become hybrid or lost. When their oral lores or their knowledge is not embraced by contemporary tradition, has resulted in losing what was considered sacred by them in their former state.[27] In the process what is lost is not just one's sacredness but also one's religious practices, social life, polity, economic concerns, ideology, etc. associated with the worldview.

27 Supongmayang Longkumer, "Indigenous Knowledge and Colonial Encounter: Re-Storying the Tribal Oral Lore in North East India through Reoralizing Hermeneutics," *Bangalore Theological Forum*, Vol. 55, No. 2 (December 2023): 99.

Therefore, in contemporary times, the indigenous orality has to be preserved in written culture and other re-storying techniques.

4.5. Sense of Harmony and Balance

Indigenous peoples maintain a profound sense of harmony and balance between individuals, nature, and the divine. They see themselves as custodians of nature, responsible for maintaining its sanctity and balance. They have a deep-seated respect for nature, viewing themselves as part of a larger ecological system. The Indigenous' dictum of Chotanangpur,[28] "*jal-jaṅgal-jamīn hamārī hain*" (water-forest-land belongs to us) summarises the cosmic worldview. They practice sustainable living, using natural resources responsibly and ensuring that their actions do not harm the environment. Their agricultural practices, hunting and gathering techniques, and conservation efforts reflect this harmonious relationship with nature. However, contemporary society appears to lack such essential, sustainable practices entirely. Harmony with the environment seems to be a myth rather than a reality. For instance, villagers often set fire to the surrounding vegetation to harvest *mahua* (*Madhuca longifolia*) flowers[29] for commercial purposes disrupting nearby trees and wildlife, yet they do not take the initiative to replant such trees in the forest. The practice of hunting has been an integral part of ancient cultures for millennia. However, can this traditional activity be directly linked to the current depletion of wildlife? Could the broader ecological disharmony, be a consequence of colonial influence? Only a thorough and critical self-assessment can offer meaningful insights into these complex questions.

For many indigenous peoples, the natural world is infused with the divine. Often, indigenous people are termed 'the animists.' Animism is the belief that objects, places, and creatures possess a distinct spiritual essence, imbuing them with agency, free will, and the power to animate the believer. E. B. Taylor, argues that animists believe in the "animation of all nature," and are characterised as having "a sense of spiritual beings…inhabiting trees and rocks and waterfalls."[30] The animism concept is drawn from the 'soul,' which could be understood as the soul of an individual capable

28 Chotanagpur plateau is the cultural territory of Jharkhand, Chhattisgarh, districts of Sambalpur, Rourkela, Sundergarh, Jharsuguda, Keonjhar, Mayurbhanj in Orissa; districts of Purulia, Bankura, Midnapur in West Bengal

29 The *mahua* tree blooms in the early summer (March-April) and the flowers are used to prepare alcohol and certain eatables. Seeds are used in making oil.

30 Y.B. Taylor, *Primitive Culture: Researches into the Development of Mythology, Philosophy, Religion, Language, Art and Custom*, Vol. I (London: John Murray, 1920), 426.

of existing after death or upward rank of higher rank of powerful deities.[31] Though Taylor speaks of animist religion for indigenous people, the Asian tribes are not animists. However, the possibility of animist religion among the indigenous people cannot be overruled. Most of the Indian Indigenous people venerate spiritual beings but do not worship them.[32] Worship is only one Supreme Being named differently by different tribes: *Singbonga, Marang Buru, Mahadev, Cando Baba*, etc. There is a strong reverence for the natural elements in the form of surnames adopted by them, spirits seen by the forest and villages etc.[33]

This belief in the sacredness of nature fosters a sense of reverence and responsibility. Rituals and ceremonies often focus on maintaining balance and harmony with the divine forces that govern the natural world. This spiritual connection to nature reinforces the community's commitment to environmental stewardship.

4.6. Sacrosanctum Tradition

Indigenous cultures often rely on an oral intellectual framework for the preservation and transmission of knowledge. In this context, sound, speech, and memory play pivotal roles. Traditional knowledge is stored and passed down through oral recitations, songs, and stories, necessitating exceptional memory skills and a profound understanding of the cultural context. The spoken word is regarded as both powerful and sacred, capable of expressing complex ideas and emotions. 'Memory keepers,' individuals with extraordinary memory abilities, are highly esteemed for their role in safeguarding cultural traditions and wisdom. Despite the frequent undervaluation of their intellectual capacities, these individuals exhibit advanced cognitive abilities. While their potential may be overlooked due to limited exposure and opportunities, their intellectual aptitude is often equal to, if not greater than, that of their peers. When provided with a supportive ecosystem, they have consistently demonstrated their intellectual proficiency.

Memory plays a crucial role in the transmission of worldviews from one generation to the next. However, technological advancements have significantly reduced the reliance on human memory, leading to a rapid decline in the retention of cultural and historical knowledge. Within the

31 Taylor, *Primitive Culture*, 426.

32 John Deeny, *The Spirit World of the Ho Tribals* (Ranchi: Xavier Publications, 2008), 16.

33 Raju Felix Crasta, "Cosmotheandric Inter-relatedness in the Life and Culture of Tribals of Chotanagpur and Its Global Significance," *Sevartham*, Vol. 38 (2013), 11–13.

span of just two to three decades,[34] this shift has caused younger generations to lose their connection to the past. This phenomenon is particularly pronounced in societies closely integrated with urban centres, where the impact is more severe than in rural areas.

4.7. Communal Interdependence

Indigenous communities prioritise interpersonal immediacy and mutual attachment, both of which are central to their social structures. These values are deeply embedded within a communitarian framework, where connectedness and reciprocal support form the foundation of social life. Unlike the often fragmented and complex dynamics of contemporary society, indigenous communities emphasise direct, face-to-face interactions and prioritise personal relationships, thus reinforcing strong social bonds and a heightened sense of communal belonging.

This communitarian orientation underscores the primacy of collective well-being, with decision-making processes centred on consensus. The collective needs of the community consistently take precedence over individual preferences, thereby facilitating robust social support networks and promoting social cohesion. Members of the same clan are considered blood relatives, forming an extended familial network. Consequently, marriage within the same clan is strictly prohibited. Marital practices are governed by a system of tribal endogamy and clan exogamy, whereby individuals marry within the tribe but outside their own clan, ensuring the maintenance of clan boundaries.

Outsiders, often referred to as "foreigners" or "*diku*," are typically viewed as external to the community. However, those who contribute positively to the community's welfare may be integrated and treated as part of the extended family, reflecting the inclusive and merit-based social structure that characterises these societies.

Peace and cooperation are essential to the social fabric of any society, and within indigenous communities, internal conflict is notably absent. Members prioritise harmonious relationships based on mutual respect and shared responsibility, fostering an environment of collective well-being. Individual actions are consistently aligned with the welfare of the group, and cooperation—rather than competition—governs social interactions, allowing the community to focus on common goals. However, inter-tribal conflict remains a persistent challenge. There are instances where one tribe

34 One generation is approximately twenty to thirty years old. "Generational Insights and the Speed of Change," *American Marketing Association* (30 June 2022). Accessed https://www.ama.org/marketing-news/generational-insights-and-the-speed-of-change/, 24 September 2024.

may attempt to dominate or eliminate another,[35] which poses a significant issue that must be carefully managed. This stands in stark contrast to the peaceful coexistence typically observed within tribes and presents a complex dynamic in maintaining broader societal harmony.

4.8. Divine Interpenetration

The concept of divine interpenetration in nature is integral to many indigenous belief systems, where nature is perceived as sacred, and its preservation is a core responsibility. Indigenous cultures regard every element of the natural world as spiritually significant, reflecting a holistic worldview in which nature is inherently holy. This belief forms the foundation of their environmental ethics, guiding the sustainable use of natural resources with reverence and caution to maintain ecological equilibrium.

The responsibility for preserving nature's sanctity is deeply embedded in indigenous cultural practices. Rituals, ceremonies, and daily activities are designed to honour and protect the natural environment. This profound sense of duty fosters a strong ethic of environmental stewardship, ensuring that natural resources are conserved for the benefit of future generations.

Conclusion

The indigenous worldview, with its core values of harmony, respect, and reciprocity, provides a model of societal organisation that aligns with modern understandings of sustainability, social equity, and environmental stewardship. Indigenous societies—often labelled *primitive*—have thrived for millennia by maintaining balanced relationships with their environment, which modern societies are increasingly unable to sustain. These communities demonstrate resilience through deep-rooted practices of communal living, resource sharing, and environmental protection—elements critical to addressing the global challenges of climate change, social inequality, and environmental degradation. Scientific studies have shown that *traditional ecological knowledge* (TEK)[36] can provide valuable insights into sustainable

35 The ethnic clash in Manipur serves as a contemporary example of inter-group conflict. While multiple factors may contribute to such conflicts, it is essential to approach the issue with sensitivity and refrain from commenting on specific causes. The situation reflects the complex dynamics that can arise in societies where ethnic, cultural, and territorial identities intersect, and highlights the importance of addressing such conflicts with care and a deep understanding of the underlying tensions.

36 TEK is a term that refers to the knowledge, beliefs, and practices of indigenous people about the relationships between people and the natural environment. It is a cumulative body of knowledge that has been passed down through generations through traditional songs, stories, and beliefs. Symma Finn, Mose Herne, and Dorothy Castille, "The Value of Traditional Ecological Knowledge for the Environmental Health Sciences and Biomedical Research," *Environmental Health Perspectives* Vol. 25, No. 8

agricultural practices, forest management, and biodiversity conservation, which modern societies are now recognising as vital for long-term planetary health.

Furthermore, social sciences offer frameworks like systems theory[37] and communitarian ethics, which support the holistic view of indigenous societies. These frameworks emphasise the importance of interconnectedness between individuals, communities, and ecosystems, similar to how indigenous communities view humans as part of a larger natural system. The notion of *Ubuntu* and similar indigenous concepts highlight the necessity of communal cooperation, mutual support, and collective responsibility, which are increasingly recognised as vital to addressing societal inequalities and fostering social cohesion.

A key issue for any society is the practice of traditional wisdom and values by one's society. Due to the contact with others, the Indigenous people are losing their sense of culture and values. Many are forgetting their language, culture, dance, festivals, etc. therefore, there is a need to rediscover them and relive them in a meaningful way.

Thus, the indigenous worldview presents not only a cultural or spiritual alternative but a scientifically supported blueprint for creating a more just, sustainable, and resilient future. By integrating indigenous principles of balance, respect for nature, and communal solidarity, modern societies can address the pressing challenges of environmental degradation, economic inequality, and social fragmentation, paving the way for a new, equitable society.

(August 2017), 085006-1. Accessed 23 August 2024 https://doi.org/10.1289/EHP858. Commentary. For more on the traditional Indigenous knowledge and its significance in the scientific world, *see* Raju Felix Crasta, "Science and Indigenous Knowledge: Resisting Biopiracy," in Joy A. P. (ed.) *Philosophizing Science: Promises, Perils and Possibilities*, ACIP Series – 21 (Eluru: ACPI; New Delhi: CWI, 2020): 117–130.

37 Systems theory is an interdisciplinary approach to understanding complex entities by examining their component parts and how they interrelate. It is used in a variety of fields like biology, engineering, management, sociology, and psychology. The core idea is that systems—whether they are biological organisms, mechanical devices, organisations, or communities—are composed of interdependent parts that work together to maintain the whole.

19

Hope of the Periphery in their Culture
An Ethnophilosophical Exploration

Basil Xavier

Abstract

Human life is full of suffering. All the more, the life of the periphery is very pathetic. They are economically exploited, socially discriminated, and politically manipulated. In spite of these sufferings, the subalterns live their life. They rather celebrate life. From where do they get this impetus to live? Their hope is 'culture.' Culture is their 'treasure house.' It is culture which resuscitates them when they are almost dead. Culture is a trench or bunker where the dalits and the periphery hide themselves. They not only hide but also take weapons from their culture to fight against caste and so on. Hence, the only hope of the periphery is their culture. This is demonstrated by conducting an ethnophilosophical enquiry into the myths, forms of worship, rituals, history, profession and identity construction of Arunthathiyars, the dalits of the dalits in Tamil Nadu.

Keywords**:** *African philosophy, Arunthathiyars, Dalit philosophy, Ethnography, Ethnophilosophy, Identity construction, Origin myth, Philosophy of periphery, Profession, Ritual, Worship.*

Introduction

Human existence is characterised by suffering. *Sarvam Duhkham*. Human life is full of agony, pain, sadness, distress, sorrow and misery. All the more, the life of the periphery is very pathetic. They are economically exploited, socially discriminated and politically manipulated. Hence, the subalterns and dalits experience indescribable sufferings and sorrows. In spite of these sufferings, the subalterns live the life. They do not commit suicide and end their life in order to escape from this life. They not only live the life but live it fully. They rather celebrate life. They sing, dance, feast and enjoy life. From where do they get this impetus to live? From where do they draw the power and energy to go on to get along with life?

The answer is 'culture.' The poor and the oppressed draw their strength and energy from their own culture. Culture is their 'treasure house.' It is culture which resuscitates them when they are almost dead. Culture is a trench or bunker where the dalits and the oppressed hide themselves in order to protect themselves from the sufferings and agonies of life. They go to these trenches and bunkers to safeguard themselves from the bombarding of the caste discrimination and economic exploitation and political manipulation. The periphery not only hide but also take weapons from their culture to fight against caste and so on. Hence, the only hope of the periphery is their culture. This is demonstrated by conducting an ethnophilosophical enquiry into the myths, worships, rituals, profession and identity construction of Arunthathiyars, the dalits of the dalits in Tamil Nadu.

1. Is there Ethnophilosophy?

In the context of post-colonialism, the concept of 'ethno'/'ethnic' is becoming popular. Especially in the 'third' world countries, research is done on 'ethno-medicine', 'ethno-chemistry', 'ethno-botany', 'ethno-history', 'ethno-economics' and so on. But unfortunately, 'ethno-philosophy' is an enigmatic word to academic philosophers. Neither in the West nor in the East, is it done. Only in Africa, a certain group of philosophers are doing ethnophilosophy.

1.1. Ethnophilosophy of African Philosophy

There are four trends in the contemporary African philosophy. One among them is ethnophilosophy. Ethnophilosophy consists of shared beliefs, values, categories, and assumptions which are implicit in the language, practices, and beliefs of African cultures. African philosophy is thus found in wise sayings, proverbs, stories, mythology, religion, and the like of the African people. It is being culled out nowadays by academic philosophers. Akan, Azande, Bokis, Igbo, Luo, and Yoruba philosophies are some of the traditional African ethnophilosophies. In short, it is the African worldview. The term ethnophilosophy was coined by francophone African philosophers. This approach is heavily subscribed to by anthropologists, sociologists, ethnologists, and some philosophers. Ethnophilosophy is an attempt to explore and systematise the conceptual world of Africa's traditional cultures.

When human beings reflect on the fundamental questions, they philosophise. Philosophising is part and parcel of human nature. Karl Jaspers rightly says, "Man cannot avoid philosophising." There is no part of the world where humans never reflect on basic philosophical questions about human person, cosmos, and God. Omoregbe says, "It is not only the Western world that men reflect on the fundamental questions about human life or about the universe."[1] He adds, "All civilizations, all people, have their own philosophers…In this Africa cannot be an exception. Unfortunately, due to the absence of records in writing in Africa until recent times, the philosophical reflections of African thinkers were not preserved effectively."[2] "Rational knowledge is not the preserve of the modern West nor is superstition a peculiarity of the African people" claims Kwasi Wiredu.[3] Hence, it is an undeniable fact that philosophy exists in Africa.

Ethnophilosophy is considered as communal property rather than an activity of an individual. Ethnophilosophy is premised on the assumption that there is a philosophy (philosophies?) and an ideology embodied in the traditional wisdom. It aims at thrashing out these philosophies from the myths, folktales, beliefs, proverbs, and languages. Some ethnophilosophers are Kwame Anthony Appiah, Kwame Gyekye, Kwasi Wiredu,[4] Oshita O Oshita, Lansana Keita, Peter Bodunrin, and Chukwudum B. Okolo. Ethnophilosophy is a philosophical interpretation of ethnography of a particular ethnic group.

1.2. Ethnography

Ethnography is a qualitative (as opposed to quantitative) research design aimed at exploring cultural phenomena. It is the branch of anthropology which deals with the scientific description of a particular human society. It is a record of beliefs and practices of a cultural group. Ethnography is a detailed description of events within a particular society to get insights into

1 Joseph I. Omoregbe, "African Philosophy: Yesterday and Today" in *African Philosophy: An Anthology*, ed. Emmanuel Chukwudi Eze (Oxford: Blackwell Publishers, 1998), 4.

2 Omoregbe, "African Philosophy: Yesterday and Today," 5.

3 Kwasi Wiredu, "How Not to Compare African Thought with Western Thought" in *African Philosophy: An Anthology*, ed. Emmanuel Chukwudi Eze (Oxford: Blackwell Publishers, 1998), 195.

4 Kwasi Wiredu, ed. *A Companion to African Philosophy* (Oxford: Blackwell Publishing Ltd., 2006).

their meaning system. In 1947 Melville J. Herskovits defined ethnography as a description of individual culture. Clifford Geertz, in 1973 popularized a term "thick-description"[5] to describe a method of ethnography which involves a detailed, contextualized account of cultural practices. Brunvand in 1986 defined ethnography as an explanation of all the lores of a particular ethnic group.

1.3. Ethnography of Arunthathiyars

In the present socio-cultural situation, Arunthathiyars have the status of being 'the Dalits of the Dalits' in Tamil Nadu. In a caste society they have traditionally been allotted the menial tasks of sweeping and scavenging the streets, cleaning the sewers, and so on. In urban areas, the sanitation work is almost their 'monopoly.' By these services they protect the health and maintain the hygiene of cities and villages. They are also specialists in tanning animal hide and making shoes. Arunthathiyars are both economically and socially at the bottom of the caste pyramid. They are "the untouchables among the untouchables."

Arunthathiyars live in large numbers in Chengalpattu, Cuddalore, Kallakurichi, Villupuram, Salem, Coimbatore, Erode, Dharmapuri, Nilgiris, Karur, Dindigul, Madurai, Theni, Sivagangai, Virudhunagar, and Nellai districts of Tamil Nadu. Arunthathiyars in Tamil Nadu are also known as Chakkiliyar, Pagadai, Thotti, Thomman, Semmaan, Aathi Aanthirar, Aathi Karnataka, and Mathari. But these people prefer to be called 'Arunthathiyar' because they think that the other labels (Chakkiliyar, Mathari, and the like) are given by other caste people to insult them. Therefore, they do not like them to be called by such names.

Arunthathiyars are forced to do the 'so called' traditional or customary jobs especially in the villages. For example, they have to do winnowing in the threshing floor, cobbling, scavenging, carrying of the carcass, announcing the death news, cremating the dead, ululating during the funeral, 'remembering the dead', and so on.

2. Ethnophilosophical Exploration

Inspired by the ethnophilosophy of Africana philosophy, an attempt is made here to delve into the ethnophilosophy of Arunthathiyars. Besides analysing and interpreting the myths, proverbs, worships, rituals, history, and profession of Arunthathiyars, their identity construction is also explored, getting inspiration from the Nationalist-Ideological Philosophy and philosophy of sagacity of Africana philosophy.

5 Cf. Clifford Geertz, *The Interpretation of Cultures* (New York: Basic Books, 1973).

2.1. Origin Myth of Arunthathiyars

Myth plays a vital role in the formation of popular consciousness. Myth is a fictitious story that recounts historical events with the purpose to explain the traditions, major doctrines, philosophy, and religious beliefs of a society. The first version of the story or myth is given here.[6]

Once there lived two brothers. They belonged to *Kambalathar* sect. They had nothing in the world except cattle, i.e., cows. They earned their living through the cattle. One fine day God came to monitor the life of the brothers. The younger brother asked God to divide the property. But the elder brother was not interested in dividing the property. But he accepted later on his brother's compulsion. God, intending to divide the property, brought them to an open field, where some cows were lying and some were standing. God asked the elder brother to choose either the lying cows or the standing ones. He told God that he would prefer the lying cows. When the younger brother was driving the standing cows, some of the lying cows also got up and began to walk. Choosing the lying cows, the elder brother met with a huge loss. Finally, there remained only few old cows and the bony ones. The cows began to die one by one. Not able to buy any food, the elder brother began to eat the meat of the dead cows. He was expelled from his community for having eaten the meat of the dead cows. There was a belief that the descendants of the elder son are Arunthathiyars (belonging to Scheduled Caste - SC) and the progeny of the younger brother is called *Kambalathar* (belonging to Most Backward Caste - MBC).

2.1.1. Immediate Message of Origin Myth

As one reads these myths, the following conclusions are arrived at without much reflection. Arunthathiyars' rights were taken away by others through cheating, conspiracy and that is why they are now made economically poor and socially backward. Though they were the elder among the Kambalathaar, now they have become the least among them. Since they are subservient and docile, they keep silence like a dice.

2.1.2. An Epistemological Excavation into Popular Consciousness: The Deeper Layers of Meaning of These Myths

The crucial issue here in all the six variations of Arunthathiyar Origin myth is beef eating. Beef-eating and no-beef-eating (a socio-cultural act) is linked with the socio-religious concept of Purity and Pollution. Therefore, the anthropology of food i.e. the popular Indian consciousness of food has to be looked into deeper.

6 Interview with Mrs Kuruvamma (age 75), conducted in Alangulam, Virudhunagar District, on 16 April 2011.

Arunthathiyars are considered as lower caste and untouchables only after eating the meat of cow, i.e., beef. The classification based on the food habit is typically Indian. Our society is constructed upon the principle that those who eat vegetarian food are considered superior and those who consume non-vegetarian are looked down upon as inferior. It is based on the ideology of 'clean-unclean.' This discrimination is found even among the non-vegetarians. Those who eat fish, chicken, egg and mutton are considered more superior (MBC & Backward Castes - BC) and those who eat pork (Devendrars, dalits) are superior and those who eat meat of cow are inferior (Arunthathiyars and Adidravidars) and untouchables. This concept of anthropology of food has been forcefully pushed into the popular consciousness of people in India.

When the popular consciousness of Arunthathiyars is delved deeper, it is a 'contradictory consciousness.' Antonio Gramsci, a noted neo-Marxist claims that the uncritical consciousness of the ordinary people is contradictory.[7] On the one side they claim that they are proud to eat beef but they also feel inferior about beef-eating as they share the Indian popular consciousness. The illiterate, rural Arunthathiyar folk in their uncritical consciousness accept this view. But the educated, urban Arunthathiyars challenge this concept of anthropology of food.

2.1.3. From Bunkers to Bombers

There could be two forms of consciousness of the subaltern people namely submissive consciousness and assertive consciousness. When dalit consciousness becomes subservient to dominant social structures and practices, it is submissive consciousness. As a result, dalits cultivate a sense of fear, anxiety, restlessness and emotional resignation. People of submissive consciousness often subscribe to fatalism and determinism. Assertive consciousness is empowerment consciousness. The oppressed people are aware of its richness in ideology, culture and self-confidence. They are driven by moral imperative based on justice and equality.

This can be further explained as 'S. C. consciousness' (Scheduled Caste) and Dalit consciousness. The first belongs to submissive consciousness. They accept their plight without any protest or revolt. In 'S. C. consciousness', they believe in the good will of the government, politicians and the dominant caste people. 'Dalit consciousness' is subversive or assertive consciousness which is empowerment consciousness and therefore, in this consciousness dalits fight for their rights.

7 Antonio Gramsci, *Selections from the Prison Notebooks*, ed. and trans. Q. Hoare and G. Nowell Smith (Hyderabad: Orient Longman, 2004), 323–343.

In assertive consciousness, Arunthathiyars claim that beef is very tasty and cheap. They do not feel ashamed to eat beef. But Arunthathiyar movements totally ban their traditional occupation of 'removing and cremating the carcasses.' They are neither doing this job nor eating meat of the dead cow. The refusal of some practices has helped the Arunthathiyar in the construction of new identity. Arunthathiyars join the other Dalit movements whose slogan is "we eat the meat of cow and live proudly."

Kancha Ilaiah writes, "No god in the world condemned beef as spiritually inferior food. No god said that vegetables do not have life. The Brahmans constructed this hierarchy of food out of thin air, for the purpose of construction of a social hierarchy."[8] While writing about beef-eating of Mala and Madiga of Andhra Kancha Ilaiah says, "Engels, in a summation of L. H. Morgan's *Ancient Society*, said that after human beings learnt to eat beef, there was an enlargement of the brain. Scientific experiments and studies have proven that only beef has 21 percent protein. It is possible that before beef became the staple food, human beings died of hunger. It is known fact that the whole world eats beef as preferred food, whereas the Brahmanical society condemned it as the food of the unworthy."[9]

Having done a detailed theoretical study of beef-eating, Arunthathiyars who are political aware now have hope again in their culture to protest. That's why they assert their culture of beef-eating.

2.2. Worship of Arunthathiyars

Worship is an important aspect of popular consciousness. Worship and rituals are the expression of popular consciousness. Arunthathiyars in the villages worship their clan deities. Most of them worship either Madurai Veeran, Ondi Veeran and their other clan deities. This is part of folk worship. These gods were once human persons who lived in the world. They were brutally murdered because they went against endogamy and casteism. The memories of these murders are still embedded in their popular consciousness. The ordinary dalits could not fight against the 'higher' caste people. Therefore, they started worshipping them. So, the folk worship is the weapon of the weak.

James Scott claims, "In the Third World it is rare for peasants to risk an outright confrontation with the authorities over taxes, cropping patterns, developing policies or onerous new laws; instead they are likely to nibble away at such policies by noncompliance, foot dragging, deception. In place of a land invasion, they prefer piecemeal squatting; in place of open mutiny,

8 Kancha Ilaiah, *Post-Hindu India* (New Delhi: Sage Publications India Pvt Ltd, 2009), 30.

9 Ilaiah, *Post-Hindu India*, 30.

they prefer desertion; in place of attacks on public or private grain stores, they prefer pilfering."[10] These are the 'weapons of the weak.'

From Bunkers to Bombers

This is how folk worship is looked at. But today the situation is different. Maduraiveeran was brutally killed by the King saying that he eloped with one of the wives (Vellaiammal). Actually Vellaiammal (a non-dalit) fell in love with Maduraiveeran and he duly reciprocated this love. Hence, he fought against endogamy imposed by caste system. The real reason for the murder is that Maduraiveeran was against the king who kept a good number of Arunthathiyars as captives for human sacrifice for the Thirumalai Nayakkar Mahāl. That's why Arunthathiyar movements have been asking the government for the past few years to put a statue of Maduraiveeran, the first fighter of caste eradication, in Madurai.

Worship is now becoming part of history in the creation of Arunthathiyar identity. Gods are now made heroes. Reconstructing history is an important aspect. It is a must now to bring out the authenticity of original history and expose false stories constructed artificially by the dominance of the 'upper' caste people. In this aspect Mudurai Veeran is the first proponent of equality against casteism. The histories of Mudurai Veeran—the first man who fought against caste system—and Ondi Veeran Pagadai—the first man who fought for Indian independence—have been recreated by the Arunthathiyar organisations.

Now, Arunthathiyar movements, instead of worshiping Madurai Veeran and Ondiveeran, politicise the history of these heroes. The spiritual status of these clan deities is now demythologised and politicised. Arunthathiyars' hope again is culture. From a culture of worship, they move to politics of protest.

2.3. Rituals of Arunthathiyars

Only human beings can celebrate life. Philosophers in the past have defined human (*homo sapien*) as a 'thinking animal' (Aristotle), 'thinking read' (Pascal), 'thinking thing' (Descartes) and so on. At the advent of anthropology, human beings are defined as celebrating animals (*homo celebratus*). Celebrations are not possible in animal kingdom. However, the present-day society has forgotten this aspect of human phenomena, i.e., celebration. Harvey Cox rightly writes, "Mankind has paid a frightful price for the present opulence of Western industrial society… He has purchased prosperity at the cost of a staggering impoverishment of the vital elements of his life. These elements are festivity - the capacity for genuine revelry

10 James C. Scott, *Weapons of the Weak* (Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1990), xvi.

and joyous celebration."[11] Richard M. Dorson says, "The industrial work ethic has blighted the impulse for communal festivals that enlivens much of the rest of the world."[12] Dorson joins with Harvey Cox who mourns and wails at the disappearance and loss of festivities in the West during the twentieth century.

Victor Turner, the famous anthropologist claims, "The word celebration is derived from the Latin *celeber*, 'numerous, much frequented' and relates to the vivacity—akin to what the great French sociologist Durkheim called 'effervescence'—generated by a crowd of people with shared purposes and common values."[13] Festival is a celebratory event which stands for an affirmation of life in the face of challenges, difficulties and uncertainties in life. Cox claims, "Festival is a special time when ordinary chores are set aside while man celebrates some event, affirms the sheer goodness of what is."[14]

When are celebrations possible? When people come together for certain occasions, they celebrate. What are those occasions? They are either personal or religious. Examples of personal celebrations are birthdays, 'baptism', tonsuring, ear-boring, attaining puberty, marriage, death and so on. Some examples of religious celebrations are worship of clan deities such as Madurai Veeran and Ondiveeran which were discussed earlier. (There can be a third kind of celebration like New Year Day, Independence Day, which can be called secular/social celebrations). In both celebrations, certain rituals are involved.

People's search for meaning in life amidst the painful realities leads them to symbols, rituals and celebrations. Some rituals enable them to relate to God. Rites of passage seek to regulate the various moments of transition in their personal and social lives and build up community.

Life Has to be Celebrated

The hidden philosophy behind these rituals in life is that life has to be celebrated. These people may have many problems, socio-economic-political tribulations; yet they celebrate life. They bubble with life when they come together and celebrate. Writing about dalit's celebrations, Maria Arul Raja says, "The spirit of re-creation can be seen to be the matrix of

11 Harvey Cox, *The Feast of Fools* (New York: Harper & Row Publishers, Inc., 1970), 7.

12 Richard M. Dorson, "Material Components in Celebration" in *Celebration: Studies in Festivity and Ritual* ed. Victor Turner (Washington, D.C.: Smithsonian Institution Press, 1982), 34.

13 Victor Turner, ed. "Introduction" in *Celebration: Studies in Festivity and Ritual* (Washington, D.C.: Smithsonian Institution Press, 1982), 12.

14 Cox, *The Feast of Fools*, 7.

Dalit hermeneutics. This is found in their aesthetic expressions, artistic rhythms, musical performances and decorative artifacts as well as in their celebrations marked by a colourful display of decorations, illuminations, crackers, costumes and delirious dances."[15] More than the psychological benefits they get by coming together, it is the philosophy (*Life has to be celebrated*) which forces them to come together to celebrate. Not only Arunthathiyars but it is an important element in any folk philosophy. These celebrations give these people a chance to come out in public. Otherwise, these oppressed people are probably fearful about the oppressors. Coming together gives them strength. That is why they celebrate life whenever chance permits. Harvey Cox is right when he defines human beings as *homo festivus*. He says, "Man not only thinks, works but he sings, dances, plays, tells stories and in one word celebrates."[16] Arunthathiyars' hope to forget the suffering is found in rituals—another cultural expression.

2.4. Profession of Arunthathiyars

As Arunthathiyars are associated with leather work and cobbling, they feel inferior. They hide themselves in the origin myth which was discussed earlier. But nowadays things are different. As they assert their identity, they claim themselves as leather artisans.

Subaltern Scientists

Kancha Ilaiah rightly calls Madigas as subaltern scientists.[17] The counterparts of Arunthathiyars of Tamil Nadu are Madigas of Andhra. These communities are involved in leather work, cobbling, scavenging and the like. Arunthathiyars must be labelled the subaltern scientists as they are specialists in leather work. Ilaiah says, "Even before a sophisticated knife system emerged, they worked with the hand and a wooden stick in tandem to separate the skin from the carcass, taking care not to tear the skin. It is an acknowledged fact that the evolutionary jump from apes to human beings took place with the effective use of the hand in process of production."[18] The lab of the Arunthathiyars was the open field where they would post-mortem the body of a cow, a bull or a buffalo in order to acquire and impart the knowledge of peeling skin from the body of dead cattle. He further says, "The whole process of leatherwork, which created a new thing from the body of a dead animal, is the most creative thing that happened in India in

15 Maria Arul Raja, "Harmony in the Midst of Anarchy: The Anatomy of the Spirit of Dalit Liberation" in *Vidyajothi Journal of Theological Reflection* 63 (1999), 421.

16 Cox, *The Feast of Fools*, 10.

17 Cf. Ilaiah, *Post-Hindu India*, 25–48.

18 Ilaiah, *Post-Hindu India*, 36.

antiquity, perhaps the first creative thing that happened in this land and later elsewhere."[19]

The scientific role of salt in keeping the wet skin from rotting was discovered by the Arunthathiyars several centuries ago. The tanning process is another wonderful discovery by these subaltern scientists. The six steps, discussed earlier in this chapter, involved in tanning process are salting, liming, dehairing, defleshing, deliming, and tanning. For this invention of tanning, Arunthathiyars must have been awarded with Nobel Prize!

Another valuable agrarian instrument in which leather played a vital role was the irrigation bucket. The earliest form of irrigation in India was well irrigation and the buckets/bags used for that purpose were made of leather. "These buckets made human settlement in villages which are far away from rivers possible. Digging of wells and drawing of water from those wells with the help of the leather bucket improved living conditions and also agrarian production" says Ilaiah.[20]

The most important instrument that the Arunthathiyars designed and developed in the process of advancing the leather economy was the needle used to stitch shoes and so on. This instrument played a vital role in moulding the leather into an agrarian usable commodity like leather ropes, bags and buckets and leather instruments like *chappals* and shoes. Its last shape was that of *dappu* which might be termed the first musical instrument. They also took the help of carpenters and ironsmiths in shaping these tools. Therefore, the Arunthathiyars are subaltern scientists. Thus, Arunthathiyars' hope is again in their culture—from the culture of customary jobs to culture of proud profession!

2.5. Identity Construction of Arunthathiyars

As we study here the identity construction of Arunthathiyars, identity movements, identity politics and their philosophical schools especially post-colonialism and postmodernism are briefly elucidated.

2.5.1. Post-colonialism and Identity Movements

All the socio-political movements of the world in the recent past can be classified into three types: bourgeoisie democratic political movements of European origin, communist political movements with class orientation, and identity movements. A lot of research has been done on the democratic and communist movements. Scholars are now interested in the exploration of the third type of movements namely identity movements. Identity movements

19 Ilaiah, *Post-Hindu India*, 37.

20 Ilaiah, *Post-Hindu India*, 39.

focus their attention on the identity of language, religion, ethnicity, caste, race, sex, region, and so on.

Western scholars write that identity movements were born in the postmodern context in the last decades of the twentieth century. They claim that identity movements are the offshoots developed to address the failures of the both bourgeoisie democratic and communist movements. But some postcolonial thinkers claim that this is a reductive and Eurocentric view of Western scholars. Rather, identity movements came into existence in Asia-Africa and Latin American countries during their colonial period. In the context of colonialism, local people wanted to preserve their indigenous culture and tradition and it is a reaction against the imposition of western culture. This is how identity (cultural) movements emerged when ordinary people could not directly confront the colonial power.

When identity movements came into existence in the later nineteenth century, there was no universal philosophy or theory to justify them. Only in the twentieth century, few philosophies came to their rescue. The theoretical meeting point of Marxism, Existentialism and Nationalism boosted up these identity movements. Marxian ideology of class struggle and imperialism fascinated the revolutionaries of Asia-Africa-Latin America who were tormented by colonialism. Yet, in their colonised countries they could not exactly see the two classes, namely—bourgeoisie and proletariat. For example, in Africa people are not only exploited economically but also ethnically and racially.

Marxism approached the world objectively, whereas existentialism and phenomenology claim that in every act of knowing, there is the very personal participation of the knower. Existentialism questions Cartesian philosophy, which prioritises human 'thinking.' It speaks instead of 'living' and 'experiencing.' The concept of the 'lived-world' comes to prominence. It is a reaction against the crude objectivism and it promotes a non-dichotomy between the subject and object, or the knower and the known. Some of the Marxist and nationalist-political thinkers in Africa such as C. L. R. James, Senghor and Franz Fanon used existentialism in their philosophising. Thus, this philosophical meeting point of Marxism, Existentialism and nationalism gave impetus to the identity movements which had sprung just then. Hence, the dialectic between objectivity of Marxism and subjectivity of Phenomenology-Existentialism could not be avoided. Epistemologically and politically, there was a productive synthesis between these two schools.

2.5.2. Characteristics of Identity Movements

It is very difficult to generalise the salient features of identity movements of Asia-Africa-Latin America in the nineteenth and the twentieth centuries because of their spatio-temporal differences. Yet few important specific characteristics can be discussed.

Identity movements had to address the issue of tradition and modernity. When colonialism entered into Asian, African and Latin American countries, it 'introduced' European modernity. Simultaneously there were different attempts by local people to prove that their cultures or religions were already modern. Two important things happen here. Firstly, there is a hypothesis that modernity belongs only to Europe. Secondly, when indigenous people were trying to prove that their culture too was modern, they incidentally accept the European yardsticks of modernity. With these confused double standards, identity movements travel by giving importance to 'reconstruction' and renaissance. Hence, there is a new space between tradition and modernity. Postcolonial thinkers like Homi Bhabha, call this as 'Third Space.'[21]

Either religion or language or caste becomes the important symbolism for identity movements. Yet the essence of this symbol cannot be defined. It is very difficult to define the essence of religion or characteristics of language or history of caste and so on. People involved in identity movements continually search, select and reconstruct these identities. Hence, identity is not a closed essence; it is only a fluid signifier. Tradition and history are open for multiple reading or 're-reading.'

Identity has a quality of 'over determination.' This is a concept developed by Louis Althusser, a French Marxist and Structuralist. There is no one factor or one contradiction responsible for social revolution. Multiple factors—economic, ideological and political—are involved. This is what Althusser calls 'over determination.' Therefore, 'over determination' becomes a quality of identity and it is more inclusive in nature. This concept of 'over determination' of identity is explained in a different way by Ernesto Laclau. He says:

> At this point we can go back to our discussion of discursive totalization. We saw that there is no totalization without exclusion, and that such an exclusion presupposes the split of all identity between its differential nature, which links/separates it from other identities, and its equivalential–bond with all the others *vis-a-vis* the excluded element. The partial totalization that the hegemonic link manages to create does not eliminate that split but, on the contrary, has to operate out of the structural

21 Homi Bhabha, *The Location of Culture* (London: Routledge, 1994), 36.

possibilities deriving from it. So both difference and equivalence have to reflect themselves into each other.[22]

2.5.3. Identity Movements: Some Problems

In any identity construction, similarities are highlighted and differences are side-lined. When unity is insisted in the name of identity, certain differences are undemocratically ignored and brushed aside. When an identity is constructed without acknowledging the inner differences, it may lead to fascism.

Identity construction gives meaning for my existence. Identity becomes my God and Opium. In any identity, I am not alone; I become a 'group.' Now my sufferings are not mine—they become part of the group to which I belong. Within that group or identity, I can cry, lament, and hug another member, and whimper together. Zygmunt Bauman, while discussing identity, writes: "We need relationships, and we need relationships in which we count for something, relationships to which we can refer in order to define ourselves."[23]

2.5.4. Identity Movement of Arunthathiyars

A cursory look at the political history of Tamil Nadu paves way to the understanding that identity construction of Arunthathiyars is the culmination of various identity movements in the recent past. A bird's eye view of the past history of Tamil Nadu shows that Tamil, Dravidian, Dalit identities were successively constructed. When the rationale of those identity movements is analysed, it can easily be inferred that Arunthathiyar identity construction is a progression from Dalit movements. As a continuation of these identity movements, dalit movements arose in 1980s and 1990s. Dalits rejected by Tamil and Dravidian movements started constructing their identity. However, even in this dalit movement, Arunthathiyars problems were adequately not addressed. In the first decade of the twenty-first century, Arunthathiyars, dalits of dalits started asserting their identity.

Arunthathiyars, who were pushed to the periphery by all the 'centres' of previous identity movements, even by dalit movements—fought and won inner reservations. Zygmunt Bauman claims, "The idea of identity was born out of crisis of belonging."[24] Arunthathiyars were under the crisis of belonging to the category of dalits as the concerns of Arunthathiyars were neglected by most of the dalit movements. Thus, a new identity—the identity of Arunthathiyars—was born during the struggle for inner

22 Ernesto Laclau, *On Populist Reason* (London: Verso, 2007), 78.

23 Zygmunt Bauman, *Identity* (Cambridge: Polity Press, 2005), 68.

24 Bauman, *Identity*, 20.

reservation. Arunthathiyars are suppressed and deceived in education, employment, politics, literature, religion, language, and media not only by the so-called upper caste people but also by fellow dalits. The demand of inner reservation was vehemently opposed by non-Arunthathiyar dalits as pointed out by M. Mathivannan, an Arunthathiyar poet and scholar.

2.5.5. Postmodernism and (Arunthathiyar) Identity Politics

Postmodernism speaks about the crisis of identity politics and the rise of the politics of difference. Grand narratives or Meta-narratives construct one identity. It argues that identity is not accidental but essential, natural, and inevitable. In this identity differences are reduced or forgotten. This identity politics rejects the existence of the 'other.' Peripheries are ignored. Therefore, postmodernism celebrates differences and talks about the politics of periphery. It talks about the remainders. This politics of remainders is the identity construction of the subaltern or periphery. The concept of periphery is a little complex. Sometimes a periphery while constructing its identity (e.g. dalits) becomes a centre when compared to another periphery (e.g. Arunthathiyars—the periphery of the periphery)

On the above basis, Linda Nicholson and others talk about 'Difference Feminism' (1996). Though all women are at the periphery, black women can never be equated with white women. In the Indian situation, the problems of dalit women are entirely different from those of Brahmin women. Kwame Anthony Appiah argues that the troubles and tribulations of blacks in America are different from those of blacks in Africa.

This politics of remainders and difference is applied in Tamil Nadu politics now; it explains why Tamil, Dravidian, Dalit, and now Arunthathiyar identities are successively constructed. When Tamil identity was constructed, OBCs became periphery. When they started constructing Dravidian identity, dalits became periphery. When dalit identity was constructed, Arunthathiyars—dalits of dalits—became periphery of the periphery. Therefore, the construction of identity of Arunthathiyars is not only against the dominant castes but also against the fellow dalits who oppress them. Power is not one-dimensional. Foucault rightly says, "Power is everywhere not because it embraces everything, but because it comes from everywhere."[25] Zygmunt Bauman, a postmodern ethicist, talking about identity writes, "Whenever you hear that word (*identity*), you can be sure that there is a battle going on. A battlefield is identity's natural home. Identity comes to life only in the tumult of battle; it falls asleep and silent the moment

25 Michel Foucault, *The History of Sexuality, Vol. I: An Introduction*, trans. R. Hurley (New York: Pantheon, 1978), 93.

noise of the battle dies down."[26] The movement of Arunthathiyars for inner reservation shows this battlefield. Arunthathiyar identity movements rightly claim, "The condition of liberation of Arunthathiyars is the liberation of dalits. Liberation of Arunthathiyars is the liberation of all."

Conclusion

Animals experience suffering but they are not conscious of it. On the contrary, human beings are conscious of their suffering. Human life is full of agonies, pain, sadness, distress, sorrow, and misery. All the more, the life of the periphery is very pathetic. People in India are divided in the name of caste. The so-called 'upper' caste people torture the so-called 'low' caste and dalits in the name of *Manu Dharma*. In spite of these sufferings, the subalterns live the life. They do not commit suicide and end their life in order to escape from this life which is full of pains and sorrows. They not only live the life but live it fully. They celebrate life. They sing, dance, feast, and enjoy life. From where do they draw the power and energy to go on to get along with life?

The answer is 'culture.' The poor and the oppressed draw their strength and energy once again from their own culture. Culture is their 'treasure house.' It is culture which resuscitates them when they are almost dead. If they do not do so, they will die. The survival instinct is drawn from their culture. Culture is a trench or bunker where the dalits and the oppressed hide themselves in order to protect themselves from the sufferings and agonies of life. They go to these trenches and bunkers to safeguard themselves from the bombarding of the caste discrimination, economic exploitation, and political manipulation. The subalterns not only hide but also take weapons from their culture to fight against caste, etc. This is what is argued in this article by exploring the ethnophilosophy of Arunthathiyars by making a deep probe into their origin-myths, worships, rituals, profession, and identity construction. Arunthathiyars—dalits of dalits— hide themselves in cultural bunkers in 'S. C. consciousness', whereas they become bombers in 'Dalit consciousness' by taking weapons from their culture.

26 Bauman, *Identity*, 77.

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Plunirality as the Metaphysical Foundation and Hope of Democracy in India

George Panthanmackel

Abstract

Being is pluniral, i.e., being is one-in-many. Being is a 'society' of one in many. The phenomenal democratic society is only a manifestation of the pluniral nature of Being, which is the metaphysical foundation of it. In other words, Being, which is pluniral, is the metaphysical foundation of democratic society. It implies that a democratic society should never strive towards a society where unity is overemphasised at the expense of genuine plurality; in the same way, plurality should never become the norm of life in such a way that it destroys genuine unity. If unity is overemphasised, democracy will turn into a kind of 'democratic dictatorship.' Similarly, if plurality is overemphasised, a democratic society will be changed into chaotic anarchy. Hence, a true democratic society should do justice to both: to unity and plurality. It is possible if we can understand the original, metaphysical, inseparable unity of both unity and plurality as expressed by the term, "plunirality." Plunirality is the nature of Being, of every being. Hence, if a society upholds the pluniral nature of Being and beings, it can never be violent. Violence and conflict are the results of the forgetfulness of this original

plurinality of Being and beings. Respect for plurinality of Being and beings lead the citizens of a country to greater harmony, peace and prosperity. The democratic values of equality, fraternity and liberty will have to show forth themselves in the ideals of justice and human rights particularly expressed in a nation's commitment to plurinality. The citizens of India are called upon to appreciate and promote the foundation and hope of our democracy, which is pluniral and unique in the world.

Keywords: *Aristocracy, Brahman, Equality, Federalism, Fraternity, Justice, Liberty, Monism, Reformation, Sovereignty*.

Introduction

Democracy is a system of government[1] of the people, by the people, and for the people in which the supreme power is vested with the people who exercise their power directly or through their elected representatives.[2] Over the past two decades, a democratic revolution has been sweeping the world, starting in Latin America, then spreading through Eastern Europe and most recently across Africa. Some 117 of the world's 191 countries are considered democratic. Over the past two centuries, the rise of democratic forms of government has been closely associated with peace, social stability and rapid socio-economic development. Democratic countries have been more successful in living peacefully with their neighbours, educating their citizens, liberating human energy and initiative for constructive purposes and economic growth.[3] In spite of its enormous contribution to an all-round development of society, the process responsible for the emergence and successful adaptation of democratic institutions in society has often been wrongly understood, and there are many instances of failure of its noble objectives. The recent increase in violence and numerous instances of rampant corruption in society are clear indications of the inadequacies and weaknesses of our system too. It is also a clarion call to think anew about how to strengthen democracy, or rather on how to transform it without undermining its own perennial and positive foundational features.

The present crisis of democratic governance is largely due to prejudices against democracy that reveal absence of conviction in its favour. When

1 John Pike, *Political Philosophy A–Z* (Edinburgh: Edinburgh University Press, 2007), 40–43.

2 Merriam-Webster, "Democracy," *Merriam-Webster.com Dictionary*, https://www.merriam-webster.com/dictionary/democracy, accessed 16 June 2011.

3 International Centre for Peace and Development, "Democracy," http://www.icpd.org/democracy/index.htm, accessed 23 July 2011.

one goes deeper into the metaphysical foundation of democracy one finds that it has its ultimate foundation in the nature of Being which is one in many, or pluniral. Unless and until humans understand and appreciate the significance of its deeper metaphysical roots, they may look upon it merely as a form of governance which could be done away with at will. History of humankind teaches us that whenever humans lacked democratic approach and spirit (as in the case of Second World War), they faced the worst crisis. It is because human's metaphysical nature and fundamental moral orientation are democratic and pluniral, founded on the nature of Being which is pluniral. In this article, an attempt is made to contend that the foundation of democratic society is plurinality (inseparable integration of plurality and unity) of society, which has its ultimate foundation in the plurinality of Being studied in metaphysics.

1. Forms and Origins of Democracy

1.1. Forms of Democracy

There are two forms of democracy: direct and representative.

1.1.1. Direct Democracy: Direct democracy believes that all people should actively participate in the democratic system so that it is representative of the people. Direct democracy gives all people the right to participate regardless of religious beliefs, gender, sexual orientation, physical well-being, etc. Only those who have specifically gone against society are excluded from direct democracy, particularly those in prison who have offended society in some way and, therefore, their democratic rights are suspended for the duration of their time in prison.[4]

1.1.2. Representative Democracy: India is a representative democracy in which the citizens elect representatives to make laws. Every five years in India, the people have the chance to vote into power those they wish to represent them in Parliament. In stark comparison to direct democracy, the people hand over the responsibility of lawmaking to someone else who wishes to be in that position.[5]

1.2. Origins of Democracy

1.2.1. Origin of Democracy in Greece: The origin of democracy can be traced back to the Greek city-state of Athens. A democratic government responsible to the people, of trial by jury and of civil liberties of thought, speech, writing and worship were valued by the Greeks. It was their sense of

4 Chris Trueman, "British Politics," *History Learning Site*, https://www.historylearningsite.co.uk/british-politics/, accessed 4 May 2011.

5 Trueman, "British Politics."

liberty, individual and collective, which inspired them to accomplishments in philosophy, politics and science. The Greeks gave to humankind the idea of politics as the business of citizens as against the arbitrary rule of the despots. The democracy propounded by the Greeks enjoyed a short span of life. The Romans, successors to Greek ideas and institutions, at first seemed to embrace Athenian democratic principles. The regime of the Romans was a mixture of kingship, aristocracy and democracy. Its aim was the collective welfare of society. But the exigencies of governing an expanding empire led to the corruption of individual rights by the arbitrary power of monarchy and aristocracy.[6]

1.2.2. Origin of Democracy in England: The latter half of the Middle Ages saw the rise of universities and educational establishments. The ideal of education changed from the training of religious scholars to the training of accomplished persons to serve the state. From 1480 to 1660, fifteen grammar schools, with places for 1,500 boys, were founded in London alone. By the end of Henry VIII's reign, almost every town had a grammar school. The Reformation freed education from the hands of religion. New ideas of democracy and equality flourished in an atmosphere of free discussion and debate. Demands were made for parliamentary reforms, the sweeping away of all manner of privileges, and the rise of liberal opinions can be attributed to the rising level of literacy in England. The revolution of 1688 gave power to the merchants and the landed aristocracy. The financial and constitutional conflicts of the 17th century ended in the establishment of the power of the parliament. The shifting of power over finance from king to parliament was one of the central factors that helped in the steady extension of democracy.[7]

2. Democracy in India

India is the biggest democracy in the world. The democracy of India is derived from the Constitution of India. Indian democracy since independence is infused with the spirit of justice, liberty, and equality. Sovereignty is a vital feature of Indian democracy. Sovereignty refers to the full power of a governing body over itself without outside interference. People can exercise power in Indian democracy by electing their own representatives, who remain responsible to the common people. It works on the principle of equality. It means all citizens of India are equal before the law. There is no discrimination on the basis of religion, caste, creed, race, sect, etc. Hence, every Indian citizen enjoys equal political rights.[8]

6 International Centre for Peace and Development, "Democracy."

7 International Centre for Peace and Development, "Democracy."

8 Vedantu, "Essay on Democracy," https://www.vedantu.com/democracy-essay, accessed 21 August 2024.

2.1. Features of Indian Democracy[9]

i. **Rule of the Majority:** Rule of the majority is an essential feature of our democracy. The party which wins the most seats forms and runs the government.
ii. **Federalism:** India is a union of states. The states are somewhat autonomous and they enjoy freedom in certain matters.
iii. **Collective Responsibility:** The Council of Ministers is collectively responsible to their respective legislatures. No minister alone is responsible for any act of their government.
iv. **Formation of Opinion:** The government and its institutions must work on the basis of public opinion, which must be formed on various matters. The Parliament and legislatures of India provide an appropriate platform to express public opinion.

2.2. Ways to Strengthen Hope in Democracy[10]

i. **Stop Blind Belief:** People must stop having a blind belief in the media. Some media outlets may propagate the propaganda of a particular political party. Therefore, people must be watchful when accepting media news.
ii. **Reject the consumer mentality in elections:** Several Indians view national elections like consumers buying a product. Elections should make Indians feel like participants rather than observers.
iii. **Make Voices Heard:** Citizens should make their voices heard. They must try to communicate with their elected representatives all year-round instead of just during elections. Citizens must write, call, email, or attend community forums to communicate with their elected representatives.
iv. **Huge voter turnouts:** People must avoid hesitation and come out to vote. Large voter turnout would signify a substantial involvement of the common people in Indian politics.

The democracy in India is something very precious. It is a gift of the patriotic national leaders to the citizens of India. The citizens of this country must realise and appreciate the foundation and hope of our democracy, which is certainly pluniral and unique in the world.

3. Pluniral Society as the Foundation of Democracy

What exactly is a society? A society is not necessarily the same as a nation-state, although in the modern world the two are often identical. Many nation-

9 Vedantu, "Essay on Democracy."

10 Vedantu, "Essay on Democracy."

states include smaller societies within their own borders. Many insects, fish, birds, and mammal species are also social animals – such as ants and bees, herrings and sardines, wolves and elephants. But non-human societies depend for their survival and functioning primarily on unlearned (instinctive) patterns of behaviour. As a result, different societies of any one species, be they termites or zebras, are virtually identical. Their societies may differ somewhat in size, but there is little or no difference in the social behaviour of their members from one society to another. When you have seen one nest of a particular termite species, you have for most purposes seen all the nests of that species. Human societies are radically different. The organisation and characteristics of each human society are not based on the rigid dictates of its members' instincts. They are created by human beings themselves and are learned and modified by each new generation. Consequently, although all human beings are members of the same biological species, every human society is different.

Although there are non-human societies of animals, humans are essentially social by nature, necessity, and personality. Human nature is such that one cannot afford to live alone. For normal growth as a human being, one needs a society, which is a group with certain characteristics such as definite territory, sexual reproduction, comprehensive culture, independence, and integration. These characteristics are fundamental to social structure, which refers to the organised relationships between the basic components in a social system very much manifest in pluniral social interaction.

Pluniral Social Interaction

Pluniral social interaction is the process by which people act and react in relation to others. Almost all human action or behaviour is oriented toward other persons.[11] A woman nodding to someone she meets on the street, an angry father scolding his child, and teacher giving students an assignment for the next day are all interactions. There are mainly eight broad or universal types of social interaction: cooperation, conflict, coercion, isolation, competition, exchange,[12] accommodation, assimilation and integration.[13]

a. **Cooperation:** Cooperation is interaction in which individuals or groups act together in order to promote common interests or shared goals. They achieve goals that might otherwise be difficult

11 Allan G. Johnson, *Human Arrangements: An Introduction to Sociology* (London: HBJ Publishers, 1989), 161.

12 David Popenoe, *Sociology* (New Jersey: Prentice Hall, 1977), 45–48.

13 Samuel König, *Sociology: An Introduction to the Science of Society* (New York: Barnes & Noble Books, 1968), 265–278.

or impossible to achieve individually. All social life, in this way, is based on cooperation. People band together in groups to adapt to the environment. They work together to meet individual needs efficiently and to provide mutual protection from threats of other societies. Society would be inconceivable without a minimum of cooperation.[14] Sociologists identify four main types of cooperation: spontaneous, traditional, directed, and contractual.[15] *Spontaneous* cooperation is the oldest and most universal. It arises out of the needs and possibilities of a situation, as when witnesses to an accident jointly give aid to the injured. *Traditional* cooperation is cooperation ingrained in a primitive tribe through repetition from one generation to another. The cooperation that originated spontaneously has become an established custom and tradition passed on from generation to generation – for example, a cooperative venture began among the families of a medieval Indian village. *Directed* cooperation is the one directed by a third party who holds a position of authority. The third party may be a swimming instructor who tells students to pair up when they go into the water. *Contractual* cooperation is that in which groups agree to cooperate in certain explicit ways, with the obligations of each clearly spelled out. A group of young mothers, for example, take turns caring for each other's children so that each can have some free time.

b. **Conflict:** Conflict is the process of social interaction in which two or more persons struggle with one another for some commonly prized object or value. It is the opposite of cooperation in which defeat of the opponent is considered essential for achieving the desired goal. Conflict arises because of scarce resources, in the pursuit of which each individual tries to subdue the others as much as necessary to satisfy one's own desires. George Simmel identified four major types of conflict: wars between groups, feuds or factional strife within groups, litigation, and the clash of impersonal ideals.

Some social thinkers have opined that conflict is a problem caused by faulty social organisation and that conflict would not arise in a perfect society. However, several sociologists have emphasised that conflict has some positive aspects. It can serve as a force that integrates the people on opposing sides. It may also lead to needed social change. Even if society could somehow succeed

14 David Popenoe, *Sociology*, 48.

15 Popenoe, *Sociology*, 48–50.

in eliminating conflicts, such a state might not be desirable. A conflict-free society would be lifeless.

c. **Coercion:** Coercion is one person or group forcing its will on another. All forms of coercion, to a large extent, rest on the threat of the ultimate use of physical force or violence. It is usually much more subtle than the open use or threat of violence. Love for a parent, faith in God, and fear of loneliness can all be used as weapons of coercion. It is usually viewed as a negative kind of social interaction. But it also has positive social functions. Although parents and educators use many patterns of social interaction in socialising children, coercion is often very effective in teaching what is right and what is wrong.

d. **Isolation:** Isolation is the absence of communicative interaction or social contact. Both individual and group can be isolated. Two main types of isolation may be distinguished: spatial isolation and organic isolation. Spatial isolation is an externally enforced deprivation of contacts through imprisonment or banishment. Organic isolation is caused by certain organic defects of the individual such as deafness or blindness.[16]

Isolation is considered to be a negative value. Despite temporary or partial isolation being useful, complete isolation can be harmful. An individual or group may sometimes have to withdraw from society, in order to preserve self-identity, but if one or group is completely separated from the rest of society for a long time, the result can be mental retardation or breakdown of personalities as humans can grow only with the help of other fellow beings.

e. **Competition:** Competition is a kind of cooperative conflict by which individuals and groups struggle to reach the same goals, but their main concern is directed toward the goals being sought, not toward the competitors. Although the defeat of the competitor is not the primary aim in competition–as in conflict–one competitor will attain the goal and the other will be defeated. Unlike cooperation, the competitors seek their goals separately, in rivalry with one another. To prevent competition from degenerating into conflict, it is necessary for parties to abide by the 'rules of the game.'

f. **Exchange:** Exchange is a form of interaction by which a person acts in a certain way toward another for the purpose of receiving

16 Vidya Bhushan and D. R. Sachdeva, *An Introduction to Sociology* (Allahabad: KitabMahal Agencies, 1987), 163–164.

a reward or return. The rewards need not be monetary or material. Subjective emotional rewards form the basis for many social exchange relationships. Exchange relationships based on gratitude are more significant in people's lives than is generally understood. Sheltering a victim of communal riot in one's own house, helping an elderly person across the street, sending a small gift to a co-worker who is ill–underlying all these actions is the expectation that the other person will feel grateful for what you have done. One's love for another is not based solely on an expected return of that love, but that expectation nonetheless is a part of the relationship. If the person never receives any gratitude for the love offered, one's feelings of love probably will not survive the unfair exchange.

g. **Accommodation:** Accommodation denotes acquired changes in the behaviour of individuals which enable them to adjust to their environment. It is distinct from adaptation, which is adjustment through organic or structural modification transmitted through heredity. Accommodation, on the other hand, is adjustment achieved through the acquisition of behaviour patterns transmitted socially and through adopting new ways of behaving. Animals lower than humans adjust themselves through adaptation, whereas humans adjust themselves through accommodation. This is due to the fact that human life in a truly social environment which demands adjustment to it.

h. **Assimilation:** Assimilation is the process through which persons and groups acquire the culture of another group by adopting its attitudes and values, its patterns of thinking and behaving. It is a process by which persons and groups acquire the memories, sentiments, and attitudes of other persons or groups by sharing their experience and history. The assimilating groups incorporate into them the common cultural life of the assimilated group. In the process of becoming assimilated, individuals or groups give up their own culture to adopt that of others. In other words, the process involves both denationalisation and renationalisation.

i. **Integration:** Integration is the harmonising or unifying process by which the various structural components of society are properly organised. Integration does not mean similarity of various structural parts, but similarity of certain basic, common values essential for the maintenance of society. When basic changes occur in a society due to a new technology, the traditional values may become inadequate calling for certain readjustment

necessary to integration. Integration, which is pluniral, not only keeps the society ongoing but also imparts a meaning and purpose to the lives of the individuals who, then, feel themselves part of a comprehensive and harmonious social life.[17]

Here we see that social interaction is a process of relating to others through cooperation, conflict, competition, coercion, exchange, accommodation, assimilation and integration. Cooperation is acting together to promote common interests or shared goals. Conflict, the opposite of cooperation, is the struggle with one another for some commonly prized object or value. Coercion is forcing another with a threat of the use of physical force or violence. Isolation is the absence of communicative interaction. Competition is a kind of cooperative conflict to reach the same goals as that of the other competitors in which one competitor will attain the goal and the other will be defeated. Exchange is for the purpose of receiving a reward or return. Accommodation enables individuals to adjust to their environment. Assimilation is the adoptive process of acquiring the culture of another group. Finally, integration – which already involves all these types of interaction – is the harmonising of the various structural components of society into a unified whole, a variety in unity, or plunirality which is the nature of Being studied in metaphysics.

4. What is Metaphysics?

The traditional explanation is that the term 'metaphysics' was coined by Andronicus of Rhodes (C. 70 B.C) for those collected works of Aristotle placed 'after physics' *(ta + meta + ta + phusika)*. The term thus had only a methodic value. It was only a coincidence that this section placed after physics treated of realities *beyond* the physical properties of beings. Hence in the course of time 'metaphysics' *(ta+ meta + ta + phusika)* came to mean that department of philosophy which deals with those features of beings that are hyperphysical, supersensible, and immaterial.[18] This seemingly reasonable explanation, though uncritically accepted by most philosophers and historians, appears to be a little far-fetched. For it would have been too much of a coincidence for the concept of metaphysics to be successfully adapted so as to contain the science of transcendent reality. Kant actually declared his suspicion, saying that the expression is too felicitous to be regarded as the result of chance.[19] However, the controversies on the origin of the term have little to do with its explanation as

17 Bhushan and Sachdeva, *An Introduction to Sociology*, 160–163.

18 Celestine Bittle, *The Domain of Being* (Milwaukee: Bruce Publishing Company, 1950), 5.

19 M. Heinze, *Vorlesungen Kants über Metaphysik aus drei Semestern* (Abhandlungen der Sächsischen Akademie der Wissenschaften, philosophisch-historische Klasse, 1894), 666.

the science of being as being. According to its traditional meaning, science is *sure and evident knowledge of things from their causes, or systematic body of knowledge.* In this sense metaphysics seems to be supremely a science; for metaphysics arrives at the first efficient cause and the ultimate final cause of all things. From the viewpoint of causal explanation, metaphysics is the highest type of science. Its starting point—that 'there is something'—is immediately known. Besides, metaphysics as science, which provides us with sure and evident knowledge of things from their causes, has also its own material and formal object.[20] *The material object of metaphysics* includes all things which fall under the notion of being, such as actual or possible, abstract or concrete, material or immaterial, finite or infinite.[21] *The formal object of metaphysics* is the study of *'being as being'*. "There is a science which investigates being as being, and is different from the sciences that investigate special parts of being."[22] That is to say, metaphysics does not restrict itself to any particular being or part of that being, but rather treats of what is *common to all beings*. It investigates the *general nature* of anything, insofar as it has some kind of being.[23] The general nature is Being in beings, as it is never apart from beings. It is the one Being in many beings. Being as one in many (pluniral) does not mean either monism or pluralism (in the ordinary sense of the term) but that which overwhelms and transcends both monism and pluralism.

I. **Pluralism:** Pluralism is the fundamental feature of any society. A pluralist society displays a high degree of heterogeneity in comparison to a homogeneous one. The principles arising from social pluralism guarantee not only individual rights, but the equal rights of the various societies against trespass. This is the division of society into numerous groups and sub-groups with varying interests, each of which considers itself equal to the others, and with various norms and values. The system of norms and values extends from absolute values accepted as universally valid to

20 *Material Object* is the definite realm or definite subject matter that a science deals with. For instance: humans, inanimate matter, the stars, the earth, language, religion, law, etc. *Formal Object* is that special aspect of the material object that is under consideration or study. A definite material object that is taken as the general matter to be studied will have too many knowable aspects to be grasped fully in a single intellectual consideration. To arrive at a well-founded total view, one will have to approach it in quasi-partial studies, i.e., through formal and analytic abstraction, the various aspects of the object. The material object so considered in a definite aspect, is thus called formal object.

21 Henry Renard, *The Philosophy of Being,* (Milwaukee: The Bruce Publishing Company, 1953), 12.

22 W. D. Ross, *Aristotle's Metaphysics,* Vol. I (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1988), 250.

23 Bruce Aune, *Metaphysics: The Elements* (Oxford: Basil Blackwell, 1986), 3.

moral norms and values adapted to a plural context. The tendency in the plural social context is for the individual to be integrated only partially into any given social group. With the partial social integration and the division of functions in modern society, there is an increasing differentiation of roles. The individual plays various roles as father, worker, a member of an association, citizen, etc. However, since pluralism is a partial social integration, it provides a norm or orientation for collective action. It helps individuals to see that the common good—which unifies all the individuals and thereby serves as the principle of unity of society—is the social goal.[24] Hence we can be sure that genuine pluralism implies a kind of fundamental unity.

II. **Unity:** Unity is the process by which a being is not divided in itself, but divided from everything else. The meaning of unity presupposes that it comes from the comparison of two or more *different* things.[25] It is the coherence of an intrinsically plural being. Hence unity too presupposes plurality. A being is all the more united in itself, and so distinguished from others, the more intimate its connection with others is. Unity and plurality, 'unism' and pluralism are inseparably related. There is no unity without plurality, and no plurality without unity. They found and sustain each other. One is in the other; the other is in the one. They are the two sides of Being, which is in some way or something. Therefore, Being is pluniral.

5. Plunirality (Unity in Plurality)

The problem of one and many is fundamental to human experience. Both poles seem to be equiprimordial to any intelligent awareness. 'The many' is inescapable for any experience which is spatio-temporal in its form consisting in the manifold of sensations that are spread out in space and that succeed one another in time. But to a human experience there belongs also from the beginning a unity, which allows the manifold items in it to be ordered and related among themselves; if this did not happen, there would be only a chaotic flux of impressions— comparable to the flux which briefly passes through consciousness when we are overcome by dizziness or are about to lose consciousness.[26] Is this unity of experience imposed entirely

24 Manfred Hättich, "Pluralism," in: *Sacramentum Mundi*, Vol. 5, ed. Karl Rahner with Cornelius Ernst and Kevin Smith (Bangalore: TPI, 1978), 33–34.

25 Lourencino-Bruno Puntel, "Unity," in *Sacramentum Mundi*, Vol. 6, 323–324.

26 John Macquarrie, "The One and the Many: Complementality of Religions," in *Meeting of Religions*, ed. Thomas A. Aykara (Bangalore: Dharmaram Publications, 1978), 168.

by the human mind, giving an illusion of unity? That might be the Kantian epistemology, in which it is the human mind which imposes unity upon the given forms of space and time by unifying the spatio-temporal data brought together under the categories of the Understanding in the unity of apperception. However, it would be impossible for the mind to impose a unity on the manifold of sensations unless the conditions for such a unity were already there in the sensations themselves. If the flux of sensations were endlessly varied, we could never emerge from the state of dizziness, leaving us helpless to construct any kind of unity. But, in fact, the same sensations keep coming back, and we are able to recognise them. It is the repetition, the recurrence of what has been, that makes possible the construction of a unified experience; this repetition lies in the given—the raw data of experience. Unity then is not a creation of the human mind, but a discovery of what has already been there, a discovery which is never complete.[27]

There has also been in many individuals and schools of thought a metaphysical awareness of this discovery of the underlying unity of all things. Such persons and schools have been seized of an awareness of a single Reality embracing all the manifestations of the manifold in itself and expressing itself in them. The metaphysical vision of an all-embracing unity has found expression in various monistic philosophies. The most illustrious representative philosopher of monism in ancient Greece was Parmenides. For him reality is one and unchanging. That which changes is that which is not, and thus unreality. The thought of Parmenides may be compared with that of Sankara. For him too, there is one unchanging reality, Brahman.[28] But from the earliest times there have been also philosophers who are openly pluralist. In ancient Greece, the priority of the multiple and the changing over the one has usually been ascribed to Heraclitus. But the typical pluralist philosophy has also been empiricist, in contrast to the rationalistic approach of monism, evident in modern and contemporary times, reaching its most extreme form in Nietzsche and the postmodernists who championed pluralism and contingency. For them there is no beginning, no end, no absolute centre, but just the endless proliferation of contingent occasions. This view lies at the opposite extreme of Parmenides, Sankara and the like.[29]

Perhaps, it is difficult to find anywhere a thoroughgoing monism or pluralism. Most advocates of monism have thought of the One implying at least some sort of differentiation in itself. They are in tacit agreement with Radhakrishnan's view that the One is so far from being empty that

27 Macquarrie, "The One and the Many: Complementality of Religions," 168–169.

28 Macquarrie, "The One and the Many: Complementality of Religions," 169–171.

29 Macquarrie, "The One and the Many: Complementality of Religions," 171.

it is characterised by a fullness that it surpasses comprehension. At the other extreme, is it possible to find a thoroughgoing pluralism? Here even Nietzsche, who denied that there is either beginning or end or middle, nonetheless taught a doctrine of eternal recurrence. Thus, we have to conclude that the extreme forms both of monism and of pluralism are untenable.[30] In the words of John Macquarrie, "The highest unity is that which already conceals within itself the richest diversity, while sheer diversity devoid of anything unifying is unthinkable. The one and the many do not stand in stark opposition to each other, for each implies the other."[31] But how do they imply each other? The question of their mutual implication calls for further ontological analysis. For the philosophical position of monism, of dualism, of radical pluralism, all depend upon the ontological solution offered to the problem of one and many: how can Being be *unitary and plural* (pluniral) at the same time?

Conclusion: Being as Pluniral is the Metaphysical Foundation of Democratic Society

In reality, monism, dualism, and pluralism, are extreme positions that create the illusion of solutions to *the problem of one and many*, which can be briefly explained in this way: Every being belongs to Being. Everywhere Being reveals itself as an absolute. Every finite being is a whole being, a complete being; yet it is not the whole of Being, for it does not contain all reality, since there are beings outside of it. A particular being participates in Being. The particular being that participates in Being is a complete being, a subsistent whole, unlike a part which is not a complete whole. The particular being, which is limited, is an imperfect being. It does not contain other particular beings; nor does it possess their perfection. Hence it does not contain all perfection. Consequently, it is imperfect. It does not mean that it is unfinished in itself. The perfection of every particular being belongs itself wholly to Being, and by that token it is to be distinguished from every other being. In this way, Being possesses an absolute character. It is not opposed to anything. Consequently, it penetrates and envelops everything. Nevertheless, Being manifests some relativity, since the real is broken up into multiple unities which participate in Being. In other words, the participation of beings in Being is an undeniable fact. But how can we explain the fact that the distinct beings in Being preserve their autonomy? This is the fundamental metaphysical problem of one and many,[32] that calls for fresh attempts aiming at a solution. Being as one-in-many (pluniral) can

30 Macquarrie, "The One and the Many: Complementality of Religions," 173–174.

31 Macquarrie, "The One and the Many: Complementality of Religions," 174.

32 L. De Raeymaeker, *The Philosophy of Being* (New York: Herder, 1966), 29–32.

be the result of such an attempt: *Being is one*: being is that which is in some way. Insofar as it is in some way, it is one. *Being is many*: being is that which is in some way. Insofar as being is in some way, each being is in its own way. Insofar as each being is in its own way, all beings are in their own ways. When all beings are in their own ways, there would be a plurality of beings that are many. In this sense, being is many. *Being is one-in-many,* or Pluniral: being is that which is in some way. Insofar as being is in some way, it is one. However, each being is in its own way. Insofar as each being is in its own way, all beings are in their own ways which are many. In other words, being which is in some way is also in its own way. Being is in beings, i.e., one is in many; Being is pluniral. Therefore, being is one-in-many, or pluniral. Being is a 'society' of one in many. The phenomenal democratic society is only a manifestation of the pluniral nature of Being, which is the metaphysical foundation of it. In other words, Being, which is pluniral, is the metaphysical foundation of democratic society; it is also its hope. Recognition and acceptance of plurinality gives hope to any democratic society, including Indian democracy.

It implies that a democratic society should never strive towards a society where unity is overemphasised at the expense of genuine plurality; in the same way, plurality should never become the norm of life in such a way that it destroys genuine unity. If unity is overemphasised, democracy will turn into a kind of 'majoritarian dictatorship.' Similarly, if plurality is overemphasised, a democratic society will be changed into chaotic anarchy. Hence, a true democratic society should do justice to both: to unity and plurality. It is possible if we can understand the original metaphysical inseparable unity of both unity and plurality as expressed by the term, "plunirality." Plunirality is the nature of Being, of every being. Hence, if a society upholds the pluniral nature of Being and beings, it can never be violent. Violence and conflict are the results of the forgetfulness of this original plunirality of Being and beings. Respect for plunirality of Being and beings lead the citizens of a country to greater harmony, peace, and prosperity. The democratic values of equality, fraternity, and liberty will have to show forth themselves in the ideals of justice and human rights, particularly expressed in a nation's commitment to plunirality. The democracy in India is a gift of the patriotic national leaders to the citizens of India. The citizens of this country must appreciate the foundation and hope of our democracy, which is pluniral and unique in the world.

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Indian Masters of Hope
Vision, Quest, Critique of Abdul Kalam, Amartya Sen and Daya Krishna

John Peter Vallabadoss

Abstract

Characteristic feature of any ordinary Indian displays his/her indifference to whatever happens in the present, justifying the existence of problems with the theory of karma, lamenting over one's helplessness, looking for charity, blaming somebody else for one's problems, living in misery and deprivation, and evidently lost in hope for a better future, as one finds oneself in a corrupt, miserable and hopeless society. Left just being proud only of India's past glory and its spiritual-philosophical traditions, most Indians bask in the bygone days of heritage, to escape the present-day woes. In contrast, Indian Masters of Hope, Abdul Kalam, Amartya Sen and Daya Krishna, three representatives from different fields amidst vast number of positive thinkers and activists, have envisioned a better and brighter future for Indians, infusing in them a hope with a vision, quest and critique. The paper highlights Kalam's Vision for India 2020, Sen's Capability Approach as a Quest for a Just, Free and Equal society, and Daya Krishna's Creative Critique of Indian Philosophical Traditions.

The Indian Masters of Hope offer an achievable goal, a realisable dream, a paradigm for a new thinking.

Keywords: *Capability, Choice, Horizon of Possibility, Integral Development, Quest for Freedom, Social Justice, Tradition and Modernity, Vision.*

Introduction

Quest for a better world emerges from the context of hopelessness, frustration and dissatisfaction with the present. Crisis calls for a creative response with impartial critique, optimistic vision, and self-confident of capability. Indian Masters of Hope have been inspiring their fellow Indians to dream big, search for the best, pursue the highest wisdom. The paper attempts to present three masters, Abdul Kalam, Amartya Sen and Daya Krishna. As a dreamer of a vision for a powerful, self-reliant nation, Abdul Kalam had imagined an India with its full potential to be realised in the near future. Envisaging a strong economic force in the ordinary from realising one's capability, Amartya Sen have been a motivational power, working for an overall growth and integral development with freedom and equality in the country. As an academic philosopher, Daya Krishna differs from the above two personalities, in his creative critique of ancient and classical Indian philosophical systems and in his proposal for a unique contemporary Indian thought.

The masters of hope as thinkers, activists, visionaries in contemporary India, inspire hope and action with a visionary approach to positive change, creating a comprehensive framework for addressing challenges, initiating critical reflections, and offering practical solutions. Engaging deeply with concerns for welfare of humanity at large, the exploration of ideas of these masters of hope from diverse perspectives in their fields of science, economy and philosophy, seeks to inspire meaningful reflection for committing oneself for creating a better world with hope. We find in them optimistic narratives of hope amidst 'doomsday' pessimism, pronouncing prophesies of well-being against apocalyptic predictions. Through a paradigm of hope—against typically characteristic feature of Indian attitudes, denial of problems, indifference, resignation tendencies, blind confidence and superstitious belief systems—the Masters of Hope exhibit their transformative vision for the bright future in contrast to cataclysmic fears for decadence of the present.

1. Dreaming a Vision as Hope: Abdul Kalam

Well-known all over India and world as the President of India from 2002–2007, Avul Pakir Jainulabdeen Abdul Kalam, the missile man of India remained an elder statesman and a great counsellor for a progressive nation, igniting the younger minds, reaching out to people and building bridges across various divides. His transformative vision for India as a developed nation by 2020 had received a wider public attention.[1] Meeting students and people from all walks of life, he disseminated his hopeful vision for a developed India in all spheres. Sharing his vision through the powerful inspiration of words and actions, Kalam had put forward his ideas to evolve a creative leadership, to shape positive thoughts, to seek opinions from the youth, to have the resolve to serve the nation, to inspire minds with aspirations and ambitions.

1.1. Vision for Ignited Minds

In his book along with his secretary V. Ponraj titled, *A Manifesto for Change: A Sequel to India 2020,* Kalam delineates his vision addressing the issues of creative leadership, people's aspirations, development, and evolving a focused, clear vision from the grassroots level to the higher leadership. Believing in the ignited minds of the youth in dedicating themselves to the nation and contributing their best to bring a change in thinking, Kalam says that they are the most powerful resource which can make the country a developed nation.[2] He hoped that his job as a sower of the seeds of confidence in every youth, with their innovative and creative minds and their out-of-the box thinking, can help develop a visionary leadership with commitment to service. Such leadership can bring about a fundamental change in the system or the society. Observing the current status he voiced out, "The alternation between hope and disappointment has become a pattern in Indian democracy. When the present fails to face challenges with a vision, the past returns to power in a democracy in the absence of a credible new alternative."[3] He always believed and hoped, "The ignited minds of the youth are bubbling with the spirit of 'I can do it' and the belief that 'India will become a developed nation.'… I strongly believe that the youth of my nation, by entering politics, will build a brand of integrity, honesty, value system, courage, commitment and responsibility with accountability around

1 Refer APJ Abdul Kalam, *Turning Points: A Journey through Challenges* (New Delhi: HarperCollins India, 2012); APJ Abdul Kalam, *Ignited Minds* (New Delhi: Penguin Books India, 2003).

2 APJ Abdul Kalam and V. Ponraj, *A Manifesto for Change: A Sequel to India 2020* (Noida: Harper Collins India, 2014), 1.

3 APJ Abdul Kalam and V. Ponraj, *A Manifesto for Change,* 5.

them and practice development politics."[4] Hope for the future is in trusting the young potentials of ignited minds of the youth of today.

1.2. Vision for Integral Development

The vision for 'India 2020' of Kalam gave Indians a new way of thinking and most Indians started believing that India could become a developed country by the year 2020 and some even used the title 'superpower' for India.[5] Vision for a developed nation not only charts out plans but also analyses, at a regular interval, the achievements, the missed opportunities and the slowdowns in project execution, while also grabbing the emerging new opportunities and technologies for faster and more inclusive growth. Kalam says, "I feel the crying need in our country is not a shortage of plans, but arriving at the correct methodologies to implement the plans and figuring out how to reach the benefits to the people for whom the plans are intended."[6] His pet project of PURA (Providing Urban Amenities in Rural Areas),[7] envisions an essential sustainable development system and inclusive growth of both urban and rural areas. Not merely utopian vision, yet realisable dreams for building a powerful and just nation, he says that the fact is that these emerging areas are not exactly beyond the horizon, seen only by especially farsighted persons.[8]

With shared resources, reimaging scientifically engaged democratic country facing crisis with 'positivity' and collective responsibility, India had made rapid progress in many sectors and made substantial progress in enhancing agricultural productivity, IT-enabled services, pharma industry, automobile industry, mobile-phone usage in communication, space exploration, multi-land roadways and airport infrastructure.[9] For Kalam, his dream and vision for India is not a mere 'fantasy wish' but a goal that is achievable. By his Vision for a developed nation, it is important to engage and train young minds with an inspiring vision for transforming India into a developed nation that entails a civil society where everyone lives well above the poverty line, with higher standards of education and health care, assured of national security, and identifying one's own core competence.

4 Kalam and Ponraj, *A Manifesto for Change*, 254.

5 Refer, APJ Abdul Kalam, *India 2020: A Vision for the New Millennium* (New Delhi: Penguin Books India, 1998).

6 APJ Abdul Kalam and Y. S. Rajan, *Beyond 2020: A Vision for Tomorrow's India* (Gurgaon: Penguin Books India, 2014), ix.

7 Refer, APJ Abdul Kalam and Srijan Pal Singh, *Target 3 Billion: PURA – Innovative Solutions towards Sustainable Development* (New Delhi: Penguin Books, 2011).

8 APJ Abdul Kalam and Y. S. Rajan, *Beyond 2020: A Vision for Tomorrow's India,* 234.

9 APJ Abdul Kalam and Y. S. Rajan, *Beyond 2020: A Vision for Tomorrow's India,* 214.

His vision for a developed India by 2020 listed out distinctive profile of an economically developed India.[10]

2. Hope as Quest: Amartya Sen

Nobel laureate for economics, Amartya Sen, a living icon for India's great mind, has dedicated himself to the integral growth and inclusive development of all, in a just, free and equal society. His unwavering quest for freedom, socio-economic and political equality, social justice in alleviating miseries of poverty, hunger and deprivation, has made us value him as a living master of hope.

2.1. Quest in Deprivation and Misery

Amartya Sen has developed the theoretical foundations of capability approach as a comprehensive theory suitable for personal and societal growth and development. Sen pays attention particularly to people who are deprived of basic needs, leading a very reduced life, unable to be adequately nourished, decently clothed, minimally educated and properly sheltered.[11] He specially focuses on the people enduring situations of severe deprivation, such as battered housewives, bonded labourers, oppressed minorities, exploited immigrants, etc.,[12] —so-called 'underdogs of society.' He insists that the social policy and political deliberations must be alert and responsive to the needs and conditions of the deprived and marginalised so that people are enabled to perform their actions according to the choices they make as preferences in life.[13]

Social Darwinists hold that humans as economic beings engage in production, exchange and consumption, are motivated to have social interactions and moral behaviour, with self-interest.[14] Against the view of self-interested behaviour as the foundation for human interactions, Sen argues for altruistic behavior, making a distinction between sympathy and commitment. Sympathy refers to one person's welfare being affected by the position of others, feeling depressed at the sight of misery. On the other hand, commitment is concerned with breaking the tight link between individual welfare and the choice of action, acting to help remove some misery even

10 Refer, APJ Abdul Kalam and V. Ponraj, *A Manifesto for Change,* 249–250.

11 Amartya Sen, *Inequality Reexamined* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1995), 55.

12 Amartya Sen, *Development as Freedom* (Oxford: University Press, 1999), 62–63.

13 Amartya Sen, *Rationality and Freedom* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2002), 121–157.

14 Sen, *Rationality and Freedom*, 484–500.

though one personally does not suffer from it.[15] Sympathy may emerge from selfish interest as people care about others because others' situation affects their own welfare in some way. Commitment involves altruistic principles and moral concerns overriding one's preferences. It is by commitment rather than just selfishness, that people contribute and collaborate willingly for collective action for social security and welfare of all. For Sen, human beings are not 'rational fools,' driven to action exclusively by selfish preferences, but influenced by plurality of motivations, commitment, moral responsibilities, guided by reason.[16] Further he says, "People in real life may or may not be entirely self-seeking, but it would be absurd to claim that anyone who does not pursue what he or she recognises to be his or her own interest must be just irrational."[17]

The birthplace of Sen's capability approach is the study of the cause of famines and starvation.[18] Analysing the situations of societal failures such as poverty, famines, hunger, malnutrition, infant mortality, health crisis, and systematic social exclusion of women and minorities, Sen points out that they are due to 'entitlement failures' and blockage to 'social, economic and political freedom.' Arguably he opines, "No famine has ever taken place in the history of the world in a functioning democracy,"[19] – a democracy which is more than just a majority rule, but intertwined connections between capabilities, rule of people and public reasoning. In a society marred with injustice, discrimination and unequal distribution of wealth, matters of justice and equality loom large as beyond achievement and realisation of just, equal and dignified living. Individual person's well-being along with his yearning for fulfilling bare survival to quality of life with socio-economic welfare, is guaranteed only with justice, freedom, equality and peace.

2.2. Quest for Justice, Freedom and Equality

Through the Capability approach, Amartya Sen provides a unique answer to the question of everyone's wellbeing and the quality of life, in the context of poverty, deprivation and social justice. Sen's capability approach criticises the social ethics that incorporates principles such as 'equal pay for equal work,' or 'elimination of exploitation,' or 'priority for feeding the hungry,'

15 Amartya Sen, *Choice, Welfare and Measurement* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1982), 7–8.

16 Refer Amartya Sen, "Rational Fools: A Critique of the Behavioural Foundations of Economic Theory," in *Philosophy and Public Affairs,* Vol. 6 (1977): 317–344.

17 Amartya Sen, *Rationality and Freedom,* 227.

18 John M. Alexander, *Capabilities and Social Justice: The Political Philosophy of Amartya Sen and Martha Nussbaum* (London: Routledge: 2008), 26.

19 Amartya Sen, *Development as Freedom*, 16.

and he opposes the ethics that does not value realisation of freedoms or the fulfilment of rights or duties on their own terms.[20] Appropriate normative principles of administering justice impartially and treating people as equals in society are delineated in Sen's vision with a liberal paradigm, playing an important role in normative economics, social ethics and political philosophy, leading not only theoretical discussions but also conceptual and practical policy-making in development discourses and structural changes for a better society. Amartya Sen as a theorist of capability defends "the idea that social justice consists in creating the greatest possible condition for the realisation of basic capabilities for all."[21] The ideal of realising basic capabilities is the guiding principle for Sen in envisioning the capability approach to the conception of justice closely connected to democracy and public reasoning.

The ideal of realisation requires, according to Sen, the required economic, social and political freedom. Certain absolute forms of poverty and capability deprivation of basic material and human resources, kill the aspiration for realising basic capabilities. Sen's capability approach as a theory of justice considers differences in individuals' talents, capacities and potentialities, as well as society's economic and political structuring, enabling individuals' access to adequate material and social resources. Along with person's capability, the social responsibility for ensuring adequate nutrition, basic education, and primary health care, remains a basic concern for any affirmative policy-making and development project proposals. Depending on a country's economic prosperity, political maturity and social security, basic capabilities of individuals are realisable. Sen strongly advocates societal policies and practices for assuring all for the adequate nutrition and good health which open the door for quality education, learning and creativity.

For Sen, human beings must be treated with dignity and respect irrespective of their class, caste and gender. Humans are the end in themselves, not as means or instruments for something else. In the view of Sen, freedom is not merely the absence of interference as emphasised by *laissez-faire* liberalism,[22] but the possession of capabilities to achieve valuable human goals. In countries like India, where persons who are poor, uneducated, unemployed, afflicted by diseases, socially excluded, certainly lack the required capabilities and opportunities to live a life of freedom.

20 John M. Alexander, *Capabilities and Social Justice*, 17.

21 Alexander, *Capabilities and Social Justice*, 1.

22 *Laissez-faire* liberalism advocates the idea of freedom as non-interference, meaning that individuals are said to be free only when there is no interference from external forces such as the state, the law, or the fellow citizens.

The society not only fails to treat all as equal, but also restricts or interferes with the members and permits them to remain in poverty and suffer various forms of deprivation. Sen, through the spirit of the capability approach, offers hope for a better human achievement for individuals and society, strengthening both the theoretical edifice of the idea of social justice, welfare economics and democratic political philosophy, and the practical policy-making for promoting a poverty-free, famine-free, capability-promoting society, empowering people and recognising each one's contribution for overall growth of both the society and individuals' achievements. Hope for a better, just, equal, dignified life is through fighting against injustice, poverty, famines, inequality, discrimination, communal and ethnic conflicts and religious strife, which can be overcome not by revolution, but by ideological correctness, by protecting rights, by promoting the realisation of capabilities, and by recognising interconnectedness.

Sen insists that every society through public discussion and democratic deliberation decides on the list of basic capabilities and he exhibits his unwavering faith in the potential of public reasoning and of a robust and well-functioning democratic government to promote individuals'' capabilities.[23] Sen distinguishing 'positive' freedom from 'negative' freedom, claims that capabilities best represent the notion of positive freedom, "concentrating on what a person can choose to do or achieve."[24] Quest for justice, freedom and equality is hopefully realised not merely by the absence of interference from external forces and having the opportunities to do, but rather by the presence of self-mastery and actually creating opportunities. Sen says that Caste can be a factor with far reaching influence on many aspects of day-to-day living, but inequality in the distribution of income and ownership will typically be part of the story, but by no means the whole of it.[25]

2.3. Hoping in Capabilities

The Capability approach of Amartya Sen, with its economic, social, spiritual and ethical emphasis, is believed to enhance human well-being and to empower the vulnerable, oppressed and those living in poverty. The mission of advocating theories for social policy and conceptions of social justice also significantly promotes a sense of meaning in concrete economic context. Building communities demands actualisation of the full developmental potential of individuals and communities, through mutually fulfilling relationships, transcending individual-centrism and all forms of

23 John M. Alexander, *Capabilities and Social Justice*, 147–148.

24 Amartya Sen, "Freedom of Choice: Concepts and Content," in *European Economic Review,* Vol. 32 (1988), 272.

25 Amartya Sen, *Inequality Reexamined*, 122.

harmful divisiveness, and recognising the interconnectedness of all humans and all beings. Social concern and social activism on behalf of the poor, vulnerable and oppressed individuals and groups, and welfare economics of Sen promote social justice for all. Drawing from both western and Indian philosophies and intellectual histories, Sen seeks to clarify how to enhance justice and remove blatant injustices. "Justice cannot be indifferent to the lives that people can actually live,"[26] he writes. He clarifies Sanskrit ideas of *niti* and *nyaya,* both standing for 'justice': *niti* refers to rules and regulations and behavioural correctness in society, whereas *nyaya* stands for realised justice.[27] The actual living that people manage to achieve to assess the extent of justice, is conditioned by freedoms and opportunities, by capabilities. Expanding people's capabilities, freedoms and opportunities involves what people are able to do and to be.

People's living and wellbeing are associated with economic and social functionings ranging from basic survival and social relationships, to specific inclinations to arts and culture; these functionings are however, related to goods and income. "Capability is a set of vectors of functionings, reflecting the person's freedom to lead one type of life or another… to choose from possible livings."[28] Capabilities are opportunity freedoms to be or to do what individuals value as worthwhile, implying a possibility or opportunity for functioning, for example, just as those with a lot of money buy various goods, similarly people with many capabilities can enjoy many activities and pursue varied life paths. Yet, the people are agents choosing how to function with the capabilities. The idea of *agency,* in the example of person fasting is choosing not to eat, while person starving is not doing so out of choice, but rather is unable to eat, due to lack of food resources. The former could eat but chooses not to; whereas the latter would eat if they could. Agency is people's ability to pursue and realise goals they value and have reason to value. An agent is someone who acts and brings about change—not someone who is forced, oppressed or passive.

Lamenting on the underdevelopment of Indian school systems, especially in socially backward regions of the country and particularly among disadvantaged groups, Sen declares that this is both deeply inefficient and amazingly unjust, leading to massive waste of talent.[29] "India has been… both an exporter and importer of ideas in our world of continuing global interaction."[30] The nature of Indian identity is in its definition of

26 Amartya Sen, *The Idea of Justice* (Harvard: University Press, 2009), 18.

27 Amartya Sen, *Development as Freedom,* 73.

28 Amartya Sen, *Inequality Reexamined,* 40.

29 Amartya Sen, *The Argumentative Indian* (London: Penguin Books, 2005), 344.

30 Sen, *The Argumentative Indian*, 346.

Indianness—one that tolerates, protects and indeed celebrates diversity within a pluralist India.[31]

3. Creative Critique as Hope: Daya Krishna

Daya Krishna developed a model of philosophising of his own, with his mind unfailingly creative and interrogative. The starting point of interrogation, *jijñāsa,* lies in the sense of discontent with what is available in a tradition of philosophising.[32] Daya Krishna's method is not for bringing out a corpus of concepts and theories, but of encountering with one's own tradition—again not merely for exegesis but for searching contemporary relevance. Consciously critical, refusing to accept any authority either of an author or of a tradition, engaging with dialogical enterprise, Daya Krishna sustained interrogation of philosophical culture from interdisciplinary point of view, bringing in new vistas of hope for Indian method of philosophising.

Being a consistent and vigorous pluralist, his approach to philosophical traditions and thinkers, leads to a type of cultural and intellectual pluralism. His conceptual articulation aims at creative and continuous dialogue, without intending to demolish or even distort other's point of view. As a philosopher of depth and diversity he is fascinated with inter-societal dialogue, inter-individual as well as individual-societal dialogues. As creativity is sensible only with transcendental moorings and social affiliations, Daya Krishna brings in the art of philosophising and creativity in philosophy.[33]

Daya Krishna asserts the tradition of questioning many beliefs accepted as unquestionably true and many myths that are to be subjected to a close scrutiny. The centrality of the Vedic stream for the philosophical traditions, historicity of disappearance of Buddhism, and dominance of Śaṅkara, the notion of *Śruti* as sacred revealed text, notions of *varṇa* and *āśrama* in Indian society, are given a counter and new perspective, through which he attempts to outline strategy for the activity of creative thinking in Indian philosophising.[34] "Love is blind' they say and philosophers seem to be so much in love with the traditional view of Indian philosophy that neither argument nor evidence, however, compelling or basic, does seem to produce the slightest change in their perception of things as they obtain in the 'text-books' on the tradition."[35] He laments that his critiques "have

31 Sen, *The Argumentative Indian*, 348.

32 Bhuvan Chandel and K. L. Sharma, Preface, *The Philosophy of Daya Krishna* (New Delhi: ICPR, 1996), vii–viii.

33 Chandel and Sharma, Preface, *The Philosophy of Daya Krishna*, x.

34 Daya Krishna, Intro., *New Perspectives in Indian Philosophy* (New Delhi: Rawat Publications, 2001), 2–3.

35 Krishna, Intro., *New Perspectives in Indian Philosophy*, 4.

not produced change in the picture relating to these fields amongst scholars of the subject."[36] But he hopes for the alternative picture to the normally accepted one. "A picture once built is difficult to dismantle, but the evidence and the argument slowly undermine it and the younger generation which is not so indissolubly 'wedded' to 'orthodoxy' as the older one, begins to be more open and responsive to the critique as it finds some substance in it."[37] Though his writings are dubbed as 'provocative' and conveniently dismissed without paying any serious attention to the content and argument, he says that his intention is not to shock or provoke anyone, but to highlight the evidences in the texts themselves, commented upon for millennia, without taking into account the contradictions.

India's intellectual tradition is so varied and complex that it is impossible for any one person to make a systematic and coherent presentation of it. The difficulty is compounded by the fact that neither the problems nor the conceptual structures in those domains have yet been articulated by anybody. The traditional scholars think in terms of the 'schools' and not in terms of the problems or the questions the schools raised, nor are they aware of the serious and the radical changes that occurred in the concepts over historical time. Even modern scholars continued the path of the traditional *pandits,* paving way for preservation of traditional thought as if there were no imperfections or incompleteness in it, or as if it was a finished picture or product of thought. The living quality of thought is affected by maintenance and preservation programme, resulting in static picture of the school freezing Indian thought, as if 'dead' and mummified and buried. Daya Krishna's attempt is for an articulation of the problematic and conceptual structure of Indian thought. The task is immense and it has to help by making us free from our 'dogmatic slumbers' and becoming aware of the need for a fresh look at the philosophical traditions of India, so that it becomes alive once again and pursued with renewed vigour once more.[38]

He attempted a detailed refutation of the traditional view that Indian philosophy is spiritually oriented, advancing certain historical and exegetical arguments to support his conclusions. While others countered these arguments stating that the avowal of the *mōkṣa* ideal marks out Indian tradition as spiritually-oriented, there is a general view that philosophy as a whole is a spiritually-oriented enterprise.[39] Spiritual orientation meaning

36 Krishna, Intro., *New Perspectives in Indian Philosophy*, 5.

37 Krishna, Intro., *New Perspectives in Indian Philosophy*, 5.

38 Daya Krishna, Intro., *New Perspectives in Indian Philosophy,* 6.

39 N. S. Dravid, "Spiritual Orientation of Philosophy," in *The Philosophy of Daya Krishna*, eds. Bhuvan Chandel and K. L. Sharma (New Delhi: ICPR, 1996), 61.

not merely dealing with the spirit or the self as the object of inquiry, but is oriented to the self, *adhyātmavidyā*.

Through his papers he questioned many of the received and taken-for-granted ideas about Indian philosophy. These challenges have gone mostly unheeded and the same *clichés* continued despite his critique on the 'spiritual' characterisation, Vedic authority for all Indian thinking, fixed number of clearly delimited schools of thought in India, and even questions about the 'textuality' of the Vedas and the Upaniṣads.[40] He draws attention to a serious drawback in our understanding of Indian philosophy and lack of innovative and interpretive originality of the thinker.[41] The overriding importance—the supreme pre-eminence, the primacy—of *śruti* lies not in its being the source of our knowledge of truths, *pramāṇa,* but in being the historical foundation of our modes of thinking, opening up an open horizon to think, to question and to interpret the self and the world.

His interventions bear ample testimony to his penetrating insight into the predispositions, presuppositions and pretensions of Indian philosophers and thinkers, classical as well as contemporary, applying rigorous textual criticism and reaching unconventional conclusions.[42] He also calls for a new arrangement of the whole Vedic corpus by a 'new Vyāsa' to rescue them "from the age-old forms in which they have been imprisoned and immobilised."[43] In fact every age, every culture has its own philosophy—articulate or inarticulate—and it is our duty to bring it into light and articulate, reconstruct or systematise it.[44]

40 J. N. Mohanty, "Some Thoughts on Daya Krishna's Three Myths," in *The Philosophy of Daya Krishna*, 68. Refer, Daya Krishna, "Vedānta: Does It Really Mean Anything?" *Conspectus* (Delhi); "The Vedic Corpus: Some Questions," in *JICPR,* Vol. III, No. 1, (1985). Three Conceptions of Indian Philosophy, *Philosophy East and West,* Vol. 15 (January 1965); Three Myths about Indian philosophy, *Diogenes*, vol. 5, Paris, July-Sept. 1966; "Indian Philosophy and Mokṣa: Revisiting an Old Controversy," in *JICPR,* Vol. II, No.1 (1984); The Myth of the Puruṣārthas" in *JICPR,* Vol. IV, No. 1 (Autum 1986); "Yajña and the Doctrine of Karma: A Contradiction in Indian Thought about Action," *JICPR,* Vol. VI, No. 2 (Jan-Apl, 1989); "The Varṇāśrama Syndrome of Indian Sociology," in *Contributions to Indian Sociology* (Delhi: 1991).

41 J. N. Mohanty, "Some Thoughts on Daya Krishna's Three Myths," 75–76.

42 Harsh Narain, "Daya Krishna on Indian Philosophy," in *The Philosophy of Daya Krishna*, 81.

43 Daya Krishna, "The Vedic Corpus: Some Questions," 125–126.

44 Harsh Narain, "Daya Krishna on Indian Philosophy," 87.

Daya Krishna's complaint is that our philosophers are *ipso facto* taken to be aspirants for *mokṣa,* and the bulk of our systematicians are experts on wire-fencing of closely guarded metaphysical truths.[45] He stimulates us to rethink the presuppositions of and about classical Indian philosophical system. Philosophy as a never-ending enterprise and Daya Krishna rejects that philosophy can give us final and absolute knowledge about the ultimate real or the 'really real.' For him, the philosopher should not don the false plumes of the *shaman,* the priest or the prophet, thus is neither supposed to prescribe for the world nor is he supposed to describe it as a scientist. However, he cannot disown his responsibility to engage himself in a rational quest into the nature of human seeking and an explication of human situation vis-à-vis existence.[46]

Daya Krishna calls for being 'creative philosophers'—those who are ready to explore the possibilities of fresh ideas and to construct new models even if it is in conflict with the tradition, and dare not to take shelter in a revered authority. Creative philosophising has a distinctive flexibility inherent in it. Philosophising is a never-ending process and its creativity is marked by the uncovering of the many faceted dimensions of an issue.[47] It is carried out in the form of a dialogue; its uniqueness lies in group thinking, as Daya Krishna says, "thinking is not a monadic activity but rather the achievement of a community of thinkers."[48] Creative philosophising is marked by interdisciplinary approach to a problem. Daya Krishna's attempt to bring in an innovative idea of creativity in philosophy would not be for creating a system, nor to encourage philosophical restlessness rather encourage a philosophical docility.[49]

The idea of 'founding project' is proposed to evaluate whether a particular traditional text or a thinker became basic authoritative for a stream of thought to follow, for example Upaniṣads or *Srīmad* Bhagavadam—the historical development takes it in different directions with variegated philosophical enterprises.[50] In course of historical development, 'many old doctrines are reinterpreted, modified, rejected and new ones added,' but Daya Krishna raises a question, "then why try to link it to some mythical

45 Narain, "Daya Krishna on Indian Philosophy," 95.

46 R. S. Bhatnagar, "Philosophy and Daya Krishna," 125, 131; Refer, Daya Krishna, *The Nature of Philosophy* (Calcutta: Progressive Publishers, 1956), 233.

47 Ranjit Ghose, "Daya Krishna and Creativity in Philosophy," in *The Philosophy of Daya Krishna*, 130–131.

48 Daya Krishna, "Thinking vs. Thought: Strategies for Conceptual Creativity," in *JICPR,* Vol. V. No. 2 (Jan-Apl 1988), 48.

49 Ranjit Ghose, "Daya Krishna and Creativity in Philosophy," 138.

50 Daya Krishna responding to J. N. Mohanthy's criticism; See, Daya Krishna, "Response to my Critics," in *The Philosophy of Daya Krishna*, 285–288.

'founding project' in the primordial beginnings about which little can be said with confidence anyway?"[51] In other words, why insist on continuity when the tradition itself is ready to call it as *navya,* and why deny the change and the novelty claimed? The tracts of recorded philosophical enterprise in India show filial obedience to tradition and the denial of freedom to the human spirit. He has questioned the unquestioned acceptance of the authority of the *śruti.* Along with Daya Krishna, Pratap Chandra sees the alleged centrality of the Vedas and the Upaniṣads as unjustified for the simple reason that not only does a large part of the *Śramaṇa* tradition fall outside it, but also the various *Āgamic* and *Pāñcarātra* traditions which form such a central part of the Indian tradition.[52]

Concluding Remarks

People look for leaders, gurus, and masters who can inspire them and transform their lives when their hopes are shattered. They look for a better leader with the hope that he/she may bring about a change. To become a leader for change, one should act with courage, conviction, and respect for the democratic traditions of the nation, and be ready to envision, explore, innovate, and plan policies and implement projects that will improve the quality of life and enrich people's lives without expecting anything in return. In the context of the degradation of moral values, traditional cultures, challenges of modernity, economic inequality, social injustice, stagnation in creative and critical thinking, these representatives of India's master minds have been driving the contemporary society forward in thinking with optimism and hope for a better future. They resonate and reflect their commitment and concern for all in the society. They hope to create a positive platform for engaging with multiple dimensions of exploring the present potentials, future possibilities, inspiring and guiding the fellow Indians to collective consciousness, self-realisation, critical analysis for a more just, sustainable, powerful, and wisdom-filled society. Their master-class insights explore the root causes of stagnation, inequality, exclusion, moral degradation, underdevelopment, and corruption, through their realistic vision, genuine recognition, and honest critique. Not stopping with criticism and investigating the causes, they address the issues and crises. These masters of hope focus on creating positivity, fostering a dialogue between the destructive notions of impossibility and the prospective frameworks for generating opportunity. The Indian masters of hope from fields of science,

51 Daya Krishna, "Response to my Critics," 290.

52 Pratap Chandra, "Daya Krishna on Indian Thought: Some Unanalysed Assumptions," in *The Philosophy of Daya Krishna*, 113–120; Daya Krishna, "Response to my Critics," 298. Refer, Chapter on "Three Myths about Indian Philosophy," in Daya Krishna, *Indian Philosophy: A Counter Perspective* (Delhi: Oxford India, 1966), 3–15.

politics, economics, and philosophy, with their vision, quest, and critique have sown the seeds of hope in the minds of Indians for a system that is responsive, just, corruption-free, equal, transparent, critical, proactive, innovative, competent, and competitive. These masters hoped with a vision for the nation, quest for freedom, a pursuit of creative and critical thinking, and wished for a transformed society, for an integral growth of individuals and for an inclusive society.

Part IV

Ethics of Hope: Transformative Vision

22

Towards a Secular Hope
A Study on Critical Theory with Special Reference to Habermas

George Rajmohan

Abstract

This present study explores a secular hope which is one different from other papers because it proposes a way out from the present scenario affecting the contemporary post-modern word which has become virtually a hell for most people who feel themselves helpless and see it destroying our lifeworld. Frankfurt school masters were at their very best to find a way out from this sort of reason that ended up in modern capitalist economy and the consequent malady that it had unleashed.

Max Weber is the first sociologist in the West who broke with the evolutionary understanding of developmental history of humankind and placed modern rationality as the cause of modernisation in Europe. According to him, it was due to specific and peculiar socio-cultural factors, namely Protestantism and its ethical orientation for perfection that the modernisation of the West began. Western rationality became purposive, calculative, instrumental, voluntaristic, logical, and formal. Capitalistic

economies and modern bureaucratic states emerged. Virtually, the life world is engulfed by the system necessities.

The emancipation of the lifeworld is sought by the Frankfurt school teachers from Lukács to Habermas. Habermas focuses on the potentials of analytic philosophy to find a way out from the anomaly of modernity. He proposes a world that communicates and establish consensus on all matters both national and international in a democratic way and resolve the stalemate in which we find ourselves today. His theory of Universal Pragmatics is a search to fulfill humanity's hope to live on earth peacefully.

Keywords: *Aesthetics, Dialectics, Disenchantment, Enlightenment, Humanisation, Idyllic, Illocutionary, Linguistification, Lifeworld, Locutionary, Media, Mimesis, Modernity, Postmodernity, Universal Pragmatics.*

Introduction

Modernity and the consequent reorganisation of socio-cultural and political-economic life has created disastrous consequence to the lifeworld all over and the critical theorists are looking at the malady, and suggesting secular remedies to contemporary societies and nation states. Here in this essay, we look at some of their findings and learn from them some solutions to our postmodern world. Modernity and its rationality are making very many negative impacts quite rapidly in our country too in the last two or three decades, for which a solution need to be sought. For this we need help from every corner of the world that will assist in overcoming them with right solutions and bringing peace and harmony in our societies. We need a hope—an earthly hope—for sorting out the massive malaise that modernity and its reason has spread all around us.

Origins of Capitalism – Insights of Max Weber

Max Weber is the first sociologist in the west who broke with the evolutionary understanding of developmental history of mankind and placed modern rationality as the cause of modernisation in Europe. Weber sought in Western rationality for the modernisation of the European society. According to him, with its specific and peculiar socio-cultural factors—namely Protestantism and its ethical orientation for perfection—that the modernisation of the west began. "Why outside of Europe, neither scientific nor artistic nor economic development entered upon the path of rationalisation, peculiar to occident? asks Weber.[1]" Weber saw in Calvinism and its ethics, the essential

1 Max Weber, *The Protestant Ethics and Spirit of Capitalism* (New York: Scribner, 1958), 25.

ingredient for the formation of a capitalistic society. Capitalism was the triumph of modernity over all other forms of socio-economic existence and practice of life. Purposive rationality won over all other forms of life and the lifeworld today spins around the capitalist economy. *Zweckrational*—purposive reason—is employed to an end. Weber's own words, "reason then is a means for the successful attainments of the actor's own rationally chosen ends"[2]

Weberian Analysis is Further Elaborated

Weberian use of rationality, Arnold Eisen would say Is that it is at the bottom of all modern enterprises. In all rational action, the social actors act, first, for some known purposes. The conscious intent of the actor is to achieve an end. It is the same in the collective action of the social actors too. Eisen considers that the collective purposive action of the actors increases the extend of control exercised over the world. Efficiency and predictability increase. This increase also results in calculability and reliability and avoids mere chance-events in the results. Rational action involves also a great amount of voluntary self-control and self-discipline. Rational action is self-disciplined action.[3] Such self-discipline is essential for rational behavior. This was provided by Calvinism in particular, and Protestantism in general.

The Impact of Purposive Rationality

The western rationality had become highly purposive and calculative, instrumental, voluntaristic, logical, and formal. It became an iron cage for the modern man in which he is condemned to live his life. Differentiation of economy and state is the direct result of this rationalisation. Capitalistic economy and the bureaucratic modern state, according to Weber, are the consequence of this rationalisation process itself. At the cultural level, the impact of this rationalisation was the universal disenchantment of all hitherto existing world views, values, and belief systems. There took place a devaluation of all existing social and religious norms.[4] And this rationalisation impacted on the formal reorganisation of symbolic systems of religions. Habermas comments, "He (Weber) sees in the overcoming of magical beliefs, the essential achievement of the great world religions as regards rationalisation. The categorial break through to a modern disenchanted

2 Max Weber, *The Theory of Social and Economic Organization* (Illinois: The Free Press), 117.

3 Arnold Eisen, "The Meaning and Confusion of Weberian Rationality," *British Journal of Sociology* 29, no. 1 (March 1978): 58.

4 Jürgen Habermas, *The Theory of Communicative Action,* Vol. 1 (Boston: Beacon Press,1989),175.

concept of the world also expresses itself in a formal-operational reworking of elements of tradition…"[5]

Not only culture and socio-political worlds, but even nature too has become an object of cause-effect explanation of scientific enquiry. The presumed value neutral and objective explanation of nature by modern sciences consequently has produced a senseless and disenchanted world. In this process, "culture becomes ever more senseless as a locus of imperfection, of injustice, of suffering, of sin, of futility… the world has become fragmentary and devalued in all those instances when judged in the light of the religious postulate of a divine meaning of existence," writes Weber.[6] This results in a conflict between religious and ethical sphere with all other value spheres. According to Habermas, "both ethics and religion come into opposition with other value spheres"[7] and the life world itself. Religious and ethical sense is lost in dealing with nature and what prevails is utility and pragmatism.

The socio-cultural changes have also impacted the personality of individual actors. The capitalistic economy and modern state are the two vehicles of this transformation. They become instrumental in the methodical conduct of life. The spectacular achievements this methodical life make, results in gradual disenchantment of religion and prevailing universe of values. Secularisation of one's vocation and consequently, a fervent pursuit of worldly fulfillment of life are undertaken. A methodically rigorous and self-controlled and principled life gives a person certain self-fulfillment and self-satisfaction. Human beings become more and more autonomous and liberated from cultural and religious bindings. Positively, the individual attains greater freedom to present their needs and express their desires and feelings. This may also lead to extreme individualism and crude egoism.

At the social and interpersonal level too, certain stiffness and inflexibility creep in. Interpersonal relations are more objectified and gradually regulated by formality and legal means. Cultural rationalisation percolates into both social and individual life. Certain normativeness and calculatedness percolate into social relationships. Weber lampoons this methodicity and calls such persons as the "professionals" (*Berufs-mensch*).

5 Habermas, *The Theory of Communicative Action,* 175.

6 Max Weber, "On Religious Rejection of the World," in *Max Weber: Essays in Sociology,* ed. and trans. H. H. Gerth and C. Wright Mills (New York, Oxford University Press, 1958), 323–359.

7 Habermas, *The Theory of Communicative Action*, Vol. 1, 163–164

The specific result of such organisation is a formalised social and political relationship in society.[8]

This disenchantment of the world-views and the rationalisation of the societies, cultures, and human person are an irreversible process. According to Habermas and other Critical theorists, the loss of freedom and loss of meaning that accompany the teleologically directed modern reason are irreversible. In the restoration of communication and discursive engagement of reason alone, Habermas hopes that mankind will find once again and resurrect meaning and purpose in life.

Frankfurt School's Assessment: Horkheimer, Lukács, Adorno

It is this Weberian critique of occidental reason that has fallen into a trap, that the Frankfurt school Masters wanted to release and suggest an alternative path and direction. Habermas reviewed his predecessors and come to the realisation that their critique of reason could not find any alternative to the purposive rationality. Frankfurt school scholars had agreed with Weber that the cultural and societal rationalisation has robbed of humanity of its freedom and meaning in life. Like Marx, Horkheimer in his *Eclipse of Reason* lamented that this rationalisation of modernity has encroached upon the most private domain of human life to the extent that the individual has become merely a tool in a whole system.

The system confronts the subject as absolute and overpowering. "Therefore, adjustment becomes the standard for every conceivable type of subjective behavior."[9] Adjustment to the system imperatives of the purposively deployed rationality confronts on all the aspects of the Life world. Absolute purposelessness prevails in the lifeworld. Both Weber and Horkheimer agreed with each other on this diagnosis of the modernity, states Habermas.[10]

Although both Weber and Horkheimer agreed over the diagnosis, they held different reasons for the phenomena. For Weber, it is the alteration in cultural sphere that spells the change; for Horkheimer, it is the reification of the human relationships based on commodity exchange that triggered the disaster. Horkheimer is indebted more to George Lukács than Weber for his analysis. According to Lukács, in wage labour, human labour is converted

8 Max Weber, *Economy, and Society, An Outline of interpretative Sociology*, G. Roth and C. Wittich (New York: Bed Minister Press, 1985), 556. In his own words: "Its typical representative was the "man of vocation" or 'professional' (*Berufsmensch*); and its specific result was the rational, functional organisation of social relations."

9 Max Horkheimer, *Eclipse of Reason* (New York: Seabury Press, 1974), 96.

10 Habermas, *The Theory of Communicative Action,* Vol. 1, 350.

into a commodity.[11] Human labour is bartered and all social relationships are reified. Human relationships are available for a price! "…Lifeworld has to become reified and individuals degraded, observes Habermas."[12]

According to Lukács, the phenomenon of purposive rationalisation that Weber focused on is a confirmation of his thesis of reification. According to him modern sciences are a perfect example of this reification. Scientism—the dogmatic pretension of objective reason—is embodied in the Kantian critique of reason extends in Newtonian physics. Reification has been at the basis of modern sciences. Lukács writes wearily, "This rationalisation of the world appears to be complete: it penetrates to the very depths of man's physical and psychic nature…"[13]

Can this reification of the human reason somehow be stopped somewhere? Can human mind be released again from the clutches of modernity and its imperatives? Lukács hopes that the formal character of reason may also serve as the redeeming point. The Subjective nature of man resists the formalisation and objectification of the lifeworld. In virtue of this, the laborer can withhold his subjective consciousness being reified. By this he hopes the humanisation of the man is once again achievable. Being an ardent adherent to Hegelian dialectics, Lukács is of the view that dialectical movement of reason will rectify the anomaly that we are in.

This hope of Lukács has belied and no automatic changes took place in the society, think both Horkheimer and Adorno. They both do not see the possibility of subjective reason attaining victory over reified reason which converts human labour into a commodity. Lukas's hope that the workers whose labour is alienated will finally overcome the structures that crippled and dehumanised them. Lukac's hope of a dialectical swing remained unfulfilled. With the help of mass media and communication objective reason gained further control over subjective reason.

This has resulted in what Horkheimer analysed as the pathological development of fascism in the West. Nazi Germany was the direct result of such a socio-pathological development. Also, at the individual level, the toll it took was the disintegration of the persons. There was an increase in clinically treated mental illnesses, phenomena of addiction and alcoholism, psycho-somatic disturbances to motivational problems and all sorts of psycho-pathological incidents and violence—both domestic and social.

11 George Lukács, *History and Class Consciousness*, trans. Rodney Livingstone (Cambridge: Massachusetts: MIT Press, 1971), 83–222

12 Habermas, *The Theory of Communicative Action,* Vol. 1, 361.

13 Lukács, *History and Class Consciousness* (Cambridge, Massachusetts: MIT Press, 1971), 101.

At the social and personal level of the individual modern reason was a catastrophe unparalleled in the history of mankind.

Adorno too rejected the logic of Hegelian dialectics in play. Adorno considers that Hegelian system relegates the particular and individual to insignificance. "[The] mediation of the universal through the particular and of the particular through the universal are put into the abstract normal form of mediation… then has to pay—to the point of being dismissed in an authoritarian manner in the material sections of Hegel's system.[14] Hegel's system relegates the particular and the individual to insignificance. This forceful reconciliation of the particular into the universal is an authoritarian reduction. Horkheimer and Adorno, tells Habermas, rejected Lukács's expectations of the restoration of subjective reason. They radicalised the critique of reification of Lukács.

According to these authors, looking bit more deeply into the problem, it is not merely at this historical juncture of the production process this disjunction between subjective and objective reason took place. They see that at the very juncture of disjunction between subjectivity and nature that the history of the reification commences. The assertion of the subject over nature, that is at the origin of the species itself, the human reason became purposive. According to them, it is at the radical disjunction between subjectivity and nature, that the history of reification begins.

The assertion of the subject over nature right at its beginning of the subject asserting itself resulted in the subjugation of the self. We quote here from *Dialectic of Enlightenment,* the joint work of Horkheimer and Adorno.

> As soon as man cuts off his consciousness of himself as nature, all the ends for which he keeps himself alive—social progress, the heightening of all his natural and spiritual powers, even consciousness itself—are nullified; the enthronement of means as ends, which in late capitalism has taken on the character of open madness, is already perceptible in the primordial history of subjectivity.[15]

Every advancement of reason detached from nature is, eventually, a detachment from man himself, and it is marked by irrationality. In capitalism, we are only at the very end of this road of self-destruction. Horkheimer and Adorno held that the basic contradiction in the human condition itself is self-alienation.

14 Theodor Adorno, *Negative Dialectics,* trans. E. B. Ashton (New York: Seabury Press, 1973), 322–323

15 Max Horkheimer and Theodor Adorno, *Dialectics of Enlightenment* (New York: Seabury Press, 1972), 54–55.

> From the time when reason became the instrument for domination of human and extra human nature by man—that is to say, from its very beginnings—it has been frustrated in its intention of discovering truth.[16]

At this juncture, that these authors idealised an idyllic return to the original unity of nature and culture. The ideal they projected is a universal reconciliation of subjective and objective reason. They dreamt of the 'emancipation of man through the resurrection of nature.'[17] This is not done through reviving the metaphysical or religious paradigms.

Horkheimer and Adorno thus turn to discussion to aesthetics. In *Dialectic of Enlightenment*, they name their method as *Mimesis*—the primordial act of giving names. It is in the primordial laughter of nature names are constituted. Mimesis is the exuberance of nature. It is nature's self-awareness.

> In laughter, blind nature precisely becomes aware of itself as such and therewith renounces destructive force. This double meaning of laughter is akin to that of name, and perhaps names are nothing but frozen laughter, as nick names are today…[18]

The primordial unity of nature and reason need to be re-established. This involves the recovery of both mind and matter and overcoming of the instrumentalising and objectifying orientation of reason. It is in the spirit of the young Marx who speaks of humanisation of nature and naturalisation of the humans, that these authors of the *Dialectic of Enlightenment* place their ideas of mimesis.

According to them, instrumentalisation of reason at the origin of the species has been a negation of this original unity. Reconciliation of the unity of reason and nature will involve recovering the unity of mind and nature. This alone can overcome the instrumentalising and objectifying of reason. *The Dialectic of Enlightenment* places these ideas of mimesis in the primordial unity of nature and reason. It is in art, they suggest, that reason will recover its balance.[19]

Aesthetics and its various forms, have the capacity to overcome the subject-object antinomy and establish harmony in our life—between

16 Horkheimer, *Eclipse of Reason,* 176.

17 Habermas, *The Theory of Communicative Action,* Vol. 1, 382.

18 Horkheimer and Adorno, *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (New York: Seabury Press, 1974), 77.

19 Horkheimer, Adorno, Marcuse and Benjamin wrote extensively on the theme of art and culture. For a summary view of their ideas, one may refer to David Held, *Introduction to Critical Theory, Horkheimer to Habermas,* 77–110.

the subjective and objective reason. Artistic expressions can expose the contradictions of the established order and negate reified consciousness. This artistic accomplishment is achieved through what these authors call 'non-identity thinking' in *Negative Dialectics*.[20] Nonidentity thinking is employing language in a manner that language can indicate beyond the signifier. It heightens the perception of thing-in-itself.

According to Adorno, *non-identity* thinking employs language, through the construction of 'constellations' of concepts, as a connotative or indicative devise and thus attains a transcendent quality.[21] However this transcendence does not lead to a final and total grasp of reality, as noted by David Held.[22] Non-identity thinking does not impose truth from without. It discloses truth from within. Language thus becomes indicative and realises its limits. Language is released of its objectivity and opens to transcendence and its symbolic nature.

In contrast, *in identity* thinking, claim is made that the concepts are adequate to the objects. Language then is made an instrument, a devise of connotation. Concepts often have hidden ideologies, and they try to subjugate the particular into the presumed universal. The particular is then thus dissolved into the universal. Truth is imposed from outside. Truth of the object is dominated by the concept of the mind. The transcendent character of nature and the universe is lost and subjugation of the world of object is relentlessly pursued.

According to Adorno, in identity thinking, claim is made that the concepts are adequate to objects. Language is made an instrument of measure. Its conative aspect is lost. According to him, bourgeois culture and art is best represented by identity thinking. It pretends itself to be mass culture—a culture of the masses—representing reality. Mass culture in fact is a flight from the real into the imaginary and the unreal. It is a distraction from the reality of the drudgery of life.

According to Adorno, authentic work of art challenges the day-to-day existence, it dismantles appearances and exposes the spurious harmonies. Aesthetic expressions have the capacity to portray the truth without distortion and exaggerations. Hence he thinks that artistic expressions could become a permanent protest of the particular against the universal and the reconciliation of the objective and subjective reason. For Adorno, art becomes the hope of man to guide him to the true path of liberation and

20 Adorno, *Negative Dialectics* (New York: Seabury Press, 1973), 146–161.

21 Theodor W. Adorno, *Prismen: Kulturkritik und Gesellshaft*, trans. Samuel and Shierry Weber, *Prisms* (London: Neville Spearman, 1967), 32.

22 David Held, *Introduction to Critical Theory* (Cambridge: Polity Press, 1990), 214.

escape from the iron cage of instrumental reason. Art paves the way for man for liberation.

Habermas Evaluates his Predecessors

These attempts of the early Frankfurt school masters, says Habermas, have not achieved the desired goals. Objective and subjective reason through the mediation of art could not achieve any real progress in social existence of man. Although their discussion deepened the critique of reason and heightened the awareness of the masses, they did not achieve any acceptable solution to the problem of objective reason claiming hold on the lifeworld. Mimetic ideas of original unity, Habermas says, escape the conceptual framework of subject-object relationship. According to him, mimesis is the 'sheer opposite of reason.' This attempt is reminiscent of the Judeo-Christian mystical approach to reality.[23]

The attempt to reconcile aesthetic reason to instrumental rationality highlights the dilemma of rationality itself. Habermas is not willing to discuss a trans-discursive reconciliation of reason. According to him, rational reconciliation must take place in discursive-communicative practice. This is possible only when cold and logical reason gives to the way to communication- to a communicative rationality. The paradigm of rational consciousness must shift to its fundamental aim: understanding, and hence of communication. Reconciliation of reason as purposive instrumentalisation ends where communication becomes the focus of reason. We read:

> But the rational core of mimetic achievements can be laid open only if we give up the paradigm of the philosophy of consciousness—namely, a subject that represents objects and toils with them—in favor of the paradigm of linguistic philosophy—namely, that of intersubjective understanding or communication and puts the cognitive instrumental aspect of reason in its proper place as part of a more encompassing *communicative rationality*.[24]

Habermas observes that this change of paradigm is near at hand in Adorno in some of his writings where he discusses his ideas of freedom and reconciliation. Mutual understanding based on free recognition of individuals and societies establishes intersubjective unity. Adorno as well as Horkheimer suggest the view that it is socialisation that makes individualisation possible. One does not achieve true freedom through the atomisation of the individuals, but rather in intersubjective recognition

23 Habermas, *The Theory of Communicative Action,* Vol. 1, 383.

24 Habermas, *The Theory of Communicative Action,* Vol. 1, 390.

and mediation.[25] It is in George Herbert Mead that we can find a fuller exposition of this concept. We have neither space nor time to look at Mead here. Perhaps we must do it at another time.

We have seen it already that the communication theory of Habermas is basically a response to the exhaustion of the western logos that seeks truth in place of understanding. According to him truth is only one condition of reason. There are also other areas reason need to fulfill its role to be successful in understanding, namely truthfulness and rightness. This thesis he arrives at by studying the speech act theories of Austin and Searle. Analytic philosophy opens us up from the focus of truth as the aim of speech. Truth is only one aspect of speech acts. Truth, truthfulness, and rightness are essential to the successful completion of speech act, and communication that it will lead to.

Understanding is the net result of all communication. All languages account to these conditions of speech, in order that they become successful in our age. In his view, all languages must accomplish these three conditions of speech and no one can force their way in the pursuit of their truth unilaterally. This would also mean that all languages are open at their horizons of truth and are available for transcendence and transformation. If reason opens to communication, Habermas hopes, our problems of modernity can be resolved and we will live a peaceful life. Communicative reason is the key to success of modernity and the hope of the humanity here on earth.

The Theory of Universal Pragmatics

Habermas constructs his theory of 'Universal Pragmatics' as a theory of hope at the juncture when western purposive rationality has paved the path for man to self-destruction. Communication theory of Habermas is basically a response to the exhaustion of the western logos. By establishing the universal conditions of speech—namely, truth, truthfulness, and rightness—mankind can recover the lost unity and purpose which man has lost by engaging with the purposive rationality. And harmony can be reestablished among themselves and nature itself and their own ontological existence through communicative reason and action. The universal conditions of speech propounded by Austin and Searle assists Habermas to establish a foundation for communication.

It is Searle who made the first distinction between a philosophy of language and linguistic philosophy. Searle thematises language and focuses on the illocutionary aspect of language. He shows in his book, *Speech Acts* what exactly makes possible in a language to produce truths, promises etc. According to Searle every speech is an act oriented to understanding.

25 Horkheimer, *Eclipse of Reason*, 176.

Speech, acts as a promise, an assertion, a warning, a command, an excuse or thousand or more types of actions. Austin corroborates this view saying that speech can do thousands of actions not just a thousand.[26] Ausstin considers every statement is a performative statement. According to Searle, besides being true or false, statements have also other functions. For example, when a bridegroom says in a marriage ceremony, "I do take this woman to be my lawful wedded wife," this statement by the speaker is not merely reporting their marriage or explaining the fact that they are now married, but rather performing an inward and spiritual action.[27]

Every speech is an action either explicit or implicit. A performative speech, according to Austin contains 'three, if not more different dimensions. Every sentence when it is employed has at first a *reference* content. When I am saying something, I am referring to something. This is the *locutionary* aspect of the utterance. Secondly, the performative act of a sentence has an *illocutionary* force, such as informing, promising, ordering, warning etc. And thirdly, what such illocutionary force brings about or achieves by saying something is the *perlocutionary* dimension of an utterance. For example, by uttering something, I may be putting someone puzzled or surprised, persuaded, warned, or get something stopped what he is doing.

Searle as well as Austin thinks that every speech is performing an act according to rules. According to Searle, "a theory of language is part of a theory of action, simply because speaking is a rule-governed behavior."[28] It is the rule-bound characteristic of language that Searle considers as that which constitutes the very possibility of language itself. The structure of language includes its rules. The illocutionary dimension of language attains its aim due to this rule-bound nature of language.[29]

Habermas develops further this thesis of Searle and states that speech acts, "must establish and bring to expression a certain relation between the speaker and his counterpart."[30] The intersubjective relational dimension of the speech acts which is based on rule-governed behavior, besides its referential function, receive great emphasis in Habermas. A speech act would succeed or fail depending on the relationship between the speaker and hearer.

26 John L. Austin, *How to do Things with Words* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1962), 150.

27 Austin, *How to do Things with Words*, 13.

28 John R. Austin, *How to do Things with Words* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1983), 17.

29 Austin, *How to do Things with Words*, 53.

30 Habermas, *Communication, and the Evolution of Society*, 34.

A speech act is bound to fulfill three conditions of speech, namely, truth, truthfulness, and rightness. Truth is the referential function. Besides this referential function, speech act also needs to show that the speaker is truthful as well as he is right. Then alone can a speech act succeed to communicate. To understand then means, fulfilling these three conditions in any speech act in an intersubjective context.

For Habermas, meaning is constituted from a pragmatic point of view, both from referential as well as the intersubjective context. It is not any logico-semantic endeavor of man such as we have in Wittgenstein, Dummet or Davidson that constitute the validity conditions of a speech act. In his pragmatic analysis, Habermas is not meddling with the truth semantics of the above authors. He is only trying to explain the connection between meaning and truth, meaning and validity, and meaning and understanding.[31] According to him, "truth is merely the most conspicuous -not the only validity claim reflected in the formal structure of speech."[32] The validity conditions to be fulfilled in any speech act are not only truth, but also truthfulness and rightness in the speech act.

Intersubjective relations in speech act are as much important for the success of speech as the truth itself. Trustworthiness in utterances is essential for any successful communication. A speaker's sincerity is as much relevant as truth itself as a validity condition for the success of the speech. A speech utterance of a speaker at the cognitive level raise not merely truth claims, but also at the interactive level, claims for rightness as well as truthfulness. According Habermas, the structure of speech includes not only the *external world* to which the truth refers, but also *the social world* and the *inner world* of the speaker. "In speech, speech sets itself off from the regions of external nature, society, and internal nature, as reality *sui generis* as soon as the sign-substrate, meaning, and denotation of a linguistic utterance can be distinguished.[33]

Habermas does not see any need for transcendental validity for his speech act claims. Speech acts unlike experiences are generated and aim at understanding. Its claims are empirically verifiable and based simply in the life-world rather than any transcendental foundation.[34] Habermas's theory of universal pragmatics is not based on truth claims alone, rather truth claims

31 Albrecht Wellmer, "What is a Pragmatic Theory of Meaning?..." in *Philosophical Interventions in the Unfinished Project of Enlightenment,* ed. Axel Honneth, Thomas McCarthy, et.al. (Cambridge: MIT Press, 1992), 193–194.

32 Wellmer, "What is a Pragmatic Theory of Meaning? ...," 193–194.

33 Habermas, *Communication, and the Evolution of Society* (Boston: Beacon Press, 1979), 68.

34 Habermas, *The Philosophical Discourse of Modernity* (Cambridge: Massachusetts: MIT Press, 1987), 312–313.

established in discourse. This means truth is established in communication. It is in intersubjective recognition that validity claims are confirmed and presuppositions and prejudices are overcome. "Communicative reason finds its criteria in the argumentative procedures for directly or indirectly redeeming claims to propositional truth, normative rightness, subjective truthfulness, and aesthetic harmony."[35] Communication is the new mantra of hope for the future of humanity. The idea of western logos contains in its soul these elements for its redemption. Truth, truthfulness, and rightness can save mankind from this relentless pursuit of truths which brings mankind to conflicts and destruction.

Consequences of Habermas' Theory of Communication

Consequences of Habermas's theory of universal pragmatics are far reaching and varied. First, this theory makes a critique of all hitherto held theories of meaning, such as that of Frege to Husserl. Meaning is no longer held as truth centred. "The pragmatically expanded theory of meaning overcomes this fixation on the fact-mirroring function of language. Like truth-condition semantics, it affirms an internal connection between meaning and validity, but it does not reduce this to the validity proper to truth."[36] Secondly, his theory disengages from all ontological presuppositions on which most often the communicational practices get bogged down. Habermas would hold that the validity conditions of all speech acts could be fulfilled mutually by the partners in dialogue, especially when they are trying to resolve conflicts.

Truth, truthfulness, and trustworthiness are a sufficient basis for the success of dialogue. Disengaging the theories of all the ontological notions, the agenda of Habermas is the formation of a society where consensual communication resolves all the problems. Having formed such a democratic community where dialogue is the essential ingredient, he hopes to respond to the crisis and ironies of the 'paradoxical contemporaneity' and instrumental reason. This will be also the answer to the 'narcistically overinflated autonomy of reason,' he claims.'[37]

Conclusion

Western logos is in crisis. Habermas seeks a way out from the blind alley in which modern reason finds itself in our age. His response springs not from religion or ontological solutions, or in an other-worldly hope, but from his confidence in reason itself. Reason is the foundation of all speech acts. Logos here on earth is not any helpless entity. Its foundation is sufficient to

35 Habermas, *The Philosophical Discourse of Modernity*, 314.

36 Habermas, *The Philosophical Discourse of Modernity,* 312–313.

37 Habermas, *The Philosophical Discourse of Modernity,* 315.

promote human harmony and hope for humanity. The very structure of the speech act reveals the various dimensions of reason.

In a new attempt in Western epistemology, Habermas also unveils another feature of human reason, namely the aspect of human interests. He writes, "Reason also means the will to reason. In self-reflection knowledge for the sake of knowledge attains congruence with the interest in autonomy and responsibility."[38] Habermas postulates a hope which is evolving, yet with a solid foundation in our age of reason. Reason employed rightly and sincerely can achieve solutions to all our modern problems, this is the hope Habermas offers to our contemporary world. Democratically engaged reason in a dialogically employed search can resolve the problems, humanity faces today. When ontological plurality puts obstacles to the resolution of pressing problems of our age, we need to look for secular means, and it is not any threat to our ontologies and metaphysics.

38 Habermas, *Knowledge, and Human Interests* (Cambridge: Polity Press, 1968), 314.

Do Human Enhancements Promote Hope?

Arnald Mahesh Irudhayadhason

Abstract

This article examines the ethical and philosophical implications of Human Enhancements (HEs) on human nature and the pursuit of a meaningful life. The drive for HE, fuelled by dissatisfaction with natural human limits, raises concerns about eroding intrinsic values that render life meaningful. Human vulnerability, rather than being a defect, is fundamental to humanity, fostering a sense of interconnectedness and depth. The analysis highlights ethical concerns, including genetic genocide, societal stratification, and disruption of individual and societal balances. It argues that true fulfilment and hope derive not from technological enhancements but from purposeful living, facing challenges optimistically, and valuing inherent vulnerabilities. The paper critiques the notion that HEs create a better life through improved health, advantages, or longevity, suggesting that these enhancements don't inherently contribute to a meaningful or hopeful existence. Instead, it advocates for embracing vulnerabilities, engaging in solidarity, and contributing to the common good. The article concludes that a meaningful life infused with hope involves adding more life to our years rather than endlessly prolonging lifespan or eliminating difficulties. It emphasises a cautious, regulated HE

approaches to preserve humanity while fostering social solidarity for a more meaningful and hopeful existence.

Keywords: *Better Life, Hope, Human Discontent, Human Enhancement, Human Finitude, Human Nature, Longer Life, Meaningful Life, Vulnerability.*

Introduction

Human Enhancement (HE) refers to "any deliberate technological and/or biomedical intervention on the healthy human body or mind to improve our physical and/or mental capabilities above the level that is typical of human beings, with a view to increasing our welfare."[1] The pursuit of HE has become contentious in modern society, prompting deep inquiries into humanity, morality, and meaningful life. This paper scrutinises the underlying dispositions driving the enhancement project and its ethical implications. At its core, this discussion centres on the human condition. Desires for improvement have historically driven humans, but now focused inward on modifying the body through various enhancements. This relentless pursuit transforms cultural, economic, social, political, ethical, and personal aspects of life, revealing deep-seated dissatisfaction with natural human limits and an unyielding desire to transcend them. Human vulnerability, characterised by susceptibility to change, chance, luck, and the natural lottery, is pivotal in this analysis. It fosters interconnectedness and gives life meaning. However, attempts to overcome vulnerability through HE raise critical ethical concerns, potentially jeopardising the nature of human essence and values that make life meaningful. This article examines the purpose and limits of HE, questioning whether the promised benefits, such as better health, greater advantages, and longer life, contribute to a more meaningful existence. It argues that true hope and fulfilment arise not from technological enhancements but from living purposefully, facing challenges optimistically, and valuing inherent vulnerabilities. Ultimately, it posits that a meaningful life involves adding more life to our years rather than endlessly prolonging lifespan or eliminating difficulties.

1. Dispositions Driving the Enhancement Project

1.1. Human Discontent

When examining HE, we ask, "Are we a dissatisfied lot?" Human history is marked by a desire for change, evident in all aspects of life. This drive has shifted inward, with efforts to modify the human body, though many

1 Arnald Mahesh Irudhayadhason, "Human Enhancement and Its Ethical Concerns," *Omega: Indian Journal of Science and Religion* 21, no. 2 (2023): 8–9.

"promised HEs" remain scientific fictions. This relentless pursuit of enhancement has transformed our cultural, economic, social, political, ethical, and personal spheres.[2] The mantra "enough is enough" no longer applies; each fulfilment creates new desires and vacuums. Any novelty becomes outdated within no time.[3] Why are we so dissatisfied? The relentless pursuit of HEs is both fascinating and disquieting. As Alvin Toffler noted, rapid change can cause stress and disorientation.[4] Initially gradual, HEs have accelerated dramatically, from natural enhancements (healthy diets) to external tools (binoculars), then to bodily assimilations (pacemakers) and direct biological interventions (kidney transplants). Now, we're tampering with genetics and dreaming of designer babies, even aiming for immortality. This reveals our deep dissatisfaction with natural limits and an unrelenting desire to overcome them, highlighting the need to manage our intrinsic discontent. The answer is not to reject HEs outright, but to reassess our relentless pursuit of them. We argue that this pursuit is not a suitable moral response to our inherent discontent. While our survival instinct may make, HE inevitable, it also risks undermining the survival and identity of the human species. This instinct could transform us into transhumans and eventually posthumans, a shift that is morally disconcerting. The current acceleration of HE may make this transformation inevitable, leading us to confront posthumanity with moral apprehensions.

1.2. Flight from Finitude

The pursuit of HEs is deeply rooted in human finitude. Humans are limited in every way. These limitations make us fragile and vulnerable. Human finitude is inevitable, but how we deal with it is a choice. Our bodies are the foundation of our goals and dreams. The natural lottery of life gives us unequal gifts, and we face additional mental, social, and psychological limitations. HEs promise to reduce these obstacles by enhancing bodily capacities and personality traits, fuelling our confidence in overcoming inherent limitations. Many Americans are ashamed of their shortcomings, which are exploited for commercial profit.[5] This raises ethical concerns:

a) Addressing shortcomings is not wrong, but the methods used are troubling;

2 Jack Woodall, "Programmed Dissatisfaction: Does One Gene Drive All Progress in Science and the Arts?" *The Scientist* 21, no. 6 (2007): 63.

3 Alfred Marshall, *Principles of Economics: An Introductory Volume*, 8th ed. (London: Macmillan and Co. Ltd., 1920), 112.

4 Alvin Toffler, *Future Shock* (New York: Bantam Books, Inc., 1970), 2.

5 Arthur Caplan and Carl Elliott, "Is It Ethical to Use Enhancement Technologies to Make Us Better than Well?" *Public Library of Science Medicine* 1, no. 3 (2004): 174.

b) We must reassess how we define "shortcomings" and avoid valuing normal human limitations as such;
c) Comparing ourselves to commercially promoted norms can lead to seeking HEs to eliminate perceived shortcomings.[6]

Commercial markets portray HEs as a means to liberate us from bodily limitations, but this is misleading. HEs do not free us from limitations; they create new ones. Yesterday's normality becomes today's limitation, and today's liberation may become tomorrow's constraint. We argue that existential finitude is essential for freedom. Without constraints, there would be no choice, and freedom and responsibility would lose their meaning. Our limitations are crucial for a life of freedom and responsibility. While considering HEs, we must remember that our finitude, social dependency, and capacity for mistakes are inherent and beyond human control. Ignoring these aspects makes HE interventions unproductive and inhumane. We should resist social pressures that promote HE as a path to perfection, recognising the importance of our limitations in a meaningful life.[7]

1.3. Culture of Restlessness

A contemporary trend of restiveness and the "easy way" has infiltrated every aspect of our personal and social life, driving the development of HEs.

i. Our restlessness is evident in our families with instant coffee and fast food, and in public life with express buses, high-speed trains, and jet planes, all aimed at saving time. Our consumer society promotes and exploits this trend for its interests. Using mountain climbing as an example, the process of climbing requires discipline, concentration, and stamina, which are essential for achieving a sense of accomplishment. Reaching the top via a helicopter misses out on these valuable experiences. This analogy also applies to HE projects, where shortcuts may deprive us of the lessons and satisfaction derived from the process itself.
ii. The concept of "the easy way" is another driving force behind HEs. Technological advancements have made our lives easier, from remote controls to e-shopping, saving time and energy. However, when this attitude extends to healthcare, it becomes disquieting. We seek to achieve our plans and dreams without effort or pain, escaping suffering rather than facing it with fortitude, empathy, and solidarity. This culture of haste and apathy undermines traditional values such as hard work, tolerance, patience, and interdependence. It has given rise to independent individualism or anti-interdependence. The fields of medicine, pharmacology, biotechnology, genetic engineering, and nanotechnology have been influenced by this consumerist trend, leading to the development of HEs. Thus, the pursuit of HE is also driven by this culture of restiveness and unease. "Going fast" is not always necessary; it depends on the context. While speeding may be safe on some roads, it's crucial to slow down or choose alternative routes for safety or higher motives, such as ecological reasons. Similarly, HEs are not a path to be rushed. We must discuss, explain, and justify the promises of HEs while addressing the potential perils.

6 Caplan and Elliott, "Is It Ethical to Use Enhancement Technologies to Make Us Better than Well?" 174.

7 Sitter-Liver, "Finitude—A Neglected Perspective in Bioethics," in *Bioethics in Cultural Contexts: Reflections on Methods and Finitude*, eds. Christoph Rehmann-Sutter *et al*. (Dordrecht: Springer, 2006), 48–50.

2. Purpose and Limit of Human Enhancement

2.1. Purpose of Human Enhancement

When the purpose is clear, setting limits becomes easier. However, individual purposes for HE can vary significantly. The ultimate aims of HE can be diverse:

a. Some seek HE to correct perceived defects or imperfections;[8]
b. Others aim to augment already healthy traits or become "better than well;"[9]
c. Some pursue HE for happiness, success, profit, competitive advantage, or biological perfection;[10]
d. Others may use HE to compensate for natural selection's shortcomings in a rapidly changing environment;[11]
e. Some choose HE to create genetically superior children with better life opportunities;
f. Finally, some may aim for overall well-being or even posthuman status as the ultimate end of HE.

These varied objectives highlight the complexity in defining and limiting HE. Some of the targeted ends of HE are not actual ends but rather means

8 Alex Rajczi, "One Danger of Biomedical Enhancements," *Bioethics* 22, no. 6 (2008): 333.

9 Bengt Brülde, "Human Enhancement and Well-Being," in *The Good Life in a Technological Age*, eds. Philip Brey *et al*. (New York: Routledge, 2012), 253.

10 Rajczi, "One Danger of Biomedical Enhancements," 331, 333.

11 Paul Miller and James Wilsdon, "Stronger, Longer, Smarter, Faster," in *Better Humans? The Politics of Human Enhancement and Life Extension*, eds. Paul Miller and James Wilsdon (London: Demos, 2006), 14.

to achieve other goals. For example, a film actress might enhance her features not just for attractiveness but to gain more acting opportunities. Similarly, enhancing capabilities could be a means to gain a competitive edge (enhancement certificate).[12] Regardless of whether these purposes are achievable, the key question is whether it is possible to determine when enough is enough or when enhancements become excessive. These questions are crucial for limiting HE. However, proponents of radical enhancement argue for continuous advancement in HE technology. Bostrom believes that the development of HE requires persistent transformation into something new.[13] Caplan warns that setting limits on HE, as suggested by anti-meliorists, would cause us and future generations to miss out on significant opportunities offered by biotechnologies.[14]

2.2. How Much is too Much?

Setting limits in HE is essential for several reasons:

a. It allows us to address ethical concerns, particularly the long-term effects of altering human traits and capacities;
b. It helps manage the socio-cultural changes brought about by the continuous development of HE technologies;[15]
c. It enables us to create a "scenario planning" for the future, avoiding overvaluation of HE and preparing for potential consequences if such overvaluation occurs.[16]

These limits are necessary to respond appropriately to the ethical and societal implications of HE. The purpose and limits of HE are closely intertwined. Our analysis suggests that the ultimate purpose of HE is unrealisable, making the pursuit endless and meaningless. Even if achievable, we do not endorse its desirability due to ethical concerns. Our examination of the 'issue of limits' addresses three key questions:

a. Are there constraints to the development of HE technologies?
b. Is there a limit to an individual's use of HEs?
c. Can the state regulate individuals' pursuit of HE?

12 Allen Buchanan *et al.*, *From Chance to Choice: Genetics and Justice* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2000): 3–4, 97–98.

13 Nick Bostrom, "Human Genetic Enhancements: A Transhumanist Perspective," *The Journal of Value Inquiry* 37, no. 4 (2003), 493–506.

14 Arthur Caplan, "Is It Wrong to Try to Improve Human Nature," in *Better Humans? The Politics of Human Enhancement and Life Extension*, eds. Paul Miller and James Wilsdon (London: Demos, 2006), 39.

15 Miller and Wilsdon, "Stronger, Longer, Smarter, Faster," 14.

16 Rajczi, "One Danger of Biomedical Enhancements," 328.

Constraints on HE technology development: We must evaluate HE technologies like any other, but their unique nature, purpose, and potential to alter human life set them apart. Given other pressing social and personal needs, there is no urgency to develop HE technologies, especially in economically self-sufficient states.

Individual use of HE and state regulation: The second and third questions are interrelated. Controlling individual use of HE is challenging due to potential underground development and backdoor entry. State legitimisation of HE does not fully address this issue; instead, state regulation through various social and legal institutions is necessary to avoid ethical and social problems. In summary, we argue against the unregulated pursuit of HE and advocate for state regulation to mitigate ethical and social issues.

3. Does Human Nature have any Normative Significance?

3.1. What is Human Nature?

Norman Daniels defines human nature in three ways: as a population concept (shared traits among species members), a dispositional concept (traits people exhibit under various conditions), and a selective, theory-laden concept (distinctive traits of humans).[17] Human nature can be seen as a set of common properties that humans possess,[18] shaped by the evolutionary process. We argue that one of the key and distinctive properties of human nature is 'vulnerability.' While all living beings are vulnerable, humans are unique in their consciousness of this vulnerability, their ability to cope with it, and to find meaning in it. Human vulnerability is not value-neutral but is both inherently and socio-culturally valuable. Attempting to alter this vulnerability[19] through HE interventions threatens human nature, which Sandel describes as the deepest form of disempowerment, and Erik Parens as an impoverishment of humans.[20] In this sense, human nature is normatively significant and morally pertinent.

17 Norman Daniels, "Can Anyone Really Be Talking About Ethically Modifying Human Nature?" in *Human Enhancement*, eds. Julian Savulescu and Nick Bostrom (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2009), 28–32.

18 Francis Fukuyama, *Our Posthuman Future: Consequences of the Biotechnology Revolution* (London: Profile Books Ltd., 2002), 171–172.

19 Jürgen Mittelstrass, "Science and the Search for a New Anthropology," in *Rethinking Human Nature: A Multidisciplinary Approach,* ed. Malcolm Jeeves (Grand Rapids, MI: William B. Eerdmans Publishing Company, 2011), 68–69.

20 Erik Parens, "The Goodness of Fragility: On the Prospect of Genetic Technologies Aimed at the Enhancement of Human Capacities," *Kennedy Institute of Ethics Journal* 5, no. 2 (1995): 141, 143.

3.2. What is the Ethical Significance of Human Vulnerability?

Vulnerability is an inherent property of human nature, characterised by the subjectivity to change, chance,[21] luck, and the natural lottery. This vulnerability drives our technological inventions, as our aims and desires are contingent on the unreliable condition of our bodies. HE aims to reduce these limitations imposed by our bodily existence. However, the promise to overcome vulnerability risks denying a fundamental aspect of human nature.[22] Our concern is more about the ethical significance of human vulnerability rather than just mastering it. Ultimately, we must question what we would lose by substantially reducing our vulnerability.

i. HE threatens human vulnerability to change and chance, potentially undermining valuable aspects of human experience. For instance, lifespan extension aims to overcome ageing difficulties but could radically alter intergenerational relationships. Enhancing the elderly might lead to reducing the time spent on younger generations, using HE to accelerate their growth. This could erode the value of caregiving and care-receiving,[23] as well as the recognition and acceptance of human neediness.

ii. Reducing vulnerability to chance also has significant implications. If everyone had all desired traits, there would be no need for further improvement,[24] leading to the "tyranny of the normal."[25] Eliminating natural imperfections would relieve society of the responsibility to respond to the needs of the disadvantaged and marginalised. This approach expresses a fear and hatred for differences, advocating for engineering sameness. Thus, our efforts to overcome vulnerability could result in losing goods such as species diversity and tolerance for inherent differences among people.

iii. Reducing our vulnerability to chance could impact the value of human excellence, particularly in sports. The excellence of athletes who perform without enhancements is more appreciated by sports enthusiasts than that of drug-induced athletes.[26] Human excellence is often the result of a unique combination of chance and effort. Without chance, sports would become a mere scientific measurement of physical and strategic abilities, reducing it to labour or entertainment.[27] The unpredictability of results is crucial in sports, which enhances the entertainment, excitement, and thrill for spectators. Manipulating vulnerability through performance enhancement could debilitate this unpredictability, potentially diminishing the value of experiencing excellence in sports.

iv. Valuing our vulnerability highlights the delicate balance of properties within individuals, our species, and between our species and the natural world. Attempts to overcome human vulnerability through enhancements could disrupt this balance and interdependence, both within our species and with nature. Our vulnerability fosters a sense of connectedness and solidarity with others, particularly the less privileged. Experiencing bad luck can develop empathy for those facing similar challenges. Mastering vulnerability would erode this sense of solidarity and shift us towards an exclusive form of individualism, elevating it as the ultimate value of life. This could lead to a loss of communal bonds and a more isolated existence.

v. Human vulnerability is closely tied to our role as responsible agents. The designer child project, where traits are chosen through genetic engineering, raises questions about moral and legal responsibility. If an individual's genetic traits are predetermined, it challenges the notion that they can be held responsible for their actions since these actions might be attributed to their genetically determined structure rather than their agency.[28] This scenario could lead to a re-evaluation of moral agency, potentially transforming our social, moral, and legal institutions. It may also impact our authentic human interrelatedness, as the attribution of character to genetic properties and environment is a contentious issue. If genetic character were fully determined, it would cast significant

21 Parens, "The Goodness of Fragility: On the Prospect of Genetic Technologies Aimed at the Enhancement of Human Capacities," 143.

22 Donna J. Haraway, *Simians, Cyborgs, and Women: The Reinvention of Nature* (London: Free Association Books, 1991), 1–4, 208–215, 224–230.

23 Stephen Gerrard Post, *Spheres of Love: Toward a New Ethics of the Family* (Dallas, TX: Southern Methodist University Press, 1994), 52–54, 92–96, 104–107.

24 Parens, "The Goodness of Fragility: On the Prospect of Genetic Technologies Aimed at the Enhancement of Human Capacities," 143–146.

25 Leslie A. Fiedler, "The Tyranny of the Normal," in *Which Babies Shall Live? Humanistic Dimensions of the Care of Imperiled Newborns*, eds. Thomas H. Murray and Arthur L. Caplan (Clifton, NJ: Humana Press, 1985), 158.

26 Parens, "The Goodness of Fragility: On the Prospect of Genetic Technologies Aimed at the Enhancement of Human Capacities," 144–147.

27 Frans De Wachter, "In Praise of Chance: A Philosophical Analysis of the Element of Chance in Sports," *Journal of the Philosophy of Sport* 12, no. 1 (1985): 52–61.

28 J. O'Higgins, "Introduction," in Anthony Collins, *Determinism and Freewill: Anthony Collins' A Philosophical Inquiry Concerning Human Liberty*, ed. J. O'Higgins (The Hague: Martinus Nijhoff, 1976), 1–45.

doubt on our moral agency and could fundamentally alter our understanding of responsibility and human relationships.

Human vulnerability *cannot be fully overcome*; attempts to achieve invulnerability are ultimately futile. Human life is multidimensional, encompassing physical, mental, psychological, moral, familial, social, political, cultural, and religious or non-religious aspects. Vulnerability is inherent in all these dimensions and fosters the interconnectedness of our social nature, making life meaningful. Considering death as the ultimate form of vulnerability, it is clear that it cannot be mastered. Death can result from various factors, including senescence, accidents, natural calamities, and the actions of others. Since mastering vulnerability is unlikely, there is no purpose in trying to control it. Happiness is not inversely related to vulnerability; instead, it involves integrating vulnerability and experiences of loss. Happiness does not mean eliminating vulnerability but rather living with it. The deepest moral objection to HE lies not in the perfection it seeks but in the human disposition it expresses and promotes (CP, 46).

4. Does the Promised *better* Life of he Promote "Hope?"

To conduct a rational, and reasonable analysis of the concept under discussion, let us understand hope as a multifaceted philosophical notion that combines desire, expectation, and uncertainty about a future outcome. Envisioned as a virtue by philosophers such as Aristotle, and Kant, hope motivates resilience and the striving for improvement. When grounded in reason, or moral principles, hope is rational, and essential for well-being, and ethical behaviour. It bridges the gap between current reality, and future aspirations, inspiring action, and perseverance. In existentialist thought, hope confers meaning, and purpose, even in the face of adversity. Ultimately, hope sustains human existence by fostering a dynamic tension between the present, and a better future.

The proponents of HE argue that HE interventions have the potential to enhance various human capabilities, and characteristics. Based on the working definition of HE, these interventions aim to elevate human capabilities beyond typical levels, potentially reducing vulnerabilities:

a. *Overcoming Limitations*,
b. *Improved Quality of Life,*
c. *Increased Resilience,* and
d. *Enhanced Creativity, and Productivity*.

On the other hand, HEs pose significant challenges to the concept of hope due to the numerous ethical concerns they raise, such as *principle-based concerns, concerns related to justice, concerns related to freedom, and autonomy, and consequentialist concerns.* Consequently, there are diverse perspectives on whether HEs genuinely promote hope for human life. While HEs might make us "better" than well, the question remains whether this "improved" state of life truly makes our lives better. If one argues that the promised *better* human life through HEs fosters hope, how are we to understand this notion of a "good", or "better" life?

4.1. Does a Healthier Life Promote Hope?

Employment of HE seems to promise a better-than-healthy life. For our discussion here, let us define health as a state of physical and mental well-being, where any impairment of normal human functioning is absent. However, health is not a permanent state of life achieved once and for all. It is also vulnerable to various social and environmental conditions, seasonal and strange communicable diseases, unforeseen accidents, and unpredictable natural calamities. We have not yet reached the stage of being "invulnerable." One may attribute either intrinsic or instrumental value to health. We, however, do not endow mere instrumental value to health; rather, we ascribe to health both intrinsic and instrumental value,[29] although it has more of an instrumental value. It is an intrinsic good inasmuch as it is a value in itself—that is, to enjoy good health in itself is a value. At the same time, good health has an immense instrumental value to the extent it helps us design and achieve our life projects. Without health, it would be nearly impossible to do anything we wish to do, or to be the kind of person we want to be. Although health is an important and inevitable element, it is not the sole matter of concern in our life. For instance, one can lead a happier and worthwhile life *because of*, not in spite of, ill health. Hence, HEs can help us improve our health above our normal human level; however, they do not necessarily make our life *better*. As such, we claim that a person with a 'better than healthy life' does not automatically lead a happier life than one with a 'less than healthy life,' —and as such, it does not promote hope either.

4.2. Does a Life with Greater Advantages Promote Hope?

When a person has her different capacities considerably enhanced, her range of opportunities is likely to become wider. Consequently, one is more likely to gain greater social and economic advantages than others. At times, enjoying good health alone may not bring great opportunities. However, when one produces an "enhancement certificate," one's opportunities will not only plausibly increase, but may also will turn in one's favour. There

29 Robin Attfield, *Ethics: An Overview* (New York: Continuum International Publishing Group, 2012), 61.

has been a claim that new technological developments improve our health, enhance our working and living conditions, offer us more opportunities to enjoy our lives, and increase our well-being on the whole.[30] However, our concern is whether one's "improved" social status makes one's life better and happier. *We maintain that one does not become happier because one has more material welfare.* People who live in developed societies are not happier than those who lived fifty years ago in the same societies when they were less developed. Besides, economic development is most unlikely to make us happier.[31] There is a highly significant relationship between intelligence and suicidal tendencies. The higher the standard IQ of a society, the greater its suicide rate.[32] Hence, our apprehension is that while an enhanced life could bring considerable advantages, it might not necessarily pave the way for a happier or more meaningful life. Would we perhaps find it challenging to cope with the greater advantages and the subsequent changes we would need to undergo thanks to HEs? Would we still need more years to convert these opportunities into realities to make a better life? Hence, we raise serious concerns about whether a life with greater advantages, as effected by HE, would promote hope.

4.3. Does a Longer Life Promote Hope?

Every HE intervention has an implicit intention to promote longer life. We wonder whether the tendency to extend our life indefinitely exhibits our desire to transcend or transgress the limits of the body.[33] Some might even consider the overcoming of human limitations as the greatest expression of human dignity and human nature.[34] When one enjoys better health, one's life is more likely to be longer than usual. However, good health will not indefinitely increase one's lifespan. Nevertheless, how do we understand "longer life" in the context of HEs? We need to clarify whether longevity is achieved through a mere disease-free, healthy life, or a healthy life accompanied by age retardation. Although the realisation of the latter is not possible in the immediate future, our question is whether we *desire* such an endless prolongation of our life through the retardation of the ageing process. If it were so, are we not trying to convert our old age into "a kind

30 Brülde, "Human Enhancement and Well-Being," 250.

31 Richard Layard, *Happiness: Lessons from a New Science* (London: Penguin Books, 2005), 223, 42.

32 Martin Voracek, "National Intelligence and Suicide Rate: An Ecological Study of 85 Countries," *Personality and Individual Differences* 37, no. 3 (2004): 543–551.

33 Gilbert Meilaender, *Should We Live Forever? The Ethical Ambiguities of Aging* (Grand Rapids, MI: William B. Eerdmans Publishing Company, 2013), x.

34 Ronald Bailey, *Liberation Biology: The Scientific and Moral Case for the Biotech Revolution* (New York: Prometheus Books, 2005), 61.

of endless middle age?"[35] One might argue that we would be able to achieve all our life projects, and realise all our dreams. However, does the former make us experience the *fullness* of life or an accomplished life? Can we value a life with a string of *mere* accomplishments as a *better* life? If yes, how do we interpret the concept of an accomplishment? In addition, when our life is prolonged "endlessly," how many accomplishments will make an accomplished life or a better life? Our understanding of a longer life, however, does not imply living more years than the human average, but living more healthily, living well, or living better. Hence, one does not make one's life better merely by extending one's longevity but by leading a meaningful life.[36] To that extent, a longer life, which is an effect of HE projects, is less likely to promote hope.

5. Vulnerability, Meaningful Life, and Hope

We contend that a "claimed" *better* life, resulting from *merely* a healthier life, or a life with greater advantages or *mere* personal accomplishments due to the engagement of HEs, does not necessarily promote hope—or hope for a meaningful life. Instead, it is a life that is lived well – a meaningful life – that is more likely to promote hope. What is important is not how *long* we live, but how *well* we live our lives infused with hope. Learning to live *well* is more important than learning to live *longer*; when we have mastered the art of living our lives well, living longer may not interest us anymore.[37] When one has lived one's life to the full for a good cause, then it would be easier to welcome death. Contrarily, death would be an unwelcome guest for a young person who still has his life projects unfulfilled, or *hopes* to realise them. Hence, we assert that a good life does not necessarily imply a life with a greater number of years, in which one has one's life dreams realised. One has brought everything to fulfilment or completion. Although medicine and health care have contributed to an increase in the average lifespan, they cannot guarantee a *hope* for a fulfilled or meaningful life.

HEs could promise a healthier life and generate significant profits by expanding the range of opportunities. They might even enable us to live longer, potentially indefinitely. However, HEs cannot make our lives meaningful or offer hope for a meaningful existence. A meaningful life

35 Daniel Callahan, "Why We Must Set Limits," in *A Good Old Age? The Paradox of Setting Limits*, eds. Paul Homer and Martha Holstein (New York: Simon & Schuster Inc., 1990), 26.

36 Arnald Mahesh Irudhayadhason, *The Ethics of Human Enhancement* (Chennai: Don Bosco Publications, 2017), 294.

37 Larry S. Temkin, "Is Living Longer Living Better?" *Journal of Applied Philosophy* 25, no. 3 (2008): 364.

involves those elements that *give* meaning to us.[38] A meaningful life need not necessarily include good health, greater opportunities, and sufficient years of life. While a meaningful life *might* integrate all these, it is not confined to them. Health and long life alone do not define a meaningful life. One could have led a meaningful life despite living fewer years than expected, experiencing poor health, or lacking remarkable success, provided one had not lost hope in continuing to live. Someone's life is well-lived when her life exhibits at least some characteristics, if not all, that we consider pertinent. In a liberal society, different people endorse varying concepts of a meaningful life. A meaningful life may include fulfilment of our basic needs, leading a life of self-affirmation, bringing our potentialities to creative actualisation, possessing freedom to determine our actions, responsibility to create our future,[39] having a bigger goal in life, being interested in the common good of society, and creating happiness by leading ethical lives.[40]

Projecting a "meaningful" life, HEs endeavour in vain to do away with our difficulties and pains, creating a painless paradise on earth. HEs promise to create happiness or meaning as a *product*, but trying to create happiness, for instance, through taking a pill, belittles the value of hope for the *meaning* of life. Happiness in itself is a by-product – "something which can only *happen* to us." Striving to produce "happiness" according to our whims and fancies will surely fail.[41] When someone leads a meaningful life, she is plausibly also happy. We can interchange 'meaningful life' and 'happy life' as long as we create meaning and happiness by living our lives to the fullest, particularly by living with a purpose. "Making happy people" through biomedical interventions or drugs can be compared to *giving* a fish to someone, rather than *teaching* them to fish. Giving a fish to someone deprives them of the experience of catching fish. "Teaching to fish" not only gives someone the experience of fishing, but also gives them fish to eat. Similarly, achieving a meaningful life through HEs, albeit a remote possibility, leads one to take a shortcut in life, and failing to face the challenges and experiences that one confronts in daily life.

Aside from living for one's larger goals in life, one could easily create meaning in one's life by fulfilling various moral ends in the context of "universal humanhood." That is, instead of searching for and trying to

38 Thaddeus Metz, "Recent Work on the Meaning of Life," *Ethics* 112, no. 4 (2002): 794.

39 Paul Kurtz, *In Defense of Secular Humanism* (New York: Prometheus Books, 1983), 162–168.

40 Rajczi, "One Danger of Biomedical Enhancements," 333.

41 Herman De Dijn, "Technology in Health Care: A Philosophical Ethical Appraisal," in *Between Technology and Humanity: The Impact of Technology on Health Care Ethics*, ed. Chris Gastmans (Leuven: Leuven University Press, 2002), 29.

create *meaning* through the employment of "expensive" HEs – some of which are either mere science fiction or vanity – one could invest one's money and energy in acts of solidarity that would not only give hope to those who are vulnerable but also strengthen our hope. One could help those living amidst insecurities and uncertainties—especially those who are struggling to meet their fundamental human needs, such as food, clothing, shelter, healthcare, sanitation, education, and many other preventable and manageable vulnerabilities. The easiest way to find meaning in one's life is by helping others find meaning and happiness, integrating hope into their lives, or enabling others to live a worthwhile life infused with hope. As such, a meaningful life is not a product of HEs, but a by-product of how *well* we live our lives—both for ourselves and for others. A meaningful life is about promoting life with purpose; a life filled with hope. It involves facing life's blessings, difficulties, and challenges with optimism and joy. Therefore, we conclude that a meaningful life infused with hope does not consist in endlessly prolonging our lifespan but in adding more life to the years we have.[42]

Conclusion

The quest of HE has brought us to a critical juncture, necessitating a reassessment of our existential foundations. This paper has uncovered profound ethical and philosophical implications in the interplay between HE, human nature, and the quest for a meaningful life. Our analysis reveals that the drive for HE often stems from a misguided attempt to transcend human limitations—risking the erosion of intrinsic values that make life meaningful. Human vulnerability is a fundamental aspect of our humanity that fosters interconnectedness and depth. The creation of posthumans through genetic enhancements poses significant risks to social cohesion and human dignity, highlighting the need for cautious and regulated approaches. True meaning and hope are not achieved through technological enhancements alone but through living a purposeful life, facing challenges with optimism, and valuing our vulnerabilities. In conclusion, while HEs promise better health, greater advantages, and longer life, they do not inherently contribute to a more meaningful or hopeful existence. The true path to fulfilment lies in embracing our vulnerabilities, engaging in acts of solidarity, and contributing to the common good. This balanced approach ensures that our pursuit of HE does not compromise our humanity. By valuing our vulnerabilities and fostering social solidarity, we can create a more meaningful and hopeful life, one that is rich in experience and depth rather than mere longevity or technological advancement.

42 Meilaender, *Should We Live Forever? The Ethical Ambiguities of Aging*, 3.

Ethics, Aesthetics, and Hope
Pathways to a Holistic Human Experience

Kuruvilla Pandikattu

Abstract

This article explores the intricate relationships between ethics, aesthetics, and hope as pathways to a holistic human experience. It draws on philosophical traditions from Plato and Aristotle to Kant, Kierkegaard, and Nietzsche, examining how ethical principles, aesthetic appreciation, and hope influence personal development and societal norms. The discussion highlights the role of ethical leadership and aesthetics in organisational life, alongside the power of hope in fostering resilience and community transformation. By linking beauty with moral virtue and illustrating hope's role in ethical striving and creative expression, the article offers a comprehensive framework for integrating these concepts in education, leadership, and personal growth. Practical implications include fostering holistic development in individuals and organisations and contributing to a compassionate, just, and aesthetically enriched society.

Keywords: *Ethics, Aesthetics, Hope, Moral Virtue, Ethical Leadership, Personal Development*.

Introduction

Exploring the interconnections between ethics, aesthetics, and hope is a compelling endeavour that offers profound insights into the human condition. Ethics, the philosophical study of moral principles, guides human conduct by establishing frameworks for determining right and wrong actions. Aesthetics, the branch of philosophy dealing with the nature of beauty and artistic taste, enriches our sensory and emotional experiences, fostering a deeper appreciation of the world around us. Hope, an essential psychological and existential state, sustains our aspirations and resilience, providing the motivation to pursue our goals despite adversities. The interrelation of these domains is crucial in understanding how humans navigate the complexities of life and strive towards a more harmonious existence.

Historically, the intersection of these concepts can be traced back to ancient philosophical traditions. Greek philosophy, particularly the works of Plato and Aristotle, often intertwined ethical considerations with aesthetic judgments. In *The Republic*, Plato posits that the good and the beautiful are intrinsically linked, with the pursuit of beauty leading one towards a virtuous life.[1] For Plato, the ideal forms of beauty and goodness were deeply connected, suggesting that the appreciation of beauty could inspire moral virtue. Similarly, Aristotle's "Nicomachean Ethics" emphasises the role of virtue and beauty in achieving eudaimonia, or human flourishing.[2] Aristotle argued that a well-lived life, characterised by the practice of virtues, was inherently beautiful, aligning moral excellence with aesthetic appreciation.

In the modern era, Immanuel Kant's "Critique of Judgment" explores the interplay between aesthetic experience and moral sensibility, suggesting that aesthetic judgments can cultivate moral feelings and ethical awareness.[3] Kant proposed that the experience of beauty could evoke a sense of moral duty, as the disinterested pleasure derived from aesthetic appreciation mirrors the impartiality required for moral judgment. The existentialist philosophy of figures like Søren Kierkegaard and Friedrich Nietzsche further delves into the role of hope in navigating ethical and aesthetic dilemmas, highlighting the importance of individual choice and authenticity.[4] Kierkegaard emphasised the necessity of hope in confronting life's uncertainties, while Nietzsche saw the creation of personal values as an aesthetic act of self-expression, driven by a hopeful vision of human potential.

1 Plato, *The Republic* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1997).

2 Aristotle, *Nicomachean Ethics* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2009).

3 Immanuel Kant, *Critique of Judgment* (Indianapolis: Hackett Publishing Company, 2000).

4 Søren Kierkegaard, *Fear and Trembling* (London: Penguin Classics, 1985); Friedrich Nietzsche, *Thus Spoke Zarathustra* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2001).

Objectives and Scope

This article aims to elucidate the interconnections between ethics, aesthetics, and hope, demonstrating how these concepts collectively influence human behaviour and societal norms. The objectives are as follows:

a. To provide a comprehensive understanding of the conceptual frameworks of ethics, aesthetics, and hope.
b. To examine the historical and philosophical foundations of these interconnections.
c. To explore practical implications and applications in contemporary contexts, including education, organisational leadership, and personal development.

The scope of this article encompasses an interdisciplinary approach, drawing from philosophy, psychology, and cultural studies to offer a nuanced analysis of these interconnections. The structure is divided into five main sections: conceptual frameworks, historical context, interconnections, practical implications, and a conclusion that synthesises key insights and suggests future research directions.

Conceptual Frameworks

The article will first define and elaborate on the conceptual frameworks of ethics, aesthetics, and hope. Ethics will be discussed in terms of its guiding principles, such as deontological ethics, consequentialism, and virtue ethics. Aesthetics will be explored through various theories, including formalism, expressionism, and aesthetic relativism. Hope will be examined from psychological and philosophical perspectives, highlighting its role in motivation, resilience, and existential meaning.

Historical Context and Philosophical Foundations

The historical context will delve into the philosophical traditions that have addressed the intersections of these concepts. The ancient Greek philosophers Plato and Aristotle laid foundational ideas by linking beauty with goodness and virtue. In the modern era, Kant's critical philosophy provided a systematic exploration of how aesthetic judgments could influence moral sensibility. Existentialists like Kierkegaard and Nietzsche brought new dimensions to the discussion, focusing on individual choice, authenticity, and the role of hope in human life.

Interconnections between Ethics, Aesthetics, and Hope

This section will explore the nuanced interconnections between the three concepts. The ethical dimension of aesthetics will be discussed, illustrating how aesthetic experiences can shape ethical perspectives. For example,

art can evoke empathy, compassion, and a sense of justice, which are core ethical values. Conversely, the aesthetic dimension of ethics will be examined, showing how ethical actions and principles can be understood and appreciated through an aesthetic lens. The role of moral beauty and the aesthetics of character and behaviour will be highlighted. The section will also discuss how hope inspires ethical behaviour and aesthetic appreciation, demonstrating the interplay between hope, ethical striving, and aesthetic creation.

Practical Implications and Applications

The practical implications of integrating ethics, aesthetics, and hope are vast and can be applied in several key areas of human life. In education, weaving these concepts into curricula and practices can significantly enhance the holistic development of students. This integration encourages students to grow not only intellectually but also morally and emotionally, nurturing a sense of responsibility, an appreciation for beauty, and a hopeful outlook on life. Successful examples of such educational approaches demonstrate how this blend fosters a deeper engagement with learning and a more meaningful connection to personal values and societal contributions.

In the realm of organisational leadership and community development, applying these principles can transform leadership styles, organisational culture, and community engagement. Ethical leadership, when combined with an appreciation for aesthetics and a hopeful vision for the future, creates environments where individuals feel valued, inspired, and connected. Organisations that embody these ideals often see enhanced collaboration, trust, and commitment within their teams and in their broader communities. Case studies of companies and communities that have successfully implemented these principles show how they can lead to more sustainable and compassionate outcomes.

On a personal level, the cultivation of ethical sensibility, aesthetic appreciation, and hope offers profound benefits for individual growth and well-being. By integrating strategies such as reflective practices, engagement with the arts, and goal-setting, individuals can foster a more mindful, morally conscious, and optimistic approach to life. Practical exercises, such as journaling or engaging with nature, serve as ways to nurture these qualities, contributing to personal development and fulfillment.

This section will synthesise the insights discussed throughout the article, highlighting the importance of integrating ethics, aesthetics, and hope in both personal and societal contexts. Additionally, it will suggest future research directions to further explore how these interconnections can be applied to improve individual lives and social structures, contributing to a more compassionate and aesthetically enriched society.

1. The Conceptual Framework of Ethics

1.1. Definition and Scope

Ethics, derived from the Greek word *ethos*, pertains to the moral principles that guide an individual's behaviour or the conduct of activities. As a philosophical discipline, ethics seeks to address core questions about what constitutes right and wrong, good and evil. It provides a comprehensive worldview, or *Weltanschauung*, that assists both individuals and societies in determining moral values and duties, thus playing an essential role in shaping moral decision-making and the foundational norms governing communal life.

The importance of ethics in guiding human behaviour cannot be overstated. It establishes the framework for making decisions that are not only legally compliant but also morally sound. Through this lens, ethics becomes the bedrock upon which societal norms are built, influencing how individuals interact within their communities. Several ethical theories and frameworks provide distinct approaches to moral issues, each offering insights into how one might resolve ethical dilemmas.

One prominent school of thought is *deontological ethics*, primarily developed by Immanuel Kant. Deontological ethics posits that the morality of an action depends on adherence to rules or duties, rather than on the consequences of the action. Kant asserted that moral actions are those performed out of duty, independent of personal desires or outcomes, and must conform to universal moral laws. Central to his philosophy is the *categorical imperative*, which mandates that one should act according to principles that could be universally applied as moral laws.[5] This framework emphasises the intrinsic value of duty and rules, suggesting that certain actions are morally obligatory regardless of their results. For instance, Kant argued that telling the truth is a moral obligation, even if it may lead to negative consequences.

In contrast, utilitarianism evaluates morality based on the outcomes or consequences of actions. This theory suggests that an action is morally right if it leads to the best overall result, often defined as the greatest happiness for the greatest number of people. Utilitarianism, as advocated by Jeremy Bentham and John Stuart Mill, emphasises maximising pleasure and minimising pain as the criteria for moral decision-making (Mill, 2002). In this view, the ends justify the means, and actions are judged primarily on their capacity to produce favourable outcomes. For example, a utilitarian might argue that sacrificing the welfare of a few individuals for the benefit

5 Immanuel Kant, *Critique of Practical Reason* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1997).

of the majority is morally acceptable if it increases the overall well-being of society.

A third major ethical perspective is *virtue ethics*, which is rooted in the philosophy of Aristotle. Unlike deontology and consequentialism, virtue ethics focuses on the character of the moral agent rather than on specific rules or consequences. Aristotle believed that living a morally good life involves cultivating virtues, such as courage, temperance, and wisdom, which enable individuals to achieve *eudaimonia*, or human flourishing.[6] Rather than prescribing specific actions, virtue ethics emphasises moral character and the habitual practice of virtues as the path to ethical living. Aristotle argued that virtues are developed through experience and practice and that the virtuous person acts in a way that is balanced and appropriate to the circumstances, achieving a "golden mean" between extremes.

These three schools—deontological ethics, consequentialism, and virtue ethics—provide distinct approaches to moral reasoning, each with its strengths and challenges. Kantian deontology offers a principled, rule-based approach to ethics, ensuring that actions are judged based on their adherence to universal laws, rather than subjective preferences. Consequentialism, especially in its utilitarian form, provides a flexible framework for evaluating actions based on their outcomes, emphasising the practical benefits of ethical decisions. Meanwhile, virtue ethics enriches the moral discourse by focusing on the cultivation of good character, reminding us that ethical living involves not just following rules or achieving good outcomes, but becoming morally excellent individuals. Together, these frameworks offer a rich array of tools for navigating the complexities of moral life, helping individuals and societies make thoughtful, ethical decisions.

Thus, ethics provides the moral compass that guides human behaviour and societal norms. By understanding and applying different ethical theories and frameworks, individuals and organisations can navigate complex moral landscapes and make decisions that uphold justice, integrity, and the common good. As the proverb "A stitch in time saves nine" aptly suggests, timely and ethical actions can prevent more significant problems in the future, underscoring the enduring relevance of ethical principles in all aspects of life.

2. The Conceptual Framework of Aesthetics

Aesthetics, derived from the Greek word *aisthesis*, refers to the philosophical study of beauty, art, and taste, as well as the processes involved in the creation and appreciation of beauty. As a branch of philosophy, aesthetics explores the nature of artistic expression and aesthetic experience, focusing

6 Aristotle, *Nicomachean Ethics*.

on fundamental questions such as what constitutes beauty and how it influences human emotions and perceptions. Aesthetics plays a central role in human experience by offering a framework to understand and appreciate the sensory and emotional aspects of life, enriching our interaction with the world through art and beauty.

The field of aesthetics is supported by several theories and frameworks, each providing a unique perspective on the nature of beauty and artistic expression. One such theory is *formalism*, which asserts that the value of art lies primarily in its form—its composition, structure, and use of visual elements—rather than in its content or context. Proponents of formalism, such as Clive Bell, argue that aesthetic appreciation stems from the perception of "significant form," a quality that evokes aesthetic emotion in the viewer.[7] According to formalism, the harmonious arrangement of visual elements, such as shape, colour, and composition, forms the basis of beauty, independent of any narrative or symbolic meaning the artwork may carry.

In contrast, *expressionism* focuses on the role of art in conveying the emotions, thoughts, and experiences of the artist. Expressionists believe that the primary function of art is to communicate the inner states of the creator, establishing an emotional connection with the audience. Works by artists like Vincent van Gogh, celebrated for their vibrant colours and intense emotional depth, exemplify this approach. Suzanne Langer, a key figure in the development of expressionist aesthetics, highlighted the significance of emotional expression in art, asserting that the power of art lies in its ability to externalise and evoke emotions. Expressionism thus emphasises the subjective and emotional dimensions of art, viewing the creative process as a means of personal expression and emotional release.

Aesthetic relativism offers a different perspective, arguing that aesthetic judgments are inherently subjective and culturally contingent. According to this view, what is considered beautiful or aesthetically pleasing can vary widely across different cultures, historical periods, and individual preferences. Aesthetic relativism challenges the notion of universal standards of beauty, instead highlighting the diversity and multiplicity of aesthetic experiences. Arthur Danto, a proponent of this view, suggested that the appreciation of art and beauty is shaped by cultural and historical contexts, and that aesthetic value is not an objective quality but a reflection of individual and societal perspectives.[8] This approach encourages a more inclusive and pluralistic understanding of beauty, recognising that aesthetic values are shaped by diverse cultural narratives and personal experiences.

7 Clive Bell, *Art* (New York: Capricorn Books, 1958).

8 Arthur Danto, *The Transfiguration of the Commonplace: A Philosophy of Art* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1981).

These varied perspectives within aesthetics—formalism, expressionism, and relativism—demonstrate the complexity of understanding beauty and art. Each framework offers valuable insights into how we engage with artistic expression and aesthetic experience, enriching our understanding of the profound role aesthetics plays in shaping human perception and emotion. Through these theories, we gain a deeper appreciation of the diverse ways in which beauty and art influence our lives, both on an individual and cultural level.

In this manner, aesthetics is a vital dimension of human experience, shaping our perceptions, emotions, and cultural expressions. By understanding and applying different aesthetic theories and principles, we can enrich our lives and foster a deeper appreciation of the world around us. As the proverb "Beauty is in the eye of the beholder" suggests, aesthetic appreciation is inherently subjective, reflecting the diverse and multifaceted nature of human experience.

The Conceptual Framework of Hope

Hope is a multifaceted experience analysed through psychological and philosophical perspectives. Psychologically, hope functions as a motivator, helping individuals overcome obstacles through agency (goal pursuit) and pathways (strategic planning), as outlined by Snyder et.al.[9] It acts as psychological fuel, fostering resilience and perseverance in adversity. Philosophically, thinkers like Kierkegaard and Marcel view hope as essential to the human condition. Kierkegaard sees it as existential courage that confronts uncertainty, while Marcel distinguishes between superficial expectation and genuine hope, linking it to faith and meaning. Hope also fosters resilience, enabling individuals and communities to navigate hardship with optimism and determination. It serves as a catalyst for personal growth and social solidarity, inspiring collective action toward a just and compassionate society. By cultivating hope, individuals and communities build resilience, maintain purpose, and strive for a better future.

3. Interconnections between Ethics, Aesthetics, and Hope

a. The Ethical Dimension of Aesthetics

Aesthetic experiences are not merely about the appreciation of beauty but can profoundly shape and inform ethical perspectives. The intersection of ethics and aesthetics invites a deeper exploration of how encounters with art and beauty can inspire moral reflection and action.

9 C. R. Snyder et al., "Hope Theory, Measurements, and Applications to School Psychology," *School Psychology Quarterly* 17, no. 2 (2002): 122–139.

Aesthetic experiences, whether through visual arts, music, literature, or nature, have the capacity to evoke deep emotional responses. These responses can lead to a heightened awareness of ethical issues and a greater sensitivity to the moral dimensions of human experience. For instance, the portrayal of suffering in works like Pablo Picasso's *Guernica* or the harrowing scenes in Tolstoy's *War and Peace* can evoke empathy and compassion, prompting viewers and readers to consider the moral implications of war and violence.[10] Such experiences can challenge individuals to reflect on their own values and behaviours, fostering a more profound commitment to ethical principles.

The role of beauty and artistic expression in fostering ethical reflection is significant. Beauty, in its myriad forms, has the potential to reveal truths about the human condition and the world we inhabit. As Plato posited, the contemplation of beauty can lead to the recognition of the good, as the two are intrinsically linked in the realm of ideals.[11] This Platonic view suggests that aesthetic experiences can serve as a bridge to ethical understanding, guiding individuals towards a greater appreciation of moral virtues.

Artistic expression often grapples with complex ethical themes, providing a medium through which these themes can be explored and communicated. The works of William Shakespeare, for example, are replete with ethical dilemmas and moral quandaries. In plays such as *Hamlet* and *Macbeth*, Shakespeare delves into issues of justice, guilt, and retribution, compelling audiences to engage with these ethical questions on a deeper level.[12] Through such artistic engagements, individuals are encouraged to reflect on their own ethical beliefs and the broader implications of their actions.

Moreover, aesthetic experiences can foster a sense of communal identity and shared values, which are essential for ethical living. The German concept of *Gemeinschaft*, referring to a sense of community and social cohesion, underscores the role of shared aesthetic values in building ethical societies. Public art, community theatre, and cultural festivals can serve as loci for communal reflection and dialogue, reinforcing ethical norms and fostering collective action towards common goals.

Aesthetic appreciation also promotes mindfulness and presence, qualities that are integral to ethical living. The practice of mindfulness, rooted in traditions such as Buddhism, emphasises the importance of being fully present and aware in each moment. This heightened awareness can enhance one's sensitivity to the ethical dimensions of everyday actions and

10 Leo Tolstoy, *War and Peace* (Moscow: The Russian Messenger, 1869).

11 Plato, *The Republic*.

12 William Shakespeare, *Hamlet* (London: Nicholas Ling, 1603); William Shakespeare, *Macbeth* (London: John Heminge and Henry Condell, 1606).

interactions.[13] By engaging deeply with aesthetic experiences, individuals can cultivate a more mindful approach to life, leading to more thoughtful and ethically grounded behaviour.

Consider the proverb "Beauty is in the eye of the beholder." This adage highlights the subjective nature of aesthetic experience, yet it also points to the potential for beauty to evoke a shared sense of wonder and appreciation. In recognising and valuing the beauty around us, we can develop a greater respect for the world and its inhabitants, fostering a more ethical and compassionate outlook.

The ethical dimension of aesthetics, therefore, encompasses the ways in which aesthetic experiences can shape and inform our moral perspectives. Through the contemplation of beauty and engagement with artistic expression, individuals are inspired to reflect on ethical issues, develop a deeper sense of empathy and compassion, and foster communal bonds that underpin ethical living. These interconnections between aesthetics and ethics highlight the profound impact that beauty and art can have on our moral development and the cultivation of a just and compassionate society.

b. The Aesthetic Dimension of Ethics

The intersection of ethics and aesthetics reveals how moral actions and virtues can be appreciated for their inherent beauty. Ethical behaviour embodies aesthetic qualities such as symmetry, harmony, and integrity, as seen in Aristotle's concept of *kalon*—the noble and beautiful. Virtue ethics, rooted in Aristotelian thought, highlights the grace and excellence (*arete*) of good character, which, like art, inspires admiration.

Moral beauty, explored by Iris Murdoch,[14] suggests that goodness captivates much like art, motivating ethical aspirations. Literary figures like Atticus Finch exemplify this aesthetic dimension of ethics, where dignity and justice evoke admiration. Gestalt psychology further illustrates how individual moral actions coalesce into a harmonious ethical life, much like an artist composing a masterpiece.

The aesthetic appeal of moral behaviour is powerful in inspiring others—actions of kindness, justice, and courage move people beyond words. Recognising the beauty in virtue enriches moral understanding and encourages ethical living as both a good and beautiful pursuit.

13 Jon Kabat-Zinn, "Mindfulness-Based Interventions in Context: Past, Present, and Future," *Clinical Psychology: Science and Practice* 10, no. 2 (2003): 144–156.

14 Iris Murdoch, *The Sovereignty of Good* (London: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1970).

c. The Role of Hope in Ethics and Aesthetics

Hope, a pivotal aspect of human existence, plays a significant role in both ethical behaviour and aesthetic appreciation. It is the *Leitmotif* that weaves through our aspirations and actions, inspiring individuals to strive for a better future and find beauty even in the most challenging circumstances. The interplay between hope, ethical striving, and aesthetic creation is profound, revealing how hope can elevate both our moral and aesthetic experiences.

Hope can serve as a powerful motivator for ethical behaviour. It provides individuals with the resilience to pursue moral ideals, even when faced with adversity. The philosopher Gabriel Marcel, in his exploration of hope, distinguishes between mere optimism and authentic hope, emphasising that true hope is rooted in an unwavering belief in the potential for goodness.[15] This belief can inspire individuals to act ethically, fostering a sense of *Dharma*—duty or righteousness—that guides their actions towards the common good.

Ethical leaders, inspired by hope, can galvanise communities and societies towards justice and compassion. The life of Mahatma Gandhi exemplifies this. His steadfast hope for an independent and just India drove his commitment to non-violent resistance, embodying ethical principles that resonated globally. Gandhi's hope was not passive but active and transformative, inspiring countless individuals to adopt similar ethical stances.[16]

In the realm of aesthetics, hope is equally influential. It enables individuals to perceive beauty amidst difficulties, fostering an appreciation for art and nature that transcends mere appearances. The German concept of *Weltschmerz*, which denotes a deep sadness at the world's imperfections, can be counterbalanced by hope, allowing individuals to find solace and beauty even in imperfection. This hopeful perspective can transform our aesthetic experiences, enabling us to see the potential for beauty and harmony in the world around us.

The interplay between hope and aesthetic creation is evident in the works of many artists who have drawn inspiration from hopeful visions of the future. Vincent van Gogh's paintings, for instance, are imbued with a sense of hope despite his personal struggles. His vibrant use of colour and dynamic compositions reflect a hopeful vision of the world's beauty, capturing the essence of hope as a driving force in artistic creation.[17]

15 Gabriel Marcel, *Homo Viator: Introduction to a Metaphysic of Hope* (New York: Harper & Row, 1962).

16 Mahatma Gandhi, *The Story of My Experiments with Truth* (New York: Penguin Books, 2009).

17 Vincent van Gogh, *The Starry Night*, The Museum of Modern Art, New York, 1889.

Furthermore, hope can inspire a commitment to *Ahimsa*—non-violence and respect for all living beings—which is both an ethical principle and an aesthetic ideal. The integration of these values is evident in the environmental movement, where hope for a sustainable future drives efforts to protect and preserve the natural world. The aesthetics of sustainability, seen in practices like green architecture and conservation art, embody this synergy between hope, ethics, and aesthetics, highlighting the beauty of living in harmony with nature.

The proverb "Every cloud has a silver lining" aptly captures the essence of hope in both ethics and aesthetics. It reminds us that even in the darkest times, there is potential for goodness and beauty. This hopeful outlook encourages ethical striving as individuals work towards creating a better world and enriches aesthetic appreciation as they find beauty in the process of overcoming challenges.

The role of hope in ethics and aesthetics underscores the interdependence of these domains. Hope not only inspires ethical behaviour by providing a vision of a better future but also enhances aesthetic appreciation by allowing us to see beauty in all aspects of life. This interplay enriches our human experience, fostering a sense of purpose and connection that is both morally and aesthetically fulfilling.

4. Practical Implications and Applications

a. Ethics, Aesthetics, and Hope in Organisational and Community Life

Incorporating ethics, aesthetics, and hope into organisational leadership and community development can lead to more compassionate and effective institutions. Ethical leadership, which focuses on integrity, fairness, and social responsibility, is essential for building trust and fostering cooperation within organisations. Leaders who embrace these principles can inspire their teams, cultivating a positive and constructive organisational culture.

One prominent example is the leadership approach at Patagonia, an outdoor clothing company known for its commitment to environmental sustainability and ethical business practices. Patagonia's initiatives, such as the "1% for the Planet" pledge, underscore its dedication to ethical values. This approach has helped build a loyal customer base and a strong organisational identity.[18] Aesthetics in organisational life involves crafting workspaces that are not only functional but also visually and emotionally pleasing. The German concept of *Gemütlichkeit*, which conveys warmth and comfort, can be applied in organisational settings to boost employee

18 Yvon Chouinard, *Let My People Go Surfing: The Education of a Reluctant Businessman* (New York: Penguin, 2005).

well-being and productivity. Companies like Google have embraced this by designing aesthetically pleasing and comfortable workspaces that encourage creativity and collaboration.[19]

Hope is crucial in driving community development and social change. Community leaders who present a hopeful vision for the future can inspire collective action. The Civil Rights Movement in the United States, led by figures like Martin Luther King Jr., illustrates how hope can serve as a powerful force for social transformation. King's vision of a just and equitable society galvanised a generation to work towards civil rights and social justice.[20]

b. Ethics, Aesthetics, and Hope in Personal Development

On a personal level, cultivating a sense of ethics, aesthetic appreciation, and hope can lead to a more meaningful and fulfilling life. Developing ethical sensibility involves becoming attuned to moral principles and committing to ethical behaviour. Reflective practices such as journaling or meditation can help individuals enhance their self-awareness and moral clarity, leading to a more ethical life.[21] Aesthetic appreciation can be fostered through engagement with the arts and nature. Activities like visiting art galleries, listening to music, or spending time in nature enhance one's aesthetic experiences, contributing to overall well-being. The Japanese concept of *Shinrin-yoku*, or forest bathing, highlights the therapeutic benefits of immersing oneself in nature's beauty.[22] Hope can be nurtured through goal-setting and positive thinking. Establishing realistic, meaningful goals offers a sense of purpose, while positive thinking helps sustain optimism and resilience. Techniques from positive psychology, such as gratitude journaling and visualisation, have been shown to foster a hopeful outlook.[23]

These practices—developing ethical sensibility, enhancing aesthetic appreciation, and cultivating hope—demonstrate how individuals can integrate these values into daily life. The proverb "Hope for the best, but prepare for the worst" captures the balance between maintaining a hopeful outlook and taking practical steps to face life's challenges. By embracing this

19 Susan Hamen, *Google: A Great Workplace* (Minneapolis, MN: ABDO Publishing, 2010).

20 Taylor Branch, *Parting the Waters: America in the King Years 1954–63* (New York: Simon & Schuster, 1988).

21 Robert J. Nash, *"Real World" Ethics: Frameworks for Educators and Human Service Professionals* (New York: Teachers College Press, 2002).

22 Qing Li, *Forest Bathing: How Trees Can Help You Find Health and Happiness* (New York: Viking, 2018).

23 Martin E. P. Seligman, *Flourish: A Visionary New Understanding of Happiness and Well-being* (New York: Free Press, 2011).

balance, individuals can lead lives that are ethically grounded, aesthetically enriched, and filled with hope. Thus, ethics and aesthetics can enable a holistic human life and lead to collective human flourishing.

Conclusion

Our exploration of ethics, aesthetics, and hope reveals the intricate connections between these fundamental aspects of human experience. Ethics, as the study of moral principles, provides the framework for determining right and wrong actions and fostering a just society. Aesthetics, the appreciation of beauty and artistic expression, enriches our sensory and emotional lives, offering profound insights into the human condition. Hope, an essential psychological and existential state, inspires resilience and motivation, driving individuals and communities towards a better future.

Philosophers like Immanuel Kant have long discussed the interplay between moral and aesthetic judgments, underscoring their interconnectedness.[24] Recent studies in positive psychology also highlight how hope can drive ethical behaviour and enhance aesthetic appreciation.[25] The article has discussed how aesthetic experiences can shape ethical perspectives, with art and beauty evoking empathy, compassion, and a sense of justice, which are core ethical values. Literature, music, and visual arts have historically played significant roles in ethical movements and social change, illustrating the ethical dimension of aesthetic experience.[26] Additionally, the aesthetic dimension of ethics has been examined, showing that ethical behaviour can be perceived as morally beautiful, and actions aligning with moral virtues often carry an aesthetic quality. The concept of 'moral beauty' highlights how individuals are drawn to ethical actions that are also aesthetically pleasing.

The role of hope in fostering ethics and aesthetics has also been explored. Hope serves as a driving force that inspires individuals to strive for ethical ideals and engage in creative, aesthetic endeavours. The synergy between hope and these domains can lead to transformative personal and societal changes.[27] Practical implications and applications in education, organisational and community life, and personal development have been outlined. Incorporating these concepts into education can foster holistic development in students, preparing them for ethical and aesthetically rich

24 Immanuel Kant, *Critique of Practical Reason* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1997).

25 Seligman, *Flourish*.

26 Murdoch, *The Sovereignty of Good*.

27 Gabriel Marcel, *Homo Viator: Introduction to a Metaphysic of Hope* (New York: Harper & Row, 1962).

lives. Organisations and communities can benefit from integrating these principles to enhance leadership, culture, and social cohesion.[28] The writings of philosophers such as Søren Kierkegaard and theologians like Jürgen Moltmann provide deep insights into the interrelations between ethics, aesthetics, and hope. The concept of 'theodicy' explores how hope and beauty can be reconciled with ethical considerations in the face of suffering and evil.[29]

28 James Arthur, Kristján Kristjánsson, David Walker, Wouter Sanderse, and Carol Jones, *Teaching Character and Virtue in Schools* (New York: Routledge, 2017).

29 Søren Kierkegaard, *Fear and Trembling* (London: Penguin Classics, 1985) and Jürgen Moltmann, *In the End—the Beginning: The Life of Hope* (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 2004).

Ecological Hope in Crisis
Reimagining Integral Ecology Through *Laudato Si'*

Sunil Jose Mattappallil

Abstract

This article examines the paradigm shift toward "integral ecology" inspired by Pope Francis's encyclical Laudato Si'. It critiques the dominant technocratic and anthropocentric worldview, highlighting their limitations in addressing ecological and social crises. Drawing from both theological and philosophical sources, including critiques of Cartesian dualism, the article emphasizes the interconnectedness of all creation and urges a holistic approach to ecological issues—one that integrates ethical, social, and spiritual dimensions. The author underscores Laudato Si' as a call not only for environmental action but for a fundamental renewal of human relationships with each other and with nature. The article concludes by affirming the profound hope offered by integral ecology, advocating for justice, sustainability, and a shared commitment to the common good.

Keywords: *Anthropocentrism, Cartesian Dualism, Catholic Social Teaching, Ecological Crisis, Integral Ecology,*

Interconnectedness, Laudato Si', Paradigm Shift, Sustainability, Technocratic Paradigm.

Introduction

The contemporary ecological crisis is marked by profound environmental degradation, including pollution, climate change, and biodiversity loss. This situation necessitates a critical assessment of current societal structures and practices that contribute to these challenges. In particular, the image of a better world envisioned by many advocates for environmental change is often juxtaposed against the backdrop of today's deteriorating order, which they seek to replace with a more sustainable and equitable framework.[1] This juxtaposition is essential for understanding the motivations behind various ecological movements and the urgency to act.

Integral ecology has emerged as a significant paradigm in ecological theory and practice. It aims to transcend disciplinary boundaries, integrating insights from the humanities, social sciences, and biophysical sciences to address the complex interrelationships among nature, culture, and consciousness.[2] This multifaceted approach is especially relevant in the context of the encyclical *Laudato Si'* by Pope Francis, which articulates a holistic vision of human ecology that emphasizes the interconnectedness of environmental and social issues.

While the Church—through different documents and in the various interventions of the different Popes and in numerous forums—has always shown concern for an appropriate understanding and response to the ecological crisis, *Laudato Si'*, as a document with its subtext, 'care of our common home,' ushers in a paradigm shift by the sheer breadth and scope of its insight and call to action towards acquiring an integral ecology. This document challenges the prevailing technocratic and anthropocentric viewpoints, advocating for a more holistic approach to planetary issues beyond environmental concerns. It encourages a holistic perspective, reminding the world that this planet is our shared home. *Laudato Si'* signifies the start of a different approach in Catholic social teachings, moving away from technocratic and anthropocentric views to embrace an integral ecology paradigm that emphasizes interconnectedness and the earth as a home.

1 Mathias Thaler, "Eco-Miserabilism and Radical Hope: On the Utopian Vision of Post-Apocalyptic Environmentalism," *American Political Science Review* 118, no. 1 (2024): 318–31.

2 Giacomo Costa, "Everything is Connected": Integral Ecology in *Laudato Si'*, *Aggiornamenti Sociali*, 6.

1. *Laudato Si'* and the Elements of the New Paradigm

Catholic social teaching signals a distinct moral imperative to review these inequalities.[3] What makes Pope Francis's *Laudato Si'* stand out, making it a paradigm shift, is that while it vigorously maintains this traditional focus, it likewise reaches beyond it. This is what makes *Laudato Si'* the most substantial enhancement to the corpus of social teaching since *Rerum Novarum.* In essence, this encyclical proposes our obligations extend across time and space, encompassing all of creation. *Laudato Si'* therefore advances a fuller view of solidarity—solidarity not merely within generations but also between generations, and solidarity not simply with our fellow human beings but also with the whole Earth and all its creatures.[4]

This fuller conception of solidarity is not an innovation, but *Laudato Si'* brings it right to the core of the church's social teaching, and one ramification of this is that all creatures have intrinsic value, and all have their own purpose, apart from their usefulness to us. Of course, such a perspective has extensive implications for human attitude and life, that is, they [plants and animals] are not just meat and vegetables. Whenever one of these relationships is fractured, the others are broken too. This is the concept of integral ecology. It is the key message of the encyclical, and it is not simply a theological message; it again has significant overtones for politics and policy.[5] To quote Pope Francis, "Obstructionist attitudes, even on the part of believers, can range from denial of the problem to indifference, nonchalant resignation or blind confidence in technical solutions. We require a new and universal solidarity."[6] As a church document, completely dedicated to integral ecology; calling for a new and universal solidarity; critiquing the current paradigms; calling earth our common home; highlighting the fact that everything is interrelated and interdependent and coming from the pope himself is nothing but a paradigm shift for the catholic church. With this general framework and thrust of *Laudato Si'*, we further examine the paradigms it critiques.

2. The Dominant Technocratic Paradigm—"an Undifferentiated and One-dimensional Paradigm"

Scientific expertise and the fiscal means to exploit them, what Pope Francis notes as "the dominant technocratic paradigm," have caused those few who

3 Cf. Anthony Annett, "The Next Step: How Laudato Si' Extends Catholic Social Teaching," *Commonweal* 142, no. 11 (2015): 19–21.

4 Annett, "The Next Step," 19–21.

5 Cf. Annett, "The Next Step," 19–21.

6 Cf. Francis, Encyclical Letter *Laudato Si'* (24 May 2015), 3: *Acta Apostolicae Sedis* 107, 9 (2015): 852.

own them "an impressive dominance over the whole of humanity and the entire world" (LS 104). He marks out the compromises generated by this privilege being enjoyed by such a minor ratio of humankind and that the enormous influence contemporary technology has provided us, has not been balanced by an advance in human responsibility, values, and conscience. Pope Francis holds that we do not have an ethics, culture, or spirituality capable of setting limits—limits that we are not even conscious of, or are averse to admit and he quotes Romano Guardini as he states: "power is never considered in terms of responsibility of choice"[7] and in *Laudate Deum* he says, "In whose hands does all this power lie, or will eventually end up? It is extremely risky for a small part of humanity to have it," and again, "We stand naked and exposed in the face of our ever-increasing power, lacking the wherewithal to control it. We have certain superficial mechanisms, but we cannot claim to have sound ethics, a culture and spirituality genuinely capable of setting limits and teaching clear-minded self-restraint" (LD 23-24). Authors like Rob Dyball and B. Newell[8] and David Korten,[9] also speak of the ecological and social perils of the "paradigm of limitless growth" and the narrative of "sacred money and markets."[10]

Pope Francis condemns the reductionist paradigm that worships technology resulting in the "deterioration of the environment" (LS 107) and indicates that by applying this "undifferentiated and one-dimensional paradigm" we neglect reality while extracting everything we can "based on the lie that there is an infinite supply of the earth's goods, and this leads to the planet being squeezed dry beyond every limit" (LS 106). He underlines the evidence that there are obviously not unending quantities of resources nor energy accessible and that the negative effects of extraction and use cannot simply be incorporated by natural systems. Additionally, "technological products are not neutral, for they create a framework which ends up conditioning lifestyles and shaping social possibilities along the lines dictated by the interests of certain powerful groups" (LS 107). That is, the preferences for society are weakened because of the dictates of technology. A "technology severed from ethics will not easily be able to limit its own power" (LS 136). He condemns that we are cornered in a scheme in which it is tolerable, indeed demanded, that technology will

7 Romano Guardini, *The End of the Modern World* (Wilmington: ISI Books, 1998), 82.

8 *See* Robert Dyball and Barry Newell, *Understanding Human Ecology: A Systems Approach to Sustainability* (New York, NY: Routledge, 2015).

9 *See* David C. Korten, *Change the Story, Change the Future: A Living Economy for a Living Earth* (Oakland: Berrett-Koehler Publishers, 2015).

10 Robin van Tine, "Reflections, Analysis, and Significance for Human Ecology of Pope Francis's Encyclical Letter *Laudato Si'*: On Care for Our Common Home," *Human Ecology Review* 23, no. 1 (2017): 156.

define lives and decide sociological norms "as dictated by the interests" of a narrow dominant group. We have turned into captives to the influences of technology. "The idea of promoting a different cultural paradigm and employing technology as a mere instrument is nowadays inconceivable […]. It has become countercultural to choose a lifestyle whose goals are even partly independent of technology, of its costs and its power to globalize and make us all the same" (LS 108). He maintains that profit, and finance for profit, encourages politics and every other facet of our technological world, with bare or no thought for the jolts on human beings or the rest of nature. "The economy accepts every advance in technology with a view to profit, without concern for its potentially negative impact on human beings" (LS 109). The deception of irrational conviction in impending technological fixes is thoroughly part of the paradigm of limitless growth.[11]

Pope Francis appeals for an alternative world view—in fact, for an alternative paradigm, given the anomalies of the dominant technocratic paradigm—containing fresh means of perceiving and understanding, new strategies, further relevant education, a different "lifestyle and a spirituality which together generate resistance to the assault of the technocratic paradigm" (LS 111). He advocates a comprehensive and systematic approach to fixing our profound human-ecological dilemmas. "To seek only a technical remedy to each environmental problem which comes up is to separate what is in reality interconnected and to mask the true and deepest problems of the global system" (LS 111). In principle, Pope Francis is signalling and hoping for an earthy spirituality plus a wider range of human ecology and environmental studies:[12] "A science which would offer solutions to the great issues would necessarily have to take into account the data generated by other fields of knowledge, including philosophy and social ethics" (LS 107). "There is a rising awareness that scientific and technological progress cannot be equated with the progress of humanity and history" (LS 107).

Pope Francis continues to appeal for a paradigm shift from a state of life permeated with the superficiality of continually evolving technological toys to one filled with wondering about "the purpose and meaning of everything" (LS 113), and proposes that there is:

> [an] urgent need for us to move forward in a bold cultural revolution […] Nobody is suggesting a return to the Stone Age, but we do need to slow down and look at reality in a different

11 Cf. Tine, "Reflections, Analysis, and Significance for Human Ecology of Pope Francis's Encyclical Letter *Laudato Si'*," 157.

12 Cf. Tine, "Reflections, Analysis, and Significance for Human Ecology of Pope Francis's Encyclical Letter *Laudato Si'*," 158.

> way, to appropriate the positive and sustainable progress which has been made, but also to recover the values and the great goals swept away by our unrestrained delusions of grandeur (LS 114).

If a just society along these lines is to emerge, if the common home we all share is to be saved and renewed for this and future generations, then our basic guiding paradigm, must change from the current dominant 'technocratic paradigm', contends Pope Francis (LS 101). He is cautiously appreciative to note that yes there have been positive outcomes of technology in history, for example, "when technology is directed primarily to resolving people's concrete problems, truly helping them live with more dignity and less suffering" (LS 111). In the same breath, he however alerts us to the fact that "science and technology are not neutral" and that people should resist being controlled by technology and lose sight of the bigger picture.

3. Crisis of Anthropocentrism

Having dealt with the problematic dominant technocratic paradigms, Pope Francis delves deeper in search of the roots of this problematic paradigm, and he discovers it in modern anthropocentrism. Pope Francis rightly claims that we presently suffer from an "excessive anthropocentrism" (LS 116). He asserts that "the time has come to pay renewed attention to reality and the limits it imposes" (LS 116). He concedes that Christianity has misconstrued the relation between humans and the world, believing in a Promethean vision of mastery over the world, which gave the impression that the protection of nature was something that only the faint-hearted cared about. Instead, our 'dominion' over the universe should be understood more properly in the sense of responsible stewardship (LS 116).

"Once the human being declares independence from reality and behaves with absolute dominion, the very foundations of our life begin to crumble" (LS 117). This is a remarkable reframing of the view of dominion, one which embodies the sensibilities of physics, chemistry, and ecological limits into an effective stewardship. However, he does caution against biocentrism, defining it as just as imbalanced as anthropocentrism. Most experts would disagree and lean towards biocentrism or ecocentrism as the most objective viewpoint. Human ecologists would undoubtedly include humans firmly within that biocentric, ecocentric, but non-anthropocentric perspective. Critics of Christianity have repeatedly pointed out its anthropocentric bias, so it is interesting that Pope Francis takes the much more nuanced position of rejecting anthropocentrism and concentrating on a wider analysis of "dominion." He goes on, however, to reiterate that Christian thought holds human beings above all other creatures, each human being innately worthy of esteem, and therefore requiring that all persons must have regard for all

others, while respecting all being in creation.[13] For example, "we are called to recognize that other living beings have a value of their own" (LS 69), and "we are called to respect creation" (LS 69), and "Man must therefore respect the particular goodness of every creature" (LS 69).

Pope Francis maintains that the ecological emergency is a "sign of the ethical, cultural and spiritual crisis of modernity," and moves on to point out that "we cannot presume to heal our relationship with nature and the environment without healing all fundamental human relationships" (LS 119). So, he considers our environmental crisis as part of a wider human-ecological crisis, as did Pope Benedict XVI before him. "The external deserts in the world are growing, because the internal deserts have become so vast,"[14] and also to quote Pope Francis, "There can be no revival of our relationship with nature without a renewal of humanity itself. There can be no ecology without an adequate anthropology" (LS 118). "The great present-day problem is that the technocratic paradigm has destroyed that healthy and harmonious relationship" (LD 27).

This brings us fundamentally to the Western concept of human existence as outside nature, and a perception of nature as consisting of all, except humans, has doubtless been developed from the Cartesian view of nature as clearly discontinuous and ontologically detached from the human realm.[15] Nature has turned into, by definition—especially since Descartes—that which is situated outside of humans.[16] This has contributed to a position wherein humans are treated as human to the degree they drift aside from animal nature and the natural world.[17] It is precisely against this approach that Pope Francis articulates in *Laudato Si'* when he says, "Nature cannot be regarded as something separate from ourselves or as a mere setting in which we live. We are part of nature, included in it and thus in constant interaction with it" (LS 139).

Descartes can be considered to be the one "who first made philosophically coherent the subject/object bifurcation that was to become an

13 Cf. Tine, "Reflections, Analysis, and Significance for Human Ecology of Pope Francis's Encyclical Letter *Laudato Si'*," 159.

14 Benedict XVI, "Homily for the Solemn Inauguration of the Petrine Ministry," *Acta Apostolicae Sedis* 97 (2005): 710.

15 Cf. Joshtrom Kureethadam, *The Philosophical Roots of the Ecological Crisis: Descartes and the Modern Worldview* (Newcastle: Cambridge Scholars Publishing, 2017), 276.

16 Cf. Val Plumwood, "Nature, Self, and Gender: Feminism, Environmental Philosophy, and the Critique of Rationalism," *Hypatia* 6, no. 1 (Spring 1991), 10.

17 Cf. Kay Anderson, "Mind over Matter?" On Decentring the Human in Human Geography," *Cultural Geographies* 21, no. 1 (2014), 3–5.

essential principle of both Western philosophy and the scientific method."[18] The plan for modern physical science, as Joseph P. Fell[19] lays out clearly, was paved by Cartesian dualism and it likewise undertook to oust the mind from nature, arraying the human subject over nature considered as object, and he claims that we now have the notion of the physical world as *res extensa* and as hostile to all final causes because of what Cartesian dualism has ultimately contributed to.[20] Georges Dicker sheds further light:

> Descartes' dualism is perhaps his most important doctrine, for it had sweeping and far-ranging implications. On one hand, it helped to clear the way for modern physical science. ... A battle was taking shape between the scholastic defenders of this traditional science and the proponents of the new science of Kepler and Galileo, which denied the relevance of final causes for explaining nature. Descartes' dualism provided a powerful philosophical rationale for the newer conception, for one implication of Descartes' dualism is that all final causes are expelled from the physical universe, or *res extensa*. The only place left for final causes of the mind, or *res cogitans*. Thus, Descartes' dualism helped prepare the way for modern physics, which does not explain nature by reference to purposes.[21]

Cartesian dualism has, to a reasonable extent, contributed to an unbridgeable rift between humanity and the rest of nature, accentuating the profound discontinuity between human beings and the natural world.[22] Pope Francis underscores this when he says,

Today, the analysis of environmental problems cannot be separated from the analysis of human, family, work-related and urban contexts, nor from how individuals relate to themselves, which leads in turn to how they relate to others and the environment. There is interrelation between ecosystems and between the various spheres of social interaction, demonstrating yet again that "the whole is greater than the part" (LS 141).

Similarly, "The rift between ourselves and the cosmos," points out William Barrett, is "one troubling legacy that the seventeenth century

18 Peter Hay, *A Companion to Environmental Thought* (Edinburgh: Edinburgh University Press, 2002), 123.

19 Cf. Joseph P. Fell, "Some Thoughts on the Modern Mind," *Journal of Speculative Philosophy* 26, no. 4, (2012): 590.

20 Cf. Kureethadam, *The Philosophical Roots of the Ecological Crisis*, 276.

21 Georges Dicker, *Descartes: An Analytical and Historical Introduction* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1993), 69–70.

22 Cf. Kureethadam, *The Philosophical Roots of the Ecological Crisis*, 278.

bequeathed to us."[23] Seen from the lens of Cartesian dualism, the natural world is scaled down to the condition of a mere object, a "bare, depopulated world of matter and motion: a wasteland."[24] One can determine from the aftermaths that the natural world is lowered to *terra nullis* for human subjugation and mastery. Obviously, it has likewise precipitated the arbitrary exploitation of the latter at the hands of the former.[25] Nature turned into "a mere resource, utensil, or instrument for human and social benefit."[26] Human beings are metaphysically and altogether distinct from the natural world has advanced a combative and selfish attitude towards the natural world, and thus one may fairly allege that the Cartesian dualism basically yields the ontology for the mastery of nature.[27] Pope Francis challenges this notion.

> It cannot be emphasized enough how everything is interconnected. Time and space are not independent of one another, and not even atoms or subatomic particles can be considered in isolation. Just as the different aspects of the planet—physical, chemical and biological—are interrelated, so too living species are part of a network which we will never fully explore and understand. A good part of our genetic code is shared by many living beings. It follows that the fragmentation of knowledge and the isolation of bits of information can actually become a form of ignorance, unless they are integrated into a broader vision of reality (LS 138).

Human estrangement from nature has its ties in a preposterous assumption that the human is autonomous from nature, a notion that came from a manipulation of the creation account as found in Genesis of the Bible, later brought in by Cartesian dualism, and acquired by the Western philosophical tradition and the modern industrial paradigm, which contributes to a view of humans as apart from or "outside of" nature, frequently, as masters or external controllers of it.[28] This is marked out also by Wim Zweers: "the environmental crisis is very closely connected to the position that humankind

23 William Barrett, *Death of the Soul: From Descartes to the Computer* (New York–London: Doubleday, 1986), 11.

24 Lewis Mumford, *Technics and Civilization* (New York: Harcourt, Brace and Co., 1934), 51, cited by Charles Eisenstein, *The Ascent of Humanity: Civilization and the Human Sense of Self* (Berkeley: Evolver Editions, 2013), 145.

25 Cf. Kureethadam, *The Philosophical Roots of the Ecological Crisis*, 278.

26 Fred Dallmayr, *Return to Nature? An Ecological Counter History* (Lexington: The University Press of Kentucky, 2011), 1.

27 Cf. Kureethadam, *The Philosophical Roots of the Ecological Crisis*, 278.

28 Cf. Plumwood, "Nature, Self, and Gender," 291.

has in modern times attributed to itself within the whole of reality, that is, separation between humans and nature as a necessary condition for the possibility of controlling nature, and reduction of nature to merely utility for humans."[29]

Pope Francis underlines that "Modernity has been marked by an excessive anthropocentrism which today, under another guise, continues to stand in the way of shared understanding and of any effort to strengthen social bonds" (LS 115).

Conclusion

Philosophically, *Laudato Si'* invites us to reconsider our ethical frameworks. It challenges the dominant technocratic paradigm and anthropocentrism—the idea that humans are the centre of the universe—and instead promotes a fresh perspective that values all forms of life. This shift fosters a more compassionate and inclusive outlook, crucial for cultivating hope. A renewed sense of purpose and interconnectedness emerges from reconsidering our role in the natural world. To quote Pope Francis, "Let us stop thinking then, of human beings as autonomous, omnipotent and limitless, and begin to think of ourselves differently, in humbler but more fruitful way" (LD 68), "For when human beings claim to take God's place, they become their worst enemies" (LD 73).

Laudato Si' provides profound hope for humanity by emphasizing our interconnectedness, raising awareness, and inspiring action. This philosophy encourages a world engagement rooted in justice, sustainability, and love for our common home rather than despair. As we navigate the complexities of the present and future, let us carry forward the hope articulated in *Laudato Si'*, transforming it into tangible actions that nurture both the Earth and humanity. "Hope would have us recognize that there is always a way out, that we can always redirect our steps, that we, can always do something to solve our problems" (LS 61). Once again to quote Pope Francis from *Fratelli Tutti* and *Laudate Deum*, "Let us dream, then, as a single human family, as fellow travellers sharing the same flesh, as children of the same earth which is our common home, each of us bringing the richness of his or her beliefs and convictions, each of us with his or her own voice, brothers and sisters all."[30] "Let us sing as we go. May our struggles and our concern for this planet never take away the joy of our hope" (LS 244).

29 Will Zweers, *Participating with Nature: Outline for an Ecologization of Our World View* (Utrecht: International Books, 2000), 72.

30 Francis, *Fratelli Tutti* Encyclical Letter (03 October 2020), 8: *Acta Apostolicae Sedis* 112, 11 (2020), 971.

26

Time = Life = Hope
Reflections on Signs of Hope in Sciences

Stephen S. Jayard

Abstract

It goes without saying that time and life are experiential realities. They are so intrinsically related that one cannot compartmentalise them. When one speaks about time, one cannot but speak about life also, and vice versa. Any experiential reality is so mysterious, and even paradoxical, that it can be approached from any angle—philosophical, scientific, theological, social, spiritual, psychological, moral, and so on—yet the comprehension of it would be incomplete. Though we cannot define it, nor comprehend it totally, we cannot ignore it either, because we need to live in it, with it. This paper attempts to show how hope is also equally an experiential reality, and therefore, hope also defies any attempt to define, or to comprehend, it completely. Hope forms the very foundation of our existence, not only for human beings, but also for any creature or living organism. So, any life-form basically involves hope. Thus, it is clear that hope cannot be discussed without reflecting upon life, and life in turn, cannot be understood without referring to the concept of time. With the insights and reflections from the fields of natural and psycho sciences, and the deep convictions of a few leading scientists,

including Stephen Hawking, a celebrated cosmologist, and Paul Sudhir Arul Kalanithi, an American neurosurgeon, this paper tries to show that as long as time and life are mysterious, there will always be something to look forward to in life, by which life gets hope and meaning.

Keywords: *Hope, Life, Meaning, Mystery, Paul Kalanithi, Stephen Hawking, Time.*

Introduction

Amidst the anxieties and uncertainties of human existence in the modern world, it is very easy to feel discouraged and disheartened. With the persistent onslaught of difficulties of everyday life, hope becomes very volatile. In the midst of war and violence, corruption and exploitation, natural disasters and moral degradation, it is indeed a challenge not to lose one's hope. What George Orwell, a British novelist and poet, described about the then-world several decades ago, in his novel, *Nineteen Eighty-Four (1984),* is sadly true, perhaps truer, even today: "War is peace, Freedom is slavery, Ignorance is strength."[1]

Nevertheless, the situation is not that bad to lose one's hope and meaning in life. Some serious reflections upon a few existential elements, like time and life, can show that hope can still be revived, restored, and reestablished in the minds and hearts of the people today. One can easily agree that time and life are experiential realities. Time and life are so intrinsically related that one cannot compartmentalise them. When one speaks about time, one cannot but speak about life also, and vice versa. Any experiential reality is so mysterious, and even paradoxical, that it can be approached from any angle—philosophical, scientific, theological, social, spiritual, psychological, and so on—yet the comprehension of it would be incomplete. Though we cannot define it, nor comprehend it totally, we cannot ignore it either, because we need to live with it.

Any life-form is filled with hope; so, hope cannot be discussed without reflecting upon life, and life, in turn, cannot be understood without referring to the concept of time. The first three parts of this paper engage with some reflections on Time, Life, and Hope respectively, from the fields of natural and psycho sciences; the last section proposes some practical strategies as to how to maintain hope in life. Deep convictions and strong resilience of Stephen Hawking, an outstanding cosmologist of this century, and Paul Kalanithi, a young and renowned neurosurgeon, in spite of their

1 George Orwell, *Nineteen Eighty-Four* (New York: Harcourt, Brace and Company, 1949).

indescribable pain and suffering in their lives, serve as proof for anyone to hope against hope.

1. Time: A Timeless Mystery

We live in time and time 'lives' in us. We are 'timed' beings as we find time in our walking, talking, breathing, heartbeats, etc. If all these things are done too fast, or too slow, there is a problem. Our brain is also aware of time and "The nerve cells of our brain do pulsate at regular or irregular frequencies depending on the health of our brain cells. The rhythmic movement extends from the day-night cycle to seasons to the cycle of life and death. Time governs not just our activity but our very being."[2] Though we cannot define time, nor comprehend it totally, we all know what it is, as Augustine would put it: "If no one asks me, I know; if I want to explain it to someone who asks me, I do not know."[3] Not only humans, but Nature is also 'timely'; the change of seasons, the falling of leaves, and the blooming of flowers—everything follows a timely cycle. The birds of the air and insects of the earth too follow time in their own way, in searching for food, procreating, making nests, hives, holes, etc. The cycle of time is built into the biological functions of animals too.

Scientists, theologians and philosophers—all are equally struggling to understand time. Cognitive sciences and bio-sciences attempt to see time in terms of neural networks of our brains. Time is mysterious, paradoxical, existential—like life, time is approachable, but never fully attainable.[4] Yes, 'What is the time?' – One can easily answer, say, 10.30 a.m., but 'What is time?'... Not easy to answer.

Measurement of a Second – a Mammoth Task!

Seconds, minutes, hours, days and years—all are just conventional tools, arbitrarily designed by human beings, to speak of time in a sensible manner. We measure time in hours, minutes, and seconds, basing it on one rotation of the earth on its axis, titled at 23.45 degree. This duration of its rotation has varied a lot since its existence!

2 Kuruvilla Pandikattu, *Time's UP! –The Story of Time Weaving Physics and Philosophy* (Pune: Jnana Deepa & Christian World Imprints, 2021), xi.

3 Augustine, *Confessions*, trans. R. S. Pine-Coffin (London: Penguin Books, 1961), XI. 14/17

4 Kuruvilla Pandikattu, *Ever Approachable, Never Attainable: Science and Religion Dialogue in India* (Pune: Jnanam & CreatiVentures), 2015.

Time period	Time for earth's one rotation
4.5 billion years ago	8 hours
1.4 billion years ago	18 hours
0.8 billion years ago	21 hours and 41 minutes
0.4 billion years ago	22 hours
200 million years ago	23 hours
At Present	23 hours, 56 minutes and 4 seconds
5 billion years from now	50 days

Interestingly, until 1500s, there was no concept of a second in our measurement of time for the practical life, but it was used only as a mathematical tool. By 1955, there was a collective effort to develop an atomic clock relying on the unchanging laws of physics.[5] In 1967, the 13th general conference of the international committee for weights and measurements chose the best atom**,** caesium-133 atom, from all the 118 elements on the periodic table. This easily vaporisable atom had a long-life and high frequency of electron oscillation, with a reliable and measurable quantum spin, and simple energy level structure. 9,132,631,770 ticks of this atom (9 billion, 132 million, 631 thousand and 7 hundred and 70 ticks) make one second. By 1968 some caesium-based clocks were commercially available; they are now used all over the earth and beyond—radio transmitters, satellites, global positioning systems, etc.[6]

Einstein's Revolutionary Understanding of time

Early in the 20th century the understanding of time and the notion of simultaneity were changed drastically. Time, till then, was taken to be absolute, irrespective of the observer; similarly, if two events appear as simultaneous to an observer, it would be the same for all the observers. But

5 Atoms were considered to determine the duration of a second. Atoms have negatively charged electrons, orbiting around a positively charged nucleus at a consistent frequency. Although the Quantum laws at the subatomic level keep the electrons intact, when atoms are exposed to light or radio waves, electrons' orientation can be slightly disturbed. When an electron is twisted at the right frequency, it can create vibrations, resembling a pendulum; unlike ordinary pendulums, which lose energy quickly, electrons can tick for centuries. To make the ticks more consistent and easier to measure, the atoms are vaporised.

6 Even a millisecond (1/1000th of a second) is highly significant in our daily lives. Though our brain acts at a very high speed, it has been discovered that it does indeed take a 'considerable' time to register the signals coming from the external world and to recognise an object. For instance, when I look at a pen on my table, my brain takes at least 13 milliseconds to process the shape, colour, and orientation of the visual image on the retina and recognise it as a pen!

Einstein showed that those two events may appear to be simultaneous to one observer, but to another, they may appear 'before' or 'after' depending upon the direction of the relative motion of that observer. The contemporary notion of time is that time and space are inter-related; time is measured as an object moving from one point to another; it is the duration between two events or points; movement implies space—physics uses space-time as one unit, not as separate ones. It is our mind that separates space and time, creates past, present and future. Time is also related to the speed of light. Though time is real, dividing it into past-present-future is only a convenient tool. Though time is real, the three divisions are not. Thus, "The most important question of time still remains open. From the scientific point of view, time remains a paradoxical mystery that invites us to approach it with awe, reverence and admiration."[7] Similarly, Alfred North Whitehead is convinced that "It is impossible to meditate on time and the mystery of the creative passage of nature without an overwhelming emotion at the limitations of human intelligence."[8] So, what time is in itself seems to be a great mystery, hiding behind many philosophical and scientific complexities.[9]

Perhaps, bypassing all the philosophical and scientific investigations into the concept and nature of time, one can simply understand 'time as life'; for a believer, since God is the author of life, God is also the author of time. That is why, when we console someone in grief saying, "Time will heal you," what we actually mean is that "God will heal you," precisely because "God is the author of time." Further, because we can't comprehend time, we cannot comprehend God either. To be aware of time is to be aware of life, to love time is to love life; because life is a gift from God, to be conscious of time is actually to be conscious of God. Often, we think it is the alarm clock that wakes us up in the morning. Is it true?... I think not. For, if we keep the same alarm clock near a dead body, will it ever wake up, even if the clock rings for a whole day? Therefore, it is God who wakes us up in the morning, and each day is a precious gift from God. That is why, it is perhaps very appropriate to say that 'what is moving on the dial of a clock is not the hands of the clock, but our life' (of course, if it is a digital clock, what is flickering there is not the LED-dots, but our heartbeats!).[10] That now takes us to reflect on life.

7 Kuruvilla Pandikattu, *Time's UP!*, 2021, 46.

8 As quoted by Kuruvilla Pandikattu, *Time's UP!*, 2021, 45.

9 For more details, Kuruvilla Pandikattu, *Time's UP!*, 2021, 10–13.

10 I have elsewhere shared some reflections on time. *See* Stephen S. Jayard, *A Book that Cannot Be Titled* (New Delhi: Christian World Imprints, 2018); Stephen S. Jayard, *A Book Seeking Its Author: Reflections towards Enriching One's Life* (Ilanthalir Focolare: Tiruchirapalli, 2021).

2. Life: A Life-long Conundrum

Since time is life and time is mysterious, life is also equally mysterious.[11] The origin of life and the full understanding of its features are still enigmatic even for sciences. Professor Stuart Kaufmann puts it more bluntly, "Anyone who tells you that he or she knows how life started on earth some 3.45 billion years ago is a fool or a knave. Nobody knows."[12] Paul Nurse, a renowned biologist and Nobel laureate, has toiled to understand how living cells work and to know what it means to live.[13]

Biosciences, even today, struggle with the fundamental question: 'What is life?' In *Biology*, "A 'living' system has been described as a dynamic formation of chemical matter that has certain salient features, such as metabolism, self-sustainability, reproduction, a capacity to undergo Darwinian evolution;"[14] of course, it is just one way of describing life, much less defining it. *Molecular Biology* tries to describe life in terms of the physico-chemical interactions, functions and mechanisms at the molecular levels, while synthetic biology aims at constructing organism with the help of synthetic genomes. *Cognitive sciences* wrestle with the issue of 'conscious life.' They wonder as to how to objectively analyse the element of consciousness, while all the time we are conscious of our consciousness?'

The notion of life cannot just be understood, in a reductionistic method, as a combination of physical and chemical elements. There is also a metaphysical angle to life, because, "The tacit assumption that life *is nothing but* a feature of complex organization of matter cannot be proved with physical evidence and therefore is metaphysical."[15] Organic (or living) and inorganic (or inanimate) divide is blurred. If one argues for the view of

11 I have elsewhere elaborated on life from various angles. *See* Stephen S. Jayard, "*Is Body Merely Bodily? – Reflections on Human Body as a Symbol in Bio- and Medical Sciences*," in *Philosophizing the Body – Physical, Social, Psychological and Spiritual Dimensions,* ed. Nishant A. Irudayadason (New Delhi: Christian World Imprints and Association of Christian Philosophers of India, 2016), 151–160.

12 Stuart Kauffman, *At Home in the Universe* (London: Viking Press, 1995), 31.

13 Paul Nurse, *What Is Life?: Five Great Ideas in Biology* (NY: W. W. Norton & Company, 2021), https://www.goodreads.com/book/show/53404245-what-is-life, accessed 17 May 2024.

14 Christoph Rehmann-Sutter, "How Do We See That Something Is Living? Synthetic Creatures and Phenomenology of Perception," *Worldviews: Global Religions, Culture, and Ecology* 17, 1 (2013): 10-25, DOI: https://doi.org/10.1163/15685357-01701002, accessed 17 May 2024.

15 Sutter, "How Do We See That Something Is Living?," 11.

emergentism,[16] then one has to agree that matter must already have some traces of life and consciousness in it, perhaps, in rudimentary forms.

Synthetic biology, an emerging field at the interface of science and technology, collaborates with computer scientists, engineers and chemists. Synthetic biologists aim to achieve different things in this process of bioengineering. They use different expressions like 'engineering life,' 'building life,' 'creation of life,' life v. 2.0, synthetic life etc. But is it true that life is created? It is more apt to say that *life-forms have been engineered*, rather than saying that life is engineered, because, chemically synthesised and/or human-designed DNA elements have been introduced into already living bacterial cells. J. Craig Venter,[17] a representative of the field of "synthetic biology," himself maintains that he has not created life; "We've created the first synthetic cell," he argues, "We definitely have not created life from scratch because we used a recipient cell to boot up the synthetic chromosome."[18]

Recently, *Quantum Biology* explores into quantum entanglement[19] to see whether it can be related to the occurrence of life. The notion of life is also equally mysterious, or weird, as the quantum world, because "Up to now no biological material or even less a complete cell could be synthesized starting from pure chemical substances. There is a mystery about life in all its forms from the most primitive forms, a virus, a bacterium, up to

16 Emergentism argues that life emerges from non-living chemical compounds. The field of abiogenesis explores complicated chemical reactions, finally leading to self-multiplying molecules and resulting in living organisms.

17 John Craig Venter (1946–), an American scientist, founded Celera Genomics, the Institute for Genomic Research, and the J. Craig Venter Institute, in 1998, to sequence the human genome with his new techniques. They copied an existing bacterial genome and transplanted it into another cell, constituting a brand new, independent organism—an artificial species. However, though it is a big milestone in the achievements of Synthetic Biology, it is presumptuous to say that life has been created by them. More details are available with various sources like: https://www.britannica.com/biography/J-Craig-Venter and https://www.jcvi.org/research/sequencing-human-genome, accessed 08 August 2025.

18 *See* Ewen Callaway, "Immaculate Creation: Birth of the First Synthetic Cell," in *New Scientist*, 20 May, 2010, http://www.newscientist.com/article/dm8942-immaculate-creation-birth-of-the-first-synthetic-cell.html, accessed 23 February 2011.

19 Quantum entanglement is a quantum relationship between two particles, irrespective of temporal or spatial parting, which can exist over great distances. The state of one particle cannot be described in itself, without the state of the other. Such feature has been experimentally proved with photons, electrons, quarks, etc. There are voices to equate love with quantum entanglement, as love is invisible force—binding two or many—regardless of spatial or temporal separation. *See* Jesse Emspak, "Quantum Entanglement: Unlocking the mysteries of particle connections," https://www.space.com/31933-quantum-entanglement-action-at-a-distance.html, accessed 19 March 2024.

higher levels in flora and fauna."[20] Unity is an important factor in a living organism. Unity is not just the combinations of the components of a system, like a forest is not the collection of trees and plants in it. P. W. Anderson demarcates between reductionism (from the complex system to the parts) and constructionism (from parts to the whole): "The ability to reduce everything to simple fundamental laws does not imply the ability to start from those laws and reconstruct the universe."[21]

Not only life is complicated but the very term 'life' is also complicated: "'Life' is a term that we use frequently in everyday language. And we use it in many different ways - in phrases such as: 'She leads the life of a poet;' 'His love life was chaotic;' 'There is no life in this dead body;' 'Life on earth has evolved.'"[22] One wonders whether there is any common element of life in all these expressions or not. Interdisciplinary approaches, thus, are needed to understand life.

3. Hope: Signs of Hope in Sciences

As time is not possible without life, and vice versa, we realise that life is not possible without hope. Hope is essential for any creature or living organism. A bird leaving the nest in the morning for food or an animal leaving its den in search of its prey, a bee in search of nectar – all these are not possible without hope. It is true, they do all these actions instinctively, and they may not be aware of their hopes, we can still see a sense of hope in them. If a bird does not get food one day, it does not refuse to go the next day, because of the disappointment of the previous day. But humans get easily dejected and depressed over disappointments. Especially, there is a dire need to think of hope today, especially after the pandemic of Covid-19: "Societies have become increasingly economically unequal, wealth has become more concentrated, organisational structures have become more corporatized…"[23]

In the postmodern world, there is a strong desire to provide or a develop a scientific basis for everything. Formal psychological research on hope did not appear until the 20th century. In the 1960s and 1970s, hope was

20 Alfred Driessen, "Life and Quantum Biology, an Interdisciplinary Approach," in *Acta Philosophica* 24, no.1 (2015): 69–86.

21 As quoted by Alfred Driessen, "Life and Quantum Biology," 75.

22 Christoph Rehmann-Sutter, "How Do We See That Something Is Living? Synthetic Creatures and Phenomenology of Perception," in *Worldviews* 17 (2013): 10–25, Doi: https://10.1163/15685357-01701002, accessed 17 May 2024.

23 Matt Sharpe and Matthew King, "Politics, Religion, Hope: Contemporary Theoretical Perspectives Critical Research on Religion," 2022, Vol. 10(3) 331–332, DOI: https://10.1177/20503032221124548, accessed 17 May 2024.

studied as "positive expectation," and in the early 1990s, Charles R. Snyder[24] introduced the most influential psychological theory on hope, known as 'hope theory.' Since then, the interest in exploring hope has increased, as hope has great impact on health and well-being.

The science of hope (Hope Science) is a discipline focusing on the experience of hope. Hope is not just a wishful or unrealistic thinking, based on ignorance of facts. It is a firm conviction that tomorrow will be better than today, and one can play a decisive role in making one's future better. Hope is often misunderstood as 'the ostrich complex' – burying one's head in the sand to think that the challenges have disappeared. Hope is not mere optimism, which just expects and waits for a better future, while hope is basically action-oriented; hope is not just wishing for a better situation. Snyder differentiates hope from optimism. As optimism, hope also involves a belief that good things will happen and bad things will be avoided, but hope (unlike optimism) has to have thoughts about how a goal will be achieved. So, both are theoretically different.[25] Hope is a psychological strength and not a liability. When filled with hope, people are motivated to grow and achieve in different life-situations, and acquire more physical and emotional well-being. Losses and adversities don't derail them easily. Hope promotes resilience while facing difficulties and challenges; it gives a perspective that if something better is possible, then one can achieve it, if not now, but at least in future.[26] Further, as *Chan Hellman, a professor of psychology and founding director of the Hope Research Center at the University of Oklahoma, puts it:* "*wishing is passive toward a goal, and hope is about taking action toward it.*"[27] Hope is a nuanced and delicate cognitive process

24 C. R. Snyder, Harris, C., Anderson, J. R., Holleran, S. A., Irving, L. M., Sigmon, S. T., Yoshinobu, L., Gibb, J., Langelle, C., & Harney, P., "The Will and the Ways: Development and Validation of an Individual-Differences Measure of Hope," in *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology* 60, no. 4 (1991): 570–585, DOI: https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.60.4.570, accessed 17 May 2024; C. R. Snyder, ed., *Handbook of Hope: Theory, Measures, and Applications* (Massachusetts: Academic press, 2000); C. R. Snyder, *Hope Theory: Rainbows in the Mind*, in *Psychological Inquiry*, 13, no.4 (2002): 249–275; and C. R. Snyder, K. L. Rand & D. R. Sigmon, *Hope theory - Handbook of Positive Psychology* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2002), 257–276.

25 C. R. Snyder, "Hope Theory: Rainbows in the Mind," in *Psychological Inquiry,* 13, no. 4 (2002): 249–275, DOI: https://doi.org/10.1207/S15327965PLI1304_01, accessed 4 March 2024.

26 *See* L. E. Steffen, et al., "Hope Interventions in Oncology," *Supportive Care in Cancer* 28 (2020); M. W. Gallagher, et al., *Journal of Clinical Psychology* 76*,* no. 3 (2020).

27 As quoted by Ashley Abramson, "Hope as the antidote - Hope may be the Antidote to Today's Chaotic World. Here's how to Cultivate it," *Emerging trends of American Psychological Association* 55, no.1 (January 2024), https://www.apa.org/monitor/2024/01/trends-hope-greater-meaning-life, accessed 23 May 23 2024.

involving goal-setting, agency and cognitive restructuring. Thema Bryant, former president of American Psychological Association, explains: "Hope isn't a denial of what is, but a belief that the current situation is not all that can be."[28]

Hope involves *Pathways Thinking* and *Agency Thinking*: the first refers to the human cognitive ability to produce various pathways that would lead from the present to the desired future, whereas the second is at the level of intention, confidence, and the human ability to concretely follow those different pathways to the desired future. Positive motivation is very important here. It enables one to reach the valuable goals easily. Barriers to reach the goals are seen as challenges, not as complete blocks. There is a dialectical relationship between these two thinking: as Pathways Thinking creates more routes, and these routes in turn lead to Agency Thinking. The American psychologist has developed a tool to measure hope; this tool consists of six questions each, focusing on Pathways and Agency Thinking. The Pathways questions inquire into the cognitive ability to come up with creative steps towards the goal, while Agency questions focus on the affective part of the brain, like sense and motivation, which are needed to strive towards the goal.[29]

Hope Harbours Health

Hope itself is a complex and multidimensional concept, and it is studied along with equally complex concepts. Robert Richardson, with his several case studies conducted among patients of varied illnesses and situations, is convinced that '*where there is hope, there is life,'* and hope enhances the quality and even the quantity of life.[30] Recent studies on hope reveal that a positive outlook improves our mental and physical health. It enables us to face challenges boldly. It improves mental health by acting as a buffer against stress, anxiety, and depression. As mental health improves, it positively affects the physical health as well. Hope increases resilience, and promotes overall well-being. Three nurse teachers, out of their 27-year long experiences of exploring the relationships between hope and health, come up with a four-dimensional model of hope: *Hope as an experiential process, Hope as a spiritual or transcendent process, Hope as a rational thought process, and Hope as a relational process.*[31]

Similarly, Norman Cousins focuses on the relationship between emotions and health. He is convinced that 'Belief Becomes Biology.' His case studies have shown that 'negative' emotions, like stress, anger, fear, and depression have serious negative impacts on health, while the 'positive' emotions like love, laughter, and hope do promote healing. He explains how two oncologists discuss their patients' response to the drugs; while one gets only 22 per cent healing, whereas the other gets 74 per cent positive response; the second one explains, "We're both Etoposide, Platinol, Oncovin and Hydroxyurea. You call yours EPOH. I tell my patients I'm giving them HOPE."[32]

Hope Influences Brain

When a person is filled with hope, a few areas of the brain, like the prefrontal cortex, which is responsible for goal-directed behaviour and decision-making, are activated. Hope stimulates the release of neurotransmitters like dopamine and serotonin, which have direct connection with feelings of pleasure, reward, and well-being; they can reduce stress, anxiety, and even pain. Hope is related to a sense of power and a feeling of being in control of a future. They together activate striatum and the medial prefrontal cortex, which are responsible for motivation and positive emotions. Constant efforts on hope produce long-term changes in the brain through neuroplasticity.[33] When one constantly engages with hopeful thinking, one can build a more resilient, joyful, and healthy life. It produces many emotional and physical benefits, essential for a brighter future. One has to consciously choose hope as a pillar of one's existence, not just an occasional fleeting thought.[34]

Hope is thus multidimensional–it is an attitude, an emotion, an activity, a disposition—all put together. Wittgensteinian notion of 'family resemblance' account would help us to understand hope better, basing on its functions, not just on analysis of the word 'hope.' We perhaps don't need a definite, final definition for hope. What is actually needed are accounts of the varieties of hope (much like the varieties of love), as well as of the many

28 As quoted by Ashley Abramson, "Hope as the antidote."

29 P. Mulder, "Snyder's Hope theory," *ToolsHero*, 2019, https://www.toolshero.com/personal-development/snyders-hope-theory/, accessed 20 January 2024.

30 Robert L. Richardson, "Where There is Hope, There is Life: Toward a Biology of Hope," *The Journal of Pastoral Care, Spring* 54, no.1 (2000): 75–83.

31 Carol J. Farran, Kaye A. Herth, and Judith M. Popovich, *Hope and Hopelessness: Critical Clinical Concepts* (Thousand Oaks, CA SAGE Publications, 1995).

32 Norman Cousins, *Head First: The Biology of Hope* (New York: E. P. Dutton, 1989), 76.

33 Neuroplasticity is the ability of our brain to rewire itself based on experiences and thoughts. When one consistently engages with hopeful thinking, studies show, one can strengthen the neural pathways associated with positive emotions and resilience.

34 Matt Mahmood-Ogston, "The Science of Hope - What Happens to Your Brain When You Focus on Optimism," https://www.linkedin.com/pulse/science-hope-what-happens-your-brain-when-you-focus-matt-kdcee, accessed 2 October 2024.

functions, positive and negative, hope plays in our lives. While stories help contextualise and illustrate the varieties and functions of hope, theorising (a variety of theories) about hope's role and nature is also needed.[35]

4. Possible Strategies to Give 'Hope' to Hope

Seeing Life in Larger Perspectives

When one views life from a broader perspective, most of the things in life become simpler, clearer, and more meaningful. Shortsightedness limits our far-reaching vision, both literally and metaphorically. A lack of readiness to keep things in a wider perspective very often lands us in resentment and regrets, fears and fatigue. To appreciate a collage on a wall, to see it in its totality, we need to stand a bit away from the wall—not too close; to enjoy the full *rangoli*, we need to patiently wait until all the dots are connected. Seeing life in larger perspectives enables one to tie all the loose ends of life and to realise that life is not a problem to be solved but a mystery to be lived; such a person will not absolutise what is relative, nor relativise what is absolute; and will easily realise that what really counts in life cannot be counted, and what can be counted does not really count in life. Developing a deep sense of common sense and sense of humour are also very helpful to see life in larger perspectives.

Figuring out the Purpose of One's Life

Stephen Hawking, perhaps the most popular and admired scientist of our times, could be an outstanding example of seeing the purpose of one's life and to develop a strong will power, in spite of his enormous physical ailments and disadvantages. At the age of 21, he was diagnosed with amyotrophic lateral sclerosis (ALS), a progressive neurodegenerative disease that would affect nerve cells in the brain and the spinal cord, slowly leading to total paralysis. He was given only about two years to live on. But he lived, almost completely paralysed, till 76; he was dependent on voice synthesiser to speak, which he controlled with a cheek muscle. He became a professor of Gravitational Physics at Cambridge in 1977, and in 1979 he was appointed to Cambridge's Lucasian professorship of Mathematics, a prestigious post once held by Isaac Newton. He was made a Commander of the Order of the British Empire (CBE) in 1982 and a Companion of Honour in 1989. It is because he never gave up hope. He himself confesses: "After my expectations had been reduced to zero, every new day became a bonus, and I began to appreciate everything I did have. *While there's life, there is hope*."[36] He had a great sense of gratitude and joy, to see every day of his life as a gracious gift: "I am uncomfortably, acutely aware of the passage of that the time that I have been granted is, as they say, borrowed."[37]

35 Michael Schrader and Michael P. Levine, "Hope: The Janus-faced Virtue (With Fathers)," *European Journal for Philosophy of Religion* 11, no. 3 (2019): 11–30, DOI: https://doi.org/10.24204/EJPR.V11I3.2935, accessed 2 October 2024.

Another example, from the recent times—of a person with resilience, willpower and serenity, even in the midst of fatal lung cancer—comes from the world of medicine: *Paul Sudhit Arul Kalanithi* (1977–2015), an American-Indian neurosurgeon, diagnosed with stage-4 non-small-cell EGFR-positive lung cancer, died rather young at just 37. Just a year before he died, they got a baby girl, Elizabeth Acadia (Cady), on 4 July, 2014. She was his satiating joy. He wrote an autobiography, *When Breath Becomes Air*, as a doctor and a patient facing a terminal illness, narrating his personal experiences and understanding of life and death. He always advised his patients not to lose hope. He wanted his daughter to read his book when she would grow up—to know that she gave him joy, that was not known in all his prior years, and that made him complete. Unfortunately, he died before he could finish it, and his wife, Lucy Goddard, completed with a poignant epilogue and published it in 2016. This book was well-received and it was a *New York Times* bestseller, spending 68 weeks on the non-fiction list.[38] He is yet another great example for being calm and serene, even if life takes him by appalling surprises, and of rolling with the waves of life! Therefore, one has to discern the purpose of one's life. Once the purpose of life is clear, life can easily become hopeful; yes, according to Viktor Frankl, "Those who have a 'why' to live, can bear with almost any 'how.'"[39]

Taking Advantages of Being a Believer in God

It is easier for a believer not to lose hope, because even an atheist like Stephen Hawking could live with hope in life. One needs to wonder: if Hawking, an atheist, can live with hope in spite of his indescribable sufferings and shortcomings in one's life, it perhaps becomes all the more possible for a believer not to lose hope. Everyone has to believe in something or the other, or someone or the other, or sometime or the other, without which life is impossible. When those beliefs are rooted in God, some transcendental,

36 Stephen Hawking, *Brief Answers to the Big Questions* (London: John Murray Publishers, 2018), 11. Emphasis mine. There is also a video clip on this: "It Can Be Done – Stephen Hawking's Message to Humanity," YouTube, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=iW1e38X6nb4, 08 August 2025.

37 Hawking, *Brief Answers to the Big Questions*, 146.

38 Paul Kalanithi, *When Breath Becomes Air* (NY: Random House, 2016), https://ew.com/article/2016/01/07/when-breath-becomes-air-paul-kalanithi-ew-review/, accessed 8 October 2024.

39 Viktor E. Frankl, *Man's Search for Meaning: The Classic Tribute to Hope from the Holocaust*, trans. Ilse Lasch (London: Rider, 2008). First published in German in 1946.

divine and supreme power (or person), it becomes much easier for one not to lose one's hope in life. One can easily let things go because s/he is anchored in God, who is steady and stable, perpetual and permanent.[40]

It is, of course, true with scientists also. The pioneers of the modern science, like Galileo, Kepler, Newton etc., were not only brilliant scientists but also devout believers. Their faith significantly influenced their scientific pursuits; they often viewed their work as a way to illuminate God's creation. They were convinced that the universe had a purpose, clearly manifesting God's design. For them, science was a means to understand and glorify God, and therefore they could see no conflict between their faith and scientific inquiry. In the recent times as well, great minds like Albert Einstein, Max Planck, Richard Feynman, James Watson, Vitaly Ginzburg, and so on – all have expressed their thoughts on the existence of God.

There are even scientists who publicly proclaimed to be staunch atheists but turned out to be strong believers because of their practice of science. For instance, Allan Sandage (1926-2011), an American astronomer, was once a public atheist, but his groundbreaking work on Astronomy and Cosmology—especially, the expansion of the universe—made him a devoted believer. He is deeply convinced of the design in the universe, which could not have come by chance.[41] Francis Collins (1950–), director of the National Institutes of Health of the USA, is another example for an atheist became a strong believer due to his scientific explorations; he was taken aback by the extremely intricate, language-like structure of DNA and the so-called inherent 'moral compass' in human genetics.[42] There are many more popular non-believing scientists who, after their prolonged research, in both the micro and macro worlds, boldly declared their faith in the designer-God.[43] We have several concrete examples from several top-level scientists and Nobel laureates.

40 Angelina Dsouza, a consultant homeopath, with many years of holding training and development programmes, explains how faith in God can help us freedom and joy of life. *See* Angelina Dsouza, *Letting Go: One Practical Solution to Almost Every Problem* (Mumbai: Pauline, 2024).

41 Allan Sandage, "A Scientist Reflects on Religious Belief," in *Truth: An International, Inter-Disciplinary Journal of Christian Thought* 4 (1985).

42 Francis Collins, *The Language of God: A Scientist Presents Evidence for Belief* (New York: Free Press, 2007).

43 Some examples: Antony Flew (1923–2010), a philosopher and atheist, began to believe in God, after reevaluating the origins of life and the universe; A. E. Wilder-Smith (1915–1995), a Chemist, who came to conclude that life's complexity required intelligent design, after his serious research on molecular biology; and Charles Townes (1915–2015), a Nobel laureate Physicist, inventor of the laser, decided to embrace faith in and through his studies on the universe's origins.

When one believes in God, it helps a lot to deepen one's hope, which "is an attitude in which we dare to commit ourselves to that which is radically beyond all human control in all our human dimensions. And it is realised precisely when the controllable is definitively transcended, i.e., in the ultimate consummation of eternal life… Hope is that which endures, in the definitive finality of our relationship to the ultimate truth."[44] Karl Rahner echoes the same: "Hope is not simply the attitude of one who is weak, but rather the courage to commit oneself in thought and deed to the incomprehensible and uncontrollable which permeates our existence… Perhaps it has been shown that in the final and definitive consummation hope still prevails and endures, because this definitive consummation is God."[45]

Concluding Remarks

Hope, as hitherto argued, is not living in an imaginary world, nor being filled with blissful ignorance of realities around. As Wes Campbell points out, "Not that hope signifies flight from this world: on the contrary it implies that the realities of this world must be taken seriously and not reduced to nothingness."[46] Hope is not a 'wish' or a 'desire,' which is oriented towards something external to us. Hope is a strong orientation towards some 'good' for oneself or others; it implies a strong sense of 'possibility' and some element of certainty.[47] Hope is the inner strength that gives clarity and vision even in the midst of despair and meaninglessness. Stephen Hawking and Paul Kalanithi, I believe, were able to accept realities of life and see life with full of hope, because they could see, as Kuruvilla puts it, "something larger than oneself and something that fully sates and satiates us."[48]

A person who is filled with humility, optimism, patience and enthusiasm, will not easily lose hope, as they are the four fundamental components of hope (Humility, Optimism, Patience and Enthusiasm H-O-P-E). St Paul, in his first letter to the Corinthians, Chapter 13, speaks about faith, hope and love. He affirms that the greatest of these is love (v. 13). However, I incline to think that hope must be the most important of all these three, because if one loses hope in love, s/he cannot continue to love! Finally, when wealth

44 Kuruvilla Pandikattu, *Time's UP!*, 78.

45 Karl Rahner, *Theological Investigations*, vol 10 (London: DLT, 1973), 259.

46 Wes Campbell, "Christian Hope, Science and Technology" in *St. Mark's Review,* March 1984, 45–54, 54.

47 I have elsewhere reflected more on hope: "Towards Enlightened and Enriched Humanity: Rays of Hope from Critical Interactions with the Contemporary Science," in *Committed to the Church and the Country*, ed. Kuruvilla Pandikattu, James Ponnaiah and Thomas Kuriakose (Delhi: ISPCK and Jnana Deepa Vidyapeeth, 2013), 56–76.

48 Kuruvilla Pandikattu, *Time's UP!*, 148.

is lost, nothing is lost, as it can be regained by earning, borrowing or even robbing. When health is lost something is lost, as it can't be totally regained as we are aging. When hope is lost, everything is lost, as life is not possible without hope. *Shall we give hope to hope?*[49]

49 I was seriously affected by Covid in 2021. I have shared my faith experiences of healing, love, care, hope and surrender in the social media, with the title: "I Will See You, in the ICU," YouTube videos, *See* https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=r40zXrIRv1k&t=207s; https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=x7dJlKmkJ_4&t=356s; https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Q1s7xkV2Q3A, accessed 08 August 2025.

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Between Christian Hope and AI's Secular Hope Thinking with and Through *Spe Salvi*

Annie Kunnath

Abstract

Drawing on Pope Benedict XVI's 2007 encyclical 'Spe Salvi,' this paper examines the relationship between Christian hope and the secular hope as embodied by artificial intelligence (AI), and questions the ongoing optimism surrounding it. However, the idea that technology can provide hope overlooks humanity's ethical, moral, and spiritual needs. The paper also discusses the threats and risks associated with AI, raising questions about human destiny, free will, and emotional states. Ultimately, it argues for a moral and ethical framework that prioritises human well-being, integral human development, and the common good.

Keywords: *Artificial Intelligence, Christian Hope, Ethical AI, Integral Human Development, Secular Hope, Spe Salvi.*

"*...aperiatur terra et germinet Salvatorem*"[1]
Isaiah 45:8

Prelude

Pandora, the first woman in Greek mythology,[2] was formed from earth and water, and breathed into life by the Olympian gods themselves. True to her name, she was "all endowed," "all gifted" by the gods,[3] with Zeus gifting her a sealed *pithos* (storage jar).[4] She was strictly warned never to open it. But the gift of curiosity that Hera graced her with eventually led her to open it, releasing all evils into the world, including anguish and sorrow, war and want, hard toil, misery, and death. It is said that Pandora hastily closed the jar's lid, trapping *Elpis* (hope),[5] the only good thing, within it:

> Only Hope remained there in an unbreakable home within under the rim of the great jar, and did not fly out at the door; for ere that, the lid of the jar stopped her, by the will of Aegis-holding Zeus who gathers the clouds.[6]

1 "Let the earth open and bring forth a Saviour," Isaiah 45:8.

2 The myth of Pandora was first told by the ancient Greek poet Hesiod in his work (c. 8–7 BC), and was later revisited in his *Works and Days* (7 BC). Cf. Hesiod, *Theogony/ Works and Days* in *The Homeric Hymns and Homerica with an English Translation by Hugh G. Evelyn-White* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press; London: William Heinemann Ltd, 1914), lines 96–99. Online version at the Perseus Digital Library, http://www.perseus.tufts.edu/, accessed 9 August 2025. The new 2018 edition by Glenn Most gives a slightly different translation, especially in translating *elpis* as "anticipation." Cf. Glenn Most, trans., *Hesiod: Theogony, Works and Days, Testimonia* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2018).

3 Scholars have observed a shift in the meaning of the name from "all giving" or "she who gives all" to "all gifted" or "all endowed." For some, this change in interpretation reflects the transition from a matriarchal to patriarchal society in ancient Greek. *See* A. H. Smith, "The Making of Pandora," *The Journal of Hellenic Studies* 11 (1890), 278–283; J. E. Harrison, *Prolegomena to the Study of Greek Religion* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1903); W. E. Phipps, "Eve and Pandora Contrasted," *Theology Today* v. 45, no.1 (1988), 34–48.

4 Ever since Erasmus mistranslated the Greek '*pithos*' as '*pyxis*' (box), Pandora's container has become in several variants a box. Hesoid uses the Latin "*dolium*," which is a large earthenware storage jar.

5 Although '*elpis*' is usually translated as 'hope', it can also mean 'expectation', 'anticipation.' In this sense, it does not signify hope for good alone; it could represent either good or evil. The daughter of the primordial goddess Nyx (Night), Elpis was conceived without a father, and played a negligible role Greek mythology, and Greek society. She is the last *daimona* (spirit) to remain on Earth, as all the others fled to Mount Olympus. Elpis is also the mother of Pheme, the personification of fame and good repute, as well as report, rumour, and gossip.

6 Hesiod, *Works and Days*, lines 96-99, Online version at the Perseus Digital Library.

The Dutch classicist W. J. Verdenius points out that Hesiod remains silent about why *elpis* remained trapped "within under the rim of the jar." Of the many modern theories and speculations, Verdenius classifies them into two categories according to the purpose of the jar: 1) to keep *elpis* for humans; 2) to keep off *elpis* from humans. In the first instance, the jar is used as a pantry; while in the second, it is used as a prison. Verdenius continues "Furthermore, *elpis* may be regarded either (a) as a good, or (b) as an evil. In the first case it is to comfort man in his misery and a stimulus rousing his activity, in the second case it is the idle hope in which the lazy man indulges when he should be working honestly for his living."[7]

So, who is sweet *Elpis*? Is she a nurturer of human hearts, a salve for human troubles, a saviour of lives?[8] Or is she an impractical expectation that is dangerous, especially when coupled with ignorance? Does she "steer mortals [with] much-veering judgement,"[9] leading them to harbour harmful, foolish, and unrealistic ambitions, and engage in destructive behaviour by fostering idleness and apathy?[10]

The Roman counterpart of *Elpis* was *Spes*. Unlike the Greeks, who had ambivalent and even negative feelings towards her, the Romans revered *Spes* as an imperial goddess. But *Spes* was more than just a deity with her own temples in Rome. She was also a virtue, a 'divine quality' – the most elusive and shadowy of all virtues. Unlike other divine powers such as *mens* ('intelligence'), or *fides* ('fidelity', 'faith'), which resided within the individual, *spes* was not an innate human quality, but was bestowed upon the mortals by the gods. *Spes* was a divine gift from the gods. She was

7 W. J. Verdenius, *A Commentary on Hesiod Works and Days vv. 1–382* (Leiden: E. J. Brill, 1985), 66.

8 Nonnus, Dionysiaca 7.7 ff., trans. W. H. D. Rouse, Loeb Classical Library, vols. 344, 354, 356 (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1940). Also, Pindar, Fragment 214, in *Odes including Principal Fragments*, trans. J. Sandys, Loeb Classical Library, Vol. 56 (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1961). Plato quotes Pindar in *Republic, Book 1 § 331a*. Plato, *Republic*, Book 1, §331a, in *Republic*, Vol. 1: Books 1–5, ed. and trans. Christopher Emlyn-Jones and William Preddy, Loeb Classical Library 237 (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2013).

9 Plato. *Republic, Book 1 § 331a*.

10 Plato's writings, such as the *Laws*, *Phaedo*, *Apology*, *Republic*, explore the complex nature of hope, including its ambivalent aspects. Many Western philosophers have assessed hope and its effects not as a virtue, but as something negative – an attitude that can mislead people and their actions. Notable examples include, Hesiod, Seneca, Aristotle, Spinoza and Schopenhauer. On the other hand, Kant viewed hope as something good. For him, the question 'What may I hope for?' forms one of the three fundamental questions of human reason, alongside 'What can I know?', and 'What ought I to do?'. Others, including Marcel, Bloch, and Ricoeur, also saw hope as positive and fundamental to humans.

typically depicted as a graceful young woman draped in a long, flowing chiton, the hem of which she has raised, either to avoid tripping or to walk easily. She strides forward, holding a cornucopia or blooming buds. The imagery is metaphorically rich, reflecting her multifaceted traits: the cornucopia speaks of nourishment, abundance, and prosperity; the blooming buds of growth, fulfilment of hope, and new beginnings; and the raised hem of hope's cautious progress into the future, and her forward-looking nature.

The state cult of *Spes* gained new significance when the Roman Republic collapsed and the imperial cult emerged. The emperor was now considered the *Soter*: a god-like saviour. He was the *Spes Augusta*. The concept of *spes* underwent yet another radical transformation with the advent of Christianity. It was no longer associated with the emperor. The *soter* was Jesus Christ, the divine figure who offered his disciples the hope of eternal salvation. This hope was not just a variant of *Spes Augusta*. The promise of eternal salvation transcended the terrestrial authority and hope offered by the Roman *soter*. Moreover, the Christian hope had canonical grounding: the New Testament recognises Jesus Christ as *Deus spei* ('God of hope', Romans 15:13), and *Spei nostrae* ('our hope', 1 Timothy 1:1).

> As in Roman imperial propaganda, Christianity channelled hope towards a singular divine figure. But the universalism of Christian hope rendered it, at least in principle, accessible to all, not just those in a position to benefit from the Roman imperial project. Indeed, the nature of Christian hope empowered its earliest adherents to actively resist the prevailing Roman worldview by refusing to recognise the divinity of the emperor. Martyrdom narratives are central to early Christian history, glorifying a devotion to faith even at the cost of terrestrial life, buoyed by a kind of hope bound not to the temporal power of Rome but to the transcendent promise of personal salvation.[11]
>
> The transition was now complete.

From a goddess to a divine quality or an idea, to being *Spes Augusta* with promises of secular or terrestrial hope, *Spes* has now transfigured into Christian hope with a steadfast gaze fixed firmly on eternal salvation.

The present paper examines two contrasting traits of hope, culled from Greek and Roman mythology, and Pope Benedict XVI's encyclical *Spe Salvi*: (1) comforting, stimulating hope versus idle, apathetic hope, and (2) transcendent, eternal hope versus secular, terrestrial hope. Are

11 Paul Johnston, "Worshipping Hope: Versions of Spes in the Roman Empire," in *Hope: The Future of an Idea*, *Colloquy*, Stanford Humanities Center: Arcade, https://arcade.stanford.edu/content/worshipping-hope, accessed 9 August 2025.

these two traits mutually exclusive, complementary, or collateral? Could they be like Matryoshka dolls, with comforting, stimulating hope nestled within transcendent, eternal hope; and idle, apathetic hope enmeshed within secular, terrestrial hope?

Human Hope in the Age of Artificial Intelligence

In the summer of 2018, the Pew Research Center conducted a study on "Artificial Intelligence and the Future of Humans."[12] A total of 979 experts from diverse fields including technology pioneers, researchers and activists, innovators and developers, business and policy leaders were asked to think forward to the year 2030, and answer the following question: "As emerging algorithm-driven artificial intelligence (AI) continues to spread, will people be better off than they are today?" The replies were conflicting, ranging from positive to negative and everything in between. There were concerns, and even fears about human agency, its evolution and survival, about the expected and unexpected consequences of AI and related technologies. Suggestions as well as possible improvements were made to address the anticipated negative impacts of AI, as well as ways in which humans and AI could evolve together over the next decade (i.e., from 2018 to 2030).

Some of the fears and apprehensions include: the use of AI limiting or even leading to a loss of human agency; people having less control over their lives; possible economic and social upheaval; the widening of economic and digital divides as a direct result of AI taking over human jobs; the diminishing or even loss of human cognitive, social, survival skills; the possibility of AI going rogue, resulting in a loss of privacy and accelerating cybercrime and cyberwarfare, thus wreaking havoc and endangering critical civilian and government infrastructure. There were moral and ethical concerns, too, that humans would ferret and exploit the harmful potential of AI.

We are halfway to the year 2030–the target date set by Pew research–and many of the concerns and fears, as well as optimism and possibilities, that the research group anticipated have become reality. One such prediction was the rise of bots made by Judith Donath.[13] Today, bots have become an integral part of our digital landscape. According to Donath's prediction:

> By 2030, most social situations will be facilitated by bots – intelligent-seeming programs that interact with us in human-like

12 "Artificial Intelligence and the Future of Humans," Pew Research Center (Washington, DC, 10 December 2018), https://www.pewresearch.org/internet/2018/12/10/artificial-intelligence-and-the-future-of-humans/, accessed 9 August 2025.

13 Judith Donath, *The Social Machine: Designs for Living Online* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2014).

> ways. At home, parents will engage skilled bots to help kids with homework and catalyze dinner conversations. At work, bots will run meetings. A bot confidant will be considered essential for psychological well-being, and we'll increasingly turn to such companions for advice ranging from what to wear to whom to marry. We humans care deeply about how others see us – and the others whose approval we seek will increasingly be artificial. By then, the difference between humans and bots will have blurred considerably. Via screen and projection, the voice, appearance and behaviors of bots will be indistinguishable from those of humans, and even physical robots, though obviously non-human, will be so convincingly sincere that our impression of them as thinking, feeling beings, on par with or superior to ourselves, will be unshaken. Adding to the ambiguity, our own communication will be heavily augmented: Programs will compose many of our messages and our online/AR appearance will [be] computationally crafted. (Raw, unaided human speech and demeanor will seem embarrassingly clunky, slow and unsophisticated.) Aided by their access to vast troves of data about each of us, bots will far surpass humans in their ability to attract and persuade us. Able to mimic emotion expertly, they'll never be overcome by feelings: If they blurt something out in anger, it will be because that behavior was calculated to be the most efficacious way of advancing whatever goals they had 'in mind.' But what are those goals? Artificially intelligent companions will cultivate the impression that social goals similar to our own motivate them – to be held in good regard, whether as a beloved friend, an admired boss, etc. But their real collaboration will be with the humans and institutions that control them. Like their forebears today, these will be sellers of goods who employ them to stimulate consumption and politicians who commission them to sway opinions.

Yes, AI is everywhere today. It has become an integral part of human existence in one form or another, and we cannot do without it. Like plastic. Or petrol.

However, although AI is often celebrated as a transformative technology that promises to enhance the quality of life and promote human progress, this optimistic narrative is anchored in a secular perception of hope. According to this view, technological advancement is the primary means of human flourishing. As AI augments human capabilities and replaces long-trusted human activities, and as society increasingly relies on AI to solve complex

global issues, it is crucial to critically examine the limits of such hopes, particularly in relation to humanity's deeper existential and spiritual needs.

So, what sets Christian hope apart from secular hope?

According to Dominic Doyle, "the distinction is not between supernatural and natural hope—that is, between hopes that are explicitly graced and hopes that are proportionate to, and attainable by, ordinary human capabilities. Rather, the distinction is between the hope that intends a divine goal utterly transcending time (which must be graced) and the hopes that intend temporal realities in the world (which may or may not be graced)."[14] In this explanation, the distinguishing feature of the two types of hope is their transcendent or immanent nature.

Benedict XVI himself provides the best explanation in *Spe Salvi*: "Let us put it very simply: man needs God, otherwise he remains without hope" (§ 2). Essentially, it is the presence or absence of God. Secular hope is placed in secular projects, such as social justice, or AI-driven technologies, whereas Christian hope is placed in God. Secular hope, which differs radically from the transcendent hope of Christianity, suggests that humans can attain ultimate fulfilment and happiness through scientific and technological progress alone, without divine intervention or transcendent purpose. AI and science enable humans to transcend the limitations imposed by nature, time, and mortality. In other words, they enable us to overcome the challenges that have historically defined the human condition: disease, ageing, physical limitations, and death.

This optimism about AI is part of a wider, increasingly common trend of placing hopes for a better world on technological advancements.

AI is not just a tool for addressing specific problems; it is also a catalyst for human enhancement and societal progress. Futurists, technologists, and transhumanists advocate using it and other emerging technologies to transcend the limits of the human body and mind. This could potentially lead to a post-human future in which humans achieve physical and intellectual superiority through technology. In this utopian world, not only would humans enhance their physical and mental abilities, creating a society free from suffering, they would also evade death. Salvation would be redefined as the eradication of suffering, and the realisation of an ideal state of existence in this world, rather than in the afterlife. Ray Kurzweil, for example, predicts that humanity will reach a technological "singularity" in the coming decades, at which point "human life will be irreversibly transformed." This singularity will be defined by the merging of physical

14 Dominic Doyle, "*Spe Salvi* on Eschatological and Secular Hope: A Thomistic Critique of An Augustinian Encyclical," *Theological Studies* 71 (2010): 350–379.

and virtual reality, and of biological (human) and machine intelligence, to such an extent that human intelligence will become non-biological.[15]

Such AI-driven solutions to human suffering and death raise fundamental questions about whether they truly address humanity's deeper spiritual needs and yearnings. They struggle to provide answers to the existential questions that have always haunted humans: the nature of human destiny, the exercise of free will, the place of affective states like emotions and sentiments. In short, the question of human identity: who am I? who are we? what does it mean to be human? If one of the aims of AI is to ward off death—because death, like suffering, is not something positive to be embraced—how then can AI seek or hope to understand what happens after death? Where is the place or need for a transcendent hope?

Eschatological Hope in *Spe Salvi*

Spe Salvi ("Saved in Hope") is the second encyclical of Pope Benedict XVI, brought out on 30 November 2007. Its title is derived from Paul's Letter to the Romans (8:24): "*Spe enim salvi facti sumus*" ("for in hope we were saved").

The encyclical focuses on hope, the second of the three theological virtues in Christianity.[16] It explores the place, meaning, and significance of hope in the Christian life, and confirms its centrality in Catholic teachings. It also discusses some of the contemporary challenges a Christian faces, particularly the false promises of 'salvation' often found in secular ideologies and technological solutions. The encyclical emphasises that although technological progress can improve material conditions, it cannot provide ultimate fulfilment or address the deepest questions of human existence.

Christian hope is a potent force, not just a feeling or a fleeting emotion. It is a virtue, a disposition, and a strength of the soul. It empowers Christians to confront the present, even in the face of adversity, by guiding them towards a future with God. This hope is eschatological, linked with salvation: "*Spe enim salvi facti sumus*" ("for in hope we were saved").

15 Ray Kurzweil, *The Singularity Is Near: When Humans Transcend Biology* (New York: Viking Penguin, 2005).

16 Of the other two theological virtues, 'charity' was addressed in two of his encyclicals: *Deus Caritas Est* (God is Love), published on 25 December 2005, and *Caritas in Veritate* (Charity in Truth), promulgated on 29 June 2009. For a detailed study on the encyclical, *see* Annie Kunnath, "Charity in Truth Is Faithfulness: A Re-Reading of the Encyclical *Caritas in Veritate* from a Jewish Religious Perspective," *Eastern Journal of Dialogue and Culture* 3, no. 1 (January–June 2010): 95–111. The encyclical on the theological virtue of faith was started by Benedict XVI and completed by Pope Francis. It was released on 5 July 2013. Entitled *Lumen Fidei* (The Light of Faith), it became Pope Francis' first encyclical.

However, hope is not solely a personal virtue; it is also a transformative power that motivates Christians to strive for justice and create a better world, as their yearning for eternal life with God inspires them to commit to goodness and justice in the present. Hope is therefore not merely an expectation, a 'somewhere over the rainbow.' Rather, because it is future-oriented, it becomes a present reality that shapes how individuals live their lives. And it is this very eschatological, 'directed-towards', gaze that enables them to face difficult present circumstances and find meaning in the dark nights of the soul. And for those who suffer injustice in this life, there is hope, because there is justice beyond this life.

Christian hope is therefore the heart of human life, an indispensable guiding force that shapes one's existence in the world. According to Benedict XVI, this hope is rooted in the promise of eternal life, and the belief in a personal relationship with God. It provides meaning and direction, orienting believers towards an improved earthly life, salvation, and eternal communion with God. This hope transcends the limits of the material world, offering a deeper purpose that extends beyond temporal concerns. It is both personal and collective, fostering a community of believers who look beyond worldly concerns to their ultimate destiny.

Spe Salvi reiterates that true Christian hope contrasts sharply with the many false hopes offered by secular ideologies. Throughout history, various utopian projects and technological advancements have promised solutions to humanity's most pressing problems, whether political, economic, or scientific. While these efforts may improve living conditions or societal structures, they are unable to fulfil humanity's profound existential needs and wants. Human beings are not merely material entities but are also spiritual beings who long for meaning, purpose, and eternal life. Secular hopes that rely solely on technological advancements, such as those surrounding AI, often overlook these deeper aspects of human existence. This could lead to people being viewed as problems to be solved by technology. Benedict XVI contends that false hopes, particularly those rooted in secular utopias or technological solutions, are limited because they address only material conditions. He maintains that, while secular advancements may alleviate suffering and improve certain aspects of life, they cannot answer fundamental existential questions about our *raison d'être*.

Secular hope and the Christian hope are therefore fundamentally and radically different. True hope, which is Christian hope, does not lie in the perfection of earthly life. It is not about overcoming physical limitations or achieving earthly perfection, but about attaining eternal life with God. If it is eschatological, i.e. future oriented, it is, however, incarnated in this earthly life in an ongoing relationship with God. Salvation, or "justification," can never be attained merely through human effort or technological innovation.

It is received by God's grace through faith in Jesus Christ, and the promise of resurrection and eternal life with God.

The encyclical also affirms that human dignity (*dignitas hominis*) is an inherent and inviolable quality of human beings, independent of their individual characteristics. Interestingly, the concept of human dignity has its roots in ancient Greek philosophy and can be interpreted in two ways: 1) respect for persons of high social status, and 2) dignity that is inherent in a person, irrespective of their characteristics. While Christian theology adopted both meanings, it gave a theological basis for the second, namely that human beings alone, of all creation, are created in the image of God (*imago Dei*), and therefore human dignity mirrors God's own dignity.[17] The concept of 'the image of God' – God's likeness and resemblance – has historically been interpreted in three ways: mimetic, relational, and dynamic. These interpretations have significantly impacted how people perceive human nature and God.

Human dignity lies at the heart of the Christian understanding of salvation, and is non-negotiable. According to the encyclical, human dignity does not depend on material circumstances, technological prowess, worldly achievements, or successes. Instead, it stems from each person being created in the image of God and having ultimate destiny of eternal life. True dignity is rooted in the recognition that every human being is called to participate in God's eternal plan. This contrasts sharply with modern views, which often equate human worth with productivity, innovation, or social status.

In this regard, *Spe Salvi* strongly criticises the modern tendency to rely on secular or material progress as the main route to human fulfilment. Benedict XVI argues that when society places its ultimate hope in material progress, it risks creating a fragile foundation for human existence. Without transcendent hope to ground them, people may despair when secular promises go unfilled. Technological solutions, for instance, can solve certain physical or social problems, but they cannot address the spiritual void or the search for ultimate meaning. By focusing exclusively on material progress, society may neglect the spiritual and moral dimensions that are essential for integral human development.

17 The concept of the *imago Dei* is only explicitly mentioned three times in the entire Hebrew Bible, and all three instances are found in Genesis, the first book of the Torah: Gen 1:26–27; 5:1–3; 9:6. The concept is also not very frequent in the New Testament. It is found in the Pauline Epistles (1 Cor 11:7; 15:49; 2 Cor 4:4; Rom 8:29; Col 1:15–16), and once in the Epistle of James (3:9). *See* Peter Søes, "Image of God (Imago Dei)," in *St Andrews Encyclopaedia of Theology*, ed. Brendan N. Wolfe et.al. (St Andrews, UK: University of St Andrews, 2025), https://www.saet.ac.uk/Christianity/ImageofGod, accessed 9 August 2025.

Therefore, *Spe Salvi* calls for a reorientation of human hope – one that looks beyond the promises of technological and secular progress to the eternal hope offered by God. The encyclical reminds us that the Christian understanding of hope is not limited to this world, but is anchored in the belief that ultimate fulfilment and salvation lie in a future with God. Accordingly, technological progress and secular advances must be integrated into a broader moral and spiritual vision, one that recognises the limits of human achievement and the primacy of hope in God's plan for humanity. This theological hope is the bedrock of human dignity, providing a sense of purpose that transcends the material world and affirms the eternal destiny of every person.

A significant critique in *Spe Salvi* is the danger of placing too much faith in technological promises and secular progress. Benedict XVI points out that modern society often places its faith in technological and scientific advancements to bring about an era of peace, prosperity, and fulfilment. While technological progress undoubtedly contributes to human development, it cannot replace the hope that stems from faith.[18] When people place their faith solely in human achievement, whether through political systems, economic reforms, or scientific breakthroughs, they risk neglecting the transcendent dimension of their existence. He notes that this secular focus on progress often leads to disillusionment when technological advancements fail to deliver the ultimate solutions they promise. Furthermore, pursuing progress without an ethical, moral, and spiritual framework can exacerbate human problems such as inequality, dehumanisation, or environmental degradation.

Unlike the transhumanist vision of salvation, which places its hope in technology to overcome human fallibilities or extend human life indefinitely, Christian salvation is firmly anchored in the hope of eternal life with God. It is this hope of eternal communion after death that inspires Christians to live meaningful lives. Hope transforms the present, and provides direction and freedom. For a Christian, death is not a stranger; nor is it an adversary to be feared, abhorred, or eliminated. Human suffering and mortality are not problems to be solved by technology. They are part of the human condition leading to a deeper understanding of life, purpose, and the need for God. Therefore, the Christian path to salvation involves accepting the limitations of human existence and trusting in God's plan for eternal life, rather than striving for perfection through human ingenuity alone.

18 *Spe Salvi* also explores the relationship between faith and hope. It notes that, in some biblical texts, the two terms are used interchangeably to emphasise their interconnectedness.

Since Christian hope is oriented towards a future with God, it enables humans to find meaning in suffering and life's struggles. Hope propels them to build a better world based on justice and love.

Unlike the limited and ultimately unsatisfying vision of human fulfilment offered by technology, Christian hope, as set out in *Spe Salvi*, transcends this world. This hope does not lie in the perfection of earthly life, but in eternal communion with God. It provides a perspective on human flourishing that surpasses the material realm by embracing the fullness of the human person, including their spiritual and moral dimensions.

Epilogue: Broken Yet Whole

While the efficiency and benefits of AI technology are undeniable, there is nevertheless something eerily Frankensteinian about it.

Frankensteinian in its mad frenzy to harness the power of the Creator, to surpass Him, to usurp His creation, even, to become God.

Frankensteinian in its assertion of infinite perfection, and in its potential to replace the imperfect human, rendering us extraneous, irrelevant, and redundant in this world.

Frankensteinian in its capability to rewrite who a human is.

For example, AI automation is not restricted by working hours, and can operate 24/7. This revokes some of the founding concepts of Judaism and Christianity, which centred around humans. These include the Sabbath, which calls for rest on one day of the week; and the association of hard labour with eating bread. Most importantly, however, AI rejects the core belief that imperfection is inscribed in human DNA, and that God alone is perfect. In an AI-driven, automated world, with a culture that celebrates flawless achievement and success, where human creativity is threatened, where robots replace partners and companionship, where human ectogenesis is transitioning from science fiction to a near possibility, and perfection is the new normal, there will never be an Abraham given over to half-truths, a Moses who stammers, or a Jacob who limps. There will be no more broken people for God to use.

On the other hand, AI's ability to challenge and potentially redefine the very concept of humanity leads us to reconsider what it is that makes humans human. What is the essence of being human?

What does it mean to be created in the 'image of God'? And perhaps most importantly, what is the *imago Dei*?

According to Lurianic Kabbalah, God first created a world of extremes before creating the world as we know it today. In this world of extremes, known as the World of *Tohu* (chaos), God's divine light shone with the utmost intensity, and abundance. It was so intense and profuse that nothing could contain it; nor could it be channelled anywhere. *Tohu* exploded. And it

is from its shattered remains that God created our imperfect, yet sustainable world of *Tikkun* (restoration, correction, improvement, fixing up).

We are the broken pieces of *Tohu*: divine sparks that are perhaps best left as fragments – as imperfections – for God to use.

As for Paul, the Roman citizen and Jew by birth, *Elpis*/*Spes* is neither ambivalent nor meaningless. It is seared "*en chair et en os*,"[19] into his very being, rooted in his personal experience of the 'Thing-in-itself.'[20] For he received his mandate from "God our Saviour" and "Christ Jesus our hope" (1 Timothy 1:1), i.e., from none other than Hope Himself.

"*Spe enim salvi facti sumus*"
Paul's Letter to the Romans 8:24

19 Literally, "in flesh and bone." Cf. The phenomenology of Merleau-Ponty.

20 *See* Jean Greisch, "The Gospel of Salvation and the Thrill of Faith," *The Japan Mission Journal* 77, no. 4 (Winter 2023): 233–243.

From AI Dystopia to Gandhian Utopia
Envisioning a Path of Hope Toward Ethical AI

Jeff Shawn Jose

Abstract

This paper examines the ethical challenges posed by artificial intelligence (AI) through the lens of Gandhian philosophy, offering an alternative to dystopian narratives. Gandhi's critique of technology and his utopian ideals—namely, Ramarajya (ideal-state), swaraj (self-rule), and ahimsa (non-violence)—are analysed through the framework of the three waves of AI ethics: futuristic risks (e.g. transhumanism), present concerns (e.g. bias and surveillance), and environmental impacts. Gandhi's emphasis on human dignity, decentralised governance, and ecological harmony contributes to a framework for ethical AI development, suggesting a balance between technological progress and moral imperatives. The paper argues that Gandhian principles can instil hope into AI discourse by prioritising holistic well-being over unchecked technological advancement.

Keywords: *Ahimsa, Bias, Ethical AI, Gandhi, Human Dignity, Longtermism, Ramarajya, Singularity, Surveillance, Swaraj, Transhumanism.*

Introduction

Dystopian scenarios surrounding Artificial Intelligence (AI) are becoming increasingly prominent in public discourse. Broadly, these dystopian scenarios are either the result of the present impact of AI in society or the possible outcome of technological developments based on AI. For instance, the potential impact of AI on democracy[1] could lead to dystopian scenarios if issues such as surveillance, information manipulation, and algorithmic bias remain unaddressed. Furthermore, technological innovations based on AI leading to Artificial General Intelligence and Artificial Super Intelligence, where machines either equal or exceed human capabilities, might result in dystopian outcomes if there are no ethical guidelines in place.[2] Geoffrey Hinton, one of the Nobel Prize winners in Physics in 2024,[3] for developing foundations of AI neural networks, and rightly called 'Godfather of AI,' warns about AI dystopia. He says, "I think that it's conceivable that this kind of advanced intelligence could just take over from us […] It would mean the end of people."[4] Elon Musk, in his interaction with US governors, sounds a warning by stating, "AI is a fundamental existential risk for human civilisation [and it is]… the scariest problem."[5] Discussions on these dystopian scenarios open doors to the necessity of an ethical AI that could infuse hope for the future.

This paper focuses on Gandhian philosophy as a source of ethical guidelines that could offer a blueprint for a hopeful future. Even though Gandhi did not discuss AI in his writings, his critique of technology and the alternate utopian vision provide a foundation for reimagining a more optimistic future. Living through challenging times, such as the imperial British rule, the adverse economic and social effects of machinery, and rising

1 *See* Jeff Shawn Jose, "Artificial Intelligence, Self-Respect and Democracy: A Rawlsian Analysis," in *Engulfing Presence of Artificial Intelligence: Philosophical Reflections on Its Challenges and Opportunities*, ed. Stephen S. Jayard (Delhi: Christian World Imprints, 2024), 289–299.

2 Gonenc Gurkaynak, Ilay Yilmaz, and Gunes Haksever, "Stifling Artificial Intelligence: Human Perils," *Computer Law & Security Review* 32, no. 5 (October 1, 2016): 751, DOI: https://doi.org/10.1016/j.clsr.2016.05.003, accessed 10 October 2024.

3 "The Nobel Prize in Physics 2024," NobelPrize.org, https://www.nobelprize.org/prizes/physics/2024/press-release/, accessed 10 October 2024.

4 Sheena Goodyear, "The 'godfather of AI' Says He's Worried about 'the End of People,'" *CBC Radio*, 3 May 2023, https://www.cbc.ca/radio/asithappens/geoffrey-hinton-artificial-intelligence-advancement-concerns-1.6830857, accessed 9 August 2025.

5 Camila Domonoske, "Elon Musk Warns Governors: Artificial Intelligence Poses 'Existential Risk,'" *NPR*, 17 July 2017, sec. America, https://www.npr.org/sections/thetwo-way/2017/07/17/537686649/elon-musk-warns-governors-artificial-intelligence-poses-existential-risk, accessed 9 August 2025.

religious intolerance, Gandhi was hopeful of transforming society. Gandhi envisioned a utopia that critiques Western modernity and is articulated primarily in *Hind Swaraj*[6] and other writings. Gandhi is sceptical about the effectiveness of institutions and places trust in the moral transformation of individuals and society, which must be shaped by religious values and wisdom.

In this paper, I adopt the following structure to explore the Gandhian Utopian vision that could infuse hope amid the dystopian clouds surrounding AI. First, I outline the characteristics of Gandhian Utopia, emphasising the aspect of hope. Second, I present three waves of AI ethics, outlined by Aimee van Wynsberghe, focusing on the future, present, and environmental impacts of AI.[7] I will use these three waves as a framework to analyse Gandhi's utopias—namely, *Ramarajya, Swaraj, and Ahimsa*—as a hopeful ethical alternative to the dystopian scenarios posed by AI.

Gandhian Utopia

Gandhi's vision for a hopeful future could be categorised as *Utopian*. This utopia is the ideal that Gandhi lives and presents to his followers. In *Gandhian Utopia: Experiments with Culture*, Richard Gabriel Fox, calls utopia as that which "contests the present and conceives a revolutionsed future."[8] The present which Gandhi contests is the critique of imperial Western civilisation exemplified by the British Administration in India. In *Hind Swaraj*, Gandhi outlines the general characteristics of this civilisation as seeking to increase bodily comforts and ignoring the necessity of morality and religion.[9] Furthermore, he is critical of Indians blindly rejecting their tradition and embracing Western Civilisation. This approach of appropriating English way of life will not give true freedom to Indians. Gandhi calls this "English rule without the Englishman" and this country will no longer be "Hindustan but *Englishtan*."[10]

In contrast, Gandhi envisions a spiritual future rooted in religion but open to experimentation and adaptation. His utopian vision has its basis in religion. Unlike Western civilisation, he cannot imagine any ethical or political engagement in society without religion. He states in his

6 Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi, *Hind Swaraj* (Delhi: Rajpal & Sons, 2009).

7 Aimee van Wynsberghe, "Sustainable AI: AI for Sustainability and the Sustainability of AI," *AI and Ethics* 1, no. 3 (1 August 2021): 213–218, DOI: https://doi.org/10.1007/s43681-021-00043-6, accessed 10 October 2024.

8 Richard Gabriel Fox, *Gandhian Utopia: Experiments with Culture* (Boston: Beacon Press, 1989), 16, http://archive.org/details/gandhianutopiaex0000foxr, accessed 9 August 2025.

9 Gandhi, *Hind Swaraj*, 29–30.

10 Gandhi, 24.

autobiography, "…I can say without the slightest hesitation, and yet in all humility, that those who say that religion has nothing to do with politics do not know what religion means."[11] Here, the word religion encompasses a wider meaning. Gandhi states, "[b]y religion, I do not mean formal religion, or customary religion, but that religion which underlies all religions, which brings us face to face with our Maker."[12] He identifies moral laws as the common foundation of all religions that brings together people from all over the world.[13] He uses the term religion in the traditional Indian sense of *dharma*, the moral code that guides personal and social order.[14]

Gandhi attempts to present a realisable utopia. The quest for realisability is seen in his approach to personally practice it in his life before sharing it with the people. Truth and Non-violence are the key foundations of his utopia. He personally made efforts to undertake diverse experiments to attain absolute Truth. Hence, he named his autobiography, *The Story of My Experiments with Truth*. He further states, underlining the choice of the title, "[t]hese will of course include experiments with non-violence, celibacy and other principles of conduct believed to be distinct from Truth. But for me, Truth is the sovereign principle, which includes numerous other principles."[15] He discusses the practical implementation of key concepts such as *swaraj* (self-rule), *satyagraha* (the quest for truth), *swadeshi* (home-based production emphasising self-reliant villages), *sarvodaya* (commitment to public welfare) and *aparigraha* (non-possessiveness) through his speeches and writings. For instance, the constructive programme, which highlights some of these aspects, outlines a pragmatic vision for societal reformation.

Gandhi's realisable utopia was guided by unflinching hope. Gandhi emphasises that he will never lose "hope for the future." He states the reason, "I have and never lost and never will, because it is embedded in my undying faith in non-violence."[16] One instance of Gandhi's optimism and hope in full display is the letter which he wrote to Hitler in 1939. When Hitler was up in arms against humanity during World War II, he wrote to him emphasising

11 Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi, *An Autobiography or The Story of My Experiments with Truth* (Ahmedabad: Navajivan Publishing House, 1996), 420.

12 Joseph J. Doke, *M. K. Gandhi: An Indian Patriot in South Africa* (Faridabad: Publication Division: Ministry of Information and Broadcasting, Government of India, 1967), 12.

13 Quoted in Romain Rolland, *Mahatma Gandhi: The Man Who Became One with the Universal Being* (London: George Allen & Unwin Ltd., 1924), 28 n3.

14 Bipan Chandra, "Gandhiji, Secularism and Communalism," *Social Scientist* 32, no. 1–2 (2004): 9.

15 Gandhi, *An Autobiography or The Story of My Experiments with Truth*, xi.

16 Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi, *The Collected Works of Mahatma Gandhi*, vol. 90 (New Delhi: The Publications Division, Ministry of Information and Broadcasting, Government of India, 1984), 2.

the need to save the world from falling into a savage state, and asks, "Will you listen to the appeal of one who has deliberately shunned the method of war not without considerable success?"[17] This letter is an expression of a true *satyagrahi* who has to undergo a painfully slow process of attaining the desired result even if one has to undergo suffering. Gandhi states, "A Satyagrahi should always be ready to undergo suffering and pecuniary loss. […] The triumph of satyagraha consists in meeting death in the insistence of truth."[18] Judith M Brown calls Gandhi a "prisoner of hope" and characterised "persistent hope" as a "hallmark of a satyagrahi." Focusing on his turbulent personal life marked by emotional and moral struggles, Brown argues that he discovered the foundation of hope in his religious faith. She states, "he was in real sense a 'prisoner of hope.' An essential aspect of his basic optimism was the belief that people and therefore situation can radically change."[19] Focusing on this Gandhian Utopia that pins hope on the possibility of radical change, the field of Artificial Intelligence Ethics opens a new arena for the application of Gandhi's ideas.

Three Waves in AI Ethics

Technological progress in AI must not be unbridled and needs to be streamlined by strengthening its ethical dimension. This is important because of the impact AI makes on individuals, society, and the environment. The dystopian view of AI has its basis in the presumption of the absence of ethical guidelines in the background. Aimee van Wynsberghe, professor of applied ethics in artificial intelligence, outlines three waves of AI ethics with distinct focuses. The first wave focuses on the ethics of the potential future of AI development, including the possibility of superintelligence and robots gaining control over humanity. The emphasis of the second wave of AI ethics is on the current drawbacks of machine learning, such as bias, discrimination, black-box algorithms, and infringement of individual rights through surveillance mechanisms. To these two waves, she adds a third wave of AI ethics, which focuses on the environmental impact of AI, particularly on sustainable development.[20] I will use this framework to explore the impact of AI on humanity and the environment, and to examine how Gandhian ideas respond to these three waves in AI ethics.

17 Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi, *The Collected Works of Mahatma Gandhi*, vol. 70 (New Delhi: The Publications Division, Ministry of Information and Broadcasting, Government of India, 1977), 70.

18 Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi, "Satyagraha – True and False," *Young India* 8, no. 39 (30 September 1926): 342.

19 Judith M Brown, *Gandhi: Prisoner of Hope* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1989), 359.

20 van Wynsberghe, "Sustainable AI," 213–214.

The First Wave and the Future of AI

The first wave of AI ethics underscores the need for ethical guidelines when envisioning a future with AI. Many movements bring various concepts to the public space, such as transhumanism (Humanity Plus), longtermism, and singularity. The common factor that unites them is the technology-based, future-oriented, radical enhancement of human beings. Nick Bostrom, one of the founders of Humanity Plus, formerly known as the World Transhumanist Association,[21] conceives the human species as being in the nascent stage of development and calls for a future-oriented approach using technology to enhance overall human capabilities. One of the definitions of transhumanism that Bostrom gives is: "The intellectual and cultural movement that affirms the possibility and desirability of fundamentally improving the human condition through applied reason, especially by developing and making widely available technologies to eliminate aging and to greatly enhance human intellectual, physical, and psychological capacities."[22] Another concept that focuses on the future of humanity is longtermism. It was coined by William MacAskill to mean "the view that the most important determinant of the value of our actions today is how those actions affect the very long-run future."[23] Hilary Greaves and MacAskill also speak about strong longtermism: "the view that impact on the far future is the most important feature of our actions today."[24] Finally, the concept of singularity is also future-oriented. In general, singularity is an extreme form of techno-progressivism that relies on the power of technology to solve all the problems faced by humanity. The term "refers to a time to come in which machine intelligence greatly surpasses that of its human originators, and biological life is subsumed by technology."[25] Vernor Vinge and Ray Kurzweil are two key figures who discuss the idea of the singularity. Kurzweil, in his book *The Singularity is Near: When Humans*

21 Nick Bostrom and David Pearce are the founders of World Transhumanist Association which is now called Humanityplus. *See* https://www.humanityplus.org/, accessed 9 August 2025.

22 Nick Bostrom, "The Transhumanist FAQ: General Introduction" (World Transhumanist Association, 2003), 4, https://nickbostrom.com/views/transhumanist.pdf, accessed 9 August 2025.

23 William MacAskill, "Longtermism," 25 July 2019, https://forum.effectivealtruism.org/posts/qZyshHCNkjs3TvSem/longtermism, accessed 9 August 2025.

24 Hilary Greaves and William MacAskill, "The Case for Strong Longtermism" (Global Priorities Institute, 2021), 2, https://globalprioritiesinstitute.org/hilary-greaves-william-macaskill-the-case-for-strong-longtermism-2/, accessed 9 August 2025.

25 Mark O'Connell, *To Be a Machine: Adventures Among Cyborgs, Utopians, Hackers, and the Futurists Solving the Modest Problem of Death* (London: Granta Books, 2017), 70.

Transcend Biology, observes that the singularity would help upgrade from the basic version of our body and intellect marked by weakness, sickness, and failures of different sorts. He states, "Our mortality will be in our own hands. […] By the end of this century, the nonbiological portion of our intelligence will be trillions of trillions of times more powerful than unaided human intelligence."[26]

However, hidden within this futuristic vision, embedded in these concepts are potentially dangerous flaws that could pose a threat to humanity. Roberto Manzocco highlights some of the key criticisms raised by scholars against transhumanism. The transhumanist quest for immortality raises moral questions from both religious and secular perspectives, concerning divine authority and the natural order, respectively. Another point of criticism is the potential for humanity to face nuanced challenges once human limitations are overcome through genetic engineering. Genetic manipulation, if not accessible to all, could lead to inequality, posing a threat to democracy. Furthermore, there may be attempts to create a superior race. Moreover, changes to human beings dictated by technology could lead to dehumanisation, placing the individuality of human beings at risk.[27]

Émile P. Torres critiques the longtermist view of overlooking immediate issues for the sake of the future. This critique, in general, can be applied to the concepts that hinge on a future paradise based on technological progress. He critiques Nick Bostrom's argument that disasters in human history, such as Chernobyl, wars, epidemics, and AIDS, did not have a long-term impact on humanity. Bostrom states, "…tragic as those events are to the people immediately affected—they have not determined the long-term fate of our species."[28] Torres also calls it an elitist idea confined to top universities and Silicon Valley. He describes this as "the most dangerous secular belief system in the world today." He underscores this by stating that the ethical theory guiding them is utilitarianism, which disregards the individual for the sake of humanity. He states, "The underlying reasoning here is based on the idea that people – you and I – are nothing more than means to an end." Another risk highlighted is uncritical technological optimism. He critiques the longtermist demand for blind reliance on technology, "despite the agreed-upon fact that the overwhelming source of risk to human existence these

26 Ray Kurzweil, *The Singularity Is Near: When Humans Transcend Biology* (New York: Viking, 2005), e-book.

27 Roberto Manzocco, *Transhumanism – Engineering the Human Condition: History, Philosophy and Current Status* (Cham: Springer, 2019), 75–80.

28 Nick Bostrom, "Dinosaurs, Dodos, Humans?," 2006, https://nickbostrom.com/papers/globalagenda.pdf.

days comes from the very technologies."[29] In short, these future-oriented concepts predominantly rely on technology such as Artificial Intelligence, overlook the present, outline an elitist vision, degrade the dignity of the human person, and blindly rely on technology.

The Second Wave and AI Today

The Second Wave of AI Ethics focuses on the challenges that AI poses in the present scenario. These challenges arise from the numerous possibilities that AI offers contemporary society. Generative AI has become a household name with the arrival of ChatGPT, Gemini, and other AI tools. It offers the possibility of generating text, images, music, and videos based on prompts. For example, "in mid-2023, it was estimated that over a billion images had been created using Dall-E 2 by Open AI, Firefly by Adobe, and Midjourney."[30] AI Chatbots on social media are capable of sending personalised messages and interacting with the user by analysing, understanding, and responding to their queries in real-time. For instance, political parties can use AI chatbots on social media platforms to influence prospective voters. AI also helps in facial recognition, such as unlocking phones and identifying individuals in photos. In England, facial recognition is used by the Police and businesses to identify offenders. Kashmir Hill observes that 'Facewatch,' a London-based company, offered its service to business establishments to identify potential offenders. She says that the technology "allows retailers in its network to scan the faces of their customers and get alerts when the system spots people who have been flagged by other merchants for shoplifting or being abusive to employees, like a neighbourhood watch for commercial sector."[31] Another area of AI in action is easing the hiring process and make it more efficient: "In the United States, three-fourth of employers use automated tools to screen job candidates."[32] AI is also employed in many crucial areas, such as making decisions on loans, university admissions, and analysing medical data.

However, all these benefits of AI come with a cost. Text, images, voices, and videos generated by AI could be used as a potential tool for

29 Émile P Torres, "Against Longtermism," Aeon, 19 October 2021, https://aeon.co/essays/why-longtermism-is-the-worlds-most-dangerous-secular-credo, accessed 9 August 2025.

30 Arvind Narayanan and Sayash Kapoor, *AI Snake Oil: What Artificial Intelligence Can Do, What It Can't, and How to Tell the Difference* (New Jersey: Princeton University Press, 2024), e-book.

31 Kashmir Hill, *Your Face Belongs to Us: A Tale of AI, a Secretive Startup, and the End of Privacy* (London: Simon & Schuster, 2024), 220.

32 Narayanan and Kapoor, *AI Snake Oil: What Artificial Intelligence Can Do, What It Can't, and How to Tell the Difference*, e-book.

disinformation and misinformation. This "can lead to deception on a large scale and damage public trust in democratic institutions."[33] Furthermore, "AI-based technologies used in online media can contribute to advancing misinformation and hate speech, create "echo chambers" and "filter bubbles" which lead individuals into a state of intellectual isolation where there is no place for dialogue, thus eroding critical thinking and disrupting democracy."[34] AI chatbots also weaken democracy by polarising individuals and groups. David L Shrier observes that "by legitimizing fringe extremist sources, AI newsfeed algorithms and unconstrained chatbots were directly responsible for electoral polarization."[35] Yuval Noah Harari cites analyses to highlight a major problem of AI-powered bots engaging in the guise of humans during debates on whom to elect as US president. He states, "out of a sample of 20 million tweets generated during 2016 US election campaign, 3.8 million were generated by bots…A 2020 study assessed that bots were producing 43.2 per cent of tweets."[36] AI raises another challenge in its use in facial recognition technology. Kashmir Hill highlights this aspect in her book *Your Face belongs to Us*. The starting point of her journey is her analysis of a facial recognition company called Clearview AI that "scraped billions of photos from the public web, including social media sites such as Facebook, Instagram, and LinkedIn to create a revolutionary app." This app was being sold to police departments because once a person's photo is uploaded, it would potentially reveal "not just their name but other personal details about their life."[37] Use of AI in the hiring process and admissions leads to a number of problems such as opacity and bias. Once the candidate is not selected, their curriculum vitae is discarded without being analysed by a human being. As Narayanan and Kapoor observe, "But the process is opaque; companies don't share how their software is built, and candidates are left in the dark about what criteria they are judged on."[38] Furthermore, AI could also reproduce human biases. Jungherr and Schroeder state:

33 Adam Michael, "Artificial Intelligence, Democracy and Elections" (European Parliamentary Research Service, 2023), 3, https://www.europarl.europa.eu/thinktank/en/document/EPRS_BRI(2023)751478, accessed 9 August 2025.

34 Parliamentary Assembly of the Council of Europe, "Need for Democratic Governance of Artificial Intelligence," Report Doc. 15150 (2020), Council of Europe, https://pace.coe.int/en/files/28742/html, accessed 9 August 2025.

35 David L. Shrier, *Welcome to AI: A Human Guide to Artificial Intelligence* (Boston: Harvard Business Press, 2024), e-book.

36 Yuval Noah Harari, *Nexus: A Brief History of Information Networks from the Stone Age to AI* (Dublin: Fern Press, 2024), 341.

37 Hill, *Your Face Belongs to Us*, vi.

38 Narayanan and Kapoor, *AI Snake Oil: What Artificial Intelligence Can Do, What It Can't, and How to Tell the Difference*, e-book.

"Many studies have shown that inherent gender, racial, and other biases lead AI to reproduce societal inequalities and injustices."[39] AI thus presents multifaceted challenges to contemporary society.

The Third Wave and AI's Environmental Footprint

The third wave in AI ethics focuses on AI's environmental impact. Although there are arguments that AI could be used to better protect the environment, it could also potentially harm the environment. "Large Language Models have a keen appetite for electricity. The energy used to train OpenAI's GPT-4 model could have powered 50 American homes for a century. And as models get bigger, costs rise rapidly."[40] Shrier highlights the environmental costs of using AI by pointing to the ecological impact of Open AI's demonstration of solving a Rubik's cube with a robot arm. He states that it consumed 2.8 GWh of electricity, which is the output of electricity generated by three nuclear reactors in a month. He further observes that we need 2.5 billion wind turbines to provide energy to all the data centres across the world. However, since we don't have this number of wind turbines, our reliance will be on fossil fuels, thereby increasing our carbon footprint.[41]

Gandhi's Utopian Response to the Dystopian Scenarios

Examining the Gandhian response to development in relation to AI's drawbacks, rooted in his views on machinery, underlines the need for ethical principles that uphold the dignity of the human person and promote the welfare of society. In general, Gandhi's views on machines changed over the years. In *Hind Swaraj*, Gandhi makes a scathing attack on machinery. He states, "Machinery is the chief symbol of modern civilization; it represents great sin."[42] His criticism of machines, focusing on the human person is centred around their harmful effect on mental health, physical health and spiritual health. He observes that workers have become slaves to machines. Highlighting mental health, he states, "If the machine craze grows in our country, it will become an unhappy land."[43] He further adds that the physical health of people is also affected by machinery. He observes, "Honest physicians will tell you that where means of artificial locomotion

39 Andreas Jungherr and Ralph Schroeder, "Artificial Intelligence and the Public Arena," *Communication Theory* 33, no. 2–3 (1 August 2023): 170, DOI: https://doi.org/10.1093/ct/qtad006, accessed 10 October 2024.

40 "The Breakthrough AI Needs," *The Economist*, 21 September 2024, 13.

41 Shrier, *Welcome to AI*, e-book.

42 Gandhi, *Hind Swaraj*, 76.

43 Gandhi, *Hind Swaraj*, 76.

have increased, the health of the people have suffered."[44] On a lighter note, the reader is reminding him that *Hind Swaraj* will also be printed on a machine. For this, Gandhi responds that it is a necessary compromise, stating, "Sometimes poison is used to kill poison." This would make some immediate benefit to those affected by the "machine craze."[45]

Gandhi later softened his stand on machines. He clarifies that he is against the "craze for machinery," which affects both society and the individual. Machines have to be rejected if they start affecting the individuality of the human person and making it a hindrance towards his goal of attaining salvation. He states, "I would rule out all machinery, even as I would reject this very body, which is not helpful to salvation and seek the absolute liberation from the soul. From that point of view, I would reject all machinery..."[46] Gandhi also highlights the societal impact of machinery. Society is affected because wealth is concentrated in the hands of a small number of individuals who are driven by greed. He states, "Today machinery helps a few to ride on the backs of millions."[47] K. Gopinathan Pillai observes that Gandhi's views on technology present an alternate approach and "were far more original than any of the modern thinkers on the issue."[48] He also argues that Gandhi did not separate the spiritual and the material and envisioned that they had to serve each other. Hence, Gandhi's views on technology are connected to his political philosophy and his moral principles.[49] Gandhi emphasises the inseparability of religion and morality from other spheres of human activity. He states, "I do not know any religion apart from human activity. It provides a moral basis to all other activities which they would otherwise lack…"[50] Hence, a Gandhian utopian vision of AI technology would be informed by religion and morality.

Ramarajya and First Wave

The Gandhian approach would critique the reductionist future-oriented relying exclusively on technology powered by AI put forward by

44 Gandhi, *Hind Swaraj*, 78.

45 Gandhi, *Hind Swaraj*, 78.

46 Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi, *The Collected Works of Mahatma Gandhi*, vol. 25 (New Delhi: The Publications Division, Ministry of Information and Broadcasting, Government of India, 1967), 255.

47 Gandhi, 25:251.

48 K. Gopinathan Pillai, "Gandhi and the Concept of Alternative Technology," *The Indian Journal of Political Science* 49, no. 3 (1988): 375.

49 K. Gopinathan Pillai, "Gandhi and the Concept of Alternative Technology," *The Indian Journal of Political Science* 49, no. 3 (1988): 375–376.

50 Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi, "Non-Violence and World Crisis," *Harijan* 6, no. 46 (24 December 1938): 393.

longtermism, transhumanism and singularity. I undertake this critique through the prism of *Ramarajya*. *Ramarajya* is Gandhi's future ideal state—kingdom of God on Earth. Even though originally a Hindu concept, Gandhi takes it beyond religious constraints and calls it the Kingdom of God. Gandhi states, "the ancient ideal of *Ramarajya* is undoubtedly one of true democracy in which the meanest citizen could be sure of swift justice without an elaborate and costly procedure."[51] He also adds other features of *Ramarajya*, such as equality of rights, non-violence, respect for other religions, self-introspection, and above all, the freedom of the people based on pure moral authority. This is the future that Gandhi envisions.

Unlike longtermism, transhumanism and singularity, the future that Gandhi envisions is not reductive. These concepts rely exclusively on technology and the power of AI. However, they overlook all other essential aspects that make a human being. Gandhi looks forward to a balanced outlook for the future that doesn't undermine morality. This is clear from his vision of *Ramarajya*. His approach is not to look back towards a golden and glorious past. Instead, he acknowledges the need for progress for humanity: "An ant is perfect, because it does not wish to become better. But we have got to progress."[52] This progress, according to Gandhi, must not exclusively confine itself to economic progress but also to moral progress, which he calls real progress. He states, "By economic progress, I take it, we mean material advancement without limit and by real progress, we mean moral progress, which again is the same thing as the progress of the permanent element within us." Ignoring the aspect of moral progress makes it easy for ideologies to employ violence for the sake of the greater good they envision. For instance, longtermists treat wars and other catastrophes as short-term disturbances in humanity's march towards the future. Eventually, respect for the human person is jeopardised. Gandhi would also critique the utilitarian approach upheld by these ideologies, to focus on the end rather than the means. He states in clear terms, "I feel that our progress towards the goal will be in exact proportion to the purity of our means." "They say 'means are after all means.' I would say 'means are after all everything.' As the means so the end." In order to overcome these reductionist ideologies, he would point to his ideals. Nonviolence is the means and truth is the end: "… ahimsa is the means and truth is the end. Means to be means must always

51 Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi, *The Collected Works of Mahatma Gandhi*, vol. 41 (New Delhi: The Publications Division, Ministry of Information and Broadcasting, Government of India, 1970), 374.

52 Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi, *The Collected Works of Mahatma Gandhi*, vol. 56 (New Delhi: The Publications Division, Ministry of Information and Broadcasting, Government of India, 1973), 67.

be within our reach, and so ahimsa becomes our supreme duty and truth becomes God for us."[53]

Swaraj and the Second Wave

From a Gandhian perspective, the drawbacks of AI highlighted in the second wave are matters of concern that have to be addressed at both individual and societal levels. His ideal would be attaining *swaraj* for the human person. Gandhi emphasised the need for swaraj, which means personal self-transformation or self-rule. He insisted on attaining personal swaraj before attaining *poorna swaraj*, or Indian political freedom from the British. He further elaborates on swaraj: "The word swaraj is a sacred word, a Vedic word, meaning self-rule and self-restraint and not freedom from all restraint which 'independence' often means."[54] Self-discipline is the key here to attain self-mastery. Attaining *swaraj* involves striving to attain the ideal of *sthitaprajna*.[55] He defines *sthitaprajna* as the person of "steady wisdom": "He is one who withdraws his senses from the objects of the senses behind the shield of the spirit, as a tortoise does its limbs under its shell."[56] He clarifies that this ideal is not exclusively for the learned, "[t]hat ideal is not meant for *jnanis* [men of knowledge] only; it is for all, even ordinary laypeople." He also underlines that "If swaraj is to be won through the non-violent strength of the millions, they must in some measure develop in them the qualities of a *sthitaprajna* or the man of steady wisdom."[57] He outlines various means to attain swaraj, such as repeating the verses in the *Gita*, the name of Rama (*Ramanama*) and keeping the vows. Gandhi observes: "[t]aking vows is not a sign of weakness, but of strength. To do at any cost something that one ought to do constitutes a vow. It becomes a bulwark of strength."[58] He underlines the importance of following traditional Hindu virtues, which are categorised as *yamas* (cardinal virtues) and *niyamas*

53 Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi, *The Collected Works of Mahatma Gandhi*, vol. 44 (New Delhi: The Publications Division, Ministry of Information and Broadcasting, Government of India, 1971), 59.

54 Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi, *The Collected Works of Mahatma Gandhi*, vol. 45 (New Delhi: The Publications Division, Ministry of Information and Broadcasting, Government of India, 1971), 263–264.

55 The Sanskrit word *sthitaprajna* can be literally translated as 'one whose consciousness (*pranja*) is stable (*sthita*).'

56 Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi, *The Collected Works of Mahatma Gandhi*, vol. 83 (New Delhi: The Publications Division, Ministry of Information and Broadcasting, Government of India, 1981), 364.

57 Gandhi, 83:363.

58 Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi, *From Yeravda Mandir: Ashram Observances* (Ahmedabad: Navajivan Publishing House, 1992), 30.

(casual virtues). To this Gandhi adds six more vows: bread labour,[59] control of the palate, *swadeshi*,[60] fearlessness, removal of untouchability, and tolerance or equality of all religions.[61] Gandhi also gives prime importance to Truth: "I take up Truth first of all, as the Satyagraha Ashram owes its very existence to the pursuit and attempted practice to Truth."[62]

Gandhi insists that only a person who has achieved swaraj or self-mastery will be able to respond to the challenges posed by the second wave. The key issues highlighted in the second wave include the possibility of misinformation and disinformation, promoting hate speech, increased activity of AI-powered chatbots leading to electoral polarisation, creating echo chambers and filter bubbles, facial recognition-based surveillance, and furthering gender and racial bias leading to societal inequalities and injustice. A human person who has attained swaraj will be able to distinguish between the manipulated information shared by AI bots on social media. She would not be influenced by the emotionally manipulative tactics employed by AI technology. In contrast to generative AI, which is not concerned about truth, a person who has attained swaraj would give prime importance to truth. She would be guided by *satyagraha*, or the quest for truth. Gandhi would also raise red flags when the government utilises AI technology for surveillance, such as facial recognition. This would further emphasise his claim that "The state represents violence in a concentrated and organised form. The individual has a soul, but as the state is a soulless machine, it can never be weaned from violence to which it owes its very existence."[63] Here, Gandhi emphasises the importance of individuals attaining *swaraj* and calls for a decentralised approach. Gandhi states: "I look upon an increase of the power of the State with the greatest fear because […] it does the greatest harm to mankind by destroying individuality, which lies at the root of all

59 Bread labour refers to engaging in physical labour to earn daily bread. *See* Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi, "Duty of Bread Labour," *Harijan* 3, no. 20 (29 June 1935): 156; Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi, "Intellectual and Manual Work," *Harijan* 11, no. 4 (23 February 1947): 36.

60 Gandhi defines *swadeshi* as follows: "Swadeshi is that spirit in us which restricts us to the use and service of our immediate surroundings to the exclusion of the more remote." Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi, *The Collected Works of Mahatma Gandhi*, vol. 13 (New Delhi: The Publications Division, Ministry of Information and Broadcasting, Government of India, 1964), 219.

61 Gandhi discusses all the vows in: Gandhi, *From Yeravda Mandir: Ashram Observances*, 3–38.

62 Gandhi, 3.

63 Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi, *The Collected Works of Mahatma Gandhi*, vol. 59 (New Delhi: The Publications Division, Ministry of Information and Broadcasting, Government of India, 1974), 318.

progress."[64] A self-disciplined individual who has achieved *swaraj* (self-rule) can effectively counter the threats posed by artificial intelligence.

Ahimsa and the Third Wave

Gandhi invokes the ideal of *ahimsa* to respond to the challenges raised by AI systems to the environment. *Ahimsa* literally means non-violence. Gandhi has a profound understanding of the concept. For instance, he states: "I accept the interpretation of Ahimsa, namely, that it is not merely a negative state of harmlessness but it is a positive state of love, of doing good even to the evil-doer." His concept of *ahimsa* can be applied to the environment too. His strong bond with the environment is clear when he states: "My ethics not only permits me to claim but requires me to own kinship with not merely the ape but the horse and the sheep, the lion and the leopard, the snake and the scorpion..." Another aspect of his connection with nature is visible in his call for cow protection. Beyond the religious connotations of cow protection, he identifies the cow as representing all living beings through which human beings realise their identity with them.[65] He also warns against the mindless exploitation that results from industrialisation. He critiques the mode of exploitative and imperialist industrialisation embraced by Western countries such as England during his time. Hence, he warns Indians: "If an entire nation of 300 million took to similar economic exploitation, it would strip the world bare like locusts."[66]

The Gandhian ideal of *ahimsa* emphasises the necessity of non-violence not only for the individual but also for the environment. The environmental impact of AI technology has to be assessed, and all efforts must be made to reduce its impact on the environment. Gandhi's idea of non-violence has inspired environmental protection movements. R. C. Sharma states, "From Chipko to the 'Save the Narmada Movement' (*Narmada Bachao Andolan*) of the present time, environment activists have relied heavily on Gandhian techniques of non-violent protest or *satyagraha*…"[67] Thus, Gandhi's commitment to the environment involved both animate and inanimate inhabitants of the universe.

64 M. K. Gandhi, *All Men Are Brothers* (Paris: UNESCO, 1958), 144, http://archive.org/details/HindSwaraj-071082eo, accessed 9 August 2025.

65 Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi, *The Collected Works of Mahatma Gandhi*, vol. 21 (New Delhi: The Publications Division, Ministry of Information and Broadcasting, Government of India, 1966), 248.

66 Gandhi, *Young India*, 20 December 1928.

67 R. C. Sharma, ed., *Gandhian Environmentalism* (Delhi: Global Vision Publishing House, 2003), 1.

Conclusion

In the contemporary world, overshadowed by a dystopian vision of a future dominated by AI, Gandhian utopia instils hope in envisioning ethical AI. Gandhian ideals, presented through three utopian visions—*Ramarajya, Swaraj,* and *Ahimsa*—offer an alternative perspective that focuses on the future, the present, and the environment. While longtermism, transhumanism, and singularity propose a reductive approach centred exclusively on technology, the Gandhian ideal of *Ramarajya* provides a holistic vision that ensures justice, equality, and non-violence without sacrificing the potential for progress. It upholds the dignity of the human person and morality.

The Gandhian ideal of *Swaraj* highlights the need to equip individuals to respond to the numerous challenges posed by AI chatbots via social media, such as misinformation, disinformation, and electoral polarisation. A person who has attained *swaraj* or self-mastery through self-discipline can address the daunting challenges that AI presents to humankind. He also underscores the violence associated with government surveillance and emphasises the necessity for a decentralised approach. Finally, the ideal of *Ahimsa* stresses the importance of protecting the environment from the impacts of training and using AI. Non-violence is a concept that transcends the confines of the individual and is applicable to creation. Just as Gandhi's non-violent approach inspired environmental movements, there is a demand for non-violent movements in the contemporary world, as opposed to violent protests that result in the defacement of monuments and artworks. Gandhi's Utopian vision centres on a bottom-up rather than a top-down approach. Constructing an ethical AI framework requires initiating change at the individual level, rather than depending exclusively on regulatory measures.

Statement of the ACPI Annual Research Seminar

St Joseph's Interdiocesan Seminary, Jeppu, Mangalore
October 19–21, 2024

We, the Association of Christian Philosophers of India (ACPI), met at St Joseph's Interdiocesan Seminary, Jeppu, Mangalore, Karnataka, for the 47th Annual Research Seminar from 19 to 21 October 2024, in which 29 research papers, including the keynote address were presented and discussed. There were 100 participants at the seminar.

The themes presented can be categorised generally into two categories, namely analytic and applicative, the former dealing primarily with the analysis of hope and the latter with its application for the good of the society at large. The analytic themes can still be subdivided into four: (1) hope as internal, (2) hope as psycho-neurological, (3) hope as external, and (4) hope as a process.

Hope serves as a vital internal force that sustains human life, enabling individuals to navigate suffering and loss, while the pursuit of meaning empowers them to transcend despair and find purpose even in the most challenging circumstances. From a psycho-neurological dimension, hope is rooted in specific neural circuits that influence reward processing, emotional regulation, and goal-directed actions, taking into consideration the ethical implications it raises for areas such as identity, autonomy, and moral agency.

The external dimension of hope, emphasises its deep rootedness in everyday experiences, highlighting its transcendent nature, anchored in the divine, fostering self-surrender and revealing the human being's future orientation toward existence rather than possession. Hope, nurtured by the teachings of religions, fosters a belief in a merciful and forgiving God and thus inspires fortitude and personal growth, affirming the potential for prosperity and peace in both this life and the hereafter.

Hope also as a process reveals an ongoing, open-ended activity, rooted in heterogeneity, continually reshapes our understanding of justice, community, and ethical responsibility in an ever-evolving world. Hope thus becomes performative, enabling itself to be applied in diverse situations such as pain-filled vulnerabilities, alienated marginalisation, complexities of modernity, dystopian technological scenario, and environmental degradation.

In the light of deliberations, we, the members of ACPI, sincerely commit ourselves to:

1. Acknowledge the persistence of hope as a vital force in times of suffering, uncertainty and despair to instil optimism and discover the meaning of human existence
2. Explore the psycho-neurological underpinnings of hope for a positive future, considering its ethical implications for identity, autonomy, and moral agency.
3. Highlight the transcendent nature of hope, respect its divine roots, and advocate for its fruition in everyday life through self-surrender.
4. Foster a culture of hope by embracing diverse perspectives, consequently encouraging ongoing dialogues about justice, community, and ethical responsibility.
5. Support vulnerable individuals in cultivating hope amidst challenges, emphasising the importance of navigating struggles and discovering meaning through shared experiences.
6. Commit to ethical guidelines that promote moral transformation and nonviolence, nurturing hope in the face of technological advancements and societal challenges.
7. Advocate for dialogue and consensus in addressing the complexities of individualism and modernity, emphasising the need for a hopeful vision that enhances our shared lifeworld.
8. Care for our Common Home in the context of the dominant technocratic and anthropocentric paradigm to uphold ecological responsibility for a hope-filled cosmic harmony.

The above-said deliberations reveal the location of hope in human history in diverse forms, encompassing both its analytical and applicative dimensions. We are convinced of the necessity to hope against hope amidst the clouds of uncertainty looming large in contemporary society. Centralising hope within the human agency, we believe in its transformative possibility towards restructuring the individual, social, political, legal, communitarian and environmental realms.

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